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2 Corinthians

2 Corinthians 1:1

Section 1:1–2: Paul and Timothy greeted the believers in Corinth

The beginning of Paul's letter follows the usual pattern for writing a letter at that time. The three parts are:

1. Paul introduced himself. He did this by writing his name, his position, and source of authority. He also mentioned Timothy, who helped him to serve the believers in Corinth.
2. Paul explained who he was writing to.
3. He greeted them.

Other examples of headings for this section are:

Introduction (NASB)

Greetings from Paul (NLT)

Opening remarks of the letter

Or you may not want to have any section heading here (as in the NIV and GNT).

1:1a

Paul, an apostle of Christ Jesus

- ¶ I, Paul, an apostle who represents Christ Jesus
- ¶ This letter is from me, Paul. I am a chosen messenger of Jesus Christ,

Paul: This name explains who wrote the letter. For example:

From Paul (NCV)

In some languages it is more natural to use a full clause. For example:

This letter is from Paul (NLT)

I, Paul, write this letter.

apostle: The Greek word that the BSB translates as apostle means “ambassador” or “messenger.” It refers to a person whom someone sends with his authority to accomplish a mission or a particular purpose. Here, an apostle is a person whom Jesus sends to represent him and teach his message with authority. The word

or phrase for apostle in your language should indicate a position of trust and authority.

If you have already translated the Gospels, you can probably use the same term for apostle as you used there. In some languages you may need to change it slightly for this context. You may want to:

- Translate the meaning. For example:

representative/ambassador

special messenger

sent-person

- Borrow a well-known word or phrase from another language. For example, if a common language is Spanish:

apostol You may then want to explain the meaning of the word in a footnote. For example:

An apostol is someone whom Christ chose to represent him and who has his authority.

See the term apostle in the Glossary. If the term you choose for apostle means “messenger,” make sure that it does not refer to a person who only delivers a message and then has no further responsibility for the message.

Christ Jesus: Paul often used the phrase Christ Jesus as an alternative to “Jesus Christ.” Putting the word Christ first probably emphasizes that word, but the meaning is the same as “Jesus Christ.” The word Christ is a title. In some languages it is more natural to have the word Christ after the name Jesus. For example:

Jesus Christ (CEV)

Christ: The word Christ is a title for Jesus. It literally means “the anointed one.” The Jews used this title to refer to the person whom God had appointed and promised to send as King and Savior. The Hebrew word is mashiach (English spells this word as “Messiah”). Some ways to translate Christ are:

- Borrow the word from a common language and spell it as a person would say it in your language. You also may want to explain the meaning of Christ. You should indicate that it is a title. For example:

Christ, the chosen one

the Christ, the one whom God promised to send

Christ, the one who was sent

- Translate the meaning of the title. You should indicate that it is a title. In English, the way to show it is a title is to capitalize the words in the phrase. For example:

The One Who Was Sent

The One Whom God Chose

The word or phrase may already be commonly used in the churches in your area. Since this is the first time the word Christ is used as a title in this book, you may want a footnote to explain the meaning. For example:

The word “Christ” means “The Chosen One.”

The word “Christ” means “The One Who Was Chosen and Anointed.” God chose Jesus to be the promised Savior.

See also Christ in the Glossary.

1:1b

by the will of God,

- because God chose me
- because that is what God wanted. (NCV)
- indeed, God chose me for this work.

by the will of God: This phrase indicates that God chose Paul to be an apostle. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

chosen by God to be an apostle (CEV)

because that is what God wanted (NCV)

whom God chose to become one/so

God: The Greek word that the BSB translates as God here refers to the eternal spirit who created everything. He is more powerful than any other spirit, and he is perfectly good and wise. He deserves to be worshiped.

Here are some ways to translate God:

- Use a name or title for God that people in your culture already use.
- Use a descriptive term that fits the truth about God that is revealed in the Bible. For example:

Creator

Great Spirit

Ruler of the universe

Choose a term that is acceptable to the believers and churches in your area. For more detailed information, see God in the Glossary.

1:1c

and Timothy our brother,

- and also Timothy, our^(incl) brother in faith/Christ.
- Our fellow believer Timothy also greets you^(plur).

and Timothy our brother: Paul included Timothy here because the believers in Corinth knew Timothy (Acts 18:5). Probably Paul wrote the letter and Timothy supported his writing in some way. (They may have discussed the problems at Corinth while Paul wrote.) This phrase probably does not imply that Timothy wrote parts of the letter and Paul wrote other parts. Indicate or imply that Paul was responsible for writing the letter, but Timothy was with him as he wrote. You may want to:

- Explain it in your translation. For example:

Also Timothy our brother is with me

and our brother Timothy greets you too

- Explain it in a footnote. An example footnote is:

Paul included Timothy here because the believers in Corinth knew Timothy (Acts 18:5). Probably Paul wrote the letter and Timothy supported his writing in some way.

Timothy: Timothy traveled with Paul (Acts 16–20), which included going to Corinth. Paul wrote two letters to him (1 Timothy and 2 Timothy).

our brother: Here the word brother refers to a believer in Jesus. The word indicates a close relationship, because all believers become children of God. In some languages a literal translation would wrongly refer only to an actual brother by birth. If that is true in your

language, you may want to explain in your translation. Some examples are:

our brother in Christ

fellow believer

who is also a follower (CEV)

1:1d

To the church of God in Corinth,

- To the church of God in Corinth,
- I write to God's people in the city/town of Corinth,
- I write to you^(plur) believers who meet together in Corinth.

To the church of God in Corinth: This phrase refers to the people to whom Paul wrote. In some languages it is more natural to use a full clause. For example:

I am writing to God's church in Corinth (NLT)

This letter is to the church of God in Corinth

church of God: The Greek word that the BSB translates as church refers to a gathering of people that someone summoned for a particular purpose. The phrase of God indicates that the gathering was a group of believers. The word church does not refer to a building. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

congregation of God

group of believers

gathering of those who follow God

The word or phrase you use should not refer to the separate groupings in the church of Jesus that exist today that each have their own name.

Corinth: This name refers to a city in southern Greece. It was an important city at that time. In some languages people are not familiar with the name Corinth. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Explain it in your translation. For example:

the city of Corinth

- Explain it in a footnote. For example:

Corinth is a city in southern Greece. It was an important city at that time.

1:1e

together with all the saints throughout Achaia:

- together with all the rest of God's holy people in the whole region of Achaia.
- and I want God's people in the other places/parts of Achaia to read this as well.
- May other believers in Achaia read this as well.

together with all the saints throughout Achaia: Paul wrote the letter to the believers in Corinth. This phrase indicates that Paul wanted the saints throughout Achaia to read the letter as well. Corinth was a city in a province then named Achaia. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

with all the saints who are in the whole of Achaia (ESV)

together with all God's people throughout the whole of Achaia (REB)

I invite all the saints throughout Achaia to read this letter as well.

saints: The Greek word that the BSB translates as saints is literally "holy ones." The word refers to all believers. For example:

God's people (GNT)

throughout Achaia: This phrase refers to the other villages and towns in the province of Achaia. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

in the whole of Achaia (RSV)

within the province of Achaia
Western Bukidnon Manobo Back Translation on TW.

Achaia: The name Achaia referred to a province that included Corinth and the southern part of Greece. In some languages people are not familiar with the name Achaia. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Explain it in your translation. For example:

the province/region of Achaia

- Explain it in a footnote. For example:

Achaia was the name of a province that included Corinth and the southern part of Greece.

2 Corinthians 1:2

Section 1:1–2: Paul and Timothy greeted the believers in Corinth

The beginning of Paul's letter follows the usual pattern for writing a letter at that time. The three parts are:

1. Paul introduced himself. He did this by writing his name, his position, and source of authority. He also mentioned Timothy, who helped him to serve the believers in Corinth.
2. Paul explained who he was writing to.
3. He greeted them.

Other examples of headings for this section are:

Introduction (NASB)

Greetings from Paul (NLT)

Opening remarks of the letter

Or you may not want to have any section heading here (as in the NIV and GNT).

1:2

Grace and peace to you from God our Father and the Lord Jesus Christ.

- ¶I May God our^(incl) Father and the Lord Jesus Christ give/bless you^(plur) with grace and peace.
- ¶I Greetings/Blessings of favor and peace from our Father God and our Lord Jesus Christ.
- ¶I May you receive grace and peace from our Father God and the Lord Jesus Christ.
- ¶I We^(excl) pray that God who is our^(incl) Father and Jesus Christ who is our leader/master will act kindly toward you and make your inner being restful.

Grace and peace to you: The clause Grace and peace to you begins similarly to the common greeting in letters at that time. But Paul changed the form of the Greek word from “greetings” to “grace” and added peace to make the greeting have a Christian message. Many New Testament letters begin this way.

This clause has no verbs. Paul asked God and Jesus to give the grace and peace. In some languages it is more natural to include a verb. For example:

May grace and peace be given to you

I ask that you may receive grace and peace

I ask God our Father and the Lord Jesus Christ to bless you with grace and peace

May God our Father and the Lord Jesus Christ give you grace and peace (GNT)

Grace: The word Grace here refers to God being kind to people, who do not deserve it. God does things for people because he wants to and not because they earned it. Here Paul asked God to show grace or be kind to his readers. Other ways to translate this are:

kindness

help

favor

voluntarily/graciously be kind

help as a gift/favor

peace: The word peace means “without anxiety” or “absence of conflict.” The word peace also refers to people being physically, mentally, and spiritually well, even when they have troubles and difficult circumstances.

In some languages, it will be better to translate peace using a verb. For example:

live peacefully

be at peace

God our Father: This phrase indicates that God has a relationship with believers such as a father has with his children. All believers are God's adopted children. This phrase does not indicate that God fathered children. In some languages translating literally would indicate the wrong meaning. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Explain the proper meaning in your translation. For example:

God our adoptive father

God our Father in heaven

God who is like a father to us

- Translate literally and explain the meaning in a footnote. An example footnote is:

The word “father” here indicates that God has a relationship with believers such as a father has with his children. All believers are his adopted children.

the Lord Jesus Christ: In some languages a possessive pronoun must be used with the word Lord. For example:

Jesus Christ who is our Lord

Lord: This word means “the one in authority over others” or “master.” Jesus has authority over all things.

Other ways to translate this word are:

Master

Chief

Owner

Sovereign

In some languages it will be necessary to add a word like “my” before such a word. For example:

my/our Chief/Sovereign

2 Corinthians 1:3

Section 1:3–11: Paul praised God for comforting him

In this section Paul told how he and his companions had suffered persecution in the Roman province of Asia (the southwestern part of what is now the country of Turkey). But God comforted and encouraged them during that time. Here Paul praised God for that (1:3). Paul also taught that those who receive comfort can comfort others (1:4–7). He explained his hardships in the province of Asia, how he felt during them, and his trust in God to deliver him from them (1:8–10). He acknowledged the prayers of the believers in Corinth

and indicated that God’s answer to those prayers would result in thanks to God (1:11).

Other examples of headings for this section are:

Paul’s Thanksgiving after Affliction (NRSV)

God comforted Paul and the Corinthians

1:3a

Blessed be the God and Father of our Lord Jesus Christ,

- ¶ Blessed be the God and Father of our^(incl) Lord Jesus Christ,
- ¶ God, who is God and Father to our Lord Jesus Christ, is worthy to be praised!

Blessed be the God and Father of our Lord Jesus Christ:

The Greek word that the BSB translates as Blessed be can also be translated as “Blessed is.” Paul declared that God was worthy to be praised. God is the Blessed One because of all he does for his people. Other ways to translate this clause are:

All praise to God, the Father of our Lord Jesus Christ (NLT)

Blessed be God, even the Father of our Lord Jesus Christ (KJV)

The Greek phrase does not have a verb here. It probably implies the verb “is/be” here. Other ways to translate this clause are:

Blessed be the God and Father of our Lord Jesus Christ (RSV)

The God and Father of our Lord Jesus Christ is worthy of praise

Praise the God and Father of our Lord Jesus Christ! (GW)

the God and Father of our Lord Jesus Christ: This phrase indicates that God is both the Father of Jesus and the God of Jesus. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

God, he is God to our Lord Jesus Christ and his Father

God who is God and Father of Jesu Cristo our Lord
Kankanaey Back Translation on TW.

If you have translated Ephesians 1:3, 1 Peter 1:3, or Romans 15:6, you may want to see how you translated this phrase there.

Father: When referring to God as Father, the word indicates that God has a relationship with Jesus that is like the relationship of a father to a son.

1:3b the Father of compassion

- he is the Father who is full of compassion/pity
- He is our^(incl) Father of/with all kinds of mercy

The words here begin a description of God that is separate from the praise/blessing of 1:3a. In some languages a new sentence here would be more natural. For example:

He is the Father who is compassionate... (GW)

God is our merciful Father... (NLT)

the Father of compassion: Here this phrase indicates that compassion/mercy describes God. Paul probably used Father here to imply that God is like a father to all who need compassion, meaning all people. For example:

the Father who is compassionate (GW)

the all-merciful Father (REB)

our merciful father
Western Bukidnon Manobo
Back Translation on TW.

compassion: This word refers to concern for someone with troubles and includes a desire to help that person. A person with compassion understands how someone feels when he is suffering. It is one of the ways a father feels toward his children when they are in trouble and need help. For example:

full of mercy (NCV)

The Greek word here is plural. The plural word probably indicates that all kinds of compassion are included. The plural may be a Hebrew idiom that has the same meaning as the singular. Either way, the word refers generally to compassion for others. For example:

all kinds of compassion

Also see the examples in the previous note.

1:3c and the God of all comfort,

- and the God who always comforts/encourages us^(incl),
- and he is always ready to make believers feel strong to face whatever happens to them.

all comfort: God comforts at all times and in all ways. Harris says “never-failing comfort of every variety” (p. 143). Other ways to translate this phrase are:

all kinds of comfort

God is full of comfort

comfort: The Greek word that the BSB translates as comfort also means “encouragement.” God comforted Paul in each of his distresses and troubles, and God encouraged Paul to be strong in faith.

The word comfort refers to speaking to or helping a person so that the person is less worried or troubled.

2 Corinthians 1:4

Section 1:3–11: Paul praised God for comforting him

In this section Paul told how he and his companions had suffered persecution in the Roman province of Asia (the southwestern part of what is now the country of Turkey). But God comforted and encouraged them during that time. Here Paul praised God for that (1:3). Paul also taught that those who receive comfort can comfort others (1:4–7). He explained his hardships in the province of Asia, how he felt during them, and his trust in God to deliver him from them (1:8–10). He acknowledged the prayers of the believers in Corinth and indicated that God’s answer to those prayers would result in thanks to God (1:11).

Other examples of headings for this section are:

Paul’s Thanksgiving after Affliction (NRSV)

God comforted Paul and the Corinthians

1:4a who comforts us in all our troubles,

- indeed/namely the one who comforts/encourages us^(incl) whenever we suffer,

- He comforts us every time hardships/difficulties happen to us.

who comforts us in all our troubles: This clause tells the reader more about God. In some languages a literal translation would wrongly indicate that there are other gods and only this one comforts us in all our troubles. If that is true in your language, translate this clause in a way that tells more about God. One way to do that is to start a new sentence here. For example:

He comforts us in all our troubles.

comforts us in all our troubles: The word troubles probably refers to persecution and physical dangers. Paul describes some of his troubles in 1:8–10 and 11:23–27. Other ways to translate this word are:

comforts us in all our hardships/difficulties

comforts us each time we undergo adversity

comforts us whenever we suffer (GW)

1:4b so that we can comfort those in any trouble

- so that we can comfort/encourage others whenever they suffer
- As a result, we are able to comfort every hardship/difficulty of others

so that: This phrase introduces the purpose or result of God's comfort (1:4a). Other ways to translate this phrase are:

in order that

As a result

That is why (GW)

1:4c with the comfort we ourselves have received from God.

- with the comfort/encouragement which we ourselves are comforted/encouraged by God.
- with the same comfort that God has given to us.

the comfort we ourselves have received from God: The Greek phrase is literally “the comfort with which we ourselves are comforted by God” (as in the RSV).

The Greek clause is passive. Some languages must use an active clause. For example:

the comfort with which God comforted us

the same comfort that God has given to us

2 Corinthians 1:5

Section 1:3–11: Paul praised God for comforting him

In this section Paul told how he and his companions had suffered persecution in the Roman province of Asia (the southwestern part of what is now the country of Turkey). But God comforted and encouraged them during that time. Here Paul praised God for that (1:3). Paul also taught that those who receive comfort can comfort others (1:4–7). He explained his hardships in the province of Asia, how he felt during them, and his trust in God to deliver him from them (1:8–10). He acknowledged the prayers of the believers in Corinth and indicated that God's answer to those prayers would result in thanks to God (1:11).

Other examples of headings for this section are:

Paul's Thanksgiving after Affliction (NRSV)

God comforted Paul and the Corinthians

1:5a For just as the sufferings of Christ overflow to us,

- Indeed, just as the things Christ suffered abound in our^(incl) lives,
- Because just as we suffer in the same ways that Christ suffered,

For: Here the conjunction For introduces an explanation of 1:4. It also indicates that 1:5a–b is the reason why Paul was able to comfort others (1:4). Other ways to translate this word are:

Indeed

Because (GW)

the sufferings of Christ overflow to us: The Greek phrase is literally “the sufferings of Christ abound to us.” This clause indicates that Paul and his coworkers suffered in the same ways that Jesus suffered. Other ways to translate this clause are:

the sufferings of Christ come on us in great measure

we participate in all the things that Christ suffered

Christ: The word Christ is a title for Jesus and means “the anointed one.” See how you translated this word in 1:1.

In some languages people always use both names “Jesus Christ” and never the title Christ alone. If that is true in your language, you may want to include the name “Jesus” here. For example:

Jesus Christ

us: Paul was probably referring here to himself and his coworkers in telling the gospel (1:8b).

1:5b

so also through Christ our comfort overflows.

- so also through Christ our^(incl) comfort/encouragement abounds.
- so also God abundantly comforts us through Christ our mediator.

through Christ our comfort overflows: The Greek clause is literally “through Christ our comfort abounds.” This clause indicates that God abundantly comforts us because Jesus reconciled us to God. So the comfort comes through him. Other ways to translate this clause are:

through Christ encouragement comes to us in great measure

our comfort is abundant through Christ

we are abundantly comforted through Christ

through Christ: This phrase is emphasized in the Greek. If you have a natural way to emphasize this clause, you may want to do so.

Here the word through indicates that Jesus mediates for us. He speaks to God on behalf of the believers. Here in some languages the meaning of through would not be clear here. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Explain the meaning in your translation. For example:

by what Christ does for us

through Christ who mediates for us

- Explain the meaning in a footnote. For example:

The phrase indicates that Jesus intercedes for believers before God.

2 Corinthians 1:6

Section 1:3–11: Paul praised God for comforting him

In this section Paul told how he and his companions had suffered persecution in the Roman province of Asia (the southwestern part of what is now the country of Turkey). But God comforted and encouraged them during that time. Here Paul praised God for that (1:3). Paul also taught that those who receive comfort can comfort others (1:4–7). He explained his hardships in the province of Asia, how he felt during them, and his trust in God to deliver him from them (1:8–10). He acknowledged the prayers of the believers in Corinth and indicated that God’s answer to those prayers would result in thanks to God (1:11).

Other examples of headings for this section are:

Paul’s Thanksgiving after Affliction (NRSV)

God comforted Paul and the Corinthians

1:6

Here, Paul told about the outcome or result of the sufferings that he and his co-workers (the pronoun “we”) experienced; it was the comfort the believers in Corinth (the pronoun “you”) received. Paul’s distress about the problems among the believers in Corinth led to both Paul and the believers being comforted.

1:6a–b

1:6 begins with a Greek conjunction that is often translated “but,” “and,” or “so.” The theme continues from 1:3–5, so the conjunction probably means “and” here. For example:

And (KJV)

The BSB has not translated this conjunction, and some languages do not need to translate it here either.

If we are afflicted, it is for your comfort and salvation; if we are comforted, it is for your comfort:

There is a textual issue in 1:6b: (1) The earliest Greek manuscripts have the word comfort (BSB, RSV, NIV,

GNT, NJB, NASB, NLT, GW, CEV, NET, JBP, REB, ESV, NCV). (2) Some later Greek manuscripts have the words comfort and salvation (KJV only). It is recommended that you follow option (1). Both situations (afflicted, comforted) and their results are assumed to be true here. Using If requires the readers to think about what Paul said and agree with him. Other ways to translate these clause are:

If we are afflicted, it is for your comfort and salvation; and if we are comforted, it is for your comfort (RSV)

if we are afflicted, it is for your comfort and salvation; or if we are comforted, it is for your comfort (NASB)

In some languages using If here implies that the readers might not be comforted or saved. If that is true in your language, you may want to translate these clauses without the If. For example:

When we are distressed, you will be comforted and saved. And when we are comforted, you will also be comforted

Even when we are weighed down with troubles, it is for your comfort and salvation! For when we ourselves are comforted, we will certainly comfort you (NLT)

1:6a

If we are afflicted, it is for your comfort and salvation;

- But if hardships/troubles come/press against us^(excl), the results are that God comforts you^(plur) and saves you,
- And/So if we experience/undergo hardships/difficulties, your benefits are comfort and salvation.
- When we suffer, it benefits you so that you may be comforted and saved,

afflicted: This word refers to both the trouble that occurs and the suffering a person experiences from that trouble. Other ways to translate this word are:

experience trouble (JBP)

hardships to undergo (NJB)

salvation: This word means “the act of rescuing someone from danger or trouble.” In this context it refers to “rescuing someone from the spiritual dangers of sin and death.” The word is a noun that refers to an event. In some languages it is more natural to translate with a verb here. For example:

saving/freeing by God of his people

for God to save his people

being saved from death

Here Paul probably implied that when he preached the gospel, people persecuted him. But he accepted that distress from the persecution because people in Corinth believed and God saved them. So salvation is not a direct result of the distress, but both distress and salvation are results of preaching. In some languages a literal translation would wrongly indicate that distress or oppression causes God to save other people. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Explain in your translation. For example:

salvation through our preaching

- Translate literally and explain the meaning in a footnote. An example footnote is:

This verse indicates that preaching the gospel of Jesus causes persecution. This distresses the preacher, but the preaching causes people to believe, which leads to their salvation.

1:6b

if we are comforted, it is for your comfort,

- and if we^(excl) are comforted/encouraged, the result is that God comforts you,
- Also, if God comforts us, your benefit is comfort.
- and when we receive comfort, it also benefits you so that you may receive comfort.

we are comforted: This clause is passive. Some languages must use an active clause. For example:

God comforts us

we receive comfort

1:6c

which accomplishes in you patient endurance of the same sufferings we experience.

- which enables you to persevere in/through the same kinds of suffering as we have.
- And from that comfort, you can patiently endure the same sufferings as us.

which accomplishes in you patient endurance of the same sufferings we experience: God's comfort strengthened their faith. Then they could patiently endure sufferings. Other ways to translate this clause are:

which enables you to bear with perseverance the same sufferings as we do (NJB)

from that comfort, you can persevere in/through the same sufferings that we also suffer

This clause tells the reader more about comfort to the believers in Corinth. In some languages, other ways must be used to indicate the correct meaning. For example:

...it is for your comfort. It produces in you patient endurance of the same sufferings we suffer

This helps you to accept patiently the same sufferings we have. (NCV)

which: This word refers to their comfort (1:6b).

patient endurance: The Greek word that the BSB translates as patient endurance refers to continuing to follow God even though there are hardships or opposition. The attitude of patience is included in the meaning. Other ways to translate the Greek word are:

perseverance

patience to continue

the same sufferings we experience: The word same indicates that the believers in Corinth and Paul both suffered in the same ways. Paul was not in Corinth, but both Paul and the believers suffered for their faith. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

the same kinds of suffering we have/experience

suffering like ours (CEV)

2 Corinthians 1:7**Section 1:3–11: Paul praised God for comforting him**

In this section Paul told how he and his companions had suffered persecution in the Roman province of Asia (the southwestern part of what is now the country of Turkey). But God comforted and encouraged them during that time. Here Paul praised God for that (1:3). Paul also taught that those who receive comfort can comfort others (1:4–7). He explained his hardships in the province of Asia, how he felt during them, and his trust in God to deliver him from them (1:8–10). He acknowledged the prayers of the believers in Corinth and indicated that God's answer to those prayers would result in thanks to God (1:11).

Other examples of headings for this section are:

Paul's Thanksgiving after Affliction (NRSV)

God comforted Paul and the Corinthians

1:7a

And our hope for you is sure,

- And our^(excl) confidence regarding you^(plur) in these/those things is certain/secure,
- Our assurance concerning you is strong/steadfast,
- And we^(excl) are strongly/steadfastly assured about/concerning you,

And: There are two ways to interpret the Greek word that the BSB translates as And:

1. The conjunction continues the theme from the previous sentence. In English this is done with either And or with no conjunction (as in the RSV). For example:

and (NASB) (BSB, RSV, NIV, NASB, NLT, GW, CEV, NET, REB, ESV, NCV, KJV)

1. The conjunction introduces the result or conclusion of 1:6. Here is another way to translate this:

So (GNT) (GNT, NJB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because that is the usual meaning of the Greek word. Thrall (p. 79), Martin (p. 7), Barrett (p. 57), Furnish (p. 108), and Kistemaker (p. 45) translate it as "and."

hope for you: Paul may hope that:

1. the believers will accept God's comfort and patiently endure suffering;
2. the believers will continue to believe in Jesus.

Translate in a way that allows one or both meanings. Some languages must say what is hoped. If that is true in your language, follow (1) or (2). For example:

hope regarding your endurance

hope about you continuing to follow Jesus

hope: The Greek word that the BSB translates hope means "expectation" or "looking forward with confidence that something will happen." The Greek word is usually more certain than the English word hope. Other ways of translating this are:

assurance

confidence (GW)

for you: Here the word for means "about" or "concerning." See the examples above.

sure: Here the word sure means "strong," "steadfast," or "certain." Paul would not lose his hope in the believers. Other ways to translate this word are:

secure (NJB)

steadfast (NET)

1:7b

because we know that just as you share in our sufferings,

- knowing that just as you join with us in experiencing hardships/sufferings,
- for we know that just like you suffer in the same ways as we do,

because we know: The Greek word that the BSB translates as because we know is literally "knowing." In this context it indicates that Paul knew that the believers shared in his suffering and comfort, so he was assured about their faith. Other ways of translating this are:

knowing (NASB)

for we know (RSV)

in the knowledge that (NJB)

you share in our sufferings: Like Paul, the believers suffered for the sake of Jesus and his gospel. In this way they shared in the sufferings. This clause may include persecution during the time Paul was in Corinth, or this clause may include the believers having pity for Paul and his sufferings. Other ways to translate this clause are:

you have to suffer troubles as we have done (JBP)

you join with us in experiencing hardships/sufferings

our sufferings: The Greek phrase is literally "the sufferings" (as in the KJV and REB). This Greek phrase probably refers to sufferings that believers have because of persecution. But these are the same sufferings that Paul experienced (1:5a), and so some English versions add the implied our.

1:7c

so also you will share in our comfort.

- so also you join with us as God comforts/encourages us.
- you also receive comfort in the same ways as we do.
- so also you join with us in experiencing God's comfort/encouragement.

you will share in our comfort: Just as God comforted Paul, God also comforted the Corinthian believers. In this way they shared the comfort. Other ways to translate this clause are:

you are comforted as we are

you join with us in experiencing comfort

our comfort: The Greek phrase is literally "the comfort/encouragement/consolation" (as in the KJV and REB). This Greek phrase probably refers to God comforting believers because of persecution. But this is the same comfort that Paul experienced (1:4c) and so some English versions add the implied our.

1:7a-c

(reordered) We know that just as you join with us in our sufferings, so also you join with us in our comfort, and our hope for you in those things is firm.

2 Corinthians 1:8

Section 1:3–11: Paul praised God for comforting him

In this section Paul told how he and his companions had suffered persecution in the Roman province of Asia (the southwestern part of what is now the country of Turkey). But God comforted and encouraged them during that time. Here Paul praised God for that (1:3). Paul also taught that those who receive comfort can comfort others (1:4–7). He explained his hardships in the province of Asia, how he felt during them, and his trust in God to deliver him from them (1:8–10). He acknowledged the prayers of the believers in Corinth and indicated that God's answer to those prayers would result in thanks to God (1:11).

Other examples of headings for this section are:

Paul's Thanksgiving after Affliction (NRSV)

God comforted Paul and the Corinthians

1:8a

We do not want you to be unaware, brothers,

- ¶ Brothers and sisters, we^(excl) do not want you^(plur) to be unaware/uninformed
- ¶ Our fellow believers, we want you to clearly know

1:8 begins with a Greek conjunction that is often translated as “for” or “because.” In this context it introduces an explanation of some of Paul's suffering (1:5a,7b). For example:

For (RSV)

In some languages it is more natural to omit the conjunction and allow the context to indicate the connection. The BSB has not translated this conjunction.

We do not want you to be unaware, brothers:

Here the term of address, brothers, comes after Paul begins saying something to the Corinthians. In some languages it is more natural to have the term of address first. For example:

Brothers, we do not want you to be uninformed

We do not want you to be unaware: This clause indicates that Paul wanted the believers to know about his hardships. Other ways to translate this clause are:

we do not want you to be ignorant (RSV)

we want you to know (NCV)

brothers: Here the word brothers refers to fellow believers. The Greek word refers to both men and women here. Other ways to translate this word are:

Brothers and sisters (NCV)

siblings in our^(incl) faith

fellow believers

1:8b

of the hardships we encountered in the province of Asia.

- about how we suffered in the province of Asia.
- about the big trouble which happened to us in the territory of Asia.

hardships: This is the same Greek word that the BSB translates as “troubles” in 1:4a–b and the Greek verb form translated “afflicted” in 1:6a. Other ways to translate this word are:

difficulties

adversity

the suffering we experienced (GW)

province: The BSB adds the word province to indicate that the name “Asia” refers to the Roman province called “Asia.” The word province refers to a large region. The Romans conquered a number of small countries and grouped them into the province of Asia.

Asia: The province of Asia included most of the land in what is now western Turkey. In some languages a literal translation would wrongly refer to the modern-day region of the world that includes China and India. If that is true in your language, you may want to explain in a footnote. For example:

At that time, the name “Asia” referred to a province that included most of the land in what is now southwestern Turkey.

1:8c

We were under a burden far beyond our ability to endure,

- We were burdened with troubles/difficulties to the extreme, beyond our strength to cope/endure,
- Excessive burdens/difficulties/hardships came upon us, which were more than we could bear/stand-against.

We were under a burden far beyond our ability to endure: The Greek word that the BSB translates as far refers to an excess of something. Here it indicates an excessive amount of pressure. The difficulties were worse than anything Paul and the others could stand against by their own power or abilities. For example:

we were burdened excessively, beyond our strength (NASB)

The burden of it was far too heavy for us to bear (REB)

we were completely overwhelmed, the burden was more than we could bear (JBP)

We were under a burden: The Greek clause is literally “we were burdened excessively” (as in the NASB). The difficulties they had were figuratively like carrying a great weight. Paul and the other evangelists often faced much persecution and opposition (as in Acts 19:23–41). Translate in a way that includes such things as persecution and opposition. Other ways to translate this clause are:

The burdens laid upon us were so great (GNT)

We were crushed and overwhelmed (NLT)

Our sufferings were so horrible (CEV)

1:8d

so that we despaired even of life.

- so that we did not think we could continue to live.
- It was so bad, we thought we could not live beyond them.

we despaired even of life: The Greek phrase is literally “to despair us even to live.” These difficulties were so great that Paul and the others thought that the difficulties might cause their death. Other ways to translate this clause are:

we despaired of life itself (RSV)

we gave up all hope even of surviving (NJB)

we thought we would never live through it (NLT)

we did not think we could continue to live

2 Corinthians 1:9

Section 1:3–11: Paul praised God for comforting him

In this section Paul told how he and his companions had suffered persecution in the Roman province of Asia (the southwestern part of what is now the country of Turkey). But God comforted and encouraged them during that time. Here Paul praised God for that (1:3). Paul also taught that those who receive comfort can comfort others (1:4–7). He explained his hardships in the province of Asia, how he felt during them, and his trust in God to deliver him from them (1:8–10). He acknowledged the prayers of the believers in Corinth and indicated that God’s answer to those prayers would result in thanks to God (1:11).

Other examples of headings for this section are:

Paul’s Thanksgiving after Affliction (NRSV)

God comforted Paul and the Corinthians

1:9a

Indeed, we felt we were under the sentence of death,

- Truly in our^(excl) hearts/insides we knew that we had received the decision for our death,
- In fact, we were convinced that we would be killed.
- Indeed, we were certain that someone would kill us because we obey/follow Jesus.

Indeed: The Greek word here is usually translated “But” (as in the KJV). However, the contrast to 1:8 is not clear, so many English versions translate this Greek word as emphasis here. For example:

In fact (NJB)

we felt we were under the sentence of death: Paul and the other evangelists felt that they would not live to old age, but that people would persecute and kill them. Other ways to translate this clause are:

we had the sentence of death within ourselves (NASB)

we were carrying the sentence of death within our own selves (NJB)

we felt sure that we would be killed

we were certain that someone would kill us

the sentence of death: The Greek word that the BSB translates as sentence usually refers to an official answer or decision made by someone in authority. In this context, Paul and his companions probably did not receive an official answer from someone that they must die, but they felt as if they had. See the examples above.

1:9b

in order that we would not trust in ourselves,

- in order that we should not trust in ourselves
- But that occurred so that we will not rely on our own power

in order that: The Greek phrase is literally “so that” (as in the NJB). The Greek conjunction introduces the purpose for what Paul said in 1:9a. Another way to translate this Greek word is:

But this made us (CEV)

we would not trust in ourselves: Here the word would indicates that Paul and the others should not rely on themselves. For example:

we should rely, not on ourselves (GNT)

not trust in ourselves: The word trust refers to trusting in something. Paul and the others would not trust in their own strength or abilities to escape death. For example:

trust not in ourselves (NJB)

1:9c

but in God, who raises the dead.

- but in God, the one who raises the dead.
- but rather we should rely only on God. He has the power to make live again those who have died.

in God: Some words from 1:9b are implied but not repeated here. In some languages it is more natural to repeat some of those words. For example:

we would trust in God

who raises the dead: This clause is a general statement about God raising the dead when he wants to and that he will one day raise everyone for judgment. Translate this clause as a general statement. Other ways to translate this clause are:

who can raise the dead (JBP)

who has the power to raise the dead back to life

This clause tells the reader more about God. In some languages a literal translation would wrongly indicate that there are other gods and only this one raises the dead. If that is true in your language, translate this clause in a way that tells more about God. For example:

for he raises the dead

He raises the dead.

raises the dead: This phrase refers to causing someone to live again after he has died. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

makes live again those who have died

brings the dead back to life (GW)

2 Corinthians 1:10

Section 1:3–11: Paul praised God for comforting him

In this section Paul told how he and his companions had suffered persecution in the Roman province of Asia (the southwestern part of what is now the country of Turkey). But God comforted and encouraged them during that time. Here Paul praised God for that (1:3). Paul also taught that those who receive comfort can comfort others (1:4–7). He explained his hardships in the province of Asia, how he felt during them, and his trust in God to deliver him from them (1:8–10). He acknowledged the prayers of the believers in Corinth and indicated that God’s answer to those prayers would result in thanks to God (1:11).

Other examples of headings for this section are:

Paul’s Thanksgiving after Affliction (NRSV)

God comforted Paul and the Corinthians

1:10a**He has delivered us from such a deadly peril,**

- Indeed he who rescued/saved us^(excl) out of so great a danger of death
- He rescued us from a great threat of death

He: The Greek word is literally “who.” The phrase continues the thought from 1:9c and keeps the focus on God. But in some languages, it is more natural to begin a new sentence here, as many English versions do. Some examples are:

He who (NRSV)

It was God who (JBP)

has delivered: Here the word delivered refers to rescuing someone from danger. Sometime earlier, God delivered/rescued them from death. Other ways to translate this clause are:

did save (NJB)

rescued (NRSV)

such a deadly peril: There is a textual issue here:

1. In some Greek manuscripts, the phrase is singular: so great a death. The phrase refers to a time when Paul and the others were in great danger of being killed. For example:

so deadly a peril (RSV) (BSB, RSV, NIV, NJB, NASB, NLT, GW, CEV, NET, REB, ESV, KJV)

1. In other Greek manuscripts, the phrase is plural: such great (dangers of) deaths. The phrase refers to several times when Paul and the others were in great danger of being killed. For example:

such terrible dangers of death (GNT) (GNT, NABRE, NCV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1), since the UBS Greek New Testament recommends it.

The Greek phrase probably refers to a great danger of being killed. The phrase may also imply that it was a very terrible kind of death. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

such a death (NJB)

such mortal peril (REB)

so great a risk/threat of death

1:10b**and He will deliver us.**

- will continue to rescue/save us.
- and he will rescue us from such threats in the future.

He will deliver: There is a textual issue in 1:10b: (1) The earliest Greek manuscripts have the expression he will deliver (BSB, RSV, NIV, GNT, NJB, NASB, NLT, GW, CEV, NET, JBP, REB, ESV, NCV). (2) Some later Greek manuscripts have the expression he does deliver. The KJV says “doth deliver” (KJV only). It is recommended that you follow option (1). Here the word deliver refers to rescuing someone. For example:

he will rescue us again (NLT)

1:10c**In Him we have placed our hope that He will yet again deliver us,**

- In him we trust/hope that he will rescue/save us yet/once again,
- We are confident that he will rescue us again,

In Him we have placed our hope: Here the word In indicates that Paul and the others expected or trusted God to deliver them. Other ways to translate this clause are:

in whom we hope/trust

we are relying on him (NJB)

we trust him (JBP)

placed our hope: The Greek clause is literally “we have hoped.” The Greek verb means “(confidently) expect.” They expected that God would deliver/rescue them. The Greek clause indicates that they began hoping earlier and continued to do so. Other ways to translate this word are:

trust (JBP)

are confident (GW)

are sure (CEV)

He will yet again deliver us: The Greek clause is literally “also yet/still he will deliver us.” Paul and the others trusted that God would deliver them at another future time. Other ways to translate this clause are:

he will deliver us again (ESV)

he will continue to rescue us (GW)

he will do so in the future

2 Corinthians 1:11

Section 1:3–11: Paul praised God for comforting him

In this section Paul told how he and his companions had suffered persecution in the Roman province of Asia (the southwestern part of what is now the country of Turkey). But God comforted and encouraged them during that time. Here Paul praised God for that (1:3). Paul also taught that those who receive comfort can comfort others (1:4–7). He explained his hardships in the province of Asia, how he felt during them, and his trust in God to deliver him from them (1:8–10). He acknowledged the prayers of the believers in Corinth and indicated that God’s answer to those prayers would result in thanks to God (1:11).

Other examples of headings for this section are:

Paul’s Thanksgiving after Affliction (NRSV)

God comforted Paul and the Corinthians

1:11a

as you help us by your prayers.

- since you^(plur) labor together with us^(excl) in prayer for these things.
- as you join us with your praying.

as you help us by your prayers: The Greek clause is literally “you also working-together for us by praying.” There are three ways to interpret this clause:

1. Paul knew that the believers were praying for him and the others. For example:

since you are also joining to help us when you pray for us (GW) (BSB, NIV, GNT, NJB, NABRE, NRSV, NASB, NLT, NET, GW, REB, KJV)

1. Paul requested that the believers pray for him and the others. For example:

You also must help us by prayer (RSV) (RSV, ESV, CEV)

1. Paul encouraged the believers to pray for him and the others. For example:

you can help us with your prayers (NCV) (NCV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), since the Greek verb indicates continuing action. Thrall translates this as “whilst you also co-operate by prayer on our behalf” (p. 78).

Other ways to translate this clause are:

as you help us by means of your prayers for us (GNT)

while you co-operate by praying for us (REB)

help us: The Greek word is literally “working-together.” Paul and the believers in Corinth were both praying for Paul’s ministry. In that way they were working together. For example:

join in helping us (NET)

prayers: The word prayers refers to the event of speaking to God, either to praise Him, thank Him, or ask Him something. This term does not refer to ritualistic words or words of magic. Use the proper word or phrase in your language.

1:11b

Then many will give thanks on our behalf

- So then, many believers will thank God for us
- Therefore, many people will thank God on our behalf

Then: The Greek word is literally “so that” (as in the RSV). The results of the believers in Corinth praying (and God answering) would be that many other believers would thank God for answering those prayers. For example:

So (GNT)

many: The Greek phrase is literally “many faces.” The word “faces” refers figuratively to people. Here this phrase refers to many believers in places other than Corinth. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

many people (NLT)

many believers

on our behalf: This phrase indicates that the believers would thank God for what he had done for Paul and the other evangelists. For example:

for us (GNT)

1:11c

for the favor shown us in answer to their prayers.

- for the gift/favor of God's help to us when God will answer the prayers of many believers.
- when he favors us with an answer/response because many people prayed for us.

the favor shown us: The Greek phrase is literally "the gift/favor to us." This phrase refers to the help that God gave to Paul and the others. The help was a gift, because Paul and the others had not earned it. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

God's favour shown to us (NJB)

the gracious gift given to us (NET)

God's gracious favour towards us (REB)

the blessings we receive (CEV)

in answer to their prayers: This phrase explains why God favored Paul and the others. Many believers prayed for Paul and the others, and God answered those prayers. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

many prayers for us will be answered (GNT)

as the result of the prayers of so many (NJB)

because many people prayed for us (GW)

The false teachers probably tried to discredit Paul in any way they could so that they could become the leaders of the church at Corinth. After Paul left Corinth, the false teachers accused him of various wrongdoings, but in this division, Paul explained his actions and explained that their accusations were wrong. One such accusation was that Paul was not keeping his promise to visit. He explained his change of plans in 1:12-2:4. He also repeatedly encouraged the believers in these verses to obey the correct teachings.

2 Corinthians 1:12

Section 1:12-2:4: Paul's change in plans

In this section Paul explained that he had earlier planned to visit the Corinthians two times, once on his way to the province of Macedonia and again on his way back from there (1:15-16). But he probably came earlier than planned and had a painful visit (2:1). After he returned to Ephesus, he wrote a painful letter (7:8-9). He then went to Macedonia via Troas (2:12-13) instead of via Corinth. The false teachers probably accused him of not being trustworthy because he had changed his plans. So Paul explained in these verses why he had changed his plans.

Other examples of headings for this section are:

Paul's Integrity (NASB)

Why Paul changed his plans (NJB)

Paul explained his change of plans

1:12a

And this is our boast:

- ¶ Indeed, our^(excl) boast is this:
- ¶ Now, one thing we are proud of is this,

And: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates here as And is often translated as "for" or "because." But in this context, the conjunction introduces a new theme and only generally connects back to the previous theme. The GNT and NJB allow the context to indicate a new theme and omit this conjunction. The conjunction may emphasize the new theme. For example:

Indeed (NRSV)

There is one thing that... (NJB)

this is our boast: This clause indicates that the boast follows in 1:12b-g. Other ways to translate this clause are:

our boast is this (RSV)

There is one thing that we are proud of, namely (NJB)

boast: This word refers to praising someone or saying how good someone is. Paul used it in both a positive

and a negative way. Here he used it in a positive way: to be happy about how he acted. God enabled him to live in a holy and sincere manner (1:12e).

1:12b

Our conscience testifies that

- our conscience accurately/faithfully reports that
- and our inner being truthfully asserts that

conscience: The Greek word that the BSB translates as conscience refers to the record of past deeds that a person has in his mind. Paul knew he did nothing wrong, so his conscience was clear and not troubled. Therefore his conscience testified that he had done nothing wrong. Other ways to translate this word are:

inner being

ways of thinking

convictions of the mind

testifies: This word means “report what one saw.” The word is often used where the person is expected to be truthful and accurate. Here Paul knew that his conscience accurately claimed he had done nothing wrong. His conscience was not deceiving him. Other ways to translate this word are:

faithfully reports

accurately/truthfully asserts

1:12c

we have conducted ourselves in the world,

- everything we have done toward people,
- whatever we did toward other people in the world,

we have conducted ourselves: Here the word conducted refers to the way they lived and the things they did. Other ways to translate this clause are:

we have behaved (RSV)

everything we have done (NCV)

in the world: Here the word world refers figuratively to the people of the world. Paul referred to people in general here and then to believers in 1:12d. The word does not imply that the people are evil here. For example:

towards everyone (NJB)

1:12d

and especially in relation to you,

- and above all how we have behaved toward you^(plur),
- and even more so whatever we did toward you,

especially: Paul and the others put special emphasis on doing the right things with the believers in Corinth. Other ways to translate this word are:

all the more (NET)

above all (REB)

in relation to you: The Greek phrase is literally “toward you” (as in the RSV). The phrase “we have conducted ourselves” (1:12c) is implied but not repeated here. For example:

when we were with you (CEV)

1:12e

in the holiness and sincerity that are from God—

- was done in an honest and sincere way, which are attitudes from God.
- God enabled us to do them openly and with true/straight motives.

the holiness and sincerity that are from God: The Greek phrase is literally “simplicity and sincerity of God.” There are two ways to interpret how the phrase “of God” connects to “simplicity and sincerity”:

1. It connects to both simplicity and sincerity. God is the source of both attitudes. For example:

God-given frankness and sincerity (GNT) (BSB, NIV, GNT, NABRE, NLT, GW, NET, NCV)

1. It connects only to sincerity. For example:

simplicity and godly sincerity (ESV) (RSV, NASB, ESV, REB, KJV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Thrall (p. 128) and Harris (p. 183) translate according to interpretation (1). Barnett (p. 95) says, “Each is ‘of God,’ that is, true of God and issuing from God in the course of his service of God.”

the holiness and sincerity: There is a textual issue regarding the Greek word that the BSB translates as holiness here:

1. Some Greek manuscripts have the word that means simplicity or frankness. For example:

we have had an honest and sincere heart from God (NCV) (GNT, NRSV, NABRE, CEV, NET, ESV, NCV, KJV)

1. Other Greek manuscripts have the word that means holiness. For example:

with holiness and godly sincerity (RSV) (BSB, RSV, NIV, NJB, NASB, NLT, GW, REB)

It is recommended that you follow option (1), since the UBS Greek New Testament recommends it.

The Greek word refers to something being sincere or honest. Nothing is hidden. All that Paul and the others did was from good motives. Other ways to translate this word are:

openly

without hiding/withholding anything

sincerity: This word refers to having pure motives. Paul and the others did not do anything for selfish or wrong reasons. Other ways to translate this word are:

true/straight motives

for no evil reasons

that are from God: This phrase indicates that God caused Paul and the others to have the attitudes of openness and sincerity. For example:

God-given (GNT)

General Comment on 1:12c–e

1:12c–e in Greek has the manner (1:12e) before the main clause (1:12c) and the emphasized clause (1:12d). This order may be more natural in some languages. For example:

^{12e}in the openness and sincerity that are from God ^{12c}we have conducted ourselves in the world, ^{12d}and especially in our relations with you.

In some languages it is more natural to have the manner clause after the main clause but before the emphasized clause. For example:

^{12c}we have conducted ourselves in the world ^{12e}in the openness and sincerity that are from God. ^{12d}We have conducted ourselves this way especially in our relationship with you.

1:12f–g (reordered) We have done like that according to God’s grace and not according to worldly wisdom.

not in worldly wisdom, but in the grace of God: These phrases contrast worldly wisdom with the grace of God. The two are very different. In some languages it is more natural to have the positive saying first. For example:

according to God’s grace but/and not according to worldly wisdom

1:12f not in worldly wisdom,

- We^(excl) have not depended on human wisdom
- We have not lived according to thoughts considered wise by people who do not follow God.

not in worldly wisdom: 1:12a–g is one sentence in the Greek and the BSB. But some translations divide the sentence by adding a phrase here to make reading and understanding easier. For example:

And we were guided by God’s wonderful kindness instead of by the wisdom of this world. (CEV)

We have done so, relying not on worldly wisdom but on God’s grace. (NIV)

worldly wisdom: The word wisdom means “the ability to understand events and know the right action.” But in this context, the phrase worldly wisdom refers to the thoughts that seem wise to people who do not follow God. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

thoughts considered wise by worldly people

worldly people’s so-called wise thoughts

Paul disliked and avoided using worldly wisdom. Your translation should not imply that worldly wisdom was a good thing that Paul chose not to use.

worldly: The Greek word that the BSB translates as worldly refers to wisdom that people discover without help from God. It implies that these people do not follow God. Other ways of translating this word are:

unspiritual

earthly (RSV)

our own human (NLT)

1:12g but in the grace of God.

- but we depended on God's undeserved favor.
- Instead, we lived according to God's way of being kind to those who do not deserve it.

the grace of God: The word grace here refers to God being kind to those who do not deserve it. God does things for people because he wants to and not because they earned it. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

kindness from God

God's help

God's favor

voluntarily/graciously be kind

help as a gift/favor

See how you translated the word grace in 1:2.

2 Corinthians 1:13

Section 1:12–2:4: Paul's change in plans

In this section Paul explained that he had earlier planned to visit the Corinthians two times, once on his way to the province of Macedonia and again on his way back from there (1:15–16). But he probably came earlier than planned and had a painful visit (2:1). After he returned to Ephesus, he wrote a painful letter (7:8–9). He then went to Macedonia via Troas (2:12–13) instead of via Corinth. The false teachers probably accused him of not being trustworthy because he had

changed his plans. So Paul explained in these verses why he had changed his plans.

Other examples of headings for this section are:

Paul's Integrity (NASB)

Why Paul changed his plans (NJB)

Paul explained his change of plans

1:13a

For we do not write you anything that is beyond your ability to read and understand.

- For when we^(excl) write to you, none of it is unreadable or impossible to understand.
- The fact is, we always write to you^(plur) so that you can read and understand.

For: This conjunction introduces an explanation. 1:13 explains why Paul and the others were open and sincere according to God's grace with the believers in Corinth.

we do not write you anything that is beyond your ability to read and understand: The Greek clause can be translated literally as "we do not write to you anything different than what you read or indeed understand." The clause indicates that Paul always wrote plainly, with no hidden messages. Also, it indicates that the believers in Corinth would easily understand his meaning. They did not need to try to discover any hidden message in his letters, because there was none. Other ways to translate this clause are:

we write to you nothing other than the things you read or/and also understand

we always write to you things you can read and indeed do understand

we do not write to you anything different from what you have already read from us or different from what you already know from us

1:13b

And I hope that you will understand us completely,

- But/And I hope/trust that you will fully understand
- I am confident that you will one day fully understand

And: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as And is often translated as "but." There is some

contrast between Paul knowing they understood him in the past and his hope that they will fully understand him in the future. For example:

But (GNT)

Some languages can use “and” or allow the context to indicate that Paul continued the same theme.

2 Corinthians 1:14

Section 1:12–2:4: Paul’s change in plans

In this section Paul explained that he had earlier planned to visit the Corinthians two times, once on his way to the province of Macedonia and again on his way back from there (1:15–16). But he probably came earlier than planned and had a painful visit (2:1). After he returned to Ephesus, he wrote a painful letter (7:8–9). He then went to Macedonia via Troas (2:12–13) instead of via Corinth. The false teachers probably accused him of not being trustworthy because he had changed his plans. So Paul explained in these verses why he had changed his plans.

Other examples of headings for this section are:

Paul’s Integrity (NASB)

Why Paul changed his plans (NJB)

Paul explained his change of plans

1:14a

as you have already understood us in part,

- as you^(plur) have partially understood us^(excl),
- as you have partly understood why we did those things among you

as you have already understood us in part: The RSV, the GW, and Barrett (p. 73) ignore the Greek word that the BSB translates as “us” and refer here to understanding what Paul had written earlier (1:13). Barrett does not explain why he does so, and it is not clear why the RSV and GW ignore that word. This clause indicates that the believers had only partially understood Paul’s motives, honesty, conduct, and teachings. Other ways to translate this clause are:

just as you have already understood us partially (NJB)

as you have not understood us fully

Some languages must say what is understood. If that is true in your language, you should add something similar to what Paul talked about in 1:12. For example:

as you have partly understood how we conducted ourselves among you

as you have partly understood why we did those things among you

1:14b

so that you may

- that you can
- so that you will

so that you may: Here the phrase so that you may indicates a future time. For example:

you will understand (RSV)

so that: There are two ways to interpret the Greek word that the BSB translates as so that:

1. The word indicates that 1:14c–d is what Paul wanted the believers to understand. He wanted them to understand fully that they could boast in Paul and his ministry. For example:

I hope you will understand fully...that you can be proud of us (RSV) (RSV, NIV, NJB, NASB, NABRE, NET, REB, ESV, KJV)

1. The word indicates that 1:14c–d is the result of 1:13b–14b. For example:

I hope that you will come to understand us completely, so that...you can be as proud (GNT) (BSB, GNT, NLT, CEV, NCV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), with the majority of English versions. Harris (p. 188) says the clause introduced with *hoti* here “defines the content of the understanding.” Furnish (p. 128) says it “specifies what Paul hopes the Corinthians will understand.”

General Comment on 1:13b–1:14b

Some English versions put part of 1:13b after 1:14a in order to make the connection from 1:13b to 1:14b–d clear. For example:

^{13b}I hope that, ^{14a}as you have understood us in part,
^{13b}you will come to understand fully ^{14b}that... (NIV)

Other translations, including the BSB, follow the Greek order. For example:

^{13b}And I hope that you will come to understand fully, ^{14a}as you have understood in part, ^{14b}that... (RSV)

The GNT puts all of 1:13b after 1:14a and combines the verse numbers:

¹³⁻¹⁴We write to you only what you can read and understand. But even though you now understand us only in part, I hope that you will come to understand us completely, so that... (GNT)

1:14c boast of us

- boast about us
- be proud of us

boast of us: The Greek clause is literally “we are your boast.” As in 1:12a, this word refers to talking proudly about someone or something in a positive way. The believers will boast about Paul and all the great things he did for God and for them. See how you translated the word in 1:12. For example:

be as proud of us (NJB)

1:14d just as we will boast of you in the day of our Lord Jesus.

- just as we can/will boast of you when the day of the Lord Jesus comes/occurs.
- in the same way that we will be proud of you at the time when the Lord Jesus returns.

in the day of our Lord Jesus: The word day refers to the time in the future when the Lord Jesus will return to earth and God will judge people. Translate in a way that refers to that general time. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

when the Day of our Lord Jesus comes (NJB)

on the day when the Lord Jesus returns (NLT)

2 Corinthians 1:15

Section 1:12–2:4: Paul’s change in plans

In this section Paul explained that he had earlier planned to visit the Corinthians two times, once on his way to the province of Macedonia and again on his way back from there (1:15–16). But he probably came earlier than planned and had a painful visit (2:1). After he returned to Ephesus, he wrote a painful letter (7:8–9). He then went to Macedonia via Troas (2:12–13) instead of via Corinth. The false teachers probably accused him of not being trustworthy because he had changed his plans. So Paul explained in these verses why he had changed his plans.

Other examples of headings for this section are:

Paul’s Integrity (NASB)

Why Paul changed his plans (NJB)

Paul explained his change of plans

1:15a Confident of this,

- ¶ Certain of this,
- ¶ And I am sure about those things between you^(plur) and me, so

This verse begins with a Greek conjunction that is often translated as “and.” Some English versions, such as the NET, translate it that way. The BSB has not translated this conjunction, and some other versions, such as the NIV and ESV, also do not translate it. In some languages, it will not be necessary to translate this conjunction either. Connect 1:15a to 1:14b in a way that is natural in your language.

Confident of this: The Greek phrase is literally “in this confidence” (NASB) or “with this confidence” (NET). The word Confident refers to a strong belief about something. Paul had no doubt that the believers in Corinth accepted him, respected him, and had a good relationship with him (1:12–14). Other ways to translate this clause are:

Confident of that

I was sure of that, and so

Certain of those things

this: Here this word refers to the mutual respect Paul expected between himself and the believers in Corinth (1:14) and more generally to the good relationship between them (1:12). Thrall (p. 136), Harris (p. 192), Barrett (p. 74), and Kistemaker (p. 57). In some languages, “that” would indicate the correct connection. See the examples above. Other languages will need to say more explicitly what this refers to. For example:

that talk

you looked well upon me

you will be boasting about me

1:15b

I planned to visit you first,

- I was planning to visit you^(plur) first
- I intended to visit you first before traveling further

I planned to visit you first: There are several ways to interpret how the word first is used:

1. The word applies to the word visit. Paul had planned to visit them before going elsewhere. For example:

I had planned to visit you first of all (CEV) (BSB, RSV, NIV, NJB, CEV, NET, REB, ESV, NCV)

1. The word applies to the word planned. He first planned to visit them but then changed his plans. For example:

I made plans at first to visit you (GNT) (GNT, NASB, NABRE, GW)

1. The word means “before.” He planned to visit them before this time. For example:

I was minded to come unto you before (KJV) (KJV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Harris (p. 192) says that the word “first” anticipates “again” in 1:16. He translates this text as “I was intending to visit you first.” Other ways to translate this clause following interpretation (1) are:

I had been meaning to come to you first (NJB)

I had intended to come first of all to you (REB)

I planned to visit you first before the other churches

planned: The Greek probably indicates that he did not do what he had planned. Other ways to translate this word are:

had intended (REB)

previously planned

1:15c

so that you might receive a double blessing.

- so that you would be favored a second time.
- in order that you might receive a second blessing/benefit.

you might receive a double blessing: The Greek clause is literally “you might have a second favor.” There are several ways to interpret it:

1. Do not interpret it. Translate without saying what “a second favor” applies to. For example:

you might be blessed twice (GNT) (BSB, NIV, GNT, NABRE, NCV)

1. The clause refers to two visits. The visit while going to Macedonia is the first benefit (1:16a) and the visit while returning from Macedonia is the second benefit (1:16b). For example:

I wanted to give you a double blessing by visiting you twice (NLT) (RSV, NJB, NASB, NLT, CEV, REB)

1. The clause refers to a second visit. Paul planned a second long visit (1 Corinthians 16:6), which would be a second benefit. Like his first long visit (Acts 18:11), they would again receive the benefit of an extended amount of teaching. For example:

you might have a second experience of grace (ESV) (ESV, KJV, GW, NET)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Thrall (p. 128) translates this text as “you might have a second benefit.” She says this benefit could be both “divine grace” and “a personal kindness” from Paul (p. 138). But some languages must explain what the second favor is. If that is true in your language, you may want to follow interpretation (2).

blessing: The Greek word here is often translated “grace.” Here it refers to a favor or benefit to someone. Other ways to translate this word are:

favor (NRSV)

benefit (KJV)

experience of grace (ESV)

2 Corinthians 1:16

Section 1:12–2:4: Paul’s change in plans

In this section Paul explained that he had earlier planned to visit the Corinthians two times, once on his way to the province of Macedonia and again on his way back from there (1:15–16). But he probably came earlier than planned and had a painful visit (2:1). After he returned to Ephesus, he wrote a painful letter (7:8–9). He then went to Macedonia via Troas (2:12–13) instead of via Corinth. The false teachers probably accused him of not being trustworthy because he had changed his plans. So Paul explained in these verses why he had changed his plans.

Other examples of headings for this section are:

Paul’s Integrity (NASB)

Why Paul changed his plans (NJB)

Paul explained his change of plans

1:16a

I wanted to visit you on my way to Macedonia,

- That is, I would pass through your^(plur) city/town on my way to Macedonia
- For I planned to stop briefly with you while I traveled to Macedonia

I wanted: The Greek word is literally “and.” But in this context, the word indicates that 1:16 explains 1:15. For example:

that is (NASB)

1:16 explains Paul’s plans, so many English versions repeat that part of 1:15. For example:

For I planned (GNT)

to visit you on my way: The Greek phrase is literally “to pass through you.” This phrase probably implies a very short stay at Corinth. For example:

to pass your way (NASB)

Many English versions use the word visit and do not say how long the visit would be.

Macedonia: This name refers to a Roman province that today would include the northern part of the country of Greece and the land a bit farther north. In some languages people are not familiar with the name Macedonia. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Explain in your translation. For example:

the province of Macedonia

- Translate literally and explain the meaning in a footnote. An example footnote is:

Macedonia was a Roman province in the northern part of Greece.

1:16b

and to return to you from Macedonia,

- and then to return to you from there/Macedonia,
- and return to you from there/Macedonia.

and to return to you from Macedonia: After visiting the churches in Macedonia, Paul planned to return to Corinth and stay with the believers there for perhaps several months (1 Corinthians 16:6).

1:16c

and then to have you help me on my way to Judea.

- and then to have you help me prepare for my journey to Judea.
- Lastly I planned for you to help with my needs when I go to Judea.

have you help me on my way: This clause refers to helping Paul with money and other needs (such as food) for his journey. Other ways to translate this clause are:

get help from you for my trip (GNT)

have you support my trip (GW)

Judea: This name refers to the Roman province that included Jerusalem. The Romans ruled all of the land

of the old kingdom of Israel. The middle part of it was the Roman province named Judea. In some languages people are not familiar with the name Judea. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Translate literally and explain the meaning in a footnote. An example footnote is:

The Romans ruled all of the land that once was the kingdom of Israel. The middle part of that land was the Roman province named Judea.

- Explain in your translation. For example:

the province of Judea

2 Corinthians 1:17

Section 1:12–2:4: Paul’s change in plans

In this section Paul explained that he had earlier planned to visit the Corinthians two times, once on his way to the province of Macedonia and again on his way back from there (1:15–16). But he probably came earlier than planned and had a painful visit (2:1). After he returned to Ephesus, he wrote a painful letter (7:8–9). He then went to Macedonia via Troas (2:12–13) instead of via Corinth. The false teachers probably accused him of not being trustworthy because he had changed his plans. So Paul explained in these verses why he had changed his plans.

Other examples of headings for this section are:

Paul’s Integrity (NASB)

Why Paul changed his plans (NJB)

Paul explained his change of plans

1:17a

When I planned this, did I do it carelessly?

- So then, does that mean I was fickle when I planned this?
- Therefore, when I made that plan, I certainly did not make it carelessly even though I changed my mind later.
- Planning that, do not think I am now changing my mind/thinking for no reason!

1:17a begins with a Greek conjunction that is often translated as “so.” Paul explained his plans in 1:16, but here he wanted to show that he was sincere when he planned his journey. For example:

Therefore (NASB)

So then

When I planned this, did I do it carelessly?: The Greek words are literally “planning this, surely I did not act in a fickle way?” (The word “fickle” refers to changing one’s mind for little or no reason.) This implies that Paul changed his plans from what he said in 1:16. The believers in Corinth knew of his change of plans. For example:

Since that was my purpose, do you think I lightly changed my mind? (NJB)

did I do it carelessly?: This is a rhetorical question. It emphasizes the fact that Paul surely did not do it carelessly. Translate in a way that emphasizes that meaning. Some ways to translate this are:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

does that mean I am/was fickle?

Do you think I make my plans carelessly? (NLT)

I was not vacillating when I intended to do this, was I? (NASB)

- As a statement. For example:

I am/was by no means fickle.

I certainly did not make my plans carelessly.

- As a command. For example:

do not think I am/was fickle!

certainly do not think that I make my plans carelessly!

1:17b–c

Or do I make my plans by human standards, so as to say “Yes, yes” when I really mean “No, no”?:

This is another rhetorical question. It emphasizes the fact that Paul surely did not make his plans in a worldly manner. Translate in a way that emphasizes that meaning. Some ways to translate this are:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Does that mean I make my plans in a worldly manner so that in the same breath I say “yes, yes” and “no, no”?

Do you think I am like people of the world who say “Yes” when they really mean “No”? (NLT)

When I make plans, I do not make them according to worldly ways, so that with me there will be yes, yes and no, no at the same time, do I?

- As a statement. For example:

I by no means make my plans in a worldly manner so that in the same breath I say “yes, yes” and “no, no.”

I certainly do not make plans like people of the world who say “Yes” when they really mean “No.”

- As a command. For example:

Do not think I make my plans in a worldly manner so that in the same breath I say, “Yes, yes” and “no, no”!

Surely do not think that I am like people of the world who say “Yes” when they really mean “No.”

1:17b

Or do I make my plans by human standards,

- Or does that mean I make my plans like worldly people,
- I certainly do not make my plans like people far from God,
- And do not think I make my plans like people who do not follow God,

by human standards: The Greek word that the BSB translates as by human standards refers to the ways of people who live without seeking guidance from God. It implies that these people do not follow God. Doing things by human standards would include lying and being hypocritical. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

like a worldly man (RSV)

according to selfish human motives

1:17c

so as to say “Yes, yes” when I really mean “No, no”?

- so that I say “Yes, yes” and “no, no” at the same time?
- who say, “Yes, certainly” when they really mean “No, not at all.”
- so that I am saying “yes indeed” and/but thinking “not at all.”

so as to say “Yes, yes” when I really mean “No, no”:

The Greek clause is literally “with me there may be the yes yes and the no no.” This clause refers to either:

1. Being hypocritical.
2. Agreeing to something and then later changing one’s mind and disagreeing.

A person who does those things is deceitful, unstable, or fickle. Other ways to translate this clause are:

ready to say Yes and No at once (RSV)

I have in my mind Yes, yes at the same time as No, no (NJB)

say “Yes” when they really mean “No” (NLT)

“Yes, yes” when I really mean “No, no”: The words yes and no are probably repeated to emphasize them. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

“yes, certainly” and “no, not at all”

“yes indeed” and “no way”

2 Corinthians 1:18

Section 1:12–2:4: Paul’s change in plans

In this section Paul explained that he had earlier planned to visit the Corinthians two times, once on his way to the province of Macedonia and again on his way back from there (1:15–16). But he probably came earlier than planned and had a painful visit (2:1). After he returned to Ephesus, he wrote a painful letter (7:8–9). He then went to Macedonia via Troas (2:12–13) instead of via Corinth. The false teachers probably accused him of not being trustworthy because he had changed his plans. So Paul explained in these verses why he had changed his plans.

Other examples of headings for this section are:

Paul’s Integrity (NASB)

Why Paul changed his plans (NJB)

Paul explained his change of plans

1:18a

But as surely as God is faithful,

- ¶ But as certainly as God can be trusted,
- ¶ But as assuredly as you^(plur) can depend on God,
- ¶ But just like God's words are true and dependable,

as surely as God is faithful: The Greek phrase is literally "God (is) trustworthy that." This saying is probably an oath. It indicates that 1:18b is true because Paul expected God to agree with Paul here, and God always tells the truth. Other ways to translate this saying are:

as God is always faithful

God is my witness that

God trusts me to say that

God supports me in this:

faithful: This word refers to being trustworthy or dependable. God is faithful to all that he has said. He supported what Paul said in 1:18b. Other ways to translate this word are:

depend on God (GW)

God can be trusted (CEV)

1:18b

our message to you is not "Yes" and "No."

- our^(excl) words to you^(plur) are not "Yes" and "No" at the same time.
- you can depend on our message not being "Yes" when we really mean "No."
- we are assuredly not saying "yes" and thinking "no."

our message to you is not "Yes" and "No.": Paul was sure of this and indicated so in 1:18a. In some languages it is more natural to repeat some of the words from 1:18a. For example:

surely our message to you is not "Yes" and "No."

our message: This phrase refers mostly to the gospel of Jesus but includes other things Paul may have told

them. Translate in a way that allows both meanings. For example:

what we say (NJB)

our words

"Yes" and "No": This phrase has the same meaning as " 'Yes, yes' and 'no, no' " (1:17c), but the words here are not repeated and so are not emphasized. Translate this phrase as you did in 1:17c but without the emphasis.

2 Corinthians 1:19

Section 1:12–2:4: Paul's change in plans

In this section Paul explained that he had earlier planned to visit the Corinthians two times, once on his way to the province of Macedonia and again on his way back from there (1:15–16). But he probably came earlier than planned and had a painful visit (2:1). After he returned to Ephesus, he wrote a painful letter (7:8–9). He then went to Macedonia via Troas (2:12–13) instead of via Corinth. The false teachers probably accused him of not being trustworthy because he had changed his plans. So Paul explained in these verses why he had changed his plans.

Other examples of headings for this section are:

Paul's Integrity (NASB)

Why Paul changed his plans (NJB)

Paul explained his change of plans

1:19a

For the Son of God, Jesus Christ,

- For God's Son, Jesus Christ,
- I say this because the Son of God, Jesus Christ,

For: Here the word For indicates that 1:19 explains 1:18b.

the Son of God, Jesus Christ: The Greek phrase is literally "of-God son, Jesus Christ." It emphasizes the phrase the Son of God. It probably emphasizes of God as well. For example:

It is God whose Son this is, namely Jesus Christ

If possible, emphasize one or both parts. In some languages it is more natural to have the name Jesus Christ first. For example:

Jesus Christ, the Son of God

the Son of God: This phrase is a title for Jesus. This title was often used to refer to a savior who would be a descendant of King David. God would send this savior to rescue his people. This person was often referred to as the “Messiah” or “Christ.”

The title the Son of God also indicates that Jesus has the same nature and character as God. The relationship between God the Father and Jesus, his Son, is similar in some way to the relationship between human fathers and sons. God the Father does not have a physical body. He did not have a sexual relationship with Mary that resulted in her becoming pregnant and giving birth to Jesus. The Son of God existed eternally as the Son with his Father.

In areas where people do not understand the title the Son of God in this way, you may want to include a footnote that explains the correct meaning. Here is a suggested footnote:

This title refers to Jesus. It indicates that Jesus has the same nature and character as God. It does not mean that God the Father had a sexual relationship with Mary that resulted in her becoming pregnant and giving birth to Jesus. Mary became pregnant with Jesus in a miraculous way by the Holy Spirit of God.

In some languages, it is natural to speak of a son as a “child,” without specifying male or female. If that is true in your language, you may use a more general term, such as:

the Child of God A translation of the title “the Son of God” must include a familial term such as “son” or “child.” Translations such as “the man who is God,” “the divine man,” or “the God man” are not acceptable, since they do not retain familial language. Examples of acceptable translation options include “the Son who comes from God,” and “the divine/unique/eternal Son of God.”

Other verses will usually make clear that Jesus was a male child. If you use a phrase such as “the male child of God,” be sure that it does not imply that God had another child who was female.

Christ: The word Christ is a title for Jesus. The word Christ literally means “the anointed one.” Translate the word Christ here as you did in 1:1.

1:19b

who was proclaimed among you by me and Silvanus and Timothy,

- whom I, Silas, and Timothy proclaimed to/among you^(plur),

who was proclaimed among you by me and Silvanus and Timothy: This clause is passive. Paul, Silvanus, and Timothy preached, but the focus is on the pronoun who, which refers to Jesus. Some languages must use an active clause. For example:

whom I, Silas, and Timothy preached among you

This clause interrupts the main discussion in 1:19. See the General Comment at the end of the notes on 1:19 about possibly moving this clause in the verse.

proclaimed: This word means “announce” or “proclaim.” Paul and the others announced that Jesus was the Christ to people in Corinth and some of them believed. For example:

preached (NIV)

among you: The word among indicates that Paul and the others preached at various times to various gatherings of the people of Corinth. For example:

to you (NJB)

me and Silvanus and Timothy: Silvanus and Timothy came to Corinth and joined Paul during his first visit to Corinth (Acts 18:5). All three preached about Jesus while they were in Corinth.

Silvanus: The Greek spelling of this name here is “Silouanos.” The Latin (Roman) spelling is Silvanus, and some translations follow that spelling. The Aramaic spelling is “Silas.” In other places in the New Testament, this name is spelled Silvanus, so the BSB consistently spells this name Silvanus. You may want to:

- Follow the Greek or Latin spelling here. You may then want a footnote to explain the other spelling. For example:

Elsewhere in the New Testament, this name is spelled “Silas.” “Silvanus” is the Latin version of this name.

- Spell the name consistently, as the BSB does. You may then want a footnote to explain the spelling in the Greek. For example:

Literally “Silvanus.” “Silvanus” is the Latin version of the name “Silas.”

1:19c

was not “Yes” and “No,”

- was not “Yes” and “No” at the same time,
- did not say “Yes” when he really meant “No.”
- was surely not saying “yes” and thinking “no.”

not “Yes” and “No”: This phrase indicates that Jesus is not hypocritical, deceitful, unstable, or fickle. See the note at 1:17 or how you translated this phrase in 1:18.

1:19d

but in Him it has always been “Yes.”

- but/and in him our words are always “Yes.”
- Through him our message is always “Yes.”
- The gospel, which we proclaim, always fulfills what it says/promises because of him.

but: The Greek language considers 1:19d to contrast to 1:19c. But some languages would not consider the connection to have contrast. For example:

and Western Bukidnon Manobo Back Translation on TW.

in Him it has always been “Yes.”: The Greek clause is literally “(it/he) has become (and still is) yes in him.” The subject of this clause is not explicit in the Greek. There are two ways to interpret what the subject should be:

1. The subject is it, and it refers to “our message” in 1:18b, meaning the gospel and the promises in it (1:20). For example:

In Christ it has always been yes (NCV) (BSB, NIV, RSV, ESV, NET, NCV, REB, GW)

1. The subject is he, and it refers to Jesus (1:19a). For example:

he is God’s “Yes” (GNT) (NJB, GNT, CEV, NASB, NABRE, KJV, NLT)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Bruce says, “all the promises of God find their Yes—a fulfillment which his people acknowledged in their worship with the confirmatory Amen, uttered through Christ” (p. 181). Some scholars support a third option: “Yes” is the subject. But then the sentence would be “in him yes has become.” To this author, that sentence feels incomplete.

The Greek clause indicates that it became “yes” in the past and continues to be “yes.” Other ways to translate this clause are:

Because of him our message was always true (GW)

by means of his deeds and words, our message is always “Yes”

General Comment on 1:19a–d

The words in 1:19b explain something about Jesus (1:19a), but they interrupt what Paul said about Jesus in 1:19a and 1:19c–d. It may be more natural to have these words before or after 1:19a and 1:19c–d. For example:

^{19a}For the Son of God, Jesus Christ, ^{19c}was not “Yes” and “No,” ^{19d}but in him it has always been “Yes.”
^{19b}It was he who was preached among you by me and Silas and Timothy.

For ^{19b}I and Silas and Timothy preached ^{19a}the Son of God, Jesus Christ among you, and he ^{19c}was not “Yes” and “No,” ^{19d}but in him it has always been “Yes.”

2 Corinthians 1:20

Section 1:12–2:4: Paul’s change in plans

In this section Paul explained that he had earlier planned to visit the Corinthians two times, once on his way to the province of Macedonia and again on his way back from there (1:15–16). But he probably came earlier than planned and had a painful visit (2:1). After he returned to Ephesus, he wrote a painful letter (7:8–9). He then went to Macedonia via Troas (2:12–13) instead of via Corinth. The false teachers probably accused him of not being trustworthy because he had changed his plans. So Paul explained in these verses why he had changed his plans.

Other examples of headings for this section are:

Paul's Integrity (NASB)

Why Paul changed his plans (NJB)

Paul explained his change of plans

1:20a

For all the promises of God are “Yes” in Christ.

- For the yes to each of God's many promises is in Christ.
- I say this because all of God's many promises will be fulfilled in Christ with a “Yes!”

For: Here the word For indicates that 1:20a–b explains 1:19d.

all the promises of God are “Yes” in Christ: This refers to every promise that God has made. God fulfilled every promise by means of what Jesus did or will do. In that way God says “yes.” Other ways to translate this saying are:

in him every one of God's promises is a “Yes” (NRSV)

in him is found the Yes to all God's promises (NJB)

all of God's promises will be fulfilled in Christ with a “Yes!”

The yes to all of God's promises is in Christ (NCV)

1:20b

And so through Him, our “Amen” is spoken to the glory of God.

- And so through him the “Amen” is said by us^(excl) and that glorifies God.
- Therefore by him enabling us, we say “It is so/true!” as praise to God.

through Him: There is a textual issue in 1:20b: (1) The earliest Greek manuscripts have the phrase through him (BSB, RSV, NIV, GNT, NJB, NASB, NLT, GW, CEV, NET, JBP, REB, ESV, NCV). (2) Some later Greek manuscripts have the phrase in him (KJV only). It is recommended that you follow option (1). This phrase indicates that Jesus enabled Paul and the others to say “Amen.” Other ways to translate this phrase are:

by the power of his deeds

by him enabling us

because of our connection to him

our “Amen” is spoken to the glory of God: The Greek phrase here is literally “the Amen to God for glory through us.” The verb “speak” is implied. The BSB uses a passive clause, but the NRSV uses an active clause:

we say the “Amen,” to the glory of God (NRSV)

If possible, keep the focus on the word Amen.

Amen: The word Amen is a Hebrew word that means “even so” or “it is true.” The word is used when someone wants to agree that something is true. The BSB and many English versions transliterate this word. You may want to:

- Spell the word as a person in your language would say it.
- Translate the meaning. For example:

“It is so”

“True!”

to the glory of God: The Greek phrase here is literally “to God for glory.” This phrase indicates that Paul and the others say “Amen” to God and this action glorifies or honors God. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

to God for his glory (ESV)

to give praise to God (NJB)

honor God (GW)

2 Corinthians 1:21

Section 1:12–2:4: Paul's change in plans

In this section Paul explained that he had earlier planned to visit the Corinthians two times, once on his way to the province of Macedonia and again on his way back from there (1:15–16). But he probably came earlier than planned and had a painful visit (2:1). After he returned to Ephesus, he wrote a painful letter (7:8–9). He then went to Macedonia via Troas (2:12–13) instead of via Corinth. The false teachers probably accused him of not being trustworthy because he had changed his plans. So Paul explained in these verses why he had changed his plans.

Other examples of headings for this section are:

Paul's Integrity (NASB)

Why Paul changed his plans (NJB)

Paul explained his change of plans

1:21a

Now it is God who establishes both us and you in Christ.

- Indeed God himself causes us^(excl) as well as you^(plur) to be secure in our relationship/position with Christ,
- Now God himself gives us, along with you, a sure/firm/stable faith/place in Christ.
- So then, it is God who causes us and you to firmly trust Christ.

Now: There are three ways to interpret the Greek conjunction here:

1. The Greek conjunction introduces a new but related theme. This is indicated by such words in English as Now, "Indeed," and "And so." For example:

And so (CEV) (BSB, NIV, NASB, CEV, NCV, KJV)

1. The Greek conjunction indicates contrast from 1:20. For example:

But (RSV) (RSV, NABRE, NET)

1. The Greek conjunction indicates a general connection to 1:20. It may be translated as "And" or omitted. Without any conjunction in English, it is possible in this context to understand the connection as a new theme as well. So the GNT, NJB, NLT, GW, and JBP are ambiguous as to whether they support interpretation (1) or interpretation (3). For example:

It is God who (NJB) (NJB, REB, ESV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). The Greek word *de* can mean each of the three interpretations. Harris (p. 190), Martin (p. 23), and Kistemaker (p. 62) translate it as "Now."

it is God who establishes both us and you in Christ:

The Greek clause is literally "the one establishing us with you in Christ (is) God." This clause emphasizes the word God. The clause indicates that God established

Paul and the other evangelists, enabling them to stand firm. God also enabled the believers in Corinth to stand firm. Other ways to translate this clause are:

It is God who gives us, with you, a sure place in Christ (NJB)

God establishes us, together with you, in a relationship with Christ (GW)

God is the One who makes you and us strong in Christ. (NCV)

establishes...in Christ: Here the Greek verb ("establish") indicates that God causes believers to be secure in their relationship with Jesus. They do not need to worry that God might reject them. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

makes...secure in our relationship with Christ

makes...firm/stable in our faith in Christ

The Greek words probably indicate that God continues to make believers firm in their relationship with Christ.

1:21b

He anointed us,

- and he himself anointed us^(incl).
- And he also chose/commissioned us.

He anointed us: In the Greek, this clause is a part of the previous words: "the one establishing us with you in Christ and having anointed us (is) God." For example:

He who establishes us with you in Christ and anointed us is God (NASB)

anointed: At that time, people and things were anointed by having oil poured on their heads. This action showed that they were chosen for a special purpose. In some languages a literal translation would not have this meaning. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Include the implied meaning in your translation. For example:

anointed that is, chose

- Translate the implied meaning in your translation. For example:

commissioned (RSV)

chose (CEV)

- Translate literally and explain the meaning in a footnote. For example:

At that time, people were anointed by having oil poured on their heads. This action showed that they were chosen for a special purpose.

2 Corinthians 1:22

Section 1:12–2:4: Paul’s change in plans

In this section Paul explained that he had earlier planned to visit the Corinthians two times, once on his way to the province of Macedonia and again on his way back from there (1:15–16). But he probably came earlier than planned and had a painful visit (2:1). After he returned to Ephesus, he wrote a painful letter (7:8–9). He then went to Macedonia via Troas (2:12–13) instead of via Corinth. The false teachers probably accused him of not being trustworthy because he had changed his plans. So Paul explained in these verses why he had changed his plans.

Other examples of headings for this section are:

Paul’s Integrity (NASB)

Why Paul changed his plans (NJB)

Paul explained his change of plans

1:22a

placed His seal on us,

- It is God who sealed us^(incl) as belonging to him,
- He also placed his mark of ownership upon us.

placed His seal on us: The Greek clause is literally “the one having sealed us.” The clause begins a new teaching that refers to all believers as us.

placed His seal: Here the phrase placed His seal refers to marking something to indicate it belongs to someone. God has marked all believers to indicate they belong to him. The mark is not a physical mark here. Paul did not say what kind of mark is meant here. Other ways to translate this clause are:

marked us with his seal (NJB)

who has placed his mark of ownership upon us (GNT)

He put his mark on us to show that we are his (NCV)

1:22b

and put His Spirit in our hearts as a pledge of what is to come.

- and he has given/sent his Spirit to live in our hearts as a pledge.
- And he himself put the Holy Spirit to live/walk/interact with us as a sign/means of knowing that we will receive all his promises in the future.

put His Spirit in our hearts: This clause indicates that God has caused the Holy Spirit to interact with the spirit of each believer. The Holy Spirit is guide and counselor (John 14:26). Other ways to translate this clause are:

giving us...the Spirit in our hearts (NJB)

has given the Spirit to dwell in our hearts (REB)

sent the Holy Spirit to walk/interact with us

caused us to be indwelt by his Spirit

hearts: In the New Testament, the word “heart” refers figuratively to the mind, emotions, and will of a person. It refers to the part of a person that he uses to think, feel, and make decisions. In some languages people refer figuratively to this part of a person as his mind, throat, liver, or stomach. They are not referring literally to that physical part of the body. You should use the word or phrase in your language that refers to this part of a person.

as a pledge of what is to come: The Greek phrase is literally “the deposit of the Spirit.” Here the word pledge refers to something paid as a promise to pay the rest. God has caused the Holy Spirit to interact with the spirits of believers as proof that he will fulfill all his promises for believers. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

as a first installment (NRSV)

as a pledge (NASB)

to be a guarantee for all he has promised (NCV)

as our means of knowing for sure that he will fulfill all that he has promised us

as the sign that He will fulfill all His promises to us

2 Corinthians 1:23

Section 1:12–2:4: Paul's change in plans

In this section Paul explained that he had earlier planned to visit the Corinthians two times, once on his way to the province of Macedonia and again on his way back from there (1:15–16). But he probably came earlier than planned and had a painful visit (2:1). After he returned to Ephesus, he wrote a painful letter (7:8–9). He then went to Macedonia via Troas (2:12–13) instead of via Corinth. The false teachers probably accused him of not being trustworthy because he had changed his plans. So Paul explained in these verses why he had changed his plans.

Other examples of headings for this section are:

Paul's Integrity (NASB)

Why Paul changed his plans (NJB)

Paul explained his change of plans

1:23a

I call God as my witness that

- ¶ So now, upon penalty of death, I myself appeal to him as a witness that what I say here is true:
- ¶ Indeed, I myself ask God to verify this truth and punish me with death if I lie:

This verse begins with a Greek conjunction that is often translated “But” (as in the RSV). But here the conjunction probably introduces a new part of what Paul wants to say. The conjunction probably does not indicate contrast to 1:22.

I call God as my witness: The Greek clause is literally “I call God as witness regarding my soul.” The KJV says, “...upon my soul.” The BDAG says that the Greek word that often means “upon” means “feelings directed toward someone, in, on, for, toward” (sense 15, page 366). It can also mean “power, authority, control of or over someone or something, over” (sense 9.c, page

365), or “hostile opposition, against” (sense 12.b, page 366). It indicates that God can say what Paul had done. It probably indicates that both:

1. God would testify against Paul if Paul lied in 1:23b;
2. God would testify for Paul if Paul spoke the truth in 1:23b.

If possible, translate in a way that allows both situations. For example:

I call upon God as witness over my life

I ask God to verify this truth

I: This pronoun is emphasized in the Greek. If possible, emphasize the pronoun here. For example:

I myself

call God as my witness: This clause asks God to verify that what Paul is about to say is true. Other ways to translate this clause are:

call upon God as my witness (NLT)

appeal to God as a witness on my behalf (GW)

ask God to be my witness that this is true: (NCV)

God is my witness, he knows what is true

1:23b

it was in order to spare you that I did not return to Corinth.

- I did not return to Corinth because I did not want to cause you^(plur) further pain.
- the reason that I did not return to visit you in Corinth was that I might not have to punish you but allow you time to repent.

it was in order to spare you: The phrase in order to indicates reason or purpose. Other ways to translate this clause are:

because I wanted to spare you (GW)

for the purpose of sparing you

to spare you: Here the word spare refers to not doing something that would cause further pain to the

believers in Corinth. Paul did not want to rebuke and discipline them at that time. He perhaps hoped that they would correct the problems themselves. Other ways to translate this word are:

to keep from punishing you

to keep from being hard on you (CEV)

to avoid hurting you (JBP)

to give you opportunity to repent so that I would not have to cause you further pain

not to scold you

2 Corinthians 1:24

Section 1:12–2:4: Paul's change in plans

In this section Paul explained that he had earlier planned to visit the Corinthians two times, once on his way to the province of Macedonia and again on his way back from there (1:15–16). But he probably came earlier than planned and had a painful visit (2:1). After he returned to Ephesus, he wrote a painful letter (7:8–9). He then went to Macedonia via Troas (2:12–13) instead of via Corinth. The false teachers probably accused him of not being trustworthy because he had changed his plans. So Paul explained in these verses why he had changed his plans.

Other examples of headings for this section are:

Paul's Integrity (NASB)

Why Paul changed his plans (NJB)

Paul explained his change of plans

1:24a

Not that we lord it over your faith,

- We^(excl) do not act as dictator over your^(plur) faith,
- We do not dominate the ways you believe.
- We do not arrogantly order you to believe this or that.

lord it over: This phrase refers to controlling something. Here the phrase implies the person wanting too much control and the people resenting him. Paul did not want to be always telling them what to do or believe. Instead he wanted them to seek God and

make God lord of their lives. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

dominate (NLT)

have control over (GW)

become sole decision maker for

set ourselves as dictators over

Paul was already leader over the believers and their teacher. The phrase here indicates that Paul did not want excessive control over them.

faith: Here the word faith means “a strong and sincere belief in something or someone.” To have faith in a person means to trust someone, to rely on someone, to be committed to someone. Faith in Jesus refers to:

1. accepting His message as true;
2. acting on the basis of His message;
3. being confident in His message;
4. trusting in Him.

Your language may have a noun, phrase, or idiom with that meaning. Some other examples for translating are:

believing

believe in Jesus

trusting and being committed to Jesus

1:24b

but we are fellow workers with you for your joy,

- but we are your co-workers in order to make you happy,
- Rather, we are working as partners with you for your happiness,

we are fellow workers with you: Paul and the evangelists were co-workers with the believers in Corinth. They all did things for God (such as telling others about Jesus). Another way to translate is:

we are your fellow workers

1:24c

because it is by faith that you stand firm.

- for you remain steadfast by faith.

- because you have stood strong by believing in Jesus.

because: This conjunction introduces an explanation of 1:24a–b. For example:

for (RSV)

it is by faith that you stand firm: The Greek clause is literally “by faith you stand firm.” The phrase by faith is possibly emphasized. The BSB and other English versions add the phrase it is to make the English grammar correct. The clause without emphasis is:

you stand firm by faith

by faith: This phrase indicates that the lives of the believers are established by means of their faith.

you stand firm: The Greek clause is literally “you have stood.” This clause indicates that the believers remained strong in faith. The Greek indicates that the believers stood firm in the past and continued to stand firm in the present. For example:

you are firmly established (JBP)

you live in upright manner

you are steadfast/stable

2 Corinthians 2:1

Section 1:12–2:4: Paul’s change in plans

In this section Paul explained that he had earlier planned to visit the Corinthians two times, once on his way to the province of Macedonia and again on his way back from there (1:15–16). But he probably came earlier than planned and had a painful visit (2:1). After he returned to Ephesus, he wrote a painful letter (7:8–9). He then went to Macedonia via Troas (2:12–13) instead of via Corinth. The false teachers probably accused him of not being trustworthy because he had changed his plans. So Paul explained in these verses why he had changed his plans.

Other examples of headings for this section are:

Paul’s Integrity (NASB)

Why Paul changed his plans (NJB)

Paul explained his change of plans

2:1a–b

So I made up my mind not to make another painful visit to you: The Greek clause is literally “I decided in/by myself this, not to come to you again in grief.” The word “this” probably emphasizes the clause that follows it. For example:

I decided this indeed, I would not come to you again in grief

I made up my mind in this: I would not make another painful visit to you

This is what I decided: I would not repeat such a grievous visit

2:1a

So I made up my mind

- Because/For I decided this:
- I decided

So: There is a textual issue in 2:1a: (1) The earliest Greek manuscripts have the word because (BSB, RSV, NIV, GNT, NJB, NLT, GW, CEV, NET, JBP, REB, ESV, NCV). (2) Some later Greek manuscripts have the word but (NRSV, NASB, KJV). It is recommended that you follow option (1). The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as So is often translated as “because” or “for.” There are two ways to interpret this word:

1. It indicates that 2:1 explains 1:23. For example:

For (RSV) (RSV, NABRE, ESV)

1. Here it connects in a general way to the previous verses. For example:

So (GNT) (BSB, NIV, GNT, NJB, NRSV, NLT, NET, REB, NCV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because that is the normal meaning of the Greek word. Harris (p. 215) says 2:1 explains 1:23 and Martin (p. 31) says 2:1 gives the reason for Paul not visiting (1:23). But if the common language version follows interpretation (2), you may want to follow that.

I made up my mind: The Greek clause is literally “I decided in/by myself.” This clause probably indicates that Paul decided this by himself.

2:1b

not to make another painful visit to you.

- I would not come again to grieve you^(plur).
- not to make my next visit with you so painful. (CEV)

make another painful visit to you: The Greek phrase is literally “come to you again in grief.” In a previous visit, Paul had to discipline some believers who were sinning. This was painful for the believers in Corinth because they should have disciplined them. They were probably also sad that such sin had occurred among them. For example:

come to you again to make you sad (GNT)

But the phrase “in grief” probably implies that Paul himself also felt grief. If possible, translate it so that it implies or indicates that. For example:

make my next visit with you so painful (CEV)

make my next visit to you painful for all of us^(incl)

2 Corinthians 2:2

Section 1:12–2:4: Paul’s change in plans

In this section Paul explained that he had earlier planned to visit the Corinthians two times, once on his way to the province of Macedonia and again on his way back from there (1:15–16). But he probably came earlier than planned and had a painful visit (2:1). After he returned to Ephesus, he wrote a painful letter (7:8–9). He then went to Macedonia via Troas (2:12–13) instead of via Corinth. The false teachers probably accused him of not being trustworthy because he had changed his plans. So Paul explained in these verses why he had changed his plans.

Other examples of headings for this section are:

Paul’s Integrity (NASB)

Why Paul changed his plans (NJB)

Paul explained his change of plans

2:2a–b

if I grieve you, who is left to cheer me but those whom I have grieved?: This is a rhetorical question. It emphasizes the fact that if Paul grieved them, none of them could make him glad. They would be sad, so it would be hard for them to encourage him. Translate in a way that emphasizes that meaning. Some ways to do this in English are:

- As a rhetorical question and an exclamation or statement. For example:

if I grieve you, is there anyone left to make me glad? There is only you whom I have grieved!

if I grieve you, could there be anyone left/else to make me glad? Only you could, but I have grieved you!

if I grieve you, how can you make me glad? You could not.

- As a statement. For example:

if I grieve you, no one among you can make me glad.

if I grieve you, none of you can make me glad.

if I grieve you, you would be too sad to make me glad.

2:2a

For if I grieve you,

- For if I myself make you^(plur) grieve,
- Furthermore, if it is I who cause you to feel sad/ashamed,

For: Here the word For introduces an explanation. For example:

Because

To explain:

Let me explain:

if I grieve you: The pronoun I is emphasized in the Greek clause. Here the contrast between I and “those whom I have grieved” (2:2b) is emphasized. Other ways to translate this clause are:

if it is I who grieve you

if I myself grieve you

grieve: This word refers to causing someone to feel sad, distressed, or ashamed. Some believers were

sinning, so Paul made them understand that what they were doing was wrong. So they became sad and repented. Other ways to translate this word are:

cause...grief (NLT)

make...sad (GNT)

make...feel bad (CEV)

2:2b

who is left to cheer me but those whom I have grieved?

- could there be someone else to make me glad but you whom I have grieved?
- no one is left to make me glad except you whom I have caused to feel sad/ashamed.

who is left to cheer me but those whom I have grieved?: The Greek clause is literally “who is the one cheering me except the one being grieved by me.” This clause indicates that if Paul grieved the believers in Corinth, they would become sad. Then they could not make him glad, because they would be too sad to try to cheer him up. Other ways to translate this clause are:

who then makes me glad but the one whom I made sorrowful? (NASB)

who remains to make me glad except those whom I have grieved?

who would make me glad? Only you! Yet I might have grieved you!

those whom I have grieved: The Greek phrase is literally “the one whom I have grieved.” It is singular, like the word “who” in “who is left...” above. But both words probably refer in general to the believers in Corinth. For example:

the people I had made to feel bad (CEV)

2 Corinthians 2:3

Section 1:12–2:4: Paul’s change in plans

In this section Paul explained that he had earlier planned to visit the Corinthians two times, once on his way to the province of Macedonia and again on his way back from there (1:15–16). But he probably came earlier than planned and had a painful visit (2:1).

After he returned to Ephesus, he wrote a painful letter (7:8–9). He then went to Macedonia via Troas (2:12–13) instead of via Corinth. The false teachers probably accused him of not being trustworthy because he had changed his plans. So Paul explained in these verses why he had changed his plans.

Other examples of headings for this section are:

Paul’s Integrity (NASB)

Why Paul changed his plans (NJB)

Paul explained his change of plans

2:3a

I wrote as I did

- I wrote that very letter
- And I wrote that way

2:3b

so that on my arrival

- so that when I came/come
- so that when I visited you^(plur),

2:3a–b

I wrote as I did: Besides the painful visit to the believers in Corinth, Paul also wrote a letter that caused grief (7:8–9). Some of the believers were sinning, so Paul probably wrote to tell them to stop sinning.

Many scholars think the letter referred to here is now lost. But a few scholars think it is now included in 2 Corinthians as chapters 10–13. A few other scholars think the letter is 1 Corinthians. So your translation should only refer in a general way to what Paul says he wrote. You may want to explain about this letter in a footnote. For example:

Besides making the painful visit to the believers in Corinth, Paul also wrote a letter that caused grief (7:8–9). Some believers were sinning, so Paul probably wrote to tell them to stop sinning. It is likely that this letter is now lost and is not 1 Corinthians.

Many scholars think the letter referred to here is now lost.

2:3c

I would not be saddened by those who ought to make me rejoice.

- I should not be grieved by those who should make me glad.
- you would not make me feel sad/ashamed when you should make me glad.

I would not be saddened by those who ought to make me rejoice: This clause is passive. Some languages must use an active clause. For example:

those who ought to make me rejoice should not distress me

saddened: The Greek word that the BSB translates as saddened is the same Greek word translated “grieve” and “grieved” in 2:2. Translate this word in a similar way to the way you translated it in 2:2.

2:3d

I had confidence in all of you, that you would share my joy.

- I am certain about all of you, that my joy is the same as all of yours.
- I am sure about all of you, that you and I would share the same joy.

I had confidence in: The Greek verb indicates that Paul had confidence in the past and continued to have confidence as he wrote. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

I am convinced about

I have no doubts about

I am sure/certain of

you would share my joy: The Greek clause is literally “my joy is (that) of all of you.” The clause can mean:

1. Paul’s joy and the believers’ joy are shared together, that is, they all have joy in what each other is doing;
2. Paul’s joy and the believers’ joy have the same source; they both serve God wholeheartedly and so they have joy.

Translate in a way that allows both meanings. Other ways to translate this clause are:

my joy is the same as all of yours

my joy would be the joy of all of you (RSV)

whatever makes me happy also makes you happy (GW)

2 Corinthians 2:4

Section 1:12–2:4: Paul’s change in plans

In this section Paul explained that he had earlier planned to visit the Corinthians two times, once on his way to the province of Macedonia and again on his way back from there (1:15–16). But he probably came earlier than planned and had a painful visit (2:1). After he returned to Ephesus, he wrote a painful letter (7:8–9). He then went to Macedonia via Troas (2:12–13) instead of via Corinth. The false teachers probably accused him of not being trustworthy because he had changed his plans. So Paul explained in these verses why he had changed his plans.

Other examples of headings for this section are:

Paul’s Integrity (NASB)

Why Paul changed his plans (NJB)

Paul explained his change of plans

2:4a

For through many tears I wrote you out of great distress and anguish of heart,

- For I wrote to you^(plur) while in great trouble/difficulty and feeling distressed in my heart/insides and with great/much weeping,
- In great suffering, grief, and with many tears I wrote that letter.

For: Here the word For indicates that 2:4 explains 2:3d.

distress: The Greek word that the BSB translates as distress refers to trouble happening to someone. Other ways to translate this word are:

affliction (RSV)

difficulty/tribulation

suffering (CEV)

anguish: The Greek word that the BSB translates as anguish refers to the feelings of dismay or grief. These feelings are painful. Other ways to translate this word are:

grief

distressed (GNT)

heart: Here the word heart refers to the source of feelings, desires, and emotions. Use a term normally used in your language to tell where feelings, desires, and emotions come from. It may be a different organ such as the liver, or it may be a general term such as “insides.”

2:4b

not to grieve you but to let you know how much I love you.

- not to grieve you but to make known to you that I love you abundantly.
- I wrote to you, in order that you might know how very much I love you and not in order to make you feel sad/ashamed.

not to grieve you but to let you know how much I love you: Paul wrote the negative reason first and then the positive reason. In some languages it is more natural to have the positive reason first. For example:

to let you know the depth of my love for you and not to grieve you

grieve: Translate this word as you did in 2:2.

how much I love: The Greek phrase is literally “the more abundant love I have.” This phrase indicates that Paul greatly loved the believers in Corinth. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

the abundant love that I have (RSV)

love: The word love refers to a strong affection and concern for a person. In some languages an idiom such as “give/put heart/liver” is used for the meaning of love.

2 Corinthians 2:5

Section 2:5–11: Forgive and comfort the repenting believer

In this section Paul reviewed the problem of a believer in Corinth who had sinned. The actions of this person caused Paul and the other believers there to grieve (2:5). Paul wrote earlier to the believers and told them to punish the believer who had sinned (2:9). The other believers obeyed and punished him (2:6), and he repented. Now Paul urged the believers to forgive and comfort this person (2:7). He explained that he had

forgiven this person but that Satan convinces people not to forgive (2:10–11).

Paul spoke kindly here because the person had repented. He used this situation as an example to teach about forgiveness.

Other examples of headings for this section are:

Forgiveness for the Sinner (NIV)

Forgive the Person Who Sinned (GW)

Forgiveness (CEV)

2:5a

Now if anyone has caused grief,

- ¶ Now if anyone has caused people/others to grieve,
- ¶ If anyone has made other people grieve by sinning,

anyone: A believer in Corinth sinned. Paul heard about it. It was probably the reason why he wrote that letter (2:3). Paul used the word anyone here to refer indirectly to that believer. He probably wanted to be kind to him instead of shaming him by naming him.

has caused grief: By sinning, this believer caused the other believers to grieve. In some languages a literal translation would wrongly indicate that the grief was caused by something other than sin. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Explain the implied meaning in your translation. For example:

has caused grief by sinning

- Translate literally and explain the meaning in a footnote. An example footnote is:

Other believers grieve when a believer sins.

2:5b

he has not grieved me but all of you—to some degree,

- he has not caused me to grieve but he has caused all of you^(plur) to grieve in various degrees/measures,
- he has made you feel sad/ashamed much more than me. His sin affected all of you, some more than others

he has not grieved me but all of you—to some degree: The Greek words are literally “he has not grieved me, but, in part, all of you.” The believers in Corinth

felt the effects of the sin much more than Paul did. Paul was not in Corinth when it happened and only heard about it later. For example:

he has not done it to me but to all of you—in part (GNT)

Any injury that has been done has not been done to me; to some extent...it has been done to you all (REB)

I'm not the one really affected. To some extent—... it has affected all of you. (GW)

In some languages it is more natural to have the positive part of these words first. For example:

the man who caused all the trouble hurt all of you more than he hurt me (NLT)

he has grieved all of you to some extent, and/but he has not grieved me

to some extent he has grieved all of you rather than me

grieved: Translate this word as you did in 2:2.

to some degree: The Greek phrase is literally “in part.” It indicates that some believers were very affected, some believers were somewhat affected, and other believers were affected very little. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

in part (GNT)

in some measure (RSV)

in some extent (NIV)

some greatly and others less so

2:5c

not to overstate it.

- not to overstate what happened.
- (I do not want to make too much of it). (REB)

not to overstate it: Paul did not want to exaggerate how much the other believers were affected by the

person's sin. Therefore, he said “to some degree” in 2:5b. Other ways to translate this saying are:

not to exaggerate (NJB)

not to overstate the problem

(I do not want to make too much of it) (REB)

not to speak too strongly

2 Corinthians 2:6

Section 2:5–11: Forgive and comfort the repenting believer

In this section Paul reviewed the problem of a believer in Corinth who had sinned. The actions of this person caused Paul and the other believers there to grieve (2:5). Paul wrote earlier to the believers and told them to punish the believer who had sinned (2:9). The other believers obeyed and punished him (2:6), and he repented. Now Paul urged the believers to forgive and comfort this person (2:7). He explained that he had forgiven this person but that Satan convinces people not to forgive (2:10–11).

Paul spoke kindly here because the person had repented. He used this situation as an example to teach about forgiveness.

Other examples of headings for this section are:

Forgiveness for the Sinner (NIV)

Forgive the Person Who Sinned (GW)

Forgiveness (CEV)

2:6

The punishment imposed on him by the majority is sufficient for him.

- The punishment given to such a person by the majority is enough.
- It is sufficient that such a person has been punished by most of you^(plur).
- That penalty which most of you agreed upon and gave him is sufficient.

The punishment imposed on him by the majority:

The Greek phrase is literally “this punishment by the majority” (as in the RSV). For example:

This punishment on such an individual (NET)

In some languages a literal translation is not possible or natural. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

The punishment that most of you gave him (NCV)

The punishment that the majority inflicted on him

this person has been punished in this way by most of you (GNT)

The punishment: The Greek phrase is literally “this punishment” (as in the RSV). Paul had not talked about the punishment before in this letter. But he had probably heard from Titus how the believers had punished that person. Therefore he referred to the punishment using the word “this.” See the NET and GNT examples above. Another way could be:

that punishment

punishment: Here the word punishment refers to an unpleasant action done against the person who sinned. It was usually unpleasant and fitting to the sin. The purpose of the punishment was to help the sinning believer to repent. If possible, it also corrected the effect of the sin.

The word punishment does not mean “beat” or “hit” here. Paul did not say what the sin or the punishment was. Use a word or phrase that refers generally to causing repentance or to correcting the effects of the sin. Other ways to translate this word are:

the discipline/action to cause repentance for the sin

reprimand

penalty (REB)

the majority: The word majority indicates that most of the believers in Corinth agreed on how to punish the sinning believer. For example:

most of you (GNT)

sufficient: This word indicates that the punishment was enough. They had not punished too little or too much. For example:

enough (RSV)

2 Corinthians 2:7

Section 2:5–11: Forgive and comfort the repenting believer

In this section Paul reviewed the problem of a believer in Corinth who had sinned. The actions of this person caused Paul and the other believers there to grieve (2:5). Paul wrote earlier to the believers and told them to punish the believer who had sinned (2:9). The other believers obeyed and punished him (2:6), and he repented. Now Paul urged the believers to forgive and comfort this person (2:7). He explained that he had forgiven this person but that Satan convinces people not to forgive (2:10–11).

Paul spoke kindly here because the person had repented. He used this situation as an example to teach about forgiveness.

Other examples of headings for this section are:

Forgiveness for the Sinner (NIV)

Forgive the Person Who Sinned (GW)

Forgiveness (CEV)

2:7a

So instead, you ought to forgive and comfort him,

- So you^(plur) should rather forgive him and encourage him,
- Now instead of punishing him further, you should cancel the debt of his sin and strengthen his mind/heart/insides.

forgive: This word refers to ending the desire to avenge/repay someone who has wronged you. Feelings of anger, hatred, and resentment toward him or her are ignored and discarded. Other ways to translate this word are:

cancel the debt of sin

take his former wrongdoing from your heart

Your language may have an idiom for the meaning of forgive.

comfort: The Greek word that the BSB translates as comfort also means “encourage.” Here the meaning probably includes both helping him to feel better and

helping him to do the right things. Other ways to translate this word are:

encourage (GNT)

strengthen his mind/heart/insides

2:7b

so that he will not be overwhelmed by excessive sorrow.

- so that he will not be swallowed/overcome by too much grief.
- If you do not do that, his sorrow may become so great that it defeats him.

so that: This phrase introduces the purpose for forgiving and comforting a believer who has repented from his sin.

he will not be overwhelmed by excessive sorrow: This clause is passive. Some languages must use an active clause. For example:

excessive sorrow will not overwhelm him

overwhelmed: The Greek word is literally “swallowed.” Here the word refers figuratively to sorrow causing him to stop doing good things for God. He might even stop following God. Other ways to translate this word are:

excessive sorrow swallow such a person

overcome (NLT)

give up in despair (CEV)

excessive sorrow: The Greek phrase is literally “more abundant grief.” For example:

too much sadness (NCV)

2 Corinthians 2:8

Section 2:5–11: Forgive and comfort the repenting believer

In this section Paul reviewed the problem of a believer in Corinth who had sinned. The actions of this person caused Paul and the other believers there to grieve (2:5). Paul wrote earlier to the believers and told them to punish the believer who had sinned (2:9). The other believers obeyed and punished him (2:6), and he

repented. Now Paul urged the believers to forgive and comfort this person (2:7). He explained that he had forgiven this person but that Satan convinces people not to forgive (2:10–11).

Paul spoke kindly here because the person had repented. He used this situation as an example to teach about forgiveness.

Other examples of headings for this section are:

Forgiveness for the Sinner (NIV)

Forgive the Person Who Sinned (GW)

Forgiveness (CEV)

2:8

Therefore I urge you to reaffirm your love for him.

- So I encourage you^(plur) to show him clearly that you love him.
- So then, I really want you to demonstrate your love for him.

Therefore I urge you: The word Therefore occurs at the beginning of the clause in Greek, and that is where the BSB has placed it. Some versions place it in the middle of the clause. Do what is natural in your language. For example:

I urge you, therefore (NIV)

urge: The Greek verb translated urge also means “encourage.” It connects to the word that means “encourage” or “comfort” in 2:7a. Paul wanted them to encourage the repenting believer. Now he encouraged them to show that they loved the repenting believer. Other ways to translate this word are:

encourage

appeal to

reaffirm: The Greek word that the BSB translates as reaffirm indicates that they should show that their love for him was real. Paul wanted the Corinthians to show by their words and actions that they really did love the man. They were to accept him as one of themselves. Other ways to translate this word are:

assure (GW)

clearly show that

2 Corinthians 2:9

Section 2:5–11: Forgive and comfort the repenting believer

In this section Paul reviewed the problem of a believer in Corinth who had sinned. The actions of this person caused Paul and the other believers there to grieve (2:5). Paul wrote earlier to the believers and told them to punish the believer who had sinned (2:9). The other believers obeyed and punished him (2:6), and he repented. Now Paul urged the believers to forgive and comfort this person (2:7). He explained that he had forgiven this person but that Satan convinces people not to forgive (2:10–11).

Paul spoke kindly here because the person had repented. He used this situation as an example to teach about forgiveness.

Other examples of headings for this section are:

Forgiveness for the Sinner (NIV)

Forgive the Person Who Sinned (GW)

Forgiveness (CEV)

2:9a

My purpose in writing you

- For I also wrote to you^(plur) then/before for this reason/purpose:
- This is another reason why I wrote to you:

2:9a begins with a Greek word that is often translated “for” or “because.” Here it introduces an explanation of something about that earlier letter. 2:9 does not explain 2:8. But Paul made a connection from “I urge you” with implied obedience (2:8) to being obedient to him in the past (2:9b). For example:

For (NASB)

But some languages can leave the connection implied and omit “for,” as the BSB does.

My purpose in writing you: The Greek phrase includes a word that means “also” here. 2:9 states the second reason why Paul wrote. For example:

I also wrote because (CEV)

in writing you: This clause refers to the earlier letter (2:3–4). Your translation should not refer to the letter Paul was writing at this time (2 Corinthians). For example:

I wrote you then

2:9b

was to see if you would stand the test and be obedient in everything.

- to know the proof of your obedience in all things.
- to test you and see whether or not you would obey all that I asked you to do.
- to find out if you are always obeying my instructions. And you do.

to see: The Greek phrase is literally “to know.” The BSB uses the word see to mean “begin to understand.” For example:

to find out (GNT)

if you would stand the test: The Greek phrase is literally “your proof.” This phrase refers to seeing whether the believers in Corinth would obey Paul’s commands. This would prove that they followed him. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

to test you (NRSV)

to know how well you had stood the test

to prove yourself

be obedient: This phrase refers to following commands. For example:

obey (GNT)

in everything: This phrase refers to all of Paul’s commands to the believers in Corinth. This would include what he wrote in the previous letter. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

in all things (NASB)

always (GNT)

General Comment on 2:9a–b

The context implies that the believers in Corinth did obey Paul. Therefore they proved that they followed him as an apostle of Jesus. In some languages a literal translation would wrongly imply that they did not obey Paul. If that is true in your language, you may want to include the implied information in your translation. For example:

The reason I wrote you was to see if you would stand the test and be obedient in everything. And you did/were.

2 Corinthians 2:10**Section 2:5–11: Forgive and comfort the repenting believer**

In this section Paul reviewed the problem of a believer in Corinth who had sinned. The actions of this person caused Paul and the other believers there to grieve (2:5). Paul wrote earlier to the believers and told them to punish the believer who had sinned (2:9). The other believers obeyed and punished him (2:6), and he repented. Now Paul urged the believers to forgive and comfort this person (2:7). He explained that he had forgiven this person but that Satan convinces people not to forgive (2:10–11).

Paul spoke kindly here because the person had repented. He used this situation as an example to teach about forgiveness.

Other examples of headings for this section are:

Forgiveness for the Sinner (NIV)

Forgive the Person Who Sinned (GW)

Forgiveness (CEV)

2:10a**If you forgive anyone, I also forgive him.**

- When you^(plur) forgive someone for what he has done, I forgive him too,
- Now, whoever you forgive, I join with you in forgiving him.

If you forgive anyone, I also forgive him: The Greek clause is literally “to whom you forgive anything, I also.” Paul had just commanded that they forgive the repenting believer (2:7a). He expected them to forgive him (2:9b). Here he said that he wanted to join them in this godly activity of forgiveness. Other ways to translate this clause are:

When you forgive people for what they have done, I forgive them too (GNT)

Whoever you have now forgiven, I also forgive

forgive: See how you translated this word in 2:7.

2:10b**And if I have forgiven anything,**

- for indeed I have forgiven this thing/sin, whatever I personally had to forgive,
- I certainly have already forgiven him whatever needed to be forgiven.

And: The Greek phrase is literally “For indeed.” The conjunction “For” introduces an explanation of 2:10a. The word “indeed” emphasizes what is said in 2:10b–c. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

For certainly

Indeed (ESV)

if I have forgiven anything: The Greek phrase is literally “what I have forgiven, if anything.” It can be understood in two ways:

1. The sin was not against Paul, so he had no need to forgive the person who sinned. But he forgave that person for the sake of the believers.
2. The sin was against Paul, but the sin was a small problem and easy to forgive. He had already forgiven the person. The sin was no longer a problem, because the person had repented.

Translate in a way that allows either interpretation. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

when I forgive—if, indeed, I need to forgive anything (GNT)

when I forgive whatever needs to be forgiven (NLT)

Inasmuch as I had anything personally to forgive, I have already forgiven it

I have forgiven anything: The Greek phrase indicates that Paul has already forgiven the person who sinned.

2:10c**I have forgiven it in the presence of Christ for your sake,**

- and I have forgiven it as before Christ for your good,
- Indeed, I forgave him in the presence of Christ to help you.

in the presence of Christ: The Greek phrase is literally “in the face of Christ.” This phrase probably means “as though standing before Christ.” The phrase indicates that Paul sincerely forgave the person. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

as before Christ (JBP)

with Christ as my witness (CEV)

Christ: The word Christ is a title for Jesus. The word Christ literally means “the anointed one.” See how you translated this word in 1:1.

for your sake: Here this phrase refers to helping the believers in Corinth. Paul sincerely forgave the person in order to help the believers there. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

for your benefit (NLT)

to benefit/help you

2 Corinthians 2:11

Section 2:5–11: Forgive and comfort the repenting believer

In this section Paul reviewed the problem of a believer in Corinth who had sinned. The actions of this person caused Paul and the other believers there to grieve (2:5). Paul wrote earlier to the believers and told them to punish the believer who had sinned (2:9). The other believers obeyed and punished him (2:6), and he repented. Now Paul urged the believers to forgive and comfort this person (2:7). He explained that he had forgiven this person but that Satan convinces people not to forgive (2:10–11).

Paul spoke kindly here because the person had repented. He used this situation as an example to teach about forgiveness.

Other examples of headings for this section are:

Forgiveness for the Sinner (NIV)

Forgive the Person Who Sinned (GW)

Forgiveness (CEV)

2:11a

in order that Satan should not outwit us.

- so that Satan might not gain an advantage over us^(incl).
- If we do not do that, Satan will outsmart us and exploit us.

in order that Satan should not outwit us: The Greek word that the BSB translates as outwit means “to take advantage of someone in an evil way.” Satan tries to take advantage of believers by trying to convince them to not forgive others. If believers do not forgive others, they also sin. Other ways to translate this clause are:

to keep Satan from gaining the advantage over us (RSV)

so that Satan might not exploit us

in order to keep Satan from getting the upper hand over us (GNT)

Satan: The word Satan is the Hebrew name of the leader of all the evil spirits. In Hebrew his name means “enemy.” He is the enemy of God and God’s people. Here are some ways to translate Satan:

- Use a local name or idiom that refers to the chief of all demons.
- Use a descriptive phrase. For example:

the chief/leader of the evil spirits

the spirit enemy of God

- Borrow the common language word and spell it as someone in your area would say it. If this word is not already known in your area, you may also want to add a descriptive phrase. For example:

Satanas, the ruler of demons

Saitan If you follow this option, be sure that it communicates the biblical meaning to people in your area.

Use a term that will be acceptable to churches in the area. You may want to add a footnote or glossary entry that further explains who Satan is. For example:

Satan is the leader of all the evil spirits or demons. Once he was an angel in heaven, but he rebelled against God. God expelled him from heaven, and now he tempts people on earth. Other names for him are “Beelzebul,” “the Devil,” “the Evil One,” “the Enemy,” and “the Tempter.”

2:11b

For we are not unaware of his schemes.

- For we^(incl) are not ignorant of his plans/purposes.
- For we know that he is always planning ways to convince/tempt us to sin.

For: Here the word For introduces an explanation of 2:11a.

we are not unaware of his schemes: This clause indicates that Paul and the believers knew about Satan’s plans to outwit them. They knew that Satan always tries to make them follow his evil plans. Other ways to translate this clause are:

we are not ignorant of his schemes (NASB)

we know what his plans are (GNT)

we know his evil purposes

2 Corinthians 2:12

Section 2:12–17: Concerns and joys of an apostle

In this section Paul reviewed going to Troas to tell people about Jesus. The idiom “a door was opened” indicates that Paul had an opportunity to preach Jesus where many people would listen (2:12). He expected to meet Titus there, but Titus was not there, so Paul went to Macedonia (2:13). Titus later came to Macedonia and met with Paul (7:5).

In 2:14, Paul stopped talking about his travels. Instead, he thanked God for leading him. Paul compared God’s leading to a victory parade (2:14). He explained that believers represent Jesus (2:15–16b). He indicated that such ministry is difficult (2:16c). He also explained that he and the other evangelists do not preach as a way to earn money (2:17).

Other examples of headings for this section are:

Paul’s Mission as Christ’s Spokesman (GW)

The ways God leads

2:12a–13a

Now when I went to Troas...and a door stood open for me in the Lord: In 2:12a–b Paul explained the situation at Troas. But Paul related in 2:13a the main event that he wanted to talk about. The BSB uses the word when at the beginning of 2:12a–b to show that 2:12a–b indicates when that event happened. For example:

Now when I came to Troas for the gospel of Christ and when a door was opened for me in the Lord, I had no rest (NASB)

There is a contrast between the good thing that God did for Paul (2:12a–b) and Paul’s lack of “peace in my spirit.” In some languages it is more natural to translate the contrast. For example:

I had gone to Troas to preach the gospel of Christ. The Lord had opened a door for me, but I still had no peace of mind

When I came to Troas to preach the gospel of Christ, even though a door was opened for me in the Lord, my spirit was not at rest (ESV)

2:12a

Now when I went to Troas to preach the gospel of Christ

- ¶ When I went to Troas for the sake of the good news about Christ
- ¶ And/Then, I went to the city of Troas in order to announce the good news concerning Christ,

Now: The Greek conjunction here indicates that Paul continues his letter. Other ways to translate this conjunction are:

Furthermore (KJV)

Then

And

Some versions omit this conjunction. For example:

When I arrived (GNT)

Troas: This name refers to an important city that followed Roman ways. It was in the Roman district of Mysia. That land is now the northwest part of the country of Turkey. In some languages people are not

familiar with the name Troas. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Explain in your translation. For example:

the city of Troas

- Translate literally and explain the meaning in a footnote. An example footnote is:

Troas was an important city that followed Roman ways. It was located in the Roman district of Mysia. That land is now the northwest part of the country of Turkey.

to preach the gospel of Christ: The Greek phrase can be translated “for the purpose of the gospel of Christ.” Paul went to Troas to spread the gospel of Christ. For example:

for the sake of the gospel of Christ (NJB)

But preaching the gospel was probably Paul’s main activity. For example:

to proclaim the gospel of Christ (NET)

gospel of Christ: The Greek word that the BSB translates here as gospel means “good news.” In the New Testament the Greek word refers to the good news that Jesus is the Christ. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

the good message about Christ

the good news concerning Jesus Christ

2:12b

and a door stood open for me in the Lord,

- and saw that the Lord had opened a door for me to serve him there,
- and a great opportunity existed for me to do the Lord’s work.

a door stood open for me in the Lord: The Greek clause is literally “a door was opened for me in the Lord.” There are two ways to interpret the phrase in the Lord:

1. The phrase indicates that Paul’s work was as the Lord had commanded him. For example:

where an opening awaited me for serving the Lord (REB) (RSV, NJB, NASB, REB, ESV, KJV)

1. The phrase indicates that the Lord made it possible for Paul to do his work. For example:

the Lord had opened the way for the work there (GNT) (NIV, GNT, NLT, GW, CEV, NET, NCV)

Paul probably indicated interpretation (1) and implied interpretation (2). It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Hodge (p. 42) says the phrase “in the Lord” relates to the whole clause. Barrett (p. 94) says “Paul’s success in evangelizing was due to the Lord.” Harris (p. 238) says it may mean “by the Lord,” “in the Lord’s providence,” or “in the Lord’s service.” If possible, interpretation (2) should be implied. Other ways to translate interpretation (1) are:

an opening awaited me for serving the Lord (REB)

a door was open for me to do the Lord’s work

a door stood open: This idiom refers to an opportunity. Here Paul had the opportunity both to preach the gospel and to strengthen the believers there. The idiom also implies that the people of Troas wanted to hear the gospel and would not persecute Paul. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

opened the way (GNT)

the Lord had already prepared the way (CEV)

an obvious...opportunity (JBP)

the Lord had made a way for me

the Lord: Here the word Lord may refer to either God or Jesus. If possible, translate in a way that allows both interpretations.

The context is not clear as to whom the word Lord refers. But other verses such as 3:16–18 imply that Paul was referring to God. Some languages must say who the Lord is. If that is true in your language, you should refer to God. For example:

the Lord God

Lord: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Lord means “the one in authority over (something)” or “master.” It refers to someone greater in status or power than the person speaking. Jesus is ruler over all things. Another way to translate this word is:

ruler

See how you translated this word in 1:2 or 1:14.

2 Corinthians 2:13

Section 2:12–17: Concerns and joys of an apostle

In this section Paul reviewed going to Troas to tell people about Jesus. The idiom “a door was opened” indicates that Paul had an opportunity to preach Jesus where many people would listen (2:12). He expected to meet Titus there, but Titus was not there, so Paul went to Macedonia (2:13). Titus later came to Macedonia and met with Paul (7:5).

In 2:14, Paul stopped talking about his travels. Instead, he thanked God for leading him. Paul compared God’s leading to a victory parade (2:14). He explained that believers represent Jesus (2:15–16b). He indicated that such ministry is difficult (2:16c). He also explained that he and the other evangelists do not preach as a way to earn money (2:17).

Other examples of headings for this section are:

Paul’s Mission as Christ’s Spokesman (GW)

The ways God leads

2:13a

I had no peace in my spirit, because I did not find my brother Titus there.

- I still had no rest/relief/peace in my spirit, because I did not see Titus, my brother in Jesus, there.
- But I did not see/find Titus there, my fellow believer, bringing news of you,^(plur) so I was feeling anxious.

I had no peace in my spirit: The Greek clause is literally “I did not have rest/relief in my spirit.” Paul wanted to talk with Titus because Titus had visited the believers in Corinth. Paul wanted to know whether the believers were still following him as their apostle. So Paul’s spirit was anxious and not restful. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

my mind could not rest (RSV)

I was deeply worried (GNT)

I had no relief from anxiety (NJB)

In some languages a literal translation would wrongly imply that Paul was anxious about something other than the believers in Corinth. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Explain in your translation. For example:

I still had no peace of mind about you

- Translate literally and explain the meaning in a footnote. An example footnote is:

Paul wanted to talk with Titus because Titus had visited the believers in Corinth. Paul wanted to know whether the believers were still following him as their apostle. So Paul was anxious.

my brother Titus: Here the word brother refers to a fellow believer. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

my colleague Titus (REB)

our brother Titus (GNT)

Titus, my brother in faith

It is not known whether Titus was older or younger than Paul. Some languages must say either “younger-brother” or “older-brother.” If that is true in your language, choose the word that is appropriate for Paul being the leader over Titus and the other evangelists.

2:13b

So I said goodbye to them and went on to Macedonia.

- But/So I said farewell to them and went to Macedonia.
- And so, I said good-bye to the believers there and went to Macedonia.

So: The Greek word is literally “But.” There is contrast between the opportunity at Troas (2:12b) and leaving Troas (2:13b). For example:

but (NASB)

Since 2:13a tells the reason for what Paul did in 2:13b, many English versions translate as the BSB does, with So.

them: This pronoun refers to the believers in Troas. In some languages a literal translation would not clearly refer to the people in Troas. If that is true in your language, you may want to explain in your translation. For example:

those at Troas

the people in Troas (GW)

the believers there

Macedonia: This name refers to a Roman province that today would include the northern part of the country of Greece and the land a bit farther north. But if you explained in 1:16a that the name Macedonia refers to a province, you probably do not need to explain again here.

2 Corinthians 2:14

Section 2:12–17: Concerns and joys of an apostle

In this section Paul reviewed going to Troas to tell people about Jesus. The idiom “a door was opened” indicates that Paul had an opportunity to preach Jesus where many people would listen (2:12). He expected to meet Titus there, but Titus was not there, so Paul went to Macedonia (2:13). Titus later came to Macedonia and met with Paul (7:5).

In 2:14, Paul stopped talking about his travels. Instead, he thanked God for leading him. Paul compared God’s leading to a victory parade (2:14). He explained that believers represent Jesus (2:15–16b). He indicated that such ministry is difficult (2:16c). He also explained that he and the other evangelists do not preach as a way to earn money (2:17).

Other examples of headings for this section are:

Paul’s Mission as Christ’s Spokesman (GW)

The ways God leads

Paragraph 2:14–17

Paul changed themes here. Paul began this letter talking to the believers in Corinth about shared concerns. At 2:12, he began to tell them that he wanted to talk with Titus about his concerns.

But in 2:14–17 he thanked God for his leading and described the life following him. In some languages it is more natural to begin a new section here. The GNT has the heading “Paul’s Anxiety in Troas” for the section 2:12–13 and the heading “Victory through Christ” for the section 2:14–17.

2:14a

But thanks be to God,

- ¶ But may we all thank God,
- ¶ ¶ Now/So, God is to be thanked!

But: Here the Greek conjunction indicates contrast between the previous theme and the new theme. But the conjunction also indicates contrast between his anxiety in 2:13 and his assurance in 2:14–17. Translate in a way that indicates that contrast.

thanks be to God: This clause thanks God without speaking to him directly. For example:

I thank God (GW)

In some languages it is more natural to use direct speech in this context. For example:

I say “thank you” to God

2:14b

who always leads us triumphantly as captives in Christ

- who always leads us^(excl) in a victory parade through Christ
- He always leads us in public display in the cause of Christ as a general leads a victory parade of soldiers and captives.

who always leads us triumphantly as captives: This clause tells the reader more about God. In some languages a literal translation would wrongly indicate that there are other gods and that only this one leads us triumphantly as captives. If that is true in your language, translate this clause in a way that tells more about God. One way to do that is to start a new sentence here. For example:

He always leads us in triumphal procession

leads us triumphantly as captives: The Romans had a custom where a victorious general had a victory parade in Rome. His soldiers were in the parade. Some of his prisoners were also in the parade. The prisoners became slaves or were executed. However, Paul does not say whether he saw himself as one of the soldiers

or as one of the prisoners. There are several ways to interpret this clause:

1. Paul implies both of the metaphors of soldiers and slaves. He used both metaphors elsewhere in his letters and may intend them both here. Early in his life, Paul fought against the followers of Jesus, but God conquered him and he began to follow Jesus. Paul saw himself as a slave to Jesus and suffered in serving him. He may have expected to be killed for serving Jesus. Being led as God's prisoner demonstrated God's greatness. On the other hand, Paul followed orders from God like a good soldier. He was victorious in spreading the gospel. So then, the translation should either: (a) refer to both the soldiers and the prisoners. An example is:

leads us like a general in a victory parade of soldiers and prisoners (b) not refer to either the soldiers or the prisoners. An example is:

leads us in a victory parade (NIV, NJB, NRSV, NABRE, NET, ESV)

1. Paul saw himself as God's prisoner. He was God's slave and suffered in serving him. He may have expected to be killed for serving Jesus. Being led as God's prisoner demonstrated God's greatness. For example:

we are always led by God as prisoners in...victory procession (GNT) (BSB, GNT, NLT, REB)

1. Paul saw himself as God's victorious soldier. Paul was victorious through Jesus in spreading the gospel. He began many new groups of believers. For example:

leads us in triumph (RSV) (RSV, NASB, GW, NCV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Martin (p. 46) says, "Paul is the conquered slave exposed to public ridicule (1 Corinthians 4:9, 10, 13)... and, at the same time, 'he is the joyful participant in Christ's victory celebration.'" You should not follow interpretation (3), because that interpretation of the Greek word is not well supported in Greek texts. Because the BSB follows interpretation (2), the NIV is in the Display.

You may want to:

- Explain this Roman custom in your translation. For example:

leads us as a general leads a victory parade of soldiers and captives

- Translate literally and explain the Roman custom in a footnote. For example:

The Romans had a custom in which a victorious general had a victory parade in Rome. His soldiers were in the parade as well as some of his prisoners. The prisoners were often executed or made slaves. Like a soldier, Paul did as God commanded and was victorious. Like a prisoner, Paul often referred to himself as God's slave.

The Romans had a custom in which a victorious general had a victory parade in Rome. His soldiers were in the parade as well as some of his prisoners. The prisoners were often executed or made slaves.

Paul used metaphors of both soldiers and slaves elsewhere in his letters. He implied both metaphors here. Paul saw himself as a slave to Jesus serving him completely. He may have expected to be killed for serving Jesus. Being led as God's prisoner demonstrated God's greatness.

On the other hand, Paul followed orders from God like a good soldier. He was victorious in spreading the gospel.

in Christ: This phrase probably means "through our union with Christ" or "in the cause of Christ." Their relationship with Jesus enables believers to remain joyful as God leads them through all circumstances. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

God who always gives us in Christ a part in his triumphal procession (NJB)

in union with Christ (GNT)

through Christ (NCV)

2:14c
and through us spreads everywhere the fragrance of the knowledge of Him.

- and who spreads the scent/aroma of knowing Christ everywhere through us.

- God also causes more and more people to know Christ through our work/ministry. That knowledge spreads everywhere like a smell spreads.

and through us spreads everywhere the fragrance of the knowledge of Him: The BSB and other English versions put the phrase through us at the beginning of the clause, probably to emphasize it. But in the Greek, the phrase the fragrance of the knowledge of Him is emphasized. Emphasizing that phrase here is difficult in English. If possible, emphasize the phrase the fragrance of the knowledge of Him.

and through us: This phrase indicates that God enables his apostles to spread the gospel of Jesus. For example:

God uses us to make the knowledge about Christ spread everywhere (GNT)

spreads everywhere: God (2:14a) causes the fragrance to spread. The Greek here indicates a continuing action.

the fragrance of the knowledge of Him: This metaphor indicates that the knowledge of Him is like a fragrance. The metaphor may refer to:

1. A fragrance is something that people smell but do not see. In the same way, believers tell others about Jesus, but true knowledge of Him occurs by faith and not by sight.
2. A fragrance can smell good to some people and bad to others. It depends on the things they relate the smell to. For example, some people like the smell of the sea and others do not.

A metaphor allows people to connect the two parts in various interesting ways. Try to translate this metaphor as a metaphor. But if that is not possible, try using a simile. For example:

the knowledge about Christ...like a sweet fragrance (GNT)

In some languages this metaphor is confusing. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Explain the meaning in your translation. For example:

the fragrance that consists of the knowledge of him (NET)

God uses us to make clear what it means to know Christ. It's like a fragrance that fills the air. (GW)

- Only use the metaphor in 2:15–16 and not here. For example:

the knowledge of him

fragrance: During the victory parade people burned incense or fragrant spices. The Greek word can refer to both good and bad smells. In 2:15–16 the smell is both good and bad, depending on who smells it. If possible, the word you use should be general. It should not refer only to good smells or only to bad smells. For example:

scent (JBP)

Many English versions use the word fragrance, which refers to a good smell, because God is completely pleased with what Jesus did. But some people reject Jesus and so consider it a bad smell.

the knowledge of Him: The pronoun Him probably refers to Christ. For example:

the knowledge about Christ (GNT)

2 Corinthians 2:15

Section 2:12–17: Concerns and joys of an apostle

In this section Paul reviewed going to Troas to tell people about Jesus. The idiom “a door was opened” indicates that Paul had an opportunity to preach Jesus where many people would listen (2:12). He expected to meet Titus there, but Titus was not there, so Paul went to Macedonia (2:13). Titus later came to Macedonia and met with Paul (7:5).

In 2:14, Paul stopped talking about his travels. Instead, he thanked God for leading him. Paul compared God's leading to a victory parade (2:14). He explained that believers represent Jesus (2:15–16b). He indicated that such ministry is difficult (2:16c). He also explained that he and the other evangelists do not preach as a way to earn money (2:17).

Other examples of headings for this section are:

Paul's Mission as Christ's Spokesman (GW)

The ways God leads

Paragraph 2:14–17

Paul changed themes here. Paul began this letter talking to the believers in Corinth about shared concerns. At 2:12, he began to tell them that he wanted to talk with Titus about his concerns.

But in 2:14–17 he thanked God for his leading and described the life following him. In some languages it is more natural to begin a new section here. The GNT has the heading “Paul’s Anxiety in Troas” for the section 2:12–13 and the heading “Victory through Christ” for the section 2:14–17.

2:15a**For we are to God the sweet aroma of Christ**

- For we^(excl) are like the aroma of Christ’s sacrifice, which was given to God
- We please God when we serve Jesus; it is like the aroma of the sacrifice of Christ that pleased God.

For: This conjunction introduces an explanation of the phrase “the fragrance of the knowledge of him.”

we are to God the sweet aroma of Christ: There are two ways to interpret this metaphor:

1. It refers to the Old Testament sacrifices. God often referred to them as a pleasing aroma to him. Jesus was the sacrifice on the cross. Paul and the other evangelists are like the aroma of that sacrifice. Their deeds while following Christ honored God and pleased him.
2. It refers to the triumphal procession of 2:14. During these processions, people sacrificed animals and cooked them. They also burned incense and other sweet-smelling things.

The metaphor probably refers to (1), because the role of Christ here is pleasing God. (In 2:14 the metaphor refers to Christ’s victory.) In some languages the metaphor would not have the correct meaning. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Explain the metaphor in your translation. For example:

we are like the aroma of the sacrifice of Christ to God

we are like the aroma of Christ’s sacrifice on the cross to God

we please God when we follow Jesus, as the aroma of the sacrifice of Christ pleased God

- Translate literally and explain the meaning in a footnote. An example footnote is:

This metaphor refers to the Old Testament sacrifices. They were often referred to as a pleasing aroma to God. Jesus was the sacrifice on the cross. Believers are like the aroma of that sacrifice.

- Translate the meaning without the metaphor. For example:

we please God when we follow Jesus You may then want to explain the literal Greek. For example:

Literally “we are the aroma of Christ to God.” This metaphor refers to the Old Testament sacrifices. They were often referred to as a pleasing aroma to God. Jesus was the sacrifice on the cross. Believers are like the aroma of that sacrifice.

the sweet aroma of Christ: This phrase is emphasized in the Greek. If possible, emphasize this phrase in your language. For example:

the aroma of Christ we are to God

sweet aroma: The Greek word here only refers to good smells. Other ways to translate this word are:

fragrance (NASB)

sweet smell (NCV)

2:15b**among those who are being saved**

- and which spreads among those whom God is saving
- This aroma spreads among those who are on the road/way to being saved
- We please God by serving Jesus among those whom God saves,

among those who are being saved: A good smell wafts among the people in a crowd. Paul and the other evangelists did things that pleased God. Their deeds were done among believers. The believers rejoiced in God when they saw those deeds, as a crowd reacts positively to a good smell. The phrase here refers to doing those things among believers. For example:

which spreads among those who are being saved (GNT)

those who are being saved: The clause who are being saved is passive. It is God who saves people. Some languages must use an active clause. For example:

those whom God is saving

The Greek clause indicates that God is saving people at the present time.

saved: The Greek word that the BSB translates as saved means “to rescue someone from danger or trouble.” In this context it refers to rescuing someone from the spiritual dangers of sin and the punishment that result from it. God will save people from the punishment that results from sin. In your translation, you may need to make explicit what people are saved from. For example:

saved from sin/hell

saved from the punishment of their sins

2:15c

and those who are perishing.

- and those whom God destroys.
- and among those who are on the road/way to being destroyed.
- We also please God by serving Jesus among those whom God will destroy.

those who are perishing: This clause refers to people who will die as an enemy of God. Their destiny is destruction in hell. For example:

those who are on the way to destruction (NJB)

2 Corinthians 2:16

Section 2:12–17: Concerns and joys of an apostle

In this section Paul reviewed going to Troas to tell people about Jesus. The idiom “a door was opened” indicates that Paul had an opportunity to preach Jesus where many people would listen (2:12). He expected to meet Titus there, but Titus was not there, so Paul went to Macedonia (2:13). Titus later came to Macedonia and met with Paul (7:5).

In 2:14, Paul stopped talking about his travels. Instead, he thanked God for leading him. Paul compared God’s leading to a victory parade (2:14). He explained that believers represent Jesus (2:15–16b). He indicated that

such ministry is difficult (2:16c). He also explained that he and the other evangelists do not preach as a way to earn money (2:17).

Other examples of headings for this section are:

Paul’s Mission as Christ’s Spokesman (GW)

The ways God leads

Paragraph 2:14–17

Paul changed themes here. Paul began this letter talking to the believers in Corinth about shared concerns. At 2:12, he began to tell them that he wanted to talk with Titus about his concerns.

But in 2:14–17 he thanked God for his leading and described the life following him. In some languages it is more natural to begin a new section here. The GNT has the heading “Paul’s Anxiety in Troas” for the section 2:12–13 and the heading “Victory through Christ” for the section 2:14–17.

2:16a–b

To the one, we are an odor of death and demise; to the other, a fragrance that brings life: The first clause, To the one, we are an odor of death, refers to 2:15c. The second clause, to the other, a fragrance that brings life, refers to 2:15b. This is good Greek style. In some languages it is more natural to have the clauses in the same order as in 2:15. For example:

To the one/first we are the fragrance of life, and to the other/second we are the smell of death

2:16a

To the one, we are an odor of death and demise;

- On the one hand, to one group we^(excl) are an aroma from death to death,
- To the latter we are like the smell of death leading to death.
- We are like a deadly stench that kills to those whom God will destroy.

2:16a begins with the Greek conjunction that means “on one hand.” The Greek word indicates contrast: 2:16a refers to one kind of people, and 2:16b refers to another kind of people. For example:

On the first hand/side

But some languages can allow the context to indicate that there are two kinds of people and can omit this conjunction, as the BSB has done.

To the one: This phrase refers to the people who are perishing (2:15c). In some languages a literal translation would not clearly indicate that. If that is true in your language, you may want to explain in your translation. For example:

To the second group

for these last (NJB)

To those who are perishing

This phrase is emphasized. If possible, emphasize this phrase in your translation.

we are an odor of death and demise: The Greek phrase is literally “a smell out of death to death.” There are several ways to interpret this clause:

1. The phrase “out of” refers to the kind of smell. The word “to” refers to the effect of the smell. For example:

the smell of death leading to death (NJB) (NJB, GNT, NABRE, CEV, REB, NCV, KJV)

1. Translate literally. In some languages a literal translation has the correct meaning as described in (1). For example:

an odor from death to death (NET) (RSV, NASB, NET, ESV)

1. The phrase “out of death to death” is based on a Hebrew idiom that emphasizes the word death. Some versions omit the emphasis. For example:

we are a deadly fragrance (GW) (NIV, GW)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Harris (p. 241) says in his translation “a deadly stench that leads to death.” But in some languages people will properly understand a literal translation. If that is true in your language, follow interpretation (2).

This clause is a metaphor. In some languages it is more natural to use a simile here. For example:

we are like the smell of death

2:16b
to the other, a fragrance that brings life.

- and on the other hand, to the other group we are an aroma from life to life.
- To the former we are like the smell of life leading to life.
- But we are like a beautiful fragrance that gives life to those whom God will save.

2:16b begins with the conjunction that means “on the other hand” here. The conjunction indicates that 2:16b refers to a second kind of people. (2:16a referred to a first kind of people.) For example:

On the second hand/side

But many languages can allow the context to indicate that there are two kinds of people and omit this conjunction, as the BSB has done.

to the other: This phrase refers to the people who are being saved (2:15b). In some languages a literal translation would not clearly refer to that. If that is true in your language, you may want to explain in your translation. For example:

to the first group

for the first (NJB)

to those who are being saved

This phrase is emphasized. If possible, emphasize this phrase in your translation.

a fragrance that brings life: The Greek phrase is literally “a smell out of life to life.” Follow the same option here as you did in 2:16a:

1. Following option (1) above, the NJB says:

the smell of life leading to life (NJB)

1. Following option (2) above, the NET says:

a fragrance from life to life (NET)

1. Following option (3) above, the GW says:

we are a life-giving fragrance (GW)

2:16c
And who is qualified for such a task?

- But can anyone be adequate/sufficient to do this work?
- Certainly no one is able to hold this responsibility.

And: In 2:14b Paul talked about life as an apostle of Jesus. In 2:14c–16b he talked about the effect of his ministry. In 2:16c he said that doing the work of an apostle is impossible without God helping him. There is some contrast here. In some languages it is more natural to translate the contrast here. For example:

But

Some languages do not need to translate the conjunction to indicate the contrast.

who is qualified for such a task?: This is a rhetorical question. It emphasizes the fact that no one is equal to such a task. Translate this clause with that meaning. Some ways are:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

is anyone equal to the task?

can anyone be equal to the task?

Who could think himself adequate for a responsibility like this? (JBP)

- As a statement. For example:

Certainly no one is equal to such a task.

No one really has what it takes to do this work. (CEV)

- As a command. For example:

do not think that anyone is equal to the task!

surely do not think that anyone is adequate for a responsibility like this.

Here Paul said that the task God gave him exceeded anyone's ability to do on his own (as 3:5 explains). In some languages a literal translation would wrongly indicate that Paul was saying that no one can be an apostle. If that is true in your language, you may want to explain the meaning in a footnote. For example:

Here Paul said that he did not have the ability to do a good job as an apostle. But he also knew that God had empowered him to do a good job (1 Corinthians 15:9–10; 2 Corinthians 3:5).

is qualified: This phrase refers to being able to do something. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

is sufficient (RSV)

is capable (GNT)

is adequate (NASB)

for such a task: The Greek word is literally “these (things).” Here the phrase refers to doing the work of an apostle. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

to do this work (CEV)

for a responsibility like this (JBP)

for such a calling (REB)

2 Corinthians 2:17

Section 2:12–17: Concerns and joys of an apostle

In this section Paul reviewed going to Troas to tell people about Jesus. The idiom “a door was opened” indicates that Paul had an opportunity to preach Jesus where many people would listen (2:12). He expected to meet Titus there, but Titus was not there, so Paul went to Macedonia (2:13). Titus later came to Macedonia and met with Paul (7:5).

In 2:14, Paul stopped talking about his travels. Instead, he thanked God for leading him. Paul compared God's leading to a victory parade (2:14). He explained that believers represent Jesus (2:15–16b). He indicated that such ministry is difficult (2:16c). He also explained that he and the other evangelists do not preach as a way to earn money (2:17).

Other examples of headings for this section are:

Paul's Mission as Christ's Spokesman (GW)

The ways God leads

Paragraph 2:14–17

Paul changed themes here. Paul began this letter talking to the believers in Corinth about shared concerns.

At 2:12, he began to tell them that he wanted to talk with Titus about his concerns.

But in 2:14-17 he thanked God for his leading and described the life following him. In some languages it is more natural to begin a new section here. The GNT has the heading “Paul’s Anxiety in Troas” for the section 2:12-13 and the heading “Victory through Christ” for the section 2:14-17.

2:17a

For we are not like so many others, who peddle the word of God for profit.

- For we^(excl) do not preach a corrupted word of God in order to make money, unlike the many deceivers who do.
- Such responsibility is hard because we are not like the many swindlers/con-men who aim to make money by proclaiming a version of the word of God that they have changed/modified/corrupted.

For: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as *For* introduces an explanation of 2:16c. 2:17 explains why being an apostle of Jesus is so difficult. In some languages it is more natural to indicate what Paul was explaining. For example:

This work is so difficult because

Such responsibility is hard because

Such a calling is difficult because

peddle the word of God for profit: The Greek word that the BSB translates as *peddle...for profit* refers to selling something in a way that deceives the buyer. The seller’s goal is to make more money than a reasonable amount of profit. For example, a grain seller may use dishonest scales. He puts nine kilograms of grain on the scale, but the scale reads ten kilograms. In that way he can sell it at the price of ten kilograms of grain and make extra money.

The Greek word can also indicate that the seller changes the product in such a way that he makes more money. For example, a wine seller may only partially fill bottles with wine and fill them the rest of the way with water. In that way he can sell more bottles of wine at the full price.

Paul used this Greek word figuratively. Using it here, he probably ridiculed the false teachers who had come to Corinth. The reason they preached was to have people pay them for preaching. They did not preach to help those listening (11:7). They also changed the

gospel (11:4) so that the hearers would be more eager to accept them and give them money. Here is a way to translate this that includes both of these meanings:

hucksters who preach for personal profit (NLT)

(Here the word “hucksters” refers figuratively to the false teachers deceiving the listeners in what they say.) Other ways to translate this clause are:

aim to make money by changing the word of God

preach a corrupted word of God in order to make money

2:17b

On the contrary, in Christ we speak before God with sincerity,

- But we always speak sincerely through Christ in the presence of God,
- But we speak with complete sincerity as Christ’s spokesmen standing before God,

On the contrary, in Christ we speak before God with sincerity: The Greek clause is literally “but as from sincerity...we speak in Christ before God.” The phrase “as from sincerity” contrasts with the deceivers in 2:17a. For example:

but in Christ we speak as persons of sincerity...
and standing in his presence (NRSV)

in Christ: This phrase probably means “through our union with Christ” or “in the cause of Christ.” Paul’s relationship with Jesus enabled him to preach accurately and sincerely. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

As Christ’s spokesmen (GW)

as servants of Christ (GNT)

through Christ

we speak before God: Paul knew that God sees all things, so Paul always spoke truthfully. For example:

in the sight of God we speak (RSV)

sincerity: This word refers to having pure motives. Paul and the others did not do anything for selfish or wrong reasons. Other ways to translate this word are:

true/straight motives

for no evil reasons

2:17c

as men sent from God.

- as people whom God has sent.
- because God has sent us with his message.

as men sent from God: God chose Paul and the other evangelists to go and tell others about Jesus. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

as commissioned by God (RSV)

because God has sent us (GNT)

as envoys of God (NJB)

2 Corinthians 3:1

Section 3:1–4:6: Confidence in the gospel of Jesus

The false teachers in Corinth were Jews (11:22). In this section, Paul wrote about some of the false teachings of these men. Since they were Jews, Paul referred to people and events in the Old Testament, such as the tablets of stone (3:3), Moses (3:7), and Moses' veil (3:13). They probably brought letters from other false teachers who said the false teachers in Corinth taught truthfully (3:1–3). The false teachers taught that believers must obey the Jewish laws. But Paul said that believers follow the new covenant with Jesus and not the old covenant with the Jews (3:14). He also spoke against their secret and shameful ways and said that they corrupted God's word (4:2). Throughout this section Paul also encouraged the believers to follow Jesus.

Other examples of headings for this section are:

The Ministry That Comes From Christ Is Greater Than Moses' Ministry (GW)

The new covenant is greater than the law of Moses

3:1a

Are we beginning to commend ourselves again?

- ¶ Can it be that we^(excl) begin to commend ourselves to you^(plur) again?
- ¶ We certainly do not begin to recommend ourselves to you again!

Are we beginning to commend ourselves again?:

This is a rhetorical question. It emphasizes the fact that Paul and his companions were not beginning to commend themselves again. Translate this clause with that meaning. Some ways are:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Do we begin to commend ourselves again?

Can it be that we begin to commend ourselves to you again? No way!

- As a statement. For example:

We certainly do not begin to commend yourselves again.

We have no need to begin commending ourselves to you again.

- As a command. For example:

Do not think that we begin to commend ourselves again!

commend ourselves: This word refers to introducing or recommending someone to someone else. If someone is well known to a group, someone else may come to him and ask him to introduce him to the group. That way the group can trust the new person. There are two ways to interpret this word:

1. The word means introduce or recommend here. For example:

produce our credentials (REB) (BSB, RSV, NIV, NJB, NASB, NABRE, GW, NET, REB, ESV, KJV)

1. The word means boast here. For example:

boasting about ourselves (GNT) (GNT, NLT, CEV, NCV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), since that is the usual meaning of the Greek word. Harris (p. 258) defines this word as "bring

together as friends,” or “introduce/recommend someone to someone else.” Other ways to translate this word are:

show...our qualifications (GW)

recommend ourselves

3:1b

Or do we need, like some people, letters of recommendation to you or from you?

- Can it be that we need letters of commendation to you or from you, like some people who need them?
- We certainly do not need letters of introduction/reference either to you or from you, as some people do.

Or do we need, like some people, letters of recommendation to you or from you?: This is also a rhetorical question. It emphasizes the fact that Paul and the others did not need letters of recommendation to the believers in Corinth or from them. But the false teachers did need such letters of recommendation. Translate this clause with that meaning. Some ways are:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Surely we do not need, as some do, letters of recommendation to you or from you, do we? (NRSV)

Can it be that we need letters of recommendation to you or from you, as some people need them?

- As a statement. For example:

We certainly do not, like some people, need letters of recommendation to you or from you.

We have no need of letters of recommendation to you or from you, as some people need them.

- As a command. For example:

Do not think that we need letters of recommendation to you or from you, as some people need them!

like some people: Paul may have been ridiculing the false teachers here, because they probably came with letters of recommendation to Corinth. But the theme

of this verse refers generally to Paul’s relationship to the believers in Corinth. So you should not translate this phrase as ridicule. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

as some do (RSV)

like some other people (NCV)

letters of recommendation: This phrase refers to letters that others would write saying that a particular person was a good person and worthy of being accepted. In Acts 15:23–27, the believers in Jerusalem recommended Judas and Silas to the believers in Antioch, Syria, and Cilicia. In Acts 18:27, when Apollos wanted to go to Achaia, the believers in Ephesus “wrote to the disciples there to welcome him.” Other ways to translate this phrase are:

letters of commendation (NASB)

letters that recommend us (GW)

letters...to tell others about us (CEV)

letters of introduction (REB)

a letter saying that this man is good

to you: Paul evangelized in Corinth, so the believers in Corinth knew him, and he did not need letters of recommendation to give to them.

from you: When Paul went to new places, he probably allowed his teaching and deeds to indicate that he was a true apostle of Jesus. So he did not need the believers in Corinth to write letters of recommendation on his behalf.

2 Corinthians 3:2

Section 3:1–4:6: Confidence in the gospel of Jesus

The false teachers in Corinth were Jews (11:22). In this section, Paul wrote about some of the false teachings of these men. Since they were Jews, Paul referred to people and events in the Old Testament, such as the tablets of stone (3:3), Moses (3:7), and Moses’ veil (3:13). They probably brought letters from other false teachers who said the false teachers in Corinth taught truthfully (3:1–3). The false teachers taught that believers must obey the Jewish laws. But Paul said that believers follow the new covenant with Jesus and

not the old covenant with the Jews (3:14). He also spoke against their secret and shameful ways and said that they corrupted God's word (4:2). Throughout this section Paul also encouraged the believers to follow Jesus.

Other examples of headings for this section are:

The Ministry That Comes From Christ Is Greater Than Moses' Ministry (GW)

The new covenant is greater than the law of Moses

3:2a

You yourselves are our letter, inscribed on our hearts,

- It is you^(plur) who are our^(excl) letter of commendation, indeed, as if written on our hearts,
- You yourselves are like a letter that recommends us. You are very loved, like a letter written on our hearts.
- Your own faith explains our ministry like a letter of recommendation for us. We have a close relationship with you, as if your names were written on our hearts in a letter.

You yourselves are our letter: This clause is a metaphor. The believers in Corinth were like a letter of recommendation because others could see the faith of the believers and know that Paul was a good apostle. In some languages the metaphor will not have the correct meaning. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Translate as a simile. For example:

You yourselves are like a letter of recommendation for us

- Explain the meaning in your translation. For example:

Your own faith explains our ministry, like a letter of recommendation for us

You yourselves can be compared to a letter that shows the good effect of our work

- Translate literally and explain the meaning in a footnote. An example footnote is:

The believers in Corinth were like a letter of recommendation because others could see the faith of the believers and know that Paul was a true apostle.

In the Greek, both the phrase our letter and the pronoun You are emphasized. If possible, emphasize both the phrase our letter and the pronoun You. For example:

You yourselves are our letter indeed

It is you who are certainly our letter

inscribed on our hearts: There is a textual issue in 3:2a: (1) Many Greek manuscripts have the word our (BSB, NIV, GNT, NJB, NLT, GW, CEV, NET, JBP, REB, ESV, NCV, KJV). (2) Some Greek manuscripts have the word your (RSV). It is recommended that you follow option (1). This clause is also a metaphor. It refers to the close relationship Paul and the other evangelists had with the believers in Corinth. Paul and the others loved the believers in Corinth. In Greek and English cultures, the heart is the place where love comes from. In some languages the metaphor will not have the correct meaning. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Translate as a simile. For example:

as if written on our hearts

- Explain the meaning in your translation. For example:

very loved, like a letter written on our hearts

we have a close relationship with you, as if your names were written on our hearts in a letter

- Translate literally and explain the meaning in a footnote. An example footnote is:

This clause indicates that Paul and the other evangelists loved the believers in Corinth. In Greek culture, the heart was the place where love came from.

inscribed: This verb is passive. Some languages must use an active clause. In the metaphor, probably Paul and his coworkers wrote. For example:

which we ourselves have written (JBP)

hearts: Here the “heart” is where emotions, purposes, and intentions are. Use a term that is normally used in your language where emotions, purposes, and intentions are. It may be a different organ such as the liver, or it may be a general term such as “insides.”

3:2b

known and read by everyone.

- which is read and known by everybody.
- It is a letter that everybody reads and knows.
- Your lives show your faith, like a letter that everybody can read and know.

known and read by everyone: This phrase continues the metaphor of the letter. People could see the changed lives of the believers and realize that Paul had helped them to become that way.

This clause is passive. Some languages must use an active clause. For example:

that everyone can read and understand (NJB)

In some languages this metaphor will not have the correct meaning. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Translate as a simile. For example:

You are like a letter that everybody reads and knows

- Explain the meaning in your translation. For example:

Your lives show your faith, like a letter that everybody can read and know

- Translate literally and explain the meaning in a footnote. An example footnote is:

The lives of the believers in Corinth showed that they believed in Jesus. So others could observe and see their good lives, like reading a letter and knowing what it said.

2 Corinthians 3:3

Section 3:1–4:6: Confidence in the gospel of Jesus

The false teachers in Corinth were Jews (11:22). In this section, Paul wrote about some of the false teachings of these men. Since they were Jews, Paul referred

to people and events in the Old Testament, such as the tablets of stone (3:3), Moses (3:7), and Moses' veil (3:13). They probably brought letters from other false teachers who said the false teachers in Corinth taught truthfully (3:1–3). The false teachers taught that believers must obey the Jewish laws. But Paul said that believers follow the new covenant with Jesus and not the old covenant with the Jews (3:14). He also spoke against their secret and shameful ways and said that they corrupted God's word (4:2). Throughout this section Paul also encouraged the believers to follow Jesus.

Other examples of headings for this section are:

The Ministry That Comes From Christ Is Greater Than Moses' Ministry (GW)

The new covenant is greater than the law of Moses

3:3a

It is clear that you are a letter from Christ, the result of our ministry,

- It is plain that you^(plur) are Christ's letter, because of what we^(excl) did among you,
- You have been revealed as a letter written by Christ. This letter was the result of our ministry.
- It is evident/obvious that your changed lives are like a letter which Christ wrote. He wrote that letter by means of our work/ministry.

It is clear: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as it is clear can be either passive or active. There are two ways to interpret it:

1. The verb is passive, therefore the phrase means it is well known. For example:

It is clear (GNT) (BSB, GNT, NJB, NASB, NLT, GW, NET, REB, KJV)

1. The verb is active, therefore the phrase means you reveal. For example:

you show (RSV) (RSV, NIV, ESV, NABRE, NCV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Thrall (p. 224) says, “it is perhaps more likely to be passive.” Harris (p. 257) translates the text as “You are shown” and says it is “more probably passive.”

you are a letter from Christ: The metaphor is described further here. Paul helped people believe in

Christ and follow him. He did that by the power of Christ. Other people saw the changes and realized that Christ had caused the changes. This was like reading a letter and seeing who had written it. In some languages this metaphor will not have the correct meaning. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Translate the metaphor as a simile. For example:

you are like a letter from Christ

- Explain the meaning in your translation. For example:

your changed lives are a letter that Christ wrote

- Translate literally and explain the meaning in a footnote. An example footnote is:

The metaphor of the letter still refers to the lives of the believers, but it now indicates that Christ enabled them to believe well.

a letter from Christ: The Greek phrase is literally “a letter of Christ” (as in the NRSV). The Greek phrase probably refers to a metaphor of Christ writing the letter. For example:

a letter written by Christ (CEV)

Christ: The word Christ is a title for Jesus and means “the anointed one.” See how you translated this word in 1:1.

In some languages people always use both names “Jesus Christ” and never the title Christ alone. If that is true in your language, you may want to include the name “Jesus” here. For example:

Jesus Christ

the result of our ministry: The Greek is literally “served/helped/cared-for by us.” This phrase continues the metaphor of the letter of Christ. This phrase refers figuratively to ministering to the people in Corinth, including when Paul preached the first time. Teaching and helping others are included as well. Paul and the other evangelists did all these things and in that way helped/served the letter of Christ, namely the believers in Corinth. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

by means of what we did among you

because of our^(excl) work to you^(plur)

entrusted to our care (NJB)

given to us to deliver (REB)

In some languages continuing the metaphor is not natural. If that is true in your language, you may want to explain the meaning in your translation, as the BSB does. Some other examples are:

by means of our work/ministry

cared for by us (NASB)

3:3b

written not with ink but with the Spirit of the living God,

- written by means of the Spirit of the living God and not with ink,
- That letter was written not with ink but the Spirit of the God who lives forever working in your lives,
- He wrote it not actually with ink but through the working of the Holy Spirit of the God who is alive.

written not with ink but with the Spirit of the living

God: The negative phrase is first (not with ink) and the positive phrase is second. In some languages it is more natural to have the positive phrase first. For example:

written with the Spirit of the living God and not with ink

This clause refers figuratively to the Holy Spirit changing the lives of believers. Others see the changes and know that they follow Jesus. This is like ink on a letter, showing the thoughts of the writer. The ink is the means of writing. Similarly, the Holy Spirit is the means of changed lives. Many English versions use the word with here. Another way to translate this clause is:

written by means of the Spirit of the living God and not with ink

In some languages the metaphor is not natural. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Translate as a simile. For example:

written as if with the Spirit of the living God and not with ink

- Explain the meaning in your translation. For example:

written not with ink but the Spirit of the living God, who causes your lives to be an example of Jesus, like a letter telling others about him

- Translate literally and explain the meaning in a footnote. An example:

The Holy Spirit causes a believer's life to be an example of Jesus. This is like a letter telling others about him, because others see the believer's faith and changed life.

written not with ink: This phrase indicates that the letter of 3:3a is only a metaphor. In some languages it is more natural to indicate that this phrase refers to the metaphor. For example:

not actually written with ink

written in reality not with ink

ink: This word refers to a colored liquid that dries on paper (or other similar materials) and permanently marks it. The words in books are usually written with black ink.

the Spirit of the living God: This phrase refers to the Holy Spirit. In some languages a literal translation would wrongly refer to another spirit. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Explain in your translation. For example:

the Holy Spirit of the living God

- Translate literally and explain the meaning in a footnote. An example footnote is:

Paul described the Holy Spirit in this way.

living God: The word living here refers to God being alive, as opposed to idols, which are not alive. Some other examples for translating are:

the alive God This expression should not imply in your language that He is one of many "gods."

the God who lives forever

In some languages people assume that God lives, so the phrase "the living God" is not natural. If that is true in your language, you may want to translate the meaning in another way. For example:

the God who never dies

3:3c

not on tablets of stone but on tablets of human hearts.

- written on tablets/plaques of human hearts and not on tablets/plaques of stone.
- and was written not on writing stones of laws to be obeyed but on the inner being of people.
- He changed the spirit/hearts of people to follow him like writing a letter for all to see and not on stone slabs of laws to follow.

not on tablets of stone but on tablets of human hearts: The verb "written" is implied from 3:3b but not repeated here. In some languages it is more natural to repeat the verb. For example:

written not on tablets of stone but on tablets of human hearts

The negative phrase is first (not on tablets of stone) and the positive phrase is second. In some languages it is more natural to have the positive phrase first. For example:

written on tablets of human hearts and not on tablets of stone

These phrases continue the metaphor but now focus on the thing that is written upon. They figuratively indicate that the believers' hearts are changed. So the believers act and speak based on their faith, and people can see the change, like reading a letter. In some languages the metaphor is not natural. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Translate as a simile. For example:

written as if on human hearts like a tablet and not on tablets of stone

- Explain the meaning in your translation. For example:

written not on tablets of stone but Christ changed your hearts to follow him, like writing a letter upon them for all to see

- Translate literally and explain the meaning in a footnote. An example footnote is:

These words indicate that the change to follow Jesus happens at the deepest level in a person. The changes are not just rules to follow like the Ten Commandments, which were written on tablets of stone. These changes at the deepest level in a person also change the way he lives for others to see.

tablets of stone: This phrase refers to the Ten Commandments (Exodus 24:12, 31:18). The writing was carved into the stone. In some languages a literal translation would not imply the Ten Commandments. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Explain in your translation. For example:

tablets of stone of laws to obey/follow

- Translate literally and explain the meaning in a footnote. An example footnote is:

This phrase refers to the Ten Commandments (Exodus 24:12, 31:18). People could publicly obey the laws but still have an unchanged heart that disobeyed God.

tablets: This word indicates the stones were flat, wide, and tall, and not very thick. The word tablets refers to something to write on. Other ways to translate this word are:

flat stones

stones flat like tablets

flat stones to write on

tablets of human hearts: This phrase refers figuratively to hearts as if they were a place on which to write. The word tablets is used here to emphasize the difference between human hearts and stone. If the word tablets is not natural as a metaphor or simile, emphasize the difference between human hearts and stone in another way. This may include explaining the difference. For example:

human hearts, which affect the whole person, unlike stone

hearts: Here the word “heart” refers to the center and source of inner life, that is, thinking, feeling, and will. Use a term that is normally used in your language for “inner life” or the place where words are thought of. It may be a different organ such as the liver, or it may be a general term such as “insides.”

2 Corinthians 3:4

Section 3:1–4:6: Confidence in the gospel of Jesus

The false teachers in Corinth were Jews (11:22). In this section, Paul wrote about some of the false teachings of these men. Since they were Jews, Paul referred to people and events in the Old Testament, such as the tablets of stone (3:3), Moses (3:7), and Moses’ veil (3:13). They probably brought letters from other false teachers who said the false teachers in Corinth taught truthfully (3:1–3). The false teachers taught that believers must obey the Jewish laws. But Paul said that believers follow the new covenant with Jesus and not the old covenant with the Jews (3:14). He also spoke against their secret and shameful ways and said that they corrupted God’s word (4:2). Throughout this section Paul also encouraged the believers to follow Jesus.

Other examples of headings for this section are:

The Ministry That Comes From Christ Is Greater Than Moses’ Ministry (GW)

The new covenant is greater than the law of Moses

3:4

Such confidence before God is ours through Christ.

- ¶ We^(excl) are confident in those things before God through Christ.
- ¶ We are certain about those things in God’s presence because Christ empowered that certainty in us.

Such confidence...is ours: The phrase Such confidence refers to the fact that a strong group of believers in Corinth clearly showed that Paul was a good apostle. Paul was sure of that; he had no doubts. Other ways to translate this clause are:

Such is the confidence we have (NJB)

We are sure about all this (CEV)

We have no doubts about those things

before God: The Greek phrase is literally “to God.” There are several ways to interpret this phrase:

1. The phrase refers to being in the presence of God. This indicates that God approved of Paul being confident. For example:

in God’s presence (GW) (BSB, NIV, NJB, GW, CEV, NCV)

1. Paul’s confidence is directed toward God. Paul was confident because he expected God to be faithful to his people. For example:

toward God (RSV) (RSV, NASB, NABRE, NCV, KJV)

1. Paul’s confidence is in God. For example:

in God (GNT) (GNT, NLT, NET, REB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Martin (p. 52) says the phrase means “in the presence of God.” He also says the phrase connects to a similar phrase in 2:17b to indicate the kinds of places in which Paul ministered. Thrall (p. 190) and Barrett (p. 110) translate it as “before God.” Barrett says that “his confidence...is not based upon his own character or qualifications.”

through Christ: This phrase indicates that Christ enabled Paul to be confident. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

by Christ enabling us

through Christ making us so

2 Corinthians 3:5

Section 3:1–4:6: Confidence in the gospel of Jesus

The false teachers in Corinth were Jews (11:22). In this section, Paul wrote about some of the false teachings of these men. Since they were Jews, Paul referred to people and events in the Old Testament, such as the tablets of stone (3:3), Moses (3:7), and Moses’ veil (3:13). They probably brought letters from other false teachers who said the false teachers in Corinth taught truthfully (3:1–3). The false teachers taught that believers must obey the Jewish laws. But Paul said that believers follow the new covenant with Jesus and not the old covenant with the Jews (3:14). He also

spoke against their secret and shameful ways and said that they corrupted God’s word (4:2). Throughout this section Paul also encouraged the believers to follow Jesus.

Other examples of headings for this section are:

The Ministry That Comes From Christ Is Greater Than Moses’ Ministry (GW)

The new covenant is greater than the law of Moses

3:5a

Not that we are competent in ourselves

- But on our own we^(excl) are not capable/competent
- Not that we are sufficient in our own abilities/powers

Not that we are competent in ourselves: The word that introduces an explanation. Paul was confident that he was an apostle, but he did not believe that the authority and power to be an apostle came from his own abilities. That authority and power came from God. Another way to translate is:

But we are not competent in ourselves

There is nothing in us that allows us to claim that we are capable of doing this work (GNT)

competent: This word refers to being able or qualified to do something. Other ways to translate this word are:

capable (GNT)

sufficient (ESV)

qualified (GW)

in ourselves: This phrase indicates that Paul’s own abilities did not make him competent to serve God. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

on our own (CEV)

of our own resources (JBP)

in our own abilities

3:5b**to claim that anything comes from us,**

- to claim any advance as being from our own abilities,
- to say that we have caused God's kingdom to grow in any way,

claim that anything comes from us: If someone builds a house well, he can claim he is a good house builder. Paul knew that God caused all the good things in Corinth, including people believing in Jesus and having strong faith. So he could not claim anything about himself. Other ways to translate this clause are:

claim anything as coming from us (RSV)

claim any credit for ourselves (NJB)

anything: This word refers to all that happened in Corinth regarding people believing in Jesus. In some languages a literal translation would not refer to the advance of God's kingdom. If that is true in your language, you may want to explain in your translation. For example:

all that happened for God's kingdom

3:5c**but our competence comes from God.**

- but the source of our capability/competence is God.
- but God gives to us the ability/power to serve him.

our competence comes from God: This clause indicates that God caused Paul and the others to have the authority and power to do God's work. Other ways to translate this clause are:

our competence is from God (RSV)

God makes us qualified (GW)

God gives us the abilities to do his work

competence: This word refers to being able or qualified to do something. The noun competence has a similar meaning to the adjective "competent" (3:5a).

General Comment on 3:5a–c

The negative clause (3:5a–b) is before the positive clause (3:5c). In some languages it is more natural to have the positive clause first. For example:

For our competence comes from God; we are not competent in ourselves to claim anything for ourselves

2 Corinthians 3:6**Section 3:1–4:6: Confidence in the gospel of Jesus**

The false teachers in Corinth were Jews (11:22). In this section, Paul wrote about some of the false teachings of these men. Since they were Jews, Paul referred to people and events in the Old Testament, such as the tablets of stone (3:3), Moses (3:7), and Moses' veil (3:13). They probably brought letters from other false teachers who said the false teachers in Corinth taught truthfully (3:1–3). The false teachers taught that believers must obey the Jewish laws. But Paul said that believers follow the new covenant with Jesus and not the old covenant with the Jews (3:14). He also spoke against their secret and shameful ways and said that they corrupted God's word (4:2). Throughout this section Paul also encouraged the believers to follow Jesus.

Other examples of headings for this section are:

The Ministry That Comes From Christ Is Greater Than Moses' Ministry (GW)

The new covenant is greater than the law of Moses

3:6a**And He has qualified us as ministers of a new covenant,**

- He has caused us^(excl) to become capable/competent ministers/servants/agents of a new covenant/promise/agreement,
- He enables us to have all the ability we need to do his work of the new covenant of Jesus well.

He has qualified us as ministers: This clause indicates that God has caused Paul and the others to become qualified...as ministers. Other ways to translate this clause are:

He made us able to be servants of (NCV)

He has given us the power to be good ministers

who made sufficient our ability to do his work

He gives us^(excl) ability to be his workersUma Back Translation on TW.

ministers: This word refers to people who serve, help, or care for others. Here the word refers to Paul and the other evangelists preaching and helping the believers in Corinth to become strong in their faith. Other ways to translate this word are:

servants (NCV)

capable of serving (GNT)

doing the work of

This word refers to people who do ministry. The word “ministry” is used in 3:7–11. These two words should be translated in a way that the readers will see the connection between the two words.

a new covenant: God made the first covenant with the Jewish people through Moses at Mt. Sinai. The new covenant refers to the promise that God would put his laws into people’s hearts and they would become his people (Hebrews 8:8–13). Jesus put the new covenant into effect by dying on the cross. In some languages a literal translation would not refer to that. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Explain in your translation. For example:

the new covenant that Jesus began

a new covenant through Jesus

- Translate literally and explain the meaning in a footnote. An example footnote is:

The new covenant refers to the promise that God would put his laws into people’s hearts and they would become his people (Hebrews 8:8–13). Jesus put the new covenant into effect by dying on the cross.

covenant: This word refers to an agreement or contract. God made the contract and people must accept it or reject it. Other ways to translate this word are:

promise (GW)

agreement (CEV)

3:6b–c

3:6b–c describe two differences between the first covenant and the new covenant. Some versions indicate the change in theme with a long dash at the end of 3:6a. Other versions use simple punctuation. For example:

a new covenant, ^{6b}not in a written code... (RSV)

Some other versions repeat some of 3:6a to help indicate the change in theme. For example:

a new covenant, ^{6b}a covenant which is not of written letters... (NJB)

3:6b

not of the letter but of the Spirit;

- which is not of written laws but of the Holy Spirit,
- This new covenant is based on the leading of the Holy Spirit in our^(incl) hearts and not based on external control by written laws.

not of the letter but of the Spirit: These phrases indicate that the first covenant is characterized by the written law, but the new covenant is characterized by the Holy Spirit. The written law controls outward behavior, but the Holy Spirit speaks to the inner being of a person and causes that person to follow Jesus from his heart. Other ways to translate this are:

not in a written code but in the Spirit (RSV)

not of written laws, but of the Spirit (NLT)

In some languages a literal translation would not have the correct meaning. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Explain in your translation. For example:

not like the written law of Moses, but rather based on the work of God’s Spirit

not based on external control by a written law but based on the internal prompting of the Holy Spirit

- Translate literally and explain the meaning in a footnote. An example footnote is:

The written law controls behavior, but the Holy Spirit speaks to the inner being of a person and causes that person to follow Jesus from his heart.

When Paul compared letter and Spirit, he was not saying that the written law of the first covenant was evil. Your translation should not indicate or imply that the written law was evil.

letter: Here the word letter refers to the written words and the letters with which words are spelled. It implies the law of Moses. The word letter does not refer to a letter of recommendation as in 3:1b.

the Spirit: Here this phrase refers to the Holy Spirit. In some languages a literal translation would not clearly refer to the Holy Spirit. If that is true in your language, you may want to explain in your translation. For example:

the Holy Spirit (CEV)

3:6c

for the letter kills, but the Spirit gives life.

- because the written laws called for death as punishment, but the Holy Spirit gives life.
- For the written laws of the old covenant condemn people to die, but under/by the new covenant the Holy Spirit enables people to live.

for: This conjunction introduces an explanation of 3:6b.

the letter kills: This phrase indicates that the law of Moses demands perfect obedience and that many of the punishments are death for the sinner. In some languages a literal translation would not have the correct meaning. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Explain in your translation. For example:

The written law brings death (GNT)

the law condemns people to die

- Translate literally and explain the meaning in a footnote. An example footnote is:

The law of Moses demands perfect obedience and many of the punishments are death for the sinner. The law did not help the person obey, it just caused fear of disobeying.

the Spirit gives life: This phrase indicates that the Holy Spirit provides the promise of eternal life to a new believer. The Holy Spirit also helps the believer change his heart to follow Jesus better. In some lan-

guages people will not see how the Spirit gives life. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Explain in your translation. For example:

the Spirit enables people to live

- Translate literally and explain the meaning in a footnote. An example footnote is:

The Holy Spirit provides the promise of eternal life to a new believer. The Holy Spirit also helps the believer change his heart to follow Jesus better.

2 Corinthians 3:7

Section 3:1–4:6: Confidence in the gospel of Jesus

The false teachers in Corinth were Jews (11:22). In this section, Paul wrote about some of the false teachings of these men. Since they were Jews, Paul referred to people and events in the Old Testament, such as the tablets of stone (3:3), Moses (3:7), and Moses' veil (3:13). They probably brought letters from other false teachers who said the false teachers in Corinth taught truthfully (3:1–3). The false teachers taught that believers must obey the Jewish laws. But Paul said that believers follow the new covenant with Jesus and not the old covenant with the Jews (3:14). He also spoke against their secret and shameful ways and said that they corrupted God's word (4:2). Throughout this section Paul also encouraged the believers to follow Jesus.

Other examples of headings for this section are:

The Ministry That Comes From Christ Is Greater Than Moses' Ministry (GW)

The new covenant is greater than the law of Moses

3:7a–8

Paul included a lot of information in a complicated sentence here. He asked a rhetorical question that expected a yes answer:

If the ministry of the old covenant came with glory, will not the ministry of the new covenant be even more glorious? Yes, it will be even more glorious!

3:7b and 3:7c–d are extra information about the ministry of the old covenant. The General Comment at the

end of the notes on 3:8 shows some ways to place the extra information without losing the main point.

This whole sentence is written as a question. But 3:7 is a statement of facts based on the Old Testament. Only 3:8 is the actual question. Having only one sentence causes the reader to compare the old ministry (3:7) to the new ministry (3:8). In some languages it is more natural to have two sentences here. For example:

⁷Now the ministry that brought death, which was engraved in letters on stone, came with glory, so that the Israelites could not look steadily at the face of Moses because of its glory, fading though it was. ⁸If that is true, will not the ministry of the Spirit be even more glorious?

3:7a

Now if the ministry of death,

- ¶ And the ministry of the written laws that brought death
- ¶ The old covenant caused the penalty of death. Now the work of serving that covenant,

Now: This word introduces another way in which the new covenant is different from the old covenant. It is not a time word. Other ways to translate this word are:

And

Also,

Some languages can allow the context to indicate the introduction and do not need to translate this word.

the ministry of death: This phrase refers to the ministry based on the law of Moses. The priests served God by teaching those laws to the Jewish people. Some of the punishments were death, therefore Paul said that this ministry was of death. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

the ministry of the letter, which brings death

the ministry of the old covenant led to death

the ministry of the law of Moses that brought death as punishment

ministry: This word usually refers to the work of serving, helping, or caring for others. But in this context, the word refers to the priests doing the work that the

law of Moses required. Paul used this word here to compare it later to his ministry (3:8). Other ways to translate this word are:

service

work

doing the work

This word is important in 3:7–11. Translate it in a similar way each time.

3:7b

which was engraved in letters on stone, came with such glory

- and which was carved with letters in stone, began with glory/splendor,
- started in glory/radiance. That work of serving is symbolized by the stone slabs that God wrote on.

which was engraved in letters on stone: This clause tells the reader more about “the ministry of death.” It does not imply that there are other ministries that brought death and this one was engraved in letters on stone. Some languages must translate differently to indicate the correct meaning. One way to do that is to start a new sentence here or use parentheses. For example:

^{7b}The ministry that brought death was engraved in letters on stone. ^{7a}Now if it ^{7b}came with glory,

Now if the ministry that brought death came with glory (that ministry was engraved in letters on stone),

This clause is passive. Some languages must use an active clause. For example:

which God engraved in letters on stone

engraved: This word refers to carving into the stone. God carved the Ten Commandments into the stone tablets. Other ways to translate this word are:

carved (RSV)

inscribed (GW)

in letters: This phrase refers to the letters of the alphabet. God carved letters to make words and wrote the Ten Commandments. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

with letters

in written form (REB)

on stone: God made grooves in the shapes of letters in the stone tablets. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

in stone (NLT)

on stone tablets (NET)

came with such glory: The Greek word that the BSB translates as came means “began to exist” here. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

occurred in such glory (NJB)

God’s glory appeared when it was given (GNT)

glory: The word glory refers literally to a very bright light. In this context it implies power, majesty, and greatness. When God gave the Ten Commandments to Moses on Mount Sinai, there was thunder and lightning, smoke and fire (Exodus 19:16–19). In Moses’ second visit to the mountain, the glory of God caused Moses’ face to shine (Exodus 34:29). Other ways to translate this word are:

splendor

radiance

3:7c–d

that the Israelites could not gaze at the face of Moses because of its fleeting glory: Moses talked with God and his face began to shine brightly (Exodus 34:29). When Moses left, the glory/radiance on his face began to fade. In some languages a literal translation would not make clear how Moses’ face became radiant. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Explain in your translation. For example:

Moses’ face also received some of that glory so that the Israelites could not look steadily at it because of its fleeting glory, fading as it was

- Translate literally and explain the meaning in a footnote. An example footnote is:

Moses went to God so that God could give the Ten Commandments to him. The Ten Commandments were the first part of the old covenant. During that time, God gave him other laws, and on one occasion Moses asked to see God’s glory. Upon seeing it, his face began to shine brightly. After he left, the glory/radiance on his face began to fade.

3:7c

that the Israelites could not gaze at the face of Moses

- so that the people of Israel could not stare/gaze at Moses’ face
- Moses’ face also received some of that glory and so the Israelites could only glance at it before looking away,

Israelites: The ending -ite means “a person of.” This word refers to the group of people named Israel. For example:

the people of Israel (GNT)

could not gaze: After Moses visited God on the mountain, his face shone very brightly. It shone so brightly that it hurt the eyes of those trying to look at him, so they could not gaze at him. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

could not look intently (NASB)

could not stare

could only glance

3:7d

because of its fleeting glory,

- because its glory was so bright, even though it was fading.
- because of the glory/brightness/radiance, even though that glory was dimming.

fleeting: The glory on Moses’ face gradually dimmed. The glory shone less each day. For example:

that glory later dimmed

2 Corinthians 3:8

Section 3:1–4:6: Confidence in the gospel of Jesus

The false teachers in Corinth were Jews (11:22). In this section, Paul wrote about some of the false teachings of these men. Since they were Jews, Paul referred to people and events in the Old Testament, such as the tablets of stone (3:3), Moses (3:7), and Moses' veil (3:13). They probably brought letters from other false teachers who said the false teachers in Corinth taught truthfully (3:1–3). The false teachers taught that believers must obey the Jewish laws. But Paul said that believers follow the new covenant with Jesus and not the old covenant with the Jews (3:14). He also spoke against their secret and shameful ways and said that they corrupted God's word (4:2). Throughout this section Paul also encouraged the believers to follow Jesus.

Other examples of headings for this section are:

The Ministry That Comes From Christ Is Greater Than Moses' Ministry (GW)

The new covenant is greater than the law of Moses

3:8

will not the ministry of the Spirit be even more glorious?

- If that is true, will not the ministry led by the Spirit be even more glorious/full-of-splendor?
- So surely the work of serving in/under the new covenant as the Holy Spirit guides will be even more full of glory/radiance!

will not the ministry of the Spirit be even more glorious?: This is a rhetorical question. It emphasizes the fact that the ministry of the Spirit will be even more glorious. Translate this clause with that meaning. Some ways are:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

won't the agreement the Spirit brings to us be even more wonderful? (CEV)

can we not see that the ministry of the Spirit will be even more glorious?

- As a statement. For example:

the ministry of the Spirit will certainly be even more glorious!

so surely the ministry of the Spirit will have even more glory.

the ministry of the Spirit: The word of may indicate that:

1. The Holy Spirit directs the ministry.
2. The ministry of believers is characterized by the Holy Spirit leading them to do the right thing.
3. The ministry brings the Holy Spirit.

Each interpretation is acceptable, but probably interpretation (1) is most in focus here. Thrall (p. 237) translates this text as "the agency of the Spirit." She also says that the phrase "may be shorthand for 'the agency which mediates a covenant characterized by the Spirit'" (p. 244). Translate in a way that allows one or more of the above interpretations. Many English versions use the phrase "the ministry of the Spirit," as in the BSB, which allows for all of the above interpretations. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

the activity of the Spirit (GNT)

the ministry led by the Spirit

the ministry based on the Holy Spirit

ministry: Paul compared the ministry of the old covenant (3:7a) to the ministry of the new covenant here. The word ministry is the key word here. Translate this word as you did in 3:7.

be even more glorious: The word glorious refers to the power, majesty, and splendor of God and is represented by the mighty acts of God during this time of the new covenant. Paul compared this glory to the glory of the old covenant (3:7a–b). If possible, translate this word in a similar way to "glory" in 3:7b. For example:

be even more splendor-filled

be even more full of radiance

bring even more glory to God

General Comment on 3:7a–8

3:7b,c,d are information that is extra to the main point (3:8) and the comparison (3:7a,b). In some languages it is more natural to have the extra information either before or after the main point and comparison. For example:

^{7a}Now the ministry that brought death, ^{7b}which was engraved in letters on stone, came with glory, ^{7c}so that the Israelites could not look steadily at the face of Moses ^{7d}because of its glory, fading though it was. So if it came with glory, ⁸will not the ministry of the Spirit be even more glorious?

Now ⁸will not the ministry of the Spirit be even more glorious than ^{7a}the ministry that brought death, ^{7b}which was engraved in letters on stone and came with glory, ^{7c}so that the Israelites could not look steadily at the face of Moses ^{7d}because of its glory, fading though it was?

The second example would need a combined verse reference (⁷⁻⁸) at the beginning.

2 Corinthians 3:9

Section 3:1–4:6: Confidence in the gospel of Jesus

The false teachers in Corinth were Jews (11:22). In this section, Paul wrote about some of the false teachings of these men. Since they were Jews, Paul referred to people and events in the Old Testament, such as the tablets of stone (3:3), Moses (3:7), and Moses' veil (3:13). They probably brought letters from other false teachers who said the false teachers in Corinth taught truthfully (3:1–3). The false teachers taught that believers must obey the Jewish laws. But Paul said that believers follow the new covenant with Jesus and not the old covenant with the Jews (3:14). He also spoke against their secret and shameful ways and said that they corrupted God's word (4:2). Throughout this section Paul also encouraged the believers to follow Jesus.

Other examples of headings for this section are:

The Ministry That Comes From Christ Is Greater Than Moses' Ministry (GW)

The new covenant is greater than the law of Moses

3:9a

For if the ministry of condemnation was glorious,

- And if the ministry of the written laws that condemns people had glory/splendor,
- Also, the old covenant condemned those who broke it. Yet glory/radiance accompanied the work of serving in/under it.

For: This verse begins with a Greek conjunction that is often translated as “for” or “because.” Here it indicates that 3:9 continues explaining the differences between the two ministries. Indicate that the explanation continues. For example:

Also,

the ministry of condemnation was glorious: The Greek clause is literally “glory (is) in the ministry of condemnation.” God's glory was associated with the old covenant (1 Kings 8:10–11). Other ways to translate this clause are:

there was glory in the ministry of condemnation (NRSV)

the ministry that brings punishment has glory (GW)

glory accompanied the ministry that caused God to condemn/punish people

the ministry of condemnation: This phrase refers to the ministry based on the law of Moses (as in 3:7). All people sin and break the law. Therefore God must condemn them according to the law. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

the ministry of the old covenant, which condemns people

the ministry of the old covenant that caused people to be punished

the ministry of the law of Moses that caused God to punish those who broke it

3:9b

how much more glorious is the ministry of righteousness!

- surely the new ministry that causes its people to be righteous has even more glory!
- But the ministry that produces righteousness abounds in much more glory!

how much more glorious is the ministry of righteousness: The Greek clause is literally “surely the ministry of righteousness abounds much more in glory.” The ministry of the new covenant has much more glory than the old ministry. Other ways to translate this clause are:

much more does the ministry of righteousness abound in glory (NASB)

surely the new ministry that causes its people to be righteous has even more glory

the ministry of the new covenant that causes people to become righteous is surely much more glorious

the ministry of the Spirit who makes us^(incl) righteous has much more glory

the ministry of righteousness: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates literally “the ministry of righteousness” indicates that the Holy Spirit guides the new ministry and helps believers to believe and do the right things. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

the ministry that produces righteousness (NET)

the ministry that causes its followers to become right in God’s eyes/consideration

2 Corinthians 3:10

Section 3:1–4:6: Confidence in the gospel of Jesus

The false teachers in Corinth were Jews (11:22). In this section, Paul wrote about some of the false teachings of these men. Since they were Jews, Paul referred to people and events in the Old Testament, such as the tablets of stone (3:3), Moses (3:7), and Moses’ veil (3:13). They probably brought letters from other false teachers who said the false teachers in Corinth taught truthfully (3:1–3). The false teachers taught that believers must obey the Jewish laws. But Paul said that believers follow the new covenant with Jesus and not the old covenant with the Jews (3:14). He also spoke against their secret and shameful ways and said that they corrupted God’s word (4:2). Throughout this section Paul also encouraged the believers to follow Jesus.

Other examples of headings for this section are:

The Ministry That Comes From Christ Is Greater Than Moses’ Ministry (GW)

The new covenant is greater than the law of Moses

3:10a

Indeed, what was once glorious has no glory now

- Indeed, the thing/ministry that had glory/splendor no longer has any
- Also, glory/radiance accompanied the work of serving in/under the old covenant. But that work now appears to have no glory/radiance at all

3:10b

in comparison to the glory that surpasses it.

- compared to the ministry that has surpassing glory/splendor.
- because of the much greater glory/radiance that accompanies the work of serving in/under the new covenant.

3:10a–b

Indeed: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as Indeed is literally “For indeed.” The conjunction “For” indicates that 3:10 continues explaining the differences between the two ministries (3:7–9). The word “indeed” probably indicates emphasis, because 3:10 makes a stronger contrast between the old and new ministries. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

For indeed (NASB)

Furthermore

what was once glorious: The word what refers to the ministry of the old covenant, which Paul also called the “ministry of condemnation” (3:9a). If people will not clearly understand that the word what refers to the ministry of the old covenant, you may want to explain that in your translation. Use a similar word or phrase for “ministry” as in 3:7a or 3:9a. For example:

that ministry of the law of Moses that was glorious

the work of serving the old covenant that had glory

has no glory now in comparison to the glory that surpasses it: This clause uses an opposite meaning (has no glory) to emphasize that the new ministry has

much more glory than the old ministry. It is like the moon which shines with the same brightness day and night, but is hardly noticed during the day because the sun is so much brighter. Other ways to translate this clause are:

has lost all claim to glory, by contrast with the glory which transcends it (NJB)

was not glorious at all compared with the overwhelming glory of the new way (NLT)

is as if it has no glory in comparison to the much greater glory of the new covenant

In some languages it is more natural to use opposites instead of a comparison. For example:

has lost its glory because of the greater glory (NRSV)

appears to have no glory because of the surpassing glory of the new ministry

2 Corinthians 3:11

Section 3:1–4:6: Confidence in the gospel of Jesus

The false teachers in Corinth were Jews (11:22). In this section, Paul wrote about some of the false teachings of these men. Since they were Jews, Paul referred to people and events in the Old Testament, such as the tablets of stone (3:3), Moses (3:7), and Moses' veil (3:13). They probably brought letters from other false teachers who said the false teachers in Corinth taught truthfully (3:1–3). The false teachers taught that believers must obey the Jewish laws. But Paul said that believers follow the new covenant with Jesus and not the old covenant with the Jews (3:14). He also spoke against their secret and shameful ways and said that they corrupted God's word (4:2). Throughout this section Paul also encouraged the believers to follow Jesus.

Other examples of headings for this section are:

The Ministry That Comes From Christ Is Greater Than Moses' Ministry (GW)

The new covenant is greater than the law of Moses

3:11a

For if what was fading away came with glory,

- For/And if the thing/ministry that is/was fading began with glory/splendor,
- Also, the work of serving in/under the old covenant was temporary like the glory on Moses' face fading even though glory/radiance accompanied it.

For: The Greek word that the BSB translates literally as For indicates that 3:11 continues explaining the differences between the two ministries (3:7–10). Indicate in your translation that the explanation continues. For example:

Also,

what was fading away: These words are a metaphor. Like the glory that faded from Moses' face, the old ministry is temporary. God wants to relate to people through the new covenant these days, not through the old covenant. In some languages the metaphor would not have the correct meaning. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Change it to a simile. For example:

what was like something fading away

what was like the fading of the glory on Moses' face

- Explain the meaning in your translation. For example:

what was temporary, like something fading away

what was not permanent, like the fading of the glory on Moses' face

- Translate literally and explain the meaning in a footnote. An example footnote is:

Just as the temporary glory faded from Moses' face, the old ministry was temporary. God wants to relate to people through the new covenant these days, not through the old covenant.

The word what refers to the ministry of the old covenant. Paul implies that the old covenant is like Moses' face when the glory faded from it (3:7). If people will not clearly understand that the word what refers to the ministry of the old covenant, you may

want to explain in your translation. Use a similar word or phrase for “ministry” as in 3:7 or 3:10. For example:

that ministry of the law of Moses that was fading away

the work of serving the old covenant that was fading away

fading away: The Greek is literally “the fading-away.” The tense of this verb can be represented in various ways:

what is fading away

what was fading away (BSB)

that which fades away (NASB)

what was going to fade

came with glory: The Greek phrase does not have a verb, but probably came, “be,” or “began” (3:7b) is implied. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

was with glory (NASB)

had its glory (REB)

began with glory

3:11b

how much greater is the glory of that which endures!

- in comparison, the ministry that will remain/last has much greater glory/splendor.
- But, the work of serving in/under the new covenant will continue and has the greatest glory/radiance by far.

how much greater is the glory of that which endures: This clause compares the new ministry to the old ministry and emphasizes that the new ministry has much more glory. For example:

what is permanent must have much more splendor (RSV)

In some languages it is more natural to use a superlative instead of a comparative. For example:

but the glory of the ministry that lasts is greatest by far

that which endures: This phrase indicates that the new ministry is permanent. No other ministry will replace it. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

that ministry which remains (GW)

this new way which continues forever (NCV)

2 Corinthians 3:12

Section 3:1–4:6: Confidence in the gospel of Jesus

The false teachers in Corinth were Jews (11:22). In this section, Paul wrote about some of the false teachings of these men. Since they were Jews, Paul referred to people and events in the Old Testament, such as the tablets of stone (3:3), Moses (3:7), and Moses’ veil (3:13). They probably brought letters from other false teachers who said the false teachers in Corinth taught truthfully (3:1–3). The false teachers taught that believers must obey the Jewish laws. But Paul said that believers follow the new covenant with Jesus and not the old covenant with the Jews (3:14). He also spoke against their secret and shameful ways and said that they corrupted God’s word (4:2). Throughout this section Paul also encouraged the believers to follow Jesus.

Other examples of headings for this section are:

The Ministry That Comes From Christ Is Greater Than Moses’ Ministry (GW)

The new covenant is greater than the law of Moses

3:12

Therefore, since we have such a hope, we are very bold.

- ¶ Therefore, we^(excl) are very bold/brave because we have hope in that fact.
- ¶ We have confidence in the new covenant, therefore we do the work of serving in/under the new covenant very boldly.

since we have such a hope, we are very bold: The reason is before the result in this clause. Many English versions translate it that way. For example:

We have this hope, so we are very bold (NCV)

In some languages it is more natural to have the result first. For example:

we are very bold because we have such a hope

we have such a hope: The Greek word that the BSB translates as hope means “confidence about a particular thing.” Paul was confident that the new covenant was permanent and the new ministry was greater than the old ministry. For example:

we have confidence [in the new promise] (GW)

we are very bold: The Greek clause can be translated literally as “we use boldness” or “we do things boldly.” Other ways to translate this clause are:

we behave with great boldness (NET)

we have no fear

Paul did not say what he and the others did boldly. But he implied that they did the new ministry boldly. Some languages must say what they did boldly. If that is true in your language, refer to the ministry. For example:

we serve God very boldly

we do the work of serving the new covenant very boldly

bold: This word refers to being brave. A bold person is not afraid to do something that might be dangerous. Paul and the other evangelists preached boldly, even though other people might persecute them. Other ways to translate this word are:

fearlessness (NJB)

brave

2 Corinthians 3:13

Section 3:1–4:6: Confidence in the gospel of Jesus

The false teachers in Corinth were Jews (11:22). In this section, Paul wrote about some of the false teachings of these men. Since they were Jews, Paul referred to people and events in the Old Testament, such as the tablets of stone (3:3), Moses (3:7), and Moses’ veil (3:13). They probably brought letters from other false teachers who said the false teachers in Corinth

taught truthfully (3:1–3). The false teachers taught that believers must obey the Jewish laws. But Paul said that believers follow the new covenant with Jesus and not the old covenant with the Jews (3:14). He also spoke against their secret and shameful ways and said that they corrupted God’s word (4:2). Throughout this section Paul also encouraged the believers to follow Jesus.

Other examples of headings for this section are:

The Ministry That Comes From Christ Is Greater Than Moses’ Ministry (GW)

The new covenant is greater than the law of Moses

3:13a–b

We are not like Moses, who would put a veil over his face to keep the Israelites from gazing at the end of what was fading away: The who-clause tells the reader more about Moses. It does not imply that there were other people named Moses and this was the only one with a veil over his face. Some languages must translate differently to indicate the correct meaning. One way to do that is to start a new sentence here. For example:

^{13a}We are not like Moses. He would put a veil over his face ^{13b}to keep the Israelites from gazing at it while the radiance was fading away.

3:13a

We are not like Moses, who would put a veil over his face

- We^(excl) are not like Moses, who used to put a veil/covering over his face
- We do not do as Moses did when he would put a veil/cloth over his face

We are not like Moses: Moses hid the fading glory, but Paul and the other evangelists were bold. Moses hid the glory, but this does not imply that he was dishonest or timid. The comparison is explained in the rest of 3:13. Your translation should clearly compare Paul and the others to this part of Moses’ life. For example:

^{13a}Moses would put a veil over his face ^{13b}to keep the Israelites from gazing at it while the radiance was fading away. ^{13a}But we do not do as he did.

who would put a veil over his face: Moses would go into the tent of meeting to talk directly with God, and Moses' face received some of God's glory. He did not wear the veil when he was with God. When he went and spoke to the people, his face shone with that glory. After he finished speaking to them, he would put a veil over his face (Exodus 34:33-35). Other ways to translate this clause are:

who put a covering over his face (NCV)

His face was shining, but he covered it (CEV)

veil: This word refers to a piece of cloth that covers a person's face. Some veils are thin and cover the whole face, but the person can still see through the cloth. Other veils only cover the face below the eyes.

3:13b

to keep the Israelites from gazing at the end of what was fading away.

- to prevent the people of Israel from watching the end of it as it faded.
- so that the people of Israel would not see the thing/glory fade to nothing.

to keep the Israelites from gazing at: Here the words keep...from mean "prevent." For example:

so that the people of Israel would not see (GNT)

the end of what was fading away: The Greek phrase is literally "the end of the thing fading away." It refers to the glory that faded after Moses left God's presence. But Paul used the general word "thing" to imply that the old ministry was also fading away or temporary. For example:

the end of what was transitory (NJB)

2 Corinthians 3:14

Section 3:1-4:6: Confidence in the gospel of Jesus

The false teachers in Corinth were Jews (11:22). In this section, Paul wrote about some of the false teachings of these men. Since they were Jews, Paul referred to people and events in the Old Testament, such as the tablets of stone (3:3), Moses (3:7), and Moses' veil (3:13). They probably brought letters from other false teachers who said the false teachers in Corinth taught truthfully (3:1-3). The false teachers taught that believers must obey the Jewish laws. But Paul said that believers follow the new covenant with Jesus and

not the old covenant with the Jews (3:14). He also spoke against their secret and shameful ways and said that they corrupted God's word (4:2). Throughout this section Paul also encouraged the believers to follow Jesus.

Other examples of headings for this section are:

The Ministry That Comes From Christ Is Greater Than Moses' Ministry (GW)

The new covenant is greater than the law of Moses

3:14a

But their minds were closed.

- But their thinking was made dull/clouded,
- But they became insensitive to what God wanted them to know,

their minds were closed: This clause is passive. Some languages must use a clause that is not passive. If that is true in your language, use an intransitive clause.

Some scholars think that Satan makes their minds dull (4:3-4). Other scholars think that God makes their minds dull (Romans 9:13-14). And other scholars think that the people themselves cause their own minds to become dull because of their disobedience. If possible, do not say who made their minds dull. For example:

their minds became closed (GW)

their thinking became clouded

their ways of thinking were blocked

their minds/heads became hard/dense

were closed: Here the Greek word that the BSB translates as were closed refers to causing something to not respond. Many Jews did not respond to the truth in the Old Testament about the Christ. See the examples above.

3:14b

For to this day the same veil remains at the reading of the old covenant.

- for to this day the same veil continues to dull their thinking when the old covenant/promise/agreement is read.

- because from then until now the same dullness remains like a veil whenever someone reads the old covenant.

For: This conjunction introduces an explanation of their minds being dull.

to this day: This phrase refers to the time Paul wrote this letter. For example:

until this very day (NJB)

the same veil remains: The phrase the same veil refers figuratively to their minds being dull (3:14a). In some languages a literal translation would wrongly refer only to an actual veil. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Explain in your translation. For example:

the same veil of dullness remains

the same dullness that is like a veil remains

- Translate literally and explain the meaning in a footnote. An example footnote is:

The phrase “the same veil” refers figuratively to their minds being dull regarding the truth about the Christ in the Old Testament.

at the reading of the old covenant: The BSB translates the Greek phrase here literally. Some English versions use a passive clause here, but other English versions use an active clause. For example:

when the old covenant is read (NIV)

when they read the old covenant (RSV)

the old covenant: This refers to the agreement or contract that God made with the Israelites in the Old Testament (Exodus 19:3–8). An important part of that agreement/contract is the Ten Commandments (Exodus 20:1–17). In some languages people will not know what this phrase refers to. If so, you may want to include a footnote to explain. An example footnote is:

This refers to the agreement that God made with the Jews in the Old Testament (Exodus 19:3–8). Part of that agreement is the Ten Commandments (Exodus 20:1–17).

covenant: This word refers to an agreement or contract. God made the contract and people must accept it or reject it. See how you translated this word in 3:6.

3:14c–d

It has not been lifted, because only in Christ can it be removed: The reason comes after the result. In some languages it is more natural to have the reason first. For example:

^{14d}Only in Christ is the veil taken away, so ^{14c}it has not been removed for those who continue to follow the old covenant

3:14c

It has not been lifted,

- That veil has not been removed,
- God has not removed it,

It has not been lifted: As 3:14d explains, God only lifts the closed veil when an Israelite believes in Jesus. Then he can understand the truth about the Christ in the Old Testament. For those who still follow the old covenant, the veil remains. For example:

that same veil remains unlifted (RSV)

This clause is passive. God removes the veil when an Israelite believes. Some languages must use an active clause. For example:

God has not removed it

3:14d

because only in Christ can it be removed.

- because only through Christ is it removed.
- because God only removes the dullness when they believe in Christ.

only in Christ can it be removed: This clause indicates that when an Israelite believes in Jesus, only then God removes the veil of dullness. Other ways to translate this clause are:

only through Christ is it taken away (RSV)

the veil is only removed when they believe in Christ

This clause is passive. God removes the veil. Some languages must use an active clause. For example:

God only removes the veil when they believe in Christ

2 Corinthians 3:15

Section 3:1–4:6: Confidence in the gospel of Jesus

The false teachers in Corinth were Jews (11:22). In this section, Paul wrote about some of the false teachings of these men. Since they were Jews, Paul referred to people and events in the Old Testament, such as the tablets of stone (3:3), Moses (3:7), and Moses' veil (3:13). They probably brought letters from other false teachers who said the false teachers in Corinth taught truthfully (3:1–3). The false teachers taught that believers must obey the Jewish laws. But Paul said that believers follow the new covenant with Jesus and not the old covenant with the Jews (3:14). He also spoke against their secret and shameful ways and said that they corrupted God's word (4:2). Throughout this section Paul also encouraged the believers to follow Jesus.

Other examples of headings for this section are:

The Ministry That Comes From Christ Is Greater Than Moses' Ministry (GW)

The new covenant is greater than the law of Moses

3:15

And even to this day when Moses is read, a veil covers their hearts.

- But/Even to this day a veil of dullness covers their hearts whenever the books of Moses are read.
- From then until now, when they read the books of Moses, that dullness prevents them from truly understanding.

And even to this day: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as And even is literally “but.” There is contrast between the veil being removed when an Israelite believes (3:14d) and the veil remaining for those who follow the old covenant, so many English versions translate this conjunction as “but.” For example:

But until this very day (NET)

However, other English versions do not translate the conjunction as “But,” since 3:15 agrees with the veil not being removed, which is the main idea in 3:14c–d. For example:

Yes, to this day (ESV)

when Moses is read: The name Moses refers figuratively to the books that Moses wrote. Moses wrote the first five books of the Old Testament, but probably the rest of the Old Testament is implied here. If people will not understand what the name Moses refers to here, you may want to explain in your translation. For example:

when the books of Moses are read

This clause is passive. The clause probably refers generally to Israelites/Jews reading the books. Some languages must use an active clause. For example:

when the Israelites/Jews read the books of Moses

whenever they read the Law of Moses (GNT)

a veil covers their hearts: This clause continues the figurative use of the word veil from 3:14a–b. You may want to:

- Translate literally if the metaphor has the correct meaning of veil from 3:14a–b.
- Explain the meaning again in your translation. For example:

a veil of dullness covers their hearts

dullness like a veil prevents understanding in their hearts

hearts: This word refers figuratively to the part of people where true understanding occurs. In your language, refer to this part of people. This may be another organ such as the liver, or it may be a general term such as “insides.” For example:

minds (RSV)

livers/insides

Your language may not use a part of the body for a figurative meaning of true understanding. In that case, translate the meaning without the figure of speech. For example:

true understanding

2 Corinthians 3:16

Section 3:1–4:6: Confidence in the gospel of Jesus

The false teachers in Corinth were Jews (11:22). In this section, Paul wrote about some of the false teachings of these men. Since they were Jews, Paul referred to people and events in the Old Testament, such as the tablets of stone (3:3), Moses (3:7), and Moses' veil (3:13). They probably brought letters from other false teachers who said the false teachers in Corinth taught truthfully (3:1–3). The false teachers taught that believers must obey the Jewish laws. But Paul said that believers follow the new covenant with Jesus and not the old covenant with the Jews (3:14). He also spoke against their secret and shameful ways and said that they corrupted God's word (4:2). Throughout this section Paul also encouraged the believers to follow Jesus.

Other examples of headings for this section are:

The Ministry That Comes From Christ Is Greater Than Moses' Ministry (GW)

The new covenant is greater than the law of Moses

3:16

But whenever anyone turns to the Lord, the veil is taken away.

- But whenever someone turns to the Lord to follow him, the veil of dullness is removed.
- But, when anyone believes in the Lord God, he/God removes that dullness from his mind.

turns to the Lord: The word turns is used in a figurative way. The phrase means “begins to believe in God,” since the word Lord refers to God in 3:17. But Paul implied believing in Jesus as the Christ and the new covenant that he began (3:6–15). In some languages a literal translation would not indicate the correct meaning. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Explain in your translation. For example:

turns to the Lord to follow him

- Translate the meaning without the figure of speech. For example:

begins to follow the Lord

the Lord: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Lord means “the one in authority over (something)” or “master.” It refers to someone greater in status or power. Here, because of the connections to the Old Testament, the Lord probably refers to God. If the word in your language for Lord is too general, you may want to include “God” in the phrase. For example:

the Lord God

the veil is taken away: This clause is passive. Some languages must use an active clause. For example:

he removes the veil

the veil: 3:16 continues with the figurative meaning for the word veil as the dullness of thinking. When the veil is removed a new believer can clearly understand who Christ is. You may want to:

- Translate literally. People in your area may understand the figurative meaning of veil from 3:14a–15.
- Explain again in your translation. For example:

the veil of dullness

- Translate the meaning without the figure of speech. For example:

dullness like a veil

2 Corinthians 3:17

Section 3:1–4:6: Confidence in the gospel of Jesus

The false teachers in Corinth were Jews (11:22). In this section, Paul wrote about some of the false teachings of these men. Since they were Jews, Paul referred to people and events in the Old Testament, such as the tablets of stone (3:3), Moses (3:7), and Moses' veil (3:13). They probably brought letters from other false teachers who said the false teachers in Corinth taught truthfully (3:1–3). The false teachers taught that believers must obey the Jewish laws. But Paul said that believers follow the new covenant with Jesus and not the old covenant with the Jews (3:14). He also spoke against their secret and shameful ways and said that they corrupted God's word (4:2). Throughout this section Paul also encouraged the believers to follow Jesus.

Other examples of headings for this section are:

The Ministry That Comes From Christ Is Greater Than Moses' Ministry (GW)

The new covenant is greater than the law of Moses

3:17a

Now the Lord is the Spirit,

- Now the Lord is experienced by us^(incl) as the Holy Spirit,
- Now the meaning of "Lord" here is the Holy Spirit.

the Lord is the Spirit: The word Lord probably refers to the same person as in 3:16, namely God. God manifests himself through the Holy Spirit and the new ministry (3:3, 6, 8). So this clause probably indicates that believers experience God through the work of the Holy Spirit. Other ways to translate this clause are:

"the Lord" in this passage is the Spirit (GNT)

the Lord of whom this passage speaks is the Spirit

The meaning of "Lord" here is the Holy Spirit

The Lord God is experienced as the Holy Spirit

3:17b

and where the Spirit of the Lord is, there is freedom.

- and where the Spirit of the Lord is present, freedom exists for his people.
- And wherever the Spirit of the Lord God lives, the people there live in freedom.

where the Spirit of the Lord is, there is freedom:

These words indicate that freedom is a result of the presence of the Spirit of the Lord. The Holy Spirit is present with every believer. Other ways to translate this are:

where the Spirit of the Lord is present, there is freedom (GNT)

whoever is in the presence of the Spirit of the Lord has freedom

wherever the Spirit of the Lord is present, the people there live in freedom

the Spirit of the Lord: The word Lord again refers to God here, and this phrase refers to the Holy Spirit. The Holy Spirit is from the Lord and belongs to the Lord.

freedom: This word refers to being allowed to do things. It also refers to not being controlled or dominated by something that is harmful. A believer is allowed to do anything that follows the teachings of the new covenant. He is not governed by the old covenant with its many laws.

2 Corinthians 3:18

Section 3:1–4:6: Confidence in the gospel of Jesus

The false teachers in Corinth were Jews (11:22). In this section, Paul wrote about some of the false teachings of these men. Since they were Jews, Paul referred to people and events in the Old Testament, such as the tablets of stone (3:3), Moses (3:7), and Moses' veil (3:13). They probably brought letters from other false teachers who said the false teachers in Corinth taught truthfully (3:1–3). The false teachers taught that believers must obey the Jewish laws. But Paul said that believers follow the new covenant with Jesus and not the old covenant with the Jews (3:14). He also spoke against their secret and shameful ways and said that they corrupted God's word (4:2). Throughout this section Paul also encouraged the believers to follow Jesus.

Other examples of headings for this section are:

The Ministry That Comes From Christ Is Greater Than Moses' Ministry (GW)

The new covenant is greater than the law of Moses

3:18a

And we, who with unveiled faces all reflect the glory of the Lord,

- Now we^(incl), whose unveiled/uncovered faces all reflect the Lord's glory/splendor,
- All of us reflect like a mirror the Lord God's glory/radiance with faces that do not have the veil that causes dullness.

And we, who with unveiled faces all reflect the glory of the Lord:

The who clause tells the reader more about believers. It does not imply that there are other believers and only these believers have unveiled faces. Some languages must translate this clause differently to indicate the correct meaning. One way to do that is to have the who-clause as a separate sentence. For example:

We all reflect the Lord's glory with unveiled faces.
And we...

we: This pronoun refers to all people who follow Jesus.

who with unveiled faces all reflect the glory of the Lord: There are several ways to interpret the Greek verb that the BSB translates as reflect:

1. The word means reflect as in a mirror or as in still water. For example:

like mirrors reflecting (NJB) (BSB, NIV, GNT, NJB, GW, CEV, NET, NCV)

1. The word means see (something) as reflected in a mirror or as reflected in still water. For example:

see as in a mirror (REB) (NRSV, NASB, REB, KJV)

1. The word just means see (something). For example:

beholding (RSV) (RSV, NABRE, ESV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Keener (on TW) says "the basis of his image is simply how Moses reflected God's glory....like Moses, they are transformed to reflect God's glory by the Spirit." Louw defines the Greek word as "to reflect light or visual patterns coming from some source." You should not follow interpretation (3), because that would be an unusual meaning of the Greek word.

unveiled faces: This phrase indicates that the faces of believers are not covered. The phrase refers figuratively to clearly seeing who God is, unlike those in 3:15. For example:

uncovered faces (GNT)

3:18b

are being transformed into His image with intensifying glory,

- are being changed to become more like him in ever greater glory/splendor,
- It is us whom God is making to be more and more like him in ever-increasing glory.
- God is changing us to be more like him in our hearts/character in brighter and brighter glory.

are being transformed into His image: This clause is passive. God transforms believers. Some languages must use an active clause. For example:

are those whom God transforms into his likeness

God transforms us into his likeness

transformed: This word refers to changing in an essential way. God changes the believer's way of thinking so he thinks and acts more like God (such as caring for others and being faithful). Other ways to translate this word are:

changed (RSV)

makes us more and more like him (NLT)

into His image: Here this phrase refers to thinking and acting like God. It does not refer to becoming physically like him. For example:

makes us more and more like our glorious Lord (CEV)

to be like him (NCV)

becoming like him in our hearts/character

with intensifying glory: The Greek phrase is literally "from glory to glory." The Greek phrase refers to increasing amounts of glory. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

in brighter and brighter glory (NJB)

in an ever greater degree of glory (GNT)

brings ever greater glory (NCV)

intensifying glory: The word glory refers literally to a very bright light. The word usually implies power, majesty, and greatness. In God's eyes, believers gain power, majesty, and greatness as they learn to live like Christ. But while on earth, people do not see this glory as God does.

In some languages a literal translation would wrongly refer to believers shining more and more brightly. If that is true in your language, you may want to explain in a footnote. For example:

While on earth, the glory of a believer would be to live like Christ, showing God's ways in how he lived.

3:18c

which comes from the Lord, who is the Spirit.

- and this is the work of the Lord, who is experienced as the Holy Spirit.
- The Lord God does this. He is described/identified as the Holy Spirit here.

which comes from the Lord: This phrase indicates that God gives the glory. It implies that God causes believers to transform/change. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

this is the working of the Lord (NJB)

through the power of the Lord (REB)

This clause tells the reader more about the ever-increasing glory. Some languages must translate differently to indicate the correct meaning. One way to do that is to start a new sentence here. For example:

It comes from the Lord.

who is the Spirit: This phrase probably has the same meaning as in 3:17a. Translate this phrase in a similar way to 3:17a. For example:

which in this passage is spoken of as the Spirit

who here is the Holy Spirit

who is experienced as the Holy Spirit

This clause tells the reader more about the Lord. Some languages must translate differently to indicate the correct meaning. One way to do that is to start a new sentence here. For example:

He is the Spirit.

2 Corinthians 4:1

Section 3:1–4:6: Confidence in the gospel of Jesus

The false teachers in Corinth were Jews (11:22). In this section, Paul wrote about some of the false teachings of these men. Since they were Jews, Paul referred to people and events in the Old Testament, such as

the tablets of stone (3:3), Moses (3:7), and Moses' veil (3:13). They probably brought letters from other false teachers who said the false teachers in Corinth taught truthfully (3:1–3). The false teachers taught that believers must obey the Jewish laws. But Paul said that believers follow the new covenant with Jesus and not the old covenant with the Jews (3:14). He also spoke against their secret and shameful ways and said that they corrupted God's word (4:2). Throughout this section Paul also encouraged the believers to follow Jesus.

Other examples of headings for this section are:

The Ministry That Comes From Christ Is Greater Than Moses' Ministry (GW)

The new covenant is greater than the law of Moses

4:1

Therefore, since God in His mercy has given us this ministry, we do not lose heart.

- ¶ Therefore, we^(excl) do not become dejected, because we have this ministry by the mercy of God.
- ¶ So we do not despair, because God had compassion on us and gave to us this work of serving in/under the new covenant.

Therefore: This conjunction connects the main idea ("we do not lose heart") to the things Paul said about the new ministry in 3:6–18.

since God in His mercy has given us this ministry, we do not lose heart: The Greek words are literally "having (received) this ministry in the same way that we received mercy, we do not lose heart." God showed mercy to Paul and the others. In the same way, God gave this ministry to them. These facts helped Paul and the others not to lose heart. Other ways to translate this clause are:

since we have this ministry, just as God has shown us mercy, we do not become discouraged (NET)

we do not lose heart, because God gave this ministry to us in the same way that he gave/showed us mercy

God in His mercy: This phrase indicates that Paul was unworthy to have this ministry, but God showed mercy to him, and so Paul was able to do this ministry. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

by the mercy of God (RSV)

through God's mercy (NIV)

mercy: Here the word mercy means: "compassion toward an offender or toward a person in one's power." Paul knew he had sinned greatly against God before he believed in Jesus, but God was merciful to him and did not punish him. Some examples for translating mercy are:

compassion

pity

this ministry: This phrase refers to the new ministry of the Spirit (3:6–18). Other ways to translate this phrase are:

that ministry

that work for God

ministry: This word refers to the work of serving, helping, or caring for others. Here the word refers to helping others believe in Jesus and teaching them about God and Jesus. Other ways to translate this word are:

service

serving

doing the work of Jesus

we do not lose heart: Here the Greek verb that the BSB translates as lose heart means "despair." For example:

we do not become discouraged (GNT)

2 Corinthians 4:2

Section 3:1–4:6: Confidence in the gospel of Jesus

The false teachers in Corinth were Jews (11:22). In this section, Paul wrote about some of the false teachings of these men. Since they were Jews, Paul referred to people and events in the Old Testament, such as the tablets of stone (3:3), Moses (3:7), and Moses' veil (3:13). They probably brought letters from other

false teachers who said the false teachers in Corinth taught truthfully (3:1–3). The false teachers taught that believers must obey the Jewish laws. But Paul said that believers follow the new covenant with Jesus and not the old covenant with the Jews (3:14). He also spoke against their secret and shameful ways and said that they corrupted God's word (4:2). Throughout this section Paul also encouraged the believers to follow Jesus.

Other examples of headings for this section are:

The Ministry That Comes From Christ Is Greater Than Moses' Ministry (GW)

The new covenant is greater than the law of Moses

4:2a

Instead, we have renounced secret and shameful ways.

- Instead of becoming dejected, we^(excl) have refused all secret deeds of shame,
- Rather than despair, we have refused to have anything to do with secret and shameful deeds.

Instead: This conjunction indicates that rather than becoming discouraged, Paul and the others renounced secret and shameful ways.

renounced: This word refers to completely rejecting something. Paul and the others refuse to do anything that was secret and shameful. Here the word does not imply that Paul and the others had done secret and shameful things in the past but had stopped by the time that he wrote this. Other ways to translate this word are:

refused to have anything to do with

reject all (NLT)

turned our backs on all

secret and shameful ways: The Greek phrase is literally "secret things/deeds of shame." Here the word secret implies that these deeds were wrong and that was why people did them secretly. These deeds were also shameful. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

secret and shameful deeds (GNT)

the deeds that people hide for very shame (REB)

shameful: This word indicates that the people doing these deeds would have been ashamed if someone had discovered that they were doing them. It does not mean that they were too ashamed to do them or that they are ashamed while doing them.

4:2b–e

The Greek uses participles to indicate that 4:2b–e explains “we have renounced secret and shameful ways.” Some English versions also use participles. For example:

^{2b}not walking in craftiness ^{2c}or adulterating the word of God, ^{2d}but by the manifestation of truth ^{2e}commending ourselves to every man’s conscience in the sight of God (NASB)

In your translation, indicate that 4:2b–e explains 4:2a. Several English versions indicate the connection by using a semi-colon (;) at the end of 4:2a. Another way to do so is with a conjunction. For example:

Namely, ^{2b}we do not use deception, ^{2c}nor do we distort the word of God, ^{2d}but on the contrary, by setting forth the truth plainly ^{2e}we commend ourselves to every man’s conscience in the sight of God.

for ^{2b}we do not use deception, ^{2c}nor do we distort the word of God, ^{2d}but on the contrary, by setting forth the truth plainly ^{2e}we commend ourselves to every man’s conscience in the sight of God

4:2b

We do not practice deceit,

- for we do not act with cunning/deceit,
- That is, we never try to cleverly deceive,

We do not practice deceit: The Greek word that the BSB translates as deceit means “cunning” or “trickery.” Other ways to translate this clause are:

we do not act with deceit (GNT)

we do not cunningly/slyly deceive

4:2c

nor do we distort the word of God.

- nor do we give wrong/false meaning to God’s word,

- and we never change God’s message to deceive people.

nor do we: The word nor means “and not.” Another way to translate this phrase is:

and we do not

distort the word of God: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as distort refers to changing something so it is no longer pure. Here the verb refers to not telling the true meaning of the word of God. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

tamper with God’s word (RSV)

falsify the word of God (NJB)

give wrong meaning to the word of God

change the teaching of God (NCV)

the word of God: This phrase refers to the Old Testament. Here are some other ways to translate it:

God’s words

God’s message (CEV)

4:2d

On the contrary, by open proclamation of the truth,

- but we proclaim the truth plainly,
- Instead, we announce the true teachings about Christ clearly,

On the contrary: 4:2a–c refers to things that Paul did not do. 4:2d–e refers to things that Paul did. For example:

but (RSV)

by open proclamation of the truth: This phrase indicates the way in which Paul and the others commended themselves (4:2e). Other ways to translate this phrase are:

by showing the truth openly (NJB)

we proclaim the truth plainly and so

open proclamation: The Greek word that the BSB translates as open proclamation refers to announcing or proclaiming something. For example:

clearly reveal (GW)

the truth: Here the word truth refers to teachings that are not false/lies. Other ways to translate this word are:

what we teach truthfully

true teachings

4:2e

we commend ourselves to every man's conscience in the sight of God.

- and so we support/approve ourselves before God to every person's conscience.
- and in that way we show to ourselves that we have done well to every person's inner being, as God knows.

we commend ourselves: Here the word commend refers to saying they are good people. The way Paul and the others taught indicated that they were good people, because they always spoke the truth. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

we recommend ourselves (REB)

we show that we are good people

Translate the word commend as you did in 3:1.

every man's: The word man's is general and refers to both men and women here. For example:

everyone's (GNT)

conscience: The Greek word that the BSB translates as conscience refers to the memories of past deeds. Other ways to translate this word are:

inner being

convictions of the mind

See how you translated this word in 1:12.

in the sight of God: The Greek phrase is literally "before God" (as in the NET). The phrase indicates that

God approved of Paul and the others. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

As God watches (GW)

God is our witness (CEV)

This phrase describes the phrase "we commend ourselves." It does not describe the phrase "every man's conscience."

2 Corinthians 4:3

Section 3:1–4:6: Confidence in the gospel of Jesus

The false teachers in Corinth were Jews (11:22). In this section, Paul wrote about some of the false teachings of these men. Since they were Jews, Paul referred to people and events in the Old Testament, such as the tablets of stone (3:3), Moses (3:7), and Moses' veil (3:13). They probably brought letters from other false teachers who said the false teachers in Corinth taught truthfully (3:1–3). The false teachers taught that believers must obey the Jewish laws. But Paul said that believers follow the new covenant with Jesus and not the old covenant with the Jews (3:14). He also spoke against their secret and shameful ways and said that they corrupted God's word (4:2). Throughout this section Paul also encouraged the believers to follow Jesus.

Other examples of headings for this section are:

The Ministry That Comes From Christ Is Greater Than Moses' Ministry (GW)

The new covenant is greater than the law of Moses

4:3a

And even if our gospel is veiled,

- But even if our^(excl) gospel seems to be veiled/unclear,
- But if the meaning of the good news about Jesus that we preach is indeed not clearly understood,

And: The Greek conjunction here is often translated as "but." There is some contrast between Paul preaching plainly (4:2d) and people not understanding his message here. For example:

But (NET)

even if our gospel is veiled: This clause uses the same metaphor of a veil as in 3:15. Here Paul explained that some people do not clearly understand the gospel of Jesus. He explained who those people are in 4:3b. For example:

If our gospel seems to be veiled at all (NJB)

If you translated the figurative meaning of “veil” in 3:15, you may want to do so here. For example:

if the meaning of our gospel is hidden

even: Here the word even emphasizes the words that follow. Another way to translate this word is:

if our gospel is indeed veiled

our gospel: The pronoun our indicates here that Paul and the other evangelists preach this gospel. The pronoun does not indicate that the gospel is about them. For example:

the gospel that we preach

gospel: The Greek word that the BSB translates here as gospel is sometimes translated as “good news.” In the New Testament the Greek word refers to the good news that Jesus is the Christ. See how you translated this word in 2:12.

is veiled: The word veiled describes the gospel. This clause refers to the gospel already being veiled rather than the act of veiling. For example:

is covered with a veil (GW)

veiled: This word is a metaphor. It refers to the gospel being unclear to people who do not believe in Jesus (4:3b). In some languages a literal translation would not have the correct meaning. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Keep the metaphor and explain the meaning in a footnote. An example footnote is:

The word “veiled” indicates that the meaning of the gospel is unclear, just as a veil makes it hard to see the face behind it. See 3:14–16.

- Translate the meaning of the metaphor in your translation. For example:

unclear

uncertain You may then want to indicate the literal word in a footnote. An example footnote is:

Literally “veiled.” Paul used the word in a similar way to 3:14–16.

4:3b it is veiled to those who are perishing.

- it is that way for those who are headed for death/destruction.
- then it is the people on the way to death and destruction who do not clearly understand it.

it is veiled to those who are perishing: Again, the Greek verb that the BSB translates as is veiled is passive, so again this clause refers to the gospel as already being hidden rather than referring to the act of veiling/hiding. If possible, describe the gospel as already being hidden. Other ways to translate this clause are:

it is so to those who are on the way to destruction (NJB)

the gospel is hidden regarding those who are perishing

those who are perishing: This phrase refers to those people who do not follow Jesus. The verb perishing refers to dying, but it also implies destruction or ruin. The present tense may indicate that these people are on the path that leads to death and destruction. For example:

those who are on the way to destruction (NJB)

2 Corinthians 4:4

Section 3:1–4:6: Confidence in the gospel of Jesus

The false teachers in Corinth were Jews (11:22). In this section, Paul wrote about some of the false teachings of these men. Since they were Jews, Paul referred to people and events in the Old Testament, such as the tablets of stone (3:3), Moses (3:7), and Moses’ veil (3:13). They probably brought letters from other false teachers who said the false teachers in Corinth taught truthfully (3:1–3). The false teachers taught that believers must obey the Jewish laws. But Paul said that believers follow the new covenant with Jesus and not the old covenant with the Jews (3:14). He also

spoke against their secret and shameful ways and said that they corrupted God's word (4:2). Throughout this section Paul also encouraged the believers to follow Jesus.

Other examples of headings for this section are:

The Ministry That Comes From Christ Is Greater Than Moses' Ministry (GW)

The new covenant is greater than the law of Moses

4:4a

The god of this age has blinded the minds of unbelievers

- The god of this time/world has caused the minds of unbelievers to be like the eyes of blind people,
- The god of this age, Satan, has made the minds of those who do not follow Jesus unable to understand/see,

The god of this age: This phrase refers to Satan. Paul calls him the god of this age because Satan has power over the people who do not follow God. The phrase this age refers to the current way of living on earth. In some languages a literal translation would not have the correct meaning. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Explain in your translation. For example:

The god of this age, Satan,

- Translate literally and explain the meaning in a footnote. An example footnote is:

This phrase refers to Satan. Paul calls him the "god of this age" because Satan has power over the people who do not follow God. The phrase "this age" refers to the current human existence on earth.

- Use Satan's name instead of the word god. For example:

Satan, who rules this age, You may then want to explain the literal phrase in a footnote. An example footnote is:

Literally "The god of this age." This phrase refers to Satan. Paul calls him the "god of this age"

because Satan has power over the people who do not follow God. The phrase "this age" refers to the current human existence on earth.

has blinded the minds of unbelievers: These words are a metaphor. Just as a blind person cannot see, Satan keeps people from understanding the message about Jesus. In some languages the metaphor is not natural. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Change it to a simile. For example:

has caused the minds of unbelievers to be like the eyes of blind people

- Explain the meaning in your translation. For example:

has made the minds of unbelievers unable to understand, like blind eyes that cannot see

- Translate literally and explain the meaning in a footnote. An example footnote is:

Just as a blind person cannot see, Satan keeps people from understanding the message about Jesus.

- Translate the meaning without the metaphor. For example:

has made the minds of unbelievers unable to understand

unbelievers: This word refers to people who do not follow Jesus. Other ways to translate this word are:

those who do not believe (NCV)

those who do not follow Jesus

4:4b

so they cannot see the light of the gospel of the glory of Christ,

- so that they cannot see the light coming from the gospel about the glory/splendor of Christ,
- therefore they cannot understand the good message about Christ and his glory/radiance.

they cannot see the light of the gospel: This clause continues to use the metaphor of blindness (4:4a). It

refers to not understanding the gospel. In some languages a literal translation would not have the correct meaning. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Change it to a simile. For example:

it is as if they cannot see the light of the gospel

- Explain the meaning in your translation. For example:

they cannot understand the gospel, like blind people who cannot see

- Translate literally and explain the meaning in a footnote. An example footnote is:

Just as a blind person cannot see, these people cannot understand the message about Jesus.

- Translate the meaning without the metaphor. For example:

they cannot understand the gospel

the light of the gospel: Here the word of indicates that the gospel is the source of the light. For example:

the light that comes from the Good News (GNT)

of the glory of Christ: The first of indicates that the gospel is about the glory that belongs to Christ. For example:

about the glory of Christ (GNT)

glory: The word glory refers literally to a very bright light. In this context it implies power, majesty, and greatness. Other ways to translate this word are:

splendor

radiance

See how you translated this word in 3:18.

4:4c

who is the image of God.

- who shows what God is like.
- He is the image of God's character.

who is the image of God: This clause tells the reader more about Christ. Some languages must translate it in a different way to indicate that meaning. One way to do that is to start a new sentence here. For example:

He is the image of God.

is the image of God: This phrase indicates that Jesus has shown to us exactly the character of God. It does not indicate that Jesus was a picture of God, because a picture only shows the physical appearance, but Jesus showed God's attitudes, thoughts, goals, desires, and so forth. In some languages a literal translation would wrongly refer only to physical appearance. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Explain in your translation. For example:

who is the image of God's character

who perfectly shows God's character

- Translate literally and explain the meaning in a footnote. An example footnote is:

This saying indicates that Jesus has shown the character of God to us.

This saying indicates that Jesus has shown God's attitudes, thoughts, goals, desires, and so forth to us.

2 Corinthians 4:5

Section 3:1–4:6: Confidence in the gospel of Jesus

The false teachers in Corinth were Jews (11:22). In this section, Paul wrote about some of the false teachings of these men. Since they were Jews, Paul referred to people and events in the Old Testament, such as the tablets of stone (3:3), Moses (3:7), and Moses' veil (3:13). They probably brought letters from other false teachers who said the false teachers in Corinth taught truthfully (3:1–3). The false teachers taught that believers must obey the Jewish laws. But Paul said that believers follow the new covenant with Jesus and not the old covenant with the Jews (3:14). He also spoke against their secret and shameful ways and said that they corrupted God's word (4:2). Throughout this section Paul also encouraged the believers to follow Jesus.

Other examples of headings for this section are:

The Ministry That Comes From Christ Is Greater Than Moses' Ministry (GW)

The new covenant is greater than the law of Moses

4:5a

For we do not proclaim ourselves,

- For we^(excl) do not proclaim our importance,
- For in our ministry, it is not ourselves that we preach/announce.

For: Here the word For indicates that 4:5 explains some things Paul had said about their ministry of preaching the gospel of Jesus (4:1–4).

proclaim ourselves: This phrase refers to preaching in a way that would have made Paul and the others seem important. Paul did not preach for the purpose of becoming famous. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

preach ourselves (NIV)

Our message is not about ourselves (GW)

preach about ourselves (NCV)

proclaim: This word means “announce” or “preach.” Paul and the others announced that Jesus was the Christ to people in Corinth. For example:

preach (NIV)

See how you translated this word in 1:19.

ourselves: This word is emphasized in the Greek. It emphasizes the contrast with what they do preach (4:5b). For example:

it is not ourselves that we preach (GNT)

4:5b

but Jesus Christ as Lord,

- but that Jesus Christ is Lord,
- Rather, we preach/announce that Jesus Christ is ruler over all,

but Jesus Christ as Lord: The words “we preach” are implied from 4:5a but are not repeated here. In some languages it is more natural to repeat some of those words. For example:

but we preach Jesus Christ as Lord

Jesus Christ as Lord: This phrase refers to explaining that Jesus Christ is the Lord. That is, he is the one who, with God, rules all things. For example:

We preach that Jesus Christ is Lord (NLT)

Jesus Christ: There is a textual issue here. Some Greek manuscripts have “Christ Jesus” instead of Jesus Christ:

1. The order is Jesus Christ. For example:

Jesus Christ (RSV) (BSB, RSV, NIV, GNT, NABRE, NLT, GW, CEV, NET, NCV, ESV)

1. The order is Christ Jesus. For example:

Christ Jesus (NASB) (NJB, NASB, REB, KJV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1), since the UBS Greek New Testament recommends it.

Lord: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Lord means “the one in authority over (something)” or “master.” It refers to someone greater in status or power. Jesus is ruler over all things. Another way to translate this word is:

ruler over all things

4:5c

and ourselves as your servants for Jesus' sake.

- and that we ourselves serve/help you^(plur) because of Jesus.
- and we made ourselves to be your humble helpers/servants in obedience to Jesus.

and ourselves as your servants for Jesus' sake:

There is no verb in this clause. The words “we proclaim” are implied from 4:5a but are not repeated here. In this context it indicates that Paul and the other evangelists considered themselves to be servants of the believers in Corinth. They helped the believers so that they believed, loved, and obeyed Jesus well. Other ways to translate this clause are:

and we made ourselves as your servants for Jesus' sake

and we told you that we were your servants for Jesus' sake

servants: The Greek word that the BSB translates as servants is literally “slaves.” The word “slaves” figuratively indicates that Paul and the other evangelists cared for the needs of the believers in Corinth. They were humble and submissive to the believers. The difference between a slave and a servant is not important here.

Some languages do not have a word for “servant” or “slave.” If that is true in your language, you may want to use a general term for “worker” or use a phrase that includes humility or submission. Some examples are:

workers

those who serve

humble helpers

for Jesus' sake: The Greek words that the BSB translates as for Jesus' sake can be literally translated as “because of Jesus.” Paul and the others served the believers to honor Jesus and in response to what Jesus had done for them. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

because of Jesus

to honor Jesus

2 Corinthians 4:6

Section 3:1–4:6: Confidence in the gospel of Jesus

The false teachers in Corinth were Jews (11:22). In this section, Paul wrote about some of the false teachings of these men. Since they were Jews, Paul referred to people and events in the Old Testament, such as the tablets of stone (3:3), Moses (3:7), and Moses' veil (3:13). They probably brought letters from other false teachers who said the false teachers in Corinth taught truthfully (3:1–3). The false teachers taught that believers must obey the Jewish laws. But Paul said that believers follow the new covenant with Jesus and not the old covenant with the Jews (3:14). He also spoke against their secret and shameful ways and said that they corrupted God's word (4:2). Throughout this section Paul also encouraged the believers to follow Jesus.

Other examples of headings for this section are:

The Ministry That Comes From Christ Is Greater Than Moses' Ministry (GW)

The new covenant is greater than the law of Moses

4:6a

For God, who said, “Let light shine out of darkness,”

- For God himself, who earlier said, “Light, shine from the darkness,”
- For God said long ago, “May light shine out of darkness,”

For: This conjunction introduces an explanation.

God, who said, “Let light shine out of darkness”:

In the beginning God caused light to shine (Genesis 1:3–4). This sentence is not an exact quote of those verses in Genesis, but it has the same meaning. You may want to indicate that God said this long ago. For example:

God, who said long ago, “Let light shine out of darkness”

God, who said: The Greek words are literally “God, the one having said.” This phrase emphasizes the word God. For example:

It is God who said (NJB)

Let light shine out of darkness: The Greek clause is literally “out of darkness light will shine.” The phrase out of darkness is emphasized in the Greek clause. For example:

Out of darkness the light shall shine! (GNT)

The Greek clause uses the future tense as a command for light to begin shining. Other ways to translate this clause are:

Out of darkness, light, shine!

May light shine out of darkness

This clause is similar to Genesis 1:3. The BSB and other English versions indicate that in a footnote or cross-reference. You may want to do that here.

4:6b

made His light shine in our hearts

- is the one who shone in our^(incl) hearts
- and he also gave to us understanding like a light in our hearts/minds.

made His light shine in our hearts: This phrase is the main point, with the words “who said, ‘Let light shine out of darkness,’ ” as supporting information. (4:6c is the purpose for shining in the hearts of believers.)

The Greek clause is literally “who shone in our hearts.” For example:

who has shone in our hearts (RSV)

This clause is a metaphor. It indicates that God caused believers to understand the gospel. In some languages a literal translation would not have the correct meaning. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Change it to a simile. For example:

it is as of he shone in our hearts

- Explain the meaning in your translation. For example:

he gave to us understanding like a light in our hearts

- Translate literally and explain the meaning in a footnote. An example footnote is:

This saying indicates that God gave understanding of the gospel to believers.

- Translate the meaning without the metaphor. For example:

he gave to us understanding in our hearts

hearts: This word refers figuratively to the part of people where true understanding occurs. In your language, refer to that part of people. This may be another organ such as the liver or generally the “insides” of a person.

Your language may not use a part of the body for a figurative meaning of true understanding. In that case, translate the meaning without the metaphor. For example:

he gave to us true understanding

See how you translated this word in 3:15.

4:6c

to give us the light of the knowledge of the glory of God in the face of Jesus Christ.

- to enlighten them with the knowledge of God’s glory, the glory on the face of Christ. (NJB)
- God caused us to understand God’s glory/radiance/splendor, which the face of Christ showed/revealed.

to give us the light of the knowledge of the glory of God in the face of Jesus Christ: There is a textual issue regarding the word Christ here:

1. Some Greek manuscripts have Christ. (RSV, NIV, GNT, NJB, NASB, GW, NET, NCV)
2. Some Greek manuscripts have Jesus Christ. (BSB, NRSV, NLT, CEV, REB, ESV, KJV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1). The UBS Greek New Testament has “Jesus” in brackets but does not state a preference as to whether it should read “Christ” or “Jesus Christ.” Harris (p. 322) says that it would be more difficult to explain the omission of Jesus if it had originally been in the text. He, Martin, and Barnett support only “Christ.” But Thrall and Kistemaker support “Jesus Christ.”

to give us the light of the knowledge of the glory of God in the face of Jesus Christ: This clause refers figuratively to understanding the gospel that reveals God’s glory. The way Jesus lived revealed God’s glory. The word knowledge refers to the things that people know about who Jesus is, namely the gospel. Other ways to translate this clause are:

to enlighten them with the knowledge of God’s glory, the glory on the face of Christ (NJB)

to bring us the knowledge of God’s glory shining in the face of Christ (GNT)

so we could know the glory of God that is seen in the face of Jesus Christ (NLT)

to give us the light: This indicates purpose. God has already given this light to us. But in some languages purpose clauses are only used to indicate something that hasn’t happened yet. If that is true in your language, indicate that this has already happened. For example:

and so gave us the light

in the face of Jesus Christ: This phrase refers to who Jesus is. He reveals God's glory. The phrase also connects to 3:13 and contrasts with Moses' face having only temporary glory. In some languages a literal translation would not clearly indicate the contrast with Moses and the old covenant. If that is true in your language, you may want to explain in a footnote. For example:

This phrase refers to who Jesus is. He reveals God's glory. But it also connects to 3:13 and contrasts with Moses' face having only temporary glory.

Since the phrase the face of Jesus Christ refers figuratively to Christ's life, you may want to translate in a way that refers generally to Christ's life. For example:

in Christ

in Christ's life

2 Corinthians 4:7

Section 4:7–18: Although our bodies are weak, our message is powerful

In this section, Paul continued to speak of the difficulties that he and the other evangelists encountered as they did the work of the new covenant. He referred to their bodies as jars of clay (4:7a), which are easily shattered. He said this to show that our human nature is weak and easily fails as we follow God. But Paul was also encouraged that God enabled him to do the work of the new covenant in spite of great difficulties (4:7b–9).

He wrote that he and the other evangelists experienced things similar to what Jesus experienced before he died, but those experiences showed to other people how Jesus lived (4:10–11). He wrote that the believers experienced the good effects of Jesus' life (4:12). He supported his ministry of preaching with a quote from the Old Testament (4:13), and he explained the promise there (4:14). He wrote that their ministry benefited the believers in Corinth and others as well (4:15).

Lastly, Paul wrote how they continue in spite of the difficulties (4:16–18).

Other examples of headings for this section are:

Spiritual Treasure in Clay Jars (NCV)

Even though our bodies are weak, God gives us strength to tell the gospel

A glorious, powerful message taught by weak messengers

4:7a

Now we have this treasure in jars of clay

- ¶ But we^(excl) have that valuable thing in jars/containers of clay
- ¶ We have that spiritual treasure in us weak humans who are like clay pots.

Now: The conjunction that the BSB translates as Now here can also be translated as “But.” It indicates that there is a contrast between the statement that we understand God's glory (4:6c) and our weakness as humans to follow God.

we: Paul wrote in this section about his experiences with his fellow apostles and evangelists. The believers in Corinth did not experience these things. But some of the truths in this section can apply to believers.

this treasure: The word this indicates that the word treasure refers to “the light of the knowledge of the glory of God in the face of Christ” (4:6c). Refer back to 4:6 in your translation. For example:

that treasure

treasure: This word refers to things that are very valuable. Here the word is a metaphor and refers to the gospel and the knowledge of it (4:6b–c). In some languages a literal translation would wrongly refer only to physical treasure. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Use a word or phrase that can refer to the gospel and the knowledge of it. For example:

valuable thing

thing like a treasure

- Explain the meaning in your translation. For example:

spiritual treasure (GNT)

gospel, which is very valuable like a treasure

- Translate literally and explain the meaning in a footnote. An example footnote is:

This word refers to the gospel and the knowledge of it (4:6).

in jars of clay: This phrase is also a metaphor. It refers to human nature and indicates that human nature is weak. A clay jar is easily broken. In the same way, people can be hurt or damaged in the face of great difficulties. But God empowered Paul and the others to survive all these difficulties.

In some languages a literal translation would not indicate the correct meaning. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Change it to a simile. For example:

in us as in jars of clay

- Explain the meaning in your translation. For example:

in us weak humans who are like jars of clay

- Translate literally and explain the meaning in a footnote. An example footnote is:

This phrase refers to human nature and indicates that human nature is weak.

- Translate the meaning without the metaphor. For example:

in us weak humans You may then want to explain the literal phrase in a footnote. For example:

Literally “in jars of clay.” This phrase refers to human nature and indicates that human nature is weak.

jars of clay: This phrase refers to containers made of a kind of earth that is soft and can be made into various shapes. It becomes hard when dried. People take clay and make bowls and bottles and other things. For example:

earthenware jars (REB)

jars: This word refers generally to any kind of container. It might hold grain or water or something else. Other ways to translate this word are:

pots (GNT)

vessels (RSV)

4:7b

to show that this surpassingly great power is from God and not from us.

- to reveal that the superior power within us is from God and not from us.
- This shows that the treasure’s power which is best/supreme comes from God and does not come from us.

this surpassingly great power: The Greek phrase is literally “the excellence of the power.” The word “excellence” indicates that the power is a better kind of power than any other kind of power. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

the surpassing greatness of the power (NASB)

the supreme power (GNT)

this extraordinary power (NRSV)

The phrase refers to the power of the gospel as revealed in miracles and so forth. For example:

this extraordinary power within us

the superior power of this treasure (GW)

2 Corinthians 4:8

Section 4:7–18: Although our bodies are weak, our message is powerful

In this section, Paul continued to speak of the difficulties that he and the other evangelists encountered as they did the work of the new covenant. He referred to their bodies as jars of clay (4:7a), which are easily shattered. He said this to show that our human nature is weak and easily fails as we follow God. But Paul was also encouraged that God enabled him to do the work of the new covenant in spite of great difficulties (4:7b–9).

He wrote that he and the other evangelists experienced things similar to what Jesus experienced before

he died, but those experiences showed to other people how Jesus lived (4:10–11). He wrote that the believers experienced the good effects of Jesus' life (4:12). He supported his ministry of preaching with a quote from the Old Testament (4:13), and he explained the promise there (4:14). He wrote that their ministry benefited the believers in Corinth and others as well (4:15).

Lastly, Paul wrote how they continue in spite of the difficulties (4:16–18).

Other examples of headings for this section are:

Spiritual Treasure in Clay Jars (NCV)

Even though our bodies are weak, God gives us strength to tell the gospel

A glorious, powerful message taught by weak messengers

4:8–11

In these verses Paul gave examples of the ways in which he and the other evangelists were weak, but God repeatedly gave them the power to continue. The BSB uses the present tense to indicate that these clauses are general examples. Translate in a way that indicates that these clauses are general examples. They were not experiences that only happened once.

4:8a

We are hard pressed on all sides, but not crushed;

- All kinds of hardships/troubles come/press against us^(excl), but we are not overwhelmed/conquered;
- For example, although we undergo/experience difficulties/suffering in all kinds of ways, they do not crush/defeat us.

We are hard pressed In some languages it may be helpful to begin this section with a phrase indicating that Paul is giving examples:

For example, we are hard pressed

The Greek verb that the BSB translates as We are hard pressed refers to both the outward trouble a person experiences and the suffering a person experiences from that trouble. The Greek word includes people oppressing Paul and the others but refers also to any kind of difficulty or hardship. Other ways to translate this word are:

We experience trouble/oppression

We undergo hardships/suffering

See how you translated this Greek word (“are afflicted”) in 1:6.

on all sides: The Greek phrase is literally “in every (way).” Paul and the others experienced all kinds of oppression and hardship. For example:

every kind of hardship (NJB)

but not crushed: The words “we are” are implied from 4:8a but are not repeated here. In some languages it is more natural to repeat those words. For example:

but we are not crushed

crushed: This word refers figuratively to being overwhelmed by the oppression or hardship (4:8a). In some languages it is more natural to translate the meaning without the metaphor. For example:

defeated (NCV)

overwhelmed

4:8b

perplexed, but not in despair;

- and we are bewildered, but we are never overwhelmed by sorrow/woe.
- Although we often do not know what to do about what is happening, we never lose all hope.

perplexed: This word means “uncertain.” Paul and the others with him sometimes did not know what was happening and therefore did not know what to do. The words “we are” are implied from 4:8a but are not repeated here. Other ways to translate this word are:

uncertain about what is happening

we are puzzled (JBP)

bewildered (REB)

We do not know what to do (NCV)

We are often troubled and say to ourselves, “What shall we do now?”

in despair: A person may have a hardship or trouble. The word despair refers to that person having extreme sadness and seeing no way to do anything about the hardship or trouble. He no longer tries to do anything about it and no longer expects others to help him. Other ways to translate this word are:

completely dejected

despondent

lose all hope

2 Corinthians 4:9

Section 4:7–18: Although our bodies are weak, our message is powerful

In this section, Paul continued to speak of the difficulties that he and the other evangelists encountered as they did the work of the new covenant. He referred to their bodies as jars of clay (4:7a), which are easily shattered. He said this to show that our human nature is weak and easily fails as we follow God. But Paul was also encouraged that God enabled him to do the work of the new covenant in spite of great difficulties (4:7b–9).

He wrote that he and the other evangelists experienced things similar to what Jesus experienced before he died, but those experiences showed to other people how Jesus lived (4:10–11). He wrote that the believers experienced the good effects of Jesus' life (4:12). He supported his ministry of preaching with a quote from the Old Testament (4:13), and he explained the promise there (4:14). He wrote that their ministry benefited the believers in Corinth and others as well (4:15).

Lastly, Paul wrote how they continue in spite of the difficulties (4:16–18).

Other examples of headings for this section are:

Spiritual Treasure in Clay Jars (NCV)

Even though our bodies are weak, God gives us strength to tell the gospel

A glorious, powerful message taught by weak messengers

4:9a persecuted, but not forsaken;

- We^(excl) are persecuted/oppresed, but we are not neglected/forsaken;
- Although others harm us, God never leaves us.

persecuted: This word refers to others causing troubles for Paul and his coworkers. The words “we are” are implied from 4:8a but are not repeated here. Other ways to translate this word are:

oppressed

we are harassed

This verb is an implied passive clause. In some languages an active clause must be used. For example:

others persecute us

forsaken: This word refers to leaving someone permanently or refusing to have any relationship with him. For example:

abandoned (NIV)

This verb is an implied passive clause. God does not abandon his people. In some languages an active clause must be used. For example:

God does not abandon us

4:9b struck down, but not destroyed.

- and we are sometimes knocked down, but we are not destroyed.
- Although others strike us severely, they do not destroy us.

struck down: Here the Greek word that the BSB translates as struck down can refer to being physically beaten to the ground or bullied. It can also refer figuratively to a devastating action by an adversary. If possible, translate in a way that can have both a physical and figurative meaning. The words “we are” are implied from 4:8a but are not repeated here. Other ways to translate this Greek word are:

We are hurt sometimes (NCV)

knocked down (NJB)

we are beaten

This clause is passive. Some languages must use an active clause. For example:

others strike us to the ground

destroyed: This word means “ruin, demolish.” When something is destroyed, it cannot work or act, and it cannot be repaired. This verb does not refer to something that disappears and is gone. The words “we are” are implied from 4:8a but are not repeated here. Other ways to translate this word are:

demolished

we are defeated

This clause is passive. It refers generally to other people destroying. Some languages must use an active clause. For example:

they did not destroy us

2 Corinthians 4:10

Section 4:7–18: Although our bodies are weak, our message is powerful

In this section, Paul continued to speak of the difficulties that he and the other evangelists encountered as they did the work of the new covenant. He referred to their bodies as jars of clay (4:7a), which are easily shattered. He said this to show that our human nature is weak and easily fails as we follow God. But Paul was also encouraged that God enabled him to do the work of the new covenant in spite of great difficulties (4:7b–9).

He wrote that he and the other evangelists experienced things similar to what Jesus experienced before he died, but those experiences showed to other people how Jesus lived (4:10–11). He wrote that the believers experienced the good effects of Jesus’ life (4:12). He supported his ministry of preaching with a quote from the Old Testament (4:13), and he explained the promise there (4:14). He wrote that their ministry benefited the believers in Corinth and others as well (4:15).

Lastly, Paul wrote how they continue in spite of the difficulties (4:16–18).

Other examples of headings for this section are:

Spiritual Treasure in Clay Jars (NCV)

Even though our bodies are weak, God gives us strength to tell the gospel

A glorious, powerful message taught by weak messengers

4:10a

We always carry around in our body the death of Jesus,

- We^(excl) always carry the experiences of Jesus dying in the/our body,
- Through suffering, our bodies continue to share in the death of Jesus (NLT)

We always carry around in our body the death of

Jesus: This clause refers to experiencing things similar to the things that Jesus experienced on the way to his death. People beat, scourged, and stoned Paul for following Jesus. The phrase carry around in our body probably refers to scars and aches and possibly other limitations from the injuries he received. These things were reminders of what Jesus suffered and his sacrifice on the behalf of believers. Other ways to translate this clause are:

always carrying about in the body the dying of Jesus (NASB)

Through suffering, our bodies continue to share in the death of Jesus (NLT)

We always feel in our bodies the things that Jesus experienced as he went to his death

We always carry the reminders of the death of Jesus in our body

4:10b

so that the life of Jesus may also be revealed in our body.

- in order that we might show others how Jesus lived by the deeds of our bodies.
- so that people will see the life of Jesus in the things we do.

so that: These words probably introduce the purpose of 4:10a.

the life of Jesus may also be revealed in our body:

This clause refers to doing similar things to the things that Jesus did while he was alive on earth. This shows

others what kind of person Jesus is. Other ways to translate this clause are:

the life of Jesus also may be manifested in our body (NASB)

we can show others how Jesus lived on earth by what we do

we do things that show people the life of Jesus

2 Corinthians 4:11

Section 4:7–18: Although our bodies are weak, our message is powerful

In this section, Paul continued to speak of the difficulties that he and the other evangelists encountered as they did the work of the new covenant. He referred to their bodies as jars of clay (4:7a), which are easily shattered. He said this to show that our human nature is weak and easily fails as we follow God. But Paul was also encouraged that God enabled him to do the work of the new covenant in spite of great difficulties (4:7b–9).

He wrote that he and the other evangelists experienced things similar to what Jesus experienced before he died, but those experiences showed to other people how Jesus lived (4:10–11). He wrote that the believers experienced the good effects of Jesus' life (4:12). He supported his ministry of preaching with a quote from the Old Testament (4:13), and he explained the promise there (4:14). He wrote that their ministry benefited the believers in Corinth and others as well (4:15).

Lastly, Paul wrote how they continue in spite of the difficulties (4:16–18).

Other examples of headings for this section are:

Spiritual Treasure in Clay Jars (NCV)

Even though our bodies are weak, God gives us strength to tell the gospel

A glorious, powerful message taught by weak messengers

4:11a

For we who are alive are always consigned to death for Jesus' sake,

- For we^(excl) living people are being delivered to death for Jesus' sake,

- For we who live are always in danger of death because we follow Jesus,

For: This conjunction indicates that 4:11 explains 4:10.

we who are alive are always consigned to death:

The Greek clause is literally “we, the living ones, are being given/delivered to death.” God sometimes allows enemies of Jesus to kill believers. Paul and his companions were in danger of death many times. Other ways to translate this clause are:

while we are still alive, we are continually being handed over to death (NJB)

We are alive, but for Jesus we are always in danger of death (NCV)

During the time we live, each day people want to kill us because we follow Jesus

we who are alive: This phrase probably refers to those who have earthly life, rather than contrasting with the people who have died. For example:

Throughout our lives (GNT)

for Jesus' sake: The Greek words that the BSB translates as for Jesus' sake can be literally translated as “because of Jesus.” Paul and the others were in danger of death because they followed Jesus. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

because of Jesus

because we serve Jesus (NLT)

4:11b

so that the life of Jesus may also be revealed in our mortal body.

- in order that we might show others how he lived by the deeds of our bodies that die.
- so that people will see the life of Jesus in the things we do here on earth before we die.

the life of Jesus may also be revealed in our mortal body: This clause is similar to 4:10b and has a similar meaning.

mortal body: The Greek word that the BSB translates as mortal body is different from the word translated as “body” in 4:10b. The Greek word here includes the

idea of the body being limited in power and destined to die. Other ways to translate this Greek word are:

dying bodies (NLT)

bodies that die (NCV)

2 Corinthians 4:12

Section 4:7–18: Although our bodies are weak, our message is powerful

In this section, Paul continued to speak of the difficulties that he and the other evangelists encountered as they did the work of the new covenant. He referred to their bodies as jars of clay (4:7a), which are easily shattered. He said this to show that our human nature is weak and easily fails as we follow God. But Paul was also encouraged that God enabled him to do the work of the new covenant in spite of great difficulties (4:7b–9).

He wrote that he and the other evangelists experienced things similar to what Jesus experienced before he died, but those experiences showed to other people how Jesus lived (4:10–11). He wrote that the believers experienced the good effects of Jesus' life (4:12). He supported his ministry of preaching with a quote from the Old Testament (4:13), and he explained the promise there (4:14). He wrote that their ministry benefited the believers in Corinth and others as well (4:15).

Lastly, Paul wrote how they continue in spite of the difficulties (4:16–18).

Other examples of headings for this section are:

Spiritual Treasure in Clay Jars (NCV)

Even though our bodies are weak, God gives us strength to tell the gospel

A glorious, powerful message taught by weak messengers

4:12a

So then, death is at work in us,

- So then, the effects of death are seen in our^(excl) bodies/lives,
- Therefore, although the disabilities of deadly experiences are active/working in our bodies/lives,

So then: These words indicate that 4:12 is the conclusion of what Paul said in 4:7–11. For example:

This means that (GNT)

death is at work in us: This clause refers to 4:10a and 4:11a. Paul and the other evangelists suffered and were in danger of death because they served Jesus. Things that can cause death, such as beatings and stoning, still affect their bodies. Harris (pp. 349–350) says that the word death here refers not only to experiences that nearly killed Paul but also to experiences that left him with reminders of those experiences. Possible examples are broken bones, a limp, or a disabled hand. Other ways to translate this clause are:

The effects of death appear in our lives

The things of death are active in our lives

We endure the kinds of sufferings in our lives that many times cause death

4:12b

but life is at work in you.

- but the effects of Jesus' life are seen in your^(plur) bodies/lives.
- the ways/power of eternal life are active/working in your bodies/lives.

life is at work in you: This clause indicates that the believers in Corinth have the life of Jesus working in them. Other ways to translate this clause are:

the effects of Jesus' life appear in your lives

the ways of life are active in your lives

the power of eternal life is affecting/changing your lives

2 Corinthians 4:13

Section 4:7–18: Although our bodies are weak, our message is powerful

In this section, Paul continued to speak of the difficulties that he and the other evangelists encountered as they did the work of the new covenant. He referred to their bodies as jars of clay (4:7a), which are easily shattered. He said this to show that our human nature is weak and easily fails as we follow God. But Paul was also encouraged that God enabled him to do the work of the new covenant in spite of great difficulties (4:7b–9).

He wrote that he and the other evangelists experienced things similar to what Jesus experienced before he died, but those experiences showed to other people how Jesus lived (4:10–11). He wrote that the believers experienced the good effects of Jesus' life (4:12). He supported his ministry of preaching with a quote from the Old Testament (4:13), and he explained the promise there (4:14). He wrote that their ministry benefited the believers in Corinth and others as well (4:15). Lastly, Paul wrote how they continue in spite of the difficulties (4:16–18).

Other examples of headings for this section are:

Spiritual Treasure in Clay Jars (NCV)

Even though our bodies are weak, God gives us strength to tell the gospel

A glorious, powerful message taught by weak messengers

4:13a

And in keeping with what is written: “I believed, therefore I have spoken,”

- ¶ It is written in the Scripture, “I believed, so I spoke.”
- ¶ Someone wrote in God's holy book, “I spoke because I believed.”

And in keeping with what is written: This clause refers to the Old Testament. For example:

The scripture says (GNT)

This clause is passive. It implies the writer of that verse writing it. Some languages must use an active clause. For example:

Someone wrote in God's holy book

I believed, therefore I have spoken: Paul quoted Psalm 116:10, where the writer also faced anguish and death. He spoke because he believed in God and trusted him. For example:

I spoke because I believed (GNT)

If you footnote the location of quotes from the Old Testament, you may want to do so here.

believed: This word refers to a strong and sincere way of thinking about something or someone. Believing in God refers to:

1. accepting His message as true,
2. acting on the basis of His message,
3. being confident in His message, and
4. trusting in Him.

Your language may have a noun, verb, phrase, or idiom with that meaning.

The past tense of believed goes with the past tense of have spoken. It does not imply that the writer of this psalm no longer believed at the time he wrote this. Your translation should not imply that the writer no longer believed at the time of writing.

4:13b

we who have the same spirit of faith also believe and therefore speak,

- We^(excl) also believe and therefore speak with that same spirit of believing,
- In the same way, we also believe and therefore speak,

the same spirit of faith: Here the word spirit refers to an attitude. Paul had the same attitude of faith as the person who wrote the quote from the Old Testament. For example:

same kind of faith (NLT)

faith: This word refers to strongly and sincerely believing in something or someone. This noun has the same meaning as the verb “believed” (4:13a). In some languages it is more natural to use a verb here. For example:

believing

also believe and therefore speak: The verbs believe and speak are present tense. This may indicate that Paul and the others continued to believe and tell the gospel message at the time he wrote this letter.

2 Corinthians 4:14

Section 4:7–18: Although our bodies are weak, our message is powerful

In this section, Paul continued to speak of the difficulties that he and the other evangelists encountered as they did the work of the new covenant. He referred to their bodies as jars of clay (4:7a), which are easily shattered. He said this to show that our human nature is weak and easily fails as we follow God. But Paul

was also encouraged that God enabled him to do the work of the new covenant in spite of great difficulties (4:7b–9).

He wrote that he and the other evangelists experienced things similar to what Jesus experienced before he died, but those experiences showed to other people how Jesus lived (4:10–11). He wrote that the believers experienced the good effects of Jesus' life (4:12). He supported his ministry of preaching with a quote from the Old Testament (4:13), and he explained the promise there (4:14). He wrote that their ministry benefited the believers in Corinth and others as well (4:15).

Lastly, Paul wrote how they continue in spite of the difficulties (4:16–18).

Other examples of headings for this section are:

Spiritual Treasure in Clay Jars (NCV)

Even though our bodies are weak, God gives us strength to tell the gospel

A glorious, powerful message taught by weak messengers

4:14a

knowing that the One who raised the Lord Jesus

- because we^(excl) know that the one who raised the Lord Jesus to life
- because we are sure that he who caused Jesus, the ruler over all, to live again after he had died

the One who raised the Lord Jesus: The word raised indicates that Jesus died on the cross but God caused him to live again. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

the one who brought the Lord Jesus back to life (GW)

he who raised the Lord Jesus to life (REB)

the One who raised: This phrase refers to God. The GNT makes that clear:

God, who raised (GNT)

However, in many languages, this use of who would wrongly imply that Paul was thinking of many gods and only this One raised Jesus. If that is true in your language, translate without using who. For example:

God, and he raised the Lord Jesus from the dead,

Lord: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Lord means “the one in authority over (something)” or “master.” It refers to someone greater in status or power. Jesus is ruler over all things. Another way to translate this word is:

ruler over all things

See how you translated this word in 4:5.

4:14b

will also raise us with Jesus

- will also raise us^(excl) to life through Jesus
- will also cause us to live again just as he raised Jesus.

with Jesus: This phrase can mean:

1. to be with Jesus,
2. because we belong to Jesus,
3. to share Jesus' resurrection,
4. in the same way that Jesus was resurrected,
5. because he was resurrected.

Translate in a way that allows one or more of the above meanings. Here the word with does not indicate that believers were resurrected at the same time as Jesus. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

through Jesus (GW)

just as God raised Jesus, he will also raise us to life (CEV)

with Jesus in our turn (NJB)

to join Jesus

sharing in Jesus' resurrection

4:14c

and present us with you in His presence.

- and bring us^(excl) along with you^(plur) to stand before him.
- And God will bring us^(excl), together with you, to present us^(incl) all to himself.

present us with you in His presence: Here the word present refers to bringing someone to stand in front of someone else. God will bring Paul, the other evangelists, and the believers in Corinth into his own

presence. In that way, they will meet God face to face. Other ways to translate this clause are:

present us to himself together with you (NLT)

will bring us together with you to stand before him

take us, together with you, into his presence (GNT)

2 Corinthians 4:15

Section 4:7–18: Although our bodies are weak, our message is powerful

In this section, Paul continued to speak of the difficulties that he and the other evangelists encountered as they did the work of the new covenant. He referred to their bodies as jars of clay (4:7a), which are easily shattered. He said this to show that our human nature is weak and easily fails as we follow God. But Paul was also encouraged that God enabled him to do the work of the new covenant in spite of great difficulties (4:7b–9).

He wrote that he and the other evangelists experienced things similar to what Jesus experienced before he died, but those experiences showed to other people how Jesus lived (4:10–11). He wrote that the believers experienced the good effects of Jesus' life (4:12). He supported his ministry of preaching with a quote from the Old Testament (4:13), and he explained the promise there (4:14). He wrote that their ministry benefited the believers in Corinth and others as well (4:15).

Lastly, Paul wrote how they continue in spite of the difficulties (4:16–18).

Other examples of headings for this section are:

Spiritual Treasure in Clay Jars (NCV)

Even though our bodies are weak, God gives us strength to tell the gospel

A glorious, powerful message taught by weak messengers

4:15a

All this is for your benefit,

- For all that has happened is for your^(plur) sake,
- All those things have been done for you,

4:15a begins with a Greek conjunction that is often translated as “for” or “because.” The conjunction introduces an explanation. For example:

For (RSV)

All this: This phrase refers to the things Paul mentioned in the letter so far. Paul and the other evangelists preached, suffered, were comforted, and were encouraged. Refer back to the things Paul talked about earlier. For example:

All those things

All that I have mentioned

is for your benefit: The difficult things that Paul experienced (4:8–12) benefited the believers in Corinth because they received the good news about Jesus Christ as a result. Other ways to translate this clause are:

is all for your sake (RSV)

has been done for you (CEV)

4:15b

so that the grace that is extending to more and more people

- in order that grace, which extends to more and more people,
- so that God's undeserved favor will spread among more and more people.

so that: This conjunction introduces the purpose for 4:15a (and indirectly 4:7–14). Another way to translate this conjunction is:

in order that

the grace that is extending to more and more people: The Greek clause is literally “grace increasing through many (people).” It indicates that God was giving his grace to more and more people; they were hearing about Jesus and believing. Other ways to translate this are:

grace extends to more and more people (RSV)

as grace spreads...among more and more people (NJB)

more and more people will know how kind God is (CEV)

as God's grace brings more and more people to Christ (NLT96)

grace: This word refers to doing good deeds for someone even though he has done nothing to deserve them. God gave grace to the believers by blessing them in various ways and by saving them from eternal death. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

kindness (GW)

help

favor

See how you translated this word in 1:12.

4:15c

may overflow in thanksgiving, to the glory of God.

- may make thanksgiving overflow to God and that glorifies him.
- And all those things have been done for you so that that grace would cause many more people to thank him abundantly, which causes/brings honor/glory to him.

may overflow in thanksgiving: This phrase is a metaphor. It describes thanksgiving as like water when it is poured into a glass until it overflows. The metaphor indicates an abundance of thanksgiving. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

may cause the giving of thanks to abound (NASB)

so there will be an abundance of thanksgiving

so many people may thank him very much

to the glory of God: This phrase indicates that the thanksgiving honors God. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

and God will receive more and more glory (NLT)

will praise and honor him (CEV)

glory: The word glory refers literally to a very bright light. In this context it implies honor, majesty, and greatness. Other ways to translate this word are:

splendor

radiance

See how you translated this word in 1:20.

2 Corinthians 4:16

Section 4:7–18: Although our bodies are weak, our message is powerful

In this section, Paul continued to speak of the difficulties that he and the other evangelists encountered as they did the work of the new covenant. He referred to their bodies as jars of clay (4:7a), which are easily shattered. He said this to show that our human nature is weak and easily fails as we follow God. But Paul was also encouraged that God enabled him to do the work of the new covenant in spite of great difficulties (4:7b–9).

He wrote that he and the other evangelists experienced things similar to what Jesus experienced before he died, but those experiences showed to other people how Jesus lived (4:10–11). He wrote that the believers experienced the good effects of Jesus' life (4:12). He supported his ministry of preaching with a quote from the Old Testament (4:13), and he explained the promise there (4:14). He wrote that their ministry benefited the believers in Corinth and others as well (4:15).

Lastly, Paul wrote how they continue in spite of the difficulties (4:16–18).

Other examples of headings for this section are:

Spiritual Treasure in Clay Jars (NCV)

Even though our bodies are weak, God gives us strength to tell the gospel

A glorious, powerful message taught by weak messengers

4:16a

Therefore we do not lose heart.

- ¶ Therefore, we^(excl) do not become dejected.
- ¶ So we do not despair.

Therefore: This word introduces a result of what Paul said in 4:7-15.

we do not lose heart: Here the Greek verb that the BSB translates as lose heart means “despair.” For example:

we are not discouraged (GW)

See how you translated this clause in 4:1.

4:16b

Though our outer self is wasting away,

- But although our bodies decay,
- Even though our bodies weaken with age and suffering,

Though: The Greek phrase here is literally “but even if” (as in the NET). The conjunction “but” indicates that 4:16b contrasts to 4:16a. For example:

but though (KJV)

Instead, although

Rather, although

Some languages will not need to translate the contrast here.

The phrase “even if” indicates that 4:16b is bad news but 4:16c is good news. Other ways to translate this Greek phrase are:

Even though (GNT)

indeed, though (NJB)

our outer self is wasting away: The term outer self refers to the physical body. The clause refers to the physical body decaying. The bodies of Paul and his coworkers were wearing out with age and the hardships they experienced. Other ways to translate this clause are:

our outer man is decaying (NASB)

The outward man does indeed suffer wear and tear (JBP)

Our physical body is becoming older and weaker (NCV)

our bodies are weakening with age and hardship

4:16c

yet our inner self is being renewed day by day.

- yet our inner being is being made new again each day.
- yet every day God makes our spirits completely strong/healthy/good again.

our inner self is being renewed: The clause is passive. The Holy Spirit or God renews the inner person. Some languages must use an active clause. For example:

the Holy Spirit renews us inwardly

our inner self: The term inner self refers to a person’s spirit and his emotions. Other ways to translate this word are:

our inner person (NET)

the inward man (JBP)

our spirit (NCV)

renewed: This word refers to making something to be like new again. Here the word refers to the Holy Spirit making Paul’s inner man come into the best condition again, as if it were a completely healthy body. Other ways to translate this word are:

made new (NCV)

receives fresh strength (JBP)

becoming healthy/strong again in regard to our new life

God gives new strength to our hearts/spirits

2 Corinthians 4:17

Section 4:7-18: Although our bodies are weak, our message is powerful

In this section, Paul continued to speak of the difficulties that he and the other evangelists encountered as they did the work of the new covenant. He referred to their bodies as jars of clay (4:7a), which are easily shattered. He said this to show that our human nature is weak and easily fails as we follow God. But Paul

was also encouraged that God enabled him to do the work of the new covenant in spite of great difficulties (4:7b–9).

He wrote that he and the other evangelists experienced things similar to what Jesus experienced before he died, but those experiences showed to other people how Jesus lived (4:10–11). He wrote that the believers experienced the good effects of Jesus' life (4:12). He supported his ministry of preaching with a quote from the Old Testament (4:13), and he explained the promise there (4:14). He wrote that their ministry benefited the believers in Corinth and others as well (4:15).

Lastly, Paul wrote how they continue in spite of the difficulties (4:16–18).

Other examples of headings for this section are:

Spiritual Treasure in Clay Jars (NCV)

Even though our bodies are weak, God gives us strength to tell the gospel

A glorious, powerful message taught by weak messengers

4:17a–b

(reordered) For our troubles gain/obtain for us an eternal glory that is very much greater than them, and so those troubles in comparison seem only light/small and last only a short time.

- (reordered) Our troubles cause us to have a splendor/majesty that will remain forever. That splendor/majesty is very much greater than the pain of all those troubles. Therefore, those troubles can be thought of as being only little and short-lived.

our light and momentary affliction is producing for us an eternal glory that is far beyond comparison:

Paul implied a comparison here. The forms of affliction experienced by Paul and his coworkers were very difficult (1:8–9). But compared to the reward in heaven (4:17b), the experiences of affliction seemed small and lasted a short time. Other ways to translate the phrase our light and momentary affliction are:

the temporary, light burden of our hardships (NJB)

this small and temporary trouble we suffer (GNT)

our present troubles that are small and that will not last very long

In some languages a literal translation would not clearly imply the comparison. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Translate literally and explain the meaning in a footnote. An example footnote is:

The troubles of Paul and his coworkers were very difficult (1:8–9). But in comparison to the reward in heaven (4:17b), the troubles seemed small and lasted only a short time.

- Include the implied comparison in your translation. For example:

our extreme/difficult troubles are only light and momentary when compared to the eternal glory they achieve for us, which far outweighs all those troubles

our great/bad troubles seem only light and momentary because they achieve for us eternal glory, which far outweighs all of them

our great/bad troubles achieve for us eternal glory, and that glory far outweighs all of them. So those troubles are only light and momentary in comparison

4:17a

For our light and momentary affliction is producing for us

- For our^(excl) slight and temporary hardships/troubles are obtaining for us
- Our great troubles seem only little and short-lived, because they result in

For: Here the conjunction For introduces an explanation of 4:16. Some English versions, such as the CEV and GW, do not translate this conjunction. Some languages can also allow the context to indicate an implied connection and do not need to use a conjunction here.

light: Here this word refers to the troubles being small. Paul calls these troubles light because in comparison with the eternal glory that believers will receive, the troubles seem small. Other ways to translate this word are:

little (CEV)

slight (REB)

of no weight

momentary: Here this word refers to the troubles lasting only a short time. Other ways to translate this word are:

temporary (GNT)

which is but for a moment (KJV)

won't last very long (NLT)

short-lived (REB)

affliction is producing: This verb phrase indicates that the affliction that Paul and his coworkers experienced resulted in glory for them. That affliction came to them as followers of Jesus and they lived with it in a godly manner, so God would reward them with glory. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

troubles are achieving (NIV)

and their outcome is (REB)

will bring (GNT)

Paul and his coworkers would not receive the glory until they arrived in heaven, so in some languages it is more natural to indicate a future result. For example:

is preparing (RSV)

4:17b

an eternal glory that is far beyond comparison.

- an eternal glory that is very much greater than those troubles,
- a splendor/majesty for us that lasts forever. That splendor/majesty is so great that it is beyond comparison to those troubles.

an eternal glory that is far beyond comparison: The Greek phrase is literally “from excess to excess an eternal weight of glory.” The phrase “from excess to excess” indicates that the glory Paul would receive was much, much greater than the troubles he was facing. The amount of glory was beyond comparison to the troubles. Other ways to translate this are:

an eternal glory that far outweighs them all (NIV)

a glory that vastly outweighs them and will last forever (NLT)

an eternal glory that is greater than anything we can imagine (GW)

glory: This word literally means “brightness.” The word can also refer to light emanating from someone. Here the word symbolizes reward, splendor, and majesty. God will reward Paul and his coworkers with eternal life, a glorified body, and other rewards. Other ways to translate this word are:

splendor

majesty

See how you translated this word in 1:20 or 4:15.

2 Corinthians 4:18

Section 4:7–18: Although our bodies are weak, our message is powerful

In this section, Paul continued to speak of the difficulties that he and the other evangelists encountered as they did the work of the new covenant. He referred to their bodies as jars of clay (4:7a), which are easily shattered. He said this to show that our human nature is weak and easily fails as we follow God. But Paul was also encouraged that God enabled him to do the work of the new covenant in spite of great difficulties (4:7b–9).

He wrote that he and the other evangelists experienced things similar to what Jesus experienced before he died, but those experiences showed to other people how Jesus lived (4:10–11). He wrote that the believers experienced the good effects of Jesus' life (4:12). He supported his ministry of preaching with a quote from the Old Testament (4:13), and he explained the promise there (4:14). He wrote that their ministry benefited the believers in Corinth and others as well (4:15).

Lastly, Paul wrote how they continue in spite of the difficulties (4:16–18).

Other examples of headings for this section are:

Spiritual Treasure in Clay Jars (NCV)

Even though our bodies are weak, God gives us strength to tell the gospel

A glorious, powerful message taught by weak messengers

4:18a

So we fix our eyes not on what is seen, but on what is unseen.

- while we^(excl) set our gaze on what is unseen rather than on what is seen.
- We keep our attention on things that cannot be seen, instead of keeping our attention on things that can be seen.

So we fix our eyes: The Greek clause is literally “fixing our eyes.” It indicates a connection to 4:17, but it does not indicate exactly which kind of connection. There are several ways to interpret the connection:

1. 4:18 describes Paul’s attitude while the troubles gain him glory. For example:

while we look (NASB) (NASB, KJV, NABRE, ESV)

1. The connection is best left untranslated. This may imply interpretation (1). For example:

We set our eyes (NCV) (GW, CEV, NCV)

1. 4:18 describes the result of troubles gaining Paul glory. For example:

So we...fix our gaze (NLT) (BSB, NIV, NLT)

1. 4:18 describes the reason why troubles gain Paul glory. For example:

because we look (RSV) (RSV, GNT, NJB, NET)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), since the connections of “reason” or “result” seem unlikely here. Thrall says that it is “accompanying circumstances” and argues against it being a connection of “reason” (p. 355). Martin translates the text according to interpretation (1), “as we set our gaze” (p. 92). See the ESV in the Display for an example of interpretation (1).

we fix our eyes: This clause means “we focus our attention on,” or “we think much about.” Other ways to translate this clause are:

we fix our gaze (NLT)

fix our attention (GNT)

our eyes are fixed (REB)

we keep our minds (CEV)

we are looking all the time (JBP)

what is seen: This phrase refers to all the things in the physical world. It refers to the things people can see in their physical existence on earth. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

the things that are seen (RSV)

things that can be seen (GW)

but on what is unseen: The phrase “we fix our eyes” is implied but not repeated here. In some languages it is more natural to repeat the verb. For example:

but we fix our eyes on what is unseen

what is unseen: This phrase refers to all the things in the eternal, spiritual world. It refers to the things people will see in their eternal existence in heaven, including God. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

the things that are unseen (RSV)

things that can’t be seen (GW)

General Comment on 4:18a

Paul referred to what is not seen before what is seen. In some languages it is more natural to refer to what is seen first. For example:

we fix our eyes on what is unseen, not on what is seen

4:18b

For what is seen is temporary,

- We do that because the things that are seen will not last forever,
- Things that can be seen are only temporary. (GW)

what is seen is temporary: This clause indicates that one day the physical world will not exist (Revelation 20:11). Other ways to translate this clause are:

the things that are seen are transient (RSV)

Things that can be seen are only temporary (GW)

the things we see now will soon be gone (NLT)

4:18c

but what is unseen is eternal.

- but the things that are unseen will last forever.
- But things that can't be seen last forever. (GW)

what is unseen is eternal: This clause indicates that the spiritual world will continue to exist. It will not end. Other ways to translate this clause are:

the things that are unseen are eternal (RSV)

things that can't be seen last forever (GW)

the things we cannot see will last forever (NLT)

2 Corinthians 5:1

Section 5:1–10: The promise of life in heaven

In this section, Paul explained that after believers die, they will receive a heavenly body (5:1). He used the metaphor of a tent to refer to the earthly body and the metaphor of a building in heaven to refer to the heavenly body. Paul and his coworkers desired that the change would happen (5:2–4). He explained that God had given that desire and that God had also given the Holy Spirit so we can be assured that the promise of a heavenly body will be fulfilled (5:5).

Then Paul wrote that they were confident in their faith (5:6–8) and purposely chose to please God (5:9). He wrote the reason to do so, namely that all believers will be judged and rewarded by God for the things they have done (5:10).

Paul continued to use the pronoun “we” to refer to himself, Timothy, and others who traveled with him telling the good news about Jesus. But in some verses in this section, the pronoun “we” probably includes the believers in Corinth and therefore all believers.

Other examples of headings for this section are:

Our Heavenly Dwelling (NIV)

The mortal body that we have and the eternal body that God has promised

Faith Guides Our Lives (GW)

God has promised a new, eternal body and so we live by faith/believing

The assurance of an eternal body and judgment compels us to please the Lord

5:1a

Now we know that if the earthly tent we live in is dismantled,

- ¶ For we^(incl) know that should the earthly tent in which we live be destroyed,
- ¶ Furthermore, we know that if someone destroys the temporary body that we have here on earth,
- ¶ We know that if this earthly body we live in like a tent is killed,

Now: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Now is often translated as “for” or “because.” It is not a time word. The conjunction may indicate that:

1. 5:1 explains 4:18.
2. 5:1 gives an example of 4:18. For example:

for instance (JBP)

1. 5:1 continues the theme of explaining from 4:18b.

In English, “for” allows all the above interpretations. Translate in a way that allows one or more of the above interpretations.

we: In 5:1–5, Paul probably used the pronoun we to include the believers in Corinth.

if: There are two ways to interpret the Greek word here:

1. The Greek refers to a possible event. For example:

if (NASB)

should (BSB, RSV, NIV, NASB, NABRE, NLT, GW, NET, REB, ESV, KJV)

1. The Greek refers to an event that is sure to happen. For example:

when (GNT) (GNT, NJB, CEV, NCV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because that is the usual meaning of the Greek word and because the interpretation of the word “destroyed” below allows for a possible event. Thrall (p. 362) says it refers to possible destruction. Martin (pp. 102–103) and Hughes (on TW) indicate that Paul has in mind the time when Jesus will return for his people and change those still alive so that they do not experience death (1 Corinthians 15:50–52).

the earthly tent we live in is dismantled: There are two issues:

Issue 1: Meaning

The Greek word that the BSB translates as dismantled has several meanings. There are two ways to interpret the Greek word here:

1. The Greek word means destroy. For example:

the earthly tent which is our house is torn down (NASB) (RSV, NIV, GNT, NASB, NABRE, CEV, REB, NCV, ESV)

1. The Greek word means disassemble. A person removes a tent’s pegs and poles from the ground, then he folds the tent to get ready to move to a new place. For example:

the tent that houses us on earth is folded up (NJB) (BSB, NJB, NLT, GW, NET)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because that is the usual meaning of the Greek word and because Paul was probably thinking of the persecution of 1:8–9 and wondering if someone might kill him for preaching about Jesus. Kruse (p. 112) refers to 4:16–5:10, where Paul wrote about the physical body “wasting away” through persecution and suffering. Thrall (p. 361) refers to “the prospect of death.” Harris (pp. 367, 371) translates the word as “is destroyed,” but allows that interpretation (2) is possible. Meaning Line 1 in the Display is an example of interpretation (1).

Issue 2: Passive

This clause is passive. It refers here to people destroying. Some languages must use an active clause. For example:

someone destroys the earthly tent we live in

people destroy the earthly tent in which we live

the earthly tent we live in: This phrase is a metaphor for our human bodies. A tent is a movable shelter. It is set up temporarily in one place and then taken down. Likewise, our earthly bodies only last while we live on earth. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

our earthly house, the tent we live in (NET)

the tent that houses us on earth (NJB)

the tent that is our earthly home (ESV)

In some languages a literal translation would wrongly refer only to an actual tent. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Translate it as a simile. For example:

our earthly dwelling...like a tent (JBP)

the life we live here on earth...like a tent (GW)

Our bodies are like tents that we live in here on earth. (CEV)

- Explain the meaning in your translation. For example:

this tent we live in—our body here on earth— (GNT)

our body—the tent we live in here on earth— (NCV)

- Translate the meaning without the metaphor. For example:

the life we live here on earth (GW)

our bodies that we only live in while here on earth
You may then want to explain the literal words in a footnote. For example:

Literally: “our earthly house that is a tent.” These words indicate that our earthly bodies are temporary like a tent.

- Translate literally and explain the meaning in a footnote. An example footnote is:

These words indicate that our earthly bodies are temporary like a tent.

tent: A tent is a temporary shelter. It can be made of sticks and animal skins or other materials that can be carried to another location and set up. In some languages people are not familiar with tents. If that is true in your language, use the word for a temporary shelter in which someone might live for a short time.

is dismantled: Here the word that the BSB translates as dismantled refers figuratively to being killed. If you translated the figurative meaning of the phrase “the earthly tent we live in” with “our earthly body,” you may want to translate the figurative meaning of dismantled here. For example:

is killed

5:1b

we have a building from God, an eternal house in heaven,

- we have an eternal building from God in which to live in heaven,
- we also know that God will give to us a permanent, heavenly body.
- we will have an eternal body, made by God himself, which is unlike a tent but is a permanent thing/building.

we have: The verb have is in the present tense. It is connected to “if the earthly tent we live in is destroyed.” So when we die, it is certain that we will each inhabit an eternal body.

In some languages a literal translation would wrongly imply that believers inhabit these eternal bodies while on earth. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Clearly indicate that 5:1b occurs when people die (5:1a). For example:

if the earthly tent we live in is destroyed, then at that time we have...

- Use the future tense. For example:

we will certainly have

God will give (CEV)

a building from God, an eternal house in heaven:

These words continue the metaphor of bodies being

like buildings. In this case, the building is eternal or permanent. It is not temporary like the tent in 5:1a. Other ways to translate this are:

a building from God...that is eternal in the heavens (NET)

a house for us from God...everlasting, in the heavens (NJB)

a building from God, a house...eternal in the heavens (ESV)

But if you followed one of the other options to translate the metaphor of a tent in 5:1a, you may want to follow the same option here:

- Translate it as a simile. For example:

an eternal body in heaven like a permanent building from God

the body in which we will live in heaven will be eternal, like a permanent house, and it will be made by God

- Explain the meaning in your translation. For example:

an eternal house—our body there in heaven, which God has promised—

God will have a body for us—a permanent home in heaven that will last forever—

- Translate the meaning without the metaphor. For example:

the heavenly body that will house us for eternity and that God will make

heavenly, eternal bodies from God You may then want to explain the literal words in a footnote. For example:

Literally: “a building from God, eternal and in heaven.” This saying indicates that God will make our heavenly bodies and they will last forever.

- Translate literally and explain the meaning in a footnote. An example footnote is:

This saying indicates that God will make our heavenly bodies and they will last forever.

from God: This phrase indicates that God creates the body for believers.

5:1c
not built by human hands.

- which is not built by mere people.
- That body originates/comes from God without any help from people.
- People are not involved at all in making that eternal body.

not built by human hands: Usually people make tents and buildings. But this phrase indicates that God makes an eternal body for each of us to live in. Other ways to translate this are:

a house not made with hands (RSV)

made for us by God himself and not by human hands (NLT)

a home he himself has made (GNT)

which people had no part in making

2 Corinthians 5:2

Section 5:1–10: The promise of life in heaven

In this section, Paul explained that after believers die, they will receive a heavenly body (5:1). He used the metaphor of a tent to refer to the earthly body and the metaphor of a building in heaven to refer to the heavenly body. Paul and his coworkers desired that the change would happen (5:2–4). He explained that God had given that desire and that God had also given the Holy Spirit so we can be assured that the promise of a heavenly body will be fulfilled (5:5).

Then Paul wrote that they were confident in their faith (5:6–8) and purposely chose to please God (5:9). He wrote the reason to do so, namely that all believers will be judged and rewarded by God for the things they have done (5:10).

Paul continued to use the pronoun “we” to refer to himself, Timothy, and others who traveled with him telling the good news about Jesus. But in some verses

in this section, the pronoun “we” probably includes the believers in Corinth and therefore all believers.

Other examples of headings for this section are:

Our Heavenly Dwelling (NIV)

The mortal body that we have and the eternal body that God has promised

Faith Guides Our Lives (GW)

God has promised a new, eternal body and so we live by faith/believing

The assurance of an eternal body and judgment compels us to please the Lord

5:2a

For in this tent we groan,

- For also we^(incl) groan in this earthly tent,
- And what’s more, we sigh in this life,

For in this tent we groan: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as For in this is literally “For also in this.” The phrase “For also” may indicate that:

1. 5:2 further explains 4:18.
2. 5:2 gives a further example of 4:18.

Translate in a way that allows one or both of the above interpretations. 5:1 also explained or gave an example of 4:18. See your translation of “for” (BSB: “Now”) in 5:1.

groan: The Greek word that the BSB translates as groan can also mean “sigh.” This sound is made by:

1. a person who is suffering or troubled;
2. a person who is anticipating that something good is going happen.

Probably both are implied here. Paul probably groaned over all his difficulties and physical aches and problems because he was still in the earthly tent. But he also sighed, waiting for God to clothe him in his heavenly body. If possible, use a word that allows both interpretations. For example:

sigh (GNT)

5:2b

longing to be clothed with our heavenly dwelling,

- desiring to be clothed with our heavenly building,

- because we earnestly want God to give to us our heavenly bodies like putting on us clothing.

longing: This word refers to wanting something very much. Other ways to translate this word are:

earnestly desiring (KJV)

yearning (REB)

to be clothed with our heavenly dwelling: This clause is passive. God will clothe believers. Some languages must use an active clause. For example:

for God to clothe us with our heavenly dwelling

clothed: Here this verb refers figuratively to God exchanging the earthly body for a heavenly body. He will remove the temporary, earthly one and replace it with an eternal, heavenly one.

In some languages a literal translation would wrongly refer only to putting on clothing. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Explain the meaning in your translation. For example:

exchange like clothing

- Translate the meaning without the metaphor. For example:

exchange

with our heavenly dwelling: This phrase continues the metaphor from 5:1b. Translate this phrase in a similar way to how you translated the phrase “an eternal house in heaven.” For example:

- Translate literally. Do not repeat the footnote here.
- Translate it as a simile. For example:

with a body like a heavenly building

with a body that will be like our heavenly house

- Explain the meaning in your translation. For example:

with our heavenly house—an eternal body—

with a heavenly body—a home in heaven—

- Translate the meaning without the metaphor. For example:

with our heavenly body

with heavenly bodies for us

2 Corinthians 5:3

Section 5:1–10: The promise of life in heaven

In this section, Paul explained that after believers die, they will receive a heavenly body (5:1). He used the metaphor of a tent to refer to the earthly body and the metaphor of a building in heaven to refer to the heavenly body. Paul and his coworkers desired that the change would happen (5:2–4). He explained that God had given that desire and that God had also given the Holy Spirit so we can be assured that the promise of a heavenly body will be fulfilled (5:5).

Then Paul wrote that they were confident in their faith (5:6–8) and purposely chose to please God (5:9). He wrote the reason to do so, namely that all believers will be judged and rewarded by God for the things they have done (5:10).

Paul continued to use the pronoun “we” to refer to himself, Timothy, and others who traveled with him telling the good news about Jesus. But in some verses in this section, the pronoun “we” probably includes the believers in Corinth and therefore all believers.

Other examples of headings for this section are:

Our Heavenly Dwelling (NIV)

The mortal body that we have and the eternal body that God has promised

Faith Guides Our Lives (GW)

God has promised a new, eternal body and so we live by faith/believing

The assurance of an eternal body and judgment compels us to please the Lord

5:3a

because when we are clothed,

- assuming, of course, that when we^(incl) have put it on,

- For when we receive our heavenly bodies and put them on,

because when we are clothed: There is a textual issue here. The Greek NT 4 indicates that there are three different verbs in the various ancient Greek manuscripts here. Two mean “unclothed” and one means “clothed.” The Greek NT 4 indicates a significant degree of doubt as to which is the original verb. Fourteen English versions in Translator’s Workplace follow the Greek verb that means “clothed.” It is recommended that you follow “clothed” here. Of the English versions in Translator’s Workplace, only the NRSV follows “unclothed.” The Greek NT 4 also recommends it. As “unclothed,” the verse would indicate that when we die and lose our earthly body (5:1a), we will not be “naked.” That means we will not exist as spirits only but will inhabit our eternal bodies. The Greek clause is literally “if indeed also we are clothed.” Here the word “if” is used rhetorically. Paul believes we are clothed to be true. Using “if” requires that readers think about what Paul said and agree with him. The word does not express doubt here. Here the word “indeed” emphasizes the meaning of “if.” Other ways to translate this clause are:

if we are indeed assured that we are clothed

because it will clothe us so (NCV)

After we have indeed clothed ourselves with it

when we are clothed: This clause continues the metaphor of wearing a body like clothing from 5:2b. It indicates that the person has already put on the clothes. It implies that the person has not removed the clothes. The clause looks at the time after the longing is fulfilled and the person has been clothed in 5:2b. Other ways to translate this are:

After we have put it on (GW)

being clothed (GNT)

Use the same method to translate this clause that you used in 5:1b or 5:2b. For example:

- Translate literally. See the examples above.
- Translate it as a simile. For example:

when we become like someone clothed

when we become like someone who put clothing on

- Explain the meaning in your translation. For example:

when we are clothed, namely that we have that heavenly body

when we gain that body like putting on heavenly clothing

- Translate the meaning without the metaphor. For example:

when we receive it

when we gain that body

5:3b we will not be found naked.

- we will not be naked.
- we will not be like someone naked.
- we will not be naked, namely without a body.

we will not be found naked: This clause repeats a similar meaning to “we are clothed.” It emphasizes the result of receiving a heavenly body.

This clause is passive. Here the passive probably only indicates being naked. It probably does not indicate someone seeing them naked. In some languages an active clause must be used. If so, translate in a way that only indicates being naked. For example:

we will not be naked

This clause continues the metaphor of a body being like clothing. Use the same method to translate this clause that you used above.

- Translate literally. Another example is:

we shall not prove to be naked

- Translate it as a simile. For example:

we will not be like someone naked

- Explain the meaning in your translation. For example:

we will not be naked, namely, without a heavenly body

we will not be without that body like a naked person

- Translate the meaning without the metaphor. For example:

we will not be without a heavenly body

we will not be without that body

2 Corinthians 5:4

Section 5:1–10: The promise of life in heaven

In this section, Paul explained that after believers die, they will receive a heavenly body (5:1). He used the metaphor of a tent to refer to the earthly body and the metaphor of a building in heaven to refer to the heavenly body. Paul and his coworkers desired that the change would happen (5:2–4). He explained that God had given that desire and that God had also given the Holy Spirit so we can be assured that the promise of a heavenly body will be fulfilled (5:5).

Then Paul wrote that they were confident in their faith (5:6–8) and purposely chose to please God (5:9). He wrote the reason to do so, namely that all believers will be judged and rewarded by God for the things they have done (5:10).

Paul continued to use the pronoun “we” to refer to himself, Timothy, and others who traveled with him telling the good news about Jesus. But in some verses in this section, the pronoun “we” probably includes the believers in Corinth and therefore all believers.

Other examples of headings for this section are:

Our Heavenly Dwelling (NIV)

The mortal body that we have and the eternal body that God has promised

Faith Guides Our Lives (GW)

God has promised a new, eternal body and so we live by faith/believing

The assurance of an eternal body and judgment compels us to please the Lord

5:4a

So while we are in this tent,

- For also, while we^(incl) are in this earthly tent,
- While we temporarily live here on earth,
- Furthermore, during the time we live in this earthly body like a tent,

So: The Greek phrase is literally “for also.” The words “For also” indicate that Paul explained further about what he wrote in 5:2. Other ways to translate this Greek phrase are:

For indeed (NASB)

...indeed (REB)

Some languages can allow the context to imply the connection and do not need to translate these Greek words.

while we are in this tent: This clause continues the metaphor of the earthly body being like a tent. Paul explained why he groaned and felt burdened in 5:4b–c.

5:4b

we groan under our burdens,

- we groan and have difficulties/troubles,
- we often sigh and are troubled,
- we groan and many things burden us.

we groan under our burdens: There are several ways to interpret the phrase our burdens:

1. This phrase refers to all difficulties while living on earth, including the difficulties Paul experienced because he was a believer and an apostle. For example:

we groan under our burden (NRSV) (BSB, NIV, NJB, NRSV, NASB, NABRE, CEV, NET, NCV, ESV, KJV)

1. This phrase refers only to other people causing difficulties for Paul and his coworkers because they were believers and apostles. For example:

We groan...we are oppressed (REB) (GNT, REB)

1. This phrase refers to worries. For example:

we sigh with anxiety (RSV) (RSV, GW)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because Paul has talked about more kinds of difficulties than oppression or anxiety in this book. For

example: 4:16b. Thrall (p. 380) says that this phrase may refer in part to Paul's suffering as an apostle.

Other ways to translate this phrase following interpretation (1) are:

we groan, being burdened (NASB)

we groan, and we experience many difficulties/troubles

under our burdens: In Greek this clause is passive and is literally "being burdened." Many things, including disease, injuries, and enemies of God cause trouble. Some languages must use an active clause. For example:

many things burden us

various things cause us trouble

5:4c

because we do not wish to be unclothed

- in that we have no desire to be stripped of it,
- inasmuch as we do not want to leave our temporary bodies at death,
- For we do not wish to leave this earthly body/tent and have no body,

because we do not wish to be unclothed: The metaphor of the body being like clothing continues from the previous verses. This phrase refers to the process of removing the earthly body. Paul was saying that it is not (negatively) that he wants to leave this life, but that (positively) he wants to enter into the heavenly life. For example:

it is not that we want to get rid of our earthly body, but that we want to have the heavenly one put on over us (GNT)

Other ways to translate this are:

not that we want to be stripped of our covering (NJB)

because we do not want to have the old body stripped off (REB)

For we do not want to be left without any covering

Translate the metaphor in a similar way as you did in the previous verses. For example:

- Translate literally. Another example is:

for we do not desire to be unclothed

- Translate it as a simile. For example:

because we do not want to be like someone who is naked

- Explain the meaning in your translation. For example:

because we do not want to be unclothed, namely without a body

because we do not want to die and be without that earthly body like a naked person

- Translate the meaning without the metaphor. For example:

because we do not want to be without that body

because we do not want to die and be without that body

to be unclothed: This clause is passive. Death will cause the person to leave the body. Some languages must use an active clause. For example:

for death to unclothe us

[to die and leave the earthly tent

5:4d

but clothed,

- but to be clothed with our heavenly building,
- but we want God to give to us our heavenly bodies like putting clothing on us,
- but we wish to receive that eternal life with its heavenly body.

but clothed: The words "we wish to be" are implied here from 5:4c. In some languages it is more natural to include the implied words. For example:

but we wish to be clothed...

clothed: These words continue the metaphor from the previous verses. Translate this in the same way as you translated it in 5:2. In some languages it is necessary to say with what Paul wanted to be clothed. For example:

but to be clothed instead with our heavenly dwelling (NIV)

but we do want to put on the eternal house (GW)

The Greek does not have a word or phrase describing with what Paul wanted to be clothed, and many English versions do not have one either. However, it is clearly implied from 5:2b, and so a descriptive word or phrase can be supplied. Express the meaning in a way that is natural in your language.

5:4e

so that our mortality may be swallowed up by life.

- so that these bodies that will die will be swallowed by eternal life.
- in order that life will fill the new existence completely and the mortal life will be gone.
- Then this body that dies will be fully covered with life. (NCV)

so that: This connecting phrase introduces the purpose for being “clothed” with our heavenly dwelling. Another way to translate this phrase is:

in order that

our mortality may be swallowed up by life: The metaphor of swallowed up refers to eternal life completely replacing the mortality or condition of earthly life. Other ways to translate this clause are:

this mortal being/existence will be swallowed by life

what is mortal will be transformed by life (GNT)

This clause is passive. Some languages must use an active clause. For example:

eternal life may/will swallow this mortal being/existence

God will transform what is mortal into what has eternal life

In some languages translating the metaphor literally is not natural. The GNT example and the last example above translate the meaning of the metaphor. Other ways to translate this metaphor are:

our mortality may be absorbed into life immortal (REB)

this body that dies will be fully covered with life (NCV)

this mortal life will be completely taken over by eternal life as if swallowed up

life will fill the new existence completely and the earthly mortal life is gone

our mortality: This phrase indicates that the earthly bodies will die. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

these bodies that will die (CEV)

the body which is subject to death

life: Here this word refers to eternal life. It implies that the heavenly body will rule a believer’s existence in heaven.

2 Corinthians 5:5

Section 5:1–10: The promise of life in heaven

In this section, Paul explained that after believers die, they will receive a heavenly body (5:1). He used the metaphor of a tent to refer to the earthly body and the metaphor of a building in heaven to refer to the heavenly body. Paul and his coworkers desired that the change would happen (5:2–4). He explained that God had given that desire and that God had also given the Holy Spirit so we can be assured that the promise of a heavenly body will be fulfilled (5:5).

Then Paul wrote that they were confident in their faith (5:6–8) and purposely chose to please God (5:9). He wrote the reason to do so, namely that all believers will be judged and rewarded by God for the things they have done (5:10).

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Our Heavenly Dwelling (NIV)

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Faith Guides Our Lives (GW)

God has promised a new, eternal body and so we live by faith/believing

The assurance of an eternal body and judgment compels us to please the Lord

5:5a-b

And God has prepared us for this very purpose and has given us the Spirit as a pledge of what is to come: The Greek words are literally “Now the one having prepared us for this very thing is God, the one having given to us the deposit of the Spirit.” The clause “the one having given to us the deposit of the Spirit” tells the reader more about God.

In some languages a literal translation would wrongly indicate that Paul was thinking of other gods and only this one has given to us the deposit of the Spirit. If that is true in your language, translate that clause in a way that tells more about God. One way to do that is to start a new sentence here or translate it as an independent clause. For example:

Now it is God who has made us for this very purpose. He has given us the Spirit as a deposit, guaranteeing what is to come.

Now the one having prepared us for this very thing is God. He has given to us the deposit of the Spirit.

God is the one who has prepared us for this change, and he gave us his Spirit as the guarantee of all that he has in store for us. (GNT)

5:5a

And God has prepared us for this very purpose

- Now the one who has prepared us^(incl) for this very thing is God,
- It is God himself who created us for this new existence/life.

has prepared us: The Greek word that the BSB translates as prepared refers generally to preparing, equipping, or creating something. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

has created us

for this very purpose: This phrase probably refers back to 5:4e. Translate so that it clearly refers back to believers gaining eternal life in 5:4e. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

for this very thing (RSV)

for this change (GNT)

5:5b

and has given us the Spirit as a pledge of what is to come.

- and has given to us the Holy Spirit as a pledge.
- He has also given to us the Holy Spirit, which is like a first payment toward fulfilling all the promises of God.

has given us: Here the pronoun us refer to people who received what was given. This phrase implies that God gave. In some languages it is more natural to repeat the implied word here. For example:

God has given to us

the Spirit as a pledge of what is to come: The Greek phrase is literally “the first payment of the Spirit.” Here the word Spirit refers to the Holy Spirit. In this metaphor of paying a large amount, this “first payment” is a pledge to pay the rest. The Holy Spirit is that “first payment” or pledge. The rest of the payment is the heavenly body, living in heaven with God, and other rewards. God has promised all these things to believers. But believers receive the Holy Spirit while on earth as a pledge for the rest. Other ways to translate this Greek phrase are:

the Spirit as a deposit, guaranteeing what is to come (NIV)

the Spirit as a down payment (NET)

Rather than translate “first payment” literally, in some languages it is more natural to explain the meaning in

some way. The BSB does this by saying pledge. Other examples are:

the Spirit to be a guarantee for this new life (NCV)

his Spirit as the guarantee of all that he has in store for us (GNT)

the Holy Spirit, which is like a first payment toward fulfilling all the promises of God

his Spirit to show that we can be certain that he will do as he promised

2 Corinthians 5:6

Section 5:1–10: The promise of life in heaven

In this section, Paul explained that after believers die, they will receive a heavenly body (5:1). He used the metaphor of a tent to refer to the earthly body and the metaphor of a building in heaven to refer to the heavenly body. Paul and his coworkers desired that the change would happen (5:2–4). He explained that God had given that desire and that God had also given the Holy Spirit so we can be assured that the promise of a heavenly body will be fulfilled (5:5).

Then Paul wrote that they were confident in their faith (5:6–8) and purposely chose to please God (5:9). He wrote the reason to do so, namely that all believers will be judged and rewarded by God for the things they have done (5:10).

Paul continued to use the pronoun “we” to refer to himself, Timothy, and others who traveled with him telling the good news about Jesus. But in some verses in this section, the pronoun “we” probably includes the believers in Corinth and therefore all believers.

Other examples of headings for this section are:

Our Heavenly Dwelling (NIV)

The mortal body that we have and the eternal body that God has promised

Faith Guides Our Lives (GW)

God has promised a new, eternal body and so we live by faith/believing

The assurance of an eternal body and judgment compels us to please the Lord

5:6a–b

Therefore we are always confident, although we know that: There are several ways to interpret the Greek word that the BSB translates as although:

1. The word means and. It introduces another thing that Paul wants to say. For example:

Therefore we are always full of courage, and we know that (NET) (NIV, NASB, NET, JBP)

1. It introduces a reason for confidence. For example:

We are always full of confidence, then, realising that (NJB) (RSV, NJB, KJV)

1. It introduces a concessive idea (“even though”). (BSB, NLT, NRSV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because that is the usual meaning of the word. Furnish (p. 272) says that the word “seems to require one to take knowing as coordinate with having confidence.” Hughes (on TW) says, “The good courage...is enhanced by the knowledge (“knowing”) that....” BDAG (pp. 494–496) does not list this verse but says the word can mean “that is” (meaning 1.c.) or be a replacement for ὅτι (“that”) (1.b.β). But no scholar refers to those possible meanings, nor does the context seem to imply either one. See Meaning Line 1 in the Display for an example of interpretation (1).

5:6a

Therefore we are always confident,

- ¶ So, we^(incl) are full of confidence
- ¶ Therefore, we are boldly certain about those things

Therefore: This conjunction indicates that the things said in 5:1–5 are the reasons for what Paul said here.

we are always confident: The word confident refers to fully believing something. Paul had no doubts about God’s promise to give the heavenly body. Other ways to translate this clause are:

We are always full of confidence (NJB)

we never doubt

we are always certain about these things

Your language may use an idiom for this meaning. For example:

we stand firm in our minds

our hearts are always strong

5:6b

although we know that while we are at home in the body,

- and we know that as long as we are at home in these bodies
- and know that while we live in our earthly bodies,

while we are at home in the body: Here the word body refers to the earthly body. This clause refers to the time we are alive on the earth. Other ways to translate this clause are:

as long as we are at home in the body (NIV)

as long as we live in these bodies (NLT)

while we live in this earthly body

5:6c

we are away from the Lord.

- we are living away from the Lord. (GW)
- we are not yet living in the presence of the Lord God.

we are away from the Lord: This phrase indicates that while we live on earth we are not face to face with the Lord as we will be after we die and go to heaven. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

we are living away from the Lord (GW)

we are not at home with the Lord (NLT)

we are not yet where the Lord is

from the Lord: Here the word Lord may refer to:

1. God.
2. Jesus.

If possible, translate in a way that allows both interpretations.

The context is not clear as to which to prefer, but 5:5a does speak of God. Some languages must say who the

Lord is. If that is true in your language, you should refer to God. For example:

from the Lord God

Lord: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Lord means “the one in authority over (something)” or “master.” It refers to someone who has greater status or power. Another way to translate this word is:

ruler

See how you translated the word Lord in 3:16 or 4:14.

2 Corinthians 5:7

Section 5:1–10: The promise of life in heaven

In this section, Paul explained that after believers die, they will receive a heavenly body (5:1). He used the metaphor of a tent to refer to the earthly body and the metaphor of a building in heaven to refer to the heavenly body. Paul and his coworkers desired that the change would happen (5:2–4). He explained that God had given that desire and that God had also given the Holy Spirit so we can be assured that the promise of a heavenly body will be fulfilled (5:5).

Then Paul wrote that they were confident in their faith (5:6–8) and purposely chose to please God (5:9). He wrote the reason to do so, namely that all believers will be judged and rewarded by God for the things they have done (5:10).

Paul continued to use the pronoun “we” to refer to himself, Timothy, and others who traveled with him telling the good news about Jesus. But in some verses in this section, the pronoun “we” probably includes the believers in Corinth and therefore all believers.

Other examples of headings for this section are:

Our Heavenly Dwelling (NIV)

The mortal body that we have and the eternal body that God has promised

Faith Guides Our Lives (GW)

God has promised a new, eternal body and so we live by faith/believing

The assurance of an eternal body and judgment compels us to please the Lord

5:7**For we walk by faith, not by sight.**

- For we^(incl) live by means of believing in him and not by means of seeing him.
- We live by what we believe, not by what we can see. (NCV)

For: This verse begins with a conjunction that is often translated as “because” or “for.” Here the conjunction introduces an explanation of the way in which we are “away from the Lord.” Some languages can allow the context to indicate that 5:7 explains 5:6c and do not need to translate the conjunction.

we walk by faith, not by sight: Here, the verb walk refers figuratively to the way people live. Other ways to translate this clause are:

we live by faith, not by sight (NIV)

we live through believing and not through seeing

our lives are guided by faith, not by sight (GW)

Our lives are based on what we believe, not on what we can see

we follow the Lord from our faith, not from our seeing him Uma Back Translation on TW.

by faith: This phrase indicates that we live by means of faith or according to faith. We believe in the Lord, whom we cannot see (5:6c). He guides our lives. See the examples above.

not by sight: This phrase indicates that we do not live by means of seeing or according to what we see. See the examples above.

2 Corinthians 5:8**Section 5:1–10: The promise of life in heaven**

In this section, Paul explained that after believers die, they will receive a heavenly body (5:1). He used the metaphor of a tent to refer to the earthly body and the metaphor of a building in heaven to refer to the heavenly body. Paul and his coworkers desired that the change would happen (5:2–4). He explained that God had given that desire and that God had also given the Holy Spirit so we can be assured that the promise of a heavenly body will be fulfilled (5:5).

Then Paul wrote that they were confident in their faith (5:6–8) and purposely chose to please God (5:9). He

wrote the reason to do so, namely that all believers will be judged and rewarded by God for the things they have done (5:10).

Paul continued to use the pronoun “we” to refer to himself, Timothy, and others who traveled with him telling the good news about Jesus. But in some verses in this section, the pronoun “we” probably includes the believers in Corinth and therefore all believers.

Other examples of headings for this section are:

Our Heavenly Dwelling (NIV)

The mortal body that we have and the eternal body that God has promised

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The assurance of an eternal body and judgment compels us to please the Lord

5:8a**We are confident, then,**

- I repeat, we^(incl) are confident
- As I said, we have confidence,

We are confident, then: The Greek word that the BSB translates as then is used to resume talking about a previous theme. Here, Paul resumes speaking about being confident (5:6). Other ways to translate this are:

Again I say, we never doubt

Furthermore, we are always certain

Some languages can allow the context to continue the theme and do not need to translate the Greek word.

We are confident: This clause is repeated from 5:6a, but without the word “always” here.

5:8b**and would prefer to be away from the body**

- and would much prefer to leave our home in the body (GNT)
- and we would be pleased to be away from our earthly bodies

would prefer to be away from the body: Here the word body refers to our earthly bodies. Paul says here that he would rather not be in his body; he would prefer to be in heaven. Other ways to translate this clause are:

we would rather be away from these earthly bodies (NLT)

we would be pleased to be away from our earthly bodies

we...long instead to be exiled from the body (NJB)

5:8c

and at home with the Lord.

- and be at home with the Lord. (GNT)
- and go and stay with the Lord God in heaven.

be...at home with the Lord: Here the phrase at home refers to living face to face with the Lord in heaven. When we die, we go to heaven and God gives heavenly bodies to us. The words “we would prefer to be” are implied from 5:8a–b. Other ways to translate this clause are:

be present with the Lord (NKJV)

we would prefer to live with the Lord

go and stay with the Lord in heaven

2 Corinthians 5:9

Section 5:1–10: The promise of life in heaven

In this section, Paul explained that after believers die, they will receive a heavenly body (5:1). He used the metaphor of a tent to refer to the earthly body and the metaphor of a building in heaven to refer to the heavenly body. Paul and his coworkers desired that the change would happen (5:2–4). He explained that God had given that desire and that God had also given the Holy Spirit so we can be assured that the promise of a heavenly body will be fulfilled (5:5).

Then Paul wrote that they were confident in their faith (5:6–8) and purposely chose to please God (5:9). He wrote the reason to do so, namely that all believers will be judged and rewarded by God for the things they have done (5:10).

Paul continued to use the pronoun “we” to refer to himself, Timothy, and others who traveled with him

telling the good news about Jesus. But in some verses in this section, the pronoun “we” probably includes the believers in Corinth and therefore all believers.

Other examples of headings for this section are:

Our Heavenly Dwelling (NIV)

The mortal body that we have and the eternal body that God has promised

Faith Guides Our Lives (GW)

God has promised a new, eternal body and so we live by faith/believing

The assurance of an eternal body and judgment compels us to please the Lord

5:9a

So we aspire to please Him,

- And therefore, our^(incl) aim/goal is to please him,
- In conclusion, we set our goal as pleasing him in everything we do.

So: This conjunction introduces Paul’s conclusion about what he said in 5:1–8. For example:

Therefore (NASB)

This verse part begins with a Greek word that means “also” here. Pleasing God is in addition to living by faith. For example:

we also have as our ambition...to be pleasing to Him (NASB)

we aspire to please Him: The phrase aspire to please Him indicates that Paul aspires to please God. Other ways to translate this clause are:

we make it our ambition to please him (NJB)

our goal is to please him (NLT)

our most important purpose/motive for living the way we do is that he be pleased with us

we say to ourselves, “We will live in a way that pleases him”

we really want to do what God wants us to do,
which pleases him

Him: This pronoun refers to the Lord (5:8c).

5:9b

whether we are here in this body or away from it.

- whether we are at home in this earthly body or away from it,
- This is true whether we are living here or have left.

whether we are here in this body or away from it: The Greek phrase is literally “whether at home or away from home.” The word here continues to be the metaphor for being in the earthly body. Harris (p. 368) translates “at home” as “resident in the body,” which he refers to as the present way of life on earth (p. 404). The BSB and other versions add the phrase in this body to make the meaning of the metaphor clear. Other ways to translate this clause are:

whether we are alive or away (NET)

Whether we live in the body or move out of it (GW)

whether we are here in this body or away from this body (NLT)

2 Corinthians 5:10

Section 5:1–10: The promise of life in heaven

In this section, Paul explained that after believers die, they will receive a heavenly body (5:1). He used the metaphor of a tent to refer to the earthly body and the metaphor of a building in heaven to refer to the heavenly body. Paul and his coworkers desired that the change would happen (5:2–4). He explained that God had given that desire and that God had also given the Holy Spirit so we can be assured that the promise of a heavenly body will be fulfilled (5:5).

Then Paul wrote that they were confident in their faith (5:6–8) and purposely chose to please God (5:9). He wrote the reason to do so, namely that all believers will be judged and rewarded by God for the things they have done (5:10).

Paul continued to use the pronoun “we” to refer to himself, Timothy, and others who traveled with him telling the good news about Jesus. But in some verses in this section, the pronoun “we” probably includes the believers in Corinth and therefore all believers.

Other examples of headings for this section are:

Our Heavenly Dwelling (NIV)

The mortal body that we have and the eternal body that God has promised

Faith Guides Our Lives (GW)

God has promised a new, eternal body and so we live by faith/believing

The assurance of an eternal body and judgment compels us to please the Lord

5:10a

For we must all appear before the judgment seat of Christ,

- for each of our^(incl) lives will be revealed before Christ in his place as judge,
- Because God will reveal all that every one of us have done before Christ our judge,

For: Here this word introduces the reason for aiming to please God (5:9a). For example:

because (NCV)

we must all appear before the judgment seat of Christ: The Greek word that the BSB translates as appear means “be revealed.” It indicates that God will reveal all that a person has done and said. Christ will hear all of it and judge them as in a court of justice.

Other ways to translate this clause are:

everything about us will be revealed before Christ our judge

God will reveal everything about us in front of Christ’s judgment seat

we must all have our lives laid open before the tribunal of Christ (REB)

the judgment seat of Christ: The phrase judgment seat refers to the place where a judge sits when he rules a court and decides court cases. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

Christ, who will sit as judge

Christ, to be judged by him (GNT)

Christ so that he will judge us

Christ: The word Christ is a title for Jesus. The word Christ literally means “the anointed one.” Translate the word Christ here as you did in 1:1.

5:10b

that each one may receive his due

- in order that each one of us^(incl) may receive what we deserve
- so that he would reward/compensate each one

that: This conjunction introduces the purpose for appearing before Christ. Here is another way to translate this:

so that (RSV)

each one may receive his due: This clause indicates that Jesus will give a judgment according to what each believer did. Other ways to translate this clause are:

We will each receive what we deserve (GNT)

each one may receive...according to (RSV)

each one may be recompensed (NASB)

each one may be paid back (NET)

he will reward each one

The Scriptures do not teach that Jesus will punish believers in heaven. Avoid translating in a way that indicates Jesus will punish believers. See also note on “bad” below.

5:10c

for the things done in the body, whether good or bad.

- for things that we did while in this earthly body, whether good or bad/worthless.
- according to whatever we^(incl) did while living on earth, whether those deeds were good or bad/immoral.

the things done in the body: This phrase refers to deeds that believers do while living on earth. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

what we did when we lived in our bodies (JBP)

everything we have done...in our bodily life (GNT)

whatever we did while living on earth in these bodies

all that we have done in this earthly body

whether good or bad: There are two ways to interpret where this phrase connects:

1. This phrase connects to the things done. For example:

the good or the bad that we do while living in these bodies (CEV) (BSB, NIV, GNT, NJB, NRSV, NABRE, NASB, KJV, NLT, GW, CEV, NET, REB, ESV, KJV)

1. This phrase connects to receive what is due. For example:

each one may receive good or evil, according to what he has done (RSV) (RSV, NCV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Harris (p. 407) says that “good or bad” should be connected to with the prior phrase “the things done” rather than the further away phrase “may receive what is due him.” Thrall (p. 357), Martin (p. 97), Kistemaker (p. 180), and Barrett (p. 160) support interpretation (1). See also the note on bad below.

bad: The Greek word that the BSB translates as bad means “morally wrong” or “worthless.” These deeds do not honor God. Jesus will discard these worthless deeds. He will not reward them. Other ways to translate this word are:

immoral

of no value

2 Corinthians 5:11

Section 5:11–6:2: Allow God to reconcile with you

In this section, Paul explained the goal that he and his coworkers had (5:11a–b). He also said that God knew and approved of what they did (5:11c). He wrote that their accomplishments should cause the believers in Corinth to be proud of them (5:12). The basis for 5:13 may be that the false teachers had accused Paul of being crazy. Sometimes obeying God requires doing things which do not make sense to people who do

not know God. Paul also explained the basis for his ministry (5:14–15).

He explained the new way believers should think of each other (5:16–17). He explained the basis for that new way of thinking (5:18–19). He told them that apostles are like ambassadors for Christ, and he urged people to be reconciled to God (5:20). He explained the basis for believers becoming righteous (5:21). He urged believers to follow God completely (6:1–2).

Other examples of headings for this section are:

The Ministry of Reconciliation (NIV)

Paul explained the basis for his ministry

Friendship with God through Christ (GNT)

God wants all people to reconcile with him

5:11a–b

Therefore, since we know what it means to fear the Lord, we try to persuade men: The first part, we know what it means to fear the Lord, is the basis or reason for persuading people. For example:

We know what it means to fear the Lord, and so we try to persuade others (GNT)

men: Here the word men is general and refers to both men and women. Here is another way to translate this:

people (NCV)

5:11a

Therefore, since we know what it means to fear the Lord,

- ¶ So then, always having/experiencing the fear of the Lord,
- ¶ Therefore, we^(excl) always revere the Lord God in great awe,

Therefore, since we know: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates literally as Therefore indicates that 5:11 is the result of what Paul said in the preceding verses. Here is another way to translate this:

Therefore, knowing (NASB)

we know: Here the word know refers to having the attitude of fearing the Lord. The word does not refer

to only knowing about something. The word also does not refer to only knowing the meaning of the words. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

we have/experience

always in mind (NJB)

what it means to fear the Lord: This Greek phrase is literally “the fear of the Lord” (as in the RSV). Here the word fear refers to:

1. knowing that God rules all things, including each person’s life;
2. knowing that one day God will judge each person;
3. awe that God is holy and all powerful;
4. reverence and honor to God.

The word fear does not imply that God is cruel, mean, or arbitrary.

In some languages a literal translation would not have the meaning as above. If that is true in your language, translate “the fear of the Lord” a way that indicates all or most of the above meaning. For example:

reverence and awe to the Lord

to respect the Lord (CEV)

the Lord: This phrase probably refers to God here.

5:11b

we try to persuade men.

- we^(excl) exhort/urge people to believe.
- and so help people to accept the truth.

we try to persuade men: The Greek words do not say what Paul was trying to persuade men to believe. There are several ways to translate the Greek:

1. Paul was trying to persuade people to believe in Jesus. 5:11b connects to 5:11a, and 5:11a would imply his responsibility to preach about Jesus. For example:

encourage everyone to turn to him (CEV) (CEV)

1. Paul was trying to persuade people that he was sincere and his ministry was proper. 5:11b connects to 5:11c–d, and 5:11c–d would imply his concern about what the believers in Corinth were thinking about him. For example:

we try to help people accept the truth about us (NCV) (NCV)

The BSB and many other English versions translate literally and do not say what or who is believed in. A literal translation in some languages would imply interpretation (1). Thrall (p. 400), Harris (p. 411), Martin (p. 117), Kistemaker (p. 173), Barrett (p. 161), Furnish (p. 305), and Hughes (on TW), in their translations, do not add what thing Paul was persuading people about. But Harris (p. 413) says that Paul was trying to convince the people “of the truth of the gospel.” If that is true in your language, you may want to translate literally. But if a literal translation would imply interpretation (2), you should translate according to interpretation (1).

Some languages must say what Paul was trying to persuade the people to believe. If that is true in your language, follow interpretation (1), since 5:11b is closely connected to 5:11a in the Greek.

try to persuade men: The Greek word that the BSB translates as try to persuade refers to talking to people with the intent to convince them of something. The Greek word does not imply that everyone is convinced. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

exhort/urge people to believe

try to help people accept the truth (NCV)

The Greek phrase indicates an ongoing action. For example:

are persuading people

are trying to persuade people

men: Here the word men is general and refers to both men and women. Here is another way to translate this:

others (GNT)

5:11c

What we are is clear to God,

- We are well known to God,
- God knows what we truly are,

This sentence begins with a Greek conjunction that probably introduces a new part of the same theme from 5:11a–b. In English, such a connection is often indicated with a new sentence with no conjunction. For example:

God himself knows... (CEV)

What we are is clear to God: This clause indicates that God knew all things about Paul and the other evangelists. There was nothing about them that was hidden from God. Other ways to translate this clause are:

we ourselves are well known to God (NRSV)

God knows us completely (GNT)

God sees us for what we are (NJB)

God knows what we truly are

5:11d

and I hope it is clear to your conscience as well.

- and I hope that we are also well known to your consciences. (NRSV)
- and I expect that you also know in your^(plur) hearts what we truly are.

I hope it is clear to your conscience as well: Here the word hope probably means “expect but possibly with some doubt.” It indicates that Paul desired that the believers would clearly understand his own life and ministry and that of the others. But he was perhaps a bit worried that the false teachers would deceive them into thinking that he was not a true apostle. So he hoped it was plain to them. Other ways to translate this clause are:

I hope that we are also well known to your consciences (NRSV)

I hope that in your hearts you truly know us as well

I expect that you see us for what we are in your consciences

conscience: The Greek word that the BSB translates as conscience refers to the memories of past deeds. Paul expected the believers to use their conscience and honestly evaluate his life and ministry and decide he had done nothing wrong. Other ways to translate this word are:

inner being

convictions of the mind

See how you translated this word in 1:12 or 4:2.

2 Corinthians 5:12

Section 5:11–6:2: Allow God to reconcile with you

In this section, Paul explained the goal that he and his coworkers had (5:11a–b). He also said that God knew and approved of what they did (5:11c). He wrote that their accomplishments should cause the believers in Corinth to be proud of them (5:12). The basis for 5:13 may be that the false teachers had accused Paul of being crazy. Sometimes obeying God requires doing things which do not make sense to people who do not know God. Paul also explained the basis for his ministry (5:14–15).

He explained the new way believers should think of each other (5:16–17). He explained the basis for that new way of thinking (5:18–19). He told them that apostles are like ambassadors for Christ, and he urged people to be reconciled to God (5:20). He explained the basis for believers becoming righteous (5:21). He urged believers to follow God completely (6:1–2).

Other examples of headings for this section are:

The Ministry of Reconciliation (NIV)

Paul explained the basis for his ministry

Friendship with God through Christ (GNT)

God wants all people to reconcile with him

5:12a

We are not commending ourselves to you again.

- We are not commending ourselves to you again, (RSV)
- We are not trying again to recommend ourselves to you, (GNT)

commending ourselves: The word commending refers to introducing or recommending someone to others. If a person is not known to a group, someone else who is known to both might introduce him to the group. That way the group will think well of the new person. Other ways to translate this word are:

recommend ourselves (REB)

show...our qualifications (GW)

See how you translated this phrase in 3:1.

5:12b

Instead, we are giving you an occasion to be proud of us,

- but we^(excl) make it possible for you^(plur) to speak highly of us,
- but are presenting an occasion/chance for you to be proud of us.

are giving you: Here the verb “give” refers to making the opportunity possible. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

are offering to you

make possible for you

an occasion: There are two ways to interpret the Greek word that the BSB translates as occasion:

1. This word refers to a favorable time to do something. For example:

an opportunity (GW) (BSB, NIV, NJB, NRSV, NABRE, NASB, GW, REB, KJV)

1. This word refers to the cause or reason for something. For example:

a good reason (GNT) (RSV, GNT, NLT, NCV, ESV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because that is the usual meaning of the Greek word. Louw and Nida say it means “favorable circumstances, opportunity, occasion.” Thrall (p. 400) translates it as “opportunity.” Hughes (on TW), Martin (p. 124), Barrett (p. 161), and Kistemaker (p. 184) translate it as “occasion.” Harris (p. 411) translates the Greek word as “cause” but in his prose he refers to it as “an opportunity” (p. 413).

be proud of us: This phrase refers to becoming satisfied and happy with the accomplishments of Paul and the other evangelists with him. The believers at Corinth should have been proud of them because they had done great things for God and they had done them in a godly way. This is similar to a father being proud of his child when that child does something good. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

take pride in us (NIV)

speaking highly of us

honor us to/before others

5:12c

so that you can answer those who take pride in appearances

- in order that you can respond well to those who are proud of outward appearances/actions
- Be proud of us so that you will know what to say to those who are so proud of external things.

those who take pride in appearances: The phrase in appearances refers to outward appearance. Here the phrase probably refers to the letters of commendation that the false teachers had, their persuasive way of speaking, and their dressing and acting like very religious people. Other ways to translate this are:

those who are proud about things that can be seen (NCV)

those who take pride in what is seen (NIV)

those who are so proud of the outward...qualification (JBP)

those whose pride is all in outward show (REB)

5:12d

rather than in the heart.

- instead of their character.
- Those people have no reason to be proud of their motives, thoughts, and desires.

in the heart: This phrase refers to a person's motives, thoughts, desires, and character. Paul and the evangelists with him ministered from godly motives, thoughts, desires, and character. But the false teachers preached from selfish motives, thoughts, and desires. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

what is in his mind

about their character (GNT)

inward qualification (JBP)

motives, thoughts, desires, and character

the good in a person's inner being

2 Corinthians 5:13

Section 5:11–6:2: Allow God to reconcile with you

In this section, Paul explained the goal that he and his coworkers had (5:11a–b). He also said that God knew and approved of what they did (5:11c). He wrote that their accomplishments should cause the believers in Corinth to be proud of them (5:12). The basis for 5:13 may be that the false teachers had accused Paul of being crazy. Sometimes obeying God requires doing things which do not make sense to people who do not know God. Paul also explained the basis for his ministry (5:14–15).

He explained the new way believers should think of each other (5:16–17). He explained the basis for that new way of thinking (5:18–19). He told them that apostles are like ambassadors for Christ, and he urged people to be reconciled to God (5:20). He explained the basis for believers becoming righteous (5:21). He urged believers to follow God completely (6:1–2).

Other examples of headings for this section are:

The Ministry of Reconciliation (NIV)

Paul explained the basis for his ministry

Friendship with God through Christ (GNT)

God wants all people to reconcile with him

5:13a–b

If we are out of our mind, it is for God; if we are of sound mind, it is for you: The Greek words are literally “Whether we are out of our mind (it is) for God, (or) whether we are in our right mind (it is) for you.” It indicates that at one time (or perhaps more than once) the first part was true. It also indicates that at one time (or perhaps more than once) the second part was true. It is also possible that the text refers to one group thinking Paul was out of his mind and another group thinking Paul was in his right mind. The word if is used rhetorically to cause the believers in Corinth to think at what times Paul and the others may have been out of their minds or in their right minds.

Also, see note below on we are out of our mind for the meaning of that clause.

5:13a

If we are out of our mind, it is for God;

- For if we^(excl) are beside ourselves, then we do it for God's sake,
- If our religious experiences seem extreme/crazy, we do that to honor God.

5:13 begins with a conjunction that is often translated “because” or “for.” Here the conjunction introduces an explanation of one of Paul's attitudes (5:12d). Here is another way to translate this:

For (RSV)

Some languages can allow the context to indicate that 5:13 explains 5:12d, as the BSB does, and do not need to translate the conjunction.

we are out of our mind: The Greek word that the BSB translates as we are out of our mind can refer to:

1. An ecstatic religious experience, such as a vision, prophetic trance, or speaking in tongues. For example:

we are beside ourselves (RSV)

1. being insane. For example:

we were crazy (GW)

Some scholars follow interpretation (1). Martin (pp. 126–127) says that Paul probably described visions, tongues, and other such experiences here and that the phrase “for the sake of God” probably indicates he was not referring to insanity. But other scholars follow interpretation (2) and believe he used the words of his enemies, who accused him of being insane. The BSB translation probably allows both interpretations.

If possible, translate in a way that allows both (1) and (2). But some languages must choose one or the other. If that is true in your language, translate in a way that indicates (1). Other ways to translate this clause are:

we have extreme religious experiences

we go out of our minds in religious ecstasy

Do not translate in a way that indicates that Paul said that he was actually insane at any time.

it is for God: This clause indicates that when Paul and the evangelists were out of their minds, this was for the benefit of God. Things like speaking in tongues honor God. But speaking in tongues is not done with

the mind of the person, so in that way the person is “out of his mind.” Other ways to translate this clause are:

we do that for God

it is to bring glory to God (NLT)

5:13b

if we are of sound mind, it is for you.

- but if we are of good/proper mind/thinking, then we do it for your^(plur) sake.
- And if we behave normally/well, we do that to benefit you.

we are of sound mind: This clause refers to being sane and thinking properly. Other ways to translate this clause are:

we are in our right mind (NIV)

we are sane (GW)

our minds are right

it is for you: This clause indicates that when Paul and the evangelists were speaking and acting rationally, this was for the benefit of the believers in Corinth. Things like teaching and preaching helped the believers. Other ways to translate this clause are:

we do that for you

it is for your benefit (NLT)

2 Corinthians 5:14

Section 5:11–6:2: Allow God to reconcile with you

In this section, Paul explained the goal that he and his coworkers had (5:11a–b). He also said that God knew and approved of what they did (5:11c). He wrote that their accomplishments should cause the believers in Corinth to be proud of them (5:12). The basis for 5:13 may be that the false teachers had accused Paul of being crazy. Sometimes obeying God requires doing things which do not make sense to people who do not know God. Paul also explained the basis for his ministry (5:14–15).

He explained the new way believers should think of each other (5:16–17). He explained the basis for that new way of thinking (5:18–19). He told them that

apostles are like ambassadors for Christ, and he urged people to be reconciled to God (5:20). He explained the basis for believers becoming righteous (5:21). He urged believers to follow God completely (6:1-2).

Other examples of headings for this section are:

The Ministry of Reconciliation (NIV)

Paul explained the basis for his ministry

Friendship with God through Christ (GNT)

God wants all people to reconcile with him

5:14a

For Christ's love compels us,

- For Christ's love directs us^(excl),
- Christ's love pushes us to do as we do,

For: This conjunction introduces an explanation of something about 5:12-13. Some languages can allow the context to indicate that 5:14-15 explains 5:12-13 and do not need to translate the conjunction.

Christ's love: The word love refers to a strong feeling of affection and concern for a person. Your language may have a word for this, or your language may use an idiom. Christ loves all people and died for them.

compels: This word indicates that Christ's love requires action by Paul and the others. It implies doing things that honor God. Other ways to translate this word are:

urges...on (NRSV)

We are ruled by Christ's love for us (CEV)

directs

pushes

5:14b

because we are convinced that One died for all,

- because we have concluded that one died for the sake of all,
- because we are certain that one person died for all people,

we are convinced: The Greek word that the BSB translates as convinced refers to making a decision and

having no doubts about that decision. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

we have concluded this (NET)

We are certain (CEV)

We have determined for sure

we have no doubt

One died for all: Here the word for indicates that Jesus died on behalf of all people. His death offered a way for all people to be reconciled to God. Another way to translate this clause is:

one died for the sake of all people

5:14c

therefore all died.

- therefore all have died.
- so all people died.

all died: Scholars have many opinions about what this clause means here. You should translate literally. The word all probably refers to the same group as in 5:14b. For example:

all people have died (GW)

2 Corinthians 5:15

Section 5:11-6:2: Allow God to reconcile with you

In this section, Paul explained the goal that he and his coworkers had (5:11a-b). He also said that God knew and approved of what they did (5:11c). He wrote that their accomplishments should cause the believers in Corinth to be proud of them (5:12). The basis for 5:13 may be that the false teachers had accused Paul of being crazy. Sometimes obeying God requires doing things which do not make sense to people who do not know God. Paul also explained the basis for his ministry (5:14-15).

He explained the new way believers should think of each other (5:16-17). He explained the basis for that new way of thinking (5:18-19). He told them that apostles are like ambassadors for Christ, and he urged people to be reconciled to God (5:20). He explained the basis for believers becoming righteous (5:21). He urged believers to follow God completely (6:1-2).

Other examples of headings for this section are:

The Ministry of Reconciliation (NIV)

Paul explained the basis for his ministry

Friendship with God through Christ (GNT)

God wants all people to reconcile with him

5:15a

And He died for all,

- He died for the sake of all,
- And he died for all people,

And He died for all: 5:15a restates the last part of 5:14b to say something more about Christ dying for all people (5:15b–c).

5:15b

that those who live should no longer live for themselves,

- so that those who live should not live by selfish motives any longer
- in order that those who live in/for Christ should not live just to please themselves any more,

that: Here the word that introduces the purpose of Christ dying. For example:

so that (GNT)

those who live: This phrase refers to believers. They live because God has given new life to them.

In some languages, after reading all of 5:15, a literal translation of those who live would wrongly refer to all people living on earth. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Explain the implied information in your translation. For example:

those who live in/for Christ

those who receive his new life (NLT)

- Translate literally and explain the implied information in a footnote. An example footnote is:

This phrase refers to believers. They live because God has given new life to them.

should no longer live for themselves: This phrase refers to doing things for others and not for selfish reasons. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

should not live by selfish motives any longer

should no longer follow their own desires as they live

5:15c

but for Him who died for them and was raised again.

- but for the sake of him who died for their sake and was raised from death.
- but they should live for him. He died for them and God raised him to life.

for Him who died for them and was raised again:

The phrase “should live” is implied from 5:15b but not repeated here. In some languages it is more natural to repeat some or all of the implied phrase. For example:

they should live for him who died for them and was raised again

was raised again: This clause is passive. God raised Jesus from death. Some languages must use an active clause. For example:

whom God raised to life

2 Corinthians 5:16

Section 5:11–6:2: Allow God to reconcile with you

In this section, Paul explained the goal that he and his coworkers had (5:11a–b). He also said that God knew and approved of what they did (5:11c). He wrote that their accomplishments should cause the believers in Corinth to be proud of them (5:12). The basis for 5:13 may be that the false teachers had accused Paul of being crazy. Sometimes obeying God requires doing things which do not make sense to people who do not know God. Paul also explained the basis for his ministry (5:14–15).

He explained the new way believers should think of each other (5:16–17). He explained the basis for that new way of thinking (5:18–19). He told them that apostles are like ambassadors for Christ, and he urged people to be reconciled to God (5:20). He explained the basis for believers becoming righteous (5:21). He urged believers to follow God completely (6:1–2).

Other examples of headings for this section are:

The Ministry of Reconciliation (NIV)

Paul explained the basis for his ministry

Friendship with God through Christ (GNT)

God wants all people to reconcile with him

5:16a

So from now on we regard no one according to the flesh.

- ¶ So, as for us^(excl), from now on we value no one based on worldly/external things.
- ¶ From this time on we do not think of anyone as the world does. (NCV)

So from now on we regard no one according to the flesh: The pronoun we is emphasized in the Greek clause. For example:

So, as for us, we regard no one from a worldly point of view from now on

With us therefore worldly standards have ceased to count in our estimate (REB)

Many English versions do not translate the emphasis, probably because the conjunction So and the time phrase from now on make such emphasis difficult in the beginning of the clause.

from now on: This phrase refers to the time starting when Christ died (5:15a). The Holy Spirit gives believers a new understanding. The phrase does not refer to the time when Paul wrote this letter.

regard: This word refers to:

1. thinking about a person in a certain way;
2. evaluating or judging that person.

Someone may consider that person good or bad based on what he thinks to be important. Other ways to translate this word are:

judge (GNT)

consider (NJB)

value

according to the flesh: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates literally as according to the flesh may refer to:

1. Using the standards or measures that are important to people in the world, such as ways of living or personal accomplishments.
2. Looking only at the appearance of a person, or how well he persuades others. This phrase may refer to “those who take pride in appearance” (5:12c).

Translate in a way that allows one or both of the above meanings. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

from a human point of view (NLT)

based on worldly values

worldly standards (REB)

as the world does (NCV)

5:16b

Although we once regarded Christ in this way,

- Even if at one time we thought of Christ merely based on worldly/external things,
- In the past we thought of Christ as the world thinks, (NCV)

5:16c

we do so no longer.

- we do not any more.
- but we no longer think of him in that way. (NCV)

5:16b–c

Although we once regarded Christ in this way, we do so no longer: Before Paul and his coworkers believed in Jesus, they valued Jesus very little because they saw him “according to the flesh” (5:16a). Back then, Paul probably thought of Jesus as a heretic whom his leaders had crucified for valid reasons. But now Paul believed that Jesus was the Christ. Other ways to translate this clause are:

At one time we thought of Christ merely from a human point of view. How differently we know him now! (NLT)

Even if once we judged Christ based on worldly values, now we have stopped that kind of thinking

In the past we thought of Christ as the world thinks, but we no longer think of him in that way (NCV)

2 Corinthians 5:17

Section 5:11–6:2: Allow God to reconcile with you

In this section, Paul explained the goal that he and his coworkers had (5:11a–b). He also said that God knew and approved of what they did (5:11c). He wrote that their accomplishments should cause the believers in Corinth to be proud of them (5:12). The basis for 5:13 may be that the false teachers had accused Paul of being crazy. Sometimes obeying God requires doing things which do not make sense to people who do not know God. Paul also explained the basis for his ministry (5:14–15).

He explained the new way believers should think of each other (5:16–17). He explained the basis for that new way of thinking (5:18–19). He told them that apostles are like ambassadors for Christ, and he urged people to be reconciled to God (5:20). He explained the basis for believers becoming righteous (5:21). He urged believers to follow God completely (6:1–2).

Other examples of headings for this section are:

The Ministry of Reconciliation (NIV)

Paul explained the basis for his ministry

Friendship with God through Christ (GNT)

God wants all people to reconcile with him

5:17a

Therefore if anyone is in Christ, he is a new creation.

- So, if anyone has a relationship with Christ, he has a new being/nature.
- Therefore, if anyone believes in Christ, he has received a new nature.

Therefore: Like “So” in 5:16a, this word indicates that 5:17 is a result of what Paul said in 5:14–15.

if anyone is in Christ, he is a new creation: This indicates that God gives people a new nature when they believe in Jesus. Since believers have the new nature, they are able to follow Jesus. Other ways to translate this are:

Anyone who is joined to Christ is a new being (GNT)

anyone who belongs to Christ has become a new person (NLT)

If anyone believes in Christ, God has made him new

If anyone accepts Christ, God has given to him a new nature

in Christ: Here this phrase refers to believing in Christ and therefore having a relationship with him.

5:17b

The old has passed away. Behold, the new has come!

- The old things have gone, and behold/hey, what is new has come!
- The old life is gone; a new life has begun! (NLT)

The old has passed away. Behold, the new has come: There is a textual issue in 5:17b. (1) The earliest Greek manuscripts have the word new (BSB, RSV, NIV, GNT, NJB, NLT, GW, NET, REB, ESV). (2) Some later Greek manuscripts have the words all things new (KJV). It is recommended that you follow option (1). The NRSV, CEV, JBP, and NCV use “everything” in their translation, but using this word may be a translation choice rather than following option (2). A Greek word that is often translated as “look,” which the BSB translates as Behold, occurs between the two clauses in 5:17b. It emphasizes the clause the new has come. Here is another way to translate this:

everything old has passed away; see, everything has become new (NRSV)

The old has passed away: The Greek clause is literally “the old things came to an end.” The old creation for a believer has ceased. Even though believers still sometimes sin in the old ways, they have begun the new life. Other ways to translate this clause are:

The old things have gone (NCV)

The old life is gone (NLT)

The old way of living has disappeared (GW)

his old ways and deeds have ended

the new has come: The Greek clause indicates that the new creation has come into existence in the believer's life. Other ways to translate this clause are:

what is new has come (NET)

a new life has begun (NLT)

A new way of living has come into existence (GW)

his new being/existence has begun

2 Corinthians 5:18

Section 5:11–6:2: Allow God to reconcile with you

In this section, Paul explained the goal that he and his coworkers had (5:11a–b). He also said that God knew and approved of what they did (5:11c). He wrote that their accomplishments should cause the believers in Corinth to be proud of them (5:12). The basis for 5:13 may be that the false teachers had accused Paul of being crazy. Sometimes obeying God requires doing things which do not make sense to people who do not know God. Paul also explained the basis for his ministry (5:14–15).

He explained the new way believers should think of each other (5:16–17). He explained the basis for that new way of thinking (5:18–19). He told them that apostles are like ambassadors for Christ, and he urged people to be reconciled to God (5:20). He explained the basis for believers becoming righteous (5:21). He urged believers to follow God completely (6:1–2).

Other examples of headings for this section are:

The Ministry of Reconciliation (NIV)

Paul explained the basis for his ministry

Friendship with God through Christ (GNT)

God wants all people to reconcile with him

5:18a

All this is from God,

- All that comes from God.
- God did all that.

All this is from God: This clause indicates that God made the new creation described in 5:17. In some languages it is more natural to use a different verb than is here. For example:

God alone did all this

All this: This phrase refers to the new creation and being in 5:17. In some languages it is more natural to use “that” here. For example:

all that

5:18b

who reconciled us to Himself through Christ

- He has restored our relationship with him through Christ, (GW)
- We^(incl) were his enemies/opponents, but he has now made us his friends by means of the sacrificial death of Christ,

who reconciled us to Himself through Christ: This clause tells the reader more about God. In some languages a literal translation would wrongly indicate that Paul was thinking of many gods and only this one had reconciled us to Himself through Christ. If that is true in your language, translate this clause in a way that tells more about God. One way to do that is to start a new sentence here. For example:

He reconciled us to himself through Christ.

reconciled us to Himself through Christ: The meaning of the word reconciled is “caused two people or two groups of people, who had been enemies, to be at peace with one another.” God appointed Jesus to receive the punishment for the sins of all people by dying on the cross. If a person believes that Jesus died on his behalf, God forgives his sins and that person is reconciled to God. Other ways to translate this are:

restored our relationship with him through Christ (GW)

sent Christ to make peace between himself and us (CEV)

by means of the sacrificial death of Christ, God has now made us his friends, who were his enemies/opponents

We were God's enemies but he has now made us his friends by Christ dying on the cross for our sins

5:18c

and gave us the ministry of reconciliation:

- and gave to us^(excl) the ministry of restoring relationships with God.
- and sent us in order to tell the good news about how to become reconciled with God.

gave us the ministry of reconciliation: This phrase refers to telling people about Jesus, what he did and how that is the way to reconcile people to God. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

has given us this ministry of restoring relationships (GW)

has given us the work of making peace between himself and others (CEV)

gave to us the work/ministry of making people friends with God, who were his enemies/opponents

sent us in order to go around telling the good news about how to become friends with God

ministry: This word refers to serving God by:

1. preaching to people about Jesus;
2. showing God's love for them by helping them.

See the examples in the note above.

reconciliation: This word refers to the event of God reconciling with people (as in 5:18b). In some languages it is more natural to use a verb here. For example:

reconciling with him

helping people restore their relationship with God

2 Corinthians 5:19

Section 5:11–6:2: Allow God to reconcile with you

In this section, Paul explained the goal that he and his coworkers had (5:11a–b). He also said that God knew and approved of what they did (5:11c). He wrote that their accomplishments should cause the believers in Corinth to be proud of them (5:12). The basis for 5:13 may be that the false teachers had accused Paul of

being crazy. Sometimes obeying God requires doing things which do not make sense to people who do not know God. Paul also explained the basis for his ministry (5:14–15).

He explained the new way believers should think of each other (5:16–17). He explained the basis for that new way of thinking (5:18–19). He told them that apostles are like ambassadors for Christ, and he urged people to be reconciled to God (5:20). He explained the basis for believers becoming righteous (5:21). He urged believers to follow God completely (6:1–2).

Other examples of headings for this section are:

The Ministry of Reconciliation (NIV)

Paul explained the basis for his ministry

Friendship with God through Christ (GNT)

God wants all people to reconcile with him

5:19a

that God was reconciling the world to Himself in Christ,

- That is, by means of the life of Christ, God was restoring his relationship with the world,
- Furthermore, God was making a way for all people to become reconciled through all that Christ did.

that: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as that here probably indicates that Paul wrote more about what he wrote in 5:18. Other ways to translate this word are:

that is (RSV)

furthermore

God was reconciling the world to Himself in Christ:

There are two ways to interpret the connection of in Christ to the verbs was and reconciling:

1. The verb was applies to reconciling and the phrase in Christ applies to both verbs together. For example:

in Christ God was reconciling (RSV) (BSB, RSV, NIV, GNT, NABRE, GW, NET, ESV)

1. The verb was is separate from reconciling and the phrase in Christ applies only to the verb was. For example:

God was in Christ, reconciling (KJV) (NJB, NASB, NLT, CEV, NCV, REB, KJV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because this verse refers to how God saves believers. Martin (p. 154) says the thought mainly refers to salvation and not to the incarnation of Christ. Thrall (p. 401) translates the text as “God, in Christ, was reconciling....” Barrett (p. 162) translates it as “God who in Christ was reconciling....” The theme of this verse is not about the relationship of God to Jesus while he lived on earth.

was reconciling: The verb tense here indicates that reconciling was a past event that extended over a period of time. God reconciled the world to himself by means of what Jesus Christ did. This would include incarnation (John 1:14, Luke 1:28–35), ministry, death, and resurrection.

the world: Here the word world refers to all people. For example:

all human beings (GNT)

5:19b

not counting men’s trespasses against them.

- for example, he will not accuse them of their sins,
- When people become reconciled with God he will not hold their sins against them.

5:19b explains something about the reconciliation in 5:19a. Indicate that in your translation. For example:

that is, he will not count their sins against them

not counting men’s trespasses against them: God keeps a record of everyone’s deeds (5:10). But these words indicate that:

1. God is patient with all people while they live on earth;
2. he will not hold those sins against them when they appear before him on the day of judgment if they believed in Jesus before they died.

Other ways to translate these words are:

not holding people’s sins against them

not charging people with their sins

saying that he will not count their sins for the purpose of punishing them

men’s: In the Greek, the word that the BSB translates men’s is the pronoun “their.” This pronoun refers back to the word “world” in 5:19a. Here the pronoun refers generally to people. For example:

anyone’s (NJB)

trespasses: This word refers to deeds and thoughts that are against God and his character.

General Comment on 5:19b

Other Scriptures indicate that people must accept Jesus as Savior before they die. Doing so, they are reconciled with God, and he does not count their sins against them on the day of judgment (Romans 4:3–8, John 3:15).

In some languages a literal translation of 5:19b would wrongly indicate that God will forgive all people. If that is true in your language, you may want to explain the implied information in your translation. For example:

not counting people’s sins against them when they believe

5:19c

And He has committed to us the message of reconciliation.

- and he appointed us^(excl) to tell the message of restoring relationships.
- He also gave to us the task of telling the message of reconciling with him.

He has committed to us: Here, the word committed refers to putting something into the care of someone. God gave to Paul and the other evangelists the task of telling people how to reconcile with God. Other ways to translate this are:

entrusting to us (RSV)

has commissioned us (JBP)

gave to us the work of

2 Corinthians 5:20

Section 5:11–6:2: Allow God to reconcile with you

In this section, Paul explained the goal that he and his coworkers had (5:11a–b). He also said that God knew and approved of what they did (5:11c). He wrote that their accomplishments should cause the believers in Corinth to be proud of them (5:12). The basis for 5:13 may be that the false teachers had accused Paul of being crazy. Sometimes obeying God requires doing things which do not make sense to people who do not know God. Paul also explained the basis for his ministry (5:14–15).

He explained the new way believers should think of each other (5:16–17). He explained the basis for that new way of thinking (5:18–19). He told them that apostles are like ambassadors for Christ, and he urged people to be reconciled to God (5:20). He explained the basis for believers becoming righteous (5:21). He urged believers to follow God completely (6:1–2).

Other examples of headings for this section are:

The Ministry of Reconciliation (NIV)

Paul explained the basis for his ministry

Friendship with God through Christ (GNT)

God wants all people to reconcile with him

5:20a

Therefore we are ambassadors for Christ,

- ¶ So, we^(excl) are official messengers of Christ,
- ¶ So then, Christ commissioned us to act on his behalf,

Therefore we are ambassadors for Christ: The conjunction that the BSB translates as Therefore introduces a result of 5:19c. Some English versions, for stylistic reasons, put this conjunction later in the clause:

We are therefore Christ's ambassadors (NIV)

In some languages it is more natural to have the conjunction first in the clause, as in the BSB.

we are ambassadors for Christ: An ambassador is a person whom the ruler of one country sends to another country to represent him. The ambassador says what the ruler of his country wants him to say. He has the authority of the ruler to do certain things. Paul

and the other evangelists represented Christ when they told his message of reconciliation. They had his authority to preach and do the things that helped people accept the message. Other ways to translate this clause are:

we are Christ's representatives (GW)

We were sent to speak for Christ (CEV)

Christ commissioned us to speak his message and do his will

5:20b

as though God were making His appeal through us.

- and God urges people to accept his message, using us to speak for him.
- indeed, God himself invites/exhorts people to believe, by having us speak on his behalf.

as though: This phrase indicates that Paul and the others spoke on behalf of God. They told his message. When they did that, it was as though God spoke.

God were making His appeal through us: The Greek does not say to whom the appeal is made. Two ways to interpret this clause are:

1. This connects to 5:20a. It indicates that God urges all people to accept his message. For example:

God were making His plea through us (NET) (BSB, RSV, NIV, GNT, NABRE, NASB, NLT, NET, ESV)

1. This is further explained by 5:20c. It indicates that God urges the believers in Corinth to repent and reconcile with him. For example:

God were appealing to you through us (REB) (NJB, GW, CEV, REB, NCV, KJV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because 5:20b is connected grammatically to 5:20a. Bruce (p. 210) says this expression does not refer to the believers in Corinth. Harris (p. 425), Thrall (p. 400), Martin (p. 135), Kistemaker (p. 198), Hughes (on TW), and Furnish (p. 338) support interpretation (1) in their translations.

making His appeal: The phrase making His appeal refers to urging someone to accept what was said. God urges all people to accept his message of reconciliation. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

is urging

ask to accept

through us: This phrase indicates that God urged the believers in Corinth to accept his message, but it was Paul and the others who brought that message to them.

5:20c

We implore you on behalf of Christ: Be reconciled to God.

- We^(excl) plead on the behalf of Christ: Let God reconcile with you^(plur).
- As those speaking for Christ, we urge this: allow God to restore his relationship with you.

We implore you on behalf of Christ: Be reconciled to God: The Greek words here do not have the pronoun you, but the command Be reconciled is a direct command. The direct command would address the listeners as you. Some scholars believe this command was addressed generally to people who do not believe in Jesus. Both Harris (p. 448) and Thrall (p. 438) say it refers to people who do not believe in Jesus. But other scholars believe this command was addressed to the believers in Corinth, for them to repent and return to God. Barnett (p. 311) says that Paul was urging the believers in Corinth to be reconciled with God, and that the believers had wandered away from God. You should not indicate to whom the pronoun you refers. The English versions only use the pronoun you without explaining it.

implore: This word refers to urging or asking someone to accept something. Paul earnestly wanted people to be reconciled to God. Other ways to translate this word are:

appeal (NJB)

plead (GNT)

on behalf of Christ: As an ambassador of Christ, Paul urged people to reconcile with God because Christ had told him to do that for him. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

as Christ's representatives

We speak for Christ when we plead (NLT)

in the name of Christ (NJB)

Be reconciled to God: This clause is passive. People should allow God to restore the relationship. Some languages must use an active clause. For example:

let God change you from enemies into his friends (GNT)

allow God to restore your relationship with him

2 Corinthians 5:21

Section 5:11–6:2: Allow God to reconcile with you

In this section, Paul explained the goal that he and his coworkers had (5:11a–b). He also said that God knew and approved of what they did (5:11c). He wrote that their accomplishments should cause the believers in Corinth to be proud of them (5:12). The basis for 5:13 may be that the false teachers had accused Paul of being crazy. Sometimes obeying God requires doing things which do not make sense to people who do not know God. Paul also explained the basis for his ministry (5:14–15).

He explained the new way believers should think of each other (5:16–17). He explained the basis for that new way of thinking (5:18–19). He told them that apostles are like ambassadors for Christ, and he urged people to be reconciled to God (5:20). He explained the basis for believers becoming righteous (5:21). He urged believers to follow God completely (6:1–2).

Other examples of headings for this section are:

The Ministry of Reconciliation (NIV)

Paul explained the basis for his ministry

Friendship with God through Christ (GNT)

God wants all people to reconcile with him

5:21a

God made Him who knew no sin to be sin on our behalf,

- Christ never sinned, but God made him become all sin for our^(incl) sakes,
- Even though Christ never sinned, God appointed him to represent all sin on our behalf,

God made Him...to be sin: This clause indicates that God caused Christ to represent all sin. God treated Christ as sin. Other ways to translate this are:

God caused Christ...actually to be sin (JBP)

God made him become sin (NCV)

God considered Christ to be sin

Translate in a way that does not indicate or imply that God caused Christ to sin.

who knew no sin: The Greek words are literally “the one not knowing sin.” Christ knew about sin because he had seen people sin, but he had never sinned in his own deeds or thoughts. Other ways to translate this clause are:

Christ was without sin (GNT)

the sinless one (NJB)

who never sinned (NLT)

on our behalf: God caused Christ to represent all sin for our benefit. Believers do not need to pay the penalty for their sins, because Christ has already paid it. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

for our sake (GNT)

to our benefit

for us (NIV)

5:21b

so that in Him we might become the righteousness of God.

- in order that by means of our relationship with him we become right with God.
- so that we^(incl) become acceptable to God through our union with Christ.

so that: This phrase introduces the purpose for 5:21a.

in Him we might become the righteousness of God: This clause indicates that by the means of what Christ did for believers, God has caused them to become right or acceptable in his eyes. Christ paid the penalty for sin, so when people believe in him, God makes

them right or acceptable. So they do not have to pay the penalty any longer. Other ways to translate this clause are:

in Christ we could become right with God (NCV)

we might receive God’s approval through him (GW)

in Him: This phrase refers to having a relationship with Christ. When people believe in Jesus, he begins a relationship with them. Through this relationship, God makes them righteous. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

in union with him (GNT)

through him (GW)

2 Corinthians 6:1

Section 5:11–6:2: Allow God to reconcile with you

In this section, Paul explained the goal that he and his coworkers had (5:11a–b). He also said that God knew and approved of what they did (5:11c). He wrote that their accomplishments should cause the believers in Corinth to be proud of them (5:12). The basis for 5:13 may be that the false teachers had accused Paul of being crazy. Sometimes obeying God requires doing things which do not make sense to people who do not know God. Paul also explained the basis for his ministry (5:14–15).

He explained the new way believers should think of each other (5:16–17). He explained the basis for that new way of thinking (5:18–19). He told them that apostles are like ambassadors for Christ, and he urged people to be reconciled to God (5:20). He explained the basis for believers becoming righteous (5:21). He urged believers to follow God completely (6:1–2).

Other examples of headings for this section are:

The Ministry of Reconciliation (NIV)

Paul explained the basis for his ministry

Friendship with God through Christ (GNT)

God wants all people to reconcile with him

6:1a**As God's fellow workers, then,**

- ¶ So as co-workers with God,
- ¶ We^(excl) work together with God.

As God's fellow workers: The Greek word that the BSB translates as As God's fellow workers is literally "working together with." Paul probably referred to working together with God. God works to reconcile people to himself (5:19a). Paul and the other evangelists also reconcile people with God (5:18c). In that way, Paul and the others are co-workers with God. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

In our work together with God (GNT)

Since we are eGod's coworkers (GW)

We are workers together with God (NCV)

6:1b**we urge you not to receive God's grace in vain.**

- we^(excl) plead with you^(plur) also: do not receive God's grace and then waste it.
- We further urge you to use God's gracious help which you receive. Do not let that help be in vain.
- We exhort you: you have received God's acts of favor, so allow it to produce results.

we urge you: The Greek clause is literally "we also urge you" (as in the NASB). Paul urged/implored people in 5:20, and here he urged them about a different matter. Other ways to translate this clause are:

we urge you also (NRSV)

we implore you further

not to receive God's grace in vain: This phrase indicates that the believers in Corinth had received God's grace, but Paul wanted that grace to produce results. Paul wanted the believers to do things that honored God. If they did nothing for God, the gift of grace in their lives was without results (in vain). Other ways to translate this are:

not to let your acceptance of his grace come to nothing (NJB)

who have received God's grace not to let it be wasted (GNT)

not let the grace that you received from God be for nothing (NCV)

In some languages it is more natural to state the meaning positively first. For example:

to do deeds/things by means of the grace of God that you receive. Do not disregard that grace.

to use God's grace which you receive. Do not let that grace be in vain.

grace: The word grace means "unearned favor or goodwill." God blesses his people because he wants to and not because they earn it. Here that blessing also helps them to live as followers of God. Other ways to translate this word are:

kindness (CEV)

help

favor

See how you translated this word in 1:2.

2 Corinthians 6:2**Section 5:11–6:2: Allow God to reconcile with you**

In this section, Paul explained the goal that he and his coworkers had (5:11a–b). He also said that God knew and approved of what they did (5:11c). He wrote that their accomplishments should cause the believers in Corinth to be proud of them (5:12). The basis for 5:13 may be that the false teachers had accused Paul of being crazy. Sometimes obeying God requires doing things which do not make sense to people who do not know God. Paul also explained the basis for his ministry (5:14–15).

He explained the new way believers should think of each other (5:16–17). He explained the basis for that new way of thinking (5:18–19). He told them that apostles are like ambassadors for Christ, and he urged people to be reconciled to God (5:20). He explained the basis for believers becoming righteous (5:21). He urged believers to follow God completely (6:1–2).

Other examples of headings for this section are:

The Ministry of Reconciliation (NIV)

Paul explained the basis for his ministry

Friendship with God through Christ (GNT)

God wants all people to reconcile with him

6:2a-b

In the time of favor...in the day of salvation: These two phrases refer to the same general time when God will both respond and help. Translate in a way that allows the two phrases to refer to the same period of time. Do not indicate in your translation that these phrases refer to different periods of time.

The Greek does not have the word the in either time phrase. It refers to a time of...favor and a day of salvation. Here is another way to translate this:

At an acceptable time... (JBP)

And in a day of salvation...

6:2a-b is a quote from Isaiah 49:8. If you footnote the location of quotes from the Old Testament, you may want to do so here.

6:2a

For He says: “In the time of favor I heard you,

- For he/God said, “At an acceptable time I have listened to you^(sing),
- I say that because in Scripture God says, “On the right day, I responded to you,

For: This conjunction introduces an explanation of something about 6:1.

Some languages allow the context to imply the connection to 6:1 and do not need to translate this word.

He says: God spoke the following words. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

God says (NLT)

For God’s word is— (JBP)

In the Scriptures God says (CEV)

In the time of favor I heard you: Here the word heard has the meaning of “responded” or “answered.” God always hears, but he chose to act at that time. This clause does not imply that God had not heard earlier. Other ways to translate this are:

In the hour of my favor I answered you (REB)

At the appropriate time I acted on what I heard from you

In the time of favor: This phrase probably refers to the day that God had decided was acceptable to him. Martin (p. 330) and Thrall (p. 453). Other ways to translate this phrase are:

At an acceptable time (NRSV)

At the right time (GW)

On an appropriate/proper day

you: In the Old Testament, this prophecy was addressed to the person who would save Israel. Here, Paul used this prophecy to encourage the believers in Corinth. He indicated that God would hear and help them.

In some languages a literal translation of this word would not indicate that meaning clearly. If that is true in your language, explain its meaning in a footnote. An example footnote is:

In the Old Testament, the prophecy was addressed to the person who would save Israel. Here, Paul used this prophecy to encourage the believers in Corinth. He indicated that God would hear and help them.

6:2b

and in the day of salvation I helped you.”

- and on a day of rescue/saving I have helped you.”^(sing)
- on a day to save, I came to your aid.”

in the day of salvation I helped you: Here the phrase the day of salvation refers to a time when God rescued or saved the people of Israel from danger. God helped the person who led the people at that time. Other ways to translate this clause are:

on a day to be saved I have helped you

on the day of deliverance I came to your aid (REB)

in a time of rescue/saving, I helped you

6:2c**Behold, now is the time of favor;**

- Look, now is the acceptable time,
- Indeed/Hey, an appropriate day is today,

Behold: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Behold is often translated as “look.” It emphasizes the saying: now is the time of favor. Paul ended the quote in 6:2b and indicated here that those words of God apply now. Other ways to translate this Greek word are:

See (NRSV)

Listen! (GNT)

Indeed (NLT)

now is the time of favor: This clause is similar to 6:2a. Paul used this prophecy to encourage the people in Corinth. This clause urges all people to accept God’s favor. Other ways to translate this clause are:

now is the acceptable time (NRSV)

the right time is now

Today is the acceptable/proper day

6:2d**now is the day of salvation!**

- look, now is the day/time to be rescued/saved.
- indeed/hey, today is the day for God to save.

A Greek word that is often translated as “look” occurs at the beginning of 6:2d. It emphasizes the saying: “now is the day of salvation.” Other ways to translate this Greek word are:

see (NRSV)

Listen!

Indeed

In some languages it is more natural to omit the Greek word here, allowing the emphasis from “look” in 6:2c to continue.

now is the day of salvation: This clause is similar to 6:2b. Paul again applied this prophecy to the people in

Corinth. This clause urges all people to accept God’s salvation. Other ways to translate this clause are:

now is the time to be saved

the day of deliverance is now

today is the day of rescue/saving

2 Corinthians 6:3**Section 6:3–10: Paul’s life showed he was a true apostle**

In this section, Paul explained that he served God properly in all circumstances. This was also true about his coworkers. They did not purposely offend others (6:3). They showed that they were true servants of God by persevering in many kinds of difficulties (6:4–5), in the way they lived (6:6–7), and in the way they responded to others (6:8–10).

Other examples of headings for this section are:

Our Lives Demonstrate That We Are God’s Servants (GW)

Proof that Paul and his coworkers were truly God’s servants

6:3a**We put no obstacle in anyone’s way,**

- ¶ We^(excl) do not give cause for anyone to be offended,
- ¶ We do not do anything that would offend others,

We put no obstacle in anyone’s way: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as no obstacle in anyone’s way is literally “a cause of stumbling in regards to no one.” The phrase is a metaphor for causing people to reject something or be offended. Paul and the other evangelists avoided doing things that might cause people to reject the gospel of Jesus. Other ways to translate this clause are:

giving no cause for offense in anything (NASB)

We put no obstacle in any one’s way (RSV)

We do not give people any opportunity to be offended

we try hard not to cause problems (CEV)

6:3b
so that no one can discredit our ministry.

- so that our ministry will not be blamed of/for misdeeds.
- in order that no one will find fault with our work of serving God.

so that: This phrase introduces the purpose for putting no obstacle (6:3a).

no one can discredit our ministry: This clause is passive in Greek. Some English versions translate it that way. For example:

our ministry will not be discredited (NIV)

Paul means that people who do not follow Jesus might discredit their ministry. Some languages must use an active clause. For example:

others will not discredit our ministry

We do not want anyone to find fault with our work (GNT)

discredit: The Greek word that the BSB translates as discredit refers to blaming someone for doing something wrong. Other ways to translate this word are:

find fault (NLT)

blamed (KJV)

ministry: This word refers to serving God by:

1. preaching to people about Jesus;
2. showing God's love for them by helping them.

Other ways to translate this word are:

service

serving

doing God's work

See how you translated this word in 3:8 or 5:18.

2 Corinthians 6:4

Section 6:3–10: Paul's life showed he was a true apostle

In this section, Paul explained that he served God properly in all circumstances. This was also true about his coworkers. They did not purposely offend others (6:3). They showed that they were true servants of God by persevering in many kinds of difficulties (6:4–5), in the way they lived (6:6–7), and in the way they responded to others (6:8–10).

Other examples of headings for this section are:

Our Lives Demonstrate That We Are God's Servants (GW)

Proof that Paul and his coworkers were truly God's servants

6:4a **Rather, as servants of God we commend ourselves in every way:**

- But instead, since our work is to serve God, we commend ourselves in every way:
- Instead, as people who do God's work, we^(excl) recommend ourselves in all the ways we can.

as servants of God we commend ourselves in every way: There are two ways to interpret as servants of God:

1. In this clause, Paul is saying that he and the other evangelists are servants of God and they commend themselves in a manner fitting to their identity as servants of God. For example:

as God's servants, we have commended ourselves in every way (NET) (BSB, RSV, NIV, NABRE, NET, REB, ESV)

1. This clause indicates that Paul and the other evangelists had to prove that they were servants of God. For example:

we prove ourselves authentic servants of God (NJB) (GNT, NJB, NLT, GW, CEV, NCV, KJV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because it follows the normal meaning of the Greek words. Thrall (p. 455) says "he commends himself in the way proper to such a vocation." Harris (p. 470) and Martin (p. 172) understand the Greek text in the same way.

servants of God: The Greek word that the BSB translates as servants refers to people who do ministry (according to the meaning of this word in 6:3b). Here Paul and the others serve God by:

1. preaching to people about Jesus;
2. showing God's love for them by helping them.

Other ways to translate this phrase are:

people who serve God

people who do God's work

commend: Here the word commend refers to saying they are good people. The list of their good deeds is in 6:4b–10c. The people saw that they were worthy of their approval. For example:

recommend (REB)

show that we are good people

See how you translated this word in 3:1 or 4:2.

6:4b–10c

In these verses, Paul listed some of the ways in which he and the other evangelists lived. These deeds commended them. These deeds showed that God was powerful and that the believers in Corinth should accept them as approved by God.

The BSB indicates the list begins at 6:4b with a colon (:) at the end of 6:4a. It shows the list continues until 6:10c by translating 6:4a–10c as one sentence.

Other English versions have several sentences in 6:4b–10c. In some languages it is more natural to use several sentences here. If that is true in your language, indicate that the list continues at each new sentence, for example, by repeating “We also commend ourselves” at the beginning of each new sentence:

^{4b}in great endurance; in troubles, hardships, and distresses; ⁵in beatings, imprisonments, and riots; in hard work, sleepless nights, and hunger. ⁶We also commend ourselves in purity, understanding, patience, and kindness; in the Holy Spirit and in sincere love; ⁷in truthful speech and in the power of God; with weapons of righteousness in the right hand and in the left. ⁸We also commend ourselves through glory and dishonor, bad report and good report; genuine, yet regarded as impostors; ⁹known, yet regarded as unknown; dying, and yet

we live on; beaten, and yet not killed; ¹⁰sorrowful, yet always rejoicing; poor, yet making many rich; having nothing, and yet possessing everything.

6:4b–5b

in great endurance; in troubles, hardships, and calamities; in beatings, imprisonments, and riots; in labor, sleepless nights, and hunger: The phrase in great endurance describes the way Paul and the evangelists with him lived during the other things that he lists here. Other ways to indicate that relationship here are:

by means of great endurance in the midst of troubles, hardships, distresses, beatings, imprisonments, riots, hard work, sleepless nights, and hunger

with great endurance during troubles, hardships, distresses, beatings, imprisonments, riots, hard work, sleepless nights, and hunger

6:4b

in great endurance;

- by persevering many times
- Some of those ways are: when we patiently endure many

in: Here the word in indicates that “great endurance” was one of the ways that Paul and the others commended themselves. They practiced great endurance, and that showed that people should accept them. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

by (ESV)

with (NET)

through (RSV)

by means of

endurance: The Greek word that the BSB translates as endurance refers to continuing to follow God even though there are hardships or opposition. The attitude of patience is included in the meaning. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

perseverance

patience to continue

See how you translated this Greek word in 1:6 (“patient endurance”).

6:4c–5b

in troubles, hardships, and calamities; in beatings, imprisonments, and riots; in labor, sleepless nights, and hunger: This list is probably three groups of three items:

1. troubles, hardships, and calamities
2. beatings, imprisonments, and riots
3. labor, sleepless nights, and hunger

Within each group, the items are similar in some way to each other. The BSB indicates the three groups by using and only once within each group and separating the groups with semi-colons (;). If possible, indicate in your translation that these items are in three groups. But clearly indicating that all these items connect to “great endurance” is more important for the correct meaning of these verses.

6:4c

in troubles, hardships, and calamities;

- in the midst of difficulties, disasters, terrible situations/circumstances;
- bad times, hard times, unavoidable disasters;

in: Here the word in indicates that the list in 6:4c–5b describes various situations that Paul and the others experienced. They practiced great endurance during those situations. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

in the midst of

during

In the Greek, the word in occurs with each of the nine items. The BSB translates it three times, corresponding to the three groups of items. Other versions, such as the RSV, translate it only once, at the beginning of the list.

troubles, hardships, and calamities: These three words refer to difficult situations of various kinds. Since God rules all things, you should not use words such as “misfortune” or “bad luck.”

troubles: This word probably refers to persecution and physical dangers. Paul describes some of his troubles in 1:8–10 and 11:23–27. Other ways to translate this word are:

afflictions (RSV)

adversity

See how you translated this word in 1:4 (where the BSB says “troubles”) or 4:17 (where the BSB says “affliction”). But you should use a word that is different from “hardships” and “distresses.”

hardships: This word refers to very difficult circumstances/situations. Other ways to translate this word are:

disasters (JBP)

difficulties (NJB)

calamities: This refers to very bad situations or circumstances that overwhelm the people in them. The people have no way to escape from those situations. They must endure through them. Other ways to translate this word are:

distresses (NIV)

very hard times

terrible situations/circumstances

2 Corinthians 6:5

Section 6:3–10: Paul’s life showed he was a true apostle

In this section, Paul explained that he served God properly in all circumstances. This was also true about his coworkers. They did not purposely offend others (6:3). They showed that they were true servants of God by persevering in many kinds of difficulties (6:4–5), in the way they lived (6:6–7), and in the way they responded to others (6:8–10).

Other examples of headings for this section are:

Our Lives Demonstrate That We Are God’s Servants (GW)

Proof that Paul and his coworkers were truly God’s servants

6:5a

in beatings, imprisonments, and riots;

- being flogged, being put in prison several times, being mobbed;

- when people beat us^(excl), or put us in prison, or when angry crowds mob us;

in: Here the word in has the same meaning as in 6:4c. Paul and the evangelists with him practiced great endurance during beatings, imprisonment, and riots.

beatings: This word refers to someone using a whip to cut the skin or leave a painful red welt. This word also includes someone hitting with a hard stick or even with fists. Other ways to translate this word are:

when we are flogged (NJB)

when someone whipped us

imprisonments: This word indicates that people put Paul and the others in prison at various times. Other ways to translate this word are:

sent to prison a number of times

being in jail several times

riots: This word refers to people creating great disturbances in reaction to something Paul and the others did (such as Acts 17:5-7 and Acts 19:23-41). Other ways to translate this word are:

being mobbed (JBP)

faced angry mobs (NLT)

hurt in riots (CEV)

6:5b

in labor, sleepless nights, and hunger;

- working hard, getting no sleep, missing meals;
- when we worked long hours, and missed sleep and food;

in: Here the word in has the same meaning as in 6:4c. They practiced great endurance during labor, sleepless nights, and hunger.

labor: This phrase refers to any work that is tiring either because it is physically hard, continues for long hours, or is emotionally difficult. Here the phrase probably refers both to Paul's work as a tentmaker and to further hours of work as an evangelist, pastor, and apostle. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

hard work (NIV)

overworked (GNT)

sleepless nights: This phrase probably refers to going without sleep because of the demands of the ministry. Paul and the others probably delayed or skipped sleeping so they could help people. This phrase probably does not refer to having time for sleep but not being able to fall asleep. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

endured sleepless nights (NLT)

have gone without sleep (GNT)

sometimes we get no sleep (NCV)

hunger: This word probably refers to going without food because of the demands of the ministry. Paul and the others probably delayed or skipped eating so they could help people. This phrase probably does not refer to choosing to fast as a part of his religious duty. Other ways to translate this word are:

starving (NJB)

have gone without...food (GNT)

sometimes we get no...food (NCV)

2 Corinthians 6:6

Section 6:3-10: Paul's life showed he was a true apostle

In this section, Paul explained that he served God properly in all circumstances. This was also true about his coworkers. They did not purposely offend others (6:3). They showed that they were true servants of God by persevering in many kinds of difficulties (6:4-5), in the way they lived (6:6-7), and in the way they responded to others (6:8-10).

Other examples of headings for this section are:

Our Lives Demonstrate That We Are God's Servants (GW)

Proof that Paul and his coworkers were truly God's servants

6:6a**in purity, knowledge,**

- by pure lives, knowledge,
- when we^(excl) live pure/straight/clean lives, when we understand things clearly,

in: Here the word in indicates that purity, knowledge, patience, and kindness were ways that Paul and the other evangelists behaved. This godly behavior commended them to others. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

by (ESV)

with

through

by means of

See how you translated this word in 6:4.

purity: This word refers to a person's morals or intentions as being right or proper. The person is not hypocritical or wishing evil upon someone. Other ways to translate this word are:

pure lives (NCV)

act and think with pure motives

straight/clean behavior

knowledge: This word usually refers to knowledge in general and proper use of it. Here it probably includes knowledge of God and the gospel of Jesus. Other ways to translate this word are:

understanding (NIV)

understanding of the truth

insight (JBP)

6:6b**patience, and kindness;**

- patience/forbearing, kindness;
- when we are patient with others, when we are kind to others;

patience: This word refers to waiting when something bad happens or someone does something bad to you and not reacting in anger or revenge. A person with patience may hope that the problem can be corrected. He does not wait in order to fight back later.

kindness: This word refers to doing something good for someone. The word does not imply expecting the other person to do something good in return.

6:6c**in the Holy Spirit and in sincere love;**

- by following the Holy Spirit, by our genuine love,
- when we depend on the Holy Spirit to guide us, when we love others sincerely;

in the Holy Spirit: This phrase indicates that Paul and the others commended themselves when they followed what the Holy Spirit told them. In some languages it is more natural to include implied information to explain how they were in the Holy Spirit. For example:

in following the Holy Spirit

by the power of the Holy Spirit

with obeying the Holy Spirit

If possible, translate the word in with the same word as you did in 6:6a.

the Holy Spirit: This is the Spirit of God. See how you translated it in 1:22 or 5:5.

in sincere love: Here the word in indicates that sincere love, "truthful speech," and "the power of God" were other ways in which Paul and the others commended themselves. They practiced those things, and that showed that people should accept them. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

by genuine love (NET)

with sincere love

through sincere love

by means of sincere love

See how you translated the word in in 6:4b or 6:6a.

sincere love: The word sincere indicates that Paul and the others truly loved the people as they did God's

work. They did not pretend to love the people. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

genuine love (RSV)

true love (GNT)

2 Corinthians 6:7

Section 6:3–10: Paul's life showed he was a true apostle

In this section, Paul explained that he served God properly in all circumstances. This was also true about his coworkers. They did not purposely offend others (6:3). They showed that they were true servants of God by persevering in many kinds of difficulties (6:4–5), in the way they lived (6:6–7), and in the way they responded to others (6:8–10).

Other examples of headings for this section are:

Our Lives Demonstrate That We Are God's Servants (GW)

Proof that Paul and his coworkers were truly God's servants

6:7a

in truthful speech and in the power of God;

- by declaring the truth, and by the power of God.
- when we^(excl) tell the true message, and when God's power is clearly seen in our lives/ministry,

truthful speech: The Greek phrase is literally “word of truth.” There are three ways to interpret the Greek phrase:

1. It refers to speaking a true message. In this context the message is the gospel of Jesus Christ. For example:

our message of truth (GNT) (GNT, NLT, NET, REB)

1. Translate literally. For example:

the word of truth (NJB) (NJB, NASB, KJV)

1. It refers generally to talking truthfully. For example:

We have spoken the truth (CEV) (BSB, RSV, NIV, NABRE, GW, CEV, NCV, ESV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Harris says that “truth” refers to the gospel here, and that “word” refers to speaking (p. 476). He has in his translation “declaring the truth.” Thrall translates the text as “the declaration of the truth” (p. 450). Martin translates it as “the message of truth” (p. 160). But if a literal translation as in option (2) would allow or imply interpretation (1), you may want to follow that.

Other ways to translate this phrase according to interpretation (1) are:

We faithfully preach the truth (NLT)

declaring the truth (REB)

the power of God: This phrase refers to the power that God gives to do things for him. This would include telling the gospel in a new place in a way that people would clearly understand, teaching well, and doing miracles and speaking prophecy. God demonstrated his power through Paul and the other evangelists. These deeds of God's power commended Paul and the others to the believers in Corinth. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

the presence of God's power (GW)

God's power is working in us (NLT)

the power of God, which he shows through us

the supernatural power of God in our lives

God's power is clearly seen in our ministry

6:7b

with the weapons of righteousness in the right hand and in the left;

- We also commend ourselves by using weapons of righteousness in the right hand and in the left hand,
- when we use the ways of righteousness that are like weapons for the right hand and the left hand,
- when we live/minister by means of the ways of righteousness that advance the kingdom of God and the ways of righteousness that defend us,

with: The Greek word that the BSB translates as with is often translated as “through.” Like the word “in” in 6:6c, “through” indicates that weapons of righteous-

ness was another way in which Paul and the others commended themselves. They used these weapons properly, and that showed that people should accept them. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

by (NASB)

through

by means of

the weapons of righteousness in the right hand and in the left: This phrase is a metaphor. The weapons are the things that believers use while serving God and that God gives to them. These weapons are things such as faith, love, truth, prophecy, knowledge, and Scripture.

These weapons both protect us and enable us to advance the kingdom of God. For example, just as soldiers use swords to attack and gain ground, Paul and the other evangelists with him told the truth about Jesus, and, as a result, people believed, and so God's kingdom grew larger. Just as soldiers use shields when people attack them, Paul and the others relied on Scripture to defend themselves. A soldier usually carried his sword in his right hand and his shield in his left. Paul spoke generally of weapons to indicate all the various ways in which they caused God's kingdom to grow larger or to defended themselves in their faith.

In some languages a literal translation would wrongly refer only to actual weapons. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Translate the phrase as a simile. For example:

ways of righteousness that are like weapons for the right hand and the left hand

- Translate the meaning without the metaphor. For example:

ways of righteousness that advance the kingdom of God and ways of righteousness that defend us

- Translate literally and explain the meaning in a footnote. An example footnote is:

This phrase is a metaphor. The term “weapons” refers to things that believers use while serving God, such as faith, love, truth, prophecy, knowledge, and Scripture.

the weapons of righteousness: The word of indicates that the weapons are connected to the idea of righteousness. God, who enables people to be righteous, also supplies weapons for believers to use. Furnish says that the “weapons of righteousness” are another sign that Paul and his co-workers “have been fully equipped by God to do battle for the gospel in the world” (p. 357). When a believer uses these weapons, he is acting righteously. Examples are probably prayer, prophecy, doing miracles, and God's word. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

weapons of God's righteousness

our righteous deeds are like weapons

fighters have weapons, and in the same way, God empowers us to do righteous deeds

2 Corinthians 6:8

Section 6:3-10: Paul's life showed he was a true apostle

In this section, Paul explained that he served God properly in all circumstances. This was also true about his coworkers. They did not purposely offend others (6:3). They showed that they were true servants of God by persevering in many kinds of difficulties (6:4-5), in the way they lived (6:6-7), and in the way they responded to others (6:8-10).

Other examples of headings for this section are:

Our Lives Demonstrate That We Are God's Servants (GW)

Proof that Paul and his coworkers were truly God's servants

6:8a through glory and dishonor,

- by how we respond to honor/respect and dishonor/disrespect,
- when people praise us^(excl) or when they despise us,
- when we live/minister with the praise of others or with their disrespect,

through glory and dishonor: This phrase indicates that whether Paul and his coworkers were honored or dishonored, they responded in a way that commended them. They behaved properly under both conditions. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

in times of honour or disgrace (NJB)

through being honored and being dishonored

by means of how we responded to honor and dishonor

by the way we behaved when people honored us and when others dishonored us

6:8b

slander and praise;

- by how we respond to being spoken well of and being spoken evil of.
- when people tell others that we are bad people and when they tell others that we are good people,
- when we respond to people spreading news that we are bad and others spreading news that we are good,

slander and praise: This phrase refers to the things people said about Paul and the other evangelists when they were not there. Some people said that they were bad people; others said that they were good people. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

ill repute and good repute (RSV)

through being spoken well of and being spoken evil of

by means of how we responded to people spreading news that we are bad and others spreading news that we are good

by the way we behaved when people reported us as good or bad

6:8c–10c

In 6:8c–10c, there are seven pairs of statements about Paul and the other evangelists. One of each pair is a statement of bad character or of a bad event. In the Greek, this statement always occurs before a statement of good character or of a good event. Each pair of statements also begins with the Greek word that means “as.”

The word “as” indicates that Paul’s enemies thought that Paul and the others were impostors (6:8c), unknown (6:9a), and so forth. It is implied that God knew they were genuine (6:8c), well-known (6:9a), and so

forth. Consider how to indicate those things in each case.

6:8c

viewed as imposters, yet genuine;

- We also commend ourselves when people treat us as impostors, and yet we are true,
- when people call us deceivers but we speak the truth,
- when people claim we are impostors and yet we are truthful,

viewed as imposters, yet genuine: The Greek words are literally “(regarded) as deceivers and (yet we are) truthful.” Some people thought Paul deceived people with his message about Jesus. Other ways to translate this are:

regarded as impostors, and yet true (NET)

Some people say we are liars, but we speak the truth (NCV)

people call us impostors and yet we are truthful

2 Corinthians 6:9

Section 6:3–10: Paul’s life showed he was a true apostle

In this section, Paul explained that he served God properly in all circumstances. This was also true about his coworkers. They did not purposely offend others (6:3). They showed that they were true servants of God by persevering in many kinds of difficulties (6:4–5), in the way they lived (6:6–7), and in the way they responded to others (6:8–10).

Other examples of headings for this section are:

Our Lives Demonstrate That We Are God’s Servants (GW)

Proof that Paul and his coworkers were truly God’s servants

6:9a

as unknown, yet well-known;

- when people treat us^(excl) as unknown people, yet we are well-known,
- when we are well-known but some people call us unknown and unimportant,
- when people call us unqualified and unknown and yet believers know us well,

as unknown, yet well-known: Some people regarded Paul and the other evangelists as unknown people, that is, people of no name, status, or importance. But other people regarded Paul and the others as well-known or important people.

Both clauses are passive. Some languages must use an active clause. For example:

some regard us as well-known, yet some regard us as unknown

some people regard us as insignificant, unknown people, but others regard us as well-known, important people

unknown: This word implies that some people considered Paul to have no status before God. Therefore he should not be preaching.

6:9b

dying, and yet we live on;

- when people say we are in danger of death, yet, look/hey, we continue to live,
- when we live in danger of dying but we still live.
- when people expect us to die and yet we survive,

In the Greek, after the word “yet” there is a word that usually means “look” or “see.” It emphasizes the fact that Paul and the others continued to live despite the danger. For example:

as dying and yet—see!—we continue to live (NET)

dying, and yet we live on: These words indicate that some people expected Paul and the others to die from the many dangers they faced. But they did not die. Other ways to translate this are:

Never far from death, yet here we are alive (JBP)

We live close to death, but we are still alive (NLT)

always in danger of being killed, but look, we continue to live

6:9c

punished, yet not killed;

- when people say that we will be punished, but we are not killed.
- when we live in danger of being punished but we are not killed;

- when people expect us to be punished and yet no one kills us;

punished, yet not killed: There are two ways to interpret the Greek word that the BSB translates as punished:

1. It refers to punishment or discipline. For example:

as punished, and yet not killed (RSV) (BSB, RSV, GNT, NASB, NABRE, GW, CEV, REB, NCV, ESV, KJV)

1. It refers specifically to beating someone with a rod or whip. For example:

scourged but not executed (NJB) (NIV, NJB, NLT, NET)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Harris (pp. 482–483), Martin (pp. 182–183), and Thrall (pp. 465–466) all say the Greek word refers to God’s discipline. Other ways to translate these words following interpretation (1) are:

disciplined by suffering, we are not done to death (REB)

as chastened, and not killed (KJV)

disciplined but not killed

The two clauses are passive. In some languages active clauses must be used. Scholars believe that Paul was referring to Psalm 118:18 here, so God is the one who disciplines. For example:

others regard us as people whom God is punishing, and yet in truth he does not put us to death

others think that someone needs to punish us with death, but God does not allow them to kill us

2 Corinthians 6:10

Section 6:3–10: Paul’s life showed he was a true apostle

In this section, Paul explained that he served God properly in all circumstances. This was also true about his coworkers. They did not purposely offend others (6:3). They showed that they were true servants of God by persevering in many kinds of difficulties (6:4–

5), in the way they lived (6:6-7), and in the way they responded to others (6:8-10).

Other examples of headings for this section are:

Our Lives Demonstrate That We Are God's Servants (GW)

Proof that Paul and his coworkers were truly God's servants

6:10a-c

sorrowful, yet always rejoicing; poor, yet making many rich; having nothing, and yet possessing everything: Paul's enemies claimed that he and the other evangelists were full of sorrow, were poor, and had nothing. Paul and the others were sorrowful sometimes, but sorrow did not characterize their lives; rejoicing did. The same is true for the other two pairs of sayings.

6:10a

sorrowful, yet always rejoicing;

- We^(excl) also commend ourselves when people say that we are sorrowful, but we always rejoice,
- when people think of us as sad but we always rejoice,
- when people regard us as being sad and yet we always rejoice in the Lord,

sorrowful, yet always rejoicing: The Greek words are literally "(regarded) as sorrowing, and (yet) always rejoicing." Paul's enemies claimed he was always sorrowful. Paul had sorrows, but he felt his life was characterized by rejoicing. Other ways to translate this are:

as sorrowful yet always rejoicing (NASB)

People think we are sad although we're always glad (GW)

6:10b

poor, yet making many rich;

- when people say that we are poor, yet we make many people rich,
- when people think of us as having no money, but we make many rich in God's promises,
- when people regard us as poor and yet we make many rich because we told them about Jesus and they believed,

poor, yet making many rich: Paul's enemies claimed he was always poor. Paul sometimes did not have

enough money for all his needs, but he characterized his life as making many rich. The word rich refers to people gaining God's promises because they believed in Jesus. Believers now had the Holy Spirit and his gifts. Other ways to translate this are:

people expect us to be poor, and yet we make many rich

In some languages a literal translation of the word rich would wrongly refer only to worldly wealth. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Include the implied information in your translation. For example:

poor, yet making many rich in God's promises

poor, yet making many rich because they believed in Jesus and received God's promises

- Translate literally and explain the meaning in a footnote. An example footnote is:

Paul was literally poor because he did not own many things. But he preached the gospel and many people believed. The word "rich" refers to gaining God's promises because they believed in Jesus. Believers now had the Holy Spirit and his gifts.

6:10c

having nothing, and yet possessing everything.

- when people say that we have nothing, yet we possess everything.
- when people think of us as having nothing worthwhile, but we own everything of importance to God.
- when people regard us as having nothing, yet we possess all that God has for us.

having nothing, and yet possessing everything:

Here the word everything refers to all the important things, which would include faith in Jesus, God's promises, and things like that. The word everything does not refer to things such as houses, money, or jewelry, because those things are not important in God's kingdom.

In some languages a literal translation of the word everything would wrongly refer only to worldly wealth. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Include the implied information in your translation. For example:

having nothing, and yet possessing everything of importance to God

having nothing, and yet possessing everything in God's promises because we believe in Jesus

- Translate literally and explain the meaning in a footnote. An example footnote is:

Here the word “everything” refers to all the important things, which would include faith in Jesus, God's promises, and things like that.

having nothing: This phrase exaggerates to emphasize the meaning. Paul had very few things. Compared to most people, the amount of things he owned was near nothing.

In some languages a literal translation of the word nothing would wrongly indicate that Paul owned nothing, not even his clothes. If that is true in your language, you may want to explain the exaggeration in your translation. For example:

having nearly nothing, and yet possessing everything

having almost nothing, and yet possessing everything

2 Corinthians 6:11

Section 6:11–7:4: Paul urged them to love him and live holy lives

In this section, Paul told the believers in Corinth that he loved them completely (6:11), but the believers did not love him completely (6:12). He urged them to love him completely (6:13).

Then he urged them to avoid partnerships with unbelievers (6:14a) and used five rhetorical questions (6:14b–16a) to support this exhortation. He also supported this exhortation with quotes from the Old Testament (6:16b–18). On the basis of these quotes, he then urged them to live pure lives (7:1).

He again urged them to love him (7:2a) and explained that he had not wronged anyone (7:2b). He explained that his love was complete (7:3) and he was very confident in them and very happy for them (7:4).

Other examples of headings for this section are:

Open your hearts to us, and live holy lives

Love us as we love you and live pure lives

6:11a

We have spoken freely to you, Corinthians.

- ¶ Corinthians, we^(excl) have spoken honestly with you^(plur),
- ¶ Believers in/at Corinth, we are writing sincerely to you,

We have spoken freely to you, Corinthians: Here the term of address, Corinthians, comes after Paul begins saying something to them. In some languages it is more natural to have the term of address first. For example:

Corinthians, we have spoken freely to you

We have spoken freely to you: The Greek clause is literally “Our mouth has opened to you.” This idiom indicates that Paul and the other evangelists had spoken honestly to the believers in Corinth. Other ways to translate this clause are:

We have spoken frankly to you (GNT)

We have spoken honestly with you (NLT)

This clause refers to what Paul had written so far in the letter of 2 Corinthians. In some languages it is more natural to refer to writing. For example:

We have written frankly to you

Since Paul was still writing, in some languages it is more natural to use the present tense. For example:

We write frankly to you

6:11b

Our hearts are open wide.

- and opened our heart to you. (NJB)
- we love you with no limits.

Our hearts are open wide: The Greek clause is literally “our heart has been enlarged.” This idiom indicates that Paul and the other evangelists loved the believers very much. Other ways to translate this clause are:

we have...opened our heart to you (NJB)

we love you without reserve

our love for you is great

2 Corinthians 6:12

Section 6:11–7:4: Paul urged them to love him and live holy lives

In this section, Paul told the believers in Corinth that he loved them completely (6:11), but the believers did not love him completely (6:12). He urged them to love him completely (6:13).

Then he urged them to avoid partnerships with unbelievers (6:14a) and used five rhetorical questions (6:14b–16a) to support this exhortation. He also supported this exhortation with quotes from the Old Testament (6:16b–18). On the basis of these quotes, he then urged them to live pure lives (7:1).

He again urged them to love him (7:2a) and explained that he had not wronged anyone (7:2b). He explained that his love was complete (7:3) and he was very confident in them and very happy for them (7:4).

Other examples of headings for this section are:

Open your hearts to us, and live holy lives

Love us as we love you and live pure lives

6:12a

It is not our affection,

- Our affection for you is not restricted, (NET)
- We^(excl) are not limiting/stopping/covering our love to you^(plur),

It is not our affection...that is restrained: The Greek clause is literally “you are not being restricted in us.” There are two main ways to interpret these words:

1. Paul and his coworkers loved the believers in Corinth completely; they did not limit their love for the believers in Corinth. For example:

We are not holding back on our love for you (CEV) (BSB, NIV, GNT, NRSV, NLT, GW, CEV, NET, REB, NCV)

1. Paul and his coworkers did not restrict the believers in Corinth in any way. For example:

You are not restricted by us (RSV) (RSV, NASB, NABRE, ESV, KJV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Harris (p. 487), Martin (p. 160), and Thrall (p. 450) translate according to interpretation (1).

Other ways to translate this clause following interpretation (1) are:

Our affection for you is not restricted (NET)

It is not we who have closed our hearts to you (GNT)

affection: This word refers to caring feelings for someone, or lasting feelings of kindness toward someone. Paul cared for them and was kind to them.

6:12b

but yours, that is restrained.

- but you are restricting your affection for us.
- but you are limiting/stopping/covering your love to us.

but yours, that is restrained: The Greek clause is literally “you are restricted in your inward parts.” It indicates that the believers in Corinth did not love Paul and his coworkers completely; they restricted themselves in that love. Other ways to translate this are:

you are restricted in your affections for us (NET)

it is you who have closed your hearts to us (GNT)

you are holding back on your love for us (CEV)

2 Corinthians 6:13

Section 6:11–7:4: Paul urged them to love him and live holy lives

In this section, Paul told the believers in Corinth that he loved them completely (6:11), but the believers did not love him completely (6:12). He urged them to love him completely (6:13).

Then he urged them to avoid partnerships with unbelievers (6:14a) and used five rhetorical questions (6:14b–16a) to support this exhortation. He also supported this exhortation with quotes from the Old Testament (6:16b–18). On the basis of these quotes, he then urged them to live pure lives (7:1).

He again urged them to love him (7:2a) and explained that he had not wronged anyone (7:2b). He explained that his love was complete (7:3) and he was very confident in them and very happy for them (7:4).

Other examples of headings for this section are:

Open your hearts to us, and live holy lives

Love us as we love you and live pure lives

6:13a–b

As a fair exchange, I ask you as my children: Open wide your hearts also: When he said I ask you as my children, Paul interrupted himself in the middle of the sentence to remind the believers that he was like a father to them. In some languages it is more natural to have the interruption first. For example:

I speak as to my children: as a fair exchange, open wide your hearts also

6:13a

As a fair exchange, I ask you as my children:

- In return—I speak to you^(plur) as if you were my children—
- If I may speak to you like a father: do to us as we did to you,

As a fair exchange: This phrase refers to a trade of things equal in kind. Paul loved the believers, and he wanted them to do the same to him. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

In return (RSV)

Do to us as we have done (NCV)

Treat us the same way we've treated you (GW)

show us the same feelings that we have for you (GNT)

I ask you as my children: Since Paul had told them the gospel and taught them, in spiritual matters he was like a father to them. Other ways to translate this clause are:

I speak to you as if you were my children (NCV)

(if I may speak to you like a father) (REB)

6:13b

Open wide your hearts also.

- open your heart to us^(excl) too.

- namely, love us with no limits.

Open wide your hearts also: The Greek clause is literally “you also be enlarged.” It refers to loving more, similar to 6:11b. Translate in a similar way as you did in 6:11b. For example:

you must open your hearts too (NJB)

love us without reserve

make your love for us great

2 Corinthians 6:14

Section 6:11–7:4: Paul urged them to love him and live holy lives

In this section, Paul told the believers in Corinth that he loved them completely (6:11), but the believers did not love him completely (6:12). He urged them to love him completely (6:13).

Then he urged them to avoid partnerships with unbelievers (6:14a) and used five rhetorical questions (6:14b–16a) to support this exhortation. He also supported this exhortation with quotes from the Old Testament (6:16b–18). On the basis of these quotes, he then urged them to live pure lives (7:1).

He again urged them to love him (7:2a) and explained that he had not wronged anyone (7:2b). He explained that his love was complete (7:3) and he was very confident in them and very happy for them (7:4).

Other examples of headings for this section are:

Open your hearts to us, and live holy lives

Love us as we love you and live pure lives

6:14a

Do not be unequally yoked with unbelievers.

- ¶ Do not harness yourselves in an uneven team with unbelievers. (NJB)
- ¶ Do not become partners with people who do not believe in Jesus.

Do not be unequally yoked with unbelievers: The phrase unequally yoked is a metaphor. A person would yoke two animals together so they could pull a plow or a heavy load. A yoke connects the animals together and also connects them to the thing they will pull.

The Greek word that the BSB translates as unequally yoked refers to two different kinds of animals being

connected to the same yoke. The metaphor indicates that a believer and an unbeliever become unequal partners. They have different goals, morals, ideals, and motives. The clause prohibits many kinds of partnerships with unbelievers, including marrying an unbeliever. But if a believer is already married to an unbeliever, the believer should not seek divorce (1 Corinthians 7:12–14). business partnerships, and participating in pagan rituals. Other ways to translate this clause are:

Do not harness yourselves in an uneven team with unbelievers (NJB)

Do not become partners with those who do not believe (NET)

You are not the same as those who do not believe. So do not join yourselves to them. (NCV)

6:14b–16a

For what partnership can righteousness have with wickedness? Or what fellowship does light have with darkness? What harmony is there between Christ and Belial? Or what does a believer have in common with an unbeliever? What agreement can exist between the temple of God and idols?: Each of these rhetorical questions emphasizes the difference between the two terms in each pair. They expect the answer, “None whatsoever.” These questions support the command to avoid becoming partners with unbelievers. Translate these sayings in a way that emphasizes the difference between the two terms in each pair. Some ways are:

- As rhetorical questions. For example:

How can right and wrong be partners? How can light and darkness live together? ¹⁵How can Christ and the Devil agree? What does a believer have in common with an unbeliever? ^{16a}How can God’s temple come to terms with pagan idols? (GNT)

Can righteous people be partners with law-breakers? Can light associate with darkness? ¹⁵Can Christ agree with Belial, or a believer join with an unbeliever? ^{16a}Can there be a pact between the temple of God and idols?

Is it possible that righteousness and wickedness have anything common? Or is it possible that light can have fellowship with darkness? ¹⁵Is it possible

that there is harmony between Christ and Belial? Is it possible that a believer has anything in common with an unbeliever? ^{16a}Is it possible that there is any agreement between the temple of God and idols?

- As questions with the answers supplied. For example:

what do righteousness and wickedness have in common? Nothing! Or what fellowship can light have with darkness? None! ¹⁵What harmony is there between Christ and Belial? None! What does a believer have in common with an unbeliever? Nothing! ^{16a}What agreement is there between the temple of God and idols? None!

- As tag questions. For example:

Righteousness and wickedness have nothing in common, do they? Light has no fellowship with darkness, does it? ¹⁵There is no harmony between Christ and Belial, is there? A believer has nothing in common with an unbeliever, does he? ^{16a}There is no agreement between the temple of God and idols, is there?

- As statements. For example:

Righteousness and wickedness have nothing in common. Light has no fellowship with darkness. ¹⁵There is no harmony between Christ and Belial. A believer has nothing in common with an unbeliever. ^{16a}There is no agreement between the temple of God and idols.

- As commands. For example:

Do not consider righteousness and wickedness to have anything in common. Do not consider light to have any fellowship with darkness. ¹⁵Do not consider there to be any harmony between Christ and Belial. Do not consider a believer to have anything in common with an unbeliever. ^{16a}Do not consider there to be any agreement between the temple of God and idols.

6:14b

For what partnership can righteousness have with wickedness?

- For, can righteous people be partners with lawbreakers?

- For example: Straight ways and lawbreaking have nothing in common.

For: This conjunction introduces an explanation of why believers should not partner with unbelievers (6:14a).

what partnership can righteousness have with wickedness?: The Greek word that the BSB translates as partnership describes people who have the same goals, motives, and intentions. But righteous people and wicked people have opposite goals, motives, and intentions. They may even have the same goal, for example, raising good children, but have differing ideas of what “good” is. Other ways to translate this clause are:

How can righteousness be a partner with wickedness? (NLT)

Can someone who is righteous share goals with someone who is evil?

righteousness: This word refers to doing what is right and good in God’s sight. A righteous person has good morals and great integrity. He does what God requires him to do. Other ways to translate this word are:

uprightness (NJB)

straight ways

wickedness: The Greek word that the BSB translates as wickedness is literally “lawlessness” (as in the NRSV). This word refers to breaking laws as a way of life. For example:

law-breaking (NJB)

6:14c

Or what fellowship does light have with darkness?

- Or, can the kingdom of the light have a close relationship with the kingdom of darkness?
- Another example: light cannot share a place with darkness.

Or what fellowship does light have with darkness?: The word fellowship refers to a close relationship, like two brothers who love each other very much. Other ways to translate this clause are:

How can light and darkness share life together? (JBP)

Can light associate with darkness? (REB)

Light and darkness cannot share together. (NCV)

Can someone who walks in the light have a close relationship with someone who walks in the darkness?

light...darkness: These words are metaphors. They refer to two different kingdoms. God’s kingdom is described as light. Satan’s kingdom is described as darkness.

In some languages a literal translation would not have the figurative meaning of the metaphors. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Explain the meaning in your translation. For example:

people of the light...people of the darkness

- Translate literally and explain the meaning in a footnote. For example:

These words are metaphors. “Light” refers to people who follow God. “Darkness” refers to people who do not follow God.

2 Corinthians 6:15

Section 6:11–7:4: Paul urged them to love him and live holy lives

In this section, Paul told the believers in Corinth that he loved them completely (6:11), but the believers did not love him completely (6:12). He urged them to love him completely (6:13).

Then he urged them to avoid partnerships with unbelievers (6:14a) and used five rhetorical questions (6:14b–16a) to support this exhortation. He also supported this exhortation with quotes from the Old Testament (6:16b–18). On the basis of these quotes, he then urged them to live pure lives (7:1).

He again urged them to love him (7:2a) and explained that he had not wronged anyone (7:2b). He explained that his love was complete (7:3) and he was very confident in them and very happy for them (7:4).

Other examples of headings for this section are:

Open your hearts to us, and live holy lives

Love us as we love you and live pure lives

6:15a

What harmony is there between Christ and Belial?

- Can Christ agree with Beliar/Belial, the devil?
- Another example: There is no agreement between Christ and Satan.

What harmony is there between Christ and Belial?:

There are two issues regarding these words.

Issue 1: Greek manuscripts

There is a textual issue with the word that the BSB spells Belial:

1. Some Greek manuscripts spell this word as Beliar. (NJB, NRSV, NABRE, NLT, NET)
2. Some Greek manuscripts spell this word as Belial. (BSB, RSV, NIV, NASB, REB, NCV, ESV, KJV)
3. Some Greek manuscripts spell this word as Belian.
4. Some Greek manuscripts spell this word as Beliab.

It is recommended that you follow option (1), since the UBS Greek New Testament recommends it. But if the common language follows one of the other options, you may want to follow that.

Issue 2: Meaning

The Greek word that the BSB translates as harmony means “agreement” (as in the NRSV). Christ and Satan agree on nothing. Other ways to translate this word are:

Can Christ agree with Belial? (REB)

Christ certainly does not agree with Belial!

Christ: The word Christ is a title for Jesus. The word Christ literally means “the anointed one.” Translate the word Christ here as you did in 1:1.

Belial: Belial is one of the names that the Jews used for Satan at that time. In some languages people will not guess that Belial refers to Satan. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Explain who this name refers to in your translation. For example:

Belial, the devil (NCV)

- Use one of the common names for Satan here. For example:

the Devil (GNT) Then you may want to include a footnote to explain the literal Greek word. For example:

Literally “Beliar/Belial.” This is another Jewish name for Satan. It probably means “worthless one.”

6:15b

Or what does a believer have in common with an unbeliever?

- Can a believer share in what unbelievers believe?
- Another example: a believer cannot share in what unbelievers follow.

Or what does a believer have in common with an unbeliever?:

The Greek word that the BSB translates as have in common refers to having a portion or share in something. This is an exaggeration. Believers do not share the unbeliever’s evil goals, intentions, or motives. They may even have the same goal, for example, raising good children, but have differing ideas of what “good” is. Other ways to translate this clause are:

what sharing can a believer have with an unbeliever?

Or what portion does a believer share with an unbeliever? (ESV)

A believer shares nothing in common with an unbeliever.

In some languages the exaggeration excludes any common goal, intention, or motive between a believer and an unbeliever. If that is true in your language, do not exaggerate here. For example:

A believer shares almost nothing in common with an unbeliever.

2 Corinthians 6:16

Section 6:11–7:4: Paul urged them to love him and live holy lives

In this section, Paul told the believers in Corinth that he loved them completely (6:11), but the believers did not love him completely (6:12). He urged them to love him completely (6:13).

Then he urged them to avoid partnerships with unbelievers (6:14a) and used five rhetorical questions (6:14b–16a) to support this exhortation. He also supported this exhortation with quotes from the Old Testament (6:16b–18). On the basis of these quotes, he then urged them to live pure lives (7:1).

He again urged them to love him (7:2a) and explained that he had not wronged anyone (7:2b). He explained that his love was complete (7:3) and he was very confident in them and very happy for them (7:4).

Other examples of headings for this section are:

Open your hearts to us, and live holy lives

Love us as we love you and live pure lives

6:16a

What agreement can exist between the temple of God and idols?

- Can the temple of God have a mutual agreement with idols?
- Another example: the temple of God and idols cannot make a mutually agreeable pact.

What agreement can exist between the temple of God and idols?: This clause uses the image of God's temple being completely separate from idol worship. It is improper for them to be mixed together. Other ways to translate this clause are:

what union can there be between God's temple and idols? (NLT)

what mutual agreement does the temple of God have with idols? (NET)

The temple of God cannot compromise with false gods.... (NJB)

The metaphor of the temple of God is explained in 6:16b.

agreement: This is a different Greek word from the Greek word that the BSB translates "harmony" in 6:15a, but the meaning is similar. The Greek word here includes the meaning of an agreement that both groups like.

6:16b

For we are the temple of the living God.

- For we^(incl) are like the temple of the living God.

- For the living God dwells among/in us like he did in the temple.

For: This conjunction introduces an explanation of the way Paul used the phrase "the temple of God" in 6:16a.

we are the temple of the living God: There is a textual issue in 6:16b. (1) Many Greek manuscripts have the pronoun we (BSB, RSV, NIV, GNT, NJB, NASB, NLT, GW, CEV, NET, JBP, REB, ESV, NCV). (2) Some Greek manuscripts have the pronoun you (KJV only). It is recommended that you follow option (1). This clause indicates that all believers are like a temple of God. Long ago, God's presence dwelt in the temple (1 Kings 8:10–13). In the same way, God lives with believers by means of the Holy Spirit. If it is not natural to refer to people as a temple, you may want to:

- Translate the metaphor as a simile. For example:

we are like the temple of the living God

- Explain the meaning in your translation. For example:

The living God dwells in us as he did in the temple
Then you may want to give the literal words. An example footnote is:

Literally "we are the temple of the living God."

- Translate literally and explain the meaning in a footnote. For example:

This clause indicates that all believers are like a temple of God. Long ago, God's presence dwelt in the temple (1 Kings 8:10–13). In the same way, God lives with believers by means of the Holy Spirit.

temple: The word temple refers to a building where people go to worship. Some ways to translate the word temple are:

- Use a descriptive phrase. For example:

house/place of worship

holy/sacred house

- If your language has a word for temple, consider using it. But in some languages the word temple may have meaning that the readers of your transla-

tion would want to avoid. In that case, consider the descriptive phrases above.

Be sure to use a different term than the one you have chosen for “synagogue.” There was only one temple, but there were many synagogues throughout the land of Israel where the Jews met regularly for worship.

the living God: The word living here refers to God being alive, as opposed to idols, which are not alive. Some other examples for translating are:

the alive God

the God who lives forever

This phrase should not imply in your language that he is one of many “gods.”

6:16c–d

I will dwell with them and walk among them, and I will be their God, and they will be My people: This quote combines Leviticus 26:12, Jeremiah 32:38, and Ezekiel 37:27. If you footnote the locations of words from the Old Testament, you may want to do so here.

6:16c

As God has said: “I will dwell with them and walk among them,

- As God said long ago, “I will live and move among them,
- That is what God meant when he said in the Scriptures, “I will live in their midst and accompany them,

As God has said: This clause introduces a quotation from the Old Testament. God spoke these words, and someone wrote them down. In some languages a literal translation would wrongly indicate that God had spoken but that these words are not in Scripture. If that is true in your language, you may want to explain in your translation. For example:

As God has said in Scripture

As God said long ago in his word

This clause indicates that the quote explains 6:16b. For example:

That is what God meant when he said

God indicated that when he said

I will dwell with them: This clause probably indicates that God will live in the midst of his people. Other ways to translate this clause are:

I will live...among them (GW)

I and they will live together

walk among them: This clause indicates that God will have a close relationship with his people and help them. Other ways to translate this clause are:

move among them (RSV)

live among them (GNT)

will accompany them

6:16d

and I will be their God, and they will be My people.”

- I am the God that they will serve and I will make them my people.”
- and I will be like a father to them, and I will acknowledge that they belong to me.”

I will be their God: Here the pronoun their indicates that God will have a relationship with his people. In some languages the word God cannot have a possessive pronoun such as their connected to it. If that is the case in your language, explain the meaning in your translation. For example:

I will have a relationship with them

I will be their leader as God

they will be My people: This clause also indicates that the people will have a relationship with God.

2 Corinthians 6:17

Section 6:11–7:4: Paul urged them to love him and live holy lives

In this section, Paul told the believers in Corinth that he loved them completely (6:11), but the believers did not love him completely (6:12). He urged them to love him completely (6:13).

Then he urged them to avoid partnerships with unbelievers (6:14a) and used five rhetorical questions (6:14b–16a) to support this exhortation. He also supported this exhortation with quotes from the Old

Testament (6:16b–18). On the basis of these quotes, he then urged them to live pure lives (7:1).

He again urged them to love him (7:2a) and explained that he had not wronged anyone (7:2b). He explained that his love was complete (7:3) and he was very confident in them and very happy for them (7:4).

Other examples of headings for this section are:

Open your hearts to us, and live holy lives

Love us as we love you and live pure lives

6:17a–b

Therefore come out from among them and be separate, says the Lord. Touch no unclean thing, and I will receive you: This quote uses parts of Isaiah 52:11 and Ezekiel 20:34, 41. If you footnote the locations of quotes from the Old Testament, you may want to do so here.

6:17a

“Therefore come out from among them and be separate, says the Lord.

- Therefore the Lord said long ago, “Leave^(plur) them and be separate.
- So the Lord God says to us through/in the Scriptures, “Leave them and be separate from them.

Therefore come out from among them and be separate, says the Lord: God says this to his people, not to everyone. Moreover, these words are also from the Old Testament. If people think that the saying here refers to all people, you may want to explain in your translation. For example:

Therefore come out from them and be separate, says the Lord to his people in Scripture.

Therefore come out from them and be separate, says the Lord to us in his holy word.

come out from among them and be separate: In the Old Testament context, these commands were to separate physically from nations that practiced idolatry. Here Paul uses these clauses to command the believers in Corinth to follow ways that honor God. Believers are to avoid practices that lead to following idols. The two commands emphasize the meaning. Other ways to translate this are:

come out from them, and be separate from them (RSV)

Leave those people, and be separate (NCV)

These words are used as a metaphor. It refers to following God only and not following the ways of people of the world. (John 17:15–18 shows that this verse must be understood as a metaphor.) In some languages a literal translation would wrongly refer only to physically leaving. If that is true in your language, explain in a footnote. An example footnote is:

This verse refers to following God only and not following the ways of people of the world. This verse does not refer to physical separation.

says the Lord: Paul has actually added this clause to indicate that God is the speaker. It is not found in the material that he is quoting. The BSB follows the Greek order by placing the clause says the Lord in the middle of what God said. But to show that it is not part of the original quote, you may want to put it at the beginning. For example:

And so the Lord says, “You must leave them and separate yourselves from them. Have nothing to do with what is unclean, and I will accept you.” (GNT)

Place this clause where it is most natural in your language.

Also, following the Greek word order literally, the BSB places the verb says before the phrase the Lord. This is acceptable but alternate English style. Other versions follow more common English word order. For example:

The Lord says (GW)

the Lord: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Lord means “the one in authority over (something)” or “master.” The word Lord refers to God here. In some languages it is more natural to include “God” in this phrase. For example:

the Lord God

6:17b

Touch no unclean thing, and I will receive you.”

- Touch no religiously unclean thing, and I will welcome you.”
- Avoid all things that I have prohibited, and I will bring you in.”

Touch no unclean thing: In the Old Testament context of this quote, unclean thing probably referred mainly to idols and the practices of worshiping them. In other places in the Old Testament, the phrase “unclean thing” usually referred to anything improper to use or touch in regard to religious purity. Such things included touching taboo food or animals or being involved with evil spirits or immoral practices. The Jews were to worship God only. In the context of this letter, Paul used this saying to command believers to avoid wickedness, anything associated with Satan, idol worship, and anything that might cause a believer to follow such practices. In some languages a literal translation would have the correct meaning. If that is true in your language, you may want to explain in a footnote. For example:

This saying refers to avoiding idols and idol worship as well as other types of wickedness.

Touch no: Here the phrase Touch no refers figuratively to avoiding something. God wants his people to avoid such things as idols and idol worship. For example:

Have nothing to do with (GNT)

unclean thing: In the Old Testament, if someone touched something unclean, God prohibited that person from going to the temple and worshiping him for a period of time. God indicated that a dead body was unclean, and people with certain skin diseases or sores were unclean. God indicated that other things were also unclean. The word unclean does not refer to having dirt on you and needing to wash.

In some languages the word unclean only means “having dirt on the skin.” If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Translate in a way that indicates the correct meaning of the word here. For example:

thing that causes a person to become religiously corrupt/unacceptable

thing that I have prohibited

- Translate literally and explain the meaning in a footnote. Some example footnotes are:

This word refers to being religiously “unclean” or unacceptable in God’s sight.

In the Old Testament, if someone touched something unclean, God prohibited that person from going to the temple and worshiping God for a period of time. Similarly, idols and idol worship are unclean, because God has prohibited believers from following them. The word unclean does not refer to having dirt on you and needing to wash.

I will receive you: The Greek word here translated receive means “show hospitality” or “welcome.” God will accept into his presence the people who avoided idol worship. Other ways to translate this clause are:

I will welcome you (RSV)

I will bring you into my presence

2 Corinthians 6:18

Section 6:11–7:4: Paul urged them to love him and live holy lives

In this section, Paul told the believers in Corinth that he loved them completely (6:11), but the believers did not love him completely (6:12). He urged them to love him completely (6:13).

Then he urged them to avoid partnerships with unbelievers (6:14a) and used five rhetorical questions (6:14b–16a) to support this exhortation. He also supported this exhortation with quotes from the Old Testament (6:16b–18). On the basis of these quotes, he then urged them to live pure lives (7:1).

He again urged them to love him (7:2a) and explained that he had not wronged anyone (7:2b). He explained that his love was complete (7:3) and he was very confident in them and very happy for them (7:4).

Other examples of headings for this section are:

Open your hearts to us, and live holy lives

Love us as we love you and live pure lives

6:18a–c

And: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as And indicates that Paul continues to quote from the Old Testament, but this is a different verse in the Old Testament.

I will be a Father to you, and you will be My sons and daughters, says the Lord Almighty: The BSB places the clause says the Lord Almighty after what God said. The BSB also places the verb says before the phrase the Lord Almighty in an alternate English style.

The BSB word order follows the Greek word order. You should place this clause where it is most natural in your language and word it in the way that is natural in your language. For example:

The Lord Almighty also says, “I will be a Father to you, and you will be my sons and daughters.”

Here Paul uses parts of 2 Samuel 7:14 and 7:8. If you footnote the locations of quotes from the Old Testament, you may want to do so here.

6:18a

And: “I will be a Father to you,

- “I will be your father, (GNT)
- “I will be like a father to you^(plur)

6:18b

and you will be My sons and daughters,

- and you will be my children,
- and you will be like my children to me,

6:18a–b

I will be a Father to you, and you will be My sons and daughters: God has a relationship with believers that is like a father-child relationship. He cares for them, guides them, protects them, and teaches them.

Some languages may not speak of God as Father. Such languages may be able to use “think,” “consider,” “regard,” or the comparative “as” here. For example:

I will be considered your Father and you will be considered my children

I will be like a father to you, and you will be like my children

6:18c

says the Lord Almighty.”

- says the all powerful Lord God.”

Almighty: The word Almighty means “all powerful.” This is a title for God. It indicates that God has more power than anyone else. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

the God of all power

the one who has all power

2 Corinthians 7:1

Section 6:11–7:4: Paul urged them to love him and live holy lives

In this section, Paul told the believers in Corinth that he loved them completely (6:11), but the believers did not love him completely (6:12). He urged them to love him completely (6:13).

Then he urged them to avoid partnerships with unbelievers (6:14a) and used five rhetorical questions (6:14b–16a) to support this exhortation. He also supported this exhortation with quotes from the Old Testament (6:16b–18). On the basis of these quotes, he then urged them to live pure lives (7:1).

He again urged them to love him (7:2a) and explained that he had not wronged anyone (7:2b). He explained that his love was complete (7:3) and he was very confident in them and very happy for them (7:4).

Other examples of headings for this section are:

Open your hearts to us, and live holy lives

Love us as we love you and live pure lives

7:1a

Therefore, beloved, since we have these promises,

- Therefore, my loved friends, having those promises,
- You^(plur) whom I love, since God promised those things to us^(incl),

Therefore, beloved, since we have these promises:

Here the term of address, beloved, comes after Paul begins saying something to the Corinthians. In Greek the term of address is literally at the end of this clause, and some English versions translate it that way. For example:

Since we have these promises, beloved (ESV)

In some languages it is more natural to have the term of address first. For example:

Dear friends, since we have these promises

Therefore...since we have these promises: The Greek words are literally “Therefore, having these promises” (as in the NASB). The conjunction Therefore indicates that the exhortation of 7:1b–c is based on the promises in Scripture that Paul quoted in 6:16c–18. The phrase since we have these promises reminds the reader of what Paul just said and prepares him for

the exhortation in 7:1b–c. Other ways to translate this clause are:

God has made us these promises. So... (CEV)

Those are the promises that were made to us, therefore

these promises: The word *these* is emphasized in the Greek. It is not possible to emphasize this word in English in the same way. If possible, emphasize this word in your language. Here is one way that you may be able to emphasize this:

These are the promises we have, beloved, so let us...

This phrase refers to the promises in 6:16–18. Clearly refer to them here. For example:

those promises

beloved: The Greek word that the BSB translates as *beloved* refers to people who are loved. Paul loved the believers in Corinth, so he addressed them with this Greek word. Other ways to translate this Greek word are:

You^(plur) whom I love

my loved friends

7:1b

let us cleanse ourselves from everything that defiles body and spirit,

- we^(incl) must cleanse ourselves from every practice that defiles body and spirit,
- let us avoid all practices that make any part of us bad/disgusting before God.

let us cleanse ourselves from: Here the verb *cleanse* refers figuratively to no longer sinning. Sin figuratively contaminates body and spirit. Other ways to translate this are:

let us separate from

we should stay away from (CEV)

we ought to turn our backs on

we must stop doing

let us: By saying *let us*, Paul included himself in this exhortation to the Corinthians to purify themselves. This grammar reminded the believers that Paul had a relationship with them and would do things with them.

everything that defiles body and spirit: The phrase *body and spirit* refers to the whole person. All practices that go against God's desires can hurt the body or the spirit of a person. Other ways to translate this are:

every defilement of body and spirit (RSV)

everything that makes body or soul/spirit religiously unclean

all things that make any part of us bad/disgusting before God

7:1c

perfecting holiness in the fear of God.

- and we must make holiness perfect by means of fearing and revering God.
- Let us also work to be completely holy by living in awe of God.

perfecting holiness in the fear of God: There are several ways to interpret how 7:1c is connected to 7:1b:

1. This is the second thing that Paul exhorts himself and the believers to do. For example:

and make holiness perfect in the fear of God (RSV) (RSV, GNT, NLT, GW, CEV, REB, NCV)

1. 7:1c is the result or purpose of Paul and the believers purifying themselves (7:1b). For example:

and thus accomplish holiness out of reverence for God (NET) (NJB, NRSV, NET, ESV)

1. 7:1c explains how Paul and the believers are to purify themselves (7:1b). For example:

perfecting holiness in the fear of God (NASB) (BSB, NIV, NABRE, NASB, KJV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Harris (p. 496), Kistemaker (p. 233), and Hughes (on TW) translate according to interpretation (1).

perfecting holiness: This phrase refers to the believer becoming more and more holy until he is completely holy. The believer makes himself more holy by following God's holy ways. Here is another way to translate this:

make holiness perfect (RSV)

holiness: This word refers to living without doing evil or sinning. The person separates himself from everything that contaminates body and spirit. Other ways to translate this word are:

consecration (REB)

pure/righteous/spotless life

without any blemish/wrong-doing

in the fear of God: This phrase probably indicates that believers were to become perfectly holy by fearing God. For example:

by living in awe of God (GNT)

the fear of God: The Greek word that the BSB translates as fear is sometimes translated as “reverence” (as in the NIV). Here the Greek word means to “respect” or “revere.” People who fear God are humble before God and are in awe of him. They also realize he is all-powerful and does as he chooses. So they respect and honor him. In some languages the word fear only means “be afraid of.” If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Include the meaning of “respect” or “venerate.” For example:

fear and respect/revere God

- Translate the meaning of fear as “respect” or “venerate.” For example:

honor God

See how you translated this word (fear) in 5:11.

2 Corinthians 7:2

Section 6:11–7:4: Paul urged them to love him and live holy lives

In this section, Paul told the believers in Corinth that he loved them completely (6:11), but the believers did not love him completely (6:12). He urged them to love him completely (6:13).

Then he urged them to avoid partnerships with unbelievers (6:14a) and used five rhetorical questions (6:14b–16a) to support this exhortation. He also supported this exhortation with quotes from the Old Testament (6:16b–18). On the basis of these quotes, he then urged them to live pure lives (7:1).

He again urged them to love him (7:2a) and explained that he had not wronged anyone (7:2b). He explained that his love was complete (7:3) and he was very confident in them and very happy for them (7:4).

Other examples of headings for this section are:

Open your hearts to us, and live holy lives

Love us as we love you and live pure lives

7:2a

Make room for us in your hearts.

- ¶ Make room in your^(plur) affections for us^(excl).
- ¶ Love us more.

Make room for us in your hearts: This clause refers to loving Paul and his coworkers more. The meaning is similar to “open wide your hearts” in 6:13b. Other ways to translate this clause are:

Open your hearts to us (RSV)

love us more

make your love for us great

7:2b–d

We have wronged no one, we have corrupted no one, we have exploited no one: These three clauses emphasize that Paul and his coworkers had not done anything evil to anyone. The false teachers probably claimed that Paul and his coworkers had wronged or corrupted or exploited others.

7:2b

We have wronged no one,

- We have done wrong/evil to no one,

- We did nothing improper/unjust to anyone,

We have wronged no one: This clause indicates that Paul and his coworkers had treated no one wrongly. They always did the right or proper things. Other ways to translate this clause are:

We have not done wrong to anyone (NCV)

We haven't treated anyone unjustly (GW)

7:2c

we have corrupted no one,

- we have led no one astray,
- we did not ruin the faith of anyone,

we have corrupted no one: This clause indicates that Paul and the others had not ruined anyone's morals or beliefs. Other ways to translate this clause are:

nor led anyone astray (NLT)

we have not ruined the faith of anyone (NCV)

7:2d

we have exploited no one.

- and we have cheated no one.
- and we did not deceive anyone regarding money.

we have exploited no one: This clause indicates that Paul and the others had not taken anyone's money by deceptive means or for wrong reasons. Other ways to translate this clause are:

nor taken advantage of anyone (NLT)

we have not cheated anyone (NCV)

2 Corinthians 7:3

Section 6:11–7:4: Paul urged them to love him and live holy lives

In this section, Paul told the believers in Corinth that he loved them completely (6:11), but the believers did not love him completely (6:12). He urged them to love him completely (6:13).

Then he urged them to avoid partnerships with unbelievers (6:14a) and used five rhetorical questions (6:14b–16a) to support this exhortation. He also supported this exhortation with quotes from the Old Testament (6:16b–18). On the basis of these quotes, he then urged them to live pure lives (7:1).

He again urged them to love him (7:2a) and explained that he had not wronged anyone (7:2b). He explained that his love was complete (7:3) and he was very confident in them and very happy for them (7:4).

Other examples of headings for this section are:

Open your hearts to us, and live holy lives

Love us as we love you and live pure lives

7:3a

I do not say this to condemn you.

- I do not say that to rebuke any of you^(plur).
- Concerning what I just said, I did not say it to accuse you of wrongdoing.

I do not say this to condemn you: Paul defended his ministry in 7:2b–d. This clause indicates that Paul did not imply that he criticized the believers in Corinth with those words. Other ways to translate this clause are:

I do not say this to blame you (NCV)

I did not say that to condemn/criticize any of you

7:3b

I have said before that you so occupy our hearts

- For I have already told you^(plur) that you are in our^(excl) hearts
- Because, just as I said/wrote earlier, we love you so much

7:3b begins with a conjunction that is often translated “because” or “for.” Here the conjunction introduces an explanation for Paul not condemning them (7:3a). Most English versions translate this conjunction. For example:

for (RSV)

In some languages it is more natural to allow the context to indicate that 7:3b explains 7:3a and omit the conjunction. The BSB and several other English versions omit the conjunction.

I have said before: This clause refers back to 6:12 and other verses where Paul explained that he loved the believers. Here is another way to translate this:

as I have already told you (NJB)

you so occupy our hearts: This clause indicates that Paul and the other evangelists already loved the believers in Corinth. The clause probably implies great love here. Other ways to translate this clause are:

you are in our hearts (RSV)

your place in our hearts is secure (REB)

we love you so much (NCV)

7:3c

that we live and die together with you.

- so that we would live or die together with you in any situation/circumstance.
- that we will not forsake you in life or death.

that: This word, together with the word “so” in 7:3b, indicate that 7:3c is the result of 7:3b. As a result of Paul’s love for them, he was willing to die with them.

we live and die together with you: This clause indicates that Paul was completely committed to them. It was a common expression for strong friendship at that time. Paul was willing to die with them if such a situation happened. Other ways to translate this clause are:

we will stand with you in life or death

together we live and together we die (NJB)

our friendship will not end in life or death

2 Corinthians 7:4

Section 6:11–7:4: Paul urged them to love him and live holy lives

In this section, Paul told the believers in Corinth that he loved them completely (6:11), but the believers did not love him completely (6:12). He urged them to love him completely (6:13).

Then he urged them to avoid partnerships with unbelievers (6:14a) and used five rhetorical questions (6:14b–16a) to support this exhortation. He also supported this exhortation with quotes from the Old Testament (6:16b–18). On the basis of these quotes, he then urged them to live pure lives (7:1).

He again urged them to love him (7:2a) and explained that he had not wronged anyone (7:2b). He explained

that his love was complete (7:3) and he was very confident in them and very happy for them (7:4).

Other examples of headings for this section are:

Open your hearts to us, and live holy lives

Love us as we love you and live pure lives

7:4a

Great is my confidence in you;

- I am completely confident in you^(plur),
- I am convinced that you will do the right thing,

Great is my confidence in you: There are several ways to interpret the Greek word that the BSB translates as confidence:

1. Here the word means confidence. For example:

I am so sure of you (GNT) (BSB, RSV, NIV, GNT, NABRE, NASB, NLT, GW, CEV, NET, NCV)

1. Here the word means speaking honestly. For example:

I can speak with the greatest frankness to you (NJB) (NJB, REB, NIV2011, KJV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Martin (p. 221) says that the meaning of the word is more general than “frankness” here. Kistemaker (p. 245) translates the Greek word as “confidence.” Hughes (on TW) translates this text as “Great is my boldness of speech toward you.”

7:4b

great is my pride in you;

- and am very proud of you. (NCV)
- and I have a lot of reasons to be proud of you. (GW)

great is my pride in you: Paul was happy about the accomplishments of the believers in Corinth. This clause implies that he may have boasted about them to others. Other ways to translate this clause are:

and am very proud of you (NCV)

I take great pride on your behalf (NET)

7:4c–d

I am filled with encouragement; in all our troubles my joy overflows: Paul was both encouraged and

joyful in all the difficulties that he and his coworkers experienced. For example:

in all our hardship, I am filled with encouragement and overflowing with joy (NJB)

7:4c

I am filled with encouragement; in all our troubles

- In the midst of all our^(excl) troubles/hardships, I am filled with comfort
- During all the difficulties that we are experiencing, I have been completely comforted and remain like that,

I am filled with encouragement: There are two ways to interpret the Greek word that the BSB translates as encouragement:

1. Here the word means comfort. While Paul had all those difficulties, God eased his worries. For example:

I am filled with comfort (NASB) (RSV, NASB, REB, ESV, NCV, KJV)

1. Here the word means to be encouraged. While Paul had all those difficulties, God helped him to be brave as an apostle. For example:

I am filled with encouragement (NJB) (BSB, NIV, GNT, NJB, NABRE, NLT, GW, CEV, NET)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Harris (p. 520), Thrall (p. 485), Barrett (p. 204), Furnish (p. 384), Hughes (on TW), and Kistemaker (p. 245) say that the meaning of the word is “comfort” here.

am filled with encouragement: The Greek words are literally “have been filled with encouragement/comfort.” It indicates a change in the past that was still true when Paul wrote this letter. So, when Titus came and told him about the believers in Corinth, he was completely encouraged and now remained completely encouraged. For example:

am filled with comfort (RSV)

in all our troubles: In the Greek, this phrase comes after the phrase “my joy overflows” (7:4d). But here it probably applies to both “I am greatly encouraged/comforted” and “my joy knows no bounds.” One way to indicate that is to put this phrase first and connect the other two phrases with “and.” For example:

in all our hardship, I am filled with encouragement and overflowing with joy (NJB)

in: The word in means “during” here. For example:

in the midst of all our suffering (NET)

troubles: This word probably refers to persecution and physical dangers. Paul describes some of his troubles in 1:8-10 and 11:23-27. Other ways to translate this word are:

hardships/difficulties

adversity

whenever we suffer

See how you translated this word in 1:4 or 6:4.

7:4d

my joy overflows.

- and overflowing with joy. (NJB)
- and I am now completely happy.

my joy overflows: The Greek words are literally “I am caused to be overflowing with joy.” Paul was completely happy. For example:

overflowing with joy (NJB)

2 Corinthians 7:5

Section 7:5–16: Paul was glad that the believers repented

In this section, Paul explained why he had great joy. Earlier he had sent Titus to Corinth because he wanted to know what the believers there were doing and whether they still accepted him. Paul had then gone to Macedonia, a northern province of Greece (7:5). He had met Titus there (7:6), and Titus had reported that the believers still accepted Paul and loved him (7:7a-d).

Then, in 7:8–9, Paul wrote that he was happy because the believers had responded properly to his earlier stern letter (also mentioned in 2:1–4; see also the section on “Paul’s letters to the Corinthians” in the introduction to these Notes). Paul explained the proper results of repentance (7:10–11). Lastly, Paul told them the reason for writing that letter (7:12–13a).

Then Paul told them that he was both encouraged and happy that they had responded properly to Titus (7:13b–16).

Other examples of headings for this section are:

Paul's Joy (NIV)

Paul's joy at the repentance of the Corinthians

Titus' news comforts Paul and makes him happy

7:5a

For when we arrived in Macedonia,

- ¶ For when we^(excl) entered Macedonia,
- ¶ Because, after we arrived here in the province of Macedonia,

For: This conjunction introduces an explanation of why Paul had great joy in the midst of troubles (7:4c–d).

when we arrived in Macedonia: Paul and the other evangelists left Troas (2:12) and traveled to Macedonia (2:13). They stayed in one of the cities in that province.

Macedonia: This name refers to a Roman province that today would include the northern part of the country of Greece and the land a bit farther north. But if you explained that the name Macedonia refers to a province in 1:16a or 2:13b, you probably do not need to explain that again here.

7:5b

our bodies had no rest,

- our bodies had no time free of troubles,
- we, in our being, had no peace.

our bodies: This phrase probably refers to the whole being, not only to the physical body. Bodies are vulnerable to many diseases and injury, but here Paul probably implied worrying and not trusting God completely. The worrying showed itself in physical restlessness and anxiety. The other evangelists with Paul were also restless and anxious. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

this body of ours (NIV)

our beings

In some languages it is more natural to use the pronoun “we” and allow the context to imply the whole person. For example:

we (NIV11)

had no rest: Here the word rest refers to time free from troubles, conflicts, and worries (7:5c–d). It does not refer to time free from work. Other ways to translate this clause are:

found no relief (REB)

had no peace

7:5c

but we were pressed from every direction—

- but we experienced all kinds of troubles/oppression:
- Indeed we underwent/experienced difficulties/hardships in all kinds of ways,

we were pressed: The Greek word that the BSB translates as were pressed refers to both trouble that occurs and the suffering a person experiences from that trouble. The Greek word includes people oppressing Paul and the others, but it also refers to any kind of difficulty or hardship. Other ways to translate this word are:

experience trouble/oppression

undergo hardships/suffering

You may want to translate this Greek word as you did in 1:6 (where the BSB says “are afflicted”) or 4:8 (where the BSB says “are hard pressed”).

from every direction: The Greek words are literally “in every way” (as in the NRSV). The BSB uses an English idiom to indicate that meaning here. Translate the meaning of “in every way.” Other ways to translate this phrase are:

all kinds of (CEV)

in a number of ways (GW)

7:5d

conflicts on the outside, fears within.

- enemies caused conflicts from the outside, and we had fears on the inside.
- namely, people opposing us, and the fears that we had.

7:5d describes the two kinds of being harassed (7:5c). The BSB indicates this connection with a long dash (—). Other ways to translate this connection are:

with battles on the outside and fear on the inside (NLT)

namely, conflicts on the outside, fears within

conflicts on the outside, fears within: Paul probably implied conflicts...outside his body/being and fears within his body/being here. People opposed Paul in Macedonia in Acts 16–17, and probably many of those same people opposed him again on this visit. Such conflicts were external to Paul. But within his mind he may have been fearful of the believers in Corinth rejecting him or Titus, and he may possibly have had other fears.

In some languages a literal translation would not indicate the correct implied meaning. If that is true in your language, you may want to add the implied meaning. For example:

conflicts on the outside of the body, fears within the body

conflicts on the outside of the/our inner person, fears within the/our inner person

quarrels with others, fears in our hearts (GNT)

conflicts: This word refers to people quarreling or confronting someone because they oppose him. Other ways to translate this word are:

disputes (NRSV)

We were troubled by enemies (CEV)

struggles (NET)

2 Corinthians 7:6

Section 7:5–16: Paul was glad that the believers repented

In this section, Paul explained why he had great joy. Earlier he had sent Titus to Corinth because he wanted to know what the believers there were doing and whether they still accepted him. Paul had then gone to Macedonia, a northern province of Greece (7:5). He had met Titus there (7:6), and Titus had reported that the believers still accepted Paul and loved him (7:7a–d).

Then, in 7:8–9, Paul wrote that he was happy because the believers had responded properly to his earlier

stern letter (also mentioned in 2:1–4; see also the section on “Paul’s letters to the Corinthians” in the introduction to these Notes). Paul explained the proper results of repentance (7:10–11). Lastly, Paul told them the reason for writing that letter (7:12–13a).

Then Paul told them that he was both encouraged and happy that they had responded properly to Titus (7:13b–16).

Other examples of headings for this section are:

Paul’s Joy (NIV)

Paul’s joy at the repentance of the Corinthians

Titus’ news comforts Paul and makes him happy

7:6a

But God, who comforts the downcast,

- But God, who encourages people when they are discouraged,
- But God comforts those who are downhearted/depressed,

But God, who comforts the downcast: The clause who comforts the downcast tells the reader more about God. In some languages a literal translation would wrongly indicate that Paul was thinking of other gods and only this one comforts the downcast. If that is true in your language, translate this clause so that it tells more about God. One way to do that is to start a new sentence here. For example:

But God comforts the downcast. And he

comforts: This word refers to easing sadness or discouragement so that a person is less sad or discouraged. The Greek word that the BSB translates as comforts also means “encourages.” God comforted Paul in each of his distresses and troubles and encouraged him to be strong in faith. See how you translated this word in 1:4 or 2:7.

the downcast: This phrase refers to people who are discouraged in some way. It probably implies God’s people rather than all people, given the similar wording in Isaiah 49:13. But you should refer generally to people here. Other ways to translate it are:

those who are discouraged (NLT)

downcast people

downcast: This word refers to being discouraged. A downcast person is tired in his spirit about all the bad things that have happened. He may not expect things to get better. Other ways to translate this word are:

downhearted (GNT)

depressed (NASB)

7:6b

comforted us by the arrival of Titus,

- encouraged us^(excl) by means of Titus coming back to us,
- and comforted us with Titus' return to us.

comforted us by the arrival of Titus: Titus arrived safely from Corinth with good news about the believers there. God comforted Paul and those with him with that news. Other ways to translate this are:

encouraged us through the arrival of Titus (NJB)

comforted us with Titus' return to us

2 Corinthians 7:7

Section 7:5–16: Paul was glad that the believers repented

In this section, Paul explained why he had great joy. Earlier he had sent Titus to Corinth because he wanted to know what the believers there were doing and whether they still accepted him. Paul had then gone to Macedonia, a northern province of Greece (7:5). He had met Titus there (7:6), and Titus had reported that the believers still accepted Paul and loved him (7:7a–d).

Then, in 7:8–9, Paul wrote that he was happy because the believers had responded properly to his earlier stern letter (also mentioned in 2:1–4; see also the section on “Paul’s letters to the Corinthians” in the introduction to these Notes). Paul explained the proper results of repentance (7:10–11). Lastly, Paul told them the reason for writing that letter (7:12–13a).

Then Paul told them that he was both encouraged and happy that they had responded properly to Titus (7:13b–16).

Other examples of headings for this section are:

Paul’s Joy (NIV)

Paul’s joy at the repentance of the Corinthians

Titus’ news comforts Paul and makes him happy

7:7a

and not only by his arrival,

- but not only by means of his coming,
- In addition to that,

7:7b

but also by the comfort he had received from you.

- but we^(excl) were encouraged by the news of you^(plur) encouraging him.
- God comforted us when we heard that you comforted him.

7:7a–b

and not only by his arrival, but also by the comfort he had received from you: The phrase not only by his arrival indicates that Paul received comfort from God in another way besides seeing Titus. The way the Corinthians had treated Titus was also an encouragement to Paul. It showed their true feelings, not just for Titus but for Paul as well. Other ways to translate this are:

not merely by his arrival, but by his being so greatly encouraged about you (REB)

His presence was a joy, but so was the news he brought of the encouragement he received from you (NLT)

7:7c

He told us about your longing,

- For he reported to us that you really wanted to see me,
- He told us that you desired very much to see me,

He told us about: The Greek words are literally “reporting to us.” This expression indicates that 7:7c–d gives examples of the things that had comforted Titus (7:7b). Other ways to translate this are:

as he told us of (RSV)

reporting to us that

your longing: This expression does not indicate in what way the Corinthians longed for Paul. Here their longing/desire could have been:

1. to see Paul again in person;
2. to restore their relationship with Paul.

Translate in a way that allows one or both of these implied meanings. Harris (p. 530) that their longing “may refer to the Corinthians’ longing to see Paul himself (cf. 2:1...) or to be reconciled to him or to do what was right by him.” If a literal translation would imply the wrong meaning in your language, you may want to include the implied information in your translation. For example:

how much you want to see me (GNT)

7:7d

your mourning, and your zeal for me,

- that you sorrowed much, and that you were eager to do anything for me,
- that you were very sad/sorry, and that you are strongly committed to me.

your mourning: This expression does not indicate in what way the Corinthians mourned. Here their sorrow could have been about:

1. the events that caused Paul to write the severe letter (2:4, 7:8);
2. their bad behavior during those events.

Translate in a way that allows one or both of these implied meanings. If a literal translation would imply the wrong meaning in your language, you may want to include some implied information in your translation. For example:

your great sorrow regarding the events that I mentioned in my letter

your great sorrow about your behavior back then

and your zeal for me: The Greek word that the BSB translates as zeal refers to eagerness or concern to do something. Here the word probably refers to eagerly wanting to do all that Paul had told them to do. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

your ardent concern for me (NIV)

how loyal you are to me (NLT)

how eager to take my side (REB)

7:7e

so that I rejoiced all the more.

- so now I rejoiced even more.

- So all those things made my joy even greater than before.

so that: This phrase introduces the result of all the things in 7:7b–d. Each of those things added to Paul’s joy.

I rejoiced all the more: This clause indicates that Paul’s joy grew greater when he heard Titus’ report of the believers and their attitudes toward Paul. Other ways to translate this clause are:

my joy was greater than ever (NIV)

I was much happier (NCV)

2 Corinthians 7:8

Section 7:5–16: Paul was glad that the believers repented

In this section, Paul explained why he had great joy. Earlier he had sent Titus to Corinth because he wanted to know what the believers there were doing and whether they still accepted him. Paul had then gone to Macedonia, a northern province of Greece (7:5). He had met Titus there (7:6), and Titus had reported that the believers still accepted Paul and loved him (7:7a–d).

Then, in 7:8–9, Paul wrote that he was happy because the believers had responded properly to his earlier stern letter (also mentioned in 2:1–4; see also the section on “Paul’s letters to the Corinthians” in the introduction to these Notes). Paul explained the proper results of repentance (7:10–11). Lastly, Paul told them the reason for writing that letter (7:12–13a).

Then Paul told them that he was both encouraged and happy that they had responded properly to Titus (7:13b–16).

Other examples of headings for this section are:

Paul’s Joy (NIV)

Paul’s joy at the repentance of the Corinthians

Titus’ news comforts Paul and makes him happy

7:8a

Even if I caused you sorrow by my letter, I do not regret it.

- ¶! For even if what I wrote in my letter made you^(plur) sad, I am not sorry that I wrote it.

- ¶ I do not regret having written that letter to you, even though it grieved you.

7:8a begins with a Greek conjunction that is often translated as “for” or “because.” In this context it introduces an explanation for Paul’s joy (7:7e). He was very happy with how the believers had responded to his letter (7:8–13a). Some ways to translate this conjunction are:

For (RSV)

So now (NJB)

Because

In some languages it is more natural to allow the context to indicate the connection and omit the conjunction, as the BSB and several other English versions do.

Even if I caused you sorrow by my letter, I do not regret it: Paul knew he should write the letter. If the letter caused sorrow, that was also as it should be. The word if is used rhetorically to cause the believers in Corinth to think about that sorrow. The word if does not indicate that Paul doubted that he had caused them sorrow. Other ways to translate this are:

though I did distress you with my letter, I do not regret it (NJB)

though I caused you sorrow by my letter, I do not regret it (NASB)

even if/though you were saddened because of that letter to you, I now have no regret that I wrote it

caused you sorrow: What Paul wrote in the letter made the believers sad. In it, Paul probably rebuked them for not doing the right thing. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

made you sad (GNT)

grieved you (NRSV)

my letter: Scholars sometimes refer to this letter as “the severe letter” because of the description of its results in this verse. (This letter is probably not 1

Corinthians; see the section on “Paul’s letters to the Corinthians” in the introduction to these Notes).

regret: The word regret refers to someone wishing they had acted differently than they had done. Earlier, Paul had changed his mind and wished he had not sent the letter. He feared a bad result, but now he was glad he had sent the letter.

7:8b

Although I did regret it,

- For some time I was sorry that I had written it,
- I was regretting for a while that I sent it.

Although I did regret it: There are two ways to interpret the Greek clause:

1. Paul regretted in the past. For example:

though I was sorry at first (NLT) (BSB, RSV, NIV, NASB, NLT, GW, CEV, NET, REB, NCV, ESV, KJV)

1. Paul did not regret in the past. For example:

I could have been sorry (GNT) (GNT, NJB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Martin says, “this regret is now a thing of the past, for when Paul wrote 2 Corinthians he had already heard the good report from Titus of the Corinthians’ change of heart” (p. 228). Thrall (p. 486), Kistemaker (p. 251), Barrett (p. 210), Furnish (p. 384), Hughes (on TW), and Harris (p. 532) support interpretation (1) in their translations.

I did regret it: The Greek words indicate that Paul had regretted for some time in the past. Perhaps soon after he sent the letter, Paul regretted sending it. But Titus arrived with good news about the believers dealing properly with what Paul had said in the letter. So Paul no longer regretted sending it. Other ways to translate this clause are:

I did regret it for some time

I was regretting it

7:8c

I now see that my letter caused you sorrow, but only for a short time.

- for I know it was painful to you for a little while. (NLT)
- I realize that the letter grieved you, even though not for long—

caused you sorrow: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as caused you sorrow is the same verb translated as “caused you sorrow” in 7:8a. Here is another way to translate this verb in both places:

made you sad (GNT)

but only for a short time: These words indicate that the sorrow or hurt lasted only a little while. These words do not refer to how long Paul’s regret lasted.

2 Corinthians 7:9

Section 7:5–16: Paul was glad that the believers repented

In this section, Paul explained why he had great joy. Earlier he had sent Titus to Corinth because he wanted to know what the believers there were doing and whether they still accepted him. Paul had then gone to Macedonia, a northern province of Greece (7:5). He had met Titus there (7:6), and Titus had reported that the believers still accepted Paul and loved him (7:7a–d).

Then, in 7:8–9, Paul wrote that he was happy because the believers had responded properly to his earlier stern letter (also mentioned in 2:1–4; see also the section on “Paul’s letters to the Corinthians” in the introduction to these Notes). Paul explained the proper results of repentance (7:10–11). Lastly, Paul told them the reason for writing that letter (7:12–13a).

Then Paul told them that he was both encouraged and happy that they had responded properly to Titus (7:13b–16).

Other examples of headings for this section are:

Paul’s Joy (NIV)

Paul’s joy at the repentance of the Corinthians

Titus’ news comforts Paul and makes him happy

7:9a

And now I rejoice,

- Now I am glad that I wrote it,
- but now I rejoice that I sent it.

And now I rejoice: This clause refers to sending the letter. For example:

Now I am glad I sent it (NLT)

7:9b

not because you were made sorrowful,

- not because you^(plur) were made sorrowful,
- I am not happy because I caused you grief.

not because you were made sorrowful: 7:9b indicates that Paul was not happy that he had made the believers sad.

you were made sorrowful: This clause is passive. Paul’s letter caused the believers to be sad. Some languages must use an active clause. For example:

my letter made you sorry

I made you sad (GNT)

made sorrowful: The Greek word that the BSB translates as made sorrowful is the same word translated as “cause sorrow” in 7:8a. You may wish to translate it here the same way you translated it there.

7:9c

but because your sorrow led you to repentance.

- but because your sorrow caused you to repent.
- But I am happy because the grief that you felt made you change your thinking and follow God again.

but because your sorrow led you to repentance: 7:9c indicates that Paul was happy because the believers’ sorrow had led them to repent.

your sorrow led you to repentance: This clause indicates that their sorrow caused the believers to repent. Other ways to translate this clause are:

you were grieved into repenting (RSV)

your sadness made you change your mind and follow God

repentance: This word refers to changing one’s mind. The word implies that the believers stopped sinning and began obeying God again. Some other examples are:

turn back to him (CEV)

change your lives (NCV)

leave the ways of sin and follow the ways of God

General Comment on 7:9a–c

In some languages it is more natural to translate the reason (7:9c) before something that is not the reason (7:9b). For example:

^ayet now I am happy ^cbecause your sorrow led you to repentance, ^bnot because you were made sorry

7:9d**For you felt the sorrow that God had intended,**

- For your sorrow was according to what God wanted you to feel,
- What I mean is this: you grieved in a godly way,

For: This conjunction introduces an explanation of why their sorrow led to repentance (7:9c).

you felt the sorrow that God had intended: The Greek words are literally “you became sorrowful in accordance with God.” It indicates that their sorrow was a proper, godly kind of sorrow that would lead them to repentance. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

You became sad in the way God wanted you to (NCV)

You were distressed in a godly way (GW)

It was the kind of sorrow God wants his people to have (NLT)

7:9e**and so were not harmed in any way by us.**

- and so you had/incurred no loss/hurt through us^(excl).
- and so we caused you no harm at all.

and so were not harmed in any way by us: These words indicate that Paul’s letter and Titus’ visit did not hurt the Corinthians in any way. Their faith remained strong, their reputation was not harmed, and so forth. Other ways to translate this are:

you suffered no loss through us (RSV)

your faith was not hurt by us

The Greek clause that the BSB translates as were not harmed...by us is passive. In some languages an active clause must be used. For example:

we caused you no harm (GNT)

2 Corinthians 7:10**Section 7:5–16: Paul was glad that the believers repented**

In this section, Paul explained why he had great joy. Earlier he had sent Titus to Corinth because he wanted to know what the believers there were doing and whether they still accepted him. Paul had then gone to Macedonia, a northern province of Greece (7:5). He had met Titus there (7:6), and Titus had reported that the believers still accepted Paul and loved him (7:7a–d).

Then, in 7:8–9, Paul wrote that he was happy because the believers had responded properly to his earlier stern letter (also mentioned in 2:1–4; see also the section on “Paul’s letters to the Corinthians” in the introduction to these Notes). Paul explained the proper results of repentance (7:10–11). Lastly, Paul told them the reason for writing that letter (7:12–13a).

Then Paul told them that he was both encouraged and happy that they had responded properly to Titus (7:13b–16).

Other examples of headings for this section are:

Paul’s Joy (NIV)

Paul’s joy at the repentance of the Corinthians

Titus’ news comforts Paul and makes him happy

7:10a–b**repentance that leads to salvation without regret:**

The Greek word that the BSB translates as without regret probably connects to the word repentance. Repentance has two results: salvation and no regret. For example:

repentance that leads to salvation and that leaves no regret

7:10a**Godly sorrow brings repentance**

- For sorrow according to what God wants causes people to repent,
- For example, when a person grieves in a godly way, he changes his thinking and follows God,

7:10a begins with a Greek conjunction that is often translated as “for” or “because.” In this context it

introduces an explanation of the kind of sorrow that leads to repentance (7:9c). For example:

For (RSV)

In fact, (GW)

In some languages it is more natural to allow the context to indicate the connection and omit the conjunction, as the BSB and some other English versions do.

Godly sorrow: The Greek words are literally “sorrow according to God.” The Greek phrase is similar in meaning to the Greek phrase “you became sorrowful according to God” in 7:9d. This kind of sorrow occurs according to what God would want believers to be sad about. Translate this phrase in a similar way to the phrase in 7:9d. For example:

sadness in the way God wants

godly grief (NRSV)

the kind of sorrow God wants us to experience (NLT)

brings repentance: Here the verb brings refers to causing something. If a person has sorrow over his own sin, then he should repent of that sin. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

produces a repentance (RSV)

leads to repentance (NJB)

repentance: Here the word repentance probably refers to turning from all sin, because this repentance leads to salvation (7:10b). Translate in a way that allows this meaning.

7:10b

that leads to salvation without regret,

- and that results in salvation and there is no regret in it.
- so that God rescues/saves him from eternal death. And no one is ever sad/sorry about those results.

that leads to salvation: This phrase indicates that the result of this kind of repentance is salvation.

salvation: This word refers to rescuing or saving someone from something. God saves people from

eternal death when they believe in Jesus. Other ways to translate this word are:

saving/freeing by God

God saving him/them

being saved from eternal death

See how you translated this word in 1:6.

without regret: The Greek word here literally means “no regrets.” Repentance and salvation do not result in regrets. Other ways to translate this Greek word are:

and brings no regret (RSV)

—and there is no regret in that (GNT)

you don’t have anything to feel bad about (CEV)

7:10c

but worldly sorrow brings death.

- But worldly people’s kind of sorrow results in death.
- But the grief of worldly people leads to eternal death.

worldly sorrow: This phrase refers to sorrow as unbelievers experience it. This kind of sorrow leads to hiding sin, making excuses, blaming others, and other things that do not lead to repentance. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

sadness that is merely human (GNT)

worldly grief (NRSV)

sorrow of worldly people

brings death: If a person experiences worldly sorrow, he sins more to hide it, blames others, or does something else hurtful. He does not turn to God. God will judge him guilty because he did not repent. So in that way worldly sorrow brings God’s punishment, namely eternal death in hell.

In some languages a literal translation of the word death would wrongly refer only to physical death. If that is true in your language, you may want to include the implied information in your translation. For example:

brings eternal death

2 Corinthians 7:11

Section 7:5–16: Paul was glad that the believers repented

In this section, Paul explained why he had great joy. Earlier he had sent Titus to Corinth because he wanted to know what the believers there were doing and whether they still accepted him. Paul had then gone to Macedonia, a northern province of Greece (7:5). He had met Titus there (7:6), and Titus had reported that the believers still accepted Paul and loved him (7:7a–d).

Then, in 7:8–9, Paul wrote that he was happy because the believers had responded properly to his earlier stern letter (also mentioned in 2:1–4; see also the section on “Paul’s letters to the Corinthians” in the introduction to these Notes). Paul explained the proper results of repentance (7:10–11). Lastly, Paul told them the reason for writing that letter (7:12–13a).

Then Paul told them that he was both encouraged and happy that they had responded properly to Titus (7:13b–16).

Other examples of headings for this section are:

Paul’s Joy (NIV)

Paul’s joy at the repentance of the Corinthians

Titus’ news comforts Paul and makes him happy

7:11a–b

Consider what this godly sorrow has produced in you: what earnestness, what eagerness to clear yourselves: The word earnestness is the first item in the list. The godly sorrow produced everything in the list. It produced them in proper measure. For example:

See what God did with this sadness of yours: how earnest it has made you, how eager to prove your innocence... (GNT)

7:11a

Consider what this godly sorrow has produced in you:

- For look at this sorrow according to God’s ways, see how much it produced in you:
- Also, you^(plur) grieved according to God’s plan. Look at all the good results:

7:11a begins with a Greek conjunction that is often translated as “for” or “because.” In this context it introduces more that Paul wanted to say about godly sorrow. For example:

For (RSV)

Just (NLT)

In some languages it is more natural to allow the context to indicate the connection and omit the conjunction.

Consider what this godly sorrow has produced in you: The Greek words are literally “Look how much this very grieving according to God produced in you.” This clause indicates that godly sorrow produced much godly fruit. The list of godly fruit is in 7:11b–d. Other ways to translate this are:

For see what this very thing, this sadness as God intended, has produced in you (NET)

For just look at what was achieved in your lives by that grief which was in accordance with God’s will Tagbanwa Back Translation in Translator’s Workplace.

You experienced your sorrow in the way that God wants, and just look at the results

Consider: This word emphasizes the clause “what this godly sorrow has produced in you.” It is not a command to look at something.

7:11b–d

what earnestness, what eagerness to clear yourselves, what indignation, what alarm, what longing, what zeal, what vindication!: Here the word what emphasizes that the believers did indeed have earnestness, eagerness to clear themselves, indignation, alarm, longing, zeal, and vindication. Repeating the word what continues the emphasis for each phrase. Other ways to translate this are:

such earnestness, such eagerness to clear yourselves, such indignation, such alarm, such longing, such concern, such readiness to see justice done

much earnestness, and also much eagerness to clear yourselves, and also much indignation, and

also much alarm, and also much longing, and also much concern, and also much readiness to see justice done

You showed much earnestness and much eagerness to clear yourselves. You also showed much indignation and much alarm. You also showed much longing and concern. And you also showed much readiness to see justice done.

7:11b

what earnestness, what eagerness to clear yourselves,

- such eagerness to do right, such clear defense of your deeds,
- You dealt with the issues/matters seriously. You readily disproved the charges against you.

earnestness: This word refers to having a strong desire to do the right thing and making every effort to do it. Paul probably indicated some things that were wrong among the believers, and they eagerly corrected those things. Other ways to translate this word are:

devoted to doing the right thing

eagerly doing what was right

deal with the issues/matters seriously

eagerness to clear yourselves: The Greek word is literally “defense.” It refers to defending their own actions properly. Paul may have accused them of some sins in the severe letter he had sent earlier, but the believers needed to correct his misunderstandings and show that they had not done those things. They wanted to show him that they had done the right thing. Other ways to translate this are:

defence (NJB)

vindicate yourselves (REB)

You were ready to clear yourselves of the charges against you (GW)

You sincerely want to prove that you are innocent (CEV)

7:11c

what indignation, what alarm, what longing,

- such upset over the sins, such shock at wrongdoing, such desire,
- You were offended with the wrong that had been done. You feared/honored God. You desired to see me.

indignation: The word indignation refers to being upset about a wrong. Here they may have been upset at:

1. the wrongdoer for his sin;
2. themselves for not doing as they should have done before Paul wrote.

If possible, translate the word indignation in a way that allows one or more of the above possible situations. Other ways to translate this word are:

upset over the sin

You were disgusted with the wrong that had been done (GW)

You are angry (CEV)

alarm: The Greek word here is usually translated “fear.” Here they may have been:

1. jolted emotionally by the severe letter;
2. fearing God in the usual sense of revering God;
3. worried about the effect of their earlier laziness in obeying Paul, so that he needed to write the severe letter;
4. afraid of not being a good witness to the world because they did not deal with the wrongdoer immediately.

If possible, translate the word alarm in a way that allows one or more of the above possible situations. Other ways to translate this word are:

fear of God

You are shocked (CEV)

This alarm is a good result of the sorrow. Translate in a way that indicates or implies that the alarm was a good result.

longing: The word longing refers to desiring something. Here they may have been desiring:

1. to see Paul again;

2. to restore their relationship with Paul.

Translate the word longing in a way that allows one or both of the above possible interpretations. Other ways to translate this word are:

desire to see me again

You wanted to see us (GW)

desire to restore our relationship

7:11d

what zeal, what vindication!

- such zeal, and such readiness to punish properly.
- You showed your eagerness to follow my commands. And you punished the wrongdoers properly.

zeal: The Greek word that the BSB translates as zeal refers to eagerness or concern to do something. Here the word probably refers to wanting eagerly to do all that Paul told them to do. Other ways to translate this word are:

You are eager to see that justice is done (CEV)

You wanted to show your concern for us (GW)

your devotion (REB)

See how you translated this word in 7:7.

vindication: Here the Greek word that the BSB translates as vindication refers to punishing someone for wrongdoing. When Paul showed the wrongdoer to them, they immediately applied a proper punishment to him. Other ways to translate this Greek word are:

punishment (RSV)

You were ready to punish the wrong that had been done (GW)

your eagerness to see justice done (REB)

7:11e

In every way you have proved yourselves to be innocent in this matter.

- In everything you showed yourselves to be blameless in that wrongdoing.

- You proved you were completely free of guilt in that problem.

In every way you have proved yourselves to be innocent in this matter: The believers in Corinth did not participate in whatever the wrongdoer did. This clause indicates that they proved to Titus and so to Paul that they had done nothing wrong in that case. (But they probably did not try to correct the sinner as soon as they found out, which is partly why Paul wrote the severe letter.) Other ways to translate this clause are:

In every way you have cleared yourselves of blame in this matter (NJB)

You proved you were innocent in the problem (NCV)

2 Corinthians 7:12

Section 7:5–16: Paul was glad that the believers repented

In this section, Paul explained why he had great joy. Earlier he had sent Titus to Corinth because he wanted to know what the believers there were doing and whether they still accepted him. Paul had then gone to Macedonia, a northern province of Greece (7:5). He had met Titus there (7:6), and Titus had reported that the believers still accepted Paul and loved him (7:7a–d).

Then, in 7:8–9, Paul wrote that he was happy because the believers had responded properly to his earlier stern letter (also mentioned in 2:1–4; see also the section on “Paul’s letters to the Corinthians” in the introduction to these Notes). Paul explained the proper results of repentance (7:10–11). Lastly, Paul told them the reason for writing that letter (7:12–13a).

Then Paul told them that he was both encouraged and happy that they had responded properly to Titus (7:13b–16).

Other examples of headings for this section are:

Paul’s Joy (NIV)

Paul’s joy at the repentance of the Corinthians

Titus’ news comforts Paul and makes him happy

7:12a

So even though I wrote to you,

- So, although I wrote earlier to you^(plur),

- So I wrote that letter to you, but

even though I wrote to you: The phrase even though indicates that Paul did write, but he did not write for the purpose of punishing the wrongdoer (7:12b) or helping the person wronged (7:12c). Other ways to translate this clause are:

although I wrote to you (RSV)

when I wrote to you, I didn't write because (GW)

I wrote that letter, not because of (NCV)

I wrote to you, but

I wrote to you: This clause refers to the severe letter that Paul wrote earlier. (See note on "my letter" in 7:8a.) Your translation should indicate or imply that same letter.

7:12b

it was not on account of the one who did wrong

- it was not for the sake of the wrongdoer
- I did not write for the purpose of dealing with the person who did the wrong,

it was not on account of the one who did wrong: This clause probably refers to the person mentioned in 2:5–8. The main purpose of Paul writing the severe letter was something other than commanding the believers to punish the wrongdoer. Other ways to translate this clause are:

it was not for the sake of the offender (NJB)

My purpose...was not to write about who did the wrong (NLT)

I didn't write because of the man who did the wrong (GW)

it wasn't to accuse the one who was wrong (CEV)

7:12c

or the one who was harmed,

- nor for the sake of the person he had wronged,
- and I did not write for the person he hurt.

or the one who was harmed: The Greek word that the BSB translates as "on account of" in 7:12b also occurs here. The BSB does not repeat it here, but the

English implies that meaning. In some languages it is necessary or more natural to have "on account of" in your translation here. For example:

nor on account of the one who suffered the wrong (RSV)

the one who was harmed: This phrase refers to the person who was sinned against. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

the one offended (NJB)

who was wronged (NLT)

the man who was hurt by it (GW)

7:12d

but rather that your earnestness on our behalf would be made clear to you in the sight of God.

- but rather I wrote earlier so that you would realize before God that you indeed earnestly support us^(excl) as your leaders.
- Rather, I wrote that letter so that it would be plain to you in the sight of God how loyal you are to us.

but rather that your earnestness on our behalf would be made clear to you in the sight of God:

The Greek words are literally "but on the account of making clear to yourselves before God your zeal/devotion for us." It describes the real reason why Paul wrote. Other ways to translate this clause are:

but in order that your zeal for us might be revealed to you in the sight of God (RSV)

but to let you see for yourselves, in the sight of God, how deeply you really do care for us (JBP)

My aim in writing was to help to make plain to you, in the sight of God, how truly you are devoted to us. (REB)

your earnestness on our behalf would be made clear to you: This clause indicates that now the believers understood that they were fully committed to following Paul as their leader. Other ways to translate this clause are:

your zeal for us might be revealed to you in the sight of God (RSV)

to make plain to you, in God's sight, how deep your devotion to us really is (GNT)

you yourselves should fully realise in the sight of God what concern you have for us (NJB)

your earnestness on our behalf: The Greek word that the BSB translates as earnestness is the same Greek word that the BSB translates as “earnestness” in 7:11b. Here the word refers to earnestly supporting Paul. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

your zeal for us (RSV)

your earnestness on our behalf (NASB)

loyal...to us (NLT)

in the sight of God: This phrase indicates that God was aware of what the believers experienced. Here is another way to translate this:

in God's sight (GNT)

General Comment on 7:12a–d

In some languages it is more natural to have the positive reason (7:12d) before the negative reasons (7:12b–c). For example:

^{12a}So I wrote to you ^{12d}so that before God you could see for yourselves how devoted to us you are, ^{12b}and it was not on account of the one who did the wrong ^{12c}or of the injured party.

^{12a}So I wrote to you ^{12d}so that before God you could see for yourselves how devoted to us you are. ^{12b}I did not write to you on account of the one who did the wrong ^{12c}or on account of the injured party.

2 Corinthians 7:13

Section 7:5–16: Paul was glad that the believers repented

In this section, Paul explained why he had great joy. Earlier he had sent Titus to Corinth because he wanted to know what the believers there were doing and whether they still accepted him. Paul had then gone to Macedonia, a northern province of Greece (7:5). He had

met Titus there (7:6), and Titus had reported that the believers still accepted Paul and loved him (7:7a–d).

Then, in 7:8–9, Paul wrote that he was happy because the believers had responded properly to his earlier stern letter (also mentioned in 2:1–4; see also the section on “Paul’s letters to the Corinthians” in the introduction to these Notes). Paul explained the proper results of repentance (7:10–11). Lastly, Paul told them the reason for writing that letter (7:12–13a).

Then Paul told them that he was both encouraged and happy that they had responded properly to Titus (7:13b–16).

Other examples of headings for this section are:

Paul’s Joy (NIV)

Paul’s joy at the repentance of the Corinthians

Titus’ news comforts Paul and makes him happy

7:13a

On account of this, we are encouraged.

- Therefore we^(excl) are encouraged.
- All those things encouraged us.

On account of this, we are encouraged: The phrase On account of this refers to all that the believers did, as Paul mentioned in 7:6–12. Other ways to translate this clause are:

Therefore we are comforted (RSV)

That is why we were encouraged (GNT)

This clause is passive. In some languages an active clause must be used. For example:

All this encouraged us

encouraged: This word refers to making someone feel confident and happy about something. Paul was now confident about the Corinthians’ faith and happy to see them obey God.

7:13b

In addition to our own encouragement,

- ¶ Even more than us^(excl) being encouraged,
- ¶ And beyond our own encouragement,

7:13b–c

In addition to our own encouragement, we were even more delighted: There is a textual issue in 7:13b. (1) The earliest Greek manuscripts have the pronoun *our* (BSB, RSV, NIV, GNT, NJB, NASB, NLT, GW, CEV, NET, JBP, REB, ESV, NCV). (2) Some later Greek manuscripts have the pronoun *your* (KJV only). It is recommended that you follow option (1). This clause indicates that Paul was even more delighted that Titus was very happy. Other ways to translate this clause are:

besides our own comfort we rejoiced still more (RSV)

But besides being encouraged ourselves, we have also been delighted beyond everything (REB)

7:13c

we were even more delighted by the joy of Titus.

- we were very joyful to see how happy Titus was,
- we were even more happy to see Titus so happy when he arrived here.

by the joy of Titus: This phrase refers to when Titus returned to Paul after his visit with the believers in Corinth (7:6–7). Titus was very happy to see the believers strong in their faith and following Paul as their leader.

7:13d

For his spirit has been refreshed by all of you.

- because all of you^(plur) encouraged him and set his mind/insides at ease.
- For you all uplifted/energized him and ended his worry.

his spirit has been refreshed by all of you: This clause is passive. The believers refreshed his spirit. Some languages must use an active clause. For example:

all of you have refreshed his spirit

his spirit has been refreshed: This clause can mean:

1. Titus was refreshed in spirit, that is, he was encouraged by seeing their strong faith;
2. His mind was at rest, that is, he was no longer worried.

Paul probably meant both of the above. If possible, translate in a way that includes both meanings. Other ways to translate this clause are:

all of you encouraged him and set his mind at ease

All of you made him feel much better (NCV)

his spirit: This refers to the inner part of a person that does not die when the body dies. In some languages the word *spirit* is only used when the body has died. If that is true in your language, refer to the inner part of a person while the person is still alive. For example:

his insides/stomach

In English, this is often translated as “heart.” See how you translated “heart” in 5:12.

2 Corinthians 7:14

Section 7:5–16: Paul was glad that the believers repented

In this section, Paul explained why he had great joy. Earlier he had sent Titus to Corinth because he wanted to know what the believers there were doing and whether they still accepted him. Paul had then gone to Macedonia, a northern province of Greece (7:5). He had met Titus there (7:6), and Titus had reported that the believers still accepted Paul and loved him (7:7a–d).

Then, in 7:8–9, Paul wrote that he was happy because the believers had responded properly to his earlier stern letter (also mentioned in 2:1–4; see also the section on “Paul’s letters to the Corinthians” in the introduction to these Notes). Paul explained the proper results of repentance (7:10–11). Lastly, Paul told them the reason for writing that letter (7:12–13a).

Then Paul told them that he was both encouraged and happy that they had responded properly to Titus (7:13b–16).

Other examples of headings for this section are:

Paul’s Joy (NIV)

Paul’s joy at the repentance of the Corinthians

Titus’ news comforts Paul and makes him happy

7:14a–b

I was not embarrassed by anything I had boasted to him about you: The Greek words are literally “If I have boasted somewhat to him about you, I was not shamed.” The Greek words begin with the word “if.” The word “if” is used rhetorically to cause the

believers in Corinth to think about the outcome of that boasting, which is that they did as he boasted. So he was not embarrassed or shamed. Paul's boasting is a fact.

In some languages the word “if” can be used rhetorically here with the above meaning. If that is true in your language, you may want to follow the literal Greek. For example:

if I have been somewhat boastful about you to him, I was not disgraced (NRSV)

if I have boasted to him about anything concerning you, I have not been embarrassed by you (NET)

Here the word “if” does not indicate possibility or doubt. In some languages, translating the word “if” will not indicate the correct meaning. If that is so, follow the BSB and other English versions that omit the word “if.” For example:

I did boast of you to him, and you have not disappointed me (GNT)

whatever boasts I made to him about you, I was not put to shame (ESV)

I didn't have to be ashamed of anything I had said to him when I bragged about you (GW)

7:14a

Indeed, I was not embarrassed

- I was not shamed.
- And you did not shame/disappoint me.

Indeed: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as Indeed is often translated as “for” or “because.” In this context it introduces another reason for Paul's joy (7:13c). For example:

For (RSV)

In some languages it is more natural to allow the context to indicate the connection and omit the conjunction.

embarrassed: This word refers to feeling anxious and uncomfortable because of a difficulty that one was responsible for. Paul would have been embarrassed if the believers had not obeyed him, because he was their leader. Other ways to translate this word are:

made to look foolish (NJB)

put to shame (RSV)

7:14b

by anything I had boasted to him about you.

- For if I have expressed to him some pride in you, (RSV)
- Earlier I boasted of you^(plur) to him,

I had boasted: This clause refers to the time before Titus left Paul and went to Corinth. Titus' trip to Corinth and back probably lasted a month or more. Another example is:

Earlier I boasted

boasted: This word refers to praising someone or saying how good someone is. Other ways to translate this word are:

speak very highly about

praise

tell about how great/wonderful/good

See how you translated this word in 1:12.

7:14c

But just as everything we said to you was true,

- just as all the things that I told you were true,
- Everything I said to you has been the truth.

7:14c-d

just as everything we said to you was true, so our boasting to Titus has proved to be true as well:

These words compare the phrase everything we said to you and the phrase our boasting to Titus. Both phrases were true. Here is another way to translate this:

We have always spoken the truth to you, and in the same way the boast we made to Titus has proved true (GNT)

7:14d

so our boasting to Titus has proved to be true as well.

- so our boasting about you to Titus has shown itself to be true.
- In the same way your deeds made my boasts to Titus true.

our boasting to Titus has proved to be true as well: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as has proved to be true is literally “became truth.” Before Titus arrived in Corinth, Paul’s boasts were his expectations about the believers in Corinth. After the believers did as Paul expected, his boasts became true. Other ways to translate this clause are:

our boasting about you to Titus has shown itself to be true

your deeds have shown that our boasting about you to Titus was true

2 Corinthians 7:15

Section 7:5–16: Paul was glad that the believers repented

In this section, Paul explained why he had great joy. Earlier he had sent Titus to Corinth because he wanted to know what the believers there were doing and whether they still accepted him. Paul had then gone to Macedonia, a northern province of Greece (7:5). He had met Titus there (7:6), and Titus had reported that the believers still accepted Paul and loved him (7:7a–d).

Then, in 7:8–9, Paul wrote that he was happy because the believers had responded properly to his earlier stern letter (also mentioned in 2:1–4; see also the section on “Paul’s letters to the Corinthians” in the introduction to these Notes). Paul explained the proper results of repentance (7:10–11). Lastly, Paul told them the reason for writing that letter (7:12–13a).

Then Paul told them that he was both encouraged and happy that they had responded properly to Titus (7:13b–16).

Other examples of headings for this section are:

Paul’s Joy (NIV)

Paul’s joy at the repentance of the Corinthians

Titus’ news comforts Paul and makes him happy

7:15a

And his affection for you is even greater

- And he cares for you^(plur) even more,
- He loves you more now,

affection: This word refers to caring feelings for someone or lasting feelings of kindness toward someone.

Titus cared for them and was kind to them. See how you translated this word in 6:12.

even greater: This phrase indicates that Titus had affection for them before but now he had even more affection for them. For example:

more than ever (NLT)

7:15b

when he remembers that you were all obedient

- as he remembers that all of you obeyed him,
- when he thinks back/again about your obedience

obedient: Here Paul implied that the believers in Corinth were obedient to Titus when he visited them. Martin (p. 244).

7:15c

as you welcomed him with fear and trembling.

- treating him with the fear of God and trembling in his authority.
- as you interacted/related to him in submission and great respect.

welcomed him: The word welcomed refers to welcoming Titus and accepting him during his visit. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

treated him (JBP)

welcomed and interacted/talked with him

with fear and trembling: This idiom refers to being very careful not to offend someone who has power over you. You treat the person in authority with great honor and respect. This idiom probably implies fear of God, since Titus came on Paul’s behalf and therefore represented God and his authority. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

with such fear and deep respect (NLT)

respect and reverence (JBP)

with respect and fear (NCV)

submitted with all respect

General Comment on 7:15a–c

In some languages it is more natural to have the result (7:15a) after the reason (7:15b–c). For example:

^{15b}When he remembers that you were all obedient and ^{15c}received him with fear and trembling, ^{15a}his affection for you is all the greater

7:15a-c

(reordered) And when he remembers that you were all obedient, receiving him with fear and trembling, his affection for you is all the greater.

- (reordered) And the times he thinks again about how you obeyed him as you welcomed him in submission and great respect, he loves you more.

2 Corinthians 7:16

Section 7:5-16: Paul was glad that the believers repented

In this section, Paul explained why he had great joy. Earlier he had sent Titus to Corinth because he wanted to know what the believers there were doing and whether they still accepted him. Paul had then gone to Macedonia, a northern province of Greece (7:5). He had met Titus there (7:6), and Titus had reported that the believers still accepted Paul and loved him (7:7a-d).

Then, in 7:8-9, Paul wrote that he was happy because the believers had responded properly to his earlier stern letter (also mentioned in 2:1-4; see also the section on “Paul’s letters to the Corinthians” in the introduction to these Notes). Paul explained the proper results of repentance (7:10-11). Lastly, Paul told them the reason for writing that letter (7:12-13a).

Then Paul told them that he was both encouraged and happy that they had responded properly to Titus (7:13b-16).

Other examples of headings for this section are:

Paul’s Joy (NIV)

Paul’s joy at the repentance of the Corinthians

Titus’ news comforts Paul and makes him happy

7:16

I rejoice that I can have complete confidence in you.

- I rejoice that I am certain that you^(plur) will do the right/proper thing in every matter.
- I am very happy because I am confident in your deeds/behavior/faith in all things.

I rejoice that I can have complete confidence in you:

The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as complete is literally “in everything” (as in the NASB). Paul was

confident that the believers would do the right thing in any situation. For example:

I’m pleased that I can be confident about you in every way (GW)

In this division, Paul encouraged the believers in Corinth to be generous when giving money for the poor believers in Jerusalem. He used the believers in Macedonia as an example of generous givers (8:1-15). He told the believers in Corinth that Titus and two other believers were coming there to get the gift ready to give. He reminded them of their earlier eagerness to give (8:16-9:5). He encouraged them again to complete this desire to give and to do so generously, as well as to give joyously (9:6-15).

2 Corinthians 8:1

Section 8:1-15: Be generous as you are able

The believers in Corinth had previously decided to collect money to send to the poor believers in Jerusalem (1 Corinthians 16:1-4). In this section, Paul spoke of the generous gift of money from the believers in Macedonia and their attitude in giving (2 Corinthians 8:1-5). Paul hoped that the believers in Corinth would follow that example of giving.

Then Paul told them that Titus was coming to them to help collect the money (8:6). Paul encouraged them to give generously just as they did other things well (8:7). He indicated that he wanted to see that they were sincere in their promise to help the poor with this gift (8:8). He further encouraged them by using the example of Jesus giving (8:9).

Then Paul advised them how best to collect the money for the gift (8:10-11). Then he explained that what matters is giving according to what each person has (8:12). The goal in giving is equality, not making oneself poor for the sake of others (8:13-15).

Other examples for this section heading are:

Encouragement to Be Generous (NRSV)

A Call to Generous Giving (NLT)

Complete^(plur) the collection for the poor believers in Jerusalem

8:1a

Now, brothers, we want you to know

- ¶ So now, brothers and sisters, we^(excl) want you^(plur) to know
- ¶ Fellow believers, next, we desire that you know

Now, brothers, we want you to know: Here the term of address, brothers, comes after Paul begins saying something to the Corinthians. In some languages it is more natural to have the term of address first. For example:

Brothers, we now want you to know

Now: Here the word Now introduces a new topic. Paul had been talking about the good behavior of the believers in Corinth and his confidence in them. Now he began talking about giving money to help the poor believers. For example:

Next (NJB)

In some languages it is more natural to allow the context to indicate the connection and omit the conjunction.

brothers: Here the word brothers refers to fellow believers. The Greek word refers to both men and women here. See how you translated this word in 1:8.

8:1b
about the grace that God has given the churches of Macedonia.

- about the grace/favor that God gave to the churches in Macedonia.
- how God favored/helped the believers who meet in the region of Macedonia.

grace: Here the Greek word that the BSB translates as grace refers to God enabling someone to do something. God enabled the believers in Macedonia to give generously. God did that without requiring anything from the believers first, so the enabling was done in grace. Other ways to translate this word are:

kindness (GW)

help

favor

See how you translated this word in 1:2 or 6:1.

churches of Macedonia: The name Macedonia refers to a Roman province that today would include the

northern part of the country of Greece and the land a bit farther north. For example:

the churches in the province of Macedonia (GW)

But if you explained that the name Macedonia refers to a province in 1:16a, 2:13b, or 7:5a, you may not want to explain that again here.

churches: Here the Greek word that the BSB translates as “church” refers generally to a gathering of people. Here, as almost always in the New Testament, it refers to groups of believers. See how you translated this word in 1:1.

2 Corinthians 8:2

Section 8:1–15: Be generous as you are able

The believers in Corinth had previously decided to collect money to send to the poor believers in Jerusalem (1 Corinthians 16:1–4). In this section, Paul spoke of the generous gift of money from the believers in Macedonia and their attitude in giving (2 Corinthians 8:1–5). Paul hoped that the believers in Corinth would follow that example of giving.

Then Paul told them that Titus was coming to them to help collect the money (8:6). Paul encouraged them to give generously just as they did other things well (8:7). He indicated that he wanted to see that they were sincere in their promise to help the poor with this gift (8:8). He further encouraged them by using the example of Jesus giving (8:9).

Then Paul advised them how best to collect the money for the gift (8:10–11). Then he explained that what matters is giving according to what each person has (8:12). The goal in giving is equality, not making oneself poor for the sake of others (8:13–15).

Other examples for this section heading are:

Encouragement to Be Generous (NRSV)

A Call to Generous Giving (NLT)

Complete^(plur) the collection for the poor believers in Jerusalem

8:2a

In the terrible ordeal they suffered,

- For during the great difficulty/troubles caused by affliction/persecution that tested them,

- That is, while they were experiencing much trouble/hardship,

8:2a begins with a Greek conjunction that is often translated as “that.” In this context it introduces an explanation of the grace that God gave to the believers in Macedonia (8:1b). For example:

for (RSV)

How that (KJV)

In some languages it is more natural to allow the context to indicate the connection and omit the conjunction.

In: This phrase indicates that their joy (8:2b) and generosity (8:2c) occurred during the most severe trial. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

throughout (NJB)

in the midst of

While (GW)

the terrible ordeal they suffered: The Greek words are literally “a great test of affliction.” This phrase refers to a very difficult situation caused by “affliction.” It may have been people persecuting the believers in Macedonia. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

They have been severely tested by the troubles they went through (GNT)

continual ordeals of hardship (NJB)

8:2b–c

their abundant joy and deep poverty overflowed into rich generosity: Paul used the noun “overflowing” (which the BSB translates as abundant) and the verb overflowed to connect this saying together. If possible, use similar words in your language. For example:

the abundance of their joy and their deep poverty abounded unto the riches of their liberality (KJV)

their overflowing joy and their extreme poverty overflowed in rich generosity

In some languages repeating the meaning like this is not natural. For example:

their abundance of joy and their extreme poverty have overflowed in a wealth of generosity (ESV)

Moreover, some languages cannot use “overflow” in this figurative sense. For example:

their joy was so great that they were extremely generous in their giving, even though they are very poor (GNT)

they are very poor. But they gave much because of their great joy. (NCV)

See also the notes on these words in 8:2b and 8:2c.

8:2b

their abundant joy and deep poverty

- their abundant joy and their deep/great poverty
- they rejoiced exceedingly even though they were very poor,

abundant: The Greek word that the BSB translates as abundant refers to an abundance or surplus of something. Other ways to translate this word are:

overflowing (NIV)

great (NCV)

deep poverty: The Greek words are literally “according to/into deep poverty of them.” The phrase deep poverty indicates that the Macedonian churches were very poor. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

their deep poverty (NASB)

were very poor (CEV)

8:2c

overflowed into rich generosity.

- caused them to give very generously.
- and those things created an exceedingly great amount of generosity.

overflowed: The Greek word that the BSB translates as overflowed refers to becoming or making an abundance or surplus of something. The joy and poverty of the Macedonian churches led them to give money willingly and generously to help the poor believers in

Jerusalem. Other ways to translate this Greek word are:

has made them even more (GW)

abounded (KJV)

welled up (NIV)

rich generosity: Paul used the word rich as a word that means the opposite of poverty in 8:2b. They were poor, but God caused them to be able to give generously. Here is another way to translate this:

a wealth of generosity (NJB)

In some languages it is not natural to refer to generosity as being rich. If that is true in your language, you should indicate the great amount of generosity. For example:

great generosity

extremely generous (GNT)

generosity: This word refers to someone giving freely because he wants to help. Other ways to translate this word are:

giving without restraint

giving in full measure

happily giving greatly/much

2 Corinthians 8:3

Section 8:1–15: Be generous as you are able

The believers in Corinth had previously decided to collect money to send to the poor believers in Jerusalem (1 Corinthians 16:1–4). In this section, Paul spoke of the generous gift of money from the believers in Macedonia and their attitude in giving (2 Corinthians 8:1–5). Paul hoped that the believers in Corinth would follow that example of giving.

Then Paul told them that Titus was coming to them to help collect the money (8:6). Paul encouraged them to give generously just as they did other things well (8:7). He indicated that he wanted to see that they were sincere in their promise to help the poor with

this gift (8:8). He further encouraged them by using the example of Jesus giving (8:9).

Then Paul advised them how best to collect the money for the gift (8:10–11). Then he explained that what matters is giving according to what each person has (8:12). The goal in giving is equality, not making oneself poor for the sake of others (8:13–15).

Other examples for this section heading are:

Encouragement to Be Generous (NRSV)

A Call to Generous Giving (NLT)

Complete^(plur) the collection for the poor believers in Jerusalem

8:3a–4a

For I testify that they gave according to their ability and even beyond it. Of their own accord, they earnestly pleaded with us: The Greek word that the BSB translates as *Of their own accord* can also be translated as “by their own choice.” There are two ways to interpret the connection of this phrase to the other words:

1. The phrase connects back to 8:3a. For example:

For they gave according to their means, as I can testify, and beyond their means, of their own free will, ⁴begging us (RSV) (RSV, NJB, GW, CEV, REB, ESV, KJV)

1. The phrase connects forward to 8:4a. For example:

I can assure you that they gave as much as they could, and even more than they could. Of their own free will ⁴they begged us (GNT) (BSB, NIV, GNT, NABRE, NLT, NET, NCV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Harris (p. 558), Martin (p. 248), Kistemaker (p. 273), and Thrall (p. 520) all connect 8:3c to 8:3a–b in their translations. Thrall says, “Paul explains further what he has just said” (p. 524).

8:3a

For I testify that they gave according to their ability

- For I can accurately/faithfully report that they gave according to what they could,
- I truthfully assert that they gave as much as their resources/means allowed,

For: This conjunction introduces a further explanation of about their generosity. But in some languages, it is more natural to allow the context to indicate the connection and omit the conjunction.

testify: This word means “report what one saw.” The word is often used where the person is expected to be truthful and accurate. Here Paul was convinced that they gave as much as they were able. Other ways to translate this word are:

faithfully report

accurately/truthfully assert

See how you translated this word in 1:12.

they gave according to their ability: The believers knew how much money it was possible for them to give. They did not keep any of it for themselves. Other ways to translate this clause are:

they gave according to their means (RSV)

they gave as much as they could (GNT)

8:3b and even beyond it.

- and even more than what they could give,
- and indeed more than their resources/means allowed.

and even beyond it: The word even emphasizes the words beyond it. It indicates that the giving of the Macedonian churches increased from as much as they were able to beyond their ability.

beyond it: This phrase indicates that not only did the believers give as much as they were able, they also gave more than that. For example, some of them may have given some of the money that they needed to buy their own food and then trusted God to provide food for them. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

beyond their means (RSV)

more than they could (GNT)

8:3c Of their own accord,

- and they chose/decided to do that on their own.
- Nobody told them to do so/that.

Of their own accord: This phrase indicates that no one told the believers in Macedonia to give. The believers heard of the need and decided by themselves that they wanted to help. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

of their own free will (RSV)

it was of their own accord (NJB)

voluntarily (NRSV)

without anyone urging them

2 Corinthians 8:4

Section 8:1–15: Be generous as you are able

The believers in Corinth had previously decided to collect money to send to the poor believers in Jerusalem (1 Corinthians 16:1–4). In this section, Paul spoke of the generous gift of money from the believers in Macedonia and their attitude in giving (2 Corinthians 8:1–5). Paul hoped that the believers in Corinth would follow that example of giving.

Then Paul told them that Titus was coming to them to help collect the money (8:6). Paul encouraged them to give generously just as they did other things well (8:7). He indicated that he wanted to see that they were sincere in their promise to help the poor with this gift (8:8). He further encouraged them by using the example of Jesus giving (8:9).

Then Paul advised them how best to collect the money for the gift (8:10–11). Then he explained that what matters is giving according to what each person has (8:12). The goal in giving is equality, not making oneself poor for the sake of others (8:13–15).

Other examples for this section heading are:

Encouragement to Be Generous (NRSV)

A Call to Generous Giving (NLT)

Complete^(plur) the collection for the poor believers in Jerusalem

8:4a they earnestly pleaded with us

- They earnestly asked us^(excl)
- They asked us again and again with much desire

they earnestly pleaded with us: The Greek words are literally “with great request asking us.” The believers in Macedonia urged Paul and the other evangelists to allow them to help. The Greek probably indicates that they asked more than once. Asking more than once shows that they really wanted to help. Other ways to translate this are:

they had kept imploring us most insistently (NJB)

begging us earnestly (ESV)

8:4b

for the privilege of sharing in this service to the saints.

- for the favor of participating together with the other churches in ministering to God’s people in Jerusalem.
- to permit them to take part in supporting believers in Jerusalem who are needy.

privilege: The Greek word that the BSB translates as privilege is usually translated “grace,” as in 8:1b. Here the Greek word refers to Paul allowing them to help. Paul may have worried that they were too poor to be able to help. Other ways to translate this word are:

favor (RSV)

to let (NCV)

blessing (NET)

Also see the note on “grace” in 8:1b.

sharing: The Greek word that the BSB translates as sharing is usually translated “fellowship,” as in 6:14c. Here the Greek word refers to doing as other churches were doing. Other churches were helping the poor believers in Jerusalem, and the churches in Macedonia also wanted to help. Other ways to translate this word are:

taking part (RSV)

participating with the other churches

this service: The Greek word that the BSB translates as service is usually translated “ministry,” as in 6:3b. Here the Greek word refers to helping the poor believers in Jerusalem. Other ways to translate this word are:

helping (GNT)

the support (NASB)

the gift (NLT)

saints: The Greek word that the BSB translates as saints is literally “holy ones.” The word refers to all believers. For example:

God’s people (GNT)

See how you translated this word in 1:1.

Here however, the word saints refers only to the believers in Jerusalem (1 Corinthians 16:3). Paul was collecting money to take to the believers there who were poor and needed help (Romans 15:25–26). In some languages a literal translation would wrongly refer to believers in general. If that is true in your language, you may want to add the implied meaning. For example:

God’s people in Jerusalem who are poor

2 Corinthians 8:5

Section 8:1–15: Be generous as you are able

The believers in Corinth had previously decided to collect money to send to the poor believers in Jerusalem (1 Corinthians 16:1–4). In this section, Paul spoke of the generous gift of money from the believers in Macedonia and their attitude in giving (2 Corinthians 8:1–5). Paul hoped that the believers in Corinth would follow that example of giving.

Then Paul told them that Titus was coming to them to help collect the money (8:6). Paul encouraged them to give generously just as they did other things well (8:7). He indicated that he wanted to see that they were sincere in their promise to help the poor with this gift (8:8). He further encouraged them by using the example of Jesus giving (8:9).

Then Paul advised them how best to collect the money for the gift (8:10–11). Then he explained that what matters is giving according to what each person has (8:12). The goal in giving is equality, not making oneself poor for the sake of others (8:13–15).

Other examples for this section heading are:

Encouragement to Be Generous (NRSV)

A Call to Generous Giving (NLT)

Complete^(plur) the collection for the poor believers in Jerusalem

8:5a

And not only did they do as we expected,

- And they gave differently than we^(excl) expected,
- We did not expect them to do this:

And not only did they do as we expected: Paul was surprised by their dedication to God (8:5b) and to himself and the others (8:5c) in this matter. He probably also expected a smaller gift because they were so poor (8:2b). Other ways to translate this clause are:

they did it differently than we expected

they gave in a way we did not expect (NCV)

we did not expect them to do this

8:5b

but they gave themselves first to the Lord

- namely, they first decided to always do what the Lord wanted them to do,
- they first completely dedicated themselves to serve the Lord Jesus.

but: There is contrast between what Paul expected them to do and what they did. 8:5a indicates that they did not do as Paul expected. So in some languages it is more natural to connect 8:5b to 8:5a without contrast. For example:

First they gave themselves to the Lord (GNT)

they gave themselves first to the Lord: This phrase refers to devoting themselves to God and to serving him. The believers decided to follow God with their whole being in preparation to give. This phrase does not refer to the first act of believing in Jesus to be saved. Other ways to translate this are:

it began by their offering themselves to the Lord (NJB)

they made a complete dedication of themselves first to the Lord (JBP)

first they entrusted their lives to the Lord

they first devoted their lives to doing the Lord's will

the Lord: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Lord means "the one in authority over (something)" or "master." It refers to someone greater in status or power. The word Lord probably refers to Jesus here, because 8:5c has the word "God" rather than the word "he." In some languages it is more natural to include the name "Jesus" here. For example:

Lord Jesus

ruler Jesus

See how you translated this word in 4:5 or 6:17.

8:5c

and then to us, because it was the will of God.

- and then followed us as God wanted them to do.
- Then/Next they dedicated themselves to following us in God's will.

and then to us: The words "they gave themselves" are implied but are not repeated here. In some languages it is more natural to repeat some or all of those words. For example:

and then they gave themselves to us

These words have a similar meaning to 8:5b. The believers decided to follow Paul as their leader in their faith.

because it was the will of God: This phrase refers to doing something according to what God would want them to do. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

by the will of God (RSV)

just as God wanted them to do (NLT)

under/through submission to God

2 Corinthians 8:6

Section 8:1–15: Be generous as you are able

The believers in Corinth had previously decided to collect money to send to the poor believers in Jerusalem (1 Corinthians 16:1–4). In this section, Paul spoke of the generous gift of money from the believers in Macedonia and their attitude in giving (2 Corinthians 8:1–5).

Paul hoped that the believers in Corinth would follow that example of giving.

Then Paul told them that Titus was coming to them to help collect the money (8:6). Paul encouraged them to give generously just as they did other things well (8:7). He indicated that he wanted to see that they were sincere in their promise to help the poor with this gift (8:8). He further encouraged them by using the example of Jesus giving (8:9).

Then Paul advised them how best to collect the money for the gift (8:10–11). Then he explained that what matters is giving according to what each person has (8:12). The goal in giving is equality, not making oneself poor for the sake of others (8:13–15).

Other examples for this section heading are:

Encouragement to Be Generous (NRSV)

A Call to Generous Giving (NLT)

Complete^(plur) the collection for the poor believers in Jerusalem

8:6a–b

So we urged Titus to help complete your act of grace, just as he had started it: The reason, just as he had started it, occurs at the end of the verse. In some languages it is more natural to state the reason before or after the main clause. For example:

Titus was the one who got you started doing this good thing, so we begged him to have you finish what you had begun (CEV)

So we asked Titus to help you finish this special work of grace since he is the one who started it (NCV)

8:6a

So we urged Titus to help complete your act of grace,

- So we urged Titus to lead you to finish collecting this gracious deed,
- So we^(excl) asked Titus to also help you complete your generous gift,

to help complete: This phrase indicates that Titus would help the believers in Corinth finish collecting the money for the gift. Other ways to translate this are:

he should also complete (RSV)

help you complete (GNT)

your act of grace: The Greek words are literally “this grace.” Here the word grace refers to the gift of money to the poor believers in Jerusalem. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

this gracious work (RSV)

this gift

this work of generosity (NJB)

this act of kindness (NET)

this ministry of giving (NLT)

your: This phrase indicates that the believers in Corinth were responsible for their gift. Titus would help them, but they needed to be ready to give. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

among you (RSV)

encourage you to finish (NLT)

8:6b

just as he had started it.

- since he had earlier led you^(plur) to start it.
- since Titus began by encouraging you in this earlier.

just as he had started it: Perhaps a year earlier, Titus was in Corinth and had helped the believers to begin collecting money to send to Jerusalem. Other ways to translate this clause are:

who began this work (GNT)

since he is the one who started it (NCV)

who encouraged your giving in the first place (NLT)

2 Corinthians 8:7

Section 8:1–15: Be generous as you are able

The believers in Corinth had previously decided to collect money to send to the poor believers in Jerusalem

(1 Corinthians 16:1–4). In this section, Paul spoke of the generous gift of money from the believers in Macedonia and their attitude in giving (2 Corinthians 8:1–5). Paul hoped that the believers in Corinth would follow that example of giving.

Then Paul told them that Titus was coming to them to help collect the money (8:6). Paul encouraged them to give generously just as they did other things well (8:7). He indicated that he wanted to see that they were sincere in their promise to help the poor with this gift (8:8). He further encouraged them by using the example of Jesus giving (8:9).

Then Paul advised them how best to collect the money for the gift (8:10–11). Then he explained that what matters is giving according to what each person has (8:12). The goal in giving is equality, not making oneself poor for the sake of others (8:13–15).

Other examples for this section heading are:

Encouragement to Be Generous (NRSV)

A Call to Generous Giving (NLT)

Complete^(plur) the collection for the poor believers in Jerusalem

8:7a

But just as you excel in everything—

- ¶ Now, as you^(plur) did very well in all ways/things,
- ¶ You already exceed/surpass in doing so many things well,

But: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as But probably introduces a new theme here. The theme changes from the recent history about collecting the money to Paul urging the believers in Corinth to finish collecting the money. The Greek conjunction probably does not indicate contrast here. Other ways to translate this word are:

Now (RSV)

Furthermore/Next

Indeed, (GW)

just as you excel: The Greek word that the BSB translates as excel refers to having or making an abundance or surplus of something. The believers in Corinth had great faith, knowledge, earnestness, and love, and

their speech honored God. Other ways to translate this are:

just as you abound (NASB)

as you do well

The BSB translates the Greek word as “overflowed” in 8:2c. If possible, use a similar word or phrase here.

in everything: The believers in Corinth were not perfect in their faith, but they did well in many areas. Paul exaggerated, using the word everything to encourage them to do well in giving as well (8:7d). Many English versions keep the exaggerating use of everything. For example:

in every good quality (JBP)

But in some languages it is not natural to exaggerate here. If that is true in your language, translate in a way that shows that Paul was encouraging the believers. For example:

in so many ways (NLT)

8:7b–c

in faith, in speech, in knowledge, in complete earnestness, and in the love we inspired in you:

This list contains examples of how the believers “excel in everything” (8:7a). The BSB indicates the list with long dashes before and after the list. Other ways to indicate that the list contains examples are:

You are so rich in all you have: in faith, speech, and knowledge, in your eagerness to help and in your love for us. And... (GNT)

for example: in faith, in speech, in knowledge, in complete earnestness, and in your love for us

including in faith, in speech, in knowledge, in complete earnestness, and in your love for us

in...in...in...in...in: The phrase “you excel” is implied before each occurrence of in but is not explicitly repeated. In some languages it is more natural to repeat some or all the words. For example:

you excel in faith, you excel in speech, you excel in knowledge, you excel in complete earnestness and you excel in your love for us

8:7b

in faith, in speech, in knowledge,

- for example: in believing well/strongly, in speaking well, in having full knowledge,
- including that you exceed/surpass in faith in Jesus, you exceed/surpass in speaking for Jesus, you exceed/surpass in being able to understand God's ways,

faith: Here the word faith means “a strong and sincere belief in something or someone.” To have faith in a person means to trust someone, to rely on someone, to be committed to someone. Faith in Jesus refers to:

1. accepting His message as true;
2. acting on the basis of His message;
3. being confident in His message;
4. trusting in Him.

Here the word may refer to having the faith to do great things such as miracles. Your language may have a noun, phrase, or idiom with that meaning. Some other examples for translating are:

believing in Jesus

trusting and committed to Jesus

See how you translated this word in 1:24 or 5:7.

speech: Here the word speech probably refers to speaking well and in a way that is easily understood. Paul probably referred to speaking the truth about the gospel here. Proper use of the gifts of prophecy and tongues might also be included here. Many English versions use a general word regarding speaking and do not refer to a particular kind of speaking. For example:

speaking (NCV)

eloquence (NJB)

you can express that faith in words (JBP)

knowledge: Here the word knowledge probably refers to a good understanding of the gospel and the truths in it. Other ways to translate this word are:

understanding (NJB)

you have excellent knowledge of spiritual matters

8:7c

in complete earnestness, and in the love we inspired in you—

- in all eagerness to do what is right, and in the love that you learned from us^(excl),
- you exceed/surpass in dealing with the issues/matters seriously in every way, and you exceed/surpass in loving Jesus which we taught you.

complete earnestness: The word earnestness refers to having a strong desire to do the right thing and making every effort to do it. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

completely devoted to doing the right thing

always eagerly doing what was right

always deal with the issues/matters seriously

See how you translated the word earnestness in 7:11.

the love we inspired in you: There is a textual issue here:

1. The correct reading is love from us in you. For example:

the love we have kindled in you (NIV11) (BSB, NIV11, NRSV, NASB, NLT, NET, ESV, NCV)

1. The correct reading is love from you in us. For example:

your love for us (RSV) (RSV, NIV, GNT, NJB, GW, CEV, REB, KJV) None of these versions follow the literal Greek words. They all interpret the Greek word “in” as “for.”

It is recommended that you follow option (1), since the scholars who edited the UBS Greek New Testament believe that this is the best reading. But they indicate that they had difficulty in deciding which text is correct.

According to option (1), this love is from Paul and the other evangelists and in the believers in Corinth. The believers excel in this love (8:7a). Here the love is probably for Jesus. Paul taught them about Jesus and

now the believers love Jesus well. The Greek probably does not mean “our love for you.” Other ways to translate this are:

the love from us that is in you (NET)

the love you learned from us (NCV)

8:7d

see that you also excel in this grace of giving.

- you should abound/do-well in this grace/favor of the gift to the poor as well.
- So, in the same way, we want you to exceed/surpass regarding this deed of helping the poor.

see that you also excel: The Greek words are literally “that you may also abound/excel.” It is like a command, because Paul expects the believers to follow these words. Other ways to translate this are:

And so we want you to be generous also (GNT)

then make sure that you excel (NJB)

you should also show yourselves to excel

Note that 8:8a says that Paul did not command them regarding this, so you should not translate this clause as a command.

in this grace of giving: The Greek words are literally in this grace. The phrase refers to the gift of money to the poor believers in Jerusalem. The BSB makes this clear by adding the words of giving. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

in this gracious work (RSV)

in this generous undertaking (NRSV)

regarding this blessing to the poor

in this act of kindness (NET)

in this deed of helping the poor

2 Corinthians 8:8

Section 8:1–15: Be generous as you are able

The believers in Corinth had previously decided to collect money to send to the poor believers in Jerusalem (1 Corinthians 16:1–4). In this section, Paul spoke of the generous gift of money from the believers in Macedonia and their attitude in giving (2 Corinthians 8:1–5). Paul hoped that the believers in Corinth would follow that example of giving.

Then Paul told them that Titus was coming to them to help collect the money (8:6). Paul encouraged them to give generously just as they did other things well (8:7). He indicated that he wanted to see that they were sincere in their promise to help the poor with this gift (8:8). He further encouraged them by using the example of Jesus giving (8:9).

Then Paul advised them how best to collect the money for the gift (8:10–11). Then he explained that what matters is giving according to what each person has (8:12). The goal in giving is equality, not making oneself poor for the sake of others (8:13–15).

Other examples for this section heading are:

Encouragement to Be Generous (NRSV)

A Call to Generous Giving (NLT)

Complete^(plur) the collection for the poor believers in Jerusalem

8:8a

I am not making a demand,

- I am not saying that as an order/command,
- What I just said is not a command,

I am not making a demand: Paul wanted the believers in Corinth to decide by themselves to give the gift. He did not want to force them to decide to give. Other ways to translate this are:

I am not saying this as an order (NJB)

I am not speaking this as a command (NASB)

What I just said is not a command

8:8b

but I am testing the sincerity of your love

- but I want to confirm that your^(plur) love is genuine

- but I want to verify that you truly love

testing the sincerity of your love: The word testing refers to checking something to see that it is true. The Greek word that the BSB translates as testing indicates that Paul expected that the love of the believers would be sincere. Other ways to translate this are:

prove...that your love also is genuine (RSV)

verify the reality of your love

see if your love is true (NCV)

sincerity: The Greek word here refers to something being truly what it says it is. Other ways to translate this word are:

genuineness (NRSV)

how real your own love is (GNT)

8:8c

in comparison to the earnestness of others.

- by the means of showing to you the earnest deeds of others.
- by telling you how eager others are to help/give.

in comparison to the earnestness of others: The Greek words are literally “through the earnestness of others.” The word others refers to the believers in Macedonia. They collected their gift with earnestness (8:3–4). They were very generous when they gave. This phrase indicates that Paul wants the believers in Corinth to prove their love by being earnest and generous like the believers in Macedonia. Other ways to translate this are:

against the earnestness of others (NRSV)

by showing how eager others are to help (GNT)

by telling you how keen others are (REB)

by the means of showing to you how eager other people are to give generously

earnestness: This word refers to having a strong desire to do the right thing and making every effort to do it. Other ways to translate this word are:

devoted

eager (GNT)

See how you translated this word in 7:11.

2 Corinthians 8:9

Section 8:1–15: Be generous as you are able

The believers in Corinth had previously decided to collect money to send to the poor believers in Jerusalem (1 Corinthians 16:1–4). In this section, Paul spoke of the generous gift of money from the believers in Macedonia and their attitude in giving (2 Corinthians 8:1–5). Paul hoped that the believers in Corinth would follow that example of giving.

Then Paul told them that Titus was coming to them to help collect the money (8:6). Paul encouraged them to give generously just as they did other things well (8:7). He indicated that he wanted to see that they were sincere in their promise to help the poor with this gift (8:8). He further encouraged them by using the example of Jesus giving (8:9).

Then Paul advised them how best to collect the money for the gift (8:10–11). Then he explained that what matters is giving according to what each person has (8:12). The goal in giving is equality, not making oneself poor for the sake of others (8:13–15).

Other examples for this section heading are:

Encouragement to Be Generous (NRSV)

A Call to Generous Giving (NLT)

Complete^(plur) the collection for the poor believers in Jerusalem

8:9a

For you know the grace of our Lord Jesus Christ,

- For you^(plur) know our Lord Jesus Christ’s grace/favor,
- Because you already know that our Lord Jesus Christ favored/blessed people.

For: This conjunction introduces a further reason why the believers should graciously give money to the poor.

grace: Here the Greek word that the BSB translates as grace refers to doing something for people even though they do not deserve it. Jesus left heaven and came to earth and sacrificed himself to reconcile people to God. Other ways to translate this word are:

kindness (GW)

help

favor

See how you translated this word in 1:2 or 8:1.

Christ: The word Christ is a title for Jesus. The word Christ literally means “the anointed one.” Translate the word Christ here as you did in 1:1.

8:9b

that though He was rich, yet for your sakes He became poor,

- in that he became poor on your behalf even though he was rich,
- He did this: he left behind his riches of power and glory in heaven and became poor in order to benefit you.

He was rich: This clause refers to the time when Jesus was in heaven before he came to earth. In some languages a literal translation would not clearly refer to Jesus living in heaven. If that is true in your language, you may want to include the implied information. For example:

he was rich in heaven

he was rich in his status/position in heaven

rich: Here this word refers to the greatness of Jesus’ life in heaven and being ruler over all creation. The word here does not refer to wealth such as lots of money or expensive things. Paul used the word rich to contrast with the word poor.

In some languages a literal translation would not indicate the above meaning. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Explain the meaning in your translation. For example:

rich in glory and power

- Translate literally and explain the meaning in a footnote. For example:

Here, the word “rich” refers to having much glory and power in heaven. The word here does not refer to lots of money or expensive things.

He became poor: When Jesus came to earth, he did not keep his glory and power but instead lived as only a man. In that way, He became poor. In some languages a literal translation would not refer clearly to Jesus living on earth. If that is true in your language, you may want to include the implied information. For example:

he became poor by coming to earth

8:9c

so that you through His poverty might become rich.

- in order that you might become rich by means of his poverty.
- and so you became rich in blessings by means of him becoming poor.

you through His poverty might become rich: This clause indicates that the believers gain blessings on earth and rewards in heaven because of what Jesus did while on earth.

poverty: This word refers to being poor. It refers to Jesus being on earth, as the phrase “he became poor” does in 8:9b.

rich: Here the word rich refers to blessings, spiritual gifts, and rewards. It does not refer to money or expensive things.

In some languages a literal translation would not indicate the above meaning. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Explain the meaning in your translation. For example:

rich in blessings on earth and rewards in heaven

- Translate literally and explain the meaning in a footnote. For example:

Here, the word “rich” refers to having blessings and spiritual gifts on earth and rewards in heaven. The word here does not refer to lots of money or expensive things.

2 Corinthians 8:10

Section 8:1–15: Be generous as you are able

The believers in Corinth had previously decided to collect money to send to the poor believers in Jerusalem (1 Corinthians 16:1–4). In this section, Paul spoke of the generous gift of money from the believers in Macedonia and their attitude in giving (2 Corinthians 8:1–5).

Paul hoped that the believers in Corinth would follow that example of giving.

Then Paul told them that Titus was coming to them to help collect the money (8:6). Paul encouraged them to give generously just as they did other things well (8:7). He indicated that he wanted to see that they were sincere in their promise to help the poor with this gift (8:8). He further encouraged them by using the example of Jesus giving (8:9).

Then Paul advised them how best to collect the money for the gift (8:10–11). Then he explained that what matters is giving according to what each person has (8:12). The goal in giving is equality, not making oneself poor for the sake of others (8:13–15).

Other examples for this section heading are:

Encouragement to Be Generous (NRSV)

A Call to Generous Giving (NLT)

Complete^(plur) the collection for the poor believers in Jerusalem

8:10a

And this is my opinion about what is helpful for you in this matter:

- ¶ And, I give advice to you about this matter, because this matter will benefit you^(plur),
- ¶ And I am telling my opinion to you because doing this deed as I suggest will be helpful to you. My opinion is this:

And: This conjunction indicates a general connection to the previous verses. Paul had more to say about the believers giving money to the poor believers in Jerusalem.

this is my opinion about what is helpful for you in this matter: The Greek words are literally “An opinion I give in this, because this is helpful/beneficial for you.” The first this refers to collecting money. The second this probably refers to the same thing. The second “this” could refer to Paul’s opinion. This interpretation is possible, but few English versions translate it that way. This clause indicates what Paul thought was the right way to collect money for the poor believers. Doing this deed as Paul suggested would also benefit those who gave. Other ways to translate this are:

I will give you my considered opinion in the matter; this will be the right course for you (NJB)

My opinion is that it is better for you to (GNT)

Here is my opinion in the matter. I think it would be a good thing for you (JBP)

8:10b

Last year you were the first not only to give, but even to have such a desire.

- considering that last year you were not only the first to begin giving, but also the first to desire to do that,
- The previous year you were the first among the churches to desire to help and to begin to do,

Last year you were the first not only to give, but even to have such a desire: In 8:10a, Paul said that he was about to give advice. 8:10b is not the advice; it is additional information before Paul gave his advice in 8:11. In 8:10b, Paul complimented the believers in Corinth, because they were the first group to think about helping and also to begin collecting the money. Translate in a way that indicates these words are not the advice that Paul said he would give. For example:

since you made a good start last year both in your giving and your desire to give, (NET)

In some languages it is more natural to put 8:10b before 8:10a. In this way, Paul’s statement that he had advice is immediately before the advice (8:11). For example:

^{10b}Last year you were the first not only to give but also to have the desire to do so. ^{10a}Here is my advice about what is best for you in this matter:

you were the first not only to give, but even to have such a desire: The Greek words are literally “you previously began not only the doing but also the desiring.” It emphasizes the believers desiring to help. Other ways to translate this are:

who...started not only to do this work but also to desire to do it (ESV)

you were the first to give, but more than that, you were the first to have the desire to do so

you were the first who wanted to give, and you were the first to begin doing it (NLT)

you were the first: The Greek word is literally “to begin before” and in this case, means “you previously began.” For example:

you began (RSV)

But the BSB and many scholars and other English versions think that Paul said here that the Corinthian believers began before all other believers. The BDAG and Louw & Nida both indicate it means “begin previously.” The scholars who say it means “begin first” do not explain why they translate it that way.

to give: The Greek words are literally “the doing.” In the context this verb is referring to giving the money.

2 Corinthians 8:11

Section 8:1–15: Be generous as you are able

The believers in Corinth had previously decided to collect money to send to the poor believers in Jerusalem (1 Corinthians 16:1–4). In this section, Paul spoke of the generous gift of money from the believers in Macedonia and their attitude in giving (2 Corinthians 8:1–5). Paul hoped that the believers in Corinth would follow that example of giving.

Then Paul told them that Titus was coming to them to help collect the money (8:6). Paul encouraged them to give generously just as they did other things well (8:7). He indicated that he wanted to see that they were sincere in their promise to help the poor with this gift (8:8). He further encouraged them by using the example of Jesus giving (8:9).

Then Paul advised them how best to collect the money for the gift (8:10–11). Then he explained that what matters is giving according to what each person has (8:12). The goal in giving is equality, not making oneself poor for the sake of others (8:13–15).

Other examples for this section heading are:

Encouragement to Be Generous (NRSV)

A Call to Generous Giving (NLT)

Complete^(plur) the collection for the poor believers in Jerusalem

8:11a

Now finish the work,

- so finish it now,
- now complete what you^(plur) began.

Now: The Greek words are literally “But now.” There is some contrast between the eager start to their giving (see note above) and the command to complete it. The word Now refers to the time Paul when wrote this letter. It contrasts with “last year” (8:10b). Here is another way to translate this:

But now (NASB)

In some languages it is more natural to not indicate the contrast, as in the BSB and other English versions.

the work: The Greek words are literally “the doing.” This phrase refers to collecting the money to give to the poor believers in Jerusalem. Other ways to translate this word are:

it (RSV)

the action (NJB)

what you began to do (GW)

8:11b

so that you may complete it just as eagerly as you began,

- in order that you might be as eager to finish it as you were to plan/begin/desire it.
- By doing that, you can also complete it just as you eagerly wanted to do it.

so that: This connecting phrase introduces the purpose for completing the work.

you may complete it just as eagerly as you began:

The Greek words are literally “just as (your) eagerness of will/desire, so also (your) completing (it) out of what (you) have.” The believers eagerly wanted to help. Paul hoped here that they would finish collecting the money in a way that equaled their desire to help. Other ways to translate this are:

you might be as eager to finish it as you were to plan/begin/desire it

just as there was the readiness to desire it, so there may be also the completion of it (NASB)

Then your willingness will be matched by what you accomplish (GW)

just as you wanted to do it eagerly, you can also complete it (NET)

8:11c

according to your means.

- And do that out of what you have.
- Give according to your ability to do so/that.

according to your means: The Greek words are literally “out of the having.” Paul wanted them to give from what they had. He did not want them to borrow money from someone else to give to the poor believers. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

out of what you have (RSV)

by your ability (NASB)

2 Corinthians 8:12

Section 8:1–15: Be generous as you are able

The believers in Corinth had previously decided to collect money to send to the poor believers in Jerusalem (1 Corinthians 16:1–4). In this section, Paul spoke of the generous gift of money from the believers in Macedonia and their attitude in giving (2 Corinthians 8:1–5). Paul hoped that the believers in Corinth would follow that example of giving.

Then Paul told them that Titus was coming to them to help collect the money (8:6). Paul encouraged them to give generously just as they did other things well (8:7). He indicated that he wanted to see that they were sincere in their promise to help the poor with this gift (8:8). He further encouraged them by using the example of Jesus giving (8:9).

Then Paul advised them how best to collect the money for the gift (8:10–11). Then he explained that what matters is giving according to what each person has (8:12). The goal in giving is equality, not making oneself poor for the sake of others (8:13–15).

Other examples for this section heading are:

Encouragement to Be Generous (NRSV)

A Call to Generous Giving (NLT)

Complete^(plur) the collection for the poor believers in Jerusalem

8:12a–c

What Paul said in 8:12a–c is true for all believers, not just the believers in Corinth. The word “one” refers to any believer. He does not use “you” in this verse. Consider how to translate this verse so that it refers to all believers.

8:12a–b

if the eagerness is there, the gift is acceptable:

These words indicate that God looks to see if the believer gives the gift eagerly, then he accepts it. Other ways to translate this are:

If you are eager to give, God will accept your gift (GNT)

Whatever you give is acceptable if you give it eagerly (NLT)

If you want to give, your gift will be accepted (NCV)

8:12a

For if the eagerness is there,

- For as long as a person is eager/willing to give,
- Because if someone wants to give something,

For: This conjunction introduces the reason why the believers should give according to their means.

if the eagerness is there: The word if indicates that Paul hoped that the believers were still willing to give. This clause refers generally to anyone giving. Other ways to translate this are:

As long as the enthusiasm is there (NJB)

if someone really wants to give

If you are eager to give (GNT)

eagerness: the Greek word that the BSB translates as eagerness here is the same word translated as “eagerly” in 8:11b. See the GNT example above.

8:12b

the gift is acceptable according to what one has,

- the gift pleases God, because it is given from the things he has,
- God will accept his gift in accordance with what he has.

the gift is acceptable: This clause implies that God accepts the gift. Here is another way to translate this:

God will accept your gift (GNT)

according to what one has: This phrase refers to giving from the things that a person already has. He decides how much of it to give. Other ways to translate this are:

on the basis of what you have to give (GNT)

from what you have (CEV)

according to our means (REB)

according to: The Greek word that the BSB translates as according to means “to the degree that” here. Other ways to translate this Greek word are:

in proportion to

in accordance with

8:12c

not according to what he does not have.

- but not given from the things he does not have.
- He is not expected to give more than he has to give.

not according to what he does not have: In 8:3 Paul praised the believers in Macedonia for giving extra. These words indicate that God does not require believers to give extra. Other ways to translate this are:

not what someone does not have (NJB)

not in proportion to any extra amount he does not have

not in accordance with some amount beyond what he has

2 Corinthians 8:13

Section 8:1–15: Be generous as you are able

The believers in Corinth had previously decided to collect money to send to the poor believers in Jerusalem (1 Corinthians 16:1–4). In this section, Paul spoke of the generous gift of money from the believers in Macedonia and their attitude in giving (2 Corinthians 8:1–5).

Paul hoped that the believers in Corinth would follow that example of giving.

Then Paul told them that Titus was coming to them to help collect the money (8:6). Paul encouraged them to give generously just as they did other things well (8:7). He indicated that he wanted to see that they were sincere in their promise to help the poor with this gift (8:8). He further encouraged them by using the example of Jesus giving (8:9).

Then Paul advised them how best to collect the money for the gift (8:10–11). Then he explained that what matters is giving according to what each person has (8:12). The goal in giving is equality, not making oneself poor for the sake of others (8:13–15).

Other examples for this section heading are:

Encouragement to Be Generous (NRSV)

A Call to Generous Giving (NLT)

Complete^(plur) the collection for the poor believers in Jerusalem

8:13a

It is not our intention that others may be relieved while you are burdened,

- For the aim is not for others to have relief and you^(plur) to have hardship,
- Of course, your gift is not to cause you economic distress/trouble while at the same time helping/relieving others.

8:13a begins with a Greek conjunction that is often translated as “for” or “because.” Here it probably introduces an explanation of the amount to be given (8:11c). For example:

For (NASB)

But the conjunction may emphasize that the giving should be the proper amount. For example:

Of course, (JBP)

In some languages it is more natural to allow the context to indicate the connection and omit the conjunction.

It is not our intention that others may be relieved while you are burdened: The Greek words are literally “not that relief to others and distress to you.” The

goal of giving is equality (8:13b), both groups having enough. Here, the goal of giving is not that the giver gives so much that he becomes needy himself. Other ways to translate this are:

this is not for the ease of others and for your affliction (NASB)

It is not that you ought to relieve other people's needs and leave yourselves in hardship (NJB)

I do not say this so there would be relief for others and suffering for you (NET)

I don't mean that others should be relieved to an extent that leaves you in distress (JBP)

It is not our intention: The BSB adds this phrase for the sake of naturalness in English.

others may be relieved: The word relieved refers to being free from troubles and worries. Poor people worry about not having enough money to buy food and such. But after the believers in Corinth helped the poor believers in Jerusalem, the poor believers would have enough money and would not worry. Other ways to translate this are:

relieve other people's needs (NJB)

make life easier for others (CEV)

others who are in difficulty might be helped

See how you translated this Greek word, translated here as "relief," in 2:13 (where the BSB says "peace") or 7:5 (where the BSB says "rest").

you are burdened: Here the Greek word that the BSB translates as burdened refers to the difficulty or trouble of being poor. Other ways to translate this are:

you have hardship/difficulty

you experience adversity/trouble

See how you translated this word in 1:4 or 6:4. (In both places the BSB says "troubles.")

8:13b

but that there may be equality.

- but the aim is to be equal.
- But it is a matter of fairness.

but that there may be equality: There is an issue with the verse division here:

1. In some versions, these words are the end of verse 13. For example:

¹³Of course, I don't mean your giving should make life easy for others and hard for yourselves. I only mean that there should be some equality. ¹⁴Right now you have plenty... (NLT) (BSB, NIV, NJB, NRSV, NASB, NABRE, NLT, GW, CEV, NET, ESV, NCV)

1. In other versions, these words are the beginning of verse 14. For example:

¹³I do not mean that others should be eased and you burdened, ¹⁴but that as a matter of equality your abundance at the present time... (RSV) (RSV, KJV, REB)

It is recommended that you follow option (1), since the UBS Greek New Testament has these words in verse 13.

there may be equality: The word equality refers to two things or groups being the same in some way. After the believers in Corinth had given the gift to the poor believers in Jerusalem, both groups would have enough money to buy the things they needed. Other ways to translate this word are:

fair balance (NJB)

to be the same

My purpose is that your lives will be the sameUma Back Translation on TW.

2 Corinthians 8:14

Section 8:1–15: Be generous as you are able

The believers in Corinth had previously decided to collect money to send to the poor believers in Jerusalem (1 Corinthians 16:1–4). In this section, Paul spoke of the generous gift of money from the believers in Macedonia and their attitude in giving (2 Corinthians 8:1–5). Paul hoped that the believers in Corinth would follow that example of giving.

Then Paul told them that Titus was coming to them to help collect the money (8:6). Paul encouraged them to give generously just as they did other things well

(8:7). He indicated that he wanted to see that they were sincere in their promise to help the poor with this gift (8:8). He further encouraged them by using the example of Jesus giving (8:9).

Then Paul advised them how best to collect the money for the gift (8:10–11). Then he explained that what matters is giving according to what each person has (8:12). The goal in giving is equality, not making oneself poor for the sake of others (8:13–15).

Other examples for this section heading are:

Encouragement to Be Generous (NRSV)

A Call to Generous Giving (NLT)

Complete^(plur) the collection for the poor believers in Jerusalem

8:14a

At the present time, your surplus will meet their need,

- Currently your^(plur) surplus/abundance will provide for their needs,
- Right now, you have more than you need and that will help them because they do not have enough.

your surplus: The Greek word that the BSB translates as surplus refers to an abundance or excess of something. The believers in Corinth had more than enough money for their needs. So they could share their extra money with other people who did not have enough. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

your abundance (RSV)

your plenty (NIV)

you have plenty (NLT)

you have extra money/goods/things

their need: The Greek words here are literally “the lack of those (people).” Lack is the opposite of the abundance of the rich. The believers in Jerusalem did not have enough money to buy the things that they really needed, such as food and clothing. Other ways to translate these words are:

those who are in need (GNT)

and they have so little (CEV)

8:14b

so that in turn their surplus will meet your need.

- in order that their surplus/abundance might later/also provide for your needs.
- Then some day if you did not have enough and they had more, they could help you.

so that: This connecting phrase introduces the result for the believers in Corinth if they help the poor believers in Jerusalem.

in turn: The Greek word is literally “also.” The word indicates that at a later time, the believers in Jerusalem might help the believers in Corinth. Other ways to translate this Greek word are:

another time (NJB)

Later (NLT)

will meet: The Greek words are literally “might be for.” This phrase indicates that some day the believers in Jerusalem might have a surplus of money which might in turn be used to benefit the believers in Corinth when they didn’t have enough. This phrase does not predict that they would be short of money.

8:14c

Then there will be equality.

- Then everyone will be equal,
- In that way things would balance out.

Then there will be equality: Paul repeated what he said at the end of 8:13 to make clear that his intention was that people would share their goods equally and fairly with one another.

2 Corinthians 8:15

Section 8:1–15: Be generous as you are able

The believers in Corinth had previously decided to collect money to send to the poor believers in Jerusalem (1 Corinthians 16:1–4). In this section, Paul spoke of the generous gift of money from the believers in Macedonia and their attitude in giving (2 Corinthians 8:1–5). Paul hoped that the believers in Corinth would follow that example of giving.

Then Paul told them that Titus was coming to them to help collect the money (8:6). Paul encouraged them to give generously just as they did other things well (8:7). He indicated that he wanted to see that they were sincere in their promise to help the poor with

this gift (8:8). He further encouraged them by using the example of Jesus giving (8:9).

Then Paul advised them how best to collect the money for the gift (8:10–11). Then he explained that what matters is giving according to what each person has (8:12). The goal in giving is equality, not making oneself poor for the sake of others (8:13–15).

Other examples for this section heading are:

Encouragement to Be Generous (NRSV)

A Call to Generous Giving (NLT)

Complete^(plur) the collection for the poor believers in Jerusalem

8:15a

As it is written:

- as it is written in Scripture,
- That agrees with what someone/they wrote in God's holy book,

As it is written: This phrase introduces a quote from the Old Testament. Paul used this quote to support what he said about the result of giving being equality. For example:

As the scripture says (GNT)

This clause is passive. It refers to the writer of that verse. In some languages an active clause must be used. For example:

as someone wrote in God's holy book

As: Here the word As refers to something agreeing with something else. What Paul had just said about equality agreed with the Scripture he quoted. Other ways to translate this word are:

this accords with

this agrees with

8:15b

“He who gathered much had no excess,

- “The one who gathered much did not have too much, (GNT)
- The person who gathered a lot did not have an excess.

8:15c

and he who gathered little had no shortfall.”

- and the one who gathered little did not have too little.” (GNT)
- And the person who gathered a little did not have a lack.”

8:15b–c

He who gathered much had no excess, and he who gathered little had no shortfall: When God sent the manna from heaven, he set a limit on how much to gather. People were to gather a certain amount (called an omer. An omer is about two liters or two quarts. in Hebrew) per person in each household. Those people who gathered for a large household did not exceed the limit. Those people who gathered only for a small household had no lack of manna. Other ways to translate this are:

The one who gathered much did not have too much, and the one who gathered little did not have too little. (GNT)

The person who gathered a lot, he did not have an excess. And the person who gathered a little, he did not have a lack.

The one who gathered a lot, it did not turn out to be too much, and the one who gathered little, it also did not turn out to be insufficient.

In some languages a literal translation would not refer clearly to equality. If that is true in your language, you may want to explain in a footnote. An example footnote is:

In the Old Testament story, some people gathered for many others and some people gathered only for a few others. But after the food was shared, every person had enough to eat. When the believers in Corinth helped the poor believers in Jerusalem, then every person would have enough to meet their needs.

This is a quote from Exodus 16:18. If you footnote the location of quotes from the Old Testament, you may want to do so here.

2 Corinthians 8:16

Section 8:16–9:5: Titus and others went to Corinth

In this section, Paul told the believers in Corinth that Titus had gone to them (8:16–17) to help them prepare

the gift for Paul to take (9:5). An unnamed believer went along with Titus, and Paul described his standing in other churches (8:18–19b). Then Paul described how they intended to be careful regarding this gift (8:19c–21). Paul referred to another unnamed believer who was going with Titus (8:22). He described the standing of Titus and the two believers going with him (8:23) and encouraged the believers in Corinth to treat them well (8:24).

Then Paul reminded the believers in Corinth of their own attitudes regarding this gift (9:1–2) and his goal (9:3–4).

Other examples for this section heading are:

The delegates recommended to the Corinthians (NJB)

Paul commended Titus and his companions

Titus and his companions came to help finish collecting the gift

8:16

But thanks be to God, who put into the heart of Titus the same devotion I have for you.

- ¶ Thanks be to God, who put the same earnest interest/care into the heart/liver/insides of Titus.
- ¶ God gave to Titus the same enthusiasm that we^(excl) have for you, so let us^(incl) thank God.

thanks be to God: The Greek words here are literally “thanks to God.” There are several ways to interpret these words:

1. It is an encouragement for Paul, the other evangelists and the Corinthian believers to thank God. For example:

thank God! (NLT) (BSB, RSV, NJB, NASB, NABRE, ESV, NLT, NET, KJV)

1. It indicates that Paul and the other evangelists (from 8:18) thank God. For example:

How we thank God for making Titus as eager as we are to help you! (GNT) (GNT)

1. It indicates that Paul (from 8:10) thanks God. For example:

I thank God (GW) (NIV, GW, CEV, REB, NCV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) because of the pronouns “our” in 8:13 and “we” in 8:18. But interpretation (2) is also possible from the general context.

who put into the heart of Titus: Here the word heart refers to the place where the emotions, will, and desire are. Your language may use another organ for that place or refer generally to a person. For example:

who put into the liver/insides of Titus

who gave to Titus

the same devotion I have for you: The words I have are not in the Greek, but are implied from the word same. Paul used “I” in 8:10. But it is also possible that the words “we have” are implied from the word “us” in 8:6. For example:

eager as we are to help you (GNT)

devotion: The Greek word that the BSB translates as devotion also refers to earnestness (7:11, 8:7–8). Here it refers to an earnest desire for good things to happen to someone. So the BSB translates the word as devotion. Other ways to translate this word are:

earnest care (RSV)

eager to help (GNT)

sincere concern (NJB)

enthusiasm (NLT)

dedicated (GW)

2 Corinthians 8:17

Section 8:16–9:5: Titus and others went to Corinth

In this section, Paul told the believers in Corinth that Titus had gone to them (8:16–17) to help them prepare the gift for Paul to take (9:5). An unnamed believer went along with Titus, and Paul described his standing in other churches (8:18–19b). Then Paul described how they intended to be careful regarding this gift (8:19c–21). Paul referred to another unnamed believer who was going with Titus (8:22). He described the standing of Titus and the two believers going with him (8:23)

and encouraged the believers in Corinth to treat them well (8:24).

Then Paul reminded the believers in Corinth of their own attitudes regarding this gift (9:1–2) and his goal (9:3–4).

Other examples for this section heading are:

The delegates recommended to the Corinthians (NJB)

Paul commended Titus and his companions

Titus and his companions came to help finish collecting the gift

8:17a–b

For not only did he welcome our appeal, but he is eagerly coming to you of his own volition: The Greek words indicate that Titus did both things (welcome our appeal and is...coming). But the grammar also emphasizes that Titus came to Corinth with much enthusiasm and on his own initiative (8:17b). In some languages emphasizing the second deed is expressed in a different way. For example:

For Titus welcomed our appeal, and more importantly, he is coming to you with much enthusiasm and on his own initiative

He certainly took our urging to heart; but greater still was his own enthusiasm, and he went off to you of his own accord (NJB)

Titus welcomed our appeal, indeed, he is coming to you with much enthusiasm and on his own initiative

Titus welcomed our appeal, and more than that, he is coming to you with much enthusiasm and on his own initiative

8:17a

For not only did he welcome our appeal,

- For he was happy to say yes to the request to return to you^(plur);
- For he gladly agreed to the encouragement to go again to you.

For: This conjunction introduces a sentence that shows Titus' attitude toward the believers in Corinth.

In some languages it is more natural to allow the context to indicate the connection and omit the conjunction.

our appeal: The Greek words are literally “the encouragement.” Scholars think that Paul and perhaps his coworkers encouraged or asked Titus to go to Corinth.

appeal: Here the word appeal refers to Paul and the other evangelists encouraging or asking Titus to return to Corinth. For example:

request (GNT)

8:17b

but he is eagerly coming to you of his own volition.

- indeed, he himself decided to return to you and is doing so with great eagerness.
- And more than that, he is very earnest about this and now comes/came back to you by his own choice/deciding.

he is eagerly coming: The Greek reads literally “he eagerly went out.” Titus probably took this letter (2 Corinthians) with him. So he left soon after Paul finished writing it.

In some languages the verb “went out” should indicate that Titus would leave after Paul wrote the letter. For example:

he is now leaving to come (REB)

he is going to you (RSV)

In other languages the verb “went out” should indicate that when the believers in Corinth read this letter, Titus had left Paul. He probably took the letter with him to Corinth. For example:

he has gone (NASB)

he went (NJB)

eagerly: The Greek words are literally “more eager/diligent.” There are several ways to interpret the Greek comparative:

1. Here the comparative indicates that Titus was very enthusiastic. For example:

he himself was very eager (NLT) (BSB, RSV, NIV, GNT, NASB, NABRE, ESV, NLT, CEV, NET, REB, NCV, ESV)

1. Here the tense indicates that Titus was more enthusiastic than Paul expected in response to the request in 8:17a. For example:

he is more eager than ever (NRSV) (NJB, NRSV, KJV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Harris (p. 596) translates the Greek word as “extremely zealous.” Martin (p. 271) translates it as “all eagerness.” Kistemaker (p. 291), Hughes (on TW), and Furnish (p. 420) also support interpretation (1) in their translations. But Thrall translates the text as “more zealous” and says it probably indicates a comparison of being more enthusiastic than the enthusiasm of saying yes to Paul asking him to help the believers in this way (p. 546).

The word eagerly refers to a strong desire to do something. Other ways to translate this word are:

earnest (RSV)

with much enthusiasm (NIV)

of his own volition: This phrase indicates that Titus decided on his own to do this. Before anyone suggested it to him, he decided that he wanted to go back to Corinth and help the believers in this way. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

of his own accord (NJB)

of his own free will (GNT)

this was his own idea (NCV)

2 Corinthians 8:18

Section 8:16–9:5: Titus and others went to Corinth

In this section, Paul told the believers in Corinth that Titus had gone to them (8:16–17) to help them prepare the gift for Paul to take (9:5). An unnamed believer went along with Titus, and Paul described his standing in other churches (8:18–19b). Then Paul described how they intended to be careful regarding this gift (8:19c–21). Paul referred to another unnamed believer who was going with Titus (8:22). He described the standing

of Titus and the two believers going with him (8:23) and encouraged the believers in Corinth to treat them well (8:24).

Then Paul reminded the believers in Corinth of their own attitudes regarding this gift (9:1–2) and his goal (9:3–4).

Other examples for this section heading are:

The delegates recommended to the Corinthians (NJB)

Paul commended Titus and his companions

Titus and his companions came to help finish collecting the gift

8:18a

Along with Titus we are sending the brother

- And with him, we^(excl) are sending the brother
- We send/sent with him another fellow-believer.

we are sending: Here the Greek reads literally “we sent.” As for the verb “went out” in 8:17b, in some languages, the verb “sent” here should indicate that the brother described in this verse would leave after Paul wrote the letter. For example:

we are sending (NIV)

I am sending

In other languages, the verb “sent” should indicate that when the believers in Corinth read this letter, the brother would be there with them. For example:

we have sent (NASB)

we sent

Use the same kind of tense or wording here as you did in 8:17b.

brother: Here the word brother refers to a believer in Jesus. The word indicates a close relationship, since all believers become children of God. See how you translated this word in 1:1 or 8:1.

8:18b

who is praised by all the churches for his work in the gospel.

- who is highly respected in all the churches for his work in/regarding the gospel.
- All the groups of believers commend him because he has faithfully served in the work of spreading/showing the good news about Jesus.

Paul described this “brother” here, but he did not name him. It is not known who this “brother” might be. The believers in Corinth probably knew him, so Paul did not name him. It is also possible that the reason why Paul did not name him was that he wanted to show that Titus was the leader of that group.

who is praised by all the churches for his work in the gospel: The Greek words are literally “whose praise/approval in the gospel (is) through(out) all the churches.” The churches knew of this person and approved of him regarding his faith and life. He served God in connection with the gospel of Jesus, possibly through preaching, evangelism, or other work. Other ways to translate this are:

whose fame in the things of the gospel has spread through all the churches (NASB)

who is well known in every church for spreading the good news (CEV)

whom all the congregations esteem on account of his work in regard to the gospel

who, because of his hard work in spreading the gospel, has become very respected by the believers in all the various towns

churches: The Greek word that the BSB translates as churches refers generally to a gathering of people. Here, as almost always in the New Testament, it refers to groups of believers. See how you translated this word in 1:1 or 8:1.

his work in the gospel: This phrase is literally just in the gospel. Here it refers to everything done to show what the gospel is about. This probably included preaching and teaching the gospel as well as showing God’s love by helping others. Other ways to translate this are:

spreading the good news (CEV)

his work in showing/carrying the Good News

his communicating the Good News

gospel: The Greek word that the BSB translates here as gospel is sometimes translated as “good news.” In the New Testament the word refers to the good news that Jesus is the Christ. See how you translated this word in 2:12 or 4:3.

2 Corinthians 8:19

Section 8:16–9:5: Titus and others went to Corinth

In this section, Paul told the believers in Corinth that Titus had gone to them (8:16–17) to help them prepare the gift for Paul to take (9:5). An unnamed believer went along with Titus, and Paul described his standing in other churches (8:18–19b). Then Paul described how they intended to be careful regarding this gift (8:19c–21). Paul referred to another unnamed believer who was going with Titus (8:22). He described the standing of Titus and the two believers going with him (8:23) and encouraged the believers in Corinth to treat them well (8:24).

Then Paul reminded the believers in Corinth of their own attitudes regarding this gift (9:1–2) and his goal (9:3–4).

Other examples for this section heading are:

The delegates recommended to the Corinthians (NJB)

Paul commended Titus and his companions

Titus and his companions came to help finish collecting the gift

8:19a

More than that, this brother was chosen by the churches to accompany us

- And not only that, he was selected/appointed by the churches to go with us^(excl)
- Furthermore, the other groups of believers decided that he would travel with us

More than that: This phrase indicates that Paul had more to say about the unnamed brother. Other ways to translate this are:

and not only that (RSV)

And besides that (GNT)

this brother was chosen by the churches: This clause is passive. Some languages must use an active clause. For example:

the churches elected him (GW)

8:19b with the offering—

- in this work of generosity, (NJB)
- as we collect and distribute/share this gift of money.

with the offering: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as with the offering is literally “with this grace.” It indicates that the churches chose the unnamed believer with this gift of money in mind. They wanted him to help Paul to collect the gift properly, take it safely to Jerusalem, and share the money fairly with the poor believers.

Many English versions add a verb to help explain what the unnamed believer would do. For example:

as we carry the offering (NIV)

as we take the offering (NLT)

help in this beneficent work (REB)

to help us in regards to this gift of money

In other languages it is more natural to follow the Greek and, like the BSB, not use a verb. For example:

in this work of generosity (NJB)

in regards to this gift of money

offering: The Greek word here is literally “grace.” Here it refers to the results of grace, which in this case are a gift. This gift of money to the poor believers in Jerusalem will help them to buy the things they need. Other ways to translate this word are:

act of grace (ESV)

gift of money (NCV)

8:19c the gracious gift we administer to honor the Lord Himself

- which we manage/oversee so that the Lord himself may be glorified/honored
- We will supervise this gift properly so that people will praise the Lord God.

we administer: This clause tells the reader more about the offering. In some languages a literal translation would wrongly indicate that Paul was thinking of other offerings and that he and his coworkers administered only this one. If that is true in your language, translate this clause in a way that tells more about the offering. One way to do that is to start a new sentence here. For example:

We administer it

administer: This verb refers to organizing a project and making it happen. Paul and the others were helping the believers collect the money. Paul and the others would also take it to Jerusalem. Other ways to translate this word are:

doing this service (NCV)

take proper care of

watch over

being leaders over this work

to honor the Lord Himself: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as honor the Lord is literally “the glory of the Lord.” This Greek phrase indicates that the purpose of administering the gift properly was to honor God. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

for the sake of the Lord’s glory (GNT)

that glorifies the Lord (NLT)

that will bring praise to the Lord (CEV)

Lord: The word Lord probably refers to God here. In some languages it is more natural to include “God” in this phrase. For example:

Lord God

The Greek word that the BSB translates as Lord means “the one in authority over (something)” or “master.” See how you translated this word in 1:2 or 8:5.

8:19d

and to show our eagerness to help.

- and to witness that we are ready and willing to help.
- We also want to show him that we are eager to help the believers in Jerusalem.

to show our eagerness to help: The Greek words are literally “for the purpose of our eagerness.” The Greek preposition *pros* occurs before the phrase “honor the Lord himself.” Here it means “for the purpose of.” The preposition connects to the phrase “our eagerness” as well. The brother would be able to tell the believers in Corinth that Paul and his coworkers eagerly administered the gift. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

for the purpose of telling you about our eagerness for this task

shows that we are doing it willingly (GW)

show our own eagerness to serve (REB)

to show that we really want to help (NCV)

2 Corinthians 8:20

Section 8:16–9:5: Titus and others went to Corinth

In this section, Paul told the believers in Corinth that Titus had gone to them (8:16–17) to help them prepare the gift for Paul to take (9:5). An unnamed believer went along with Titus, and Paul described his standing in other churches (8:18–19b). Then Paul described how they intended to be careful regarding this gift (8:19c–21). Paul referred to another unnamed believer who was going with Titus (8:22). He described the standing of Titus and the two believers going with him (8:23) and encouraged the believers in Corinth to treat them well (8:24).

Then Paul reminded the believers in Corinth of their own attitudes regarding this gift (9:1–2) and his goal (9:3–4).

Other examples for this section heading are:

The delegates recommended to the Corinthians (NJB)

Paul commended Titus and his companions

Titus and his companions came to help finish collecting the gift

8:20a

We hope to avoid any criticism

- We^(excl) use this plan to avoid anyone blaming us
- We are doing that so that no one will accuse us

We hope to avoid any criticism: The Greek words are literally “Avoiding this lest anyone should blame us.” Paul agreed to the plan of sending the unnamed brother because that brother could verify that everything had been done properly and that no one had stolen money from the gift. Other ways to translate this are:

We arranged it this way so that no one should be able to make any accusation against us (NJB)

We took this precaution so that no one would blame us of wrongdoing

We take this course so that no one should blame us (ESV)

We did this as a precaution so that no one should blame us (NET)

8:20b

of the way we administer this generous gift.

- about the way we manage/oversee this abundant/plentiful gift.
- of wrongdoing in regard to this large/generous gift.

generous: Here the word generous refers to an abundant or plentiful amount of money. Other ways to translate this word are:

overflowing

rich/ample

large (NCV)

2 Corinthians 8:21

Section 8:16–9:5: Titus and others went to Corinth

In this section, Paul told the believers in Corinth that Titus had gone to them (8:16–17) to help them prepare the gift for Paul to take (9:5). An unnamed believer went along with Titus, and Paul described his standing

in other churches (8:18–19b). Then Paul described how they intended to be careful regarding this gift (8:19c–21). Paul referred to another unnamed believer who was going with Titus (8:22). He described the standing of Titus and the two believers going with him (8:23) and encouraged the believers in Corinth to treat them well (8:24).

Then Paul reminded the believers in Corinth of their own attitudes regarding this gift (9:1–2) and his goal (9:3–4).

Other examples for this section heading are:

The delegates recommended to the Corinthians (NJB)

Paul commended Titus and his companions

Titus and his companions came to help finish collecting the gift

8:21a

For we are taking great care to do what is right,

- For we^(excl) plan and do what is proper
- We give our attention to doing things in a good/correct way,

For: This conjunction introduces a further explanation about Paul's desire to administer the gift properly. In some languages it is more natural to allow the context to indicate the connection and omit the conjunction.

we are taking great care to do what is right: The Greek words are literally “we think beforehand about good/noble.” Other ways to translate this are:

we are planning/thinking ahead of time about doing what is right

we plan beforehand the proper things to do

we are concerned about what is right (NET)

we are taking pains to do what is right (NIV)

8:21b

not only in the eyes of the Lord, but also in the eyes of men.

- in the sight of the Lord and also in the sight of people.

- not only in ways that the Lord God accepts but also in ways that people accept.

not only in the eyes of the Lord, but also in the eyes of men: These words indicate that Paul and the other evangelists wanted to do things in ways that both the Lord and other people would accept. Other ways to translate this are:

not only in the sight of the Lord but also in the sight of people (NJB)

what the Lord accepts as right and also what people think is right (NCV)

We are careful to be honorable before the Lord, but we also want everyone else to see that we are honorable (NLT)

that which the Lord calls appropriate, as well as that which people call appropriate

Lord: The word Lord probably refers to God here. In some languages it is more natural to include “God” in this phrase. For example:

Lord God

men: Here this word refers generally to people. For example:

others (GNT)

2 Corinthians 8:22

Section 8:16–9:5: Titus and others went to Corinth

In this section, Paul told the believers in Corinth that Titus had gone to them (8:16–17) to help them prepare the gift for Paul to take (9:5). An unnamed believer went along with Titus, and Paul described his standing in other churches (8:18–19b). Then Paul described how they intended to be careful regarding this gift (8:19c–21). Paul referred to another unnamed believer who was going with Titus (8:22). He described the standing of Titus and the two believers going with him (8:23) and encouraged the believers in Corinth to treat them well (8:24).

Then Paul reminded the believers in Corinth of their own attitudes regarding this gift (9:1–2) and his goal (9:3–4).

Other examples for this section heading are:

The delegates recommended to the Corinthians
(NJB)

Paul commended Titus and his companions

Titus and his companions came to help finish
collecting the gift

8:22a

And we are sending along with them our brother

- ¶ And with them, we^(excl) are sending our^(incl) brother
- ¶ Furthermore, we send/sent to you^(plur) another fellow-believer along with them.

And: The Greek word that the BSB translates as And indicates that Paul had something more to say about who was going to Corinth. He explained in this verse that another person was going to Corinth with Titus and the unnamed believer. Here is another way to translate this word:

also (NLT)

In some languages it is more natural to allow the context to indicate the connection and omit the conjunction.

we are sending along with them our brother: This clause indicates that a third man, also unnamed, would also go with Titus and the unnamed believer of 8:18–19. For example:

we are sending our brother with them (GNT)

we are sending: Here the Greek reads literally “we sent.” As for the verb “went out” in 8:17b and the verb “sent” in 8:18a, in some languages, the verb “sent” here should indicate that the second brother described in this verse would leave after Paul wrote the letter. For example:

we are sending (NIV)

I am sending

In other languages, the verb “sent” should indicate that when the believers in Corinth read this letter, this second brother would also be there with them. For example:

we have sent (NASB)

we sent

Use the same kind of tense or wording here as you did in 8:17b and 8:18a.

brother: Here the word brother refers to a believer. See how you translated this word in 8:18.

8:22b

whose earnestness has been proven many times and in many ways,

- whom we have often tested in many kinds of tasks and saw/found that he was always earnest/diligent,
- We have given many tasks of various sorts to him and he has proved to be eager/zealous to do them each time.

whose earnestness has been proven many times and in many ways: There are two ways to interpret the Greek word that the BSB translates as has been proven:

1. It means that Paul gave tasks to this person and each time he did those deeds eagerly and well. In that way Paul tested him and saw his earnestness. For example:

we have tested him many times and found him always very eager (GNT) (RSV, GNT, NJB, NASB, NABRE, ESV, GW, NET, REB)

1. It means that Paul observed this person do things that honored God. His deeds proved to Paul that he had earnestness. For example:

who has proven himself many times and has shown on many occasions how eager he is (NLT) (BSB, NIV, NLT, NCV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), since the Greek word is active here. Barrett, Harris, Martin, Thrall, Hodge, Furnish, and Kistemaker support interpretation (1). Harris also says that “the reference is not simply to testing but to this person’s emergence from testing with proven character.” Other ways to translate this are:

whom we have often tested and found earnest in many matters (RSV)

we have tested him many times and found him always very eager to help (GNT)

whose eagerness we have tested over and over again in many ways (NJB)

earnestness: The Greek word that the BSB translates as earnestness refers to being eager to do a task and diligent to do it well. Other ways to translate this word are:

zealous (NIV)

eager (GNT)

diligent (NASB)

8:22c

and now even more so by his great confidence in you.

- and who is now more earnest/diligent because he is very confident in you.
- He is certain that you will give willingly, so now he is even more eager than he was before to help in this task.

and now even more so: This phrase indicates that the second unnamed believer heard about the eagerness of the believers in Corinth to give the gift and after that he was more eager to help them in that task. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

but who is now more earnest than ever (RSV)

he is all the more eager to help (GNT)

by his great confidence in you: This phrase indicates that the reason why the second unnamed believer was more eager was that he was very confident that the believers in Corinth would collect the gift properly and give willingly (8:12). Other ways to translate this are:

because he is very confident in you

because he trusts you so much (CEV)

since he is sure that you will give willingly

2 Corinthians 8:23

Section 8:16–9:5: Titus and others went to Corinth

In this section, Paul told the believers in Corinth that Titus had gone to them (8:16–17) to help them prepare the gift for Paul to take (9:5). An unnamed believer

went along with Titus, and Paul described his standing in other churches (8:18–19b). Then Paul described how they intended to be careful regarding this gift (8:19c–21). Paul referred to another unnamed believer who was going with Titus (8:22). He described the standing of Titus and the two believers going with him (8:23) and encouraged the believers in Corinth to treat them well (8:24).

Then Paul reminded the believers in Corinth of their own attitudes regarding this gift (9:1–2) and his goal (9:3–4).

Other examples for this section heading are:

The delegates recommended to the Corinthians (NJB)

Paul commended Titus and his companions

Titus and his companions came to help finish collecting the gift

8:23a

As for Titus,

- If someone has questions regarding Titus,
- If anyone questions why I send/sent Titus,

As for Titus: The Greek words are literally “If regarding Titus.” Paul leaves the subject and verb implied. The clause with the implied words is probably “If (anyone asks) regarding Titus,” because Paul told the believers in Corinth that they should love and accept Titus (8:24b) as they had before (7:7b, 13d). Some people in Corinth, perhaps the false apostles (11:13), might claim that Titus should not do this work and question his authority or standing. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

If anyone asks about Titus (NLT)

If there is any question about Titus (NET)

If Titus is in question (NJB)

8:23b

he is my partner and fellow worker among you.

- he is my colleague and coworker to benefit you^(plur),
- we have a close relationship in this ministry of the gospel and he has worked together with me in ministering/serving you.

my partner: Here the phrase my partner indicates that Titus had a close relationship with Paul and had similar goals. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

my colleague

my associate

fellow worker: This phrase indicates that Titus worked together with Paul in the ministry to the non-Jewish people. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

works with me (GNT)

coworker (GW)

among you: This phrase refers to Titus preaching, teaching, helping, and things like that in the midst of the believers in Corinth. Both Paul and Titus ministered to them and helped them. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

in your midst

to help you (GNT)

for your benefit (ESV)

8:23c

As for our brothers,

- and if someone has questions regarding our^(incl) brothers,
- If anyone questions why our two fellow-believers come/came,

As for our brothers: The Greek words are literally “if our brothers.” Here the phrase refers to someone perhaps asking about these brothers. Someone might also question the authority of the two other believers. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

If anyone asks about our brothers

if there is any question about our brothers (NET)

8:23d

they are messengers of the churches,

- they are official messengers of the churches
- they act on behalf of the other groups of believers

they are messengers of the churches: The Greek word that the BSB translates as messengers is often translated as “apostles.” Here it indicates that the churches chose the two unnamed believers and gave them the authority to do things on their behalf. Other ways to translate this are:

they are the emissaries of the churches (NJB)

the brothers are official messengers of the churches (JBP)

they are delegates of the churches (REB)

they represent the churches

8:23e

to the glory of Christ.

- and they bring glory/honor to Christ.
- and people praise/honor Christ because of all that they do.

to the glory of Christ: The phrase the glory of Christ describes the “brothers” in 8:23c. Here the phrase may refer to:

1. their strong faith honors Christ;

- (bd) the things they do show Christ’s power and majesty.

Translate in a way that allows one or both meanings. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

bring glory to Christ (GNT)

and they bring honor to Christ (NLT)

their lives are to the praise of Christ

people praise/honor Christ because of what they do

2 Corinthians 8:24

Section 8:16–9:5: Titus and others went to Corinth

In this section, Paul told the believers in Corinth that Titus had gone to them (8:16–17) to help them prepare the gift for Paul to take (9:5). An unnamed believer went along with Titus, and Paul described his standing in other churches (8:18–19b). Then Paul described how they intended to be careful regarding this gift (8:19c–

21). Paul referred to another unnamed believer who was going with Titus (8:22). He described the standing of Titus and the two believers going with him (8:23) and encouraged the believers in Corinth to treat them well (8:24).

Then Paul reminded the believers in Corinth of their own attitudes regarding this gift (9:1–2) and his goal (9:3–4).

Other examples for this section heading are:

The delegates recommended to the Corinthians (NJB)

Paul commended Titus and his companions

Titus and his companions came to help finish collecting the gift

8:24a

In full view of the churches, then,

- So that the other churches will be certain of those things,
- So that the churches will understand the great degree/amount of your love and faith,

In full view of the churches: The Greek words are literally “in the presence of the churches.” Paul commanded the believers to love God, Jesus, and the poor believers in Jerusalem. He also commanded them to live according to faith in Jesus (6:1) and live separate from pagan practices and other sins (7:1). They were to do those things in such a way that the other churches would clearly see their love and faith. Other ways to translate this are:

before the churches (RSV)

so that all the churches will be sure of it (GNT)

let the churches see/understand

8:24b

show these men the proof of your love

- clearly show^(plur) to these three men evidence/proof of your^(plur) love
- openly/publicly show that you love God/Jesus

show these men the proof of your love: Paul commanded the believers in Corinth to demonstrate

clearly that they loved God and Jesus. Other ways to translate this are:

give proof...of your love...to these men (RSV)

show them openly...the proof of your love (NET)

give them...clear evidence of your love (REB)

show: The Greek word that the BSB translates as show implies publicly showing their love. For example:

show...openly (NET)

your love: This phrase probably refers to love for Jesus, for Paul, or for the Jerusalem church. If possible, do not indicate to whom this love refers. In some languages it is more natural to indicate whom they love. If so, refer to Jesus. For example:

your love for Jesus

8:24c

and the reason for our boasting about you.

- and why we^(excl) boast about you.
- and openly/publicly show why we are always saying such good things about you.

the reason for our boasting about you: Paul also commanded the believers in Corinth to demonstrate clearly that they believed very much in Jesus. He commanded them to act in ways proper for believers. Paul had boasted about their faith and life to the three men. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

of our boasting about you (RSV)

prove...that our boasting about you is justified (NLT)

Show...that we were right to be proud of you (GW)

2 Corinthians 9:1

Section 8:16–9:5: Titus and others went to Corinth

In this section, Paul told the believers in Corinth that Titus had gone to them (8:16–17) to help them prepare the gift for Paul to take (9:5). An unnamed believer went along with Titus, and Paul described his standing in other churches (8:18–19b). Then Paul described how they intended to be careful regarding this gift (8:19c–

21). Paul referred to another unnamed believer who was going with Titus (8:22). He described the standing of Titus and the two believers going with him (8:23) and encouraged the believers in Corinth to treat them well (8:24).

Then Paul reminded the believers in Corinth of their own attitudes regarding this gift (9:1-2) and his goal (9:3-4).

Other examples for this section heading are:

The delegates recommended to the Corinthians (NJB)

Paul commended Titus and his companions

Titus and his companions came to help finish collecting the gift

9:1-3c

there is no need for me to write to you...But I am sending: Two Greek conjunctions indicate that Paul had two thoughts about the believers in Corinth in regard to giving. One thought was that Paul knew that they were enthusiastic to give, so he did not need to write more (9:1-2). Another thought was that he wanted to send someone to help them finish (9:3-4), as well as write more to explain and encourage them further (9:5-15). Other ways to translate the two conjunctions are:

¹ On one hand, there is no need for me to write...
³ But on the other hand I am sending...

¹ In one way, there is no need for me to write...
³ But in another way I am sending...

¹ One thought I have is that there is no need for me to write...³ But another thought is this: I am sending...

9:1

Now about the service to the saints, there is no need for me to write to you.

- ¶ Indeed, about this ministry to God's holy people who are poor, in one way, I have no need to write further to you^(plur),
- ¶ About supporting believers who are needy, from one standpoint, it is unnecessary for me to write more to you about it.

Now: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as Now is often translated as “for” or “because.” Here it probably introduces a further explanation about giving (chapter 8). For example:

For (NASB)

In some languages it is more natural to allow the context to indicate the connection and omit the conjunction.

about the service to the saints, there is no need for me to write to you: The BSB follows the Greek word order here. It gives prominence to the topic the service to the saints. Some English versions use a different word order. For example:

There is no need for me to write to you about this service to the Lord's people (NIV)

Use the word order that would be natural in your language.

the service to: The Greek word that the BSB translates as service is usually translated “ministry,” as in 6:3b. Here the Greek word refers to helping the poor believers in Jerusalem. Other ways to translate this word are:

the help being sent to (GNT)

this support to

the gift for

this ministry of giving for (NLT)

See how you translated this phrase in 8:4.

the saints: The Greek word that the BSB translates as saints is literally “holy ones.” The word usually refers to all believers. Here it probably refers to the poor believers in Jerusalem. Other ways to translate this word are:

God's people (GNT)

the followers of Jesus

the poor believers

the believers in Jerusalem (NLT)

there is no need for me to write to you: In many ways, the believers were already prepared to give, so Paul did not need to write to encourage them. Other ways to translate this are:

it is superfluous for me to write to you (RSV)

I don't need to write anything further to you (GW)

2 Corinthians 9:2

Section 8:16–9:5: Titus and others went to Corinth

In this section, Paul told the believers in Corinth that Titus had gone to them (8:16–17) to help them prepare the gift for Paul to take (9:5). An unnamed believer went along with Titus, and Paul described his standing in other churches (8:18–19b). Then Paul described how they intended to be careful regarding this gift (8:19c–21). Paul referred to another unnamed believer who was going with Titus (8:22). He described the standing of Titus and the two believers going with him (8:23) and encouraged the believers in Corinth to treat them well (8:24).

Then Paul reminded the believers in Corinth of their own attitudes regarding this gift (9:1–2) and his goal (9:3–4).

Other examples for this section heading are:

The delegates recommended to the Corinthians (NJB)

Paul commended Titus and his companions

Titus and his companions came to help finish collecting the gift

9:2a

For I know your eagerness to help,

- because I know that you^(plur) are eager regarding this ministry,
- For I know that you are very earnest to help them,

For: This conjunction introduces the reason why Paul believed that there was no need for him to write more on this topic. Here is another way to translate this:

because (NET)

In some languages it is more natural to allow the context to indicate the connection and omit the conjunction.

your eagerness to help: The BSB adds the phrase to help. The context implies that the believers were eager to collect money and send it to the poor believers in Jerusalem (9:1). So the BSB and some other English versions add implied information. For example:

I know how eager you are to give (CEV)

9:2b

and I have been boasting to the Macedonians

- and I boast about you to the Macedonians.
- and I speak of you with pride to the believers in Macedonia

I have been boasting: While Paul was in Macedonia, he was telling the believers there about the eagerness of the believers in Corinth (9:2a, 2c). He expected the believers in Corinth to give generously. That was his boast. Other ways to translate this clause are:

I brag about you (GW)

I speak of it with pride (REB)

The Greek uses the present tense, “I boast.” Here the present tense indicates that Paul was boasting about the believers in Corinth during the time he was in Macedonia. He probably also boasted about them after he left Macedonia, even to the day he wrote this letter. For example:

I keep boasting (NET)

boasting: This word refers to praising someone or saying how good someone is. Other ways to translate this word are:

speaking very highly about

praising

telling about how great/good

See how you translated this word in 1:12 or 7:14.

the Macedonians: This phrase refers to the believers in the province of Macedonia. It does not refer to all the people in Macedonia. For example:

the churches in Macedonia (NLT)

9:2c

that since last year you in Achaia were prepared to give.

- I was telling them that you in Achaia were ready to help, beginning from last year,
- namely, boasting to them that you in the province of Achaia have been ready to give since last year.

you in Achaia: The city of Corinth was in the province of Achaia, so Paul could refer to the believers in Corinth by that name.

In some languages people are not familiar with the name Achaia. If that is true in your language, you may want to explain in your translation. For example:

you in the province of Achaia

were prepared to give: The Greek word is literally “were ready.” It is implied that the believers were ready to collect money and send it to the poor believers in Jerusalem (9:1). So the BSB and some other English versions add implied information such as the phrase to give. Here is another way to translate this:

have been ready to help (GNT)

9:2d

And your zeal has stirred most of them to do likewise.

- and your zeal/eagerness to help has caused most of them to prepare a gift.
- And when they heard of your readiness to give, most of them collected money as well.

your zeal has stirred most of them to do likewise:

The Greek word that the BSB translates as stirred can be translated literally as “provoked” (as in the KJV). This clause indicates that the enthusiasm of the believers in Corinth caused many believers in Macedonia to want to help the poor believers also. Other ways to translate this clause are:

your enthusiasm has moved most of them [to act] (GW)

your desire to give has made them want to give (CEV)

zeal: The Greek word that the BSB translates as zeal refers to eagerness or readiness to do something. Here the word refers to eagerly wanting to help. Other ways to translate this word are:

enthusiasm (NIV)

eagerness (GNT)

2 Corinthians 9:3**Section 8:16–9:5: Titus and others went to Corinth**

In this section, Paul told the believers in Corinth that Titus had gone to them (8:16–17) to help them prepare the gift for Paul to take (9:5). An unnamed believer went along with Titus, and Paul described his standing in other churches (8:18–19b). Then Paul described how they intended to be careful regarding this gift (8:19c–21). Paul referred to another unnamed believer who was going with Titus (8:22). He described the standing of Titus and the two believers going with him (8:23) and encouraged the believers in Corinth to treat them well (8:24).

Then Paul reminded the believers in Corinth of their own attitudes regarding this gift (9:1–2) and his goal (9:3–4).

Other examples for this section heading are:

The delegates recommended to the Corinthians (NJB)

Paul commended Titus and his companions

Titus and his companions came to help finish collecting the gift

9:3a

But I am sending the brothers in order that

- But in another way, I am sending the three brothers so that
- Yet from another standpoint, I am sending those fellow-believers to you so that

But: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as But connects to 9:1 and means “on the other hand” here. See the note on 9:1–3c above.

I am sending: Here the Greek says literally “I sent.” Use the same kind of tense or wording as you did for “went out” in 8:17b and “sent” in 8:18a and 8:22a.

the brothers: This phrase refers to Titus and the two other believers. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

these brothers (NLT)

Titus and the two others (CEV)

9:3b

our boasting about you in this matter should not prove empty,

- our^(excl) boasts about you regarding this ministry will not become vain/empty/wrong,
- the boasts we made about you supporting the poor believers will prove true.

in this matter: This phrase refers to collecting and sending the gift for the poor believers.

should not prove empty: The word empty describes something that might look solid on the outside but is empty on the inside. Paul boasted about the eagerness of the believers in Corinth to collect the gift. But if they gathered only a small gift, then his boasts would be empty of meaning, or empty. Other ways to translate this are:

may not prove vain (RSV)

may not turn out to be empty words (GNT)

were not wrong (CEV)

should prove true

9:3c

but that you will be prepared, just as I said.

- and/but so that you^(plur) may be ready with your gift, just as I had said/boasted.
- Rather, I am sending the brothers so that your gift will be prepared when I come, just as I have been telling/boasting to the Macedonian churches that you would do.

but that you will be prepared: The Greek word that the BSB translates as but that is literally “in order that.” It indicates that 9:3c is the second part of the purpose for what Paul said in 9:3a.

In English, using “in order that” here would imply that 9:3c explains something about 9:3b. In some languages it is more natural to use “and” or but here. Paul first said what he did not want (9:3b) and here said what he wanted. For example:

and that you may be ready (NJB)

and in order that what you give will be prepared-
Kankanaey Back Translation on TW.

but in order that you may be ready

In some languages it is more natural to repeat some of the words in 9:3a. For example:

but I am sending the brothers in order that you may be ready

you will be prepared: The believers were to have their gift prepared when Paul arrived. The three men went ahead of Paul to make sure the gift would be ready. The gift was probably not ready when Titus and the other two men arrived, since they went to help prepare it.

In some languages a literal translation would wrongly indicate or imply that the gift was ready for the three men. If that is true in your language, you may want to explain in your translation. For example:

you may be ready for me

you may have your gift ready when I arrive

General Comment on 9:3b–c

In some languages it is more natural to say what Paul wanted (9:3c) first, and what he did not want (9:3b) second. For example:

^{3a}But I am sending the brothers in order that ^{3c}you may be prepared, as I said you would be, ^{3b}and that our boasting about you in this matter should not prove empty.

2 Corinthians 9:4

Section 8:16–9:5: Titus and others went to Corinth

In this section, Paul told the believers in Corinth that Titus had gone to them (8:16–17) to help them prepare the gift for Paul to take (9:5). An unnamed believer went along with Titus, and Paul described his standing in other churches (8:18–19b). Then Paul described how they intended to be careful regarding this gift (8:19c–21). Paul referred to another unnamed believer who was going with Titus (8:22). He described the standing of Titus and the two believers going with him (8:23) and encouraged the believers in Corinth to treat them well (8:24).

Then Paul reminded the believers in Corinth of their own attitudes regarding this gift (9:1-2) and his goal (9:3-4).

Other examples for this section heading are:

The delegates recommended to the Corinthians (NJB)

Paul commended Titus and his companions

Titus and his companions came to help finish collecting the gift

9:4a

Otherwise, if any Macedonians come with me and find you unprepared,

- Otherwise, if some Macedonians come with me and see that you^(plur) are not ready,
- Some believers from Macedonia may come with me. If they see/discover that you have not prepared your gift,
- If some Macedonian believers come with me to you, they might find that you have not prepared your gift.

Otherwise, if any Macedonians come with me and find you unprepared: These words indicate that the believers in Corinth might be unprepared with their gift when the Macedonians arrived. Then, the Macedonians would see that the believers in Corinth had not done as they had said they would. Other ways to translate this are:

Otherwise, if any Macedonians come with me, they might find out that you're not ready after all (GW)

Some followers from Macedonia may come with me, and I want them to find that you have the money ready. If you don't, (CEV)

any Macedonians: This phrase refers to believers from the Macedonian churches. It probably refers to people whom the churches chose to take the gift from the Macedonian churches to Jerusalem. The phrase does not refer to the two unnamed believers of 8:18-24. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

some Macedonian believers (NLT)

other delegates from the churches in Macedonia

find you unprepared: This clause indicates that the Macedonians might discover that the believers in Corinth were not prepared to give the gift. Another way to translate this is:

see that you are unprepared

9:4b

we—to say nothing of you—would be ashamed of having been so confident.

- we^(excl) would be humiliated for being so confident—to say nothing of you.
- we would be ashamed by our thinking with no doubts that you would do as you said you would, but you would be ashamed even more.
- If you are unprepared, that would shame us for being certain about you. It would shame you even more!

we—to say nothing of you—would be ashamed: The Greek words are literally “we, in order that we should not say you, should be ashamed.” The Greek and the BSB emphasize that the believers in Corinth would indeed be ashamed as well. It is a polite way to urge the believers to finish collecting the gift so that neither Paul nor the believers will be ashamed. Other ways to translate this are:

how ashamed we would be—not to speak of your shame— (GNT)

we would be ashamed, but you would be even more ashamed

we will be ashamed... (And you will be ashamed, too!) (NCV)

Your translation should not indicate or imply a rebuke.

ashamed: Paul and the other evangelists were confident and boasted that the believers in Corinth would prepare their gift. But if the believers did not prepare it, both groups would be ashamed. Other ways to translate this word are:

humiliated (RSV)

be put to shame (NJB)

be embarrassed (NLT)

a disgrace it will be to us (REB)

of having been so confident: There is a textual issue in 9:4b. (1) Most early Greek manuscripts have the Greek phrase that the RSV translates as being so confident (BSB, RSV, NIV, GNT, NJB, GW, NET, JBP, REB, ESV). (2) A few early Greek manuscripts have the Greek phrase that the KJV translates as this same confident boasting (KJV only). It is recommended that you follow option (1). This phrase refers to Paul being sure that the believers in Corinth would finish collecting the money for the gift before he arrived in Corinth. For example:

by our confidence in you (NJB)

2 Corinthians 9:5

Section 8:16–9:5: Titus and others went to Corinth

In this section, Paul told the believers in Corinth that Titus had gone to them (8:16–17) to help them prepare the gift for Paul to take (9:5). An unnamed believer went along with Titus, and Paul described his standing in other churches (8:18–19b). Then Paul described how they intended to be careful regarding this gift (8:19c–21). Paul referred to another unnamed believer who was going with Titus (8:22). He described the standing of Titus and the two believers going with him (8:23) and encouraged the believers in Corinth to treat them well (8:24).

Then Paul reminded the believers in Corinth of their own attitudes regarding this gift (9:1–2) and his goal (9:3–4).

Other examples for this section heading are:

The delegates recommended to the Corinthians (NJB)

Paul commended Titus and his companions

Titus and his companions came to help finish collecting the gift

9:5a

So I thought it necessary to urge the brothers to visit you beforehand

- Therefore I thought that urging the brothers to visit you^(plur) first was necessary.
- So, I decided that I needed to encourage the three fellow-believers to go and visit you before I arrive.

I thought it necessary to urge the brothers: This clause indicates that Paul thought about what was best to do, and he decided that he needed to urge the three men to go to Corinth. Other ways to translate this are:

I decided that the only correct thing to do was to urge the brothers

I considered/realized that I needed to encourage the brothers

urge: This word refers to encouraging someone to do something. Paul encouraged the three men to go. This word does not imply that the men were unwilling to go. Here is another way to translate this:

encourage (NJB)

beforehand: This phrase indicates that Titus and the other two believers would go to Corinth ahead of Paul. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

before me (RSV)

ahead of me (GNT)

9:5b

and make arrangements for the bountiful gift you had promised.

- Before I arrive, they will arrange the blessing to the poor believers that you had earlier promised.
- They will help you to finish preparing/gathering the gift that will cause many to thank God, that is, the gift that you had promised to give.

make arrangements: Here this phrase refers to collecting all the money that the believers planned to give, keeping it safe until Paul arrived, and perhaps choosing some men to go with Paul when he took the gift to Jerusalem. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

arrange beforehand (NASB)

get ready in advance (GNT)

will finish getting in order (NCV)

the bountiful gift you had promised: The believers had earlier promised to give a bountiful gift, perhaps in the previous year (9:2c). Here is another way to translate this:

the gift that you have already promised (NJB)

bountiful gift: The Greek word is literally “blessing.” This gift would bless and encourage the poor believers in Jerusalem. They would be thankful to God and to the churches that had given. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

generous gift (NIV)

gift of blessing

a gift that will benefit the poor believers

9:5c

This way, your gift will be prepared generously

- If you do that, you will have prepared it as a gift that will benefit the poor believers,
- Then you would make it a gift that blesses,
- May your gift be a gift of generosity,

This way, your gift will be prepared generously: The Greek words are literally “this to be ready as a free gift.” Here are some ways to translate this:

as a generous gift (NIV)

as a willing gift (ESV)

This donation would bless and encourage the poor believers in Jerusalem, as in 9:5b. Other ways to translate this are:

so that the same would be ready as a bountiful gift (NASB1995)

so it would be ready/given as a gift of blessing

9:5d

and not begrudgingly.

- and not as something you feel forced to do. (NET)
- and not because anyone has required/compelled you to give.
- not as one grudgingly given (NIV)

and not begrudgingly: If the believers in Corinth did not get the gift ready before Paul arrived, he would have to help them finish getting it ready. Then people might say that the believers in Corinth did not really want to give it, but that Paul had pushed them into giving it. Paul did not want people to say that. Other ways to translate this are:

and not as something you feel forced to do (NET)

not one given under pressure (NLT96)

and not money that I/someone required of you

2 Corinthians 9:6

Section 9:6–15: Give generously and joyfully

In this section, Paul continued to encourage the believers in Corinth to give generously and joyfully. He began with a proverb about planting few seeds as compared to planting many seeds (9:6). He told them that a person should decide for himself how much to give and that he should give because he wants to and not because someone is forcing him to give (9:7). He told them to give graciously because God would give graciously to them so that they would have all they needed (9:8). He supported what he said in 9:8 with a quote from the Old Testament (9:9). He used a metaphor of a farmer (9:10) to illustrate that God would provide for them. He told them that God would provide for them generously so they could give generously, which would cause those who received the gift to thank God very much (9:11).

Then Paul explained that the gift would help God’s people who were in need and would cause them to thank God (9:12–13), as well as to pray for the people who had given (9:14). Paul finished by thanking God for his gift of Jesus as Savior (9:15).

Other examples for this section heading are:

Blessings to be expected from the collection (NJB)

The Cheerful Giver (ESV)

Paul encouraged them to give joyfully because they wanted to

9:6a

Remember this: Whoever sows sparingly will also reap sparingly,

- ¶ So/And think about this saying: If someone plants few seeds, he will harvest a little fruit/grain.
- ¶ Consider these words: The person who sows sparsely will also reap sparsely,

9:6b

and whoever sows generously will also reap generously.

- And, if someone plants generously/much, he will also harvest generously/much.
- and/but the person who sows in a way that blesses will also reap a blessing.

9:6a-b

Remember this: The Greek phrase can be translated as “And/But/Then this.” The conjunction connects this verse to 9:5 and introduces what Paul said next. The word this introduces the following proverb as his main point for the readers to think about here. The Greek phrase tells the reader to think about the meaning of what follows and how it applies to 9:5. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

The point is this (RSV)

Consider these words

So/And think about this saying

Note this principle/proverb

Whoever sows sparingly will also reap sparingly, and whoever sows generously will also reap generously: This proverb or saying indicates that if a person plants only a few plants, then he should only expect only a small harvest. Likewise, if he plants a lot, he can expect a lot. With this saying Paul encouraged the believers to give generously to the poor believers in Jerusalem so that God would bless them much.

In some languages this saying does not clearly connect to 9:5. If that is true in your language, you may want to explain in a footnote. An example footnote is:

Paul used this saying to encourage the believers to give generously.

sparingly: The Greek word that the BSB translates as sparingly refers to doing only a little of something. It is the opposite of “generous.” Here it indicates that a person only plants a few seeds when he could have planted much more. As a result, he will only see a small harvest. Other ways to translate this word are:

few seeds...small crop (GNT)

sparsely (NJB)

whoever sows generously will also reap generously: The Greek words are literally “the one sowing upon blessings will also reap upon blessings.” The Greek word translated blessings has a figurative meaning of “generous,” and that is the meaning here. Paul probably used the word “blessings” here to help connect this saying to the word “blessing” in 9:5c, where the BSB translates it as “bountiful gift” (see note there). Other ways to translate this clause are:

whoever sows in a way that blesses will also reap a blessing

whoever sows in the manner of generosity will also reap generously

If possible, use the same word you used in 9:5c for “bountiful” to show the connection to that verse. However, in some languages it will be necessary to use a different word here for the proper meaning. Other ways to translate this clause are:

he who sows bountifully will also reap bountifully (RSV)

the person who sows plentifully/abundantly will also reap plentifully/abundantly

2 Corinthians 9:7

Section 9:6–15: Give generously and joyfully

In this section, Paul continued to encourage the believers in Corinth to give generously and joyfully. He began with a proverb about planting few seeds as compared to planting many seeds (9:6). He told them that a person should decide for himself how much to give and that he should give because he wants to and not because someone is forcing him to give (9:7). He told them to give graciously because God would give graciously to them so that they would have all they needed (9:8). He supported what he said in 9:8 with a quote from the Old Testament (9:9). He used a metaphor of a farmer (9:10) to illustrate that God would provide for them. He told them that God would provide for them generously so they could give generously, which would cause those who received the gift to thank God very much (9:11).

Then Paul explained that the gift would help God's people who were in need and would cause them to thank God (9:12-13), as well as to pray for the people who had given (9:14). Paul finished by thanking God for his gift of Jesus as Savior (9:15).

Other examples for this section heading are:

Blessings to be expected from the collection (NJB)

The Cheerful Giver (ESV)

Paul encouraged them to give joyfully because they wanted to

9:7a

Each one should give what he has decided in his heart to give,

- Each person should decide for himself how much to give, and then give that amount.
- Each of you must make up your own mind about how much to give. (CEV)

Each one should give what he has decided in his heart to give: The Greek words are literally "each person as he has decided in his heart." In some languages, as in English, for naturalness a verb such as should give (as in the BSB) or "must do" (as in the RSV) may be added. For example:

Each one should give as much as he has decided on his own initiative (NJB)

Each one: This phrase applies to all believers, but Paul said this for the believers in Corinth to follow. In some languages it is more natural to include those he spoke to. For example:

Each of you

But the phrase you use should also apply to all believers.

one: Here the word one refers to both men and women. For example:

person (REB)

in his heart: Here this phrase refers to making a decision privately. The person should not be influenced by others when he decides. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

on his own initiative (NJB)

for himself (REB)

Each of you must make up your own mind (CEV)

9:7b

not out of regret or compulsion.

- He should not give regretting it or because someone forced him to give,
- When you give, you should not feel sorry/sad that you have to give, and you should not give because someone is pushing you to give.

out of regret: The Greek word that the BSB translates as out of regret refers to a person not wanting to do something or wishing he had not done something. A person may give but wish he did not have to give. Other ways to translate this word are:

feel sorry that you must give (CEV)

grudgingly (NASB)

with regret (GNT)

compulsion: This phrase refers to someone forcing somebody to do something. Some believers might think that Paul was pushing them to give. Paul was not pushing them, but he wanted them to do as they had promised. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

feel forced to give (GW)

feeling pushed/pressured to give

9:7c

For God loves a cheerful giver.

- because it is the cheerful giver whom/that God loves.
- For God loves the person who gives gladly/with-joy.

God loves a cheerful giver: In the Greek the phrase a cheerful giver is emphasized. Consider how to emphasize this phrase in your language. In English, one example is:

It is the cheerful giver whom/that God loves

a cheerful giver: This phrase refers to a person who is happy to give. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

the one who gives gladly (GNT)

the person who gives happily (NCV)

2 Corinthians 9:8

Section 9:6–15: Give generously and joyfully

In this section, Paul continued to encourage the believers in Corinth to give generously and joyfully. He began with a proverb about planting few seeds as compared to planting many seeds (9:6). He told them that a person should decide for himself how much to give and that he should give because he wants to and not because someone is forcing him to give (9:7). He told them to give graciously because God would give graciously to them so that they would have all they needed (9:8). He supported what he said in 9:8 with a quote from the Old Testament (9:9). He used a metaphor of a farmer (9:10) to illustrate that God would provide for them. He told them that God would provide for them generously so they could give generously, which would cause those who received the gift to thank God very much (9:11).

Then Paul explained that the gift would help God's people who were in need and would cause them to thank God (9:12–13), as well as to pray for the people who had given (9:14). Paul finished by thanking God for his gift of Jesus as Savior (9:15).

Other examples for this section heading are:

Blessings to be expected from the collection (NJB)

The Cheerful Giver (ESV)

Paul encouraged them to give joyfully because they wanted to

9:8a

And God is able to make all grace abound to you,

- God is able to abundantly provide you^(plur) with every grace/goodness,
- And it is in God's power to provide you with all good gifts in abundance, (REB)
- And God can give you more good things than you need.

And: This Greek conjunction probably indicates that Paul continued talking about the same topic. In some languages it is more natural to omit the conjunction. For example:

God is perfectly able to... (NJB)

It is also possible that the Greek conjunction emphasizes 9:8. For example:

Besides (GW)

Indeed

God is able to make all grace abound to you: This clause indicates that God has the power to provide abundantly all that anyone needs. It is implied that he does indeed provide that much. This would include things such as faith, love, and knowledge. Other ways to translate this are:

God is able to provide you with every blessing in abundance (RSV)

God is able to make all grace overflow to you (NET)

it is in God's power to provide you with all good gifts in abundance (REB)

God can give you more blessings than you need (NCV)

9:8b

so that in all things, at all times, having all that you need,

- so that you may always have enough of everything (RSV)
- in order that you will always have all that you need,
- Then you will always have everything you need (NLT)

in all things, at all times, having all that you need:

This clause refers to having enough for their own needs. For example:

you will always have all you need for yourselves (GNT)

9:8c

you will abound in every good work.

- and may provide in abundance for every good work. (RSV)
- and you will be able to generously help others in many ways.
- and plenty left over to share with others. (NLT)

you will abound in every good work: This clause indicates that the believers will have plenty to help other's needs. For example:

more than enough for every good cause (GNT)

2 Corinthians 9:9

Section 9:6–15: Give generously and joyfully

In this section, Paul continued to encourage the believers in Corinth to give generously and joyfully. He began with a proverb about planting few seeds as compared to planting many seeds (9:6). He told them that a person should decide for himself how much to give and that he should give because he wants to and not because someone is forcing him to give (9:7). He told them to give graciously because God would give graciously to them so that they would have all they needed (9:8). He supported what he said in 9:8 with a quote from the Old Testament (9:9). He used a metaphor of a farmer (9:10) to illustrate that God would provide for them. He told them that God would provide for them generously so they could give generously, which would cause those who received the gift to thank God very much (9:11).

Then Paul explained that the gift would help God's people who were in need and would cause them to thank God (9:12–13), as well as to pray for the people who had given (9:14). Paul finished by thanking God for his gift of Jesus as Savior (9:15).

Other examples for this section heading are:

Blessings to be expected from the collection (NJB)

The Cheerful Giver (ESV)

Paul encouraged them to give joyfully because they wanted to

9:9a

As it is written:

- As it is written in Scripture,
- That agrees with what someone wrote in God's holy book about a generous giver,

As it is written: These words introduce a quote from the Old Testament. Paul used this quote to support what he said about giving generously. For example:

As the scripture says (GNT)

This clause is passive. In some languages an active clause must be used. For example:

As someone wrote in God's holy book

See how you translated this phrase in 8:15.

9:9b–c

He has scattered abroad His gifts to the poor; His righteousness endures forever: These words are a quote from Psalm 112:9. If you footnote the location of quotes from the Old Testament, you may want to do so here.

9:9b

“He has scattered abroad His gifts to the poor;

- “He scatters his gifts as he gave to those who are poor.
- “He scatters his gifts to poor people in many places.

He has scattered abroad His gifts to the poor: The Greek words are literally “he scattered, he gave to the poor.” There are two ways to interpret these words:

1. The clause “he gave” explains “he scattered.” For example:

He gives generously to the needy (GNT) (BSB, NIV, GNT, NJB, GW, CEV, REB, NCV)

1. This clause “he gave to the poor” is a separate thought from “he scattered.” For example:

He scattered abroad, he gave to the poor (NASB) (RSV, NASB, NABRE, NLT, ESV, NET, KJV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Harris (pp. 639–640), Kistemaker (p. 314), Furnish (p. 442), and Martin (p. 291) support interpretation (1).

He has scattered abroad: This phrase indicates that the person helps the needy over a large area, not just those who are nearby. It uses the metaphor of a farmer scattering seed, which was the normal way to plant at that time. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

He has distributed freely (ESV)

He scattered his gifts far and near

The Greek uses the past tense. But this refers generally to what this person does, rather than just one event of giving. In some languages it may be natural to use the present tense. For example:

He scatters abroad (RSV)

He: In the Greek here and the Old Testament verse, the subject of the verb scattered is a person who follows God well. Paul used this verse to support giving generously (9:8c).

In some languages translating the pronoun He literally would refer to God. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Explain in your translation. For example:

^{9a}As it is written about such people: ^{9b}“He...

- Explain in a footnote. An example footnote is:

This verse refers to someone who gives generously.

9:9c

His righteousness endures forever.”

- His righteousness continues forever.” (GW)
- The things he does are right and will continue forever.” (NCV)

His righteousness endures forever: This clause indicates that the results of good deeds such as giving last forever. God does not forget those deeds and rewards those who give. Other ways to translate this clause are:

his kindness lasts forever (GNT)

his uprightness stands firm for ever (NJB)

2 Corinthians 9:10

Section 9:6–15: Give generously and joyfully

In this section, Paul continued to encourage the believers in Corinth to give generously and joyfully. He began with a proverb about planting few seeds as compared to planting many seeds (9:6). He told them that a person should decide for himself how much to give and that he should give because he wants to and not because someone is forcing him to give (9:7). He told them to give graciously because God would give graciously to them so that they would have all they needed (9:8). He supported what he said in 9:8 with a quote from the Old Testament (9:9). He used a metaphor of a farmer (9:10) to illustrate that God would provide for them. He told them that God would provide for them generously so they could give gener-

ously, which would cause those who received the gift to thank God very much (9:11).

Then Paul explained that the gift would help God's people who were in need and would cause them to thank God (9:12–13), as well as to pray for the people who had given (9:14). Paul finished by thanking God for his gift of Jesus as Savior (9:15).

Other examples for this section heading are:

Blessings to be expected from the collection (NJB)

The Cheerful Giver (ESV)

Paul encouraged them to give joyfully because they wanted to

9:10a

Now He who supplies seed to the sower and bread for food

- Furthermore, he who provides seed to the farmer/planter and bread to eat
- God gives seed to people for planting/scattering in his field. He also gives food for people to eat.

Now: Here the word Now introduces a new topic that is related to the old topic. Paul has been talking about believers giving generously. Here Paul began talking about God doing that. Another way to translate this conjunction is:

Furthermore,

In some languages it is more natural to allow the context to indicate the connection and omit the conjunction.

He: In this verse, the Greek word that the BSB translates as He refers to God. But “He” in 9:9 refers to someone else. In some languages the pronoun He here would not refer to God. If that is true in your language, you may want to indicate the proper meaning in your translation. For example:

God (CEV)

seed to the sower and bread for food: These two phrases refer figuratively to all the needs of believers. The phrase seed to the sower probably refers to earthly wealth. Like the person who scatters in 9:9b, the sower scatters seed, which refers figuratively to

sharing wealth with the needy. The phrase bread for food probably refers to daily needs.

In some languages this saying would refer only to actual seed and bread. If that is true in your language, you may want to explain in a footnote. For example:

The seed and bread in this verse refer figuratively to all the needs of believers. God provides for all the needs of believers and even more so that they can give to others.

sower: This word refers to the person who sows/plants seeds. At that time in that area, the usual way to do that was to scatter seed by throwing it over a cleared area.

The fact that the sower scatters seed is somewhat important because it connects to the saying in 9:9b. If the usual word for a person who plants seeds does not imply scattering the seed, you may want to:

- Translate the meaning “a person who sows/plants seeds” and explain its meaning in a footnote. An example footnote is:

At that time in that area, the usual way to plant seeds was to scatter seed by throwing it over a cleared area. This connects to the saying of scattering in 9:9b.

- Explain its meaning in your translation. For example:

seed scattering farmer But the added implied information should not restrict God only to giving seed to this kind of farmer and not giving seed to other kinds of farmers. If your translation limits God in this way, you may want to use the footnote above instead.

bread for food: The word bread refers generally to food. Bread was the daily food of the people at that time and place. It is also connected to the word “seed,” since wheat seed is used to make bread.

You may want to use the general word for food or use a kind of food that is eaten daily and can refer figuratively to all kinds of food. But it would be good if it grows from a planted seed. For example:

food to eat

rice/corn/millet for food

If you use a word such as rice/corn/sago/millet, you may want to explain the literal word in a footnote. For example:

Literally: “bread.” Bread was the daily food of the people at that time and place.

9:10b

will supply and multiply your store of seed

- will also provide and expand your^(plur) supply of seed
- So like that, God will give to you seed and increase its amount

will...multiply your store of seed: The Greek words are literally “will increase your seed.” Here the phrase refers to having more than what is needed for the time of sowing. The extra seed can also be shared with others in need. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

increase your resources (NLT)

increase what you have (CEV)

multiply your supply of seed (NET)

your store of seed: This phrase continues the figurative use of seed to refer to earthly wealth.

9:10c

and will increase the harvest of your righteousness.

- and will also increase the fruit from your righteous deeds.
- and also increase the good things that come from the upright things that you do.

the harvest of your righteousness: Here the word harvest refers figuratively to the results of righteous deeds. Helping the poor is one kind of righteous deed. Helping the poor provides for their needs, they praise God, and God also increases the results with added blessings on earth and rewards in heaven. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

the fruits of your righteousness (KJV)

the good results that come from our righteous deeds to others

2 Corinthians 9:11

Section 9:6–15: Give generously and joyfully

In this section, Paul continued to encourage the believers in Corinth to give generously and joyfully. He began with a proverb about planting few seeds as compared to planting many seeds (9:6). He told them that a person should decide for himself how much to give and that he should give because he wants to and not because someone is forcing him to give (9:7). He told them to give graciously because God would give graciously to them so that they would have all they needed (9:8). He supported what he said in 9:8 with a quote from the Old Testament (9:9). He used a metaphor of a farmer (9:10) to illustrate that God would provide for them. He told them that God would provide for them generously so they could give generously, which would cause those who received the gift to thank God very much (9:11).

Then Paul explained that the gift would help God's people who were in need and would cause them to thank God (9:12–13), as well as to pray for the people who had given (9:14). Paul finished by thanking God for his gift of Jesus as Savior (9:15).

Other examples for this section heading are:

Blessings to be expected from the collection (NJB)

The Cheerful Giver (ESV)

Paul encouraged them to give joyfully because they wanted to

9:11a

You will be enriched in every way

- You will be blessed in every way, (CEV)
- God will give to you^(plur) an abundance in all ways,

You will be enriched in every way: This clause is passive. God makes believers rich in spiritual blessings. Some languages must use an active clause. For example:

God will enrich you in every way

be enriched: Here this verb phrase refers to blessings on earth and rewards in heaven. The verb phrase does not refer only to increasing the amount of things and money someone has.

In some languages the phrase be enriched would refer only to earthly wealth. If that is true in your language, you may want to use a more general verb. For example:

God will cause you to have abundance in every way

9:11b

to be generous on every occasion,

- for every kind of generosity, (NJB)
- and so you will always be able to give generously/freely.

to be generous on every occasion: The Greek words are literally “to all generosity.” God makes believers rich so that they can generously give to others. Other ways to translate this are:

for every kind of generosity (NJB)

to be generous at all times (GNT)

9:11c

so that through us your giving will produce thanksgiving to God.

- which we^(excl) administer in this case. That generosity causes people to thank God.
- And when we take your generous gift to those in need, they will thank God.

through us: The phrase refers to Paul and others helping to collect the gift of money and take it to the poor believers in Jerusalem. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

Through our action (REB)

administered through us (JBP)

when we take your gifts to those who need them (NLT)

your giving will produce thanksgiving to God: This phrase indicates that the poor believers will thank God when they receive the gift. Here is another way to translate this:

makes people thank God (NJB)

2 Corinthians 9:12

Section 9:6–15: Give generously and joyfully

In this section, Paul continued to encourage the believers in Corinth to give generously and joyfully. He began with a proverb about planting few seeds as compared to planting many seeds (9:6). He told them that a person should decide for himself how much to give and that he should give because he wants to and not because someone is forcing him to give (9:7). He told them to give graciously because God would give graciously to them so that they would have all they needed (9:8). He supported what he said in 9:8 with a quote from the Old Testament (9:9). He used a metaphor of a farmer (9:10) to illustrate that God would provide for them. He told them that God would provide for them generously so they could give generously, which would cause those who received the gift to thank God very much (9:11).

Then Paul explained that the gift would help God's people who were in need and would cause them to thank God (9:12–13), as well as to pray for the people who had given (9:14). Paul finished by thanking God for his gift of Jesus as Savior (9:15).

Other examples for this section heading are:

Blessings to be expected from the collection (NJB)

The Cheerful Giver (ESV)

Paul encouraged them to give joyfully because they wanted to

9:12a

For this ministry of service is not only supplying the needs of the saints,

- ¶ For this ministry that you do not only provides for the needs of God's holy people,
- ¶ For when you^(plur) help in that way, God's people who are poor receive help that provides for their needs,

For: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as *For* probably introduces a further explanation about giving (9:1–11). For example:

because (NET)

In some languages it is more natural to allow the context to indicate the connection and omit the conjunction.

ministry of service: This phrase refers to the work of serving, helping, or caring for others. Here the phrase refers to the believers in Corinth collecting the money and sending it to the poor believers in Jerusalem. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

the administration of this service (KJV)

this ministry of giving (NLT)

the help provided by this contribution (NJB)

the saints: The Greek word is literally “holy ones.” The BSB usually translates this word as saints. Here the word refers to all the poor believers in Jerusalem. The word does not refer to a small group of believers who were extremely godly. See how you translated this Greek word in 1:1 or 9:1.

9:12b

but is also overflowing in many expressions of thanksgiving to God.

- but also produces more and more prayers of thanksgiving to God. (GW)
- and in addition, the number of people thanking God will increase very much.

is also overflowing in many expressions of thanksgiving to God: The Greek word that the BSB translates as overflowing is literally “be abundant.” This clause indicates that many people thank God very much.

Other ways to translate this clause are:

produces more and more prayers of thanksgiving to God (GW)

abound in people thanking God

abundantly produces much/many thanksgivings to God

the number of those who thank God will also increase greatly

2 Corinthians 9:13

Section 9:6–15: Give generously and joyfully

In this section, Paul continued to encourage the believers in Corinth to give generously and joyfully. He began with a proverb about planting few seeds as compared to planting many seeds (9:6). He told them that a person should decide for himself how much

to give and that he should give because he wants to and not because someone is forcing him to give (9:7). He told them to give graciously because God would give graciously to them so that they would have all they needed (9:8). He supported what he said in 9:8 with a quote from the Old Testament (9:9). He used a metaphor of a farmer (9:10) to illustrate that God would provide for them. He told them that God would provide for them generously so they could give generously, which would cause those who received the gift to thank God very much (9:11).

Then Paul explained that the gift would help God's people who were in need and would cause them to thank God (9:12-13), as well as to pray for the people who had given (9:14). Paul finished by thanking God for his gift of Jesus as Savior (9:15).

Other examples for this section heading are:

Blessings to be expected from the collection (NJB)

The Cheerful Giver (ESV)

Paul encouraged them to give joyfully because they wanted to

9:13a

Because of the proof this ministry provides,

- Because of the proof given by this ministry, (NASB)
- Doing this ministry of giving shows that you^(plur) kept your promise,

Because of the proof this ministry provides: The Greek words are literally "because/through the proof of this ministry." Doing this service was a way that showed their faith to be true. Other ways to translate this are:

because when you have proved your quality by this help (NJB)

The way in which you have proved yourselves by this service (CEV)

Because of: This phrase indicates that providing the gift (9:13a) was the reason or basis for people praising God (9:13b). Other ways to translate this phrase are:

As a result of your ministry, ^{13b}they will give glory to God (NLT)

Through the evidence of this service ^{13b}they will glorify God (NET)

the proof: The Greek word that the BSB translates as the proof refers to evidence of the truthfulness of something as a result of testing it. God tested the believers by seeing if they would collect the money as they had promised they would. The evidence that they were true to their promise would be the fact that they completed collecting the money. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

the evidence (NET)

the proof which this service of yours brings (GNT)

the test of this service

the test of this ministry of giving as a proof of your obedience to Christ

9:13b

the saints will glorify God

- they will praise God
- so God's people will praise God
- so those to whom your gift is given will praise God

the saints will glorify God: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the saints will glorify God is literally "they (are) praising God." There are three ways to interpret this clause:

1. Those who receive the gift, that is, "the saints" mentioned in 9:12a, will praise God. For example:

they will glorify God (NET) (BSB, NJB, NASB, NLT, NET, ESV, REB, KJV)

1. Any believer who hears of this gift will praise God. For example:

Many people will praise God (NCV) (NIV, GNT, CEV, NCV)

1. The believers in Corinth will praise God. For example:

you will glorify God (RSV) (RSV, NABRE, GW)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because this phrase probably connects to the word

saints in 9:12a. Martin (p. 287) translates this text as “they give praise to God,” where the word “they” would refer to the believers in Jerusalem. Thrall (p. 563) translates it similarly: “they will be glorifying God.”

Here is another way to translate this clause following interpretation (1):

those who receive it will give honour to God (REB)

the saints: Here the word saints is general and refers to both men and women. Here is another way to translate this:

people (NCV)

9:13c

for your obedient confession of the gospel of Christ,

- because you confessed that the gospel of Christ is true and now obey/follow your own words,
- about/for the fact that you are obeying your own words about the gospel of Christ when you acknowledged that you believed it.

for: Here the word for indicates that 9:13c–d are the things that people praise God about or the basis for praising God.

your obedient confession of the gospel: The Greek words are literally “the obedience of your confession to the gospel.” There are a number of ways to interpret the relationship of the words obedient, confession, and gospel. The four most likely interpretations are:

1. People obey their confession. Believers agree that the gospel is true and have publicly said so. They live in obedience to what they said about the gospel. For example:

your obedience to your confession of the gospel of Christ (NASB) (RSV, NABRE, NASB, NET)

1. People obey in connection to confessing the gospel. For example:

the obedience that accompanies your confession of the gospel (NIV) (BSB, NIV)

1. People obey the command to preach the gospel. For example:

the obedience which you show in professing the gospel (NJB) (NJB)

1. People obey the gospel. For example:

your loyalty to the gospel of Christ, which you profess (GNT) (GNT, CEV, NCV, KJV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because the word “obedience” is most closely connected to the word confession in the Greek. Kistemaker (p. 320), Hodge (p. 226), and Hughes (on TW) follow interpretation (1). Other ways to translate this following interpretation (1) are:

your obedience to your confession in the gospel (NET)

you obey/follow your own words when you said that the gospel was true and that you would obey it

confession: Here the word confession refers to saying publicly that they believe the gospel about Jesus. Other ways to translate this word are:

acknowledging (RSV)

professing (NJB)

publicly say is true

Christ: The word Christ is a title for Jesus. The word Christ literally means “the anointed one.” Translate the word Christ here as you did in 1:1.

9:13d

and for the generosity of your contribution to them and to all the others.

- and because you will generously share with them and for all in need.
- They will also praise God about/for the fact that you will abundantly give money in your sharing with them and with all others.

and for: Here the phrase and for indicates that 9:13d is the second thing that people praise God about or a second basis for praising God. The first one is 9:13c.

contribution: This word refers to giving some of what they had to others. The Greek word also implies a relationship included with that contribution. For example:

fellowship (NJB)

them: Here the pronoun them refers to the poor believers (“saints” in 9:12a).

and to all the others: These words probably refer to the willingness of the believers in Corinth to help any believer in need. The words do not indicate that the believers in Corinth had already shared with every other believer. Other ways to translate this are:

and towards all (NJB)

to the general good (REB)

2 Corinthians 9:14

Section 9:6–15: Give generously and joyfully

In this section, Paul continued to encourage the believers in Corinth to give generously and joyfully. He began with a proverb about planting few seeds as compared to planting many seeds (9:6). He told them that a person should decide for himself how much to give and that he should give because he wants to and not because someone is forcing him to give (9:7). He told them to give graciously because God would give graciously to them so that they would have all they needed (9:8). He supported what he said in 9:8 with a quote from the Old Testament (9:9). He used a metaphor of a farmer (9:10) to illustrate that God would provide for them. He told them that God would provide for them generously so they could give generously, which would cause those who received the gift to thank God very much (9:11).

Then Paul explained that the gift would help God’s people who were in need and would cause them to thank God (9:12–13), as well as to pray for the people who had given (9:14). Paul finished by thanking God for his gift of Jesus as Savior (9:15).

Other examples for this section heading are:

Blessings to be expected from the collection (NJB)

The Cheerful Giver (ESV)

Paul encouraged them to give joyfully because they wanted to

9:14a

And their prayers for you will express their affection for you,

- And when they pray for you^(plur), they will show they truly care for you,
- At the same time, their prayer for you will express the affection they feel for you (NJB)

And their prayers for you will express their affection for you: The Greek words are literally “their prayers for you having great affection/yearning for you.” There are several ways to interpret the Greek words:

1. They have affection for the believers in Corinth and their prayers are the way that they express their affection. For example:

their prayer for you will express the affection they feel for you (NJB) (BSB, NIV, NJB, NASB, NABRE, NET, REB, NCV)

1. They will pray with affection for them. For example:

with deep affection they will pray for you (GNT) (GNT, NLT, GW)

1. They pray for them and they have affection for them. For example:

they long for you and pray for you (RSV) (RSV, ESV, CEV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Harris (p. 657) calls “as they pray” attendant circumstances. Martin (p. 294) translates the text as “in their prayers for you they yearn for you.” Thrall (p. 563) translates the text as “in their prayer for you they will be longing for you.” Other ways to translate this following interpretation (1) are:

in their prayers on your behalf they long for you (NET)

they truly care for you as they pray for you

when they pray, they will wish the best for you

will express their affection for you: The Greek clause is literally “having great affection/yearning for you.” It refers to the believers in Jerusalem liking the believers in Corinth, caring for them, and wanting the best for them. See the examples above.

9:14b

because of the surpassing grace God has given you.

- because of the surpassing grace of God in you. (RSV)
- because God blessed you with great/extraordinary kindness.

because of the surpassing grace God has given you:

The Greek words are literally “because of the surpassing grace of God upon you” (as in the ESV). The word grace is like a gift. God’s gift was that he caused the believers in Corinth to be able to give generously. He did this without requiring the believers to do something for him as payment. Other ways to translate this are:

because of the surpassing grace of God in you (RSV)

because God put an amazing amount of grace upon you

because God blessed you greatly to bless others

See how you translated the word grace in 1:12.

surpassing: This word refers to going beyond an ordinary amount. Other ways to translate this word are:

exceeding (KJV)

extraordinary (GNT)

unbounded (NJB)

2 Corinthians 9:15

Section 9:6–15: Give generously and joyfully

In this section, Paul continued to encourage the believers in Corinth to give generously and joyfully. He began with a proverb about planting few seeds as compared to planting many seeds (9:6). He told them that a person should decide for himself how much to give and that he should give because he wants to and not because someone is forcing him to give (9:7). He told them to give graciously because God would give graciously to them so that they would have all they needed (9:8). He supported what he said in 9:8 with a quote from the Old Testament (9:9). He used a metaphor of a farmer (9:10) to illustrate that God would provide for them. He told them that God would provide for them generously so they could give generously, which would cause those who received the gift to thank God very much (9:11).

Then Paul explained that the gift would help God’s people who were in need and would cause them to thank God (9:12–13), as well as to pray for the people who had given (9:14). Paul finished by thanking God for his gift of Jesus as Savior (9:15).

Other examples for this section heading are:

Blessings to be expected from the collection (NJB)

The Cheerful Giver (ESV)

Paul encouraged them to give joyfully because they wanted to

9:15

Thanks be to God for His indescribable gift!

- Let us^(incl) thank God for his gift that no one can fully describe!
- We should thank God because he gave us the gift that is so great that it is beyond anyone’s ability to tell about it adequately/fully!

Thanks be to God: This clause encourages the readers also to thank God. For example:

Let us thank God (GNT)

This is the same expression that Paul used in 8:16. See how you translated it there.

His indescribable gift: Here, the gift is probably Jesus and what he did for people. This would include salvation and righteousness. In some languages, a literal translation would wrongly indicate or imply a different meaning. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Explain the meaning in your translation. For example:

his Son—a gift too wonderful for words (NLT96)

his indescribable gift of his Son

- Explain the meaning in a footnote. An example footnote is:

Here, the gift is probably Jesus as Savior.

indescribable: This word indicates that the gift is so wonderful or great that no one can completely describe it. Other ways to translate this word are:

that is beyond all telling (NJB)

that words cannot describe (GW)

that is too wonderful for words (CEV)

In this division, Paul returned to talking about his work as an apostle. However, in these chapters he spoke in a somewhat more urgent or severe way. He told them that he had the authority of an apostle of Jesus and explained how that was true. He spoke about the false teachers who were trying to introduce Jewish practices into the practices of Christians. He explained how to evaluate their claims of authority and their teachings. And he warned them that he was ready to discipline anyone who was sinning.

2 Corinthians 10:1

Section 10:1–18: Paul defended his ministry

In this section, Paul asked the believers in Corinth to live in obedience to their faith, or he might have to rebuke or discipline some (10:1–2). He explained how a believer fights against those who oppose God (10:3–4) and how to rebuke them as well as correct a disobedient believer (10:5–6).

He told them to understand their situation, including Paul's authority (10:7–8). He explained that he was forceful in his letters, and that he would be forceful in person if he had to be (10:9–11).

He told them that people who commend themselves are not wise (10:12). He explained that he boasted only in proper ways. One of those ways was boasting about the faith of people whom he had helped become believers, which included those in Corinth (10:13–15a). He told them that he hoped to preach the gospel in more regions (10:15b–16a). He explained further about proper things to boast about (10:16b–17). Lastly, he told them that God approves of people according to what God himself says in favor of them and not what a person boasts about himself (10:18).

Other examples of headings for this section are:

Paul's reply to accusations of weakness (NJB)

Paul Describes Himself (NASB)

Paul responded to some who had criticized him

10:1a

Now by the mildness and gentleness of Christ, I appeal to you—I, Paul,

- ¶ Now I, Paul, urgently/strongly ask you^(plur) something in the manner of the humbleness and forbearance of Christ.
- ¶ I myself, Paul, urge you here. I speak as Christ would, meekly and gently.

Now by the mildness and gentleness of Christ, I appeal to you—I, Paul: The Greek words are literally “Now I myself Paul appeal to you by the meekness and gentleness of Christ.” Paul emphasized referring to himself here. For example:

I, Paul, myself entreat you, by the meekness and gentleness of Christ (RSV)

Now by the mildness and gentleness of Christ: Both mildness and gentleness are of Christ. Jesus showed both mildness and gentleness when he lived on earth. Paul lived according to the example that Jesus showed.

mildness: This word refers to a person being considerate of others, not putting himself first and not wanting to argue. Another example is:

humble (CEV)

gentleness: The Greek word that the BSB translates as gentleness refers to a person being patient when others do not do as he wishes. Such a person shows mercy to them and does not retaliate. Another example is:

forbearance (NJB)

Christ: The word Christ is a title for Jesus. The word Christ literally means “the anointed one.” Translate the word Christ here as you did in 1:1.

appeal: This word refers to asking people to do as you say they should do. It does not mean “command.” Other ways to translate this word are:

entreat (RSV)

urge (NJB)

Paul did not say here what he was asking the Corinthians to do. But in 10:2 he implied that they should live according to their faith so he would not have to be bold and discipline those who sinned. He also said in 10:6 that he would punish every act of disobedience once their obedience was complete. So he was urging them to obey what he had said that they should do.

10:1b

who am humble when face to face with you, but bold when away.

- Some call me cowardly when I am face to face with you but bold when I am away.
- Certain people claim I am timid before you and outspoken when I am away from you and write to you.

who am humble when face to face with you, but bold when away: The word who indicates that Paul described himself in 10:1b. In some languages using the word “who” may indicate a different meaning or person. If that is true in your language, translate the correct meaning. For example:

I am timid when face to face with you, but bold when away.

am humble when face to face with you, but bold when away: Opponents of Paul accused him of being humble when face to face but bold when writing his letters to the believers in Corinth, as in 10:10. There are two ways to interpret these words:

1. Translate in a way that indicates that Paul spoke of that accusation here. One way to do this is to put the words humble and bold in quote marks. For example:

who am “timid” when face to face with you, but “bold” toward you when away (NIV)

Another way to do this is to translate the words in such a way as to show that someone else had spoken those words and that Paul did not agree with the accusation. For example:

am said to be meek and mild when I am with you, but harsh with you when I am away (GNT) (RSV, NIV, GNT, NASB, NLT, CEV, NET, REB, ESV, NCV) The RSV, NASB, ESV, and NET use an exclamation point at the end of this text. That probably indicates that this statement is ironic. That would imply that this text is an accusation of Paul’s enemies in Corinth.

1. Translate in a way that implies that Paul referred to himself as having these attitudes. For example:

is so humble when he is facing you but full of boldness at a distance (NJB) (BSB, NJB, NABRE, GW, KJV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because Paul explained that accusation in 10:10. Harris (p. 664) translates the text as “who face to face with you am ‘timid’ but when absent am ‘bold’.” Martin (p. 297) translates the text as “who am ‘timid’ when face to face with you, but when I am away, I am ‘haughty’ over you.” Thrall (p. 603) says, “Paul reproduces their criticism.” Other ways to translate this following interpretation (1) are:

whom some call timid when I am face to face with you but bold when away

even though some of you say I am bold in my letters but timid in person (NLT96)

Some people say that I am easy on you when I am with you and bold when I am away (NCV)

humble: Following interpretation (1) in the previous note in 10:1b, this word would have the meaning of “timid” (as in the NIV). This would refer to lacking confidence or being afraid to speak an opinion that is different from others. It might also refer to thinking of everyone else as being of a higher status. Following interpretation (2) in the previous note in 10:1b, this word would have the meaning of “humble” (as in the BSB). That would be a positive quality. For example:

a coward (CEV)

bold: Following interpretation (1) in the previous note in 10:1b, this word would have a negative meaning, such as “outspoken” (as in JBP). It would refer to speaking an opinion without proper concern for the feelings and opinions of others. Following interpretation (2) in the first note in 10:1b, this word would have a positive meaning, such as “brave” (CEV) or “courageous” (REB).

2 Corinthians 10:2

Section 10:1–18: Paul defended his ministry

In this section, Paul asked the believers in Corinth to live in obedience to their faith, or he might have to

rebuke or discipline some (10:1-2). He explained how a believer fights against those who oppose God (10:3-4) and how to rebuke them as well as correct a disobedient believer (10:5-6).

He told them to understand their situation, including Paul's authority (10:7-8). He explained that he was forceful in his letters, and that he would be forceful in person if he had to be (10:9-11).

He told them that people who commend themselves are not wise (10:12). He explained that he boasted only in proper ways. One of those ways was boasting about the faith of people whom he had helped become believers, which included those in Corinth (10:13-15a). He told them that he hoped to preach the gospel in more regions (10:15b-16a). He explained further about proper things to boast about (10:16b-17). Lastly, he told them that God approves of people according to what God himself says in favor of them and not what a person boasts about himself (10:18).

Other examples of headings for this section are:

Paul's reply to accusations of weakness (NJB)

Paul Describes Himself (NASB)

Paul responded to some who had criticized him

10:2a-d

I beg you that when I come I may not need to be as bold as I expect toward those who presume that we live according to the flesh: These words indicate that:

1. The people whom Paul calls those who presume had come to Corinth while he was away and falsely claimed that Paul and the other evangelists lived according to the flesh rather than following the gospel of Jesus. These people were trying to make the believers reject Paul as their leader (10:10, 11:5). These people wanted to be leaders over the believers (11:4) and lead them away from the true gospel of Jesus (11:13, 20).
2. Paul knew that these people were liars and false teachers. He expected to confront them boldly and force them by God's power to repent or leave when he went to Corinth.
3. He asked the believers to reject these false teachers and not follow them. If they did follow them, he would have to confront the believers boldly as well.

In some languages it is more natural to translate this verse in the order of the events as they occurred. For example:

^{2c}Some people ^{2d}presume that we live according to the flesh. ^{2c}I expect to be bold toward them to make them repent or leave ^{2a}when I come. I beg you that ^{2b}I do not have to be so bold with you.

10:2a

I beg you that when I come

- I urgently ask that when I am there
- I strongly request from you^(plur) that after/when I arrive

I beg you: The word beg here refers to asking people with a great desire. Paul asked the believers in Corinth to take care of the problems there. That was what he implied when he told them that he did not want to be bold with any of the believers there. Other ways to translate this clause are:

I urgently ask

my appeal to you is (NJB)

you: The BSB and many English versions add the pronoun you here. It is clearly implied from 10:1a. But the meaning may be clear in your language without repeating the implied pronoun here.

when I come: The Greek word that the BSB translates as when I come is literally "being present." The Greek word refers to the time Paul would be staying with the believers in Corinth. This would be after he had sent the letter and then traveled to Corinth. Other ways to translate this Greek word are:

in your presence (JBP)

when I am with you (GW)

after I arrive

10:2b

I may not need to be as bold

- I should not have to be bold with the confidence
- I will not need to be outspoken

I may not need to be as bold: The Greek words are literally: "not to be bold in the confidence." Paul expected to be confident when he was bold. For example:

I may not have to show boldness with such confidence (RSV)

as bold: Here the word bold refers to openly and forcefully opposing someone. If possible, you should use the same word here as in 10:1b.

The context implies that Paul would boldly deal with anyone sinning in connection with the false teachers. In some languages it is more natural to refer to the implied information. For example:

as bold when acting against sinners

as bold when dealing with such problems

10:2c

as I expect toward those

- that I plan to be bold against certain people
- as I certainly will be against those

I expect: The Greek words are literally “I consider to have the courage.” Paul had thought about it and had decided that he would be bold/courageous toward the false teachers. He would boldly oppose them and probably show by God’s power that they were not appointed by God. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

I propose to be courageous (NASB)

by daring to (NRSV)

I expect I will have to be firm and forceful (CEV)

I am sure I can deal harshly (GNT)

those: This word refers to the false teachers who had come to Corinth. Paul did not call them “false teachers” here, but he described them in 10:2d so the believers in Corinth would know exactly to whom he was referring. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

certain people

some people (NIV)

10:2d

who presume that we live according to the flesh.

- who claim that we^(excl) act in a worldly fashion.
- who falsely say that we behave like people who do not follow God.

presume: In this context the word presume refers to believing something. The false teachers claimed that Paul lived by the standards of this world, but they were wrong. Other ways of translating this word are:

consider

claim

according to the flesh: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates literally as according to the flesh probably refers to doing things as people who do not believe in God would do them. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

in worldly fashion (RSV)

guided by human motives (NJB)

according to human standards (NRSV)

in a worldly way (NCV)

in a way people who do not know God do things

2 Corinthians 10:3

Section 10:1–18: Paul defended his ministry

In this section, Paul asked the believers in Corinth to live in obedience to their faith, or he might have to rebuke or discipline some (10:1–2). He explained how a believer fights against those who oppose God (10:3–4) and how to rebuke them as well as correct a disobedient believer (10:5–6).

He told them to understand their situation, including Paul’s authority (10:7–8). He explained that he was forceful in his letters, and that he would be forceful in person if he had to be (10:9–11).

He told them that people who commend themselves are not wise (10:12). He explained that he boasted only in proper ways. One of those ways was boasting about the faith of people whom he had helped become believers, which included those in Corinth (10:13–15a). He told them that he hoped to preach the gospel in more regions (10:15b–16a). He explained further about proper things to boast about (10:16b–17). Lastly, he told them that God approves of people according to what God himself says in favor of them and not what a person boasts about himself (10:18).

Other examples of headings for this section are:

Paul's reply to accusations of weakness (NJB)

Paul Describes Himself (NASB)

Paul responded to some who had criticized him

10:3a-b

though we live in the flesh, we do not wage war according to the flesh: The Greek words are literally, "in flesh living, not according to flesh we war." Paul indicated here that though he had a human body he did not wage war according to human motives, means, or goals.

The phrase wage war is a metaphor here. It refers to opposing others. People of the world oppose other people. Believers are told to oppose Satan and the demons.

In some languages a literal translation of this metaphor would not indicate the correct meaning. In that case you may want to:

- Change the metaphor to a simile. For example:

we do not oppose our enemies in the way that the people of this world wage war against their enemies

we do not oppose the false teachers in the way that worldly people make war against their enemies

- Translate the meaning without the metaphor. For example:

we do not fight/come against people as the people of this world do You may then want a footnote to indicate the literal words. An example footnote is:

Literally: "we do not wage war as the world does." This refers to opposing Satan and his followers, not about taking weapons and killing people.

10:3a

For though we live in the flesh,

- For although we^(excl) walk on earth,
- We live human lives

For: The conjunction introduces an explanation of why Paul could be bold toward those who opposed him. In some languages it is more natural to allow the

context to indicate the connection to 10:2d and omit the conjunction.

though: The word though indicates a connection between admitting one statement and denying another statement. Paul and the others lived on this earth, but they did not wage war according to earthly ways. This is different from what people might expect. Other ways to translate this word are:

although we are human, it is not by human methods that we do battle (NJB)

We are human, but we don't wage war as humans do. (NLT)

we live in the flesh: The Greek words are literally "in the flesh walking (around)." This Greek phrase refers to living on earth as all people do. Other ways to translate this clause are:

we live as human beings (NRSV)

We are human (NLT)

10:3b

we do not wage war according to the flesh.

- we do not war according to earthly ways.
- but we do not fight/oppose our enemies/opponents by human methods/means.

we do not wage war according to the flesh: The phrase wage war according to the flesh refers to how people of the world oppose others. This would include lying, deceiving, slandering, secretly plotting, fighting, and so forth.

In some languages it is necessary to say whom a person wages war against. In that case you may want to include the implied information. For example:

we do not wage war against our opponents as the world does

we do not fight our enemies as people who do not know God do

according to the flesh: Here the word flesh refers to people who do not know God. They use earthly weapons, but believers use weapons such as prayer and God's word. Other ways to translate this clause are:

according to earthly ways

according to human standards (NRSV)

by human methods (NJB)

as humans do (NLT)

2 Corinthians 10:4

Section 10:1–18: Paul defended his ministry

In this section, Paul asked the believers in Corinth to live in obedience to their faith, or he might have to rebuke or discipline some (10:1–2). He explained how a believer fights against those who oppose God (10:3–4) and how to rebuke them as well as correct a disobedient believer (10:5–6).

He told them to understand their situation, including Paul's authority (10:7–8). He explained that he was forceful in his letters, and that he would be forceful in person if he had to be (10:9–11).

He told them that people who commend themselves are not wise (10:12). He explained that he boasted only in proper ways. One of those ways was boasting about the faith of people whom he had helped become believers, which included those in Corinth (10:13–15a). He told them that he hoped to preach the gospel in more regions (10:15b–16a). He explained further about proper things to boast about (10:16b–17). Lastly, he told them that God approves of people according to what God himself says in favor of them and not what a person boasts about himself (10:18).

Other examples of headings for this section are:

Paul's reply to accusations of weakness (NJB)

Paul Describes Himself (NASB)

Paul responded to some who had criticized him

10:4a

The weapons of our warfare are not the weapons of the world.

- For the weapons with which we^(excl) do battle are not human weapons.
- Fighting men use weapons made by people, but we use different weapons.
- The methods/means we use to oppose our enemies/opponents are not the methods/means that ungodly people use.

10:4 begins with a Greek conjunction that introduces an explanation about how Paul and the other evangelists oppose other people. For example:

for (RSV)

In some languages it is more natural to allow the context to indicate the connection and omit the conjunction.

The weapons of our warfare are not the weapons of the world: This clause continues the metaphor about war from 10:3b. The weapons that Paul uses are not the same kind of weapons as the people of the world use. His weapons are from God (10:4b). They would include the gospel, prophecy, doing miracles, and things like that. Another way to translate this is:

We fight with weapons that are different from those the world uses (NCV)

the weapons of the world: This phrase refers to the ways in which the world fights. For example:

human weapons (NET)

10:4b

Instead, they have divine power to demolish strongholds.

- Instead, they have power to destroy fortresses on God's behalf.
- Our weapons have God's power to destroy/ruin spiritual strong places of his enemies.
- Our methods/means have the power of God to tear down the places of strength of our enemies/opponents.

they have divine power: The Greek words are literally "powerful to/for/through God." God gives this power. For example:

God's powerful weapons (GNT)

powerful in God's warfare (JBP)

powerful weapons from God (GW)

they: Here this pronoun refers to "the weapons of our warfare" in 10:4a.

demolish strongholds: Like strongholds in human warfare, the enemies of God have spiritual strong-

holds. But the weapons of believers can demolish them. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

destroy strongholds (RSV)

destroy spiritual strong places of the enemies of God

strongholds: This word refers to places easy to defend against attack. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

fortresses (NASB)

the enemy's strong places (NCV)

However, the word here is used figuratively for “arguments” (10:5a). Any opposition to the gospel of Jesus is a stronghold. In some languages a literal translation of this word would wrongly refer only to places on earth. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

General Comment on 10:4a–b

- Explain its meaning in your translation. For example:

spiritual strongholds

strongholds in people's minds

- Translate literally and explain the meaning in a footnote. An example footnote is:

Here, the word “stronghold” refers to any opposition to the gospel of Jesus.

Paul first explained what the weapons were not and then explained what the weapons were. In some languages it is more natural to explain what the weapons were first. For example:

^{4a}The weapons we fight with ^{4b}have divine power to demolish strongholds. They ^{4a}are not the weapons of the world.

2 Corinthians 10:5

Section 10:1–18: Paul defended his ministry

In this section, Paul asked the believers in Corinth to live in obedience to their faith, or he might have to rebuke or discipline some (10:1–2). He explained how a believer fights against those who oppose God (10:3–4)

and how to rebuke them as well as correct a disobedient believer (10:5–6).

He told them to understand their situation, including Paul's authority (10:7–8). He explained that he was forceful in his letters, and that he would be forceful in person if he had to be (10:9–11).

He told them that people who commend themselves are not wise (10:12). He explained that he boasted only in proper ways. One of those ways was boasting about the faith of people whom he had helped become believers, which included those in Corinth (10:13–15a). He told them that he hoped to preach the gospel in more regions (10:15b–16a). He explained further about proper things to boast about (10:16b–17). Lastly, he told them that God approves of people according to what God himself says in favor of them and not what a person boasts about himself (10:18).

Other examples of headings for this section are:

Paul's reply to accusations of weakness (NJB)

Paul Describes Himself (NASB)

Paul responded to some who had criticized him

10:5a

We tear down arguments

- We^(excl) destroy arguments/ideas
- Namely, we destroy/ruin false reasoning,

We tear down arguments: The Greek has this clause at the end of 10:4. The GNT, NJB, NRSV, and other English versions put this clause there. For example:

We destroy false arguments; ⁵we pull down every proud obstacle (GNT)

You should follow where the common language version puts this clause.

arguments: The word arguments refers to a series of thoughts that connect together and lead to a conclusion. Paul's opponents would use ideas that sounded right and seemed to connect together in order. But their arguments were not based on truth and were used to deceive their listeners. Other ways to translate this word are:

false arguments (GNT)

ideas (NJB)

seemingly correct reasonings/excusesKankanaey
Back Translation on TW.

reasoning/arguments of the people who follow
the teaching which is not trueYakan Back Trans-
lation on TW.

10:5b

and every presumption set up against the knowledge of God;

- and every proud idea raised against the knowledge of God,
- and we destroy/ruin every arrogant opinion that opposes knowing God.
- and each time they proudly oppose the knowledge of God with their own opinions, we destroy/ruin those opinions too.

presumption: The Greek word that the BSB translates as presumption is literally “high thing/place.” Here Paul uses the figurative meaning of “arrogance.” The false teachers were proud of who they were and their ideas. Other ways to translate this word are:

presumptuous notion (NJB)

proud thing (NCV)

arrogant obstacle (NET)

lofty opinion (ESV)

set up against the knowledge of God: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as set up is literally “rise.” In this context the verb refers figuratively to opposing someone. These pretensions oppose true knowledge, so the person believing these pretensions opposes God.

the knowledge of God: This phrase refers to knowing who God is and knowing the kinds of things he does. For example:

knowing God (NLT)

10:5c

and we take captive every thought to make it obedient to Christ.

- and we capture every thought of such people so that they obey Christ.
- Also, we persuade such people to correct their ways of thinking and obey Christ.

we take captive every thought to make it obedient

to Christ: This clause continues the metaphor of warfare. Like capturing an enemy, Paul and the other evangelists would persuade those who oppose them to accept the truth of Christ. Harris (pp. 682–683) says this clause refers to unbelievers. Thrall (pp. 614–615) says it refers to the thoughts of those who oppose the true gospel, and he uses 10:6 to support this conclusion. Other ways to translate this clause are:

we compel every human thought to surrender in obedience to Christ (REB)

We capture their rebellious thoughts and teach them to obey Christ (NLT)

2 Corinthians 10:6

Section 10:1–18: Paul defended his ministry

In this section, Paul asked the believers in Corinth to live in obedience to their faith, or he might have to rebuke or discipline some (10:1–2). He explained how a believer fights against those who oppose God (10:3–4) and how to rebuke them as well as correct a disobedient believer (10:5–6).

He told them to understand their situation, including Paul’s authority (10:7–8). He explained that he was forceful in his letters, and that he would be forceful in person if he had to be (10:9–11).

He told them that people who commend themselves are not wise (10:12). He explained that he boasted only in proper ways. One of those ways was boasting about the faith of people whom he had helped become believers, which included those in Corinth (10:13–15a). He told them that he hoped to preach the gospel in more regions (10:15b–16a). He explained further about proper things to boast about (10:16b–17). Lastly, he told them that God approves of people according to what God himself says in favor of them and not what a person boasts about himself (10:18).

Other examples of headings for this section are:

Paul’s reply to accusations of weakness (NJB)

Paul Describes Himself (NASB)

Paul responded to some who had criticized him

10:6a

And we will be ready to punish every act of disobedience,

- And we^(excl) are prepared to punish any disobedience,
- Also, we are ready to punish/discipline all who disobey him/Christ,

punish every act of disobedience: Paul planned to punish the false teachers. Other ways to translate this clause are:

punish any disobedience (NJB)

punish anyone who refuses to obey (CEV)

10:6b

as soon as your obedience is complete.

- as soon as you^(plur) obey completely.
- after you completely obey him.

as soon as your obedience is complete: This obedience includes:

1. fully rejecting the false teachers;
2. completely supporting Paul as their leader;
3. stopping any practices associated with idol worship.

Translate in a way that allows these things. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

once you have given your complete obedience (NJB)

when you completely obey him (CEV)

General Comment on 10:6a–b

The believers in Corinth were to obey first (10:6b), then Paul could punish those who were disobedient (10:6a). In some languages it is more natural to have 10:6b first. For example:

And ^{6b}once your obedience is complete, ^{6a}we will be ready to punish every act of disobedience.

2 Corinthians 10:7

Section 10:1–18: Paul defended his ministry

In this section, Paul asked the believers in Corinth to live in obedience to their faith, or he might have to rebuke or discipline some (10:1–2). He explained how a

believer fights against those who oppose God (10:3–4) and how to rebuke them as well as correct a disobedient believer (10:5–6).

He told them to understand their situation, including Paul's authority (10:7–8). He explained that he was forceful in his letters, and that he would be forceful in person if he had to be (10:9–11).

He told them that people who commend themselves are not wise (10:12). He explained that he boasted only in proper ways. One of those ways was boasting about the faith of people whom he had helped become believers, which included those in Corinth (10:13–15a). He told them that he hoped to preach the gospel in more regions (10:15b–16a). He explained further about proper things to boast about (10:16b–17). Lastly, he told them that God approves of people according to what God himself says in favor of them and not what a person boasts about himself (10:18).

Other examples of headings for this section are:

Paul's reply to accusations of weakness (NJB)

Paul Describes Himself (NASB)

Paul responded to some who had criticized him

10:7a

You are looking at outward appearances.

- ¶ Look at the facts before you^(plur).
- ¶ Accept the evidence of your eyes.
- ¶ Believe what should be obvious to you.

You are looking at outward appearances: The Greek words are literally either “The things according to face/appearance, look at,” or “The things according to face/appearance you see.” The Greek clause can be either a command or a statement. There are two ways to interpret this clause:

1. The clause is a command and Paul commanded them to look at what was obvious. For example:

Look at the evidence of your eyes (NJB) (RSV, NJB, NABRE, NLT, GW, REB, ESV, NCV)

1. The clause is a statement and Paul rebuked them for looking only at appearances. For example:

You are looking at the outward appearance of things (GNT) (BSB, NIV, GNT, NASB, CEV, NET)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Martin (p. 297) translates this text as “Look at what is in front of you!” (p. 297). He says, “Paul...invites them to consider what that presence meant at a time when his initial evangelism in Corinth is under suspicion” (p. 307). Thrall translates the text as “Look at what is before your eyes” (p. 597). Harris says that if it were a statement and not a command, a “but” “might have been expected” (p. 687) at the beginning of 10:7b.

10:7b

If anyone is confident that he belongs to Christ,

- If someone is sure that he belongs to Christ,
- If anyone is convinced that he is Christ’s follower,

If anyone is confident that he belongs to Christ: This clause refers to anyone who is convinced that he believes in Jesus and therefore Jesus is Lord/leader over him and he belongs to Christ. Other ways to translate this clause are:

If you feel sure that you belong to Christ (NCV)

if anyone is sure that he is Christ’s follower/disciple

10:7c

he should remind himself that we belong to Christ just as much as he does.

- let him understand that we^(excl) belong to Christ just as much as he does.
- well, he should think again about this: We are Christ’s followers just as certainly as he is.

he should remind himself that we belong to Christ just as much as he does: This clause indicates that this other person should think about all that God had done through Paul and the other evangelists. He would then realize that God had enabled them to do that ministry. Other ways to translate this clause are:

he should reflect on this again: Just as he himself belongs to Christ, so too do we (NET)

must recognize that we belong to Christ as much as they do (NLT)

let them think again about themselves, because we belong to Christ just as much as they do (GNT)

he...he: The pronoun he refers to the word “anyone” in 10:7b. The word “anyone” can refer to either a man or a woman. The pronoun he can imply either here.

2 Corinthians 10:8

Section 10:1–18: Paul defended his ministry

In this section, Paul asked the believers in Corinth to live in obedience to their faith, or he might have to rebuke or discipline some (10:1–2). He explained how a believer fights against those who oppose God (10:3–4) and how to rebuke them as well as correct a disobedient believer (10:5–6).

He told them to understand their situation, including Paul’s authority (10:7–8). He explained that he was forceful in his letters, and that he would be forceful in person if he had to be (10:9–11).

He told them that people who commend themselves are not wise (10:12). He explained that he boasted only in proper ways. One of those ways was boasting about the faith of people whom he had helped become believers, which included those in Corinth (10:13–15a). He told them that he hoped to preach the gospel in more regions (10:15b–16a). He explained further about proper things to boast about (10:16b–17). Lastly, he told them that God approves of people according to what God himself says in favor of them and not what a person boasts about himself (10:18).

Other examples of headings for this section are:

Paul’s reply to accusations of weakness (NJB)

Paul Describes Himself (NASB)

Paul responded to some who had criticized him

10:8a

For even if I boast somewhat excessively about the authority the Lord gave us

- For if I indeed might talk proudly a little too much about our^(excl) authority, which the Lord gave
- Perhaps some of you think that I talk/boast a bit too much about the authority that the Lord Jesus gave to us.

For: This conjunction introduces an explanation of something about Paul and the others belonging to Christ. In some languages it is more natural to allow the context to indicate the connection and omit the conjunction.

even: Here the word even emphasizes the words that follow. Another way to translate this word is:

if I indeed boast

if I boast: The word if is used rhetorically. Paul wanted the believers in Corinth to think about whether Paul boasted about the authority that Jesus gave to him as an apostle. Paul probably expected that some of the Corinthians believed that he boasted too much about that. But Paul indicated that those people had to realize that he did that to strengthen the believers, not to belittle them (10:8b). Here is another way to translate this phrase:

Maybe I brag (CEV)

In some languages translating literally would imply that Paul did not know or was unsure whether he boasted freely about his authority. If that is true in your language, indicate the correct meaning. For example:

when I boast

some of you may think that I boast

I boast: Here the word boast refers to talking about the things that God did through Paul and the others. Paul felt he needed to boast to encourage the believers in Corinth (10:8b). He did not boast for selfish reasons.

In some languages, the word boast only refers to talking big about oneself in a selfish way. A person often boasts to make others think well of him. Paul would boast, but he would do so in this letter to encourage the believers in Corinth. So if the word boast only refers to selfish talk in your language, you may want to translate using a different word or phrase. For example:

I talk about my good deeds

somewhat excessively: There are three ways to interpret the Greek phrase that the BSB translates as somewhat excessively:

1. The Greek phrase refers to boasting somewhat too much. For example:

a little too much (RSV) (BSB, RSV, GNT, NJB, NABRE, NLT, GW, CEV, REB, ESV)

1. The Greek phrase refers to boasting much but not too much. For example:

freely (NCV) (NIV, NCV)

1. The Greek phrase refers to boasting somewhat more. For example:

somewhat further (NASB) (NASB, NET, KJV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Harris (p. 664) translates as in the RSV. Kistemaker (p. 327) translates the text as “somewhat excessively.” Hughes (on TW) translates it as “somewhat abundantly.”

the authority the Lord gave us: This phrase refers to the authority as apostles and evangelists that Jesus had given to Paul and the others. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

our authority, which the Lord gave (RSV)

the authority given to us by the Lord (NLT)

the authority that the Lord Jesus gave to us

10:8b

for building you up rather than tearing you down, I will not be ashamed.

- to build your^(plur) faith rather than destroy it, I will not be ashamed of doing that.
- I do so/that in order to help you to become mature believers rather than hindering the way you believe. But no one can make me feel shame about such boasting.

for: Here the word for introduces the purpose for Paul's authority.

building you up: The verb phrase building...up refers figuratively to encouraging the believers so that they believe, love, and obey Jesus well. If the verb phrase building...up does not have that figurative meaning in your language, you may want to:

- Explain the metaphor in your translation. For example:

to build your faith (REB)

- Translate the meaning without the metaphor. For example:

to help you (CEV)

to help your faith grow

tearing you down: The verb phrase tearing...down usually refers to destroying something. The BSB translates this Greek word as “demolish” in 10:4b. Here it refers figuratively to discouraging the believers from believing, loving, and obeying Jesus well. If the verb phrase tearing...down does not have that figurative meaning in your language, you may want to:

- Explain the metaphor in your translation. For example:

pull your faith down, making it ineffective/useless

- Translate the meaning without the metaphor. For example:

to hurt you (CEV)

to make your faith ineffective/useless

I will not be ashamed: The Greek words are literally “I will not be put to shame.” Paul would not accept the effort of anyone trying to shame him about this boast.

2 Corinthians 10:9

Section 10:1–18: Paul defended his ministry

In this section, Paul asked the believers in Corinth to live in obedience to their faith, or he might have to rebuke or discipline some (10:1–2). He explained how a believer fights against those who oppose God (10:3–4) and how to rebuke them as well as correct a disobedient believer (10:5–6).

He told them to understand their situation, including Paul’s authority (10:7–8). He explained that he was forceful in his letters, and that he would be forceful in person if he had to be (10:9–11).

He told them that people who commend themselves are not wise (10:12). He explained that he boasted only in proper ways. One of those ways was boasting about the faith of people whom he had helped become believers, which included those in Corinth (10:13–15a). He told them that he hoped to preach the gospel in more regions (10:15b–16a). He explained further about proper things to boast about (10:16b–17). Lastly, he told them that God approves of people according to what God himself says in favor of them and not what a person boasts about himself (10:18).

Other examples of headings for this section are:

Paul’s reply to accusations of weakness (NJB)

Paul Describes Himself (NASB)

Paul responded to some who had criticized him

10:9

I do not want to seem to be trying to frighten you by my letters.

- I do not want to seem as though I am trying to frighten you with my letters. (NRSV)
- And I do not want you^(plur) to think I am trying to terrify you with my forceful words in my letters.

10:9 begins with a Greek conjunction that is often translated as “that” (as in the KJV). It probably connects in a general way to 10:8 rather than to “ashamed” of 10:8b. It introduces a negative purpose. The BSB and many other English versions allow the context to imply a general connection and omit the Greek conjunction.

I do not want to seem to be trying to frighten you:

The Greek words are literally “that I may not seem as if to frighten you.” Paul wrote boastfully about his authority from God to encourage them, not to frighten them. He did not even want them to think that he was trying to frighten them. Other ways to translate this clause are:

I do not want to seem as though I am trying to frighten you with my letters (NRSV)

I do not wish to seem as if I would terrify you by my letters (NASB)

I do not want you to think I am trying to scare you with my letters (NCV)

frighten: The Greek word that the BSB translates as frighten probably means “cause to be very much afraid.” For example:

terrify (NET)

by my letters: Sometimes, Paul wrote very forcefully in his letters. In some languages it is more natural to speak of the forceful words possibly frightening the believers. For example:

with the forceful words in my letters

2 Corinthians 10:10

Section 10:1–18: Paul defended his ministry

In this section, Paul asked the believers in Corinth to live in obedience to their faith, or he might have to rebuke or discipline some (10:1–2). He explained how a believer fights against those who oppose God (10:3–4) and how to rebuke them as well as correct a disobedient believer (10:5–6).

He told them to understand their situation, including Paul's authority (10:7–8). He explained that he was forceful in his letters, and that he would be forceful in person if he had to be (10:9–11).

He told them that people who commend themselves are not wise (10:12). He explained that he boasted only in proper ways. One of those ways was boasting about the faith of people whom he had helped become believers, which included those in Corinth (10:13–15a). He told them that he hoped to preach the gospel in more regions (10:15b–16a). He explained further about proper things to boast about (10:16b–17). Lastly, he told them that God approves of people according to what God himself says in favor of them and not what a person boasts about himself (10:18).

Other examples of headings for this section are:

Paul's reply to accusations of weakness (NJB)

Paul Describes Himself (NASB)

Paul responded to some who had criticized him

10:10a

For some say,

- For a person says,
- Because someone is saying about me,
- For someone who has been criticizing me has been saying

For: This conjunction introduces an explanation of why Paul mentioned his letters in 10:9.

some say: The Greek word is literally “he says.” This clause may refer to the same person as in 10:7 or to any of the false teachers. This person probably was saying these things in Corinth during the time when Paul was writing this letter. For example:

someone is saying (GW)

10:10b–c

10:10b–c contain a pair of Greek words that together compare two different statements. Here the Greek words indicate that 10:10b refers to opinions about one situation (Paul being away) and 10:10c refers to other opinions about a contrasting situation (Paul being in Corinth). For example:

“On one hand, his letters are severe and pushy; on the other hand, he is unimpressive in person and his speaking amounts to nothing.

“In one case/situation, when he is away, his letters are severe and pushy; in the other case/situation, in person, he is unimpressive and his speaking amounts to nothing.

His letters are weighty and forceful, but in person he is unimpressive and his speaking amounts to nothing. (NIV)

10:10b

“His letters are weighty and forceful,

- “On the one hand, the words in his letters are important and strong;
- “In his letters, he writes impressively and powerfully,

weighty: The Greek word that the BSB translates as weighty can also mean “burdensome” or “difficult.” There are two ways to interpret the Greek word:

1. The word means important here. Paul's opponents complimented his letters only to contrast with criticizing him in 10:10c–d. For example:

impressive (JBP) (NJB, GW, JBP, NCV)

1. The word means burdensome here. Paul's opponents criticized his letters as well as his conduct and speaking (10:10c–d). For example:

severe (GNT) (GNT, NABRE, NLT, CEV)

The English word weighty, like the Greek word, allows both interpretations. However, many languages must choose. It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Thrall (p. 630) says it “more probably means ‘weighty’ in the sense of ‘impressive’.” It is contrasted with (the Greek word that means) ‘contemptible.’” Martin (p. 311) calls it a “backhanded...

compliment” (something that sounds like a compliment but is used in the middle of an insult).

forceful: This word is probably a compliment, like the word weighty in interpretation (1) above. Other ways to translate this word are:

strong (RSV)

full of strength (NJB)

But if you followed interpretation (2) above, you should translate the Greek word as a criticism. For example:

aggressive

overbearing

demanding

10:10c

but his physical presence is unimpressive,

- on the other hand, his personal presence impresses/inspires no one
- but when he is here, people think that he is weak/cowardly

his physical presence is unimpressive: This clause refers to what Paul’s opponents thought of Paul’s personal presentation. They probably thought he did not act like an important leader. Other ways to translate this clause are:

his personal presence is unimpressive (NASB)

he does not act like an important leader in person

his ways as a leader are weak/cowardly when among us

10:10d

and his speaking is of no account.”

- and his speeches are worthless!” (NLT)
- and despise his public speaking.”

his speaking is of no account: The Greek words are literally “the speech is being despised.” This clause indicates that Paul’s opponents think that Paul spoke very poorly when speaking publicly (as in sermons and evangelizing). Other ways to translate this clause are:

his speeches are worthless (NLT)

people disdain/ridicule his public speaking

2 Corinthians 10:11

Section 10:1–18: Paul defended his ministry

In this section, Paul asked the believers in Corinth to live in obedience to their faith, or he might have to rebuke or discipline some (10:1–2). He explained how a believer fights against those who oppose God (10:3–4) and how to rebuke them as well as correct a disobedient believer (10:5–6).

He told them to understand their situation, including Paul’s authority (10:7–8). He explained that he was forceful in his letters, and that he would be forceful in person if he had to be (10:9–11).

He told them that people who commend themselves are not wise (10:12). He explained that he boasted only in proper ways. One of those ways was boasting about the faith of people whom he had helped become believers, which included those in Corinth (10:13–15a). He told them that he hoped to preach the gospel in more regions (10:15b–16a). He explained further about proper things to boast about (10:16b–17). Lastly, he told them that God approves of people according to what God himself says in favor of them and not what a person boasts about himself (10:18).

Other examples of headings for this section are:

Paul’s reply to accusations of weakness (NJB)

Paul Describes Himself (NASB)

Paul responded to some who had criticized him

10:11a

Such people should consider that what we are in our letters when absent,

- That person should understand that who we are in writing our letters when absent
- Such people must realize that the kind of people that our letters show us^(excl) to be when we are away

Such people: The Greek words are literally “such a one.” The words probably refer to the same person or group as in 10:10. For example:

The person (GW)

what we are in our letters when absent: This clause refers to Paul's forceful character. This forceful character was clearly seen in his letters. Other ways to translate this clause are:

what we are in word by letters when absent (NASB)

the same qualities as our letters when we were at a distance (NJB)

the same authority that we show in our letters (NCV)

10:11b

we will be in our actions when present.

- is who we will be in action when we are with you.
- will be the same as the kind of people we will be in our actions when we arrive.

we will be in our actions when present: This clause indicates that Paul would also be forceful when he went to Corinth and confronted the false teachers. Other ways to translate this clause are:

we are also in deed when present (NASB)

we will also show in our deeds when present

we will show by what we do when we are there with you

2 Corinthians 10:12

Section 10:1–18: Paul defended his ministry

In this section, Paul asked the believers in Corinth to live in obedience to their faith, or he might have to rebuke or discipline some (10:1–2). He explained how a believer fights against those who oppose God (10:3–4) and how to rebuke them as well as correct a disobedient believer (10:5–6).

He told them to understand their situation, including Paul's authority (10:7–8). He explained that he was forceful in his letters, and that he would be forceful in person if he had to be (10:9–11).

He told them that people who commend themselves are not wise (10:12). He explained that he boasted only in proper ways. One of those ways was boasting about the faith of people whom he had helped become believers, which included those in Corinth (10:13–15a). He told them that he hoped to preach the gospel in

more regions (10:15b–16a). He explained further about proper things to boast about (10:16b–17). Lastly, he told them that God approves of people according to what God himself says in favor of them and not what a person boasts about himself (10:18).

Other examples of headings for this section are:

Paul's reply to accusations of weakness (NJB)

Paul Describes Himself (NASB)

Paul responded to some who had criticized him

10:12a

We do not dare to classify or compare ourselves with some who commend themselves.

- ¶ For we^(excl) would not risk classifying/ranking ourselves or compare ourselves with some people who recommend themselves as qualified to be your leaders.
- ¶ Some people praise themselves about how important they are. Should we be bold enough to say we are the same kind of person or compare ourselves to them? No way!
- ¶ Some people wrongly think that we would be too bold to say that we have the same status or are the same kind of person as those who proclaim how great/important they are.

10:12 begins with a Greek conjunction that is often translated as “for” or “because.” Here it probably indicates that 10:12 connects the comparison of Paul's letters and his deeds (10:11) to his ironic comparison of himself to the false teachers here. For example:

For (NASB)

Many English versions allow the context to indicate the connection and omit the conjunction.

We do not dare to classify or compare ourselves with some who commend themselves: Paul used irony here. He wrote as if the false teachers were true apostles and he was not. But Paul knew that he was a true apostle and they were not. So the irony showed that he was different from them and was actually greater than them. The irony also implies that those people were wrong to commend themselves. Translate in a way that clearly shows the irony. For example:

Of course we would not dare classify ourselves or compare ourselves with those who rate themselves so highly. (GNT)

Oh, don't worry; we wouldn't dare say that we are as wonderful as these other men who tell you how important they are! (NLT)

We really are cowards so we do not rank or compare ourselves with some of the people there who call themselves great leaders

In some languages a literal translation would not have the correct meaning. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Translate these words in a way that explains the irony. Your translation should indicate or imply that the false teachers were wrong to commend themselves. For example:

Some people there commend themselves. Should we be bold enough to classify or compare ourselves to them? No way!

We should/will not classify or compare ourselves to some people there who wrongly commend themselves

Classifying or comparing ourselves to some people there who commend themselves is worthless.

Some people are with you and they praise themselves saying, "We are good/great people, respect us." But as for us, in no way do we want to say that the ways of those people and our own ways are the same.

- Translate literally and explain the irony in a footnote. An example footnote is:

Paul used irony here. He wrote as if the false teachers were true apostles and he was not. But Paul knew that he was a true apostle and they were not.

We do not dare: The word dare refers to being bold in regard to doing something risky. For example, jumping off a high bridge might be dangerous, but someone challenges you to jump. Here Paul used irony to pretend that comparing themselves with the false

teachers was risky or dangerous, because they might be found to be inferior (in this irony). Other ways to translate this clause are:

We do not risk

We are not so bold as

classify: This word refers to the effort to decide if one thing is the same sort of thing as another. The false teachers claimed to be apostles. But Paul did not think it worthwhile to think about whether he was like them, or whether they were like him, because he already knew they were false teachers. Other ways to translate this word are:

class (RSV)

rank (NJB)

say we are the same kind of person

say we have the same kind of status

some who commend themselves: Here the word commend indicates that they boasted about themselves to the believers in Corinth so that the believers would accept them and follow their teaching. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

these other men who tell you how important they are (NLT)

some people who recommend themselves

those who write their own testimonials (JBP)

10:12b

When they measure themselves by themselves

- But when they measure themselves by one another (RSV)
- Those who proclaim how great/important they are say that their colleagues/friends behavior is good and then judge themselves by it

10:12b begins with a Greek conjunction that is often translated as "but" (as in the NASB). Here it indicates that 10:12b–c contrasts with 10:12a.

In some languages it is more natural to allow the context to indicate the contrast and omit the conjunction.

they measure themselves by themselves: This clause indicates that the false teachers used their own behavior as a standard of goodness. They said that it was correct and proper. They did not look to see what Scripture said were correct behavior and beliefs. Other ways to translate this clause are:

they measure themselves by one another (RSV)

They make up their own standards to measure themselves by (GNT)

they...measure themselves by their own standards (JBP)

they say that they are good in their own sight/measure/guideline

10:12c

and compare themselves with themselves, they show their ignorance.

- and compare themselves with one another, they are without understanding. (RSV)
- and look at the lives of their colleagues/friends and say about themselves that they are the same as them and therefore good/right/proper. This shows that they do not have good sense.

compare themselves with themselves: This phrase indicates that the false teachers evaluated themselves by comparing themselves with other false teachers in their group. So they said something like “I am like you, therefore I am good.” They did not look to see what Scripture said were correct behavior and beliefs. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

compare themselves with one another (RSV)

compare themselves with their own people whom they agree with

look at their own friends/colleagues and say about themselves that they are good

they show their ignorance: The Greek words are literally “they do not understand.” The false teachers did not realize that doing such things was improper and worthless. Other ways to translate this clause are:

they are without understanding (RSV)

they are foolish (CEV)

they do not show good sense (NRSV)

2 Corinthians 10:13

Section 10:1–18: Paul defended his ministry

In this section, Paul asked the believers in Corinth to live in obedience to their faith, or he might have to rebuke or discipline some (10:1–2). He explained how a believer fights against those who oppose God (10:3–4) and how to rebuke them as well as correct a disobedient believer (10:5–6).

He told them to understand their situation, including Paul’s authority (10:7–8). He explained that he was forceful in his letters, and that he would be forceful in person if he had to be (10:9–11).

He told them that people who commend themselves are not wise (10:12). He explained that he boasted only in proper ways. One of those ways was boasting about the faith of people whom he had helped become believers, which included those in Corinth (10:13–15a). He told them that he hoped to preach the gospel in more regions (10:15b–16a). He explained further about proper things to boast about (10:16b–17). Lastly, he told them that God approves of people according to what God himself says in favor of them and not what a person boasts about himself (10:18).

Other examples of headings for this section are:

Paul’s reply to accusations of weakness (NJB)

Paul Describes Himself (NASB)

Paul responded to some who had criticized him

10:13–b

We, however, will not boast beyond our limits, but only within the field of influence that God has assigned to us: The Greek words are literally “now we do not boast in unmeasured (amounts) but according to the measure of the sphere that God measured to us with a measure.” Here Paul used the same idea, “measure,” in four different ways:

1. As its negated or opposite idea (“unmeasured”).
2. As a calculation (“the measure [of the sphere]”).
3. As the action of marking something out (“measured to us”).

4. As the means of making a measurement (“[with] a measure”).

He first denied that he boasts without limits. He then described what was acceptable as boasting. They could boast only about work that God had given responsibility to them for.

Generally, English versions do not try to use the word “measure” or a similar word four times, since that would not be natural English. But some versions use the word three times to try to mimic Paul’s repeated use of the word. For example:

But we will not boast beyond our measure, but within the measure of the domain which God assigned to us as a measure (NASB)

10:13a

We, however, will not boast beyond our limits,

- But as for us^(excl), we will not talk proudly about things outside of the duties that God has given to us,
- But we, on the other hand, will not talk/boast about things we do not have the right to talk/boast about.

We, however, will not boast beyond our limits: The limits for boasting are explained in 10:13b–16. Paul would boast about what God had done through him. He had been the first to preach in Corinth (10:13c). He would not boast about what others had done, as if he had done those things himself (10:15–16). Other ways to translate this clause are:

But we will not boast beyond our measure (NASB)

We will not boast about things done outside our area of authority (NLT)

We won’t brag about something we don’t have a right to brag about (CEV)

We will not boast about changed lives in places that result from someone else’s preaching

We: This pronoun is emphasized in the Greek. It emphasizes the contrast between the false teachers (“they” in 10:12) and Paul and his coworkers. For example:

As for us (GNT)

boast: The word boast refers to talking proudly about something. Here it refers to the things that God had done through Paul and the other evangelists. Paul felt he needed to boast to encourage the believers in Corinth. He did not boast for selfish reasons. See how you translated this word in 10:8.

10:13b

but only within the field of influence that God has assigned to us—

- but we will limit what we talk proudly about to the area s that God assigned to us.
- But we will only talk/boast about the deeds that God authorized us to do.

but only within the field of influence: This phrase refers to limiting what they boasted about. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

but within the measure of the domain (NASB)

We will boast only about what has happened within the boundaries of the work (NLT)

We will only brag about the work (CEV)

the field of influence: The Greek words are literally “the measure/limit of the sphere/region.” The Greek word “of” indicates here that “sphere” explains what is “limited.” The word “sphere” refers here to all of Paul’s ministry. For example:

the limits of the work (GNT)

field: The Greek word is literally “sphere/region.” The Greek word and the English word field refer here to all of Paul’s ministry. This includes the people groups and places where God had sent them to preach and evangelize. Acts 13:1–21:16 tells about the cities where Paul and his coworkers went, preached, and evangelized. They preached mainly to non-Jews, but they usually offered the opportunity to believe in Jesus to the Jews in those cities first. For example:

regions/peoples

the area (ESV)

In some languages it is more natural to refer to the ministry done in those places rather than the places themselves. For example:

work (CEV)

10:13c

a field that reaches even to you.

- This area also includes you.
- And, indeed, God authorized us to minister/work in your city.

a field that reaches even to you: Corinth was one of the places where God had sent Paul to preach and evangelize. So this phrase indicates that Corinth and the believers there were included in that field. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

a field that even includes you

this includes our work among you (GNT)

you are part of that work (CEV)

field: This word refers figuratively to the places where God had sent them to preach and evangelize, as in 10:13b.

even: This word emphasizes that God had authorized Paul to preach and evangelize in Corinth. So the believers in Corinth were a part of Paul's ministry.

2 Corinthians 10:14

Section 10:1–18: Paul defended his ministry

In this section, Paul asked the believers in Corinth to live in obedience to their faith, or he might have to rebuke or discipline some (10:1–2). He explained how a believer fights against those who oppose God (10:3–4) and how to rebuke them as well as correct a disobedient believer (10:5–6).

He told them to understand their situation, including Paul's authority (10:7–8). He explained that he was forceful in his letters, and that he would be forceful in person if he had to be (10:9–11).

He told them that people who commend themselves are not wise (10:12). He explained that he boasted only in proper ways. One of those ways was boasting about the faith of people whom he had helped become believers, which included those in Corinth (10:13–15a). He told them that he hoped to preach the gospel in more regions (10:15b–16a). He explained further about proper things to boast about (10:16b–17). Lastly, he told them that God approves of people according to what God himself says in favor of them and not what a person boasts about himself (10:18).

Other examples of headings for this section are:

Paul's reply to accusations of weakness (NJB)

Paul Describes Himself (NASB)

Paul responded to some who had criticized him

10:14a

We are not overstepping our bounds,

- We^(excl) are not reaching/stretching beyond what God assigned to us,
- We are not talking/boasting about ministry/work that we are not responsible for.
- We do not brag about things other than our own/proper work/ministry,

10:14 begins with a Greek conjunction that is often translated as "for" or "because." Here it probably introduces an explanation of what Paul said in 10:13. For example:

For (RSV)

In some languages it is more natural to allow the context to indicate the connection and omit the conjunction.

We are not overstepping our bounds: The Greek words are literally "We are not reaching/stretching beyond ourselves." There are two ways to interpret the Greek:

1. It refers to not going beyond the places where Paul first preached. Paul was the first to evangelize in Corinth. For example:

we are not overextending ourselves, as though we did not reach you (RSV) (BSB, RSV, GNT, NJB, ESV, NABRE, NASB, KJV, NLT, GW, NET, REB)

1. It refers to not boasting too much. For example:

We are not bragging more than we should (CEV) (NIV, CEV, NCV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because 10:13 ends with "even to you," so the topic seems to be the places where Paul first preached. Harris, Martin, Barrett, Furnish, Barnett, Kistemaker, Hughes, and Kruse support interpretation (1).

Other ways to translate this clause according to interpretation (1) are:

We are not overreaching ourselves (NJB)

For we were not overstepping our limits (NRSV)

And since you are within those limits, we were not going beyond them (GNT)

We are not reaching beyond these boundaries (NLT)

10:14b

as if we had not come to you.

- as we would be if we had not come all the way to you, (NJB)
- Look, if we had not come to you and started the church there, then we would not be responsible for you.
- since we came to Corinth to do God's work there.

as if we had not come to you: God had told Paul and the others to go to Corinth and preach the gospel. They established the church there. So it was proper for them to be proud of what God was doing among the believers there. If Paul and the others had not gone to Corinth, it would be improper for them to boast about the believers there as if Paul were responsible for them. Other ways to translate this clause are:

as we would be if we had not come all the way to you (NJB)

as though we hadn't already been to Corinth (GW)

as if we had not come to you and begun the church there

Since 10:14a already has the word not, in some languages the meaning is clearer when not is avoided here. For example:

since you are within those limits (GNT)

10:14c

Indeed, we were the first to reach you with the gospel of Christ.

- but it was us who came all the way to you with the gospel about Christ.

- Indeed, we came as far as you with the gospel of Christ.
- In fact we came as far as you with the good news of Christ and began the church/group of believers there.

Indeed: This Greek word that the BSB translates as Indeed is a conjunction usually translated as “for” or “because.” It introduces an explanation of why Paul had not boasted too much (10:14a).

we were the first to reach you: The Greek word that the BSB translates as first to reach implies that Paul started the church in Corinth.

to reach you: The Greek words are “even to you.” It is the same phrase as in 10:13c.

gospel: The Greek word that the BSB translates here as gospel is sometimes translated as “good news.” In the New Testament the word refers to the good news that Jesus is the Christ. See how you translated this word in 2:12 or 4:3.

2 Corinthians 10:15

Section 10:1-18: Paul defended his ministry

In this section, Paul asked the believers in Corinth to live in obedience to their faith, or he might have to rebuke or discipline some (10:1-2). He explained how a believer fights against those who oppose God (10:3-4) and how to rebuke them as well as correct a disobedient believer (10:5-6).

He told them to understand their situation, including Paul's authority (10:7-8). He explained that he was forceful in his letters, and that he would be forceful in person if he had to be (10:9-11).

He told them that people who commend themselves are not wise (10:12). He explained that he boasted only in proper ways. One of those ways was boasting about the faith of people whom he had helped become believers, which included those in Corinth (10:13-15a). He told them that he hoped to preach the gospel in more regions (10:15b-16a). He explained further about proper things to boast about (10:16b-17). Lastly, he told them that God approves of people according to what God himself says in favor of them and not what a person boasts about himself (10:18).

Other examples of headings for this section are:

Paul's reply to accusations of weakness (NJB)

Paul Describes Himself (NASB)

Paul responded to some who had criticized him

10:15a

Neither do we boast beyond our limits in the labors of others.

- We^(excl) do not boast beyond limit, that is, in the labors of others.
- We do not talk proudly for selfish gain about work/ministry done by others, since such talk is outside of what is proper.

Neither do we boast beyond our limits in the labors of others: The Greek words are literally “in the (things) beyond measure boasting in others’ labors.” It indicates two things:

1. Some kinds of boasting in the labors of others are acceptable. This is probably boasting that praises those people who did the work.
2. Some kinds of boasting in the labors of others are not acceptable. This is probably boasting about being responsible for the work when they were not.

For example, Paul would not have boasted about Peter’s work as if he (Paul) had done that work himself or was responsible for it. Other ways to translate this clause are:

We do not boast beyond limits, that is, in the labors of others (NRSV)

we do not boast of work done where others have laboured, work beyond our proper sphere (REB)

We limit our bragging to the work that is ours, not what others have done (NCV)

boast beyond our limits in the labors of others: This clause refers to a wrong kind of boasting. This kind of boast claims to be responsible for work done by others, when the person who boasts was not responsible for that work.

In some languages a literal translation would not have the correct meaning. If that is true in your language, you may want to explain the correct meaning in your translation. For example:

selfish boasting of work done by others

boasting of work done by others as if we had done the work ourselves

boasting of work done by others as if the credit/responsibility was ours

labors: Here the word labors refers to doing things for God such as preaching and evangelizing. The Greek word often implies hard work. Other ways to translate this word are:

hard work

ministry

work of God

what others have done for God

10:15b

But we hope that as your faith increases,

- As your^(plur) faith/believing becomes stronger, we expect that
- As you believe in Jesus more and more, we have confidence that

hope: The Greek word that the BSB translates as hope means “confidence about something happening.” Paul expected their faith to grow and that would cause him to have more opportunities to preach and teach among them. For example:

confidence (GW)

as your faith increases: This phrase refers to the believers’ faith in Jesus increasing. As this happened, they would have fewer doubts and trust him to do more and more in their lives. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

as your faith continues to grow (NIV)

as you become stronger in your faith (CEV)

as your believing becomes great/large

10:15c

our area of influence among you will greatly increase as well,

- our area of influence among you may be greatly enlarged, (ESV)
- our work among you will grow/extend greatly.

our area of influence among you will greatly increase as well: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as our area of influence is literally “according to our sphere/region.” There are several ways to interpret this phrase. The three main ways are:

1. The Greek phrase refers to the places, people, and ministries where Paul was already working. For example:

our field among you may be greatly enlarged
(RSV) (BSB, RSV, NIV, NASB, NLT, ESV)

1. The Greek phrase refers to what is limited (10:15a). For example:

always within the limits that God has set (GNT)
(GNT, NET, REB)

1. The Greek phrase refers to a standard or rule. For example:

by this standard of ours (NJB) (NJB, KJV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Harris (p. 705) translates this phrase as “in accordance with our assignment.” Martin (p. 322) translates the Greek phrase as “within the sphere we have.” Kistemaker (p. 349) translates it as “our sphere of influence.” Furnish (p. 465) translates it as “in accord with our jurisdiction.”

our area of influence: The word area refers figuratively to the people groups and places where God had sent them to preach and evangelize. The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as area of influence is translated “field” in 10:13b. The meaning is similar in both places. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

regions/people

our sphere of activity (NIV)

we will be able to reach many more of the people around you (CEV)

2 Corinthians 10:16

Section 10:1–18: Paul defended his ministry

In this section, Paul asked the believers in Corinth to live in obedience to their faith, or he might have to rebuke or discipline some (10:1–2). He explained how a believer fights against those who oppose God (10:3–4)

and how to rebuke them as well as correct a disobedient believer (10:5–6).

He told them to understand their situation, including Paul’s authority (10:7–8). He explained that he was forceful in his letters, and that he would be forceful in person if he had to be (10:9–11).

He told them that people who commend themselves are not wise (10:12). He explained that he boasted only in proper ways. One of those ways was boasting about the faith of people whom he had helped become believers, which included those in Corinth (10:13–15a). He told them that he hoped to preach the gospel in more regions (10:15b–16a). He explained further about proper things to boast about (10:16b–17). Lastly, he told them that God approves of people according to what God himself says in favor of them and not what a person boasts about himself (10:18).

Other examples of headings for this section are:

Paul’s reply to accusations of weakness (NJB)

Paul Describes Himself (NASB)

Paul responded to some who had criticized him

10:16a

so that we can preach the gospel in the regions beyond you.

- so that we^(excl) can proclaim the gospel in the places beyond you^(plur).
- Then we can go to lands/regions beyond where you live and tell the good news/message about Jesus/Christ to people there.

so that we can preach the gospel in the regions beyond you: If the believers in Corinth grew in faith (10:15b), then they would be mature enough to govern themselves and Paul would be free to preach in new regions. For example:

Then we can preach the Good News in other countries beyond you (GNT)

preach the gospel: The Greek word that the BSB translates as preach the gospel means “announce good news.” Here the good news is about Jesus as the Christ. Other ways to translate this Greek word are:

proclaim the good news

tell people about Jesus

See how you translated the word gospel in 2:12 or 4:3.

the regions beyond you: The Greek words are literally “the (things) beyond you.” The implied word “things” probably refers to places such as towns, cities, regions, and even countries. Paul was probably thinking of the city of Rome and the country of Spain, and perhaps other places between Rome and Spain. Use a phrase that would include towns, cities, regions, and countries. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

lands beyond you (ESV)

other places far beyond you (NLT)

the regions that lie beyond you (NET)

beyond you: This probably refers to at least Rome and Spain, which are farther west from Ephesus than Corinth and therefore beyond them.

10:16b

Then we will not be boasting

- We would never boast
- We will not talk proudly for selfish gain

10:16b–c

Then we will not be boasting in the work already done in another man’s territory: There is actually no conjunction at the beginning of the Greek here. 10:16b–c describes Paul’s attitude about wrongful boasting of another man’s work. Other ways to translate this clause are:

without boasting of work already done in another’s field (RSV)

and shall not have to boast about work already done in someone else’s field (GNT)

10:16c

in the work already done in another man’s territory.

- about work already done in anyone else’s area of influence.
- about work/ministry already done in someone else’s area.

the work already done in another man’s territory:

This clause refers to a region or people group in which someone other than Paul and his coworkers had

already preached and taught. Other ways to translate this clause are:

things already accomplished by someone else (GW)

work already done in another person’s area (NET)

ministry in regions/peoples where someone else has already begun

man’s: Here this word refers generally to people. For example:

person’s (NET)

territory: The Greek word that the BSB translates as territory is the same word that the BSB translates as “field” in 10:13c and “area of influence” in 10:15c. The meaning of the Greek word is the same here as in 10:13c and 10:15c. Other ways to translate this word are:

field (RSV)

area of activity

2 Corinthians 10:17

Section 10:1–18: Paul defended his ministry

In this section, Paul asked the believers in Corinth to live in obedience to their faith, or he might have to rebuke or discipline some (10:1–2). He explained how a believer fights against those who oppose God (10:3–4) and how to rebuke them as well as correct a disobedient believer (10:5–6).

He told them to understand their situation, including Paul’s authority (10:7–8). He explained that he was forceful in his letters, and that he would be forceful in person if he had to be (10:9–11).

He told them that people who commend themselves are not wise (10:12). He explained that he boasted only in proper ways. One of those ways was boasting about the faith of people whom he had helped become believers, which included those in Corinth (10:13–15a). He told them that he hoped to preach the gospel in more regions (10:15b–16a). He explained further about proper things to boast about (10:16b–17). Lastly, he told them that God approves of people according to what God himself says in favor of them and not what a person boasts about himself (10:18).

Other examples of headings for this section are:

Paul's reply to accusations of weakness (NJB)

Paul Describes Himself (NASB)

Paul responded to some who had criticized him

10:17

Rather, "Let him who boasts boast in the Lord."

- But, let the one who boasts, boast of the Lord.
- However, the Scriptures make this clear: "If anyone wants to talk proudly about something, he should talk proudly about the Lord and what he has done."

Rather: This conjunction introduces something in contrast to incorrect boasting (10:15a, 16b-c).

Let him who boasts boast in the Lord: The Greek clause says literally, "The one boasting, in (the) Lord let him boast." This clause is Paul's interpretation of Jeremiah 9:24. It is not an exact quote of that verse. But Paul probably expected the believers to know that he was referring to Scripture here. In some languages it is more natural to indicate the implied information. Other ways to translate this clause are:

But a saying like/from the Scriptures is this: "Let him who boasts boast in the Lord."

But as the Scripture says, "Whoever wants to boast must boast about what the Lord has done." (GNT)

You may want to:

- Simply refer to the book, chapter, and verse in a footnote. For example:
- Jeremiah 9:24
- Explain in a footnote that Paul interpreted Jeremiah 9:24 rather than quoted it. An example footnote is:

Paul made this saying from the meaning of Jeremiah 9:24. He did not use the exact words from that verse.

boast in the Lord: This phrase refers to boasting about who God is and what he does. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

boast in who the Lord is and what he does

boast about what the Lord has done (GNT)

the Lord: In the context of Jeremiah 9:24, the phrase the Lord refers to God. Paul probably used only the Lord so the phrase could also refer to Jesus, who is also Lord (1:2). If possible, translate in a way that allows the Lord to refer to either God or Jesus.

In some languages it is more natural to refer to either God or Jesus here. If that is true in your language, refer to God, since Jeremiah 9:24 refers to God. For example:

the Lord God

2 Corinthians 10:18

Section 10:1-18: Paul defended his ministry

In this section, Paul asked the believers in Corinth to live in obedience to their faith, or he might have to rebuke or discipline some (10:1-2). He explained how a believer fights against those who oppose God (10:3-4) and how to rebuke them as well as correct a disobedient believer (10:5-6).

He told them to understand their situation, including Paul's authority (10:7-8). He explained that he was forceful in his letters, and that he would be forceful in person if he had to be (10:9-11).

He told them that people who commend themselves are not wise (10:12). He explained that he boasted only in proper ways. One of those ways was boasting about the faith of people whom he had helped become believers, which included those in Corinth (10:13-15a). He told them that he hoped to preach the gospel in more regions (10:15b-16a). He explained further about proper things to boast about (10:16b-17). Lastly, he told them that God approves of people according to what God himself says in favor of them and not what a person boasts about himself (10:18).

Other examples of headings for this section are:

Paul's reply to accusations of weakness (NJB)

Paul Describes Himself (NASB)

Paul responded to some who had criticized him

10:18a

For it is not the one who commends himself who is approved,

- For it is not the person who recommends himself who is accepted as genuine,
- Since praising oneself is not what the Lord listens to in order to approve him.
- What I mean is that you^(plur) praising yourselves does not indicate that the Lord approves you,

For: This conjunction introduces an explanation. 10:18 also concludes what Paul said about a person boasting about what he has done and commending himself (10:12–18).

Many English versions translate the Greek conjunction as For. In some languages it is more natural to allow the context to indicate the connection and omit the conjunction.

it is not the one who commends himself who is approved: This clause is passive. Implicitly, the Lord is the one who approves. Some languages must use an active clause. For example:

it is not the one who commends himself whom the Lord approves

It isn't the person who makes his own recommendation who receives approval (GW)

it is not the one who commends himself: The phrase not the one who commends himself is emphasized in the Greek. English adds the words it is to indicate that emphasis. Emphasize this phrase in a natural way in your language.

the one who commends himself: The Greek word that the BSB translates as commends has the same meaning as in 10:12. The verse here refers to anyone who praises himself for selfish reasons. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

people who tell you how important they are

people who recommend themselves

those who write their own testimonials (JBP, 10:12)

You should translate in a similar way to the way that you translated the word commends in 10:12. The GNT changes its interpretation of the Greek word here and says “when we think well of ourselves.” If you followed the wording in the GNT in 10:12, you may want to:

- Translate here as the BSB and other English versions do. For example:

those who commend themselves (NRSV)

- Use the same wording here as in the GNT in 10:12:

those who rate themselves so highly

is approved: This phrase indicates that someone tests something and finds it acceptable. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

is accepted as genuine

is acknowledged as having good ways

is good in the Lord's sight

10:18b

but the one whom the Lord commends.

- but the person whom the Lord recommends is accepted by him.
- No, instead, if the Lord praises someone, then the Lord has approved him.
- but rather, the Lord praising you is what indicates that the Lord approves you.

the one whom the Lord commends: The words “is approved” are implied from 10:18a but are not repeated here. In some languages it is more natural to repeat those words here. For example:

the one whom the Lord commends is approved

General Comment on 10:18a–b

This verse emphasizes “the one who commends himself” and “the one whom the Lord commends.” Paul did that to contrast the two phrases. Paul had an apostleship that God commended. But the false teachers commended themselves. If possible, translate the contrast clearly.

Also, this verse tells what does not happen and then what does happen. In some languages it is more natural to tell what happens first. For example:

^{18a}For a person has the Lord's approval ^{18b}when the Lord commends him ^{18a}and not when the person commends himself.

2 Corinthians 11:1

Section 11:1–15: Paul spoke against the false teachers

In 11:1, Paul prepared his readers for what he would say in 11:7–10 and 11:16. He described the way he would speak as “foolishness.” Paul used the term “foolishness” here in a special way. In this chapter Paul said he was “foolish” because he praised himself for his own good character, attitudes, and actions. He called this praise “foolish” especially because he had just said in 10:17–18 that believers should not praise themselves.

Paul was very concerned for the believers in Corinth, like a father wanting his daughter to be faithful to the man whom she would marry one day (11:2). In the same way he worried that the false teachers might have led the believers away from following Jesus (11:3–4).

Since the false teachers had deceived some of the believers in Corinth, Paul had to defend himself to the believers (11:5–6). The false teachers had praised themselves and some of the believers had believed them, so Paul had to praise himself. He reminded them that he had not allowed them to support him. He wanted them to know that he was serving them because he truly loved them and wanted to help them, unlike the false teachers.

In Greek culture, a teacher expected those whom he taught to support him. It was an honor to support a well-known teacher. But Paul had not let the believers in Corinth support him. Using irony, Paul asked them if they were upset about his not letting them support him (11:7). Using irony again, he told them that churches in other cities had supported him while he lived in Corinth so that he could serve them full time (11:8–9). But the false teachers probably did the culturally expected thing and accepted money from the believers. Paul explained that he loved the believers in Corinth and therefore had not accepted their money (11:10–11). This example of love showed that the false teachers were not equals with Paul as apostles (11:12). He described the false teachers as claiming to be apostles while actually following Satan (11:13–15).

Other examples for this section heading are:

Paul Contrasts Himself With False Apostles (GW)

Paul and His Opponents (NET)

11:1a

I hope you will bear with a little of my foolishness,

- ¶ I wish/desire that you^(plur) would allow me to be a little foolish.
- ¶ You accept others who commend themselves, so please tolerate me while I act a little like a foolish/silly person.

I hope you will bear with a little of my foolishness:

Paul told the believers that they should only boast in what the Lord does (10:17–18). In 10:12 he referred to people who commended themselves, and in 10:18 he implied that it was not good for people to do that.

But here he asked them to allow him to commend himself. Doing that was foolish. He did so because the false teachers had been foolishly and boastfully commending themselves. The believers had been listening to the foolish boasting of the false teachers. He wanted to commend himself a little to show the believers that he had better credentials than the false teachers. In some languages it is more natural to:

- Introduce this change in topic with some implied information. For example:

Those false teachers act foolishly yet you listen to them, so I hope you will bear with a little of my foolishness

You accept others who commend themselves, so I hope you will put up with a little of my foolishness

- Explain this change in topic in a footnote. For example:

Here Paul asked the believers to allow him to commend himself a little. He did so because the false teachers had been foolishly commending themselves with boasts about themselves. Some believers had accepted these boasts as reasons to follow the false teachers. Paul wanted to boast a little to show the believers that they should accept him instead.

I hope: The Greek word that the BSB translates as I hope refers to a desire for something to happen. The Greek word usually indicates that the person does not expect it to happen. But Paul was probably speaking ironically here and was hoping that the believers would do as he desired. Other ways to translate this clause are:

I wish (GNT)

I should like (REB)

Please (CEV)

you will bear with: This phrase refers to tolerating something. Paul wanted the believers to allow him to be a little foolish. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

you will put up with (NIV)

you will tolerate/permit/allow

a little of my foolishness: The word little refers here to Paul being foolish for a short time.

foolishness: The Greek word that the BSB translates as foolishness often refers to doing things that make no sense for a good moral person to do. It does not refer here to being intellectually stupid. Paul will praise himself later in his letter. Praising oneself is foolish if the purpose is to make oneself look better than others. But he boasted in this letter to show the believers in Corinth that he could have boasted earlier but had stopped himself from doing so. This was because he had wanted them to believe the gospel because of its truth rather than because of Paul's credentials.

Here some languages may need to express the idea of foolishness in different ways. For example:

silly boasting

foolishly praising myself

11:1b

but you are already doing that.

- Indeed, allow me to do that.
- Look/Yes, let me do so/that!

but: The Greek words here are literally “but even.” The second word emphasizes the clause that follows. For example:

but indeed (NASB)

you are already doing that: The Greek words are literally “you^(plur) tolerate me” or “tolerate me.” The word “tolerate” is the same word as in 11:1a that the BSB translates as “bear with.”

The Greek clause here can either be a statement or a command. There are two ways to interpret this clause:

1. It is a command (or request) to tolerate Paul's foolishness. For example:

Do bear with me! (RSV) (RSV, GNT, NABRE, NLT, CEV, REB, ESV, KJV)

1. It is a statement that the believers were already tolerating Paul's foolishness. For example:

you are bearing with me (NASB) (BSB, NIV, NJB, NASB, GW, NET, NCV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Harris (p. 730) translates the Greek text as “Yes, do put up with me!” He says it is “an unambiguous request...an imperative” (p. 733). Thrall translates it as “Now do tolerate me” (p. 659). She believes that the context suggests the imperative. Martin translates it as “Yes, please put up with me!” (p. 327). Other ways to translate this clause following interpretation (1) are:

Please try and tolerate me

Please do! (GNT)

2 Corinthians 11:2

Section 11:1-15: Paul spoke against the false teachers

In 11:1, Paul prepared his readers for what he would say in 11:7-10 and 11:16. He described the way he would speak as “foolishness.” Paul used the term “foolishness” here in a special way. In this chapter Paul said he was “foolish” because he praised himself for his own good character, attitudes, and actions. He called this praise “foolish” especially because he had just said in 10:17-18 that believers should not praise themselves.

Paul was very concerned for the believers in Corinth, like a father wanting his daughter to be faithful to the man whom she would marry one day (11:2). In the same way he worried that the false teachers might have led the believers away from following Jesus (11:3-4).

Since the false teachers had deceived some of the believers in Corinth, Paul had to defend himself to the believers (11:5-6). The false teachers had praised themselves and some of the believers had believed them, so Paul had to praise himself. He reminded them that he had not allowed them to support him. He wanted them to know that he was serving them because he truly loved them and wanted to help them, unlike the false teachers.

In Greek culture, a teacher expected those whom he taught to support him. It was an honor to support a well-known teacher. But Paul had not let the believers in Corinth support him. Using irony, Paul asked them if they were upset about his not letting them support him (11:7). Using irony again, he told them that churches in other cities had supported him while he lived in Corinth so that he could serve them full time (11:8–9). But the false teachers probably did the culturally expected thing and accepted money from the believers. Paul explained that he loved the believers in Corinth and therefore had not accepted their money (11:10–11). This example of love showed that the false teachers were not equals with Paul as apostles (11:12). He described the false teachers as claiming to be apostles while actually following Satan (11:13–15).

Other examples for this section heading are:

Paul Contrasts Himself With False Apostles (GW)

Paul and His Opponents (NET)

11:2a

I am jealous for you with a godly jealousy.

- For I am jealous for you with the jealousy of God himself. (NLT)
- I tell you to do that because I am concerned about you^(plur) like God is.
- I am concerned about you, just as God is,

11:2 begins with a Greek conjunction that is often translated as “for” or “because.” Here it probably introduces the reason why Paul asked them to endure his foolishness. For example:

For (NASB)

My reason is that

I ask this because

Many English versions, including the BSB, allow the context to indicate the connection and omit the conjunction.

I am jealous for you: The Greek word that the BSB translates as jealous indicates concern or zeal for someone to do the right thing. Paul had zeal for the believers in Corinth to follow God and reject the false teachers. Other ways to translate this clause are:

I am...concerned about you (CEV)

I'm protective of you (GW)

I greatly/strongly desire/want you to follow Christ completely/exclusively

a godly jealousy: This phrase is literally “jealousy of God.” It implies that Paul’s feelings about the Corinthians were like the feelings that God has about his people. God is concerned for them. He protects them. He wants them to worship only him. When they begin to follow idols or false teachings, God has often used the metaphor of a husband jealous for his wife who acted like a prostitute. God wants his people to return to him. Paul had that same kind of feelings for the church in Corinth. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

God’s own jealousy (NJB)

the jealousy of God himself (NLT)

11:2b

For I promised you to one husband, to present you as a pure virgin to Christ.

- I promised you as a pure bride to one husband—Christ. (NLT)
- I promised to give you to Christ, as your only husband. I want to give you as his pure bride. (NCV)
- for/because I promised to give/present you to Christ as a people devoted to him, and to him alone. This is like a father gives/presents his daughter to her husband when they marry.

For: 11:2b begins with the Greek conjunction that the BSB translates literally as For. It introduces the reason why he is so zealous. Other ways to translate this word are:

because (NET)

since (ESV)

Many English versions allow the context to indicate the connection and omit the conjunction.

I promised you to one husband, to present you as a pure virgin to Christ: This is a metaphor. Paul had promised the believers in Corinth to Christ. He compared that with a father presenting his daughter as a pure virgin to a man in marriage. Paul wanted the

believers to follow Christ completely and no one else. Other ways to translate this are:

you are like a pure virgin whom I have promised in marriage to one man only, Christ himself (GNT)

I promised you as a pure bride to one husband—Christ (NLT)

I promised to give you to Christ, as your only husband. I want to give you as his pure bride. (NCV)

In some languages the meaning of this metaphor is not clear. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Change the metaphor to a simile. For example:

I promised to give you to Christ, and to him alone, as a father gives his daughter as a pure virgin to her husband when they marry

I promised to present you to Christ as a people devoted to him, and to him alone. This is like the way a father presents his daughter to her husband when they marry

- Translate the meaning without the metaphor. For example:

I promised to give/present you to Christ, as a people devoted only/completely to him. You may then want to give the literal words in a footnote. An example footnote is:

Literally “I promised you to one husband, to Christ, so that I might present you as a pure virgin to him.”

a pure virgin: Here this phrase refers to a woman who has not had sexual relations. In the metaphor, it refers to the believers following only Jesus and not following any false teachings.

Christ: The word Christ is a title for Jesus. The word Christ literally means “the anointed one.” Translate the word Christ here as you did in 1:1.

2 Corinthians 11:3

Section 11:1–15: Paul spoke against the false teachers

In 11:1, Paul prepared his readers for what he would say in 11:7–10 and 11:16. He described the way he would speak as “foolishness.” Paul used the term “foolishness” here in a special way. In this chapter Paul said he was “foolish” because he praised himself for his own good character, attitudes, and actions. He called this praise “foolish” especially because he had just said in 10:17–18 that believers should not praise themselves.

Paul was very concerned for the believers in Corinth, like a father wanting his daughter to be faithful to the man whom she would marry one day (11:2). In the same way he worried that the false teachers might have led the believers away from following Jesus (11:3–4).

Since the false teachers had deceived some of the believers in Corinth, Paul had to defend himself to the believers (11:5–6). The false teachers had praised themselves and some of the believers had believed them, so Paul had to praise himself. He reminded them that he had not allowed them to support him. He wanted them to know that he was serving them because he truly loved them and wanted to help them, unlike the false teachers.

In Greek culture, a teacher expected those whom he taught to support him. It was an honor to support a well-known teacher. But Paul had not let the believers in Corinth support him. Using irony, Paul asked them if they were upset about his not letting them support him (11:7). Using irony again, he told them that churches in other cities had supported him while he lived in Corinth so that he could serve them full time (11:8–9). But the false teachers probably did the culturally expected thing and accepted money from the believers. Paul explained that he loved the believers in Corinth and therefore had not accepted their money (11:10–11). This example of love showed that the false teachers were not equals with Paul as apostles (11:12). He described the false teachers as claiming to be apostles while actually following Satan (11:13–15).

Other examples for this section heading are:

Paul Contrasts Himself With False Apostles (GW)

Paul and His Opponents (NET)

11:3a–c

I am afraid, however, that just as Eve was deceived by the serpent’s cunning, your minds may be led

astray from your simple and pure devotion to Christ: The comparison with Eve and the serpent is in the middle of what Paul said he was worried about. In some languages it is more natural to have the comparison before or after it. For example:

But just as Eve was deceived by the serpent's cunning, I am afraid that your minds may somehow be led astray from your sincere and pure devotion to Christ

But I am afraid that your minds may somehow be led astray from your sincere and pure devotion to Christ, just as Eve was deceived by the serpent's cunning

11:3a

I am afraid, however, that just as Eve was deceived by the serpent's cunning,

- But I am afraid that, as the serpent deceived Eve by his clever lies,
- However, just like when the snake deceived Eve with guile, I feel anxious that

Eve was deceived by the serpent's cunning: This story is in Genesis 3:1-19. Paul used this story as an example of being deceived.

In the BSB, this clause is passive. The Greek clause is active, and many English versions translate it that way. For example:

the serpent deceived Eve by his cunning (RSV)

Eve: Eve was the first woman (Genesis 2:22, 3:20). In some languages people are not familiar with who Eve is. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Explain in your translation. For example:

the first woman Eve

- Explain in a footnote. An example footnote is:

Eve was the first woman.

the serpent's: The word "serpent" refers generally to any kind of snake.

cunning: This word refers to the ability to deceive people. Other ways to translate this word are:

craftiness (NASB)

clever lies (GNT)

deceitful ways

11:3b

your minds may be led astray

- your^(plur) thinking might be led away
- someone might pull you astray/away

your minds may be led astray: This clause is passive. Some languages must use an active clause. Paul means that the false teachers might lead them astray. But since they are not named here, you may want to refer generally to people. For example:

someone might lead you astray

your minds: The Greek word that the BSB translates as minds is literally "thoughts." For example:

your thoughts (RSV)

Some languages must refer to people being led astray, not thoughts or minds. For example:

you

11:3c

from your simple and pure devotion to Christ.

- from following Christ in a genuine and uncontaminated way.
- from frankly/honestly and completely serving/obeying/honoring Christ.

your simple and pure devotion to Christ: There are two issues here:

Issue 1: Greek manuscripts

There is a textual issue here:

1. Some Greek manuscripts have the Greek phrase that means and pure. (BSB, RSV, NIV, GNT, NLT, NET, ESV)
2. Some Greek manuscripts do not have that phrase. (NJB, GW, REB, KJV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1), since the UBS Greek New Testament recommends it. But it does say that the Committee had difficulty in deciding.

Issue 2: Meaning

The Greek words are literally "the sincerity and the purity in Christ." In their relationship with Christ, the

believers were both sincere and pure. They did not try to lie to Jesus. They followed him and no one else. Other ways to translate this are:

the sincere and pure relationship you have with Christ

your true and pure following of Christ (NCV)

2 Corinthians 11:4

Section 11:1–15: Paul spoke against the false teachers

In 11:1, Paul prepared his readers for what he would say in 11:7–10 and 11:16. He described the way he would speak as “foolishness.” Paul used the term “foolishness” here in a special way. In this chapter Paul said he was “foolish” because he praised himself for his own good character, attitudes, and actions. He called this praise “foolish” especially because he had just said in 10:17–18 that believers should not praise themselves.

Paul was very concerned for the believers in Corinth, like a father wanting his daughter to be faithful to the man whom she would marry one day (11:2). In the same way he worried that the false teachers might have led the believers away from following Jesus (11:3–4).

Since the false teachers had deceived some of the believers in Corinth, Paul had to defend himself to the believers (11:5–6). The false teachers had praised themselves and some of the believers had believed them, so Paul had to praise himself. He reminded them that he had not allowed them to support him. He wanted them to know that he was serving them because he truly loved them and wanted to help them, unlike the false teachers.

In Greek culture, a teacher expected those whom he taught to support him. It was an honor to support a well-known teacher. But Paul had not let the believers in Corinth support him. Using irony, Paul asked them if they were upset about his not letting them support him (11:7). Using irony again, he told them that churches in other cities had supported him while he lived in Corinth so that he could serve them full time (11:8–9). But the false teachers probably did the culturally expected thing and accepted money from the believers. Paul explained that he loved the believers in Corinth and therefore had not accepted their money (11:10–11). This example of love showed that the false teachers were not equals with Paul as apostles (11:12). He described the false teachers as claiming to be apostles while actually following Satan (11:13–15).

Other examples for this section heading are:

Paul Contrasts Himself With False Apostles (GW)

Paul and His Opponents (NET)

11:4a–e

For if someone comes and proclaims a Jesus other than the One we proclaimed, or if you receive a different spirit than the One you received, or a different gospel than the one you accepted, you put up with it way too easily: Paul used the words For if rhetorically to cause the believers in Corinth to consider those situations in which someone had preached a different gospel. At that time the false teachers had preached things that disagreed with what Paul taught about Jesus and the gospel.

In some languages using the word if indicates that no such situations have happened yet. If that is true in your language, translate the correct meaning. For example:

For you gladly tolerate anyone who comes to you and preaches a different Jesus, not the one we preached; and you accept a spirit and a gospel completely different from the Spirit and the gospel you received from us! (GNT)

whenever anyone comes to you and preaches a Jesus other than the Jesus we preached, or whenever you receive a different spirit from the one you received, or a different gospel from the one you accepted, you put up with it easily enough

11:4a

For if someone comes and proclaims

- Because if anyone comes to you^(plur)
- Whenever someone comes to you
- For someone arrives among you

For: This conjunction may:

1. Introduce the reason for the fear Paul had that the false teachers had led the believers in Corinth away from proper faith and doctrine (11:3).
2. Introduce a second reason for tolerating his temporary foolishness (11:1). Since they tolerate the false teachers, they should also tolerate his foolishness.

You should translate the connection that indicates (1), or possibly both (1) and (2). For example:

Because (NJB)

For this reason

The reason I am worried about you is that

11:4b

a Jesus other than the One we proclaimed,

- and preaches a different Jesus, not the one we preached, (GNT)
- and proclaims things about Jesus that disagree with what we^(excl) proclaimed,
- and preaches a different meaning about Jesus' sayings and deeds than our preaching.

proclaims a Jesus other than the One we proclaimed: The false teachers changed the meaning of what Jesus did and said. It was different from what Paul taught about Jesus. Other ways to translate this are:

preaches a different Jesus, not the one we preached (GNT)

proclaims things about Jesus that disagree with what we preached

preaches a different meaning about Jesus' sayings and deeds than we did

proclaims: This word means "announces" or "preaches." For example:

preaches (NIV)

See how you translated this word in 1:19 or 4:5.

11:4c

or if you receive a different spirit than the One you received,

- or if you accept a different spirit, not the one you accepted from us,
- or you agree to a different spirit than the Holy Spirit whom we taught you about,
- He tells you about a different spirit than the Holy Spirit, the spirit we had told you about earlier and you accepted.

if you receive a different spirit than the One you received: Here the word spirit can refer to:

1. An evil spirit. The false teachers follow an evil spirit rather than the Holy Spirit. For example:

you accept a spirit...completely different from the Spirit (GNT) (GNT, NIV11, NLT, GW, CEV, REB, NCV)

1. A way of living or thinking. The false teachers taught different ways to live and different attitudes than Paul. Hughes (on TW) says, "a spirit, perhaps... of human wisdom and gnosis (1 Cor. 2:12) (and)... bondage." Kruse (p. 185) says, "The spirit in which Paul's opponents operated was authoritarian and overbearing (11:20), and as far as Paul was concerned drew its inspiration from Satan (11:13-15)." For example:

adopt a different outlook on life that disagrees with what we taught

receive a different teaching/doctrine about how to live than you did from us

The BSB, RSV, NIV, NJB, ESV, NASB, NET, JBP, and KJV can refer to either interpretation (1) or (2). It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because the phrase a different spirit occurs with "a Jesus other than the One we proclaimed" and "a different gospel" in this verse, so Paul is likely thinking of a substitute for the Holy Spirit. Harris (p. 744). Hodge, Bruce, and Martin also support interpretation (1).

Here is another way to translate this according to interpretation (1):

you receive/accept a different spirit, not the one you received/accepted from us

receive: Here the word receive refers to accepting what someone says as true. For example:

accept (ESV)

acknowledge as true

11:4d

or a different gospel than the one you accepted,

- or if you accept a different gospel, not the one you accepted from us,
- or news different from the good news about Jesus,
- He tells you what he calls the gospel of Jesus but it is different from what we taught you earlier and you accepted.

or a different gospel than the one you accepted: The words "if you receive" are implied from 11:4c but

are not repeated here. In some languages it is more natural to repeat some or all of the implied words. For example:

or if you receive/accept a different gospel from the one you accepted

a different gospel than the one you accepted: The false teachers changed some of the teachings in the gospel of Jesus to their own teachings. So their gospel was different or false. Other ways to translate this are:

a false gospel, not the one you received/accepted from us

adopt a different gospel about Jesus that disagrees with what we taught

receive a different meaning to the good news about Jesus than you received/did from us

a changed/deceitful message about Jesus that is different from the one you accepted from us

their own lies that they claim to be the good news concerning Jesus as opposed to the true gospel that you received from us

gospel: You may not be able to translate gospel in the usual way here. See the note and examples above.

General Comment on 11:4c–d

It may be natural to combine 11:4c and 11:4d and so omit “from the one you accepted” in 11:4d, because words with the same meaning occur in 11:4c. For example:

^{4c}or if you receive a different spirit ^{4d}or a different gospel ^{4c}from the one you received

11:4e

you put up with it way too easily.

- that is wrong, but you do it eagerly!
- you wrongly accept it wholeheartedly!
- And you change your mind and accept these differences/changes! That is wrong!

you put up with it way too easily: The Greek indicates that Paul used irony here. He wrote as if to commend them for tolerating the false teachers. But he was

actually rebuking them for doing that. Translate in a way that clearly shows the irony. For example:

you bear this beautifully (NASB)

you eagerly accept it

You happily put up with whatever anyone tells you (NLT)

In some languages the irony must be explained in the translation so that the correct meaning is clear. Your translation should indicate a rebuke. For example:

you wrongly accept it wholeheartedly!

Why do you accept it? That is wrong!

you put up with: These words refer to tolerating something. Other ways to translate this are:

you submit to (RSV)

you tolerate/permit/allow

it: The BSB adds the pronoun it for natural English. This pronoun refers to the false teachings regarding the “different” Jesus, spirit, and gospel. Other ways to translate this word are:

that (REB)

those things

those false teachings

2 Corinthians 11:5

Section 11:1–15: Paul spoke against the false teachers

In 11:1, Paul prepared his readers for what he would say in 11:7–10 and 11:16. He described the way he would speak as “foolishness.” Paul used the term “foolishness” here in a special way. In this chapter Paul said he was “foolish” because he praised himself for his own good character, attitudes, and actions. He called this praise “foolish” especially because he had just said in 10:17–18 that believers should not praise themselves.

Paul was very concerned for the believers in Corinth, like a father wanting his daughter to be faithful to the man whom she would marry one day (11:2). In the same way he worried that the false teachers might have led the believers away from following Jesus (11:3–4).

Since the false teachers had deceived some of the believers in Corinth, Paul had to defend himself to the believers (11:5–6). The false teachers had praised themselves and some of the believers had believed them, so Paul had to praise himself. He reminded them that he had not allowed them to support him. He wanted them to know that he was serving them because he truly loved them and wanted to help them, unlike the false teachers.

In Greek culture, a teacher expected those whom he taught to support him. It was an honor to support a well-known teacher. But Paul had not let the believers in Corinth support him. Using irony, Paul asked them if they were upset about his not letting them support him (11:7). Using irony again, he told them that churches in other cities had supported him while he lived in Corinth so that he could serve them full time (11:8–9). But the false teachers probably did the culturally expected thing and accepted money from the believers. Paul explained that he loved the believers in Corinth and therefore had not accepted their money (11:10–11). This example of love showed that the false teachers were not equals with Paul as apostles (11:12). He described the false teachers as claiming to be apostles while actually following Satan (11:13–15).

Other examples for this section heading are:

Paul Contrasts Himself With False Apostles (GW)

Paul and His Opponents (NET)

11:5

I consider myself in no way inferior to those “super-apostles.”

- For I consider/believe that none of those very superior/special “apostles” is in any way superior to me.
- Also, I think I have done as much or more than those who wrongly act like they have authority over all the chosen messengers of Jesus Christ.

The Greek begins this verse with a word that is often translated as “for” or “because.” It introduces another reason why the believers in Corinth should listen to Paul (11:1). In some languages the most natural way to indicate that connection may be:

- Use the conjunction “for” here. For example:

For (NASB)

- Allow the context to imply a general connection and omit the conjunction. For example:

I do not... (GNT)

- Use the conjunction “and” or “now” to connect this verse to the other reasons in 11:2–4. For example:

Also,

Now (NJB)

- Use the conjunction “but” to connect this verse to the reason in 11:4 but indicate contrast to it. For example:

Yet (JBP)

I consider myself in no way inferior to: The false teachers probably claimed to have much power and authority, but Paul knew that God had given as much and actually more power and authority to him. So he did not think of himself as having a lower status than the status that the false teachers claimed for themselves. Other ways to translate this are:

I consider that I am not in the least inferior to (NJB)

I think I am as good as (CEV)

those “super-apostles”: The phrase super-apostles is sarcasm. It refers to the false teachers. The phrase means “better than all other apostles.” With this phrase, Paul mocked them and their attitude of thinking that they were better than Paul. The BSB puts quotes around the words super-apostles to indicate the sarcasm more clearly in English. Translate this phrase so that it clearly shows the sarcasm. For example:

those very special so-called “apostles” (GNT)

those “great apostles” (NCV)

those who are reportedly the highest apostles

those very superior/special “apostle.”

In some languages the sarcasm must be explained in your translation to indicate the correct meaning. Your translation should indicate that Paul is mocking them. For example:

those who act as if they are the greatest of all apostles

those who behave as if they were the apostles greater than all others

those greatest apostles, if only in their attitude toward others

apostles: The Greek word that the BSB translates as apostles means “ambassadors” or “messengers.” Here, apostles are people whom Jesus sends to represent him and teach his message with authority. See how you translated this word in 1:1. Or see the word apostle in the Glossary.

2 Corinthians 11:6

Section 11:1–15: Paul spoke against the false teachers

In 11:1, Paul prepared his readers for what he would say in 11:7–10 and 11:16. He described the way he would speak as “foolishness.” Paul used the term “foolishness” here in a special way. In this chapter Paul said he was “foolish” because he praised himself for his own good character, attitudes, and actions. He called this praise “foolish” especially because he had just said in 10:17–18 that believers should not praise themselves.

Paul was very concerned for the believers in Corinth, like a father wanting his daughter to be faithful to the man whom she would marry one day (11:2). In the same way he worried that the false teachers might have led the believers away from following Jesus (11:3–4).

Since the false teachers had deceived some of the believers in Corinth, Paul had to defend himself to the believers (11:5–6). The false teachers had praised themselves and some of the believers had believed them, so Paul had to praise himself. He reminded them that he had not allowed them to support him. He wanted them to know that he was serving them because he truly loved them and wanted to help them, unlike the false teachers.

In Greek culture, a teacher expected those whom he taught to support him. It was an honor to support a well-known teacher. But Paul had not let the believ-

ers in Corinth support him. Using irony, Paul asked them if they were upset about his not letting them support him (11:7). Using irony again, he told them that churches in other cities had supported him while he lived in Corinth so that he could serve them full time (11:8–9). But the false teachers probably did the culturally expected thing and accepted money from the believers. Paul explained that he loved the believers in Corinth and therefore had not accepted their money (11:10–11). This example of love showed that the false teachers were not equals with Paul as apostles (11:12). He described the false teachers as claiming to be apostles while actually following Satan (11:13–15).

Other examples for this section heading are:

Paul Contrasts Himself With False Apostles (GW)

Paul and His Opponents (NET)

11:6a

Although I am not a polished speaker, I am certainly not lacking in knowledge.

- I may be untrained in public speaking, but I have knowledge about Christ.
- Perhaps I am not an expert in public speaking, yet I certainly do know about Christ.

Although I am not a polished speaker: The Greek words are literally “But even if untrained in speaking.” While Paul would disagree that “his speaking is of no account” (10:10d), he did admit here that he did not have the training of a professional speaker. He was not an expert at speaking in the Greek oratory style. The false teachers may have had such training and so were able to convince some people in Corinth of their lies with their clever speeches. But Paul purposely spoke plainly rather than cleverly (1 Corinthians 2:4–5). Other ways to translate this clause are:

I may be untrained in speech (NRSV)

But even if I am an unskilled speaker

Perhaps I am not an expert in speaking

I am certainly not lacking in knowledge: The Greek words indicate that Paul had great knowledge. God revealed much knowledge to him. Other ways to translate this are:

I’m not lacking in knowledge (NLT)

I know what I'm talking about (GW)

I thoroughly understand what I am teaching

I know the true doctrine/teaching well

knowledge: This word refers to knowledge about Jesus and his gospel. Paul had not lived with Jesus during Jesus' three years of earthly ministry, but God had revealed many things to him about Jesus and his gospel.

In some languages a literal translation would wrongly refer to general knowledge. If that is true in your language, you may want to include some implied information. For example:

knowledge about Christ

11:6b

We have made this clear to you in every way possible.

- In every way we have made this plain to you in all things. (RSV)
- We^(excl) have made it clear to you^(plur) that we have that knowledge in every detail about the Christ using every teaching method.

We have made this clear to you in every way possible: The Greek words are literally "in every way we have made that clear to you in all things." Paul showed the believers that he had knowledge of every detail of Jesus and the gospel. He did this using every method of teaching he knew. Other ways to translate this are:

in every way we have made this plain to you in all things (RSV)

We have made it clear that we have that knowledge in every situation and in every detail

We have shown you that knowledge using every teaching method in regard to anything about the Christ

2 Corinthians 11:7

Section 11:1–15: Paul spoke against the false teachers

In 11:1, Paul prepared his readers for what he would say in 11:7–10 and 11:16. He described the way he would speak as "foolishness." Paul used the term "foolish-

ness" here in a special way. In this chapter Paul said he was "foolish" because he praised himself for his own good character, attitudes, and actions. He called this praise "foolish" especially because he had just said in 10:17–18 that believers should not praise themselves.

Paul was very concerned for the believers in Corinth, like a father wanting his daughter to be faithful to the man whom she would marry one day (11:2). In the same way he worried that the false teachers might have led the believers away from following Jesus (11:3–4).

Since the false teachers had deceived some of the believers in Corinth, Paul had to defend himself to the believers (11:5–6). The false teachers had praised themselves and some of the believers had believed them, so Paul had to praise himself. He reminded them that he had not allowed them to support him. He wanted them to know that he was serving them because he truly loved them and wanted to help them, unlike the false teachers.

In Greek culture, a teacher expected those whom he taught to support him. It was an honor to support a well-known teacher. But Paul had not let the believers in Corinth support him. Using irony, Paul asked them if they were upset about his not letting them support him (11:7). Using irony again, he told them that churches in other cities had supported him while he lived in Corinth so that he could serve them full time (11:8–9). But the false teachers probably did the culturally expected thing and accepted money from the believers. Paul explained that he loved the believers in Corinth and therefore had not accepted their money (11:10–11). This example of love showed that the false teachers were not equals with Paul as apostles (11:12). He described the false teachers as claiming to be apostles while actually following Satan (11:13–15).

Other examples for this section heading are:

Paul Contrasts Himself With False Apostles (GW)

Paul and His Opponents (NET)

11:7a–b

Was it a sin for me to humble myself in order to exalt you, because I preached the gospel of God to you free of charge?: This is a rhetorical question. It emphasizes the fact that it was not a sin for Paul to lower himself in order to elevate the believers. Translate this with that meaning. Some ways to translate it are:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Could it possibly be a sin for me to lower myself in order to elevate you by preaching the gospel of God to you free of charge?

How can it be a sin for me to lower myself in order to elevate you by preaching the gospel of God to you free of charge?

I did not charge you a thing when I preached the Good News of God to you; I humbled myself in order to make you important. Was that wrong of me? (GNT)

- As a statement. For example:

It was certainly not a sin for me to lower myself in order to elevate you by preaching the gospel of God to you free of charge.

- As a command. For example:

Do not think that I sinned when I lowered myself in order to elevate you by preaching the gospel of God to you free of charge!

11:7a

Was it a sin for me to humble myself in order to exalt you,

- ¶ Can it be that I sinned when I humbled myself in order to cause you^(plur) to have high status,
- ¶ Surely I did not sin when I humbled myself so that you might be exalted/honored,

humble myself: This phrase refers to Paul humbling himself. He did not act like a worldly leader and make demands. Instead he served them and supported himself by making tents (Acts 18:1–5). Other ways to translate this phrase are:

lower myself (NIV)

I made myself unimportant (NCV)

I did what lower class people do

Paul may have been also thinking of a common Greek attitude. They believed that a free citizen should not do manual labor (such as making tents), because that made him like a slave or lower class person.

in order to exalt you: This phrase refers to causing someone to have high status. Before Paul came, the people in Corinth lived apart from God. Now the believers had a relationship with God through Jesus Christ. So through Paul's ministry, the believers in Corinth became of high status in God's eyes. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

so that you might be raised up (NJB)

in order to make you important (GNT)

in order to give/confer high status to you

11:7b

because I preached the gospel of God to you free of charge?

- which I did by proclaiming the gospel of God without cost to you?
- because I did not accept any pay from you while I preached God's message to you!

the gospel of God: This phrase refers to the good news about Jesus and restoring people's relationship with God. In some languages a literal translation would wrongly refer to something other than the gospel of Jesus. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Explain in your translation. For example:

the gospel of God concerning Jesus

- Translate literally and explain the meaning in a footnote. An example footnote is:

This refers to the gospel of Jesus.

free of charge: This phrase refers to not taking pay. Paul did not allow the Corinthians to give him money when he preached and taught among them. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

without cost (RSV)

without taking money for my work/ministry

Some Greek wise men (Sophists) said that if someone taught without receiving pay, then their teaching was worth nothing. This may have been part of the accusation of those "super-apostles" against Paul.

2 Corinthians 11:8

Section 11:1–15: Paul spoke against the false teachers

In 11:1, Paul prepared his readers for what he would say in 11:7–10 and 11:16. He described the way he would speak as “foolishness.” Paul used the term “foolishness” here in a special way. In this chapter Paul said he was “foolish” because he praised himself for his own good character, attitudes, and actions. He called this praise “foolish” especially because he had just said in 10:17–18 that believers should not praise themselves.

Paul was very concerned for the believers in Corinth, like a father wanting his daughter to be faithful to the man whom she would marry one day (11:2). In the same way he worried that the false teachers might have led the believers away from following Jesus (11:3–4).

Since the false teachers had deceived some of the believers in Corinth, Paul had to defend himself to the believers (11:5–6). The false teachers had praised themselves and some of the believers had believed them, so Paul had to praise himself. He reminded them that he had not allowed them to support him. He wanted them to know that he was serving them because he truly loved them and wanted to help them, unlike the false teachers.

In Greek culture, a teacher expected those whom he taught to support him. It was an honor to support a well-known teacher. But Paul had not let the believers in Corinth support him. Using irony, Paul asked them if they were upset about his not letting them support him (11:7). Using irony again, he told them that churches in other cities had supported him while he lived in Corinth so that he could serve them full time (11:8–9). But the false teachers probably did the culturally expected thing and accepted money from the believers. Paul explained that he loved the believers in Corinth and therefore had not accepted their money (11:10–11). This example of love showed that the false teachers were not equals with Paul as apostles (11:12). He described the false teachers as claiming to be apostles while actually following Satan (11:13–15).

Other examples for this section heading are:

Paul Contrasts Himself With False Apostles (GW)

Paul and His Opponents (NET)

11:8

I robbed other churches by accepting their support in order to serve you.

- I “robbed” other churches by accepting their contributions so I could serve you at no cost. (NLT)
- I received money from other churches so I could help you more of the time. Do not call that robbery!
- It was certainly not wrong when other churches gave money to me so I could minister to you more!

I robbed other churches by accepting their support in order to serve you: Paul used irony here. He wrote as if he had stolen money from other churches. But actually the other churches had given money to Paul willingly. He had accepted this money so that he could spend more time preaching and teaching in Corinth rather than working to earn money.

Paul probably used irony here to show the believers that it was proper for him to preach free of charge in Corinth (11:7b). He did not accept their money, so they did not have the honor of supporting him. In that way some people may have claimed he robbed the believers in the other churches. If possible, show the irony clearly. For example:

I was robbing other churches, taking wages from them in order to work for you (NJB)

It was an act of robbery when I received support from other churches so as to serve you

While I was working among you, I was paid by other churches. I was robbing them, so to speak, in order to help you (GNT)

I became like a thief, taking money from other churches in order to serve you

In some languages the irony must be explained in your translation to indicate the correct meaning. Your translation should indicate that Paul was trying to correct their wrong attitude. For example:

I accepted contributions from other churches so I could serve you at no cost. Do not call that robbery!

I received support from other churches so as to serve you. You should not say that doing so is wrong!

It was certainly not wrong when I received support from other churches so as to serve you!

churches: Here the Greek word that the BSB translates as churches refers generally to more than one gathering of people. Here, as almost always in the New Testament, it refers to groups of believers. See how you translated this word in 1:1 or 8:18.

support: This word refers to money that the other churches gave to Paul so that he could pay for his needs. Other ways to translate this word are:

contributions (NLT)

money (CEV)

serve: This word refers to the work of helping or caring for others. Here the word refers to Paul preaching, teaching, and helping them to believe well in Jesus. For example:

help (GNT)

minister to (JBP)

2 Corinthians 11:9

Section 11:1–15: Paul spoke against the false teachers

In 11:1, Paul prepared his readers for what he would say in 11:7–10 and 11:16. He described the way he would speak as “foolishness.” Paul used the term “foolishness” here in a special way. In this chapter Paul said he was “foolish” because he praised himself for his own good character, attitudes, and actions. He called this praise “foolish” especially because he had just said in 10:17–18 that believers should not praise themselves.

Paul was very concerned for the believers in Corinth, like a father wanting his daughter to be faithful to the man whom she would marry one day (11:2). In the same way he worried that the false teachers might have led the believers away from following Jesus (11:3–4).

Since the false teachers had deceived some of the believers in Corinth, Paul had to defend himself to the believers (11:5–6). The false teachers had praised themselves and some of the believers had believed them, so Paul had to praise himself. He reminded them that he had not allowed them to support him. He wanted them to know that he was serving them because he truly loved them and wanted to help them, unlike the false teachers.

In Greek culture, a teacher expected those whom he taught to support him. It was an honor to support a well-known teacher. But Paul had not let the believ-

ers in Corinth support him. Using irony, Paul asked them if they were upset about his not letting them support him (11:7). Using irony again, he told them that churches in other cities had supported him while he lived in Corinth so that he could serve them full time (11:8–9). But the false teachers probably did the culturally expected thing and accepted money from the believers. Paul explained that he loved the believers in Corinth and therefore had not accepted their money (11:10–11). This example of love showed that the false teachers were not equals with Paul as apostles (11:12). He described the false teachers as claiming to be apostles while actually following Satan (11:13–15).

Other examples for this section heading are:

Paul Contrasts Himself With False Apostles (GW)

Paul and His Opponents (NET)

11:9a

And when I was with you and in need,

- And when I was with you and was in want, (RSV)
- And when I was there with you^(plur) and had no money to buy things I needed,

in need: This phrase refers to lacking money to buy the things Paul needed for daily living. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

in want (RSV)

needed money (GNT)

didn't have enough to live on (NLT)

11:9b

I was not a burden to anyone;

- I did not trouble any of you for money/help,
- I did not cause difficulty for anyone among you by asking him for support,

I was not a burden to anyone: The word burden refers figuratively to causing difficulty for someone. Here it refers to needing money. If Paul asked for money, the believers might have lacked money for their own needs. Other ways to translate this clause are:

I did not become a financial burden to anyone (NLT)

I did not trouble any of you (NCV)

I still did not bother any of you by asking you to help/support me

anyone: Here this word refers to any believer in Corinth. Other ways to translate this are:

any of you (NCV)

any of you believers in Corinth

11:9c
for the brothers who came from Macedonia supplied my needs.

- for brothers came from Macedonia and fully supplied my needs.
- because the fellow-believers who came from Macedonia brought enough money for me to buy everything I needed to live on.

for: This conjunction introduces an explanation of why Paul was not a burden to anyone in Corinth (11:9b).

the brothers: Here the word brothers refers to believers in Jesus. The word indicates a close relationship, because all believers become children of God. See how you translated this word in 1:1 or 9:5. Here the word probably refers only to men.

Macedonia: This name refers to a Roman province that today would include the northern part of the country of Greece and the land a bit farther north.

In some languages people are not familiar with this name. If that is true in your language, you may want to explain it here. For example:

the province of Macedonia (GW)

However, if you explained in 1:16a or 8:1b that the name Macedonia refers to a province, you may not want to explain again here.

supplied my needs: This phrase refers to the believers from Macedonia giving Paul enough money so he could buy the things he needed. The Greek verb implies fully supplying his needs. For example:

fully supplied my needs (NET)

gave me everything that I lacked

11:9d

I have refrained from being a burden to you in any way,

- I avoided being any trouble to you in any way,
- In every way I prevented myself from being a difficulty to you,

11:9e

and I will continue to do so.

- and I will continue to do that.
- and I will continue to prevent myself from being a difficulty to you.

11:9d-e

I have refrained from being a burden: Paul used the word refrained to refer to preventing himself from being a burden. Either Paul worked to earn money or believers from Macedonia helped him. In either case, he was not a burden to the believers in Corinth. Other ways to translate this clause are:

I refrained...from burdening you (RSV)

I did not allow myself to depend on you (NCV)

2 Corinthians 11:10

Section 11:1-15: Paul spoke against the false teachers

In 11:1, Paul prepared his readers for what he would say in 11:7-10 and 11:16. He described the way he would speak as “foolishness.” Paul used the term “foolishness” here in a special way. In this chapter Paul said he was “foolish” because he praised himself for his own good character, attitudes, and actions. He called this praise “foolish” especially because he had just said in 10:17-18 that believers should not praise themselves.

Paul was very concerned for the believers in Corinth, like a father wanting his daughter to be faithful to the man whom she would marry one day (11:2). In the same way he worried that the false teachers might have led the believers away from following Jesus (11:3-4).

Since the false teachers had deceived some of the believers in Corinth, Paul had to defend himself to the believers (11:5-6). The false teachers had praised themselves and some of the believers had believed them, so Paul had to praise himself. He reminded them that he had not allowed them to support him. He wanted them to know that he was serving them because he truly loved them and wanted to help them, unlike the false teachers.

In Greek culture, a teacher expected those whom he taught to support him. It was an honor to support a

well-known teacher. But Paul had not let the believers in Corinth support him. Using irony, Paul asked them if they were upset about his not letting them support him (11:7). Using irony again, he told them that churches in other cities had supported him while he lived in Corinth so that he could serve them full time (11:8–9). But the false teachers probably did the culturally expected thing and accepted money from the believers. Paul explained that he loved the believers in Corinth and therefore had not accepted their money (11:10–11). This example of love showed that the false teachers were not equals with Paul as apostles (11:12). He described the false teachers as claiming to be apostles while actually following Satan (11:13–15).

Other examples for this section heading are:

Paul Contrasts Himself With False Apostles (GW)

Paul and His Opponents (NET)

11:10a

As surely as the truth of Christ is in me,

- In the same way that Christ's truth is in me,
- Just as the truth that Christ spoke resides in my heart/mind,

As surely as the truth of Christ is in me: These words are like an oath. They indicate that 11:10b is true just as this saying is true. Other ways to translate this are:

In the same way that the truth of Christ is in me

As surely as I speak the truth about Christ (CEV)

Just as the truth of Christ resides in my heart/
mind

the truth of Christ: This phrase refers to the truth that Jesus Christ gave. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

Christ's truth (GNT)

the truth from Christ

the truth that is in Christ

11:10b

this boasting of mine will not be silenced in the regions of Achaia.

- this boast of mine shall not be silenced throughout Achaia.
- no one in the districts of Achaia will block/prevent that boast of mine.

this boasting of mine will not be silenced: The Greek words are literally "this boasting will not be silenced in me." No person or circumstance would prevent Paul from boasting. The word boasting refers here to God providing for him so that he was not a burden to the believers in Corinth. Other ways to translate this are:

this boast of mine shall not be silenced (RSV)

nothing shall bar me from boasting about this (REB)

no one will prevent me from bragging about this

nobody will keep me from proudly claiming this

this boasting of mine: Paul referred here to his boast that he was not being a burden to the believers in Corinth. Some languages must say what he boasted about. If that is true in your language, refer to that meaning. For example:

this boast of mine about not being a burden to
you

boasting: This word refers to praising someone or saying how good someone is. Normally a person would not speak highly of himself. That is not the proper thing to do. In this context Paul chose not to boast about himself but made it clear that if he did, he would be telling the truth. Other ways to translate this word are:

speaking very highly about

praising

telling about how great/wonderful/good

See how you translated this word in 1:12 or 10:13.

the regions of Achaia: Achaia is a province, so the word regions refers to areas in that province. Here Paul probably implied all the places in the province. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

the districts of Achaia

all of Achaia (GNT)

2 Corinthians 11:11

Section 11:1–15: Paul spoke against the false teachers

In 11:1, Paul prepared his readers for what he would say in 11:7–10 and 11:16. He described the way he would speak as “foolishness.” Paul used the term “foolishness” here in a special way. In this chapter Paul said he was “foolish” because he praised himself for his own good character, attitudes, and actions. He called this praise “foolish” especially because he had just said in 10:17–18 that believers should not praise themselves.

Paul was very concerned for the believers in Corinth, like a father wanting his daughter to be faithful to the man whom she would marry one day (11:2). In the same way he worried that the false teachers might have led the believers away from following Jesus (11:3–4).

Since the false teachers had deceived some of the believers in Corinth, Paul had to defend himself to the believers (11:5–6). The false teachers had praised themselves and some of the believers had believed them, so Paul had to praise himself. He reminded them that he had not allowed them to support him. He wanted them to know that he was serving them because he truly loved them and wanted to help them, unlike the false teachers.

In Greek culture, a teacher expected those whom he taught to support him. It was an honor to support a well-known teacher. But Paul had not let the believers in Corinth support him. Using irony, Paul asked them if they were upset about his not letting them support him (11:7). Using irony again, he told them that churches in other cities had supported him while he lived in Corinth so that he could serve them full time (11:8–9). But the false teachers probably did the culturally expected thing and accepted money from the believers. Paul explained that he loved the believers in Corinth and therefore had not accepted their money (11:10–11). This example of love showed that the false teachers were not equals with Paul as apostles (11:12). He described the false teachers as claiming to be apostles while actually following Satan (11:13–15).

Other examples for this section heading are:

Paul Contrasts Himself With False Apostles (GW)

Paul and His Opponents (NET)

11:11a

Why? Because I do not love you?

- Why, because I do not love you?^(plur)
- Why did I not take your money? Did I do that because I do not love you?
- Think of the reason why I was not a burden to you! It certainly is not because I do not love you.

Why?: This question probably connects to 11:9d–e and asks: “Why (did I avoid being a burden to you)?” In some languages it may be necessary to include the implied information. For example:

Why was I not a burden to you?

Why did I not take your money?

This is a rhetorical question. It causes the readers to think about a possible reason why Paul did not accept their money. Translate in a way that emphasizes that meaning. Some ways to translate this are:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Why should it be? (NJB)

And why do I not depend on you? (NCV)

- As a command. For example:

Think of the reason why I was not a burden to you!

Because I do not love you?: This question also has implied information. It asks: “(Did I avoid being a burden to you) Because I do not love you?” Paul avoided being a burden to the believers in Corinth for other reasons, not because he did not love them. In some languages it may be necessary to include the implied information. For example:

Was I not a burden to you because I do not love you?

Is it that I do not love you and therefore did not take your money?

This is a rhetorical question. It emphasizes the fact that Paul avoided being a burden to the believers because he loved them. Translate these words so that they emphasize that meaning. Some ways to translate this are:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Does this mean that I do not love you? (JBP)

Do you think it is because I do not love you? (NCV)
See also the two examples at the beginning of this note.

- As a statement. For example:

And it isn't because I don't love you. (CEV)

I certainly did not become a burden to you because I do not love you!

- As a command. For example:

Do not think that I was not a burden to you because I do not love you!

11:11b

God knows I do!

- God knows that I do!
- God knows that I love you!

God knows I do: Paul emphasized that he loved the believers in Corinth by adding the words God knows. The clause indicates that God knew that Paul loved them.

2 Corinthians 11:12

Section 11:1–15: Paul spoke against the false teachers

In 11:1, Paul prepared his readers for what he would say in 11:7–10 and 11:16. He described the way he would speak as “foolishness.” Paul used the term “foolishness” here in a special way. In this chapter Paul said he was “foolish” because he praised himself for his own good character, attitudes, and actions. He called this praise “foolish” especially because he had just said in 10:17–18 that believers should not praise themselves.

Paul was very concerned for the believers in Corinth, like a father wanting his daughter to be faithful to the man whom she would marry one day (11:2). In the same way he worried that the false teachers might have led the believers away from following Jesus (11:3–4).

Since the false teachers had deceived some of the believers in Corinth, Paul had to defend himself to the believers (11:5–6). The false teachers had praised themselves and some of the believers had believed

them, so Paul had to praise himself. He reminded them that he had not allowed them to support him. He wanted them to know that he was serving them because he truly loved them and wanted to help them, unlike the false teachers.

In Greek culture, a teacher expected those whom he taught to support him. It was an honor to support a well-known teacher. But Paul had not let the believers in Corinth support him. Using irony, Paul asked them if they were upset about his not letting them support him (11:7). Using irony again, he told them that churches in other cities had supported him while he lived in Corinth so that he could serve them full time (11:8–9). But the false teachers probably did the culturally expected thing and accepted money from the believers. Paul explained that he loved the believers in Corinth and therefore had not accepted their money (11:10–11). This example of love showed that the false teachers were not equals with Paul as apostles (11:12). He described the false teachers as claiming to be apostles while actually following Satan (11:13–15).

Other examples for this section heading are:

Paul Contrasts Himself With False Apostles (GW)

Paul and His Opponents (NET)

11:12a

But I will keep on doing what I am doing,

- ¶ And/But I will continue to do as I have done
- ¶ I plan to continue to avoid being a burden to you.

But: Here the Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as But probably introduces a new thought related to what Paul had been talking about.

There is some contrast between people trying to stop Paul's boasting and what Paul said here.

In some languages it is more natural to allow the context to indicate the connection and omit the conjunction.

I will keep on doing what I am doing: This clause probably refers to Paul earning money to support himself and receiving help from other churches. In that way he would not be a financial burden to the believers in Corinth. In some languages it may be necessary to make the meaning clearer. For example:

I will continue not to accept money from you

11:12b-d

in order to undercut those who want an opportunity to be regarded as our equals in the things of which they boast: In Greek culture, people supported a good teacher. This brought honor to both the people and the teacher. While the false teachers took money from the believers in Corinth, God directed Paul not to do so. Although the false teachers boasted that they were apostles, Paul used this difference to show that they were not.

11:12b

in order to undercut those

- so that I may cut off opportunity from those (NASB)
- Doing that will block/stop those people from having a chance to

in order to undercut those: The Greek words are literally “to cut off the opportunity of the ones.” Paul wanted to prevent the false teachers from having an opportunity to claim equality with him. Other ways to translate this are:

so that I may cut off opportunity from those (NASB)

to deny an opportunity to those (NRSV)

so that I may eliminate any opportunity for those (NET)

to stop those people from having a chance

11:12c

who want an opportunity to be regarded as our equals

- who desire an opportunity to be regarded just as we are (NASB)
- be considered equal with us^(excl). They really want that chance to

to be regarded as our equals: The false teachers wanted to claim that they had equal status with Paul and his coworkers. Then they could demand that the believers in Corinth obey their teachings. Other ways to translate this are:

to claim that...they work on the same terms as we do (RSV)

to be recognized as our equals (NRSV)

to be regarded just as we are (NASB)

11:12d

in the things of which they boast.

- in the matter about which they are boasting. (NASB)
- prove that they are right to boast/claim that they are equal with us.

in the things of which they boast: Here this phrase probably refers to the false teachers boasting about being true apostles. Other ways to translate this are:

in what they boast about (NRSV)

in the matter about which they are boasting (NASB)

regarding their proud claims

2 Corinthians 11:13

Section 11:1–15: Paul spoke against the false teachers

In 11:1, Paul prepared his readers for what he would say in 11:7–10 and 11:16. He described the way he would speak as “foolishness.” Paul used the term “foolishness” here in a special way. In this chapter Paul said he was “foolish” because he praised himself for his own good character, attitudes, and actions. He called this praise “foolish” especially because he had just said in 10:17–18 that believers should not praise themselves.

Paul was very concerned for the believers in Corinth, like a father wanting his daughter to be faithful to the man whom she would marry one day (11:2). In the same way he worried that the false teachers might have led the believers away from following Jesus (11:3–4).

Since the false teachers had deceived some of the believers in Corinth, Paul had to defend himself to the believers (11:5–6). The false teachers had praised themselves and some of the believers had believed them, so Paul had to praise himself. He reminded them that he had not allowed them to support him. He wanted them to know that he was serving them because he truly loved them and wanted to help them, unlike the false teachers.

In Greek culture, a teacher expected those whom he taught to support him. It was an honor to support a well-known teacher. But Paul had not let the believers in Corinth support him. Using irony, Paul asked them if they were upset about his not letting them support him (11:7). Using irony again, he told them that churches in other cities had supported him while

he lived in Corinth so that he could serve them full time (11:8–9). But the false teachers probably did the culturally expected thing and accepted money from the believers. Paul explained that he loved the believers in Corinth and therefore had not accepted their money (11:10–11). This example of love showed that the false teachers were not equals with Paul as apostles (11:12). He described the false teachers as claiming to be apostles while actually following Satan (11:13–15).

Other examples for this section heading are:

Paul Contrasts Himself With False Apostles (GW)

Paul and His Opponents (NET)

11:13a

For such men are false apostles,

- For people like that are lying when they say they are apostles.
- Such men claim to be chosen messengers of Jesus Christ but lie.

For: This conjunction introduces an explanation. Here Paul explained why he would continue not to accept money from the believers in Corinth.

Many English versions translate the Greek conjunction as *For*. In some languages it is more natural to allow the context to indicate the connection and omit the conjunction.

men: The Greek word here can refer to both men and women. For example:

people (NJB)

But in the culture at that time, probably only men came to Corinth with false teachings.

false apostles: The term false apostles refers to people who claim to be apostles but are lying. They may act like true apostles and expect people to respect them as if they were apostles, but they teach lies and false doctrine. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

those who claim to be apostles but are not

those who lie saying they are apostles

apostles: The Greek word that the BSB translates as “apostle” means “ambassador” or “messenger.” Here an “apostle” is a person whom Jesus sends to represent him and teach his message with authority. The

word or phrase for “apostle” in your language should indicate a position of trust and authority. See how you translated this word in 1:1 or 11:5.

11:13b

deceitful workers,

- They lie about working for Christ and seek to deceive people,
- They falsely claim to be Christ’s workmen, but are only treacherous people.

deceitful workers: Here the word workers implies doing God’s work such as evangelizing, preaching, and teaching. These men pretended to be true workers of Jesus, but their goal was to deceive people. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

who lie about their work (GNT)

those who falsely claim to be Christ’s workmen and deceive people

those who lie saying they are workers for Christ but only try to deceive people

11:13c

masquerading as apostles of Christ.

- and they disguise themselves to look like apostles of Christ.
- Outwardly they pretend to be chosen messengers of Jesus Christ, but they are only lying.

masquerading as: The word masquerading refers to pretending to be something you are not. The false teachers pretended to be apostles of Christ, but in reality they taught lies and false doctrine. Other ways to translate this word are:

disguising themselves as (RSV)

They only pretend to be (CEV)

falsely claiming to be

2 Corinthians 11:14

Section 11:1–15: Paul spoke against the false teachers

In 11:1, Paul prepared his readers for what he would say in 11:7–10 and 11:16. He described the way he would speak as “foolishness.” Paul used the term “foolishness” here in a special way. In this chapter Paul said he

was “foolish” because he praised himself for his own good character, attitudes, and actions. He called this praise “foolish” especially because he had just said in 10:17–18 that believers should not praise themselves.

Paul was very concerned for the believers in Corinth, like a father wanting his daughter to be faithful to the man whom she would marry one day (11:2). In the same way he worried that the false teachers might have led the believers away from following Jesus (11:3–4).

Since the false teachers had deceived some of the believers in Corinth, Paul had to defend himself to the believers (11:5–6). The false teachers had praised themselves and some of the believers had believed them, so Paul had to praise himself. He reminded them that he had not allowed them to support him. He wanted them to know that he was serving them because he truly loved them and wanted to help them, unlike the false teachers.

In Greek culture, a teacher expected those whom he taught to support him. It was an honor to support a well-known teacher. But Paul had not let the believers in Corinth support him. Using irony, Paul asked them if they were upset about his not letting them support him (11:7). Using irony again, he told them that churches in other cities had supported him while he lived in Corinth so that he could serve them full time (11:8–9). But the false teachers probably did the culturally expected thing and accepted money from the believers. Paul explained that he loved the believers in Corinth and therefore had not accepted their money (11:10–11). This example of love showed that the false teachers were not equals with Paul as apostles (11:12). He described the false teachers as claiming to be apostles while actually following Satan (11:13–15).

Other examples for this section heading are:

Paul Contrasts Himself With False Apostles (GW)

Paul and His Opponents (NET)

11:14

And no wonder, for Satan himself masquerades as an angel of light.

- That is not surprising, because Satan disguises himself as a shining angel.
- That does not surprise us, for even Satan himself pretends to be an angel with God’s glory in order to deceive people.

And no wonder: This phrase indicates that the believers should not be surprised that the false teachers

falsely claimed to be apostles of Christ (11:13c). Other ways to translate this are:

This does not surprise us (NCV)

Nothing surprising in that!

Satan himself: The pronoun himself emphasizes the fact that Satan masquerades. For example:

even Satan (RSV)

Satan: The word Satan is the Hebrew name of the chief or leader of all the evil spirits. In Hebrew his name means “enemy.” He is the enemy of God and God’s people. Translate this word as you did in 2:11.

masquerades: This word refers to being disguised as someone else. Here this verb is in the present tense, and this may indicate that Satan often masquerades. Translate in a way that indicates that Satan’s habit is to masquerade. For example:

habitually masquerades

regularly impersonates

often deceitfully acts as

angel of light: This phrase refers to an angel that has light or glory around him. Here the word light is a metaphor for goodness or association with God. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

shining angel

angel with glory

bright angel of God

angel: The Greek word that the BSB translates as angel means “messenger.” It refers here to a spirit being who serves God. Some ways to translate this term are:

- Use a descriptive word or phrase. For example:

messenger from God/heaven

good/holy spirit-being

- Use a local term that fits the biblical meaning.
- In some areas the churches may already be using the common language word for angel. Be sure that this term fits the biblical meaning. If some people do not understand the right meaning from this term, you may need to indicate the meaning in some way. For example:

angel messenger from God

sacred angel spirit

Be sure that your term for angel is different from your terms for “prophet” and “apostle.”

2 Corinthians 11:15

Section 11:1–15: Paul spoke against the false teachers

In 11:1, Paul prepared his readers for what he would say in 11:7–10 and 11:16. He described the way he would speak as “foolishness.” Paul used the term “foolishness” here in a special way. In this chapter Paul said he was “foolish” because he praised himself for his own good character, attitudes, and actions. He called this praise “foolish” especially because he had just said in 10:17–18 that believers should not praise themselves.

Paul was very concerned for the believers in Corinth, like a father wanting his daughter to be faithful to the man whom she would marry one day (11:2). In the same way he worried that the false teachers might have led the believers away from following Jesus (11:3–4).

Since the false teachers had deceived some of the believers in Corinth, Paul had to defend himself to the believers (11:5–6). The false teachers had praised themselves and some of the believers had believed them, so Paul had to praise himself. He reminded them that he had not allowed them to support him. He wanted them to know that he was serving them because he truly loved them and wanted to help them, unlike the false teachers.

In Greek culture, a teacher expected those whom he taught to support him. It was an honor to support a well-known teacher. But Paul had not let the believers in Corinth support him. Using irony, Paul asked them if they were upset about his not letting them support him (11:7). Using irony again, he told them that churches in other cities had supported him while he lived in Corinth so that he could serve them full time (11:8–9). But the false teachers probably did the culturally expected thing and accepted money from the believers. Paul explained that he loved the believ-

ers in Corinth and therefore had not accepted their money (11:10–11). This example of love showed that the false teachers were not equals with Paul as apostles (11:12). He described the false teachers as claiming to be apostles while actually following Satan (11:13–15).

Other examples for this section heading are:

Paul Contrasts Himself With False Apostles (GW)

Paul and His Opponents (NET)

11:15a

It is not surprising, then,

- So, it is no surprise
- So then, expect

It is not surprising, then: The Greek word that the BSB translates as then introduces a conclusion. In some languages it is more natural to have the conjunction at the beginning of the verse. For example:

Therefore it is not surprising (NASB)

So it is not strange (RSV)

It is not surprising: The Greek words are literally “(it is) no great thing.” This phrase indicates that people can expect Satan’s servants to masquerade as servants of righteousness. In some languages it is more natural to use a positive saying here. For example:

It is expected

It often happens that

11:15b

if his servants masquerade as servants of righteousness.

- if his servants also deceitfully change to look like righteous/upright servants.
- those who serve Satan also to act like someone who does right things. They do that in order to deceive people.

if his servants masquerade as servants of righteousness: The word if is used rhetorically to cause the believers in Corinth to think about when Satan’s servants might masquerade as servants of righteousness.

In some languages using the word *if* indicates that Satan's servants do not masquerade in that way. If that is true in your language, indicate the correct meaning. One way is to use the word "when" instead of *if*. For example:

when his servants masquerade as servants of righteousness

if his servants masquerade: The Greek here includes the word that means "also" here. Satan's servants copy his behavior. For example:

if his servants also disguise themselves (RSV)

servants of righteousness: The word *of* indicates here that the servants do things that God considers right to do. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

agents of good (REB)

servants who work for what is right (NCV)

11:15c

Their end will correspond to their actions.

- Their final place of residence will be appropriate to their deeds.
- Their destiny will be in accordance with what they do.
- In the end, God will punish them as they deserve for their actions.

Their end will correspond to their actions: The word *end* refers to the final outcome for them. Since they follow Satan, God will send them to hell, just as he will send Satan there. Other ways to translate this clause are:

But their fate will match their deeds. (REB)

But in the end they will be punished for what they do. (NCV)

whose end will correspond to their action (NET)

2 Corinthians 11:16

Section 11:16–33: Paul suffered for serving Jesus

In this section, Paul first warned the Corinthians that he was not a fool (11:16a). But he wanted them to listen to what he was foolishly going to boast about (11:16b–

d). He told them that Jesus would not foolishly boast in this way (11:17). He told them that he would boast in the way that the false teachers were boasting (11:18). Using irony, he rebuked them for accepting people who boasted (11:19), implying that they were wrong to accept the false teachers because the false teachers boasted about themselves. Again using irony, he told them that they should not tolerate the false teachers taking advantage of them (11:20–21a).

In 11:21b Paul began foolishly to boast about things similar to the ones that the false teachers boasted about. Recounting all his hardships, he showed that he was more devoted to serving Jesus than they were (11:23–29).

Then Paul explained the correct kind of boasting (11:30). He gave an example (11:32–33), with an oath to God to indicate he was not lying (11:31).

Other examples for this section heading are:

Paul Boasts About His Sufferings (NIV)

Paul's Sufferings as an Apostle (ESV)

11:16a

I repeat: Let no one take me for a fool.

- ¶ I say again: Let no one think that I am a fool.
- ¶ What I said to you before, I now say to you^(plur) again, please do not believe I am a fool.

I repeat: Let no one take me for a fool: The Greek word that the BSB translates as *take* means "consider" or "think." The English verb *take* is used figuratively here to mean "think" or "believe." Paul was about to speak like a fool (11:22–29), but he warned them here not to think that he was a fool. Other ways to translate this are:

I repeat, let no one think me foolish (RSV)

Again I say, don't think that I am a fool to talk like this (NLT)

Let no one: This is an indirect command. It is more polite than a direct command ("Do not...") here. For example:

no one should (GNT)

fool: This word refers to someone who often makes bad decisions or lacks good sense. He chooses based

on a faulty understanding of the world and of people. Here the word does not imply “insane” or “ignorant.”

11:16b

But if you do,

- But if otherwise,
- But if you do think that I am a foolish person,

But if you do: The Greek words are literally “But if otherwise.” Paul expected the believers to think of him as someone who was not a fool. These words indicate that if some believers thought of Paul as a fool, they should continue to listen to him (11:16c–d). In some languages it is clearer to explain the word do in the translation. For example:

But if you take me for a fool

But if you do think of me as a fool

11:16c

then receive me as a fool,

- at least accept me as a fool, (GNT)
- accept me as you would accept a fool. (NCV)

receive me as a fool: Here the word receive refers to welcoming someone as he is. If some believers thought that Paul was a fool, he asked them to accept him that way. Other ways to translate this are:

at least accept me as a fool (GNT)

let me be a fool (CEV)

11:16d

so that I too may boast a little.

- in order that I also can boast a little bit.
- Then I can brag a little, too. (NCV)

so that: This phrase introduces the purpose for accepting him as a fool.

I too may boast a little: The Greek words are literally “I also may boast a little bit.” The word “also” indicates that Paul would boast as the false teachers boasted. Other ways to translate this clause are:

I may do a little boasting (NIV)

I can brag a little, too (NCV)

I may speak proudly about myself as well

boast a little: Paul used the word little as irony. The false teachers boasted much. Now he would boast more than a little, just as they did. He boasted in 11:22–29 and in 12:1–5.

In some languages the word little will not translate as irony. If that is true in your language, you may want to indicate its meaning in your translation. For example:

let me have my little boast like others (REB)

then listen to what this “fool” has to boast about (JBP)

a little boasting, like their “little” bit of boasting

2 Corinthians 11:17

Section 11:16–33: Paul suffered for serving Jesus

In this section, Paul first warned the Corinthians that he was not a fool (11:16a). But he wanted them to listen to what he was foolishly going to boast about (11:16b–d). He told them that Jesus would not foolishly boast in this way (11:17). He told them that he would boast in the way that the false teachers were boasting (11:18). Using irony, he rebuked them for accepting people who boasted (11:19), implying that they were wrong to accept the false teachers because the false teachers boasted about themselves. Again using irony, he told them that they should not tolerate the false teachers taking advantage of them (11:20–21a).

In 11:21b Paul began foolishly to boast about things similar to the ones that the false teachers boasted about. Recounting all his hardships, he showed that he was more devoted to serving Jesus than they were (11:23–29).

Then Paul explained the correct kind of boasting (11:30). He gave an example (11:32–33), with an oath to God to indicate he was not lying (11:31).

Other examples for this section heading are:

Paul Boasts About His Sufferings (NIV)

Paul’s Sufferings as an Apostle (ESV)

11:17a

In this confident boasting of mine, I am not speaking as the Lord would,

- In this matter of boasting, I talk not as the Lord would talk,

- Regarding the things that I will boast about myself, I do not follow the manner in which the Lord Jesus talked.

this confident boasting of mine: There are two ways to interpret the Greek word that the BSB translates as confident:

1. It means situation or project. For example:

this matter of boasting (GNT)

in this boastful state (NABRE) (GNT, NABRE)

1. It means confidence. For example:

this boastful confidence (RSV) (BSB, RSV, NIV, NASB, NET, REB, NCV, ESV, KJV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because scholars who explain the origin of the Greek word follow interpretation (1). These scholars include Kittel, Moulton and Milligan, Martin, and BDAG. BDAG says that “The sense ‘confidence’, ‘assurance’...must be eliminated, since examples of it cannot be found.”

I am not speaking as the Lord would: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as as the Lord would is literally “according to the Lord.” There are several ways to interpret this phrase:

1. The phrase refers to a style of speech that Jesus never used. Jesus never boasted about himself. For example:

I shall not be following the Lord’s way in what I say now (NJB) (BSB, NIV, NJB, NASB, NABRE, NET, REB, NCV, KJV)

1. The phrase indicates that the source of the words is not Jesus. Jesus did not give Paul the authority to make these boasts. For example:

what I am saying now is not what the Lord would have me say (GNT) (RSV, GNT, NLT, ESV)

1. The phrase refers to not speaking on behalf of Jesus. Here Paul’s boasts were not on behalf of Jesus. For example:

It’s not something I would say if I were speaking for the Lord (GW) (GW, CEV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Thrall (p. 709) translates the Greek text as “I am not saying in a Christian way.” She says ‘The preposition... indicates (here) that something is done, or occurs, in accordance with the ‘will, pleasure, or manner’ of that person” (p. 713). Hughes (on TW) translates the Greek text as “I speak not after the Lord.” “After” here has the sense of “according to.” He says that boasting about oneself is “incompatible with the Lord’s example of humility.”

the Lord: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Lord means “the one in authority over (something)” or “master.” The word Lord refers to Jesus here. In some languages it is more natural to include the name “Jesus” here. For example:

the Lord Jesus

11:17b but as a fool.

- but like a fool.
- But instead, I will speak as a fool speaks.

but as a fool: Paul was about to speak of events that really happened, but he did it in a manner of someone who selfishly boasts to make himself look good. In that way he would speak as a fool. He had many things he could boast about but had not done so until now. But the false teachers were boasting and convincing some believers to listen to them. So Paul would show the believers that such boasting did not help them.

He imitated the false teachers’ kind of boasting in order to mock them. He was playing the role of fool to make a point about how foolish they were and how foolish the believers in Corinth were for following them.

In some languages a literal translation would wrongly indicate that Paul was lying. If that is true in your language, you may want to indicate that he was being truthful or that boasting does not help others. For example:

but as a fool although everything I will say is true

but as a fool even though such boasting does not help you

**11:17a–b
(reordered) In this topic/issue of boasting, I am speaking as a fool, not as the Lord Jesus would speak.**

- (reordered) Regarding this discussion about boasting, I speak as a fool, and not as the Lord Jesus would speak.

2 Corinthians 11:18

Section 11:16–33: Paul suffered for serving Jesus

In this section, Paul first warned the Corinthians that he was not a fool (11:16a). But he wanted them to listen to what he was foolishly going to boast about (11:16b–d). He told them that Jesus would not foolishly boast in this way (11:17). He told them that he would boast in the way that the false teachers were boasting (11:18). Using irony, he rebuked them for accepting people who boasted (11:19), implying that they were wrong to accept the false teachers because the false teachers boasted about themselves. Again using irony, he told them that they should not tolerate the false teachers taking advantage of them (11:20–21a).

In 11:21b Paul began foolishly to boast about things similar to the ones that the false teachers boasted about. Recounting all his hardships, he showed that he was more devoted to serving Jesus than they were (11:23–29).

Then Paul explained the correct kind of boasting (11:30). He gave an example (11:32–33), with an oath to God to indicate he was not lying (11:31).

Other examples for this section heading are:

Paul Boasts About His Sufferings (NIV)

Paul's Sufferings as an Apostle (ESV)

11:18a

Since many are boasting according to the flesh,

- Since many are boasting according to human standards, (NET)
- Since many people boast about themselves in worldly ways,

11:18b

I too will boast.

- I also will boast.
- I too will boast about myself in that way.

11:18a–b

many: This word probably refers only to the false teachers. Paul probably used this word in contempt of them and their supporters. But this word may refer to people in general who boast of themselves, and the false teachers are just a part of this larger group. The believers in Corinth would know that Paul was referring to the false teachers in one of the above ways.

Follow the literal Greek and do not describe who the many are.

However, in some languages a literal translation would wrongly refer to people other than the false teachers. If that is true in your language, you may want to explain in a footnote. For example:

Paul referred to the false teachers with the word “many.” He may have mocked them by calling them “many” when they were not. Or he may have included them in a larger group of non-believers who boasted about themselves.

according to the flesh: There are a number of ways to interpret this phrase. The four most likely ways are:

1. The phrase refers to the way in which they boasted. They boasted as unbelievers boast. For example:

according to human standards (NRSV) (BSB, NIV, NRSV, NABRE, NASB, NET, ESV, KJV)

1. The phrase refers to the content of the boasting. They boasted about worldly things. For example:

about their lives in the world (NCV) (RSV, NLT, REB, NCV)

1. The phrase refers to the purpose for boasting. For example:

for merely human reasons (GNT) (GNT)

1. The phrase refers to the basis of their boasting. For example:

on merely human grounds (NJB) (NJB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because it is the same as the interpretation for the same phrase “according to” in 11:17a. Thrall (p. 709) translates the Greek phrase as “in an unspiritual fashion.” She says, “It is in opposition to kata kurion of verse 17” (p. 715). Harris (p. 778) translates it as “as the world does.” Martin (p. 356) translates it as “as ‘people of the world.’”

2 Corinthians 11:19

Section 11:16–33: Paul suffered for serving Jesus

In this section, Paul first warned the Corinthians that he was not a fool (11:16a). But he wanted them to listen

to what he was foolishly going to boast about (11:16b-d). He told them that Jesus would not foolishly boast in this way (11:17). He told them that he would boast in the way that the false teachers were boasting (11:18). Using irony, he rebuked them for accepting people who boasted (11:19), implying that they were wrong to accept the false teachers because the false teachers boasted about themselves. Again using irony, he told them that they should not tolerate the false teachers taking advantage of them (11:20-21a).

In 11:21b Paul began foolishly to boast about things similar to the ones that the false teachers boasted about. Recounting all his hardships, he showed that he was more devoted to serving Jesus than they were (11:23-29).

Then Paul explained the correct kind of boasting (11:30). He gave an example (11:32-33), with an oath to God to indicate he was not lying (11:31).

Other examples for this section heading are:

Paul Boasts About His Sufferings (NIV)

Paul's Sufferings as an Apostle (ESV)

11:19

For you gladly tolerate fools, since you are so wise.

- For you^(plur) are so wise that you very gladly tolerate fools!
- You claim to be so wise, but you gladly submit to fools!

For: This verse begins with a Greek conjunction that is often translated as “for” or “because.” Here it probably introduces an explanation of why Paul was about to boast in worldly ways like others were boasting (11:18).

In some languages it is more natural to allow the context to indicate the connection and omit the conjunction.

you gladly tolerate fools, since you are so wise:

Paul used irony here. He wrote as if the believers were so wise that they tolerated the false teachers (11:20). He actually thought that the believers were foolish to tolerate them. With this ironic statement, he wanted them to realize it was wrong to do that. Clearly show the irony. For example:

You yourselves are so wise, and so you gladly tolerate fools! (GNT)

After all, you are the wisest people I know, and you happily tolerate fools!

In some languages it is more natural to translate these words in a way that explains the irony. Your translation should indicate that Paul was trying to correct their wrong attitude. For example:

After all, you think you are so wise, but you enjoy putting up with fools! (NLT)

You claim to be wise. But you so gladly tolerate fools!

If you are wise, why do you gladly permit fools to dominate/lead you?

tolerate: This phrase refers to allowing something and not interfering with it. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

put up with (NIV)

submit to

permit/allow

See how you translated this phrase in 11:4, where the BSB translates it as “put up with.”

you are so wise: The word wise means “to have the ability to understand events and know the right thing to do.” In some languages it may not be possible to use the term wise as an adjective. Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

you understand the meaning of many things

your thinking is right and true/clear

2 Corinthians 11:20

Section 11:16-33: Paul suffered for serving Jesus

In this section, Paul first warned the Corinthians that he was not a fool (11:16a). But he wanted them to listen to what he was foolishly going to boast about (11:16b-d). He told them that Jesus would not foolishly boast in this way (11:17). He told them that he would boast in the way that the false teachers were boasting (11:18). Using irony, he rebuked them for accepting people who boasted (11:19), implying that they were wrong to

accept the false teachers because the false teachers boasted about themselves. Again using irony, he told them that they should not tolerate the false teachers taking advantage of them (11:20–21a).

In 11:21b Paul began foolishly to boast about things similar to the ones that the false teachers boasted about. Recounting all his hardships, he showed that he was more devoted to serving Jesus than they were (11:23–29).

Then Paul explained the correct kind of boasting (11:30). He gave an example (11:32–33), with an oath to God to indicate he was not lying (11:31).

Other examples for this section heading are:

Paul Boasts About His Sufferings (NIV)

Paul's Sufferings as an Apostle (ESV)

11:20a–c

In fact, you even put up with anyone who enslaves you or exploits you or takes advantage of you or exalts himself or strikes you in the face: Paul continued to use irony here. He listed five examples of how the believers tolerated others when they should not have tolerated them. Clearly show the irony. For example:

In fact, you let people make slaves of you and cheat you and steal from you. Why, you even let them strut around and slap you in the face. (CEV)

Indeed, when someone makes you slaves, consumes your wealth, brings you under their sway, looks down on you, or slaps your faces, you gladly tolerate it!

You don't mind, do you, if a man takes away your liberty, spends your money, takes advantage of you, puts on airs or even smacks your face? (JBP)

In some languages it is more natural to translate these words in a way that explains the irony. Your translation should indicate that Paul was trying to correct their wrong attitude. For example:

For example, when someone enslaves you, or exploits you, or persuades you to follow their lies, or acts arrogant over you, or slaps you in the face, you gladly tolerate it! You should not!

For example, people have enslaved you, exploited you, persuaded you to follow their lies, acted arrogant toward you, and slapped you in the face. And you gladly tolerate it. That is wrong!

11:20a

In fact, you even put up with anyone who enslaves you

- Indeed/For you^(plur) very gladly tolerate anyone who makes you his slaves,
- For example, you gladly submit to anyone when he forces you to be his lowly servant.

In fact: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as In fact is often translated as “for” or “because.” Here the conjunction indicates that 11:20 gives examples of how the believers in Corinth gladly tolerate fools (11:19). Other ways to translate this Greek word are:

For (RSV)

For example,

enslaves you: The word enslaves refers to forcing someone to do as he is commanded to do. Slaves are required to do as their master commands them. The false teachers were making the believers serve them. The word is used figuratively. Paul was not saying that the believers had literally become slaves. Other ways to translate this word are:

makes slaves of you (RSV)

subjugates you

makes you their lowly servants/workers

demands that you do what they say

11:20b

or exploits you or takes advantage of you

- devours what you possess, cheats you,
- And you gladly submit to anyone when he takes your money for himself or deceives you into doing things for his own benefit.

exploits you: The Greek word that the BSB translates as exploits is literally “devours” or “swallows.” Here, it refers figuratively to using other people's money for selfish reasons. Other ways to translate this word are:

eats up all you possess (NJB)

takes everything you have (NLT)

consumes your wealth (GW)

spends your money for their own selfish/devious reasons

takes advantage of: The Greek word here is literally only takes. Here it refers figuratively to influencing people so they follow lies. Here the false teachers deceived the believers into following them and their selfish desires. Other ways to translate this Greek word are:

trick to his own advantage

cheat

11:20c or exalts himself or strikes you in the face.

- sets himself above you, or slaps you in the face.
- And you gladly submit to anyone when he acts haughtily/arrogantly toward you, or slaps you in the face in order to humiliate you. Is that right? Of course not!

exalts himself: This phrase refers to honoring or praising oneself. It implies being arrogant toward others. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

sets himself above you (NJB)

pushes himself forward (NIV)

behaves arrogantly toward you (NET)

think they are better than you (NCV)

strikes you in the face: This phrase indicates that the person insults someone. It can also indicate that the person humiliates the other person in order to make him submit to his authority.

If slapping in the face has a different meaning in your language, you may want to:

- Explain the correct meaning in your translation. For example:

slaps you in the face in order to humiliate you

- Translate the meaning of the action. For example:

humiliates you

2 Corinthians 11:21

Section 11:16–33: Paul suffered for serving Jesus

In this section, Paul first warned the Corinthians that he was not a fool (11:16a). But he wanted them to listen to what he was foolishly going to boast about (11:16b–d). He told them that Jesus would not foolishly boast in this way (11:17). He told them that he would boast in the way that the false teachers were boasting (11:18). Using irony, he rebuked them for accepting people who boasted (11:19), implying that they were wrong to accept the false teachers because the false teachers boasted about themselves. Again using irony, he told them that they should not tolerate the false teachers taking advantage of them (11:20–21a).

In 11:21b Paul began foolishly to boast about things similar to the ones that the false teachers boasted about. Recounting all his hardships, he showed that he was more devoted to serving Jesus than they were (11:23–29).

Then Paul explained the correct kind of boasting (11:30). He gave an example (11:32–33), with an oath to God to indicate he was not lying (11:31).

Other examples for this section heading are:

Paul Boasts About His Sufferings (NIV)

Paul's Sufferings as an Apostle (ESV)

11:21a

To my shame I concede that we were too weak for that!

- I am ashamed to admit that we were too timid to do those things! (GNT)
- We^(excl) have been too fainthearted to do those things to you! I would be ashamed to do them!
- We have been too meek/gentle to do those things to you! I am certainly not ashamed that we avoided doing them!

To my shame I concede that we were too weak for that: Paul continued to use irony here. He did not want to enslave the believers in Corinth, or exploit them, or take advantage of them, or be arrogant toward them, or insult them as the false teachers did (11:20). So he

said in a joking manner that he was not bold enough to do those things. Clearly show the irony. For example:

I am ashamed to admit that we were too timid to do those things! (GNT)

I'm ashamed to say that we've been too "weak" to do that! (NLT)

In some languages it is more natural to translate these words in a way that explains the irony. Your translation should indicate that Paul was trying to correct their wrong attitude toward the false teachers. For example:

We have been too weak/timid to do those things to you! I would be ashamed to do them!

We have been too weak/timid to do those things to you! I would be ashamed to try!

shame: This word refers to discomfort or loss of self-respect because of a mistake, bad behavior, or failure.

we were too weak: Here the word weak refers to lack of boldness. It does not refer to a lack of physical strength. For example:

we lacked courage

we were too timid (GNT)

11:21b

Speaking as a fool, however, I can match what anyone else dares to boast about.

- ¶ But, talking like a fool, I say I can bravely boast about any subject that someone else might bravely boast about.
- ¶ But regarding any topic that someone is bold enough to boast about, I also am bold enough to boast about. (Just remember, I am talking like a foolish person does.)

Speaking as a fool: This clause explains the manner in which Paul was going to speak. Paul was about to boast to show the believers that such boasting is not proper for believers. He wanted them to see that they should not have listened to the foolish boasting of these false teachers. So, he spoke as a fool. Other ways to translate this clause are:

I (speaking as a fool, remember) (JBP)

but it is a foolish thing to do (CEV)

however: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as however is often translated as "but" (as in the RSV). Here it indicates that 11:21b contrasts to 11:21a. For example:

Yet (JBP)

In some languages it is more natural to allow the context to indicate the contrast and omit the conjunction.

I can match what anyone else dares to boast about:

These words indicate that Paul would be able to boast about anything that the false teachers might boast about. Paul had many experiences as an apostle, so he had much he could boast about. These words do not refer to repeating the exact boast each time. For example:

if anyone dares to boast about something...I will be just as daring (GNT)

dares: This word refers to being bold enough to do something. Other ways to translate this word are:

is bold (NASB)

is brave enough (NCV)

2 Corinthians 11:22

Section 11:16–33: Paul suffered for serving Jesus

In this section, Paul first warned the Corinthians that he was not a fool (11:16a). But he wanted them to listen to what he was foolishly going to boast about (11:16b–d). He told them that Jesus would not foolishly boast in this way (11:17). He told them that he would boast in the way that the false teachers were boasting (11:18). Using irony, he rebuked them for accepting people who boasted (11:19), implying that they were wrong to accept the false teachers because the false teachers boasted about themselves. Again using irony, he told them that they should not tolerate the false teachers taking advantage of them (11:20–21a).

In 11:21b Paul began foolishly to boast about things similar to the ones that the false teachers boasted about. Recounting all his hardships, he showed that he was more devoted to serving Jesus than they were (11:23–29).

Then Paul explained the correct kind of boasting (11:30). He gave an example (11:32–33), with an oath to God to indicate he was not lying (11:31).

Other examples for this section heading are:

Paul Boasts About His Sufferings (NIV)

Paul's Sufferings as an Apostle (ESV)

11:22a–c

Paul asked three rhetorical questions. The answer to all three is “yes.” The false teachers bragged about being Hebrews, Israelites, and descendants of Abraham. Paul could brag about those things too.

11:22a

Are they Hebrews? So am I.

- Do they boast that they are Hebrews? I am too.
- They boast that they are Hebrews. Well, I also can boast that I am a Hebrew.

Are they Hebrews?: This is a rhetorical question. It emphasizes the fact that the false teachers were Hebrews. The context implies that the false teachers were boasting that they were Hebrews. Translate it in a way that emphasizes that meaning. Some ways to translate this are:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Do they boast that they are Hebrews?

They boast that they are Hebrews, isn't that so?

- As a statement. For example:

They boast that they are Hebrews.

Hebrews: This word refers to people who were Jews both from their ancestors and in their culture. Their ancient language was Hebrew and their Bible (what Christians call the Old Testament) was written mostly in Hebrew. Hebrew was also the religious language. The language of daily use was Aramaic, which was very similar to Hebrew.

In some languages people are not familiar with this name. If that is true in your language, you may want to explain in a footnote. For example:

The word “Hebrews” refers to Jews.

11:22b

Are they Israelites? So am I.

- Do they boast that they are Israelites? I am too.
- They boast that they are Israelites. Well, I also can boast that I am an Israelite.

Are they Israelites?: This is also a rhetorical question. It emphasizes the fact that the false teachers were Israelites. The context implies that the false teachers were boasting that they were Israelites. Translate it in a similar way to the rhetorical question in 11:22a. For example:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Do they boast that they are Israelites?

They boast that they are Israelites, isn't that so?

- As a statement. For example:

They are boasting that they are Israelites.

Israelites: This word refers to people who were descendants of Jacob (also known as Israel). He was the founder of the nation of Israel. But in this context the word implies the relationship that the Jews had with God based on a covenant with him (Exodus 19–20). The “-ites” ending means “people of.” For example:

people of Israel

Israel people

In some languages people are not familiar with this name. If that is true in your language, you may want to explain in a footnote. For example:

The word “Israelites” also refers to Jews. Here, the word indicates that the Jews had a relationship with God based on the covenant he made with them. No other nation had a relationship or covenant like the one the Jews had.

11:22c

Are they descendants of Abraham? So am I.

- Do they boast that they are Abraham's descendants? I am too.
- They boast that they descend from Abraham. Well, I also can boast that I descend from Abraham.

Are they descendants of Abraham?: This is also a rhetorical question. It emphasizes the fact that the false teachers were descendants of Abraham. The context implies that the false teachers were boasting that they were descendants of Abraham. Translate it in a similar way to the rhetorical question in 11:22a. For example:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Do they boast that they are descended from Abraham?

They boast that they are Abraham's descendants, isn't that so?

- As a statement. For example:

They boast that they are descendants of Abraham.

descendants of Abraham: The Jews descended from Abraham. Other nations descended from Abraham, but Jews use the words “descendants of Abraham” to refer to themselves and God's promises to Abraham (Genesis 12–22). In this context the phrase implies that the Jews benefited from the promises that God made with Abraham.

In some languages people do not know that the Jews are descendants of Abraham. If that is true in your language, you may want to explain in a footnote. For example:

The Jews use the words “descendants of Abraham” to refer to themselves. Using these words implies that the Jews received the promises that God made with Abraham (Genesis 12–22).

2 Corinthians 11:23

Section 11:16–33: Paul suffered for serving Jesus

In this section, Paul first warned the Corinthians that he was not a fool (11:16a). But he wanted them to listen to what he was foolishly going to boast about (11:16b–d). He told them that Jesus would not foolishly boast in this way (11:17). He told them that he would boast in the way that the false teachers were boasting (11:18). Using irony, he rebuked them for accepting people who boasted (11:19), implying that they were wrong to accept the false teachers because the false teachers boasted about themselves. Again using irony, he told them that they should not tolerate the false teachers taking advantage of them (11:20–21a).

In 11:21b Paul began foolishly to boast about things similar to the ones that the false teachers boasted about. Recounting all his hardships, he showed that he was more devoted to serving Jesus than they were (11:23–29).

Then Paul explained the correct kind of boasting (11:30). He gave an example (11:32–33), with an oath to God to indicate he was not lying (11:31).

Other examples for this section heading are:

Paul Boasts About His Sufferings (NIV)

Paul's Sufferings as an Apostle (ESV)

11:23a–b

The clause “I am out of my mind to talk like this” stands between Paul's question and his answer. See the General Comment at the end of 11:23b for suggestions as to how possibly to reorder this verse.

11:23a

Are they servants of Christ?

- Do they boast that they are servants of Christ?
- They boast that they serve Christ.

Are they servants of Christ?: This is also a rhetorical question. Translate it in a similar way to the rhetorical questions in 11:22.

servants of Christ: This phrase refers to people who serve Christ. They serve him by preaching, teaching, evangelizing, and things like that. The false teachers claimed to be servants of Christ but actually served Satan (11:13–15).

11:23b

I am speaking like I am out of my mind, but I am so much more:

- —I speak as if insane—I more so. (NASB)
- I am a complete fool to talk like this, but I serve him better/more than they do.

I am speaking like I am out of my mind: This clause explains the manner in which Paul stated that he serves Christ more than they. Paul boasted when he said that he served Christ more. He had already explained that such boasting was foolish (11:21b). So this clause is an apology for speaking like a fool. He exaggerated the meaning of “fool” by saying that he was insane. But Paul was not actually saying he was insane.

In some languages a literal translation would wrongly indicate that Paul admitted to being insane. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Indicate that only the following words are “insane” words. For example:

It’s insane to say it, but (GW)

Well, here are some crazy/insane words:

- Translate the clause as a simile. For example:

I speak as if insane (NASB)

I sound like a madman (GNT)

- Translate the meaning of “insane” without the exaggeration. For example:

I speak in utter folly (NJB)

I am a fool to talk this way (CEV)

I am so much more: This clause indicates that Paul served Christ more than the false teachers claimed to. Other ways to translate this clause are:

I more so (NASB)

I have served him far more (NLT)

I serve him better than they do (CEV)

I have more claim to this title than they (JBP)

General Comment on 11:23a–b

Paul answers his own question after he said “I am out of my mind to talk like this.” In some languages it may be more natural to reorder the clauses. For example:

Are they servants of Christ? I am more. (I am out of my mind to talk like this.)

I am out of my mind to talk like this: Are they servants of Christ? I am more.

11:23c–f

In 11:23c–f, Paul gave examples of how he served Christ more (11:23b).

11:23c

in harder labor,

- I have done God’s work much more,
- For example: I have worked for God much harder,

in harder labor: A literal translation of the Greek here is “much more in labor.” Here the phrase indicates that Paul worked much more for God than the false teachers did. He did much more preaching, teaching, evangelizing, and things like that.

In some languages a literal translation would wrongly refer only to physical work or secular jobs. If that is true in your language, you may want to explain in your translation. For example:

I have done God’s work much more

I have worked for God much harder than they

I have served God much more

See how you translated the Greek word in 6:5 (“labor”).

11:23d

in more imprisonments,

- been put in prison for the sake of Christ more often,
- and people put me in jail more times because I preached Christ,

in more imprisonments: This phrase refers to people putting Paul in prison because he preached about Jesus. Clement, a church leader who died about a hundred years after Jesus was born, wrote that people put Paul in prison seven times.

In some languages a literal translation would wrongly refer only to being in prison for stealing, killing, or another crime. If that is true in your language, you may want to explain in your translation. For example:

been in prison for the sake of Christ more frequently

people put me in prison more frequently because I preached Christ

11:23e

in worse beatings,

- been beaten much more because I believe in Christ,
- and people beat/whipped me much worse because I follow Christ,

in worse beatings: Exactly who gave Paul these beatings is not important here. However, some languages must state an agent. Here is one way to do that:

someone flogged me

worse: There are two ways to interpret the Greek word that the BSB translates as worse:

1. It means to a much greater extent here. For example:

hurt more (NCV) (BSB, NIV, GNT, NJB, NABRE, GW, CEV, NET, REB, NCV)

1. It means countless times here. Paul exaggerated to indicate “very many times.” For example:

without number (NASB) (RSV, NASB, NLT, ESV, KJV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Harris (p. 791) and Furnish (p. 512) translate the Greek word as “far worse.” Thrall (p. 722) translates the Greek clause as “exceptionally subject to beatings.” Kistemaker (p. 388) translates the Greek word as “more severely.”

beatings: This word refers to someone using a whip to cut the skin or leave a painful red welt.

The Greek word can also refer to someone hitting with a hard stick or even with fists. Other ways to translate this word are:

whipped (GNT)

scourged (REB)

11:23f in frequent danger of death.

- and many times I almost died.
- and I have often been in danger of dying as I served Christ.

in frequent danger of death: The Greek words are literally “in deaths often.” The phrase refers to Paul almost being killed on numerous occasions. This phrase probably includes things such as people trying to kill Paul (Acts 21:31) as well as the danger of drowning in a shipwreck (Acts 27). Other ways to translate this are:

faced death again and again (NLT)

I have been near death many times (NCV)

Many times I almost died

2 Corinthians 11:24

Section 11:16–33: Paul suffered for serving Jesus

In this section, Paul first warned the Corinthians that he was not a fool (11:16a). But he wanted them to listen to what he was foolishly going to boast about (11:16b–d). He told them that Jesus would not foolishly boast in this way (11:17). He told them that he would boast in the way that the false teachers were boasting (11:18). Using irony, he rebuked them for accepting people who boasted (11:19), implying that they were wrong to accept the false teachers because the false teachers boasted about themselves. Again using irony, he told them that they should not tolerate the false teachers taking advantage of them (11:20–21a).

In 11:21b Paul began foolishly to boast about things similar to the ones that the false teachers boasted about. Recounting all his hardships, he showed that he was more devoted to serving Jesus than they were (11:23–29).

Then Paul explained the correct kind of boasting (11:30). He gave an example (11:32–33), with an oath to God to indicate he was not lying (11:31).

Other examples for this section heading are:

Paul Boasts About His Sufferings (NIV)

Paul’s Sufferings as an Apostle (ESV)

11:24

Five times I received from the Jews the forty lashes minus one.

- On five occasions Jewish leaders whipped me forty times minus one.
- In addition, at five different times, the Jews punished me with thirty-nine/39 lashes with a whip.

Five times I received from the Jews the forty lashes minus one: The phrase Five times indicates that the Jews whipped Paul on five different occasions, and that on each occasion they whipped him thirty-nine times (forty lashes minus one).

I received from the Jews the forty lashes minus one: This clause refers to the Jews striking Paul with a whip. Paul probably used the verb received to keep the focus on himself. In some languages it is more natural to refer to the Jews striking Paul with a whip than translating the verb received. For example:

the Jews whipped me the forty lashes minus one

the Jews: This phrase refers to Jewish leaders. They could have been synagogue leaders or city leaders or some other kind of leader.

In some languages a literal translation would wrongly indicate that Jews without proper authority were whipping Paul. If that is true in your language, you may want to explain in your translation. For example:

the Jewish leaders (NLT)

forty lashes minus one: This phrase refers to thirty-nine strikes with a whip. This was the worst punishment (other than death) that the Jews used. They used thirty-nine lashes on those who broke their more important laws. They used a leather whip. Their laws allowed forty at the most, but they always made sure to strike one less than forty in case they had not counted correctly. A man would whip the lawbreaker thirteen times on his chest and thirteen times on each shoulder. This kind of punishment was very severe. Another way to translate this phrase is:

thirty-nine lashes (GNT)

2 Corinthians 11:25

Section 11:16–33: Paul suffered for serving Jesus

In this section, Paul first warned the Corinthians that he was not a fool (11:16a). But he wanted them to listen to what he was foolishly going to boast about (11:16b–d). He told them that Jesus would not foolishly boast in this way (11:17). He told them that he would boast in the way that the false teachers were boasting (11:18). Using irony, he rebuked them for accepting people who boasted (11:19), implying that they were wrong to accept the false teachers because the false teachers boasted about themselves. Again using irony, he told them that they should not tolerate the false teachers taking advantage of them (11:20–21a).

In 11:21b Paul began foolishly to boast about things similar to the ones that the false teachers boasted about. Recounting all his hardships, he showed that he was more devoted to serving Jesus than they were (11:23–29).

Then Paul explained the correct kind of boasting (11:30). He gave an example (11:32–33), with an oath to God to indicate he was not lying (11:31).

Other examples for this section heading are:

Paul Boasts About His Sufferings (NIV)

Paul's Sufferings as an Apostle (ESV)

11:25a

Three times I was beaten with rods,

- On three occasions I was beaten with a stick.
- Three times Roman leaders/officials beat me with a rod/cane.

Three times I was beaten with rods: To be beaten with a rod was a Roman punishment. Acts 16:19–22 tells of one time that officials had Paul beaten with a rod. On each of the three occasions, the officials probably beat Paul many times. The exact number probably varied, depending on what the head official wanted. Another way to translate this is:

On three occasions I was repeatedly beaten with a rod

I was beaten: This clause is passive. People, probably Roman officials, beat Paul. Some languages must use an active clause. For example:

people struck/hit me

the Romans beat me (CEV)

rods: The term rods refers to straight sticks of wood. They were probably 3–5 cm (1–2 inches) thick and 50–70 cm long.

Other ways to translate this word are:

sticks

canes

During each beating, only one rod was used. Paul was probably beaten in a number of cities. People in each city would have their own rod, so Paul used the plural word rods when referring to all of these beatings. But in some languages the singular word is more natural. For example:

a rod

11:25b

once I was stoned,

- On one occasion I was hit by many stones in an attempt to kill me.
- One time people tried to kill me by throwing stones at me.

once I was stoned: People threw stones at Paul, trying to kill him (Acts 14:19). This clause is passive. Some languages must use an active clause. Refer generally to people. For example:

Once people tried to stone me to death (GW)

one time people tried to kill me by throwing stones at me

11:25c

three times I was shipwrecked.

- On three occasions the ship that I traveled/was on was wrecked.
- Three times when I was on a boat on the sea, something destroyed the boat.

three times I was shipwrecked: The word shipwrecked refers to a boat or ship being destroyed while people are on it. A storm can destroy a ship, or the ship can hit an underwater rock. There are many ways for a boat or ship to be destroyed.

The people either drown, swim to shore, or float until another ship comes by and rescues them. Paul had been on three different ships that were destroyed. Other ways to translate this clause are:

I was on three different ships that broke into pieces on the sea

Three times I was in ships that wrecked (NCV)

At three different times I was traveling on a ship that was destroyed at sea

11:25d

I spent a night and a day in the open sea.

- I floated on the open sea for a night and a day.
- I floated in the sea with no sight of land for a night and the following day.

I spent a night and a day in the open sea: At that time, ships often stayed within sight of land. But some ships would travel far from land. The phrase open sea refers to parts of the sea from which no land can be seen. Paul floated on the open sea probably with help from a piece of wood from the wrecked ship. Other ways to translate this are:

I floated on the open sea for a night and a day

I floated on the sea with no sight of land for a night and the following day

a night and a day: This phrase refers to all or most of a night, and all or most of the following day. See the above example.

2 Corinthians 11:26

Section 11:16–33: Paul suffered for serving Jesus

In this section, Paul first warned the Corinthians that he was not a fool (11:16a). But he wanted them to listen to what he was foolishly going to boast about (11:16b–d). He told them that Jesus would not foolishly boast in this way (11:17). He told them that he would boast in the way that the false teachers were boasting (11:18). Using irony, he rebuked them for accepting people who boasted (11:19), implying that they were wrong to accept the false teachers because the false teachers boasted about themselves. Again using irony, he told them that they should not tolerate the false teachers taking advantage of them (11:20–21a).

In 11:21b Paul began foolishly to boast about things similar to the ones that the false teachers boasted about. Recounting all his hardships, he showed that he was more devoted to serving Jesus than they were (11:23–29).

Then Paul explained the correct kind of boasting (11:30). He gave an example (11:32–33), with an oath to God to indicate he was not lying (11:31).

Other examples for this section heading are:

Paul Boasts About His Sufferings (NIV)

Paul's Sufferings as an Apostle (ESV)

11:26a

In my frequent journeys,

- I have traveled much and while traveling
- Since I travel a lot,

In my frequent journeys: The Greek words here are literally “in journeys often.” There are two ways to interpret how the Greek phrase connects to the rest of the verse:

1. The Greek phrase refers to the general situation of traveling and the rest of the verse lists particular dangers while traveling. For example:

In my many travels I have been in danger (GNT)
(BSB, GNT, NJB, GW, CEV, NET, REB, NCV)

1. The Greek phrase refers to traveling, but the rest of the verse refers to dangers at any time. The connection from 11:26a to the rest of the verse is not between a general situation and particular examples of it. For example:

I have traveled on many long journeys. (NLT) (NIV, NABRE, NLT)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Martin (p. 367) translates the Greek text as “During my frequent journeys, I have been exposed to dangers....” Harris (p. 791) translates the Greek text as “on frequent journeys, exposed to dangers....” Thrall (p. 722) translates it as “frequently on journeys, beset by dangers....” The RSV, NASB, ESV, and KJV do not clearly indicate the connection of 11:26a to the rest of the verse. Other ways to translate the Greek phrase according to interpretation (1) are:

continually travelling, I have been in danger... (NJB)

Because I’ve traveled a lot, I’ve faced dangers... (GW)

11:26b–f

Paul used the Greek word for “danger” eight times in 11:26b–f to emphasize how much danger he had faced. If possible, translate using the same word or phrase each time.

11:26b

I have been in danger from rivers

- I was in dangerous situations on/crossing rivers,
- I faced dangerous rivers,

I have been in danger from rivers: The Greek words are literally “in dangers of rivers.” It refers to Paul being in danger while either traveling on a boat on a river or crossing/fording a river. The word “dangers” is plural to indicate that he was in danger more than once. Other ways to translate this are:

I have faced danger from rivers (NLT)

I traveled hazardous rivers

11:26c

and from bandits,

- and I was in dangerous situations from thieves/muggers,

- and from dangerous robbers,

bandits: This word refers to people who hide in places along a road and then rush out and attack travelers. They steal money and possessions. They also sometimes hurt or kill people. Other ways to translate this word are:

robbers (RSV)

thieves

people who steal things from others

11:26d

in danger from my countrymen and from the Gentiles,

- I was in dangerous situations from people of my own nation, I was in dangerous situations from people of other nations,
- dangerous fellow Jews and dangerous foreigners,

my countrymen: This phrase refers to Israelites/Jews. Some Jews attacked Paul for believing in Jesus as the Christ, as in Acts 9:22–23. Your translation should clearly refer to people of the same language, culture, and ethnic background as Paul. For example:

people of my own nation/culture

my fellow Jews

my own people (GNT)

Your translation should not refer to or imply believers.

the Gentiles: This word refers to people from nations other than Israel. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

the nations

foreigners

people who are not Jews

11:26e

in danger in the city and in the country, in danger on the sea

- I was in dangerous situations in cities/towns/villages, in uninhabited regions, and on the sea/water,

- dangers in cities/towns/villages, dangers in places where few people live, dangers at sea,

the city: Here the word city refers generally to cities, towns, or villages. Use the word in your language that can be used in a general way.

the country: The Greek word that the BSB translates as country refers to places where few or no people live. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

the wilderness (RSV)

places where no one lives (NCV)

uninhabited regions

sea: Here the word sea refers to large bodies of water. Usually a sea is so large that someone standing on one side cannot see the shore on the other side. Some languages do not have a word or phrase for sea. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Explain in your translation. For example:

the saltwater place

large body of water

large round water

- Use the common language word.

11:26f and among false brothers,

- and I was in dangerous situations from people who claim to be fellow- believers but who are not.
- and dangerous people masquerading as brothers/ believers.

false brothers: This phrase refers to people who claim to be believers but who are lying. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

people masquerading as brothers (NJB)

men who claim to be believers but are not (NLT)

people who only pretended to be the Lord's followers (CEV)

2 Corinthians 11:27

Section 11:16–33: Paul suffered for serving Jesus

In this section, Paul first warned the Corinthians that he was not a fool (11:16a). But he wanted them to listen to what he was foolishly going to boast about (11:16b–d). He told them that Jesus would not foolishly boast in this way (11:17). He told them that he would boast in the way that the false teachers were boasting (11:18). Using irony, he rebuked them for accepting people who boasted (11:19), implying that they were wrong to accept the false teachers because the false teachers boasted about themselves. Again using irony, he told them that they should not tolerate the false teachers taking advantage of them (11:20–21a).

In 11:21b Paul began foolishly to boast about things similar to the ones that the false teachers boasted about. Recounting all his hardships, he showed that he was more devoted to serving Jesus than they were (11:23–29).

Then Paul explained the correct kind of boasting (11:30). He gave an example (11:32–33), with an oath to God to indicate he was not lying (11:31).

Other examples for this section heading are:

Paul Boasts About His Sufferings (NIV)

Paul's Sufferings as an Apostle (ESV)

11:27a–c

in labor and toil and often without sleep, in hunger and thirst and often without food, in cold and exposure: The Greek words are literally “in labor and toil, in wakefulness often, in hunger and thirst, in avoiding eating often, in cold and nakedness.” The wakefulness, hunger, and so forth probably describe the situations in which Paul labored and toiled. For example:

Because I've had to work so hard, I've often gone without sleep, been hungry and thirsty, and gone without food and without proper clothes during cold weather. (GW)

11:27a

in labor and toil and often without sleep,

- I labored and did tiring work, in which many times I voluntarily did not sleep,
- I have worked hard and long, enduring many sleepless nights. (NLT)

in labor and toil: The two Greek words that the BSB translates as labor and toil are similar in meaning, but the first word can also mean “being tired from hard work.” Some languages may only have one word for the meaning of labor and toil. These languages can translate the meaning of “being tired” here. For example:

I have done hard and tiring work (NCV)

I have worked hard and long (NLT)

I have done very tiring work

I have worked very hard and become very tired

and often without sleep: This phrase probably refers to voluntarily going without sleep to minister to others or to do other kinds of work. It probably does not refer to Paul being unable to sleep because he was worrying a lot. Other ways to translate this are:

and many times I voluntarily did not sleep

enduring many sleepless nights (NLT)

Often my work prevented/kept me from sleeping.

11:27b

in hunger and thirst and often without food,

- was hungry and thirsty, frequently skipped eating,
- Sometimes I did not have enough food to eat or water to drink, and often I did not take time to eat.

in hunger and thirst and often without food: The clause in hunger and thirst probably refers to being in places or situations where food and water were not available. The phrase and often without food probably refers to having food available but not eating because doing so would interrupt what he was doing. Other ways to translate this are:

hungering and thirsting, as well as often skipping meals

often hungry and thirsty, at other times avoiding eating to avoid interruption

being hungry and thirsty with nothing available, often skipping meals to continue to work even though food was available

11:27c

in cold and exposure.

- and was often cold and lacked warm clothes.
- Sometimes I was cold and had no more/extra clothes to wear.

exposure: Here the word exposure probably refers to not having enough clothes to wear when it was cold. For example:

lacked clothing (NJB)

without enough clothing (NET)

did not have enough clothes to keep warm

2 Corinthians 11:28

Section 11:16–33: Paul suffered for serving Jesus

In this section, Paul first warned the Corinthians that he was not a fool (11:16a). But he wanted them to listen to what he was foolishly going to boast about (11:16b–d). He told them that Jesus would not foolishly boast in this way (11:17). He told them that he would boast in the way that the false teachers were boasting (11:18). Using irony, he rebuked them for accepting people who boasted (11:19), implying that they were wrong to accept the false teachers because the false teachers boasted about themselves. Again using irony, he told them that they should not tolerate the false teachers taking advantage of them (11:20–21a).

In 11:21b Paul began foolishly to boast about things similar to the ones that the false teachers boasted about. Recounting all his hardships, he showed that he was more devoted to serving Jesus than they were (11:23–29).

Then Paul explained the correct kind of boasting (11:30). He gave an example (11:32–33), with an oath to God to indicate he was not lying (11:31).

Other examples for this section heading are:

Paul Boasts About His Sufferings (NIV)

Paul’s Sufferings as an Apostle (ESV)

11:28a

Apart from these external trials,

- Now continuing on to mention other things,
- Aside from all the other things/difficulties I could mention,

Apart from these external trials: The Greek words are literally “Besides the things without.” There are two ways to interpret this phrase:

1. This phrase refers to besides the things that Paul would not mention. The implied words “mentioning them” should be supplied after the Greek word literally translated “without” here. For example:

not to mention other things (GNT) (RSV, NIV, GNT, NLT, CEV, NET, NCV, ESV)

1. This phrase refers to besides the things that are external to Paul. This includes dangers and enemies. The internal things are worries and concerns, as in 11:28b. For example:

besides all the external things (NJB) (BSB, NJB, NASB, GW, REB, KJV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Harris (p. 792) translates this text as “Not to mention other things.” Thrall (p. 748) says that a majority of commentaries prefer interpretation (1).

This phrase refers to difficulties in Paul’s life as an apostle that he had not mentioned yet. With this phrase Paul showed that he could continue to list the difficulties he experienced, but chose to list one last thing in 11:28b. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

not to mention other things (GNT)

aside from all the other things I could mention

11:28b

I face daily the pressure of my concern for all the churches.

- every day I am burdened with care/concern for all the churches.
- I daily carry the responsibility to care for all groups of believers.

pressure: This word refers to the feeling of responsibility and the burden of wanting to do the right things when it is not always clear what the right things to do are. Other ways to translate this word are:

burden (NLT)

I am burdened (CEV)

the responsibility that weighs on me (REB)

concern: The Greek word that the BSB translates as concern can mean either “worry” or “care.” There are two ways to interpret the Greek word:

1. The word means care or concern here. It refers to spending much time thinking about how to help the churches. For example:

care (KJV) (BSB, NIV, GNT, NASB, NLT, NET, REB, NCV, KJV)

1. The word means worry here. Paul worried about the churches turning away from following Jesus well. For example:

anxiety (RSV) (RSV, NJB, NABRE, GW, CEV, ESV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), since Paul did not characterize his attitude toward the churches as “worried” anywhere else in the NT. Martin (p. 367), Kistemaker (p. 393) translate the Greek word as “concern.” Martin (p. 381) says that the context indicates that it does not have its usual sense of “worry” here but is like its use in 1 Corinthians 12:25. Barrett (p. 288) translates it as “care.” Hodge (p. 276) refers to it as “solicitude.”

all the churches: This phrase probably refers to all the groups of believers that Paul had started. Paul probably meant implicitly other churches such as the ones at Colosse, Laodicea, and Rome. Paul did not start those churches, but he wrote to them to help them. But Paul may have been thinking of the churches in Judea, Samaria, and Syria as well. Translate the word all without adding any implied information.

churches: Here the Greek word that the BSB translates as churches refers generally to a gathering of people. Here, as almost always in the New Testament, it refers to groups of believers. See how you translated this word in 1:1 or 8:18.

2 Corinthians 11:29

Section 11:16–33: Paul suffered for serving Jesus

In this section, Paul first warned the Corinthians that he was not a fool (11:16a). But he wanted them to listen to what he was foolishly going to boast about (11:16b–d). He told them that Jesus would not foolishly boast in this way (11:17). He told them that he would boast in the way that the false teachers were boasting (11:18).

Using irony, he rebuked them for accepting people who boasted (11:19), implying that they were wrong to accept the false teachers because the false teachers boasted about themselves. Again using irony, he told them that they should not tolerate the false teachers taking advantage of them (11:20–21a).

In 11:21b Paul began foolishly to boast about things similar to the ones that the false teachers boasted about. Recounting all his hardships, he showed that he was more devoted to serving Jesus than they were (11:23–29).

Then Paul explained the correct kind of boasting (11:30). He gave an example (11:32–33), with an oath to God to indicate he was not lying (11:31).

Other examples for this section heading are:

Paul Boasts About His Sufferings (NIV)

Paul's Sufferings as an Apostle (ESV)

11:29a

Who is weak, and I am not weak?

- Who is weak without my feeling that weakness? (NLT)
- Can anybody be weak without me feeling that weakness?
- When someone is weak, then I in sympathy for him feel weak too.

Who is weak, and I am not weak?: This is a rhetorical question. It emphasizes the fact that Paul sympathized with all who were weak. Translate in a way that emphasizes that meaning. Some ways to translate this are:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Who is weak without my feeling that weakness? (NLT)

Do you think anyone is weak without my feeling his weakness? (JBP)

- As a statement. For example:

When someone is weak, then I feel weak too. (GNT)

I feel weak every time someone is weak. (NCV)

- As an if-then clause. For example:

If anyone weakens, then I feel his weakness

weak: Here the word weak may refer to:

1. physical weakness from illness or persecution;
2. moral weakness as in being timid and fearful;
3. a lack of social power or status;
4. weakness in faith,
5. weakness in convictions, such as not wanting to eat food sacrificed to idols for fear that such food might contaminate one's faith in Jesus.

Paul probably spoke in a general way to allow all the above meanings.

I am not weak: In this rhetorical question, this clause indicates that Paul understood how the weak person felt. Paul would know how to help him. For example:

I do not feel weak with sympathy for his trouble

11:29b

Who is led into sin, and I do not burn with grief?

- Who is led astray, and I do not burn with anger? (NLT)
- Can anybody be led astray without me burning with anger?
- Or if someone leads that person into sin, I am very upset.

Who is led into sin, and I do not burn with grief?:

This is a rhetorical question. It emphasizes the fact that Paul burned when someone was led into sin. Translate in a way that emphasizes that meaning. Some ways to translate this are:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Who is led astray, and I do not burn with anger? (NLT)

Does anyone have his faith upset without me being upset about it?

- As a statement. For example:

when someone is led into sin, I am filled with distress. (GNT)

I feel upset every time someone is led into sin. (NCV)

- As an if-then clause. For example:

If anyone is led into sin, then I burn with anger/indignation.

Who is led into sin: This clause is passive. Someone led that person into sin. Some languages must use an active clause. For example:

When others lead someone into sin

Or if someone leads that person into sin

If possible, focus on the person who has been led into sin in your translation, because the clause “I do not inwardly burn” refers to having sympathy for that person.

led into sin: This phrase refers to someone causing the person to sin. Other ways to translate this are:

made to fall (NJB)

led astray (NLT)

tricked into sin (CEV)

enticed/allured to sin

burn with grief: Here this phrase refers to being upset. Paul would be upset with someone who caused the person to sin. Harris (p. 815) says this refers to “anger at those responsible.” Other ways to translate this phrase are:

indignant (RSV)

feel upset (NCV)

filled with distress (GNT)

burn with anger (NLT)

2 Corinthians 11:30

Section 11:16–33: Paul suffered for serving Jesus

In this section, Paul first warned the Corinthians that he was not a fool (11:16a). But he wanted them to listen to what he was foolishly going to boast about (11:16b–d). He told them that Jesus would not foolishly boast

in this way (11:17). He told them that he would boast in the way that the false teachers were boasting (11:18). Using irony, he rebuked them for accepting people who boasted (11:19), implying that they were wrong to accept the false teachers because the false teachers boasted about themselves. Again using irony, he told them that they should not tolerate the false teachers taking advantage of them (11:20–21a).

In 11:21b Paul began foolishly to boast about things similar to the ones that the false teachers boasted about. Recounting all his hardships, he showed that he was more devoted to serving Jesus than they were (11:23–29).

Then Paul explained the correct kind of boasting (11:30). He gave an example (11:32–33), with an oath to God to indicate he was not lying (11:31).

Other examples for this section heading are:

Paul Boasts About His Sufferings (NIV)

Paul’s Sufferings as an Apostle (ESV)

11:30a–b

If I must boast, I will boast of the things that show my weakness: Here the word If refers to any time that Paul might boast about himself. In some languages using the word If indicates that Paul might not boast. If that is true in your language, you may want to indicate that this sentence refers generally to any time. For example:

Whenever I boast about myself, I will boast of the things that show my weakness

11:30a

If I must boast,

- ¶ If it is necessary for me to boast,
- ¶ Whenever I have to boast about myself,

I must boast: The word must indicates that it is necessary for Paul to boast here. Other ways to translate this clause are:

I have to boast (NJB)

it is necessary for me to boast

I am obliged to brag

you force me to speak boastfully

11:30b

I will boast of the things that show my weakness.

- I will boast about the events that show that I am weak.
- I will boast about the ways in which I am weak.

the things that show my weakness: The word things refers to examples of events that showed that Paul was weak. Other ways to translate this are:

all the ways in which I am weak (NJB)

the things that show how weak I am (GW)

the examples/events that show that I am not strong

2 Corinthians 11:31

Section 11:16–33: Paul suffered for serving Jesus

In this section, Paul first warned the Corinthians that he was not a fool (11:16a). But he wanted them to listen to what he was foolishly going to boast about (11:16b–d). He told them that Jesus would not foolishly boast in this way (11:17). He told them that he would boast in the way that the false teachers were boasting (11:18). Using irony, he rebuked them for accepting people who boasted (11:19), implying that they were wrong to accept the false teachers because the false teachers boasted about themselves. Again using irony, he told them that they should not tolerate the false teachers taking advantage of them (11:20–21a).

In 11:21b Paul began foolishly to boast about things similar to the ones that the false teachers boasted about. Recounting all his hardships, he showed that he was more devoted to serving Jesus than they were (11:23–29).

Then Paul explained the correct kind of boasting (11:30). He gave an example (11:32–33), with an oath to God to indicate he was not lying (11:31).

Other examples for this section heading are:

Paul Boasts About His Sufferings (NIV)

Paul's Sufferings as an Apostle (ESV)

11:31a

The God and Father of the Lord Jesus,

- The God and Father of the leader/Lord Jesus,
- The God and Father of the leader/Lord Jesus

The God and Father of the Lord Jesus: This phrase indicates that God is both the Father of Jesus and the God of Jesus.

Father: This word indicates that God has a relationship with Jesus. The relationship is like a father-to-son relationship. This word does not indicate that God fathered Jesus by having a physical relationship with a woman. Translate the correct meaning.

Lord: This word means “the one in authority over others” or “master.” God has authority over all things. Another way to translate this word is:

ruler

See how you translated this word in 4:5 or 8:5.

11:31b

who is forever worthy of praise,

- he who is blessed for ever, (RSV)
- is worthy to be praised forever.

who is forever worthy of praise: The Greek words are literally “the one being blessed into the ages.” Paul acknowledged that God is blessed for all eternity. The Greek words are not a command to bless God. For example:

who is blessed forever (NET)

This clause tells the reader more about God. In some languages using the word who would indicate that there are other beings named God and only this one is forever worthy of praise. If that is true in your language, translate this clause in a way that tells more about God. One way to do that is to start a new sentence here. For example:

He is to be praised forever.

worthy of praise: The Greek word that the BSB translates as praise can mean:

1. To bless.
2. To praise.

As meaning (1), it indicates here that God is good and no one can make any of that goodness bad. As meaning (2), it refers to others praising him. Other ways to translate this Greek word are:

blessed (RSV)

honored

worthy to be praised

11:31c

knows that I am not lying.

- knows that what I am saying to you is not a lie.
- He himself knows I am telling you the truth.

knows that I am not lying: The verb knows refers to God knowing that Paul was not lying. In some languages it is more natural to use a positive statement here. For example:

knows that I am telling the truth

General Comment on 11:31a–c

The first and last parts of this saying (“The God and Father of the Lord Jesus...knows that I am not lying”) are an oath. Paul indicated that God was able to confirm that Paul was not lying about boasting in his weaknesses (11:30) and that the following verses were also true. The middle part (“who is forever worthy of praise”) is praise to God.

In some languages it is more natural to have the praise before or after the oath. For example:

God is blessed forever! He is the God and Father of the Lord Jesus. He knows that I am not lying.

The God and Father of the Lord Jesus knows that I am not lying. God is blessed forever!

Also, 11:31b emphasizes that God is worthy of praise. This God knows that Paul was not lying. In some languages using “who” in 11:31b indicates the wrong meaning. (See note in 11:31b.) If that is true in your language, you may need to indicate the emphasis elsewhere. For example:

The God and Father of the Lord Jesus is to be praised forever! It is he who knows that I am not lying.

The God and Father of the Lord Jesus is to be praised forever! He himself knows that I am not lying.

2 Corinthians 11:32

Section 11:16–33: Paul suffered for serving Jesus

In this section, Paul first warned the Corinthians that he was not a fool (11:16a). But he wanted them to listen to what he was foolishly going to boast about (11:16b–d). He told them that Jesus would not foolishly boast in this way (11:17). He told them that he would boast in the way that the false teachers were boasting (11:18). Using irony, he rebuked them for accepting people who boasted (11:19), implying that they were wrong to accept the false teachers because the false teachers boasted about themselves. Again using irony, he told them that they should not tolerate the false teachers taking advantage of them (11:20–21a).

In 11:21b Paul began foolishly to boast about things similar to the ones that the false teachers boasted about. Recounting all his hardships, he showed that he was more devoted to serving Jesus than they were (11:23–29).

Then Paul explained the correct kind of boasting (11:30). He gave an example (11:32–33), with an oath to God to indicate he was not lying (11:31).

Other examples for this section heading are:

Paul Boasts About His Sufferings (NIV)

Paul’s Sufferings as an Apostle (ESV)

11:32a–b

This event happened about fifteen years before the time Paul wrote this letter. In some languages it is more natural to begin the verse with a time word or phrase to indicate that the event had happened about fifteen years earlier. For example:

One time, in Damascus...

Years ago in Damascus...

Once, when I was in Damascus...

11:32a

In Damascus, the governor under King Aretas

- When I was in Damascus, the town ruler who reported to King Aretas
- In Damascus the governor/mayor, an official of King Aretas,

Damascus: This name refers to an important city/town in the Roman province of Syria. In some languages

people are not familiar with this name. If that is true in your language, you may want to explain in your translation. For example:

the town/city of Damascus

governor: The Greek word that the BSB translates as governor probably refers to the ruler over the city. For example:

town governor (JBP)

mayor

under King Aretas: This phrase indicates that the leader over the governor was King Aretas. Another way to translate is:

serving under King Aretas

King: Here this word refers to a ruler who ruled an area that was partly independent. Aretas ruled Nabatea, but he had to follow directions from the emperor in Rome.

11:32b

secured the city of the Damascenes in order to arrest me.

- told his soldiers to guard the gates of the town in order to grab me and bring me before the town ruler.
- had soldiers guard the gates in the walls of the town/city to arrest me.

secured the city of the Damascenes: There was a wall all the way around the town, with gates in the walls at various places. The governor commanded some soldiers to stand at the gates and watch for Paul. He told them to arrest Paul if he tried to leave through one of the gates. Another way to translate is:

had soldiers guard the city of the Damascenes

placed guards at the city gates (GNT)

the city of the Damascenes: The word Damascenes refers to the people who lived in the city of Damascus. In some languages it is more natural to not repeat the meaning of “Damascus” here. For example:

the city (REB)

arrest: This word refers to soldiers or other officials of the city grabbing someone in order to bring him to court and punish him. Other ways to translate this word are:

seize (RSV)

grab and bring before the governor

2 Corinthians 11:33

Section 11:16–33: Paul suffered for serving Jesus

In this section, Paul first warned the Corinthians that he was not a fool (11:16a). But he wanted them to listen to what he was foolishly going to boast about (11:16b–d). He told them that Jesus would not foolishly boast in this way (11:17). He told them that he would boast in the way that the false teachers were boasting (11:18). Using irony, he rebuked them for accepting people who boasted (11:19), implying that they were wrong to accept the false teachers because the false teachers boasted about themselves. Again using irony, he told them that they should not tolerate the false teachers taking advantage of them (11:20–21a).

In 11:21b Paul began foolishly to boast about things similar to the ones that the false teachers boasted about. Recounting all his hardships, he showed that he was more devoted to serving Jesus than they were (11:23–29).

Then Paul explained the correct kind of boasting (11:30). He gave an example (11:32–33), with an oath to God to indicate he was not lying (11:31).

Other examples for this section heading are:

Paul Boasts About His Sufferings (NIV)

Paul’s Sufferings as an Apostle (ESV)

11:33a

But I was lowered in a basket through a window in the wall

- But I was put in a basket and lowered from a window in the wall of the city
- But friends tied a long rope to a large basket and put me in it and lowered it to the ground outside the town through a small opening in the wall,

I was lowered: This clause is passive. Believers living in Damascus probably lowered Paul. Some languages must use an active clause. For example:

my friends lowered me (NCV)

believers lowered me

in a basket: This basket was big enough for a man to get into. The basket had a rope attached to it, so the people could lower it carefully all the way down the wall.

basket: A basket is a bowl-shaped device woven from stiff material such as cane.

a window in the wall: The word window refers to an opening in the wall. It did not have glass in it as modern windows do. It was high up so an enemy could not climb in. It was large enough for a person to climb through, but probably not much bigger.

the wall: The wall of a city was made of large stones and was high enough to keep enemies out. The wall had gates with strong doors.

11:33b
and escaped his grasp.

- and escaped from the ruler.
- and I fled to safety from the governor/mayor.

escaped: Here this word refers to escaping. Paul avoided the soldiers by leaving through the window. For example:

slipped through (NIV)

2 Corinthians 12:1

Section 12:1–10: Paul's vision and God's promise to him

In this section, Paul continued boasting, but now about a vision he received (12:1). He spoke of a man who had seen into heaven through a vision (12:2). He indicated in 12:7 that he was the man who had seen the vision. But he spoke of another man to avoid sounding as if he was boasting. He did not want people to stop honoring him because he had seen that vision. He was not sure whether his body had been taken to heaven or whether it was only a vision (12:3). In the vision he saw amazing things (12:4). He told the Corinthians that regarding himself, he would only boast of his weaknesses (12:5). He explained why he normally avoided speaking of that vision (12:6).

Paul told of a physical ailment and why he had it (12:7). He told them that he had prayed that God would heal it (12:8). But God had said that he would not heal it. He promised that his grace would be enough to help Paul in all that he did (12:9a). God said that having

that physical ailment would help show that God's power was working though Paul (12:9b). So Paul was glad to boast in this weakness (12:9c), because when he was weak, then God's power was strong (12:9d). He explained why he was happy when trouble occurred (12:10).

Other examples for this section heading are:

Paul's Vision and His Thorn (NIV)

Paul discovered that God's grace was sufficient when he was weak

God's grace and power shown through human weakness

12:1a
I must go on boasting.

- ¶ It is necessary for me to boast now.
- ¶ I am boasting because I have to. (NJB)
- ¶ These false teachers are bragging, so I must continue bragging.

I must go on boasting: The Greek words are literally "It is necessary to boast" (as in the NRSV). Since the false teachers were boasting and at least some believers believed them, Paul felt that he must boast too. Other ways to translate this Greek phrase are:

Boasting is necessary (NASB)

I am boasting because I have to (NJB)

Paul was not saying that believers are to boast at all times. He was boasting because of the situation in Corinth. You may want to indicate that this was the proper time for him to boast. For example:

Boasting is necessary today

I am boasting now because I have to

For your sake I need to continue boasting

12:1b
Although there is nothing to gain,

- Though this boasting has no usefulness,
- Even though such boasting does not help you at all,
- This type of bragging does not usually help, but

Although there is nothing to gain: There are two ways to interpret what 12:1b connects to:

1. It connects most closely to 12:1c. For example:

Not that it does any good, but... (NJB) (BSB, RSV, NIV, NJB, CEV, NET, NCV, ESV)

1. It connects most closely to 12:1a. For example:

I have to boast, even though it doesn't do any good. (GNT) (GNT, NASB, NLT, GW, REB, KJV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Thrall (p. 772) translates the Greek text as "It is not expedient, but...." Harris (p. 828) translates it as "Although boasting is not beneficial, I will...." Martin (p. 388) translates it as "Though it is of no advantage, I will...."

there is nothing to gain: This clause indicates that Paul's boasting does not benefit the believers. After hearing the boasts, they may think more highly of Paul, but such boasting does not help them in their faith in Jesus. Other ways to translate this are:

Not that it does any good (NJB)

Though this boasting has no usefulness

Even though this boasting is unhelpful

Though this is not to anyone's personal advantage

12:1c

I will go on to visions and revelations from the Lord.

- I will begin telling about visions and revelations from the Lord.
- I will now tell you about the times that the Lord Jesus showed visions and revealed secret things.

I will go on to visions and revelations from the Lord:

The phrase I will go on refers to Paul beginning to talk about something other than what he had been talking about before. He had been talking about experiences that showed his weakness. Now he would talk about a different kind of experience. Other ways to translate this are:

But I will now talk about visions and revelations given by the Lord

but I will move on to visions and revelations from the Lord (NJB)

In 12:2a Paul spoke of the visions and revelations that he had seen as if another man had seen them. So you should not indicate here that the visions and revelations were to Paul. Translate only that he began to speak of them here.

visions: Here the word visions refers to seeing things in a supernatural way. It is like a dream, but the person is usually awake. It is something or someone that people usually cannot see, but God helps them to see it. People, by their own power, cannot see into heaven, but God enabled Paul to see into heaven (12:2). Such visions show a person something that is important for him to know.

revelations: This word means "something unknown that someone shows/reveals." It can be seen, heard, or revealed in some other way. Here it refers to God revealing something to Paul. Other ways to translate this word are:

things revealed

other things that the Lord has shown (CEV)

tell the hidden things

reveal secret knowledge

the Lord: The word Lord probably refers to Jesus here. In some languages it is more natural to include the name "Jesus" here. For example:

the Lord Jesus

2 Corinthians 12:2

Section 12:1–10: Paul's vision and God's promise to him

In this section, Paul continued boasting, but now about a vision he received (12:1). He spoke of a man who had seen into heaven through a vision (12:2). He indicated in 12:7 that he was the man who had seen the vision. But he spoke of another man to avoid sounding as if he was boasting. He did not want people to stop honoring him because he had seen that vision. He was not sure whether his body had been taken to heaven or whether it was only a vision (12:3). In the vision he saw amazing things (12:4). He told the Corinthians that regarding himself, he would only

boast of his weaknesses (12:5). He explained why he normally avoided speaking of that vision (12:6).

Paul told of a physical ailment and why he had it (12:7). He told them that he had prayed that God would heal it (12:8). But God had said that he would not heal it. He promised that his grace would be enough to help Paul in all that he did (12:9a). God said that having that physical ailment would help show that God's power was working through Paul (12:9b). So Paul was glad to boast in this weakness (12:9c), because when he was weak, then God's power was strong (12:9d). He explained why he was happy when trouble occurred (12:10).

Other examples for this section heading are:

Paul's Vision and His Thorn (NIV)

Paul discovered that God's grace was sufficient when he was weak

God's grace and power shown through human weakness

12:2a–5c

I know a man in Christ... Paul spoke about his own visions and revelations of heaven as if someone else had seen them. 12:7 makes it clear that it was Paul who had seen them. Paul wanted to tell the believers in Corinth about his experience of seeing visions. Then they would know that he was not lacking in such experiences.

But he did not want to act like the false teachers. They boasted about such experiences so that the believers would esteem them as powerful men of God. Paul did not want to boast about himself like that (12:5b). So he spoke about himself regarding these experiences in the third person (using "he" and "him" instead of "I" and "me").

In many languages a literal translation would wrongly indicate that someone else had these visions and revelations and Paul did not. If that is true in your language, you may want to explain in a footnote why Paul spoke about himself using "he" and "him." Example footnotes are:

Paul spoke about his own visions and revelations of heaven as if someone else had seen them. 12:7 makes it clear that it was Paul who had seen them. Paul wanted to tell the believers in Corinth of his experience of seeing visions so that they

would know that he was not lacking in such experiences. But Paul did not want to boast about himself as the false teachers were doing.

Paul spoke about his own visions and revelations of heaven as if someone else had seen them. He did that to avoid speaking as if he were boasting about himself. He did not want to act like the false teachers. They boasted about themselves.

12:2a–4a

I know a man in Christ who fourteen years ago was caught up to the third heaven. Whether it was in the body or out of it I do not know, but God knows. And I know that this man—whether in the body or out of it I do not know, but God knows—was caught up to Paradise. In the Greek, Paul interrupts himself twice in the middle of a sentence. The order of clauses in the Greek is:

^{2a}I know a man in Christ ^{2b}who fourteen years ago

—

^{2c}whether it was in the body or out of the body I do not know, God knows—

^{2b}was caught up to the third heaven.

^{3a}And I know that this man—

^{3b}whether in the body or apart from the body I do not know, God knows—

^{4a}was caught up to paradise.

The BSB puts the Greek 12:2b before the Greek 12:2c but does not move 12:3b. You may want to:

- Follow the order of the clauses in the Greek. In some languages it is natural to do so. For example:

^{2a}I know a man in Christ ^{2b}who fourteen years ago —^{2c}whether in the body I do not know, or out of the body I do not know, God knows—^{2b}such a man was caught up to the third heaven. ^{3a}And I know how such a man—^{3b}whether in the body or apart from the body I do not know, God knows—^{4a}was caught up into Paradise. (NASB)

- Move the interruptions to the beginning of the sentences. For example:

^{2c}Whether it was in the body or out of the body I do not know—God knows, ^{2a}but I know a man in Christ ^{2b}who fourteen years ago was caught up to the third heaven. ^{3b}And whether in the body or apart from the body I do not know—God knows, ^{3a}I know that such a man ^{4a}was caught up into Paradise.

- Move the interruptions to the end of the sentences. For example:

^{2a}but I know a man in Christ ^{2b}who fourteen years ago was caught up to the third heaven. ^{2c}Whether it was in the body or out of the body I do not know—God knows. ^{3a}And I know that such a man ^{4a}was caught up into Paradise. ^{3b}Whether in the body or apart from the body I do not know—God knows. Doing it this way, you would need to combine verse markers 3 and 4 in your translation like this:

³⁻⁴And I know that...

12:2a

I know a man in Christ

- I know a man/person who has a relationship with Christ,
- I know a follower of Christ,

a man in Christ: This phrase refers to a person who believes in Christ. He belongs to Christ. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

a man who belongs to Christ

a follower of Christ (GW)

a believerWestern Bukidnon Manobo Back Translation on TW.

See how you translated a similar phrase in 5:17 (“if anyone is in Christ”).

a man: Paul was speaking of himself here, but used the phrase a man to speak humbly about himself.

12:2b

who fourteen years ago was caught up to the third heaven.

- who was grabbed and lifted to the third heaven fourteen years ago—
- and fourteen years ago God suddenly/unexpectedly took this person above the sky, above the stars, to the place where God lives.

who fourteen years ago was caught up: This clause is passive. God brought him up to heaven. Some languages must use an active clause. For example:

whom fourteen years ago God caught up

caught up: This phrase refers to being forcefully grabbed and taken in an upward direction. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

taken up (CEV)

lifted

third heaven: This phrase refers to the place where God lives. In the Greek way of speaking, the first heaven is where the birds fly and the clouds are. The second heaven is where the sun, moon, and stars are. In some languages a literal translation would not refer to the place where God lives. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Translate literally and explain the meaning in a footnote. An example footnote is:

This phrase refers to the place where God lives. In the Greek way of speaking, the first heaven is where the birds fly and the clouds are. The second heaven is where the sun, moon, and stars are. The third heaven is the place where God lives.

- Translate the cultural meaning. For example:

the heaven/place where God lives

the highest heaven/sky

the place beyond the sun, moon, and stars

12:2c

Whether it was in the body or out of it I do not know, but God knows.

- I do not know whether his spirit was in the body or apart from the body, only God knows.
- I do not know whether he was there in his physical body, or whether he was there only with his spirit. Only God knows. that.

in the body or out of it: The phrase in the body refers to God taking Paul’s body and spirit to heaven. The phrase out of it refers to God taking only Paul’s spirit

to heaven. Paul did not know which way it happened. Other ways to translate this are:

in the body or away from the body

physically or spiritually (GW)

spirit as well as body, or only spirit

2 Corinthians 12:3

Section 12:1–10: Paul’s vision and God’s promise to him

In this section, Paul continued boasting, but now about a vision he received (12:1). He spoke of a man who had seen into heaven through a vision (12:2). He indicated in 12:7 that he was the man who had seen the vision. But he spoke of another man to avoid sounding as if he was boasting. He did not want people to stop honoring him because he had seen that vision. He was not sure whether his body had been taken to heaven or whether it was only a vision (12:3). In the vision he saw amazing things (12:4). He told the Corinthians that regarding himself, he would only boast of his weaknesses (12:5). He explained why he normally avoided speaking of that vision (12:6).

Paul told of a physical ailment and why he had it (12:7). He told them that he had prayed that God would heal it (12:8). But God had said that he would not heal it. He promised that his grace would be enough to help Paul in all that he did (12:9a). God said that having that physical ailment would help show that God’s power was working through Paul (12:9b). So Paul was glad to boast in this weakness (12:9c), because when he was weak, then God’s power was strong (12:9d). He explained why he was happy when trouble occurred (12:10).

Other examples for this section heading are:

Paul’s Vision and His Thorn (NIV)

Paul discovered that God’s grace was sufficient when he was weak

God’s grace and power shown through human weakness

12:3a

And I know that this man—

- And I know that such a man—

- I know that this same man (REB)

I know that this man: This clause indicates that Paul explained a bit more about the vision he had, but he still referred to it as if the man he mentioned in 12:2a had seen it. For example:

I know that such a man

I know that this same man (REB)

12:3b

whether in the body or out of it I do not know, but God knows—

- I do not know whether his spirit was in the body or apart from the body, only God knows—
- (again, I do not know whether he was there in his physical body, or whether he was there only with his spirit, only God knows that),

out of it: This phrase is similar in meaning to “out of the body” in 12:2c. It does not refer to a different experience.

2 Corinthians 12:4

Section 12:1–10: Paul’s vision and God’s promise to him

In this section, Paul continued boasting, but now about a vision he received (12:1). He spoke of a man who had seen into heaven through a vision (12:2). He indicated in 12:7 that he was the man who had seen the vision. But he spoke of another man to avoid sounding as if he was boasting. He did not want people to stop honoring him because he had seen that vision. He was not sure whether his body had been taken to heaven or whether it was only a vision (12:3). In the vision he saw amazing things (12:4). He told the Corinthians that regarding himself, he would only boast of his weaknesses (12:5). He explained why he normally avoided speaking of that vision (12:6).

Paul told of a physical ailment and why he had it (12:7). He told them that he had prayed that God would heal it (12:8). But God had said that he would not heal it. He promised that his grace would be enough to help Paul in all that he did (12:9a). God said that having that physical ailment would help show that God’s power was working through Paul (12:9b). So Paul was glad to boast in this weakness (12:9c), because when he was weak, then God’s power was strong (12:9d). He explained why he was happy when trouble occurred (12:10).

Other examples for this section heading are:

Paul's Vision and His Thorn (NIV)

Paul discovered that God's grace was sufficient when he was weak

God's grace and power shown through human weakness

12:4a

was caught up to Paradise.

- was grabbed and lifted into paradise.
- God suddenly/unexpectedly took him into his land that is perfectly/only good.

was caught up: See how you translated this phrase in 12:2.

to Paradise: The Greek preposition that the BSB translates as to can mean either "into" or to. In either case, Paul had arrived at paradise and could see what it looked like. For example:

into paradise (ESV)

Paradise: The word Paradise refers to a place where there are only good things. Here this good place belongs to God and he rules there. It probably refers to the third heaven.

Some languages do not have a word for the meaning of Paradise. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Translate the meaning. For example:

God's good place

God's land that is perfect

- Use the common language word.

12:4b

The things he heard were too sacred for words,

- He heard indescribable words
- He heard words which cannot be expressed in human language

The things he heard were too sacred for words:

The phrase too sacred for words indicates that Paul had heard words in heaven that he could not explain properly in human language. Other ways to translate this are:

things which cannot be put into words (GNT)

things so astounding that they cannot be expressed in words (NLT)

12:4c

things that man is not permitted to tell.

- that people are not allowed to tell others about.
- and which God has prohibited to tell.

man is not permitted to tell: This clause is passive. God prohibited speaking those words. Some languages must use an active clause. For example:

God prohibited for man to tell

God does not allow mere men to talk about

man: Here the word man refers generally to people. For example:

humans (GW)

2 Corinthians 12:5

Section 12:1–10: Paul's vision and God's promise to him

In this section, Paul continued boasting, but now about a vision he received (12:1). He spoke of a man who had seen into heaven through a vision (12:2). He indicated in 12:7 that he was the man who had seen the vision. But he spoke of another man to avoid sounding as if he was boasting. He did not want people to stop honoring him because he had seen that vision. He was not sure whether his body had been taken to heaven or whether it was only a vision (12:3). In the vision he saw amazing things (12:4). He told the Corinthians that regarding himself, he would only boast of his weaknesses (12:5). He explained why he normally avoided speaking of that vision (12:6).

Paul told of a physical ailment and why he had it (12:7). He told them that he had prayed that God would heal it (12:8). But God had said that he would not heal it. He promised that his grace would be enough to help Paul in all that he did (12:9a). God said that having that physical ailment would help show that God's power was working through Paul (12:9b). So Paul was glad to boast in this weakness (12:9c), because when he was weak, then God's power was strong (12:9d). He explained why he was happy when trouble occurred (12:10).

Other examples for this section heading are:

Paul's Vision and His Thorn (NIV)

Paul discovered that God's grace was sufficient when he was weak

God's grace and power shown through human weakness

12:5a

I will boast about such a man,

- I will boast about such a man,
- I will brag about a man who experienced that.

12:5b

but I will not boast about myself,

- but I will not boast about my own deeds,
- But I will not brag about things that give me high status in your/anyone's sight.

12:5a–b

I will boast about such a man, but I will not boast about myself: Paul continued to speak about his own visions and revelations of heaven as if someone else had seen them.

12:5c

except in my weaknesses.

- except about things that show my weaknesses.
- I will only boast about things that show that I am weak.

except in my weaknesses: This phrase indicates that Paul would only boast about things that showed his weaknesses.

weaknesses: This word refers generally to things that a person is not fully able to do. An example of Paul's weakness was his escaping from the Damascus governor in a basket (11:32–33). Paul ran away from him rather than face him. Another example of a weakness was Paul's ailment, which he called a "thorn" (12:7).

2 Corinthians 12:6

Section 12:1–10: Paul's vision and God's promise to him

In this section, Paul continued boasting, but now about a vision he received (12:1). He spoke of a man who had seen into heaven through a vision (12:2). He indicated in 12:7 that he was the man who had seen the vision. But he spoke of another man to avoid sounding as if he was boasting. He did not want people to stop honoring him because he had seen that vision. He was not sure whether his body had been taken to heaven or whether it was only a vision (12:3). In the vision he saw amazing things (12:4). He told the Corinthians that regarding himself, he would only

boast of his weaknesses (12:5). He explained why he normally avoided speaking of that vision (12:6).

Paul told of a physical ailment and why he had it (12:7). He told them that he had prayed that God would heal it (12:8). But God had said that he would not heal it. He promised that his grace would be enough to help Paul in all that he did (12:9a). God said that having that physical ailment would help show that God's power was working through Paul (12:9b). So Paul was glad to boast in this weakness (12:9c), because when he was weak, then God's power was strong (12:9d). He explained why he was happy when trouble occurred (12:10).

Other examples for this section heading are:

Paul's Vision and His Thorn (NIV)

Paul discovered that God's grace was sufficient when he was weak

God's grace and power shown through human weakness

12:6a

Even if I wanted to boast,

- For/But if I should decide to boast,
- Let me explain, if I wanted to boast about my experiences,

12:6 begins with a Greek conjunction that is often translated as "for" or "because." Here Paul explained why he could boast if he wanted to. For example:

For (NASB)

Let me explain,

Normally people boast about their strengths. Here, by contrast, Paul boasted about his weaknesses (12:5b–c). In some languages it is more natural to translate the contrast. For example:

But (NRSV)

In some languages it is more natural to allow the context to indicate the connection and omit the conjunction.

Even if I wanted to boast: This clause indicates that Paul might desire or decide to boast at some time. Other ways to translate this are:

If I wanted to boast (GNT)

then, if I do choose to boast (NJB)

But if I wish to boast (NRSV)

wanted to boast: Here Paul implied he could boast about things other than his weaknesses. This would include his visions, his deeds as an apostle, and so forth.

In some languages it may be more natural to add what Paul might boast about. For example:

wanted to boast about other things

wanted to boast about my strengths

wanted to boast about the things that show I am strong in the Lord

boast: This word refers to praising someone or saying how good someone is. Normally it is not proper for a believer to speak highly of himself. In this context Paul chose not to boast about himself, but he made it clear that if he did, he would be telling the truth. Other ways to translate this word are:

speak very highly about

praise

tell about how great/wonderful/good

See how you translated this word in 1:12 or 11:10.

12:6b

I would not be a fool,

- I would not speak like a fool,
- I would not be foolish,

12:6c

because I would be speaking the truth.

- because I would tell the truth.
- because I would be telling you what actually happened.

12:6b–c

I would not be a fool, because I would be speaking the truth: 12:6c is the reason for Paul not being a fool (12:6b). In some languages it is more natural to translate the reason before the result. For example:

I would be speaking the truth, so I would not be a fool

While it is foolish for a believer to boast about himself, because it is selfish to do that, it is even more foolish to boast untruthfully about what he has done. Paul implied here that the false teachers were fools because they lied when they boasted.

12:6d

But I refrain,

- But I avoid doing that,
- But I prevent myself from such boasting,

I refrain: The verb refrain refers to not doing something. Here Paul would refrain from selfish boasting. If people would not clearly see what Paul would refrain from, you may want to explain in your translation. For example:

I refrain from boasting about myself

12:6e

so no one will credit me with more

- in order that no one will give too high of status to me,
- so that no one would hold/regard my name/reputation too highly.

credit me with more: The Greek word that the BSB translates as credit me with more refers to considering someone to have high status. Paul did not want people to think that he was better or more important than other believers because he had visions and revelations. Other ways to translate this are:

have a higher opinion of me (GNT)

go too far in giving me high status

regard me beyond (NET)

12:6f

than he sees in me or hears from me,

- rather than giving me status based on what I do and say.
- I want people's opinion of me to be based on only what I have done and said.

than he sees in me or hears from me: These words indicate that Paul wanted people to think of him based only on what he did and said. Other ways to translate this are:

you have as a result of what you have seen me do and heard me say (GNT)

he sees and hears me to be (NJB)

I want people's opinion of me to be based only on what I have done and said

2 Corinthians 12:7

Section 12:1–10: Paul's vision and God's promise to him

In this section, Paul continued boasting, but now about a vision he received (12:1). He spoke of a man who had seen into heaven through a vision (12:2). He indicated in 12:7 that he was the man who had seen the vision. But he spoke of another man to avoid sounding as if he was boasting. He did not want people to stop honoring him because he had seen that vision. He was not sure whether his body had been taken to heaven or whether it was only a vision (12:3). In the vision he saw amazing things (12:4). He told the Corinthians that regarding himself, he would only boast of his weaknesses (12:5). He explained why he normally avoided speaking of that vision (12:6).

Paul told of a physical ailment and why he had it (12:7). He told them that he had prayed that God would heal it (12:8). But God had said that he would not heal it. He promised that his grace would be enough to help Paul in all that he did (12:9a). God said that having that physical ailment would help show that God's power was working through Paul (12:9b). So Paul was glad to boast in this weakness (12:9c), because when he was weak, then God's power was strong (12:9d). He explained why he was happy when trouble occurred (12:10).

Other examples for this section heading are:

Paul's Vision and His Thorn (NIV)

Paul discovered that God's grace was sufficient when he was weak

God's grace and power shown through human weakness

12:7a

or because of these surpassingly great revelations. So to keep me from becoming conceited,

- ¶ And/But in order that I might not become too proud because of those very wonderful revelations,

- ¶ I had those surpassingly great revelations, so to prevent me from setting myself above others,

or: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as or indicates that Paul continues talking about revelations from God but now identifies himself as the man who received these revelations. This conjunction is commonly translated as “and.”

There is some contrast to Paul boasting about his experiences (12:6a–c), so the GNT says:

But (GNT)

In some languages it is more natural to allow the context to indicate the connection and omit this conjunction.

because of these surpassingly great revelations. So to keep me from becoming conceited: In the Greek, the phrase because of these surpassingly great revelations occurs at the beginning of the verse. English versions interpret in two different ways how this phrase connects to the context:

1. It connects to the rest of 12:7a. For example:

But to keep me from being puffed up with pride because of the many wonderful things I saw (GNT) (BSB, RSV, NIV, GNT, NASB, REB, NCV, ESV, KJV)

1. It connects to 12:6d–f (“But I refrain, so no one will credit me with more than he sees in me or hears from me”). For example:

^{6d}But I refrain from it, ^{6e}so that no one may think better of me ^{6f}than what is seen in me or heard from me, ^{7a}even considering the exceptional character of the revelations. Therefore, to keep me from being too elated (NRSV) (NJB, NIV11, NRSV, NABRE, NLT, CEV, GW, NET)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Harris (p. 828), Thrall (p. 772), and Barrett (p. 305), translate according to interpretation (1). Thrall takes over two pages to describe the problem and her reasoning for choosing interpretation (1).

to keep me from: The verb phrase keep...from refers here to preventing something. God allowed a physical ailment to affect Paul to prevent him from being conceited. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

in order to prevent my (JBP)

So that I would not become (NCV)

in order that I might not

becoming conceited: This phrase refers to being overly proud of oneself. Paul, after seeing Paradise, might have become too proud because he had seen it. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

exalting myself (NASB)

feel too proud (CEV)

become arrogant (NET)

these surpassingly great revelations: There are two ways to interpret the Greek word that the BSB translates as surpassingly great:

1. It indicates that the revelations were very great. For example:

the exceptional greatness of the revelations (NJB) (BSB, NIV, NJB, NRSV, NASB, NLT, CEV, NET, REB, NCV, ESV)

1. It indicates that there were very many revelations. For example:

the abundance of revelations (RSV) (RSV, NABRE, GW, KJV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Harris (p. 828) translates the Greek phrase as “the extraordinary nature of the revelations.” Thrall (p. 772) translates it as “the extraordinary quality of the revelations.” Martin (p. 388) translates it as “the extraordinary revelations.” The GNT (“many wonderful”) interprets the Greek word both ways, but this seems unlikely here.

these: This word indicates that Paul was speaking of the revelations in 12:2–4.

surpassingly great: The Greek word that the BSB translates surpassingly great means “beyond measure, to the extreme, exceptional.” Other ways to translate the Greek word are:

extraordinary character (NET)

magnificence (REB)

General Comment on 12:7a

The reason occurs second here. In some languages it is more natural to have the reason first. For example:

I had these surpassingly great revelations, so to keep me from becoming conceited

12:7b

I was given a thorn in my flesh,

- a thorn in my body was given to me,
- God allowed me to suffer an ailment in my body.

I was given a thorn: This clause is passive. God allowed Satan to give the thorn to Paul. Some languages must use an active clause. For example:

God allowed a thorn to torment me

thorn: This is a metaphor. It probably refers to a physical ailment or continuous suffering of some kind. Paul never explained exactly what the thorn was.

In some languages a literal translation would wrongly refer only to an actual thorn. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Translate literally and explain the meaning in a footnote. For example:

The word “thorn” is a metaphor. It probably refers to a physical ailment or suffering of some kind.

- Explain the meaning in your translation. For example:

thorn, namely, this suffering I endure

- Translate the meaning without the metaphor. For example:

suffering

in my flesh: This phrase refers to Paul’s body. For example:

in my body

12:7c

a messenger of Satan, to torment me.

- a messenger sent by Satan to make me suffer. This was to keep me from becoming too proud.

- It was like a messenger whom Satan sent to hit me again and again. As I said, the purpose of this suffering was to prevent me from setting myself above others.

a messenger of Satan: This phrase explains the phrase “a thorn in my flesh.” The word messenger could refer to:

1. A demon tormenting Paul’s body in some way.
2. A metaphor for the suffering. Satan caused Paul to suffer in some way.

Translate in a way that allows either one or both of these meanings.

Satan: The word Satan is the Hebrew name of the chief or leader of all the evil spirits. In Hebrew his name means “enemy.” He is the enemy of God and God’s people. Translate this word as you did in 2:11 and 11:14.

to torment me.: Paul repeated the phrase (“to keep me from becoming conceited,” 12:7a) here to emphasize that meaning. The BSB chose not to repeat it here. That meaning is more important than who was tormenting him. Paul realized that God’s purpose for this suffering was to keep Paul humble. Other ways to translate this emphasis are:

to torment me—to keep me from exalting myself!
(NASB)

to torment me. As I said, this was to keep me from becoming conceited.

Translate “to keep me from becoming conceited” as you did in 12:7a.

torment: This word refers to hitting someone or causing someone pain in some way over a period of time. Other ways to translate this word are:

beat (GNT)

make...suffer (CEV)

cause pain

2 Corinthians 12:8

Section 12:1–10: Paul’s vision and God’s promise to him

In this section, Paul continued boasting, but now about a vision he received (12:1). He spoke of a man who had seen into heaven through a vision (12:2). He

indicated in 12:7 that he was the man who had seen the vision. But he spoke of another man to avoid sounding as if he was boasting. He did not want people to stop honoring him because he had seen that vision. He was not sure whether his body had been taken to heaven or whether it was only a vision (12:3). In the vision he saw amazing things (12:4). He told the Corinthians that regarding himself, he would only boast of his weaknesses (12:5). He explained why he normally avoided speaking of that vision (12:6).

Paul told of a physical ailment and why he had it (12:7). He told them that he had prayed that God would heal it (12:8). But God had said that he would not heal it. He promised that his grace would be enough to help Paul in all that he did (12:9a). God said that having that physical ailment would help show that God’s power was working through Paul (12:9b). So Paul was glad to boast in this weakness (12:9c), because when he was weak, then God’s power was strong (12:9d). He explained why he was happy when trouble occurred (12:10).

Other examples for this section heading are:

Paul’s Vision and His Thorn (NIV)

Paul discovered that God’s grace was sufficient when he was weak

God’s grace and power shown through human weakness

12:8

Three times I pleaded with the Lord to take it away from me.

- Concerning that thorn, I prayed three separate times to the Lord to remove it.
- I prayed three times to the Lord Jesus, earnestly asking him to stop the suffering.

12:8 begins with the Greek phrase that can be translated as “About this” (as in the NJB). The word “this” refers to the thorn in the flesh, the messenger of Satan. For example:

Concerning this (NASB)

Many English versions omit this phrase, because the pronoun “it” in this verse makes it clear what Paul is referring to.

Three times: This phrase refers to three separate occasions. It does not mean that Paul repeated himself three times in one prayer.

pleaded: This word refers to asking something earnestly. Other ways to translate this word are:

appealed (NRSV)

earnestly asked

prayed (GNT)

the Lord: The word Lord means “one in authority over others” or “master.” See how you translated this word in 1:2 or 1:14.

The word Lord probably refers to Jesus here. In some languages it is more natural to include the name “Jesus” here. For example:

the Lord Jesus

it: This pronoun refers to the thorn in the flesh, the messenger of Satan (12:7b–c).

2 Corinthians 12:9

Section 12:1–10: Paul’s vision and God’s promise to him

In this section, Paul continued boasting, but now about a vision he received (12:1). He spoke of a man who had seen into heaven through a vision (12:2). He indicated in 12:7 that he was the man who had seen the vision. But he spoke of another man to avoid sounding as if he was boasting. He did not want people to stop honoring him because he had seen that vision. He was not sure whether his body had been taken to heaven or whether it was only a vision (12:3). In the vision he saw amazing things (12:4). He told the Corinthians that regarding himself, he would only boast of his weaknesses (12:5). He explained why he normally avoided speaking of that vision (12:6).

Paul told of a physical ailment and why he had it (12:7). He told them that he had prayed that God would heal it (12:8). But God had said that he would not heal it. He promised that his grace would be enough to help Paul in all that he did (12:9a). God said that having that physical ailment would help show that God’s power was working through Paul (12:9b). So Paul was glad to boast in this weakness (12:9c), because when he was weak, then God’s power was strong (12:9d). He

explained why he was happy when trouble occurred (12:10).

Other examples for this section heading are:

Paul’s Vision and His Thorn (NIV)

Paul discovered that God’s grace was sufficient when he was weak

God’s grace and power shown through human weakness

12:9a

But He said to me, “My grace is sufficient for you,

- But he said to me, “My grace is enough for you^(sing),
- And he told me, “No, my kindness is adequate for you to live/cope with that thorn/suffering.

But He said to me: Jesus replied after Paul had prayed the third time.

said: The tense on the Greek verb indicates that Jesus had answered earlier and that the answer remains the appropriate when Paul wrote this letter. For example:

has said (NASB)

Many English versions translate with a simple past tense as the BSB does.

My grace is sufficient for you: Jesus had replied that he would not remove the thorn, but that instead his grace would enable Paul to live and cope with the suffering. Other ways to translate this clause are:

My grace is enough for you (NET)

My grace is sufficient for you to live/cope with this thorn/suffering

grace: The word grace here refers to God being kind to those who do not deserve it. God does things for people because he wants to and not because they have earned it. Other ways to translate this word are:

kindness (CEV)

help

favor

See how you translated this word in 1:12 or 9:14.

12:9b

for My power is perfected in weakness.”

- because my power has complete influence/control in weakness.”
- For if someone is weak, my strength is completely clear/evident.”

for: Jesus used the word that the BSB translates as for to introduce the reason why his grace was sufficient for Paul.

My power is perfected in weakness: The Greek words are literally “power is perfected in weakness” (as in the NASB). The word power refers to Jesus’ power. This clause indicates that when a person is weak, he has no power of his own. Therefore Jesus’ power can operate in a complete manner because no other power is available. Other ways to translate this are:

my power has complete influence/control in weakness

my power is exactly/completely shown in a person’s weakness

This will show that only my power is working in your weakness

if someone is weak, my strength is completely clear/evident

when a person is weak, then it is obvious that it is my power working in him

12:9c

Therefore I will boast all the more gladly in my weaknesses,

- So I will very gladly boast about my weaknesses instead of praying that prayer.
- So I will more happily praise the things that weaken me,

Therefore I will boast all the more gladly in my weaknesses: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as all the more gladly is literally “rather, most gladly.” The word “rather” implies that Paul would boast of his weaknesses instead of asking God to remove them. Other ways to translate this are:

Most gladly, therefore, I will rather boast about my weaknesses (NASB)

So I stopped requesting that he remove it, but rather I am very happy to brag about my weakness

12:9d

so that the power of Christ may rest on me.

- I will do that in order that Christ may empower me.
- so that the power of Christ remains in me.

so that: This phrase introduces the purpose in boasting about his own weakness. Here is another way to translate this:

in order that (GW)

the power of Christ may rest on me: The word rest means “remain” here. If Paul lived according to his weakness and avoided trying to do things by his own power, then the power of Christ would continuously operate in his life. Other ways to translate this are:

the power of Christ may dwell in me (NASB)

Christ’s power will live in me (GW)

Christ keeps giving me his power (CEV)

2 Corinthians 12:10

Section 12:1–10: Paul’s vision and God’s promise to him

In this section, Paul continued boasting, but now about a vision he received (12:1). He spoke of a man who had seen into heaven through a vision (12:2). He indicated in 12:7 that he was the man who had seen the vision. But he spoke of another man to avoid sounding as if he was boasting. He did not want people to stop honoring him because he had seen that vision. He was not sure whether his body had been taken to heaven or whether it was only a vision (12:3). In the vision he saw amazing things (12:4). He told the Corinthians that regarding himself, he would only boast of his weaknesses (12:5). He explained why he normally avoided speaking of that vision (12:6).

Paul told of a physical ailment and why he had it (12:7). He told them that he had prayed that God would heal it (12:8). But God had said that he would not heal it. He promised that his grace would be enough to help Paul in all that he did (12:9a). God said that having that physical ailment would help show that God’s power was working through Paul (12:9b). So Paul was glad to boast in this weakness (12:9c), because when he was weak, then God’s power was strong (12:9d). He

explained why he was happy when trouble occurred (12:10).

Other examples for this section heading are:

Paul's Vision and His Thorn (NIV)

Paul discovered that God's grace was sufficient when he was weak

God's grace and power shown through human weakness

12:10a

That is why, for the sake of Christ, I delight in weaknesses,

- Therefore, I am very content/delighted enduring for Christ whenever I am weak,
- So I am joyful enduring through these to benefit Christ: things that weaken me,

That is why: The Greek word that the BSB translates as That is why is often translated as "therefore" (as in the NRSV).

for the sake of Christ: This phrase applies to all five situations: "in weaknesses, in insults, in hardships, in persecutions, in difficulties." Paul endured weaknesses, insults, hardships, persecutions, and difficulties to benefit the cause of Christ. For example:

I am well content with weaknesses, with insults, with distresses, with persecutions, with difficulties, for Christ's sake (NASB)

I delight in weaknesses, in insults, in hardships, in persecutions, in difficulties, endured for the benefit of Christ

I delight in: When Paul experienced weaknesses, insults, hardships, persecutions, or difficulties, then God's power could operate. So Paul was happy about that. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

I am glad of (NJB)

I am well content with (NASB)

I am very pleased with

I gladly accept

12:10b

in insults, in hardships,

- or when people insult me, or when I endure disasters,
- insults, hard times that happen to me,

insults: This word refers to saying evil or wrong things about someone's character, beliefs, or behavior. People would say these things in order to shame someone, hurt his feelings, or ruin his reputation. Some other examples for translating are:

ridicule my character

say bad/hurtful things about me

hardships: This word refers to very difficult situations or circumstances. Other ways to translate this word are:

disasters

troubles

See how you translated this word in 6:4.

12:10c

in persecutions, in difficulties.

- or when people persecute me, or whenever I am in terrible situations.
- people causing me to suffer, or disasters.

persecutions: This word refers to other people causing troubles for Paul. They did that because Paul preached about Jesus. Other ways to translate this word are:

oppression

being harassed

causing me to suffer

difficulties: This refers to very bad situations or circumstances that overwhelm the people who are in them. They must endure through them. Other ways to translate this word are:

calamities (RSV)

very hard times

terrible situations

See how you translated this word in 6:4 (where the BSB translates it as “calamities”).

12:10d

For when I am weak, then I am strong.

- For it is when I am weak that I am strong. (NJB)
- I can say that because when I am weak, I am strong in the power of Christ.

then I am strong: The word strong refers to someone being strong with Christ’s power and not his own power. Paul used the opposite of “weak” without explaining it so that the readers would think about the meaning.

In some languages a literal translation would not have the above meaning. If that is true in your language, you may want to include the implied information. For example:

then I am strong in Christ’s power

then I am strong because he strengthened me

then I am empowered by Christ’s strength

2 Corinthians 12:11

Section 12:11–21: Proof that Paul was an apostle and his concern for the believers

In this section, the attitude of some believers in Corinth forced Paul to act foolishly and boast (12:11a). Paul knew he deserved praise from them and was better than the false teachers even though humanly speaking he deserved nothing (12:11b–d). Paul reminded the believers of all that he had done among them that proved he was an apostle (12:12). He asked them if they were angry at him with a rhetorical question and, using irony, told them that they should not be angry (12:13).

He told them that he would continue to avoid accepting their money for his support and explained why (12:14). He told them of his great love for them (12:15).

Using irony, Paul told them that he had not deceived them (12:16) and that his colleagues had not exploited them either (12:17–18). He explained that he had not been defending himself, but rather he was teaching them to be strong in their faith (12:19). He told them of some of his fears about them (12:20–21).

Other examples for this section heading are:

Paul’s Concern for the Corinthian Church (NRSV)

Paul loved the believers in Corinth

Paul reminded the believers in Corinth about his deeds and explained his worry for them

Paul defended his apostleship and spoke about his concern for the believers

12:11a

I have become a fool, but you drove me to it.

- ¶ I have been foolish, but it is you^(plur) who forced me to be that way.
- ¶ I spoke like a fool in the things I just wrote, because you yourselves made me do it/that.

I have become a fool, but you drove me to it:

The Greek words are literally “I became foolish, you compelled me.” The clause “you compelled me” is the reason for Paul acting like a fool. The Greek does not indicate contrast. Other ways to translate this are:

I became foolish because you compelled me

You have made me act like a fool (NLT)

I have become a fool: By boasting in a worldly way (11:17–12:10), Paul acted foolishly. Other ways to translate this are:

I have been a fool! (RSV)

I am acting like a fool (GNT)

I spoke like a fool in the things I have just said

you drove me to it: The pronoun you is emphasized in the Greek. If possible, emphasize the pronoun in your language. For example:

you yourselves drove me to it

it is you who drove me to it

you were the ones who drove me to it

12:11b

In fact, you should have commended me,

- For I should have been recommended by you
- It would have been right/proper for you to recommend me to others,

In fact: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as In fact is often translated as “for” or “because.” Here Paul explained why he felt he needed to boast foolishly. For example:

for (RSV)

Let me explain,

In some languages it is more natural to allow the context to indicate the connection and omit the conjunction.

you should have commended me: Although the BSB translates this clause as active, it is passive in Greek and some other English versions. For example:

I ought to have been commended by you (NIV)

commended: Here the word commended indicates to speak favorably of someone and say that he is worthy of the approval of others. Paul had to boast about himself because the believers in Corinth did not commend him to others. Other ways to translate this are:

show your approval (GNT)

say good things (NCV)

urge approval of

See how you translated the word “commend” in 6:4.

12:11c

since I am in no way inferior to those “super-apostles,”

- because none of the very superior/special “apostles” is in any way superior to me,
- for I have done as much or more as those who wrongly call themselves the greatest of all the chosen messengers of Jesus Christ,

since: Here the word since introduces the reason why the believers should have commended Paul.

I am in no way inferior to: The Greek words are literally “in nothing did I fail to reach.” These words indicate that Paul was equal to (or better than) the false teachers in every way. The BSB translation has the same meaning. The believers in Corinth had seen

his deeds and heard his teachings, so they could agree that Paul was equal to or better than the false teachers. Other ways to translate this are:

I am not surpassed by

in every way I am as good as

those super-apostles are no more worthy than I

inferior: This word refers to one thing being less good than something else. Paul did not have a weaker ministry than the false teachers.

super-apostles: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as super-apostles also occurs in 11:5. Translate the phrase as you did in 11:5. For example:

very special “apostles” (GNT)

12:11d

even though I am nothing.

- even if I am nobody.
- even though I have no worth/importance.

even though I am nothing: The phrase even though indicates that Paul had a great ministry (12:11c) but as a person he had no status before God. Other ways to translate this are:

even if I am nobody

I may be nothing at all, but I am as good as those super apostles. (CEV)

I am nothing: This clause indicates that humanly speaking, Paul had no status to impress God with. Nobody else does either. Other ways to translate this clause are:

I am a nobody (NASB)

I am worth nothing (NCV)

I have no importance

I have nothing to impress God with

2 Corinthians 12:12

Section 12:11–21: Proof that Paul was an apostle and his concern for the believers

In this section, the attitude of some believers in Corinth forced Paul to act foolishly and boast (12:11a). Paul knew he deserved praise from them and was better than the false teachers even though humanly speaking he deserved nothing (12:11b–d). Paul reminded the believers of all that he had done among them that proved he was an apostle (12:12). He asked them if they were angry at him with a rhetorical question and, using irony, told them that they should not be angry (12:13).

He told them that he would continue to avoid accepting their money for his support and explained why (12:14). He told them of his great love for them (12:15).

Using irony, Paul told them that he had not deceived them (12:16) and that his colleagues had not exploited them either (12:17–18). He explained that he had not been defending himself, but rather he was teaching them to be strong in their faith (12:19). He told them of some of his fears about them (12:20–21).

Other examples for this section heading are:

Paul's Concern for the Corinthian Church (NRSV)

Paul loved the believers in Corinth

Paul reminded the believers in Corinth about his deeds and explained his worry for them

Paul defended his apostleship and spoke about his concern for the believers

12:12a–c

The true marks of an apostle—signs, wonders, and miracles—were performed among you with great perseverance: The list signs, wonders, and miracles appears at the end of the verse in the Greek. For example:

The signs of a true apostle were performed among you with utmost patience, signs and wonders and mighty works. (NRSV)

In some languages it is more natural to have the list at the end of the sentence, rather than interrupting the sentence as the BSB does.

12:12a–b

The true marks of an apostle—signs, wonders, and miracles: There are several ways to interpret the connection of these two phrases. Two of the main ones are:

1. The signs, wonders, and miracles are examples of The true marks of an apostle. For example:

the things that prove I am an apostle—signs, wonders, and miracles (NCV) (BSB, NIV, GNT, NJB, NRSV, NABRE, NLT, GW, CEV, NCV)

1. The signs, wonders, and miracles are the means of making The true marks of an apostle evident. They are not The true marks of an apostle. For example:

The signs of an apostle were performed among you with great perseverance by signs and wonders and powerful deeds (NASB) (NASB, NET, REB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Thrall (p. 837) says “he has produced the recognised signs of apostleship.” Bruce (p. 250) seems to equate “the signs of a true apostle” with “signs and wonders and mighty works.” Hodge (pp. 291–292) says the “signs, wonders, and mighty deeds...are different designations for the same thing” (referring to the “signs of an apostle”).

12:12a

The true marks of an apostle—

- Truly/Indeed, the deeds that indicate someone is an apostle,
- The characteristic acts of an apostle

12:12a begins with the Greek conjunction that probably means “indeed” here. It emphasizes that Paul did things that apostles do and the believers saw them. Some ways to translate this conjunction are:

Truly (KJV)

certainly (NLT)

Indeed (NET)

In some languages it is more natural to omit the conjunction.

The true marks of an apostle: This phrase refers to deeds that show a person is a true apostle of Jesus. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

The signs of a true apostle (RSV)

the things that prove I am an apostle (NCV)

The characteristic acts of an apostle

In some languages it is more natural to put the list “signs, wonders, and miracles” before the phrase true marks of an apostle. For example:

the signs, wonders, and miracles that mark an apostle’s life/ministry

the signs, wonders, and miracles which prove that I’m an apostle (GW)

12:12b signs, wonders, and miracles—

- for example, miraculous signs, marvels, and miracles,
- are things such as deeds/miracles of showing that someone is an apostle, miracles of awe, and miracles of power.

signs, wonders, and miracles: This list includes examples of the things that mark an apostle. It is not a complete list, because Paul lists other examples in other verses. You may want to indicate in your translation that this list offers some (but not all) examples of the things that mark an apostle. For example:

such as signs, wonders, and miracles

for example, signs, wonders, and miracles

signs: The word signs refers to unusual events that people regard as having special meaning. A sign suggests or points to a meaning other than its own. Here the word probably refers to miracles that clearly indicated that Paul was an apostle of Jesus. Other ways to translate this word are:

miraculous signs

miracles of proof

wonders: This word refers to miracles that amaze people. Other ways to translate this word are:

marvels (NJB)

miracles of awe

awesome miracles

miracles: The Greek word that the BSB translates here as miracles is literally “powers.” A miracle is an action that requires great power to accomplish. When a human being does a miracle, he must use greater power than human beings normally have. Paul used God’s power to do miracles, and these miracles demonstrated that God was working through him. Other ways to translate this word are:

mighty works

amazing acts done with/by God’s power

wonderful actions that only God can empower

supernatural deeds

12:12c were performed among you with great perseverance.

- were done with patient endurance when I was with you^(plur).
- God did those things among you through me as I was very patient with you.

were performed: The clause “things...were performed” is passive. Paul probably implied that God performed the signs, wonders, and miracles. He did them through Paul. But Paul may be humbly referring to himself by using the passive. Some languages must use an active clause. For example:

God did through me

I did

among you: God (through Paul) did the signs, wonders, and miracles so that the believers in Corinth saw them. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

When I was with you (CEV)

You saw

perseverance: This word refers to continuing to follow God even though there are hardships or oppo-

sition. The attitude of patience is included in the meaning. Other ways to translate this word are:

patient endurance

patiently (NLT)

See how you translated this Greek word in 1:6 (where the BSB translates it as “patient endurance”) or 6:4 (where the BSB translates it as “endurance”).

2 Corinthians 12:13

Section 12:11–21: Proof that Paul was an apostle and his concern for the believers

In this section, the attitude of some believers in Corinth forced Paul to act foolishly and boast (12:11a). Paul knew he deserved praise from them and was better than the false teachers even though humanly speaking he deserved nothing (12:11b–d). Paul reminded the believers of all that he had done among them that proved he was an apostle (12:12). He asked them if they were angry at him with a rhetorical question and, using irony, told them that they should not be angry (12:13).

He told them that he would continue to avoid accepting their money for his support and explained why (12:14). He told them of his great love for them (12:15).

Using irony, Paul told them that he had not deceived them (12:16) and that his colleagues had not exploited them either (12:17–18). He explained that he had not been defending himself, but rather he was teaching them to be strong in their faith (12:19). He told them of some of his fears about them (12:20–21).

Other examples for this section heading are:

Paul’s Concern for the Corinthian Church (NRSV)

Paul loved the believers in Corinth

Paul reminded the believers in Corinth about his deeds and explained his worry for them

Paul defended his apostleship and spoke about his concern for the believers

12:13a

In what way were you inferior to the other churches, except that I was not a burden to you?

- One thing that I did to other churches was accept their money to supply my needs. I did not do to you^(plur). Does that make you feel inferior?
- I asked other churches to support me by sending me money, but I never asked you to do that. Do not think that I treated you worse by doing that!
- Do not feel inferior to other churches just because I never required money from you!

In what way were you inferior to the other churches, except that I was not a burden to you?:

This is a rhetorical question. It emphasizes the meaning, “You were not inferior to other churches, except that I was not a burden to you.” This question is also irony because Paul asked them how they were inferior when he wanted them to know that they were not inferior. Paul had not been a burden to them, but that was no reason to feel inferior. Translate in a way that emphasizes that meaning. Some ways to translate this are:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Is there any way in which you have been given less than the rest of the churches, except that I did not make myself a burden to you? (NJB)

What makes you feel so inferior to other churches? Is it because I have not allowed you to support me financially? (JBP)

There was one thing I did not do to you that I did to other churches, namely, I was never a financial burden to you. Does that make you feel inferior?

- As a statement. For example:

There is one way in which I have lowered your status compared with the rest of the churches, namely, I did not make myself a burden to you.

One thing I did not do to you that I did to other churches was to make myself a financial burden to you.

- As a command. For example:

Do not feel inferior to other churches just because I was never a burden to you!

were...inferior: This phrase refers to having less status than others. The believers in Corinth felt they had

less status than other churches because they had not supported Paul with money. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

were...less favored (RSV)

treated...worse (GNT)

given less (NJB)

the other churches: This phrase refers to groups of believers in other towns where Paul had preached and taught.

I: The Greek words are literally “I alone” or “I myself.” The Greek phrase emphasizes the contrast between what he did and what the false apostles did. For example:

I myself (RSV)

As for me, I

burden: Here the word burden refers to the believers in Corinth needing to give money to Paul for his needs. It would have been a burden because if they gave money to Paul, they would have less for themselves. Other ways to translate this word are:

financial help (GNT)

you didn’t have to support me (CEV)

12:13b

Forgive me this wrong!

- Please forgive me for being so wrong!
- I have not been unfair to you^(plur) so do not think I have sinned against you!

Forgive me this wrong: This is irony, as in 12:13a. Paul did not need them to forgive him. He wanted them to see their wrong thinking and change their minds. Other ways to translate this are:

Please forgive me for being so unfair! (GNT)

Do you think I have sinned against you in this way? Then forgive me!

In some languages the correct meaning can only be translated by explaining the irony. Some ways to translate this clause in that way are:

I have not been unfair to you so do not think I have sinned against you!

You are wrong to think that I have sinned against you by doing that!

There is no way that my doing that could truly/ honestly be considered doing you wrong!

2 Corinthians 12:14

Section 12:11–21: Proof that Paul was an apostle and his concern for the believers

In this section, the attitude of some believers in Corinth forced Paul to act foolishly and boast (12:11a). Paul knew he deserved praise from them and was better than the false teachers even though humanly speaking he deserved nothing (12:11b–d). Paul reminded the believers of all that he had done among them that proved he was an apostle (12:12). He asked them if they were angry at him with a rhetorical question and, using irony, told them that they should not be angry (12:13).

He told them that he would continue to avoid accepting their money for his support and explained why (12:14). He told them of his great love for them (12:15).

Using irony, Paul told them that he had not deceived them (12:16) and that his colleagues had not exploited them either (12:17–18). He explained that he had not been defending himself, but rather he was teaching them to be strong in their faith (12:19). He told them of some of his fears about them (12:20–21).

Other examples for this section heading are:

Paul’s Concern for the Corinthian Church (NRSV)

Paul loved the believers in Corinth

Paul reminded the believers in Corinth about his deeds and explained his worry for them

Paul defended his apostleship and spoke about his concern for the believers

12:14a

See, I am ready to come to you a third time,

- ¶ Look/Hey, I am ready to travel to you^(plur) for a third visit,
- ¶ Now listen! I am ready to come and visit you for the third time.

See: The Greek word here is literally “look.” It emphasizes the fact that Paul was ready to visit them for the third time. It is not a command to look at something. Other ways to translate this word are:

Look (NET)

Here (NJB)

Indeed/Hey

Listen!

I am ready to come to you a third time: Paul had made plans to visit the believers in Corinth a third time. At that time he was ready to begin traveling to them. Other ways to translate this are:

I am...ready to come to you this third time (NRSV)

I am coming to you for the third time (NLT)

I am ready to travel to you for a third visit

12:14b

and I will not be a burden,

- and I will still not be a financial burden to you,
- And again I will not accept support from you,

a burden: This word has the same meaning here as it does in 12:13a.

12:14c

because I am not seeking your possessions, but you.

- because I do not want your things, I want you instead.
- because I do not want you to give me your things. I just want you to devote yourselves to me as your leader.

I am not seeking your possessions: This clause indicates that Paul was not interested in taking what the believers possessed. Other ways to translate this clause are:

I seek not what is yours (RSV)

it is not your possessions that I want (NJB)

I don't want what you have (NLT)

possessions: This word includes money as well as anything else they might give to Paul. If the word possessions in your language does not include money, include that in your translation. For example:

money and things

what you have including money

but you: The phrase “I want” is implied but not repeated here. For example:

Instead, I want you (GW)

It indicates that Paul wanted them to be devoted to him and not to follow the false teachers. He wanted them to love him and accept him as their leader in spiritual matters (as the Macedonians did in 8:5). In some languages a literal translation would not have that meaning. If that is true in your language, you may want to explain in your translation. For example:

I want your hearts to be true/faithful

I want you to be devoted to me as your leader

12:14d

For children should not have to save up for their parents,

- For children ought not to save their money and things for their parents to use,
- This saying applies to you and me: young children should not have to save money for their parent's benefit,

For: The Greek word that the BSB translates literally as For introduces the reason for Paul not wanting the possessions of the believers. For example:

because (NET)

In some languages it is more natural to allow the context to imply the connection and omit this word.

But Paul used the following saying to show he was doing the right thing. He was like the parent and the believers were like the children in the saying. In

some languages it is more natural to indicate that the following saying refers figuratively to Paul and the believers. For example:

An example is this:

This saying applies to you and me:

children should not have to save up for their parents: Paul used this saying to help explain why he does not want their money. He is like a father to the believers.

In some languages a literal translation would not refer to the believers and Paul here. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Explain beforehand that the saying applies to them, as in the examples above.
- Explain the meaning in your translation. For example:

I am like your parent/father, and children should not have to save up for their parents

- Translate literally and explain the meaning in a footnote. An example footnote is:

Paul was like a father to the believers.

children: Here the word children refers to young children. It does not refer to grown men and women who are the children of their parents. In some languages a literal translation of 12:14d would indicate or imply grown children. If that is true in your language, indicate that the word here refers to young children. For example:

little children

save up: This phrase refers to saving money. When the children are little, they do not work and save money for their parents.

12:14e
but parents for their children.

- rather parents save their money for their children to use.
- instead a parent should save money for their children's benefit.

parents for their children: The verb phrase "save up" is implied from 12:14d but not repeated here. In some

languages it is more natural to repeat the phrase here. For example:

parents save up for their children

2 Corinthians 12:15

Section 12:11–21: Proof that Paul was an apostle and his concern for the believers

In this section, the attitude of some believers in Corinth forced Paul to act foolishly and boast (12:11a). Paul knew he deserved praise from them and was better than the false teachers even though humanly speaking he deserved nothing (12:11b–d). Paul reminded the believers of all that he had done among them that proved he was an apostle (12:12). He asked them if they were angry at him with a rhetorical question and, using irony, told them that they should not be angry (12:13).

He told them that he would continue to avoid accepting their money for his support and explained why (12:14). He told them of his great love for them (12:15).

Using irony, Paul told them that he had not deceived them (12:16) and that his colleagues had not exploited them either (12:17–18). He explained that he had not been defending himself, but rather he was teaching them to be strong in their faith (12:19). He told them of some of his fears about them (12:20–21).

Other examples for this section heading are:

Paul's Concern for the Corinthian Church (NRSV)

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Paul defended his apostleship and spoke about his concern for the believers

12:15a–b

I will most gladly spend my money and myself: The Greek words that the BSB translates literally as I will most gladly spend imply that Paul would spend what he had, without keeping anything for himself. Other ways to translate this are:

I will very gladly spend and be spent for you (KJV)

I am more than glad to spend what I have (NJB)

I will be glad to spend all I have (GNT)

12:15a

And for the sake of your souls, I will most gladly spend my money

- And I will very gladly give what I have
- I will be very happy to use all I have to help you^(plur) follow God.

And: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as And is often translated as “and” or “but.” Here it indicates a continuation of the story.

Several English versions interpret the connection as introducing a result. For example:

So (NIV)

In some languages it is more natural to allow the context to indicate the connection and omit the conjunction.

spend: This verb refers to spending money. But in this context, it also refers to using any resources that Paul had, including his possessions and his time. If the verb spend refers only to spending money in your language, you should use a verb that includes the whole meaning here. For example:

give (CEV)

use

12:15b and myself.

- and give my life for you.
- I will also be very happy to use all that I am to help you follow God.

and myself: The Greek literally says “and be completely spent.” The words refer to Paul devoting his whole life to helping the believers in Corinth be strong in faith. It indicates that he would work so hard that his life would be shorter and therefore be expended for them. Other ways to translate this are:

to be spent (NJB)

be expended (NASB)

myself as well (GNT)

give...all that I am (CEV)

12:15c

If I love you more, will you love me less?

- If my love for you is great, why is your love for me small?
- I love you much, but it seems that you love me only a little.

If I love you more, will you love me less?: There is a textual issue in 12:15c. (1) Some Greek manuscripts have the Greek word that means if (BSB, RSV, NIV, NASB, NET, REB, NCV, ESV). (2) Some Greek manuscripts have the Greek phrase that means even though (KJV, NLT, JBP). It is recommended that you follow option (1). The word If is used rhetorically to cause the believers in Corinth to think about how much Paul loves them. If using the word If indicates in your language that Paul might not love them as much as they love him, you may want to omit the word If. For example:

I love you more; will you love me less?

I love you more, right? Will you love me less?

I love you more, will you love me less?: This is a rhetorical question. It emphasizes the meaning, “My love for you is much, but your love for me is little.” The clause is a rebuke. Paul wanted them to love him more than they did at that time. Translate in a way that emphasizes that meaning. Some ways to translate this are:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

My love for you is great; why is your love for me small?

- As a statement. For example:

it seems that the more I love you, the less you love me. (NLT)

I love you much, but it seems that you love me little!

more...less: These two words refer to how much love Paul and the believers in Corinth have. It does not refer to increasing or decreasing that love. Other ways to translate this are:

the more...the less (RSV)

much...little

2 Corinthians 12:16

Section 12:11–21: Proof that Paul was an apostle and his concern for the believers

In this section, the attitude of some believers in Corinth forced Paul to act foolishly and boast (12:11a). Paul knew he deserved praise from them and was better than the false teachers even though humanly speaking he deserved nothing (12:11b–d). Paul reminded the believers of all that he had done among them that proved he was an apostle (12:12). He asked them if they were angry at him with a rhetorical question and, using irony, told them that they should not be angry (12:13).

He told them that he would continue to avoid accepting their money for his support and explained why (12:14). He told them of his great love for them (12:15).

Using irony, Paul told them that he had not deceived them (12:16) and that his colleagues had not exploited them either (12:17–18). He explained that he had not been defending himself, but rather he was teaching them to be strong in their faith (12:19). He told them of some of his fears about them (12:20–21).

Other examples for this section heading are:

Paul's Concern for the Corinthian Church (NRSV)

Paul loved the believers in Corinth

Paul reminded the believers in Corinth about his deeds and explained his worry for them

Paul defended his apostleship and spoke about his concern for the believers

12:16a

Be that as it may, I was not a burden to you;

- ¶ Let us agree that I was not a financial burden to you^(plur),
- ¶ You admit, then, that I certainly did not accept support from you.

Be that as it may: The phrase that the BSB translates as Be that as it may is literally “And/But let.” There are two ways to interpret the Greek words:

1. They indicate that Paul believed the believers in Corinth would agree with the following statement (“I have not been a burden to you”). This statement

is a summary of a previous topic (12:13–14). For example:

granting that (RSV) (RSV, GNT, NABRE, NLT, GW, CEV, ESV, NCV)

1. They conclude the previous topic about love (12:15c) and indicate contrast to the next statement. For example:

All right, then (NJB) (BSB, NIV, NJB, NASB, NET, KJV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Martin (p. 444) says “he assumes that his readers concede him the point that he has not been a direct burden on anyone.” Furnish (p. 557) translates the Greek phrase as “Now, it is agreed that.” Furnish (p. 558) says, “Epictetus II.iv.5...provides the closest parallel...‘assuming that’.”

Other ways to translate this phrase according to interpretation (1) are:

You agree, then, (GNT)

I know you agree that

12:16b

but crafty as I am, I caught you by trickery.

- but/however you know me to be so crafty/clever, and I deceived you completely!
- Am I such a crafty fellow that I caught/deceived you by a trick? Of course not!
- But someone must have said that I am crafty and deceived you completely, which is a lie.

but: The Greek word that the BSB translates as but indicates strong contrast. Here 12:16a is a statement the believers in Corinth could agree with. But 12:16b is a false statement, written as irony, so that the believers would disagree. They would say that Paul was always honest and taught without deceit. Consider how to indicate here this kind of contrast in your language.

crafty as I am, I caught you by trickery: This clause is probably the accusation of the false teachers against Paul. He uses it in irony. Paul was not crafty. He did not deceive the believers. By using irony here, Paul said that the accusation was a lie and the believers should know it was a lie. For the irony you may want to:

- Translate in a way that clearly shows the irony. For example:

You know me to be so crafty/clever, and I deceived you completely!

because I was such a crafty person, I captured you by deceit!

- Translate the irony as a rhetorical question. The rhetorical question should clearly indicate that Paul said that the accusation was a lie. For example:

Am I such a crafty fellow that I caught/deceived you by a trick? Of course not!

Was I a clever person who trapped you by some trick? (GW)

- Translate the irony as a statement from someone else. Most of the believers did not believe that Paul deceived them, so the “someone” should imply the false teachers. For example:

someone must have said that I am crafty and deceived you completely, which is a lie.

others still think I was sneaky and took advantage of you by trickery (NLT)

crafty: Here the word crafty refers to a person who is able to deceive people easily. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

a clever person (GW)

I was tricky (GNT)

I am such a good deceiver

caught: The Greek word here is literally “took.” Here it refers figuratively to influencing people so that they follow lies. The false teachers probably accused Paul of influencing the believers so that they followed lies. Other ways to translate this Greek word are:

trick to his own advantage

cheat

See how you translated this Greek word in 11:20 (where the BSB translates it as “takes advantage of”).

trickery: The Greek word that the BSB translates as trickery refers to deceit or treachery. Other ways to translate this word are:

guile (RSV)

deceit (NASB)

2 Corinthians 12:17

Section 12:11–21: Proof that Paul was an apostle and his concern for the believers

In this section, the attitude of some believers in Corinth forced Paul to act foolishly and boast (12:11a). Paul knew he deserved praise from them and was better than the false teachers even though humanly speaking he deserved nothing (12:11b–d). Paul reminded the believers of all that he had done among them that proved he was an apostle (12:12). He asked them if they were angry at him with a rhetorical question and, using irony, told them that they should not be angry (12:13).

He told them that he would continue to avoid accepting their money for his support and explained why (12:14). He told them of his great love for them (12:15).

Using irony, Paul told them that he had not deceived them (12:16) and that his colleagues had not exploited them either (12:17–18). He explained that he had not been defending himself, but rather he was teaching them to be strong in their faith (12:19). He told them of some of his fears about them (12:20–21).

Other examples for this section heading are:

Paul’s Concern for the Corinthian Church (NRSV)

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Paul defended his apostleship and spoke about his concern for the believers

12:17

Did I exploit you by anyone I sent you?

- Have I taken advantage of you through any of the people I have sent to you? (NJB)
- Certainly I have not cheated you by means of any of the ones I sent to you, have I?

- Indeed, I have not exploited you^(plur) when I sent to you people at various times.

Did I exploit you by anyone I sent you?: This is a rhetorical question. It emphasizes the meaning, “I did not exploit you through any of the men I sent you.” Paul expected the believers to know that his men had not exploited them. Translate in a way that emphasizes that meaning. Some ways to translate this are:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Have I taken advantage of you through any of the people I have sent to you? (NJB)

Certainly I have not taken advantage of you through any of those whom I have sent to you, have I? (NASB)

- As a statement. For example:

Indeed, I have not taken advantage of you through any of the people I have sent to you!

As you know, I have certainly not taken advantage of you through any of those whom I have sent to you.

exploit you by anyone I sent you: Here the word by refers to doing something by means of someone else. Paul ordered the men to do certain things with the believers, and they followed those orders. But Paul did not tell them to exploit the believers, and they did not exploit the believers in any way. Other ways to translate this are:

exploit you by means of any of the men I sent you

cheat you by using any of the messengers I sent to you (NCV)

exploit: This word refers to taking someone’s money by deceptive means or for wrong reasons. Other ways to translate this are:

take advantage of (RSV)

cheat (NCV)

See how you translated this word in 7:2.

2 Corinthians 12:18

Section 12:11–21: Proof that Paul was an apostle and his concern for the believers

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He told them that he would continue to avoid accepting their money for his support and explained why (12:14). He told them of his great love for them (12:15).

Using irony, Paul told them that he had not deceived them (12:16) and that his colleagues had not exploited them either (12:17–18). He explained that he had not been defending himself, but rather he was teaching them to be strong in their faith (12:19). He told them of some of his fears about them (12:20–21).

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12:18a

I urged Titus to visit you, and I sent our brother with him.

- I urged Titus and he went and visited you^(plur). And I sent our^(incl) other brother with him.
- For example, I urged Titus to go and sent our fellow-believer with him.

I urged Titus to visit you, and I sent our brother with him: This sentence refers to one of the times that Paul had sent someone (12:17). The visit of Titus was important to Paul. Of all of Paul’s coworkers, the believers in Corinth perhaps knew Titus the best and trusted him the most. So Paul used the example of Titus to show clearly that the believers could trust Paul as well.

In some languages it will not be clear that 12:18 is an example of what Paul said in 12:17. If that is true in your language, you may want to explain the connection in your translation. For example:

In particular, I urged Titus to go to you and I sent our brother with him

For example, I urged Titus to go to you and I sent our brother with him

brother: Here the word brother refers to a believer. The word indicates a close relationship, because all believers are children of God. See how you translated this word in 1:1 or 11:9.

Paul did not name this believer, but the believers in Corinth knew him.

12:18b

Did Titus exploit you in any way?

- Did Titus take advantage of you? Of course not!
- Titus certainly did not exploit you!

Did Titus exploit you in any way?: This is a rhetorical question. It emphasizes the meaning, “Titus did not exploit you in any way.” Translate in a way that emphasizes that meaning. Some ways to translate this are:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

did Titus take advantage of you? No! (NLT)

Would you say that Titus took advantage of you? (GNT)

- As a statement. For example:

Titus certainly did not exploit you!

Assuredly Titus did not take advantage of you!

12:18c

Did we not walk in the same Spirit and follow in the same footsteps?

- Did we^(excl, dual) not act the same way towards you? Did we not take the same steps/path regarding you?
- We certainly had the same motives and behaved the same way in relating to you!

Did we not walk in the same Spirit and follow in the same footsteps?: There are two issues here.

Issue 1: Interpretation

There are two ways to interpret the word Spirit:

1. It refers to attitudes about things. Paul and Titus had the same attitude about relating to the believers. For example:

Do not he and I act from the very same motives and behave in the same way? (GNT) (RSV, NIV, GNT, NASB, NABRE, NLT, GW, CEV, NET, NCV, ESV, KJV)

1. It refers to the Holy Spirit. For example:

Have we not both been guided by the same Spirit, and followed the same course? (REB) (BSB, NJB, REB, NLT96)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Harris (p. 892) says it refers here to a “disposition of mind.” Thrall (p. 855) says it refers here to the “human disposition.” Martin (p. 449) says it is “parallel with ‘in the same steps’.”

Issue 2: Rhetorical Question

This is a rhetorical question. It emphasizes the meaning of “we acted in the same spirit and follow the same course.” Translate in a way that emphasizes that meaning. Some ways to translate this are:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Did we not conduct ourselves with the same spirit? Did we not take the same steps? (NRSV)

Didn't we have the same motives and do things the same way? (GW)

- As a statement. For example:

Indeed, we acted in the same spirit and follow the same course!

We certainly have the same motives and do things the same way!

walk in the same Spirit: This phrase refers to relating to the believers in the same way. Both Paul and Titus had the same attitudes towards the believers in Corinth. Other ways to translate this are:

act from the very same motives (GNT)

have the same heart

follow in the same footsteps: This phrase refers to doing things in the same way. Paul and Titus related to the believers in Corinth in the same manner. Other ways to translate this are:

behave in the same way (GNT)

walked the same path/track

2 Corinthians 12:19

Section 12:11–21: Proof that Paul was an apostle and his concern for the believers

In this section, the attitude of some believers in Corinth forced Paul to act foolishly and boast (12:11a). Paul knew he deserved praise from them and was better than the false teachers even though humanly speaking he deserved nothing (12:11b–d). Paul reminded the believers of all that he had done among them that proved he was an apostle (12:12). He asked them if they were angry at him with a rhetorical question and, using irony, told them that they should not be angry (12:13).

He told them that he would continue to avoid accepting their money for his support and explained why (12:14). He told them of his great love for them (12:15).

Using irony, Paul told them that he had not deceived them (12:16) and that his colleagues had not exploited them either (12:17–18). He explained that he had not been defending himself, but rather he was teaching them to be strong in their faith (12:19). He told them of some of his fears about them (12:20–21).

Other examples for this section heading are:

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Paul reminded the believers in Corinth about his deeds and explained his worry for them

Paul defended his apostleship and spoke about his concern for the believers

12:19a–b

Have you been thinking all along that we were making a defense to you?: This rhetorical question emphasizes the meaning, “You should not have been

thinking all along that we were making a defense to you.” Translate in a way that emphasizes that meaning. Some ways are:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Is it possible that all along you have been thinking that we have been defending ourselves to you?

Might you have been thinking all along that we have been defending ourselves to you?

- As a statement. For example:

Perhaps you have been thinking all along that we have been defending ourselves before you.

Perhaps you think we're saying these things just to defend ourselves. No,... (NLT)

12:19a

Have you been thinking all along that

- ¶ Is it possible that for a long time now you^(plur) have been thinking that
- ¶ Perhaps you have been thinking the whole time while hearing this letter that

all along: This phrase refers to the whole time that this letter was being read to the believers in Corinth. Some of the believers may have thought from the beginning of the reading that the letter was about Paul defending himself. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

up to now

all the time you have been reading this letter

12:19b

we were making a defense to you?

- we^(excl) have been speaking on our own behalf to you?
- we have been speaking to you about/against those accusations against us. Not so/true.

we were making a defense: The phrase making a defense refers to people explaining that they have done the right thing, or that they have not done the wrong thing. Paul sometimes explained those things in this letter, but the purpose of doing so was to strengthen the faith of the believers (12:19d). Other ways to translate this are:

we have been pleading our own cause (NJB)

we have been speaking against those accusations against us

we have been explaining that our actions are correct/right instead of what the people who accuse us say

12:19c

We speak before God in Christ,

- We have been speaking before God as followers of Christ.
- We have been saying those things as Christ would have us say them and with God hearing all we say.

before God: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates literally as before God indicates that God knew all that Paul said. Paul lived his life as if God was watching him. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

in the presence of God (NJB)

in the sight of God (NIV)

with God as our witness (NLT)

in Christ: This phrase refers to Paul acting in ways that believers should act. The phrase in Christ refers to having a relationship with Jesus. The person behaves as Jesus showed him how to. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

as Christ would have us speak (GNT)

as followers of Christ (CEV)

12:19d

and all of this, beloved, is to build you up.

- And, our loved ones, all of it is to improve your faith.
- Loved friends, all we have said/done is for the purpose of helping you believe well.

and all of this, beloved, is to build you up: Here the term of address, beloved, is in the middle of the clause. In some languages it is more natural to have the term of address first. For example:

Dear friends, everything we do is for your strengthening

beloved: The Greek word that the BSB translates as beloved means “those who are loved.” The word indicates that Paul loved the believers in Corinth. Other ways to translate this Greek word are:

dear friends (NIV)

those whom we love

our dear ones

we love you

all of this: The Greek word that the BSB translates as all of this is literally “all things.” Here the Greek word refers to all that Paul and his coworkers said and did for the believers in Corinth. Other ways to translate this Greek word are:

all of it

we did it all (CEV)

build you up: This word refers to helping the believers in Corinth to believe in Jesus without doubting. Other ways to translate this word are:

strengthening of your faith

help you believe well

help you in your spiritual life (JBP)

edifying (KJV)

2 Corinthians 12:20

Section 12:11–21: Proof that Paul was an apostle and his concern for the believers

In this section, the attitude of some believers in Corinth forced Paul to act foolishly and boast (12:11a). Paul knew he deserved praise from them and was better than the false teachers even though humanly speaking he deserved nothing (12:11b–d). Paul reminded the believers of all that he had done among them that proved he was an apostle (12:12). He asked them if they were angry at him with a rhetorical question and, using irony, told them that they should not be angry (12:13).

He told them that he would continue to avoid accepting their money for his support and explained why (12:14). He told them of his great love for them (12:15).

Using irony, Paul told them that he had not deceived them (12:16) and that his colleagues had not exploited them either (12:17–18). He explained that he had not been defending himself, but rather he was teaching them to be strong in their faith (12:19). He told them of some of his fears about them (12:20–21).

Other examples for this section heading are:

Paul's Concern for the Corinthian Church (NRSV)

Paul loved the believers in Corinth

Paul reminded the believers in Corinth about his deeds and explained his worry for them

Paul defended his apostleship and spoke about his concern for the believers

12:20a

For I am afraid that when I come,

- For I fear that when I come
- For I am concerned/worried that when I come to visit you,

For: This conjunction introduces the reason why Paul wanted to strengthen the faith of the believers in Corinth. Another way to translate this word is:

because

In some languages it is more natural to allow the context to indicate the connection and omit the conjunction.

I am afraid: This clause indicates that Paul was concerned about finding that the believers were quarreling and so forth (12:20d–f). Other ways to translate this are:

I fear (RSV)

I am uneasy

I am concerned

12:20b

I may not find you as I wish,

- I shall not perhaps find you as I should like to find you, (JBP)
- I will perhaps see that you^(plur) are not living as I want you to live.

I may not find you as I wish: Paul wanted the believers to live according to the ways of Jesus. This clause indicates that they might instead have the problems listed in 12:20d–f. Other ways to translate this are:

I may find you different from what I should like you to be (NJB)

I shall not perhaps find you as I should like to find you (JBP)

I might discover that you are not living for Christ as I would like for you to live

I may...find you: The Greek phrase is literally “I may perhaps find you.” The word “perhaps” indicates uncertainty or gentleness. By saying 12:20, Paul hoped that if there were problems, the believers would correct them before he arrived. For example:

perhaps...I may find you (ESV)

find you: The word find refers to seeing for himself that the believers were a certain way. In some languages it is more natural to use another verb here. For example:

see that you

discover that you

observe that you

12:20c

and you may not find me as you wish.

- and you shall not perhaps find me as you should like to find me.
- And because of that, you will perhaps see that I will not act as gently with you as you would like.

you may not find me as you wish: If the believers had problems as in 12:20d–f, then Paul would have to correct them. In that case, the believers might not see Paul as an encouraging leader. They would want an encouraging leader rather than someone who disciplined them. Other ways to translate this are:

you may find me what you would not like me to be (NJB)

you will not find me coming quite as you would like me to come (JBP)

you may not find me: The word “perhaps” is implied but not repeated here.

find: The word find has the same meaning here as in 12:20b.

12:20d

I fear that there may be quarreling, jealousy,

- For I fear that perhaps you may be arguing, resenting other believers,
- I am concerned/worried that I will perhaps see that you are bickering, or acting as rivals,

I fear that there may be: The Greek phrase includes the word “perhaps,” as in 12:20b.

jealousy: Here the Greek word that the BSB translates as jealousy refers to zeal for the wrong things. It may have been rivalry between believers over what was correct Christian teaching, support for false teachers, or perhaps bad feelings towards other believers because of what they have. The word does not refer to a man being jealous about a woman or a woman being jealous about a man. Other ways to translate this word are:

resentment

evil zeal

rivalry

12:20e–f

rage, rivalry, slander, gossip, arrogance, and disorder: The items in this list are all plural. This indicates that each of these things might happen more than once, or that many people were involved in doing these things.

12:20e

rage, rivalry, slander,

- acting in anger, being selfish, insulting/dishonoring other believers with words,
- or that you are often angry, selfish, or speaking evil things against another,

rage: This phrase refers to strong anger and not to just being upset. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

intense anger (NET)

hot tempers (GNT)

rivalry: There are three ways to interpret the Greek word that the BSB translates as rivalry:

1. It means selfishness. For example:

selfish ambition (GW) (RSV, GNT, NABRE, NLT, GW, CEV, NET, NCV)

1. It means divisions between groups who are arguing with one another. For example:

personal rivalries (REB) (BSB, NIV, REB)

1. It means quarrels. For example:

disputes (NASB) (NJB, NASB, ESV, KJV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Martin (p. 463) translates the Greek word as “selfish ambitions” and says, “Originally this word was used to describe one seeking political office for selfish reasons.” Kistemaker (p. 435) translates it as “outbreaks of selfishness.” Furnish (p. 557) translates it as “cases of self-seeking.” It is not recommended that you follow interpretation (3), because “quarrels” had already been mentioned in 12:20d.

slander: This word refers to lies told for the purpose of hurting someone’s reputation, name, or status. Other ways to translate this word are:

insults (GNT)

speaking evil things against another

12:20f

gossip, arrogance, and disorder.

- telling gossip/rumors, acting proudly, or being rebellious.
- or that you are spreading lies, being conceited, or disturbing others.

gossip: This word refers to telling harmful information to one person about someone else. Often this information is not true but only what people are saying. Other ways to translate this word are:

rumor telling

spreading lies

arrogance: This word refers to acting in a proud and conceited way. Such a person thinks he is better than others. Other ways to translate this word are:

pride (GNT)

conceit (RSV)

thinking he is important

disorder: This word refers to a person doing things that disturb others or being rebellious. Other ways to translate this word are:

acting like a mob (CEV)

disturbances (NASB)

defying authority

2 Corinthians 12:21

Section 12:11–21: Proof that Paul was an apostle and his concern for the believers

In this section, the attitude of some believers in Corinth forced Paul to act foolishly and boast (12:11a). Paul knew he deserved praise from them and was better than the false teachers even though humanly speaking he deserved nothing (12:11b–d). Paul reminded the believers of all that he had done among them that proved he was an apostle (12:12). He asked them if they were angry at him with a rhetorical question and, using irony, told them that they should not be angry (12:13).

He told them that he would continue to avoid accepting their money for his support and explained why (12:14). He told them of his great love for them (12:15).

Using irony, Paul told them that he had not deceived them (12:16) and that his colleagues had not exploited them either (12:17–18). He explained that he had not been defending himself, but rather he was teaching them to be strong in their faith (12:19). He told them of some of his fears about them (12:20–21).

Other examples for this section heading are:

Paul's Concern for the Corinthian Church (NRSV)

Paul loved the believers in Corinth

Paul reminded the believers in Corinth about his deeds and explained his worry for them

Paul defended his apostleship and spoke about his concern for the believers

12:21a

I am afraid that when I come again, my God will humble me before you,

- I fear that when I come again, God will humble me in your^(plur) presence,
- I am concerned/worried that when I come to visit you, God will shame me as I stand before you over the disobedience I will see.

my God will humble me before you: If the believers obeyed Paul's commands in this letter, he would be proud of them. But if they did not obey him, he would feel that God had humbled him because they had not learned well what he taught them. Other ways to translate this are:

God will humble me in your presence (NLT)

God will shame me as I stand before you over the disobedience I will see

before you: This phrase indicates that the believers would see that God had humbled Paul. See the examples above.

12:21b

and I will be grieved over many who have sinned earlier

- and I will mourn about many of you who sinned previously
- And I will weep as if over a dead loved one for any of you who sinned before

I will be grieved: The verb grieved indicates that Paul would feel very sad toward those who had not repented. He would feel as he would toward someone whom he had loved but who had died. For example:

I may have to mourn (RSV)

I will feel as if I am grieving for someone who died

12:21c–d

impurity, sexual immorality, and debauchery: Here the three Greek words refer to sexual sin. Each term focuses on a slightly different kind of sexual sin. All together they refer to every kind of sexual sin. Also see the notes on these words below.

12:21c

and have not repented of their acts of impurity, sexual immorality,

- and have not repented of the perverse sex, sexual immorality,
- but have not changed their thinking about the dirty/impure sex, other sexual sin,

repented: The Greek word here refers to changing one's mind. It implies that the believers were to stop sinning and start obeying God. Some other examples are:

turn back to God

changed their hearts or turned from (NCV)

leave the ways of sin and follow the ways of God

See how you translated this word in 7:9 (where the BSB translates it as “repentance”).

acts: The Greek word that the BSB translates as acts refers to something that is done regularly. For example:

practicing

habitually doing

impurity: Here the Greek word that the BSB translates as impurity refers to sex that people would say was morally awful. For example:

perversion (GW)

filthy sexual sins

sexual immorality: Here the Greek word that the BSB translates as sexual immorality refers to prostitution and sex between people who are not married. For example:

fornication (KJV)

12:21d

and debauchery.

- and life of lust that they practiced.
- and their continual desiring/seeking of sex.

debauchery: This word refers to excessive sexual practices. Other ways to translate this word are:

living based on lust

sensuality (NASB)

eagerness for lustful pleasure (NLT)

promiscuity (GW)

In this division, Paul concluded his letter with some warnings (13:1–10) and some final greetings (13:11–13). He then ended the letter with a blessing (13:14).

2 Corinthians 13:1**Section 13:1–10: Some warnings**

In this section, Paul warned the believers that he would punish anyone who was sinning and refusing to repent (13:1–2). He said he would do that because some believers in Corinth were demanding proof from him that he was a true apostle (13:3a). He told them that he could work powerfully because Jesus is powerful (13:3b). He told them that they were weak in their natural abilities but had God's power, as Jesus did when he lived on earth (13:4).

Then Paul commanded them to look carefully at themselves to see if they were truly believers or not (13:5). Paul expected that if they studied Paul's words and deeds, then they would see that he was a true apostle (13:6). Paul told them that he and his coworkers prayed for the believers in Corinth that they would not sin and that they would do what was right (13:7). Paul told them that he and his coworkers worked in accordance with the truth (13:8). He told the believers that he prayed that they would always do as God wanted them to do (13:9). He told them that he wrote about their problems so that they would correct those problems themselves. Then he would encourage them when he went there and would not have to discipline them (13:10).

Other examples for this section heading are:

Examine Yourselves (NASB)

Paul gave final warnings

Final warnings and greetings

13:1a

This is the third time I am coming to you.

- ¶ I am coming to you^(plur) for a third visit.
- ¶ I will come to you for the third time. (NCV)

This is the third time I am coming to you: Paul's first visit was when he first went to Corinth and spent eighteen months preaching and starting a new church (Acts 18:1-11). Later he made a short visit to deal with a believer who was sinning (2 Corinthians 2:1). Now, after he had sent this letter, he would go to Corinth a third time. Other ways to translate this are:

I am coming to you for a third visit

I will come to you for the third time (NCV)

13:1b

“Every matter must be established by the testimony of two or three witnesses.”

- “By the evidence of two or three witnesses, every issue/problem will be proved.”
- “In a case of sin/wrongdoing, two or three witnesses must say the same thing about it to prove that it truly happened.”

Every matter must be established by the testimony of two or three witnesses: Paul quoted Deuteronomy 19:15b here. He used it as a basis for his words in 13:2. Paul had already warned the sinning believers. He warned them again in 13:2. When he returned to Corinth, he would punish the believers who had not repented. Paul established this matter by writing these warnings that they had sinned.

In some languages people will not see the connection of this clause to 13:2. If that is true in your language, you may want to:

- Simply refer to the book, chapter and verse in a footnote. For example:

Deuteronomy 19:15b

- Explain in a footnote. An example footnote is:

These words are from Deuteronomy 19:15b. They are the basis for judging someone guilty or innocent according to Jewish law. By quoting it here,

Paul indicates he has done as the law requires and is ready to punish any believer who has not repented of that sin.

matter: Here the word matter refers to what is being talked about. As 13:2 explains, Paul referred here to the sin that some believers in Corinth were still doing. Other ways to translate this word are:

fact (NASB)

facts of every case (NLT)

charge (RSV)

accusation (GNT)

by the testimony of two or three witnesses: This phrase is emphasized in the Greek. If possible, emphasize it in your language. In some languages this may be emphasized by putting this phrase first in the sentence. For example:

It is by the testimony of two or three witnesses that any matter/charge is established.

testimony: The Greek word that the BSB translates as testimony is literally “mouths.” If a second person tells the same information as another person, he verifies the information told by the first person. Other ways to translate this word are:

evidence (NJB)

message about what happened

Some languages translate this meaning using a verb. For example:

revealed the truth

proved true (CEV)

witnesses: This word refers to people who speak about something they saw, something they heard, or something they know. The word is often used where the person is expected to be truthful and accurate. Other ways to translate this are:

people who tell what they saw/know

people who report/explain

2 Corinthians 13:2

Section 13:1–10: Some warnings

In this section, Paul warned the believers that he would punish anyone who was sinning and refusing to repent (13:1–2). He said he would do that because some believers in Corinth were demanding proof from him that he was a true apostle (13:3a). He told them that he could work powerfully because Jesus is powerful (13:3b). He told them that they were weak in their natural abilities but had God's power, as Jesus did when he lived on earth (13:4).

Then Paul commanded them to look carefully at themselves to see if they were truly believers or not (13:5). Paul expected that if they studied Paul's words and deeds, then they would see that he was a true apostle (13:6). Paul told them that he and his coworkers prayed for the believers in Corinth that they would not sin and that they would do what was right (13:7). Paul told them that he and his coworkers worked in accordance with the truth (13:8). He told the believers that he prayed that they would always do as God wanted them to do (13:9). He told them that he wrote about their problems so that they would correct those problems themselves. Then he would encourage them when he went there and would not have to discipline them (13:10).

Other examples for this section heading are:

Examine Yourselves (NASB)

Paul gave final warnings

Final warnings and greetings

13:2a–c

The order of the Greek phrases in this verse are:

1. I have foretold
2. and I say beforehand,
3. as being present the second time,
4. and now being absent,
5. to the ones having sinned previously,
6. and to all of the rest,
7. that if I come again,
8. I will not spare (anyone/them).

Paul gave this warning twice: "if I come again, I will not spare (anyone/them)" (parts g-h). The first time

is described in parts (a) and (c). The second time is described in parts (b) and (d). Paul probably told both groups, (e) and (f), both times. In English, it is more natural to have the parts in this order: (c), (a), (e), (f), (g), (h), (d), (b). This becomes:

When I was present the second time, I have foretold to the ones having sinned previously and to all of the rest that if I come again I will not spare anyone who is still sinning. And now being absent I say beforehand that same warning.

It is also possible, from the order of the Greek phrases, that (e) goes with (a) and (c) and that (f) goes with (b) and (d). This option would translate as: "When I was present the second time, I have foretold to the ones having sinned previously that if I come again I will not spare anyone who is still sinning. And now being absent I say beforehand that same warning to all of the rest." But the warning was probably told to everyone both times.

The Display has moved (e) and (f) to be the hearers of the warning, which follows the Greek.

13:2a

I already warned you the second time I was with you.

- When I visited you^(plur) the second time, I warned those who sinned earlier and all the others.
- During my second visit, I warned those who sinned in the past and all the others there.

the second time I was with you: This clause refers to the previous visit that Paul made to Corinth. That was his second visit there. He was about to visit them the third time. Other ways to translate this clause are:

when I was there on my second visit (NLT)

during my second visit to you (GNT)

13:2b

So now in my absence I warn those who sinned earlier and everyone else:

- Now while I am not yet there, I repeat what I said beforehand,
- Before I come there, I now warn again ahead of my next visit to you

now in my absence I warn: This clause indicates that Paul warned them again in this letter. The Corinthians received this letter before he arrived there. Other ways to translate this clause are:

I will say it again now that I am away (GNT)

though I am not with you, I give notice again (NJB)

I now repeat it before I am with you again

13:2c

If I return, I will not spare anyone,

- that if I come back there I will not let any of them escape punishment.
- that when I return I will not have mercy on any who have not repented.

those who sinned earlier and everyone else: If I return, I will not spare anyone: In the Greek the phrases those who sinned earlier and everyone else refer to those whom Paul warned (13:2a–b). For example:

I warned those who sinned before and all the others, and I warn them now while absent, as I did when present on my second visit, that if I come again I will not spare them (RSV)

The meaning lines in the Display move those phrases to 13:2a.

If I return, I will not spare anyone: The Greek words are literally “if I come again I will not spare.” When Paul was with them the previous time, he was probably not sure that he would return. So he used the word “if.” Later, when he wrote this letter, he was planning to return to Corinth. But he used the word “if” again, as he did the first time he warned them. For example:

if I come again I will not spare them (RSV)

But in some languages using “if” would indicate that Paul might not visit them a third time. If that is true in your language, translate without using “if.”

I will not spare anyone: Here this phrase indicates that Paul would punish all who were sinning. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

I will punish all who deserve it

I will stop being patient with everyone who is sinning

I shall have no mercy (NJB)

I will not be lenient (NRSV)

those who sinned earlier: The tense of the Greek verb probably indicates that these people were sinning during Paul’s second visit and had not repented at the time of this letter. This group were probably committing sexual sins as listed in 12:21, but they may also have been committing other sins. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

those who sinned earlier and have not repented

those who have sinned before (NKJV)

those who had sinned before that visit (JBP)

everyone else: This phrase may refer to:

1. People who began sinning after Paul’s second visit. They may have sinned as listed in 12:20 or by following the false teachers. (The false teachers came after Paul’s second visit.)
2. The rest of the believers. The second warning would be to warn them not to begin sinning.

These are two very different groups, and it is not clear which interpretation is correct. So, translate this phrase in a general way. For example:

all the others (GNT)

all the rest (NASB)

2 Corinthians 13:3

Section 13:1–10: Some warnings

In this section, Paul warned the believers that he would punish anyone who was sinning and refusing to repent (13:1–2). He said he would do that because some believers in Corinth were demanding proof from him that he was a true apostle (13:3a). He told them that he could work powerfully because Jesus is powerful (13:3b). He told them that they were weak in their natural abilities but had God’s power, as Jesus did when he lived on earth (13:4).

Then Paul commanded them to look carefully at themselves to see if they were truly believers or not (13:5). Paul expected that if they studied Paul’s words and deeds, then they would see that he was a true apostle (13:6). Paul told them that he and his coworkers prayed for the believers in Corinth that they would not sin and that they would do what was right (13:7). Paul told them that he and his coworkers worked in accordance

with the truth (13:8). He told the believers that he prayed that they would always do as God wanted them to do (13:9). He told them that he wrote about their problems so that they would correct those problems themselves. Then he would encourage them when he went there and would not have to discipline them (13:10).

Other examples for this section heading are:

Examine Yourselves (NASB)

Paul gave final warnings

Final warnings and greetings

13:3a

since you are demanding proof that Christ is speaking through me.

- For you^(plur) seek proof that Christ speaks through me.
- I say that since you want me to prove to you that Christ speaks through me as his apostle/representative.

since: This word introduces a reason why Paul would spare no one who had continued to sin. Other ways to translate this are:

because

The reason is

you are demanding proof: The Greek word that the BSB translates as are demanding is literally “seek.” Some of the believers were not satisfied that Paul was truly an apostle, so they sought proof from him about that. Other ways to translate this clause are:

you seek proof (ESV)

you desire proof (RSV)

you are asking for a proof (NJB)

proof: This word refers to evidence of the truthfulness of something that comes from testing it. The believers wanted to test Paul to see if he was truly an apostle. The evidence that they expected was probably a miracle or sign. Other ways to translate this word are:

evidence

This should prove to you (CEV)

Christ is speaking through me: This clause refers to Paul speaking the things that Jesus would want him to say. The false teachers were probably saying that Paul preached and taught from his own thoughts rather than preaching and teaching what Jesus wanted him to. Other ways to translate this clause are:

I am speaking for Christ (CEV)

Christ tells me what to say to you

I am Christ’s messenger

13:3b

He is not weak in dealing with you, but is powerful among you.

- When he deals with you, he is not weak. Instead, he is powerful among you.
- He is not weak in his relationship with you—instead he works powerfully among you.

He is not weak in dealing with you: The Greek words are literally “who is not weak toward you” (as in the NASB). This clause indicates that Christ is powerful in his relationship with the believers. Christ is not so weak that he can do nothing regarding them. He is able to correct them if he chooses to. He also empowers them to do the right things. Other ways to translate this are:

When he deals with you, he is not weak (GNT)

he is not weak in his relationship with you

Christ is not too weak to punish you or to help you

is powerful among you: This phrase refers to Christ doing powerful deeds in connection with the believers. Other ways to translate this are:

his power is at work among you (NJB)

he shows his power among you (GNT)

2 Corinthians 13:4

Section 13:1–10: Some warnings

In this section, Paul warned the believers that he would punish anyone who was sinning and refusing to repent (13:1–2). He said he would do that because some believers in Corinth were demanding proof from him that he was a true apostle (13:3a). He told them that he could work powerfully because Jesus is powerful (13:3b). He told them that they were weak in their natural abilities but had God's power, as Jesus did when he lived on earth (13:4).

Then Paul commanded them to look carefully at themselves to see if they were truly believers or not (13:5). Paul expected that if they studied Paul's words and deeds, then they would see that he was a true apostle (13:6). Paul told them that he and his coworkers prayed for the believers in Corinth that they would not sin and that they would do what was right (13:7). Paul told them that he and his coworkers worked in accordance with the truth (13:8). He told the believers that he prayed that they would always do as God wanted them to do (13:9). He told them that he wrote about their problems so that they would correct those problems themselves. Then he would encourage them when he went there and would not have to discipline them (13:10).

Other examples for this section heading are:

Examine Yourselves (NASB)

Paul gave final warnings

Final warnings and greetings

13:4a

For He was indeed crucified in weakness,

- For indeed he was killed on a cross because of him being man and therefore weak,
- It is true that he was weak like any other person when people nailed him to a cross and left him to die.

For: This word introduces an explanation about Christ's weakness and power. Other ways to translate this word are:

Because

What I am saying is

In some languages it is more natural to allow the context to indicate the connection and omit the conjunction here.

He was indeed crucified: This clause is passive. Some languages must use an active clause. Roman soldiers crucified him, but Paul wanted to focus on the fact that Jesus was crucified rather than the people who crucified him. For example:

people/they crucified him

If possible, keep the focus on the fact that Jesus was crucified and not on the people who crucified him.

He was indeed: The Greek word that the BSB translates as indeed is the word often translated "and" or "even." Here it emphasizes the following words. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

to be sure (NIV)

It is true that (NCV)

crucified: This verb refers to a person being nailed to a cross, someone placing the cross upright, and the person remaining there until he dies.

Other ways to translate this word are:

killed on the cross (NCV)

nailed to a cross and left to die

crucified in weakness: Here the Greek word that the BSB translates as in probably indicates that Jesus as a human being was weak. He did not have political or economic power. Other ways to translate this are:

crucified because he had no earthly power

Christ's weakness in his human form was seen in his being nailed to the cross

13:4b

yet He lives by God's power.

- but he now lives because of the power of God.
- However, he now lives because God used his power to make him alive again.

He lives by God's power: The Greek word that the BSB translates as by is literally "out of." Here the Greek

word indicates that God used his power to raise Jesus back to life after his death on the cross. It also implies that Jesus continues to live and be powerful. Other ways to translate this are:

He lives because of the power of God (NASB)

from God's power he now lives

13:4c

And though we are weak in Him,

- Similarly, in our^(excl) relationship/union with him we also experience the same weaknesses,
- And we who joined ourselves with him are weak just as he was,

And: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as And is literally “For indeed,” as in 13:4a. But here Paul probably repeated the phrase to introduce a comparison between Christ's weakness and his power. So the BSB translates the Greek phrase as And. Here is another way to translate this:

also (GNT)

though we are weak in Him: This clause indicates that in our relationship with Jesus we experience difficulties of life just as he did. Other ways to translate this are:

We, too, are weak, just as Christ was (NLT)

we share in experiencing his weakness because we are joined to him

We are in Christ and we also are weak

we who joined ourselves with him have weakness just as he did

This clause does not indicate that believers have a weak relationship with Jesus.

13:4d

yet by God's power we will live with Him to serve you.

- but from God's power we will share in his life in our relationship/union with him when we deal with you^(plur).

- but God will powerfully cause us to live experiencing his life because we are joined to him as we minister/relate to you.

by God's power: As in 13:4b, the Greek word that the BSB translates as by is literally “out of.” Here the Greek word indicates that God empowers the apostles to do the work that God gave them. Other ways to translate this are:

because of the power of God (NASB)

from God's power

we will live with Him: Here the phrase with Him indicates that the apostles will share the empowered life of Jesus. Other ways to translate this are:

we shall share...in his life (GNT)

we will be alive with him (NLT)

we will share in experiencing his life because we are joined to him

we also will live having a share of his life

we will live just as he did

to serve you: The Greek words are literally “toward you” (as in the KJV). This phrase may indicate:

1. helping them believe in Jesus well;
2. punishing the sinners among them.

It probably implies both meanings, as it does in 13:3b (“in dealing with you”). Translate the phrase in a similar way here. For example:

in dealing with you (RSV)

in our relationship with you

to help you

2 Corinthians 13:5

Section 13:1–10: Some warnings

In this section, Paul warned the believers that he would punish anyone who was sinning and refusing to repent (13:1–2). He said he would do that because some

believers in Corinth were demanding proof from him that he was a true apostle (13:3a). He told them that he could work powerfully because Jesus is powerful (13:3b). He told them that they were weak in their natural abilities but had God's power, as Jesus did when he lived on earth (13:4).

Then Paul commanded them to look carefully at themselves to see if they were truly believers or not (13:5). Paul expected that if they studied Paul's words and deeds, then they would see that he was a true apostle (13:6). Paul told them that he and his coworkers prayed for the believers in Corinth that they would not sin and that they would do what was right (13:7). Paul told them that he and his coworkers worked in accordance with the truth (13:8). He told the believers that he prayed that they would always do as God wanted them to do (13:9). He told them that he wrote about their problems so that they would correct those problems themselves. Then he would encourage them when he went there and would not have to discipline them (13:10).

Other examples for this section heading are:

Examine Yourselves (NASB)

Paul gave final warnings

Final warnings and greetings

13:5b test yourselves.

- and prove that you have true faith.
- and prove it is true by doing the right thing in this regard.
- Carefully examine them, do they prove what you claim about your faith?

13:5a-b

Examine yourselves...test yourselves: The two Greek verbs that the BSB translates as Examine and test are similar in meaning. The first verb refers to determining the nature of something by testing it. In other words, something is examined to discover its true nature. The second verb refers to checking something to see if it is genuine. In other words, something is examined to see if it is what it claims to be. An example explaining the difference is:

Examine yourselves to discover the true nature of your faith, test yourselves to see if what you say about your faith is true

yourselves...yourselves: Both times this pronoun is used, it is emphasized in the Greek clause. Paul probably emphasized these pronouns because some of the believers were wrongly examining and testing Paul. They were doing that because they doubted that he was a true apostle. Some languages can emphasize the pronoun in a natural way. Some examples in English are:

It is yourselves whom you must examine...it is yourselves whom you must test

You are the ones you need to examine...test yourselves to see if your faith is true/genuine

13:5a

Examine yourselves to see whether you are in the faith;

- ¶ Examine yourselves to see if you have true faith
- ¶ It is you yourselves that you must examine to discover the true nature of your faith
- ¶ Look at your own ways, do they match the ways of faith?

to see whether you are in the faith: The clause you are in the faith refers to living and believing according to Christian teaching. Paul commanded them here to prove that they were living the proper Christian way. Other ways to translate this are:

to see whether you are holding to your faith (RSV)

to find out whether you are living in faith (GNT)

find out if you really are true to your faith (CEV)

are you living the life of faith? (REB)

13:5c-d

Can't you see for yourselves that Jesus Christ is in you—unless you actually fail the test?: This is a rhetorical question. Paul expected the believers to answer that they knew that Jesus was in them. But he used the rhetorical question to imply that some of them might not be completely following proper Christian ways (13:5a-b). These words exhort the believers to live according to the fact that Jesus was in them. Translate in a way that indicates that meaning. Some ways to translate this are:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Do you not recognise yourselves as people in whom Jesus Christ is present?—unless, that is, you fail the test. (NJB)

Don't you recognize that you are people in whom Jesus Christ lives? Could it be that you're failing the test? (GW)

Surely you recognize that Jesus Christ is present in you, don't you? If not, you have failed the test.

- As a statement. For example:

You ought to know by this time that Christ is in you, unless you are not real Christians at all. (JBP)

You know that Jesus Christ is in you—unless you fail the test. (NCV)

13:5c

Can't you see for yourselves that Jesus Christ is in you—

- Do you not recognize yourselves as people in whom Jesus Christ is present? (NJB)
- Certainly you know that Jesus Christ is in you!

Jesus Christ: There is a textual issue here. The Greek manuscripts differ in the order of these two words:

1. The order of the words is Jesus Christ. For example, see the BSB. (BSB, RSV, NJB, NASB, NABRE, NLT, GW, NET, REB, NCV, ESV, KJV)
2. The order of the words is Christ Jesus. For example:

Christ Jesus (GNT) (NIV, GNT)

It is recommended that you follow option (1) because the UBS Greek New Testament has that order. The meaning is basically the same in either order. But having "Christ" first emphasizes that Jesus is the Christ.

is in you: This phrase refers to Jesus encouraging, guiding, correcting, and helping the believers, both individually and as a group. The believers experience changes in their lives because they follow Jesus. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

people in whom Jesus Christ is present (NJB)

walks with/guides you

lives in your heart/insides

13:5d

unless you actually fail the test?

- But perhaps you will examine yourselves and find that God has not approved you!
- I do not expect many of you to be unable to prove that you truly believe!

unless you actually fail the test: This is irony. To fail the test refers here to not having faith. Paul expected the believers to pass the test. But Paul used irony to encourage them to examine themselves. He probably implied that a few people in the church in Corinth did not truly believe or had sinned greatly. For the irony you may want to:

- Translate in a way that clearly shows the irony. For example:

unless you have completely failed (GNT)

- Translate the irony with a rhetorical question or a rhetorical "if." For example:

Could it be that you're failing the test? (GW)

But if Christ isn't living in you, you have failed (CEV)

- Translate in a way that explains the irony. For example:

I do not expect many of you to fail that test!

you...fail the test: The Greek words here are literally "you are unapproved." Here it indicates that they were unable to show that they had true faith in Jesus. Other ways to translate this are:

you are unable to prove your faith

you cannot pass the test

2 Corinthians 13:6

Section 13:1–10: Some warnings

In this section, Paul warned the believers that he would punish anyone who was sinning and refusing to repent (13:1–2). He said he would do that because some believers in Corinth were demanding proof from him that he was a true apostle (13:3a). He told them that

he could work powerfully because Jesus is powerful (13:3b). He told them that they were weak in their natural abilities but had God's power, as Jesus did when he lived on earth (13:4).

Then Paul commanded them to look carefully at themselves to see if they were truly believers or not (13:5). Paul expected that if they studied Paul's words and deeds, then they would see that he was a true apostle (13:6). Paul told them that he and his coworkers prayed for the believers in Corinth that they would not sin and that they would do what was right (13:7). Paul told them that he and his coworkers worked in accordance with the truth (13:8). He told the believers that he prayed that they would always do as God wanted them to do (13:9). He told them that he wrote about their problems so that they would correct those problems themselves. Then he would encourage them when he went there and would not have to discipline them (13:10).

Other examples for this section heading are:

Examine Yourselves (NASB)

Paul gave final warnings

Final warnings and greetings

13:6

And I hope you will realize that we have not failed the test.

- And I hope that you^(plur) will know that God has approved us in our work.
- And I expect you to recognize that we have proved that we are truly apostles.

I hope: The Greek word that the BSB translates literally as hope refers to expecting something to happen. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

I trust (NIV)

I am confident (JBP)

you will realize: The Greek word that the BSB translates as realize is literally "know." Some believers in Corinth may not have been certain that Paul was an apostle, but Paul expected that after they examined themselves, they would know for certain that they had true faith in Jesus. Therefore they would also know for certain that Paul was a true apostle because he was

the one who had preached Jesus to them. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

you will know (GNT)

you will discover (NIV)

you will recognize (NLT)

you will see (NCV)

we have not failed the test: The Greek words here are literally "we are not unapproved." Here it indicates that Paul was able to show that God approved him. Other ways to translate this are:

we have proved we are apostles

we have shown that God approves us

See how you translated the phrase "fail the test" in 13:5d.

General Comment on 13:5d–6

In some languages, it may be more natural to refer to "pass the test" in 13:6 rather than "not fail the test." For example:

^{5d}unless you actually fail the test. ⁶And I hope you will realize that we have passed the test.

And in some languages, it may be more natural to use the phrase "pass the test" in 13:5d as well. For example:

^{5d}unless you actually do not pass the test. ⁶And I hope you will realize that we have passed the test.

2 Corinthians 13:7

Section 13:1–10: Some warnings

In this section, Paul warned the believers that he would punish anyone who was sinning and refusing to repent (13:1–2). He said he would do that because some believers in Corinth were demanding proof from him that he was a true apostle (13:3a). He told them that he could work powerfully because Jesus is powerful (13:3b). He told them that they were weak in their natural abilities but had God's power, as Jesus did when he lived on earth (13:4).

Then Paul commanded them to look carefully at themselves to see if they were truly believers or not (13:5). Paul expected that if they studied Paul's words and deeds, then they would see that he was a true apostle (13:6). Paul told them that he and his coworkers prayed for the believers in Corinth that they would not sin and that they would do what was right (13:7). Paul told them that he and his coworkers worked in accordance with the truth (13:8). He told the believers that he prayed that they would always do as God wanted them to do (13:9). He told them that he wrote about their problems so that they would correct those problems themselves. Then he would encourage them when he went there and would not have to discipline them (13:10).

Other examples for this section heading are:

Examine Yourselves (NASB)

Paul gave final warnings

Final warnings and greetings

13:7a

Now we pray to God that you will not do anything wrong—

- But we^(excl) ask God to help you^(plur) not to do anything bad/evil,
- And we are praying that God will help you to live in only good ways.

Now: Here this word introduces a new but related theme. There is some contrast with what Paul had said in 13:6, and some versions translate the word to indicate that. For example:

But (RSV)

In some languages it is more natural to allow the context to indicate the connection and omit the conjunction. For example:

We pray... (GNT)

we pray to God that you will not do anything wrong: This clause refers to asking God to help the believers so that they will not do anything wrong.

do anything wrong: This phrase refers to doing things that believers should not do. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

do any evil

doing evil things (CEV)

commit sin

13:7b

not that we will appear to have stood the test,

- not in order that people will think that God has approved us as apostles,
- We are not praying that way so that people will say that we have God's approval.

not that: This phrase introduces what is not the purpose for Paul to pray to God in 13:7a. Paul wanted the believers to behave correctly in all things (13:7a). He wanted them to agree that Paul was a true apostle. But that was not the reason why he wanted them to behave correctly. He wanted them to behave correctly to honor God. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

My purpose is not that

I am not saying this in order that

We don't pray like this to (CEV)

we will appear to have stood the test: The Greek words here are literally "we may appear approved." "Approved" indicates that Paul and the others were able to show that God gave them the work of apostles. Other ways to translate this are:

we may appear to have met the test (RSV)

to show that we are a success (GNT)

we ourselves may appear approved (NASB)

13:7c

but that you will do what is right,

- but that you will act properly according to your faith,
- No, we are praying in that way so that you will live in right ways

but that: This phrase introduces what the purpose is for Paul to pray to God in 13:7a. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

Rather, my purpose is that

Instead, I pray like this in order that

you will do what is right: This clause refers to following the ways of Jesus. Paul wants the believers to do what Jesus says is right. Other ways to translate this clause are:

I just want your lives to be straight

you will do the deeds that Jesus says are right to do

13:7d even if we appear to have failed.

- even though it might seem/appear that God has not approved us as apostles.
- even though some people would think that we still have no proof that we are apostles.

even if we appear to have failed: Some people might have thought that God had not made Paul an apostle. Their opinions were not important to Paul. He wanted the believers to do what was right regardless of what people thought. Other ways to translate this are:

even though we may seem to be failures (GNT)

even though we may appear unapproved (NASB)

even if it seems as if we have not passed the test

have failed: This is the same Greek word that the BSB translates as “failed the test” in 13:5d and 13:6. See how you translated it there.

2 Corinthians 13:8

Section 13:1–10: Some warnings

In this section, Paul warned the believers that he would punish anyone who was sinning and refusing to repent (13:1–2). He said he would do that because some believers in Corinth were demanding proof from him that he was a true apostle (13:3a). He told them that he could work powerfully because Jesus is powerful (13:3b). He told them that they were weak in their natural abilities but had God’s power, as Jesus did when he lived on earth (13:4).

Then Paul commanded them to look carefully at themselves to see if they were truly believers or not (13:5). Paul expected that if they studied Paul’s words and deeds, then they would see that he was a true apostle (13:6). Paul told them that he and his coworkers prayed

for the believers in Corinth that they would not sin and that they would do what was right (13:7). Paul told them that he and his coworkers worked in accordance with the truth (13:8). He told the believers that he prayed that they would always do as God wanted them to do (13:9). He told them that he wrote about their problems so that they would correct those problems themselves. Then he would encourage them when he went there and would not have to discipline them (13:10).

Other examples for this section heading are:

Examine Yourselves (NASB)

Paul gave final warnings

Final warnings and greetings

13:8a For we cannot do anything against the truth,

- For we cannot oppose the truth (NLT)
- Since, whatever happens with you,^(plur) we^(excl) cannot do a thing against the truth,

For: This conjunction introduces an explanation of 13:7c–d or of the whole of 13:7.

we cannot do anything against the truth: Here the word truth probably refers to the gospel of Jesus. Paul could do nothing to hurt it. He implied that if the believers were following the truth, then he would have no need to do anything against them. Other ways to translate this clause are:

we cannot oppose the truth (NLT)

All we can do is to follow the truth and not fight against it (CEV)

as in this situation, we cannot do anything against the truth of the gospel about Jesus Christ

13:8b but only for the truth.

- but must always stand for the truth. (NLT)
- instead, we can only do things for the truth.

but only for the truth: Some of the words from 13:8a are implied but not repeated here. In some languages, it may be more natural to repeat some or all of those words. For example:

but we can only do things for the truth

but we have power only to do things for the truth

but God gave us this power only for advancing the message of truth

2 Corinthians 13:9

Section 13:1–10: Some warnings

In this section, Paul warned the believers that he would punish anyone who was sinning and refusing to repent (13:1–2). He said he would do that because some believers in Corinth were demanding proof from him that he was a true apostle (13:3a). He told them that he could work powerfully because Jesus is powerful (13:3b). He told them that they were weak in their natural abilities but had God's power, as Jesus did when he lived on earth (13:4).

Then Paul commanded them to look carefully at themselves to see if they were truly believers or not (13:5). Paul expected that if they studied Paul's words and deeds, then they would see that he was a true apostle (13:6). Paul told them that he and his coworkers prayed for the believers in Corinth that they would not sin and that they would do what was right (13:7). Paul told them that he and his coworkers worked in accordance with the truth (13:8). He told the believers that he prayed that they would always do as God wanted them to do (13:9). He told them that he wrote about their problems so that they would correct those problems themselves. Then he would encourage them when he went there and would not have to discipline them (13:10).

Other examples for this section heading are:

Examine Yourselves (NASB)

Paul gave final warnings

Final warnings and greetings

13:9a

In fact, we rejoice when we are weak but you are strong,

- For we^(excl) rejoice when you^(plur) are strong even if we ourselves are weak,
- We are glad to be weak in any way if it means that you are strong in faith.

In fact: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates here as In fact is often translated as “for” or “because.” Here are some other ways to translate this conjunction:

For (RSV)

Furthermore

Here Paul said more about what he had said in 13:7. In some languages it is more natural to allow the context to indicate the connection and omit the conjunction.

we rejoice when we are weak but you are strong: It is not important to Paul to appear strong. These words indicate that he was happy when the believers were strong in their faith, even if he had no opportunity to show that he was strong and therefore some people thought of him as weak. Other ways to translate this are:

we rejoice when we ourselves are weak but you are strong (NASB)

We are happy to be weak at any time if only you are strong (REB)

We are glad to seem weak if it helps show that you are actually strong (NLT)

We are glad to be weak if it means that you are strong (JBP)

weak: Here the word weak refers to any sort of weakness.

strong: Here the word strong refers to believing in Jesus well and therefore properly following the ways of Jesus. For example:

strong in faith

believing in Jesus strongly/well

powerfully/steadfastly following Jesus' teachings

13:9b

and our prayer is for your perfection.

- and this is what we pray for, that you will be restored to perfection.

- We also pray for you like this: May God enable you to be completely faultless in faith.

your perfection: The Greek word that the BSB translates as perfection refers to the process of restoring or repairing something so that it works perfectly. Here the word refers to the believers removing sin from their lives so that they could live completely according to the ways of Jesus. Other ways to translate this word are:

your restoration (ESV)

God will correct you until you have no faults

your thinking and behaving properly will be thoroughly strengthened

2 Corinthians 13:10

Section 13:1–10: Some warnings

In this section, Paul warned the believers that he would punish anyone who was sinning and refusing to repent (13:1–2). He said he would do that because some believers in Corinth were demanding proof from him that he was a true apostle (13:3a). He told them that he could work powerfully because Jesus is powerful (13:3b). He told them that they were weak in their natural abilities but had God's power, as Jesus did when he lived on earth (13:4).

Then Paul commanded them to look carefully at themselves to see if they were truly believers or not (13:5). Paul expected that if they studied Paul's words and deeds, then they would see that he was a true apostle (13:6). Paul told them that he and his coworkers prayed for the believers in Corinth that they would not sin and that they would do what was right (13:7). Paul told them that he and his coworkers worked in accordance with the truth (13:8). He told the believers that he prayed that they would always do as God wanted them to do (13:9). He told them that he wrote about their problems so that they would correct those problems themselves. Then he would encourage them when he went there and would not have to discipline them (13:10).

Other examples for this section heading are:

Examine Yourselves (NASB)

Paul gave final warnings

Final warnings and greetings

13:10a

This is why I write these things while absent,

- That is why I wrote those things in this letter while I am not yet there,
- I am writing this letter before I arrive there for that very purpose/reason,

This is why I write these things: This clause refers to all the things Paul had written in this letter. Other ways to translate this are:

So I write these things (NRSV)

That's why I'm writing this letter (GW)

Therefore I wrote all those things

while absent: This clause refers to the time when Paul wrote this letter. He was not there in Corinth with them.

13:10b

so that when I am present I will not need to be severe in my use of the authority

- so that when I come I will not have to act severely towards you^(plur) with the authority
- in order that I will not need to use my authority in a severe way when I come.

so that: This conjunction introduces another purpose for writing. For example:

in order that (RSV)

in my use of the authority: The Greek words are literally "according to the authority." Paul had the authority from Jesus to be an apostle. He used that authority to start churches and correct believers. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

with the authority (NJB)

when I use the authority (CEV)

13:10c

that the Lord gave me for building you up, not for tearing you down.

- that the Lord gave to me to build your faith rather than destroy it.

- The Lord gave that authority to me to help you to become mature believers, and not to hurt/harm the way you believe.

for building you up, not for tearing you down: The verb phrase “build up” refers figuratively to encouraging the believers so that they believe in Jesus well. The verb phrase “tear down” refers figuratively to discouraging the believers so that they do not believe in Jesus well. See how you translated the similar phrase in 10:8, where the BSB translates it as “for building you up rather than tearing you down.” Other ways to translate this are:

to help you, not to destroy you

to make your faith grow, not to make your faith ineffective/useless

to cause you to be strong in faith, not to cause you to be weak in faith

2 Corinthians 13:11

Section 13:11–14: Final greetings and blessings

This is the final section of the letter. Paul concluded as he did in most of his other letters with closing greetings, some encouragement, and a blessing.

Other examples for this section heading are:

Final Exhortations and Greetings (NET)

Paul gave final encouragement and a blessing

Conclusion (NJB)

13:11a

Finally, brothers, rejoice!

- ¶ Brothers and sisters, I say to you at the end of this letter, rejoice,
- ¶ Our fellow believers, I close my letter to you in this way. We want you to have joy,

Finally: This word indicates that Paul began the last part of his letter here. Other ways to translate this word are:

In conclusion

Last of all

To end then (NJB)

brothers: Here this word refers to both men and women believers. It does not refer to brothers from the same mother or father. For example:

brothers and sisters (NLT)

fellow believers

rejoice: The Greek word that the BSB translates literally as rejoice can be interpreted in two ways:

1. The Greek word is a command to rejoice. It goes with the other four commands in 13:11b–c. For example:

rejoice (NASB) (BSB, NJB, NASB, NABRE, ESV, NLT, NET)

1. The Greek word means good-bye. It is part of the beginning of the final section of the letter (along with “Finally”). For example:

farewell (RSV) (RSV, NIV, GNT, GW, CEV, REB, NCV, KJV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), since there is no other place in the New Testament where this Greek word clearly means “good-bye.” Harris (p. 932) lists four other reasons the Greek word should be translated as “rejoice.” Martin (p. 490), Thrall (p. 904), and many other commentators believe it means “rejoice” here.

Other ways to translate this Greek word according to interpretation (1) are:

Be joyful (NLT)

we wish you joy (NJB)

be glad

13:11b

Aim for perfect harmony, encourage one another,

- be restored to perfection, do what I have urged you to do,
- to allow God to enable you to mature in faith, and to listen to my advice.

Aim for perfect harmony: The Greek is literally “be perfected.” Like the similar Greek noun in 13:9b, this

Greek verb, which the BSB translates as Aim for perfect harmony, refers to the process of restoring or repairing something so that it works perfectly. As a command, Paul told the believers to restore themselves or to allow God to restore them. Other ways to translate this Greek word are:

work at your restoration

allow God to correct you until you have no faults

change your ways of thinking and behaving so they will be completely proper

encourage one another: English versions translate the Greek word that the BSB translates as encourage one another in three ways:

1. It means heed/listen to Paul's requests/exhortations here. Paul urged them in many ways in this letter. For example:

heed my appeal (RSV) (RSV, NIV, GNT, GW, CEV, REB, NCV)

1. It means help one another to be strong here. For example:

encourage one another (NJB) (BSB, NJB, ESV, NABRE, NLT)

1. It means be encouraged here. Paul wanted them to allow God to comfort them. For example:

be comforted (NASB) (NASB, NET, KJV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Harris (p. 931) translates the Greek word as "heed my appeals." Thrall (p. 904) translates it as "accept admonition."

13:11c be of one mind, live in peace.

- be united in what you think, and make peace with each other.
- We also want you to agree with each other and to be at peace with each other.

be of one mind: This phrase refers to being unified in thinking. The believers were divided into factions and Paul wanted them to be united. Other ways to translate this are:

agree with one another (RSV)

be like-minded (NASB)

be united in your thinking

live in peace: This phrase refers to resolving any conflicts the believers may already have and not creating any new ones. Other ways to translate this are:

be at peace with one another

reconcile conflicts

13:11d And the God of love and peace will be with you.

- God, who enables you to love each other and be peaceful, will be with you.
- God gives you love and peace. He will be with you and help you.

And the God of love and peace will be with you: This clause is probably a promise that God would help them at all times. Paul wrote this promise here to encourage the believers.

And: This conjunction connects 13:11d to 13:11a-c in a general way. In some languages it is more natural to allow the context to indicate the connection and omit the conjunction.

the God of love and peace will be with you: The phrase the God of love and peace indicates that God is the source of love and peace. He enables believers to love one another and other people. And he enables believers to live peacefully. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

the God who supplies all love and peace will be with you

the God who gives love and peace freely will be with you

In some languages a literal translation would wrongly indicate that Paul was thinking of other gods and want to make clear which god he referred to. If that is true in your language, indicate that this phrase refers to the only true God. For example:

God will be with you. He supplies all love and peace.

God is the source of love and peace and he will give you help to do these things.

2 Corinthians 13:12

Section 13:11–14: Final greetings and blessings

This is the final section of the letter. Paul concluded as he did in most of his other letters with closing greetings, some encouragement, and a blessing.

Other examples for this section heading are:

Final Exhortations and Greetings (NET)

Paul gave final encouragement and a blessing

Conclusion (NJB)

13:12–14

There is an issue with verse numbering here:

1. The verse numbers go to thirteen. For example:

¹²Greet one another with the kiss of peace. All of God's people send you their greetings. ¹³The grace of the Lord Jesus Christ, the love of God, and the fellowship of the Holy Spirit be with you all. (GNT) (GNT, NJB, NRSV, NABRE, GW, CEV, NET)

1. The verse numbers go to fourteen. For example:

¹²Greet one another with a holy kiss. ¹³All the saints greet you. ¹⁴The grace of the Lord Jesus Christ and the love of God and the fellowship of the Holy Spirit be with you all. (RSV) (BSB, RSV, NIV, NASB, NLT, REB, NCV, ESV, KJV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1). The Greek words are the same in both cases. Robert Estienne added verse numbers to the text in A.D. 1551. Originally, he had 13 verses in this chapter, but the Bishop's Bible of 1572 had 14 verses here (Furnish, page 583). The KJV follows the verse numbering in the Bishop's Bible, as did some of the later English versions. But if the common language version follows option (2), you may want to follow that. The Display follows option (2) and the BSB to avoid making the Display complicated and confusing.

13:12

Greet one another with a holy kiss.

- ¶ Greet^(plur) each other with a holy kiss.

- ¶ Greet each other in a way that shows you are God's people.

Greet one another with a holy kiss: The holy kiss is a greeting. One person kisses another person on the cheek or side of the face, and the other person does the same in return. This kiss is holy because it is a gesture of friendship and unity, and it is done between God's holy people. Also, since all believers are brothers and sisters in Jesus, the holy kiss does not have any sexual connotations.

If the kiss is not known in your area, or if it is only a gesture of sexual desire, you may want to:

- Translate literally and explain its meaning in a footnote. For example:

This kiss is holy because it was a gesture of friendship and unity, and it was done between God's holy people. Also, since all believers are brothers and sisters in Jesus, the holy kiss was not sexual.

- Use the common gesture of friendship or unity in your area. You may then want to explain the literal word in a footnote. For example:

Literally "holy kiss." This kiss is holy because it was a gesture of friendship and unity, and it was done between God's holy people. Also, since all believers are brothers and sisters in Jesus, the holy kiss was not sexual.

- Translate the meaning of the gesture in a general way. For example:

Greet each other sincerely as loving brothers and sisters in God's family. You may then want to explain the literal word in a footnote. For example:

Literally "holy kiss." This kiss was considered holy because it was a gesture of friendship and unity.

2 Corinthians 13:13

Section 13:11–14: Final greetings and blessings

This is the final section of the letter. Paul concluded as he did in most of his other letters with closing greetings, some encouragement, and a blessing.

Other examples for this section heading are:

Final Exhortations and Greetings (NET)

Paul gave final encouragement and a blessing

Conclusion (NJB)

13:13

All the saints send you greetings.

- All the believers greet you^(plur).
- All God's people say hello to you.

All the saints: This phrase could refer to:

1. All of the believers in the town where Paul was writing this letter from.
2. All of the believers in that region.
3. All of the believers in all the churches that Paul was responsible for.

Paul may have implied more than one meaning. Translate in a way that allows for at least interpretation (1). Harris (p. 937) says "they are probably the Philipian believers. Alternatively, the reference could be to believers throughout Macedonia...or...the church as a whole."

saints: The Greek word that the BSB translates as saints is literally "holy ones." The word refers to all who believe in Jesus as the Christ. For example:

God's people (GNT)

send you greetings: This word greetings refers to welcoming someone. Here Paul indicated here that other believers wanted to send words of welcome to the believers in Corinth. Other ways to translate this are:

greet you (ESV)

send you their good wishes

say hello

2 Corinthians 13:14

Section 13:11–14: Final greetings and blessings

This is the final section of the letter. Paul concluded as he did in most of his other letters with closing greetings, some encouragement, and a blessing.

Other examples for this section heading are:

Final Exhortations and Greetings (NET)

Paul gave final encouragement and a blessing

Conclusion (NJB)

13:14a–b

The grace of the Lord Jesus Christ, and the love of God, and the fellowship of the Holy Spirit be with all of you: These words indicate that Paul wants Jesus, God, and the Holy Spirit to bless the believers in Corinth with grace, love, and fellowship. Other ways to translate this are:

May you be blessed with the grace of the Lord Jesus Christ and the love of God and the fellowship of the Holy Spirit.

May God give to you even more grace of the Lord Jesus Christ and even more love of God and even more fellowship of the Holy Spirit.

13:14a

The grace of the Lord Jesus Christ, and the love of God,

- ¶ The grace of the Lord Jesus Christ and the love of God (RSV)
- ¶ I pray that the Lord Jesus Christ will favor you^(plur), I pray that God will love you,

The grace of the Lord Jesus Christ: This phrase refers to the grace that the Lord Jesus Christ gives. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

the grace from the Lord Jesus Christ

the grace that the Lord Jesus Christ gives

grace: The word grace here refers to God being kind to people who do not deserve it. See how you translated this word in 1:2 or 12:9.

the love of God: This phrase refers to love that God gives. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

the love from God

the love that God gives

love: Here the word love refers to the totally unselfish concern and care that God has for people.

13:14b

and the fellowship of the Holy Spirit be with all of you.

- and the fellowship of the Holy Spirit be with you all. (RSV)
- and I pray that the Holy Spirit will give to you close relationships with him and with each other.

the fellowship of the Holy Spirit: This phrase refers to believers having fellowship with the Holy Spirit. It probably also includes the fact that the Holy Spirit enables believers to have fellowship with him and one another. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

the fellowship with the Holy Spirit

may the Holy Spirit join all your hearts together
(CEV)

fellowship: The word fellowship refers to having a close relationship with someone. Other ways to translate this word are:

join all your hearts together (CEV)

cause you to be in harmonyUma Back Translation
on TW.

make you to be of one heart/liver

See how you translated this word in 6:14.